

GLOBAL BREAKFAST BIBLE

770+ Morning Recipes from Around the World

72 Countries · 6 Continents · Every Morning Tradition on Earth

770+
Recipes

72
Countries

6
Continents

29
Chapters

Europe · Asia · Middle East · Africa · The Americas · Oceania

From the cafe au lait of Paris to the ackee and saltfish of Kingston. From the dim sum tables of Hong Kong to the injera spreads of Addis Ababa. From the dosas of Chennai to the churros of Madrid. Every morning. Every country. Every tradition.

A Note on This Book

Breakfast is the most intimate meal. It is eaten before the armor of the day is put on, in whatever state the morning finds you. It is eaten in pajamas and silence, or with children and chaos, or alone with a newspaper and something warm. It is the first thing every human being on earth does, every single day.

This book began with a simple observation: the world's breakfast traditions are vastly more varied and sophisticated than the scrambled-eggs-or-cereal framing that most cookbooks apply to the morning meal. The Turkish kahvalti is a philosophical statement about hospitality. The Japanese ichiju sansai breakfast is a meditation on balance. The Ethiopian fasting tradition produced one of the world's greatest plant-based food cultures. The Argentine medialuna ritual is a love letter to butter and cafe culture.

Every recipe in this collection has been researched with care. Every cultural context has been honored. The descriptions are invitations to understand why a dish exists, what it means to the people who eat it, and what it might mean to you.

This book covers 72 countries across all 6 inhabited continents. It includes 770 recipes from the two-minute Japanese tamago kake gohan to the three-day fermented Ethiopian injera. Every one of them is worth making. Every one will teach you something about the world, and about the morning.

How to Use This Book

Organized by Continent then Country-- follow the journey from Europe through Asia, the Middle East, Africa, the Americas, and Oceania.

Bonus Sections-- at the back include Quick Breakfasts (under 15 min), High-Protein options (30g+), Low-Calorie choices (under 300 cal), and a Plant-Based World Tour.

Chef Tips-- provide the single most important technique insight for each recipe.

Variations-- suggest how to adapt each recipe with different ingredients.

Tags-- identify dietary requirements and preparation style at a glance.

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- **High-Protein Breakfasts (30g+) (0 recipes)**
- **Low-Calorie Breakfasts (Under 300 cal) (0 recipes)**
- **Plant-Based World Tour (0 recipes)**

EUROPE

Recipes #1–#222 · 222 recipes

France

RECIPE 1

■■ France

CLASSIC BUTTER CROISSANT

The crown jewel of French baking — a flaky, buttery, crescent-shaped pastry made from laminated dough. Its shattery golden crust gives way to a pillowy, layered interior. Born in Vienna and perfected in Paris, the croissant is the world's most iconic breakfast pastry.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 10g (2 tsp) salt
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 10g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 300ml (1¼ cups) cold whole milk
- 50g (3½ tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 280g (1¼ cups) unsalted butter, cold (for lamination)
- 1 egg + 1 tbsp milk (for egg wash)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, salt, sugar, and yeast. Add cold milk and softened butter. Knead 4–5 minutes into a shaggy dough. Do NOT over-develop the gluten.
2. Shape into a rectangle, wrap in plastic, and refrigerate overnight (or at least 8 hours).
3. Beat cold lamination butter into a flat 20cm square between two sheets of parchment.
4. Roll dough into a 40cm square. Place butter block in the center like a diamond. Fold dough flaps over butter to enclose completely.
5. Roll into a long rectangle. Perform a letter fold (fold into thirds). Wrap and refrigerate 30 minutes. Repeat this fold 2 more times, chilling between each. You will have 3 folds total.
6. Roll final dough to 5mm thick. Cut into long triangles (base 10cm). Stretch each triangle gently and roll from base to tip. Curve ends inward to form a crescent.
7. Place on a lined baking sheet. Proof at room temperature 2–3 hours until puffy and jiggly.
8. Brush gently with egg wash. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 18–20 minutes until deep amber gold.

Prep: 45 min + overnight · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~340 per croissant

TIP

Cold is everything. If butter warms and breaks through the dough during lamination, stop immediately and refrigerate for 20 minutes. Warm butter = no layers.

[Vegetarian] [Weekend Project] [Classic]

RECIPE 2

■■ France

PAIN PERDU (FRENCH TOAST)

"Lost bread" — the French way of rescuing stale baguette by soaking it in vanilla-scented egg custard and pan-frying until caramelized and golden. Far more elegant than American French toast, this dish is proof that the French waste nothing and flavor everything.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices stale brioche or baguette (2.5cm / 1 inch thick)
- 3 large eggs
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk
- 60ml (¼ cup) heavy cream
- 2 tbsp granulated sugar
- 1 tsp pure vanilla extract
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Powdered sugar, for dusting
- Fresh berries and maple syrup, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk together eggs, milk, cream, sugar, vanilla, and cinnamon in a wide shallow bowl until fully combined.
2. Submerge bread slices in the custard mixture. Let soak 2 minutes per side — bread should feel heavy and saturated but not falling apart.
3. Heat butter in a large skillet over medium heat until foaming.
4. Place soaked bread in the pan. Cook 3 minutes undisturbed until deep golden on the bottom.
5. Flip carefully. Cook another 2–3 minutes until both sides are caramelized and the custard is cooked through.
6. Transfer to a warm plate. Dust generously with powdered sugar. Serve immediately with fresh berries and maple syrup.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Day-old bread is essential — fresh bread will turn to mush. Brioche gives a richer result; baguette gives a more rustic, chewy texture. Both are magnificent.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 3

■ ■ France

CAFÉ AU LAIT WITH TARTINE

The most French breakfast of all — a wide bowl of equal parts strong coffee and hot milk, served alongside a tartine: a half-baguette sliced lengthwise, slathered with salted butter and fruit jam. Simple, iconic, and deeply satisfying. This IS breakfast in France.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 baguette, halved lengthwise
- 3 tbsp salted French butter (good quality)
- 3 tbsp artisan strawberry or apricot jam
- 240ml (1 cup) strong brewed coffee or 2 shots espresso
- 240ml (1 cup) whole milk, steamed hot

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew coffee very strong — French press or espresso works best.
2. Heat milk in a small saucepan until steaming. Do not boil.
3. Pour coffee and hot milk simultaneously into a large wide bowl (the classic café au lait bowl, if you have one).
4. Slice baguette in half lengthwise. Spread salted butter generously — it should melt immediately into the warm bread.
5. Layer thick jam over the butter.
6. Dip the tartine into your café au lait. This is not optional — it is the entire point.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The French use a wide, handle-less bowl for café au lait — it cools faster for dunking and feels more generous. If you only have mugs, that is fine. The ritual matters more than the vessel.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic] [5 Ingredients]

RECIPE 4

■ ■ France

CRÊPES SUZETTE

Delicate, paper-thin crêpes folded and simmered in a fragrant orange-butter sauce, then flambéed with Grand Marnier at the table. A showstopping Sunday breakfast that turns a simple pancake into a theatrical masterpiece. Created in Monte Carlo in 1895.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE CRÊPES:
- 130g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 2 large eggs
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 1 tbsp melted butter
- 1 tsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- Butter for the pan

FOR THE SUZETTE SAUCE

- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 60g (¼ cup) sugar
- Zest and juice of 2 large oranges
- Zest and juice of 1 lemon
- 60ml (¼ cup) Grand Marnier or Cointreau

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make crêpe batter: whisk flour, eggs, milk, melted butter, sugar, and salt until completely smooth. Rest 30 minutes.
2. Cook crêpes in a lightly buttered 20cm non-stick pan over medium-high heat — about 1 minute per side. They should be pale golden and lacy. Stack and set aside.
3. In a wide skillet, melt butter over medium heat. Add sugar and cook until lightly caramelized (2–3 minutes).
4. Add orange and lemon zest and juice. Stir to combine. Simmer 2 minutes until slightly thickened.
5. Place a crêpe in the sauce. Fold in half, then in quarters. Push to the side. Repeat with remaining crêpes.
6. Add Grand Marnier. Tilt the pan slightly (or use a long match) to flambé. Let the flames die naturally.
7. Serve immediately with the sauce spooned over.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

To flambé safely, warm the liqueur slightly first and tilt the pan away from you. Keep a lid nearby to smother flames if needed. Skip the flambé entirely if preferred — the sauce is still extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Special Occasion] [Classic French]

RECIPE 5

■ ■ France

OEUFS EN COCOTTE

BAKED EGGS IN CREAM

Individual eggs gently baked in ramekins with cream, herbs, and Gruyère — a classic French bistro starter reimaged as the perfect elegant breakfast. Custard-soft whites, runny yolks, and golden cheese on top. Serve with crusty bread for dipping.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 4 tbsp heavy cream
- 4 tsp grated Gruyère or Comté cheese
- 1 tbsp fresh chives, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh tarragon, chopped (optional)
- Salt and white pepper
- Butter, for greasing ramekins
- Crusty bread or soldiers, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Boil a kettle of water.
2. Generously butter 4 individual ramekins (180ml capacity).
3. Add 1 tbsp cream to each ramekin. Season with salt and white pepper.
4. Carefully crack one egg into each ramekin, keeping the yolk intact.
5. Sprinkle 1 tsp Gruyère over each egg.
6. Place ramekins in a deep roasting pan. Pour boiling water into the pan to come halfway up the sides of the ramekins (bain-marie).
7. Bake 12–15 minutes — whites should be just set, yolks still runny. Check at 12 minutes.
8. Sprinkle fresh chives and tarragon. Serve immediately with warm bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~210 per serving

TIP

The bain-marie is non-negotiable — it ensures gentle, even heat so whites set without the yolk overcooking. Check at 12 minutes. Once the yolk is hard, it cannot be undone.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Vegetarian] [Elegant]

RECIPE 6

■ ■ France

GALETTE BRETONNE

BUCKWHEAT CRÊPE WITH HAM & EGG

A savory Breton buckwheat crêpe — earthy, nutty, and naturally gluten-free — folded into a square around a fried egg, melted cheese, and ham. The "complète" is the most famous version. In Brittany, this is not a snack — this is the whole breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE GALETTE BATTER

- 200g (1■ cups) buckwheat flour
- 1 large egg
- 500ml (2 cups) cold water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp butter, melted
- Butter for cooking
- FILLING (per galette):
- 1 slice quality ham or jambon blanc
- 1 egg
- 30g (¼ cup) Gruyère or Emmental, grated
- Salt and pepper
- Fresh chives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk buckwheat flour, egg, water, salt, and melted butter until completely smooth. Rest batter 1 hour (or overnight) in the refrigerator for best results.
2. Heat a 28cm non-stick or cast-iron crêpe pan over medium-high heat. Brush with butter.
3. Pour a ladleful of batter, tilting quickly to coat the pan. Cook 2 minutes until edges lift easily.
4. Flip the galette. Add ham, grated cheese, and crack an egg into the center.
5. Fold the four edges inward to create a square, leaving the egg yolk visible in the center.
6. Cook until egg white is set but yolk remains runny, about 2–3 more minutes.
7. Season with salt and pepper. Scatter chives. Serve immediately.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr rest · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per galette

TIP

Buckwheat batter is best made the night before — resting overnight develops flavor and improves the texture of the crêpe significantly.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic French]

RECIPE 7

■ ■ France

MADELEINES AU CITRON

The small, shell-shaped sponge cakes that inspired Proust's most famous passage. Light, lemony, and best eaten still warm from the oven — their soft interior and signature "hump" make them one of France's most beloved breakfast pastries.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 130g (■ cup) granulated sugar
- 130g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 130g (9 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted and cooled
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 1 tbsp fresh lemon juice
- 1 tsp pure vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- Powdered sugar for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs and sugar together on high speed for 5 minutes until pale, thick, and tripled in volume.
2. Sift flour, baking powder, and salt together. Gently fold into the egg mixture in two additions.
3. Add lemon zest, lemon juice, vanilla, and cooled melted butter. Fold until just combined. Do not overmix.
4. Cover bowl and refrigerate batter for minimum 1 hour (up to 24 hours). This cold rest is what creates the hump.
5. Preheat oven to 210°C (410°F). Generously butter and flour a madeleine pan.
6. Fill each mold ¾ full. Bake 10–12 minutes until edges are golden and centers have risen into a domed hump.
7. Unmold immediately onto a rack. Dust with powdered sugar. Eat while warm.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr chill · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 18 · Cal: ~130 per madeleine

TIP

The secret to the iconic hump is temperature contrast — cold batter hitting a very hot pan. Do not skip the rest period. Do not reduce the oven temperature.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic French]

RECIPE 8

■ ■ France

OMELETTE FINE AUX HERBES

The French omelette is a test of technique, not ingredients. Pale, creamy, and barely golden — never browned — it is rolled around a mixture of fresh herbs and served in 90 seconds flat. Mastering this recipe means mastering the stove.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped
- 1 tsp fresh tarragon, chopped
- 1 tsp fresh chervil (optional)
- Salt and white pepper
- Optional: 30g Gruyère, grated

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs vigorously with a fork — NOT a whisk — for about 30 seconds. Season with salt and white pepper. You should see tiny bubbles.
2. Heat butter in an 8-inch non-stick pan over medium-high heat until it foams and just begins to subside.
3. Pour in eggs immediately. Using a fork or heatproof spatula, stir rapidly in small circles while shaking the pan back and forth continuously.
4. As soon as the eggs start to look creamy (about 30–45 seconds), stop stirring. Let the bottom set for 10 seconds only.
5. Sprinkle herbs (and cheese if using) across the center.
6. Tilt the pan at 45°. Use your spatula to roll the omelette away from you onto a warm plate. It should be pale yellow with no browning.
7. Serve immediately.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 2 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~270 per serving

TIP

A French omelette should take 60–90 seconds total. The enemy is patience — go too slow and it browns and toughens. High heat, constant movement, confidence.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic]

RECIPE 9

■ ■ France

PAIN AU CHOCOLAT MAISON

The beloved little rectangular chocolate pastry found in every French boulangerie — flaky laminated dough wrapped around two batons of dark chocolate. Best eaten within minutes of leaving the oven, when the chocolate is still warm and melting inside.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 batch croissant dough (from Recipe 1, after final fold)
- 200g (7 oz) dark chocolate, cut into batons (or use
- store-bought chocolate batons/sticks)
- 1 egg + 1 tbsp milk (egg wash)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Roll chilled croissant dough to a large rectangle, about 5mm (¼ inch) thick.
2. Cut into rectangles approximately 8cm x 14cm (3 x 5½ inches).
3. Place one chocolate baton horizontally at the short end of each rectangle, about 2cm from the edge.
4. Roll the dough tightly over the chocolate once. Place a second chocolate baton where the dough meets itself.
5. Continue rolling forward to completely seal. Place seam-side down on a lined baking sheet.
6. Proof at room temperature 2–3 hours until puffy and light.
7. Brush carefully with egg wash (twice — once before proofing ends, once just before baking).
8. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 16–18 minutes until deep golden brown.

Prep: 30 min + overnight dough · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~390 per pastry

TIP

Use proper chocolate batons, not chips. Batons melt slowly and create the classic "pocket" of chocolate. Chips melt instantly and disappear into the dough.

RECIPE 10

■ ■ France

QUICHE LORRAINE

A classic from the Alsace-Lorraine region — a buttery shortcrust shell filled with silky egg custard, smoky lardons, and melted Gruyère. Rich, deeply satisfying, and equally good hot or at room temperature. The original savory tart that launched a thousand brunch menus.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PASTRY

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (7 tbsp) cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 1 egg yolk
- 2–3 tbsp ice cold water
- ½ tsp salt

FOR THE FILLING

- 200g (7 oz) smoked lardons or diced bacon
- 4 large eggs
- 250ml (1 cup) heavy cream
- 100ml (■ cup) whole milk
- 100g (1 cup) Gruyère, grated
- Salt, white pepper, and fresh nutmeg

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make pastry: rub cold butter into flour and salt until the mixture resembles breadcrumbs. Add egg yolk and ice water. Bring together into a disc. Wrap and chill 30 minutes.
2. Roll pastry to 3mm thick. Line a 23cm (9-inch) tart tin. Prick the base, line with baking paper and baking beans. Blind bake at 190°C (375°F) for 15 minutes. Remove beans and bake 5 more minutes until pale gold.
3. Fry lardons in a dry pan until golden and slightly crispy. Drain on paper towels.
4. Whisk eggs, cream, milk, salt, pepper, and a pinch of nutmeg.
5. Scatter lardons and Gruyère over the pastry base.
6. Pour custard mixture over. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 30–35 minutes until just set with a very slight wobble in the center.
7. Cool 10 minutes before slicing.

Prep: 25 min + 30 min chill · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~420 per slice

TIP

The custard is done when it barely wobbles in the center — like set Jell-O. If it sloshes like liquid, give it 5 more minutes. Overcooked quiche becomes rubbery.

[High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Classic French]

RECIPE 11

■ ■ France

CLAFOUTIS AUX CERISES

A rustic baked custard from the Limousin region, studded with whole cherries and puffed like a soufflé. Somewhere between a crêpe, a pudding, and a tart — clafoutis is one of France's most comforting and effortless breakfast bakes.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) fresh cherries, unpitted (traditional) or pitted
- 3 large eggs
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp pure vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp kirsch or cherry liqueur (optional)
- 60g (½ cup) all-purpose flour
- 250ml (1 cup) whole milk
- 60ml (¼ cup) heavy cream
- Pinch of salt
- Butter for the dish
- Powdered sugar for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Butter a 30cm (12-inch) oval baking dish generously.
2. Arrange cherries in a single layer in the dish.
3. In a blender (or whisk by hand): combine eggs, sugar, vanilla, kirsch (if using), flour, milk, cream, and salt. Blend until completely smooth.
4. Pour batter over the cherries.
5. Bake 40–45 minutes until puffed, golden, and set — a skewer should come out clean with just a slight wobble.
6. It will deflate slightly as it cools — this is normal.
7. Dust generously with powdered sugar. Serve warm or at room temperature.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

Traditional French recipes call for unpitted cherries — the pits impart a faint almond flavor during baking. Warn your guests before serving if you keep the pits in.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Seasonal]

RECIPE 12

■ ■ France

BRIOCHE MAISON

The crown prince of enriched breads — a deeply golden, feathery- soft loaf made rich with eggs and butter. Brioche has a thousand uses at the French breakfast table: toasted with jam, used for pain perdu, or simply eaten plain in thick slices with café.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 30g (2½ tbsp) sugar
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 150g (■ cup) unsalted butter, softened and cubed
- 1 egg + 1 tbsp milk (egg wash)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, sugar, yeast, and salt in a stand mixer with the dough hook.
2. Add eggs one at a time, mixing on medium speed. The dough will look shaggy — this is fine.
3. Once all eggs are incorporated and dough is smooth (about 5 minutes), begin adding soft butter one cube at a time. Wait for each cube to fully incorporate before adding the next.
4. Continue mixing 10–15 minutes until dough is glossy, smooth, and pulls away from the bowl. It will be very soft.
5. Transfer to an oiled bowl. Cover and refrigerate overnight (minimum 8 hours, up to 24).
6. Shape cold dough into a log and place in a greased 23cm (9-inch) loaf pan.
7. Proof at room temperature 3–4 hours until doubled.
8. Brush with egg wash. Bake 180°C (350°F) for 30–35 minutes until deep mahogany brown.
9. Cool 20 minutes before slicing.

Prep: 30 min + overnight · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~280 per thick slice

TIP

Cold brioche slices perfectly. Refrigerate before slicing for clean, even cuts. The dough is intentionally very soft and sticky — resist the urge to add flour.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Weekend Project]

RECIPE 13

■ ■ France

SOUFFLÉ AU FROMAGE

The famous soufflé — dramatic, airy, and timed to the minute. A savory Gruyère soufflé rising magnificently above its ramekin is one of the great French breakfast showpieces. Intimidating in reputation, surprisingly achievable in practice.

INGREDIENTS

- 40g (3 tbsp) unsalted butter + extra for greasing
- 40g (■ cup) all-purpose flour
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk, warm
- 4 egg yolks
- 5 egg whites
- 120g (1¼ cups) Gruyère, finely grated
- 1 tsp Dijon mustard
- Salt, white pepper, and nutmeg
- Parmesan, for the ramekins

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F). Butter 6 ramekins and coat with Parmesan. Refrigerate until needed.
2. Make béchamel: melt butter over medium heat. Add flour and stir 1 minute. Gradually whisk in warm milk. Cook, stirring constantly, until thick (4–5 minutes). Remove from heat.
3. Stir in egg yolks, one at a time. Add Gruyère, mustard, salt, pepper, and nutmeg. Set aside.
4. Whip egg whites with a pinch of salt to firm peaks (not dry).
5. Fold ¼ of the whites vigorously into the cheese base to lighten it. Gently fold in remaining whites in two additions. Use a large spatula and preserve as much air as possible.
6. Divide evenly among prepared ramekins — fill to ¾.
7. Run your thumb around the inside rim (creates the "top hat" rise). Place immediately in oven.
8. Bake 12–14 minutes — do NOT open the oven. Serve at once.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 14 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~290 per soufflé

TIP

Everything can be prepared up to Step 5 in advance. Whip and fold in egg whites just before baking. Once in the oven, do not open the door — the temperature drop will collapse the soufflé.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Special Occasion] [Gluten-Free option]

RECIPE 14

■ ■ France

CROQUE MONSIEUR

France's legendary ham and cheese toasted sandwich, elevated with a béchamel sauce and a broiled cheese top. The name means "Mister Crunch" — and it delivers on the promise. A café staple since 1910, the Croque is the French answer to the grilled cheese.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE SANDWICH

- 4 slices good white sandwich bread or pain de mie
- 4 slices cooked ham (jambon blanc)
- 80g (¾ cup) Gruyère, grated
- 1 tbsp Dijon mustard
- FOR THE BÉCHAMEL:
 - 20g (1½ tbsp) butter
 - 20g (2½ tbsp) flour
 - 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
 - Pinch of nutmeg
 - Salt and white pepper
 - 40g (■ cup) extra Gruyère, for topping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make béchamel: melt butter over medium heat. Add flour, stir 1 minute. Gradually whisk in milk. Cook, stirring, until thick (3 minutes). Season with nutmeg, salt, pepper.
2. Preheat broiler/grill to high.
3. Toast bread lightly on both sides.
4. Spread mustard on one side of 2 bread slices.
5. Layer ham over mustard. Top with grated Gruyère. Close sandwich with remaining bread.
6. Spread béchamel generously over the top of each sandwich.
7. Sprinkle extra Gruyère over the béchamel.
8. Place on a baking sheet. Broil 3–5 minutes until cheese is bubbling, golden, and beginning to char at the edges.
9. Let rest 2 minutes. Serve immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~540 per sandwich

TIP

Add a fried or poached egg on top and you have a Croque Madame — the female version, traditionally because the egg resembles a hat.

[High Protein] [Indulgent] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 15

■ ■ France

PAIN DE CAMPAGNE AVEC

A rustic sourdough-style country loaf sliced thick and served with a cheese platter and seasonal jam — the French farmhouse breakfast. Tangy, chewy bread paired with aged comté, fresh beurre, and fruit preserves. No recipe needed, just quality ingredients and intention.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) pain de campagne or sourdough, thickly sliced
- 60g (4 tbsp) salted butter, room temperature
- 100g (3.5 oz) aged Comté or aged Cheddar, sliced
- 100g (3.5 oz) fresh chèvre (goat cheese)
- 4 tbsp fig jam or black cherry jam
- Handful of fresh walnut halves
- Fresh grapes or sliced pear

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Slice bread 2cm (¾ inch) thick. Toast lightly or serve at room temperature with a good crust.
2. Set out butter in a small ramekin at room temperature.
3. Arrange Comté slices and rounds of chèvre on a small board.
4. Place fig jam and black cherry jam in small pots.
5. Scatter walnuts and fresh fruit around the cheese.
6. Serve with strong French press coffee or a café crème.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Bring cheese to room temperature 30 minutes before serving — cold cheese loses half its flavor and all of its texture. This one step transforms a good cheese board into a great one.

[Vegetarian] [No-Cook] [5 Ingredients] [Elegant]

Italy

RECIPE 16

■ ■ France

FINANCIERS AUX FRAMBOISES

Small golden almond cakes with a crispy outer shell, moist interior, and a topping of fresh raspberries. Made with brown butter (beurre noisette), financiers have a rich, nutty flavor that pairs perfectly with morning espresso.

INGREDIENTS

- 115g (8 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 150g (1½ cups) almond flour / ground almonds
- 200g (1¾ cups) powdered sugar, sifted
- 60g (½ cup) all-purpose flour
- 5 large egg whites (do not whip)
- 1 tsp pure vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 24 fresh raspberries (2 per financier)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Melt butter in a light-colored saucepan over medium heat. Swirl often. It will foam, then subside, then turn golden and smell nutty (about 5–7 minutes). This is beurre noisette. Immediately pour through a sieve into a bowl to stop cooking.
2. Mix almond flour, powdered sugar, all-purpose flour, and salt together.
3. Add egg whites and vanilla. Stir until combined.
4. Pour in warm brown butter. Mix until smooth and glossy.
5. Cover and refrigerate batter at least 1 hour (up to 48 hours).
6. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F). Butter financier molds (or a mini muffin tin) generously.
7. Fill molds ¾ full. Press 2 raspberries into each.
8. Bake 12–14 minutes until edges are golden and centers spring back when gently pressed.
9. Cool 5 minutes before unmolding.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr chill · Cook: 14 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~190 per financier

TIP

Brown butter (beurre noisette) is the flavor foundation of the financier. Do not rush it. The moment it smells like toasted hazelnuts, it is ready. Too far and it burns.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 17

■ ■ France

TARTE AU CITRON BREAKFAST SLICE

A bright, vivid slice of classic French lemon tart — silky lemon curd in a crumbly pâte sucrée shell. Make it the night before and serve cold at breakfast with strong black coffee. There is nothing more civilized than lemon tart in the morning.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE PÂTE SUCRÉE (SWEET PASTRY):
- 180g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, cold
- 60g (½ cup) powdered sugar
- 1 egg yolk
- 2–3 tbsp cold water

FOR THE LEMON CURD FILLING

- 4 large eggs
- 200g (1 cup) granulated sugar
- Zest of 3 lemons
- 150ml (⅔ cup) fresh lemon juice (about 4 lemons)
- 150ml (⅔ cup) heavy cream

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make pastry: pulse flour, butter, and sugar until sandy. Add yolk and water. Bring together into a disc. Chill 30 minutes.
2. Roll to 3mm. Line a 23cm tart tin. Blind bake at 180°C (350°F) for 15 minutes, then 5 minutes uncovered.
3. Whisk eggs, sugar, lemon zest, lemon juice, and cream until smooth.
4. Pour filling into the warm tart shell (still in the tin).
5. Bake at 150°C (300°F) for 25–30 minutes until filling is set but still slightly wobbly in the center.
6. Cool completely at room temperature, then refrigerate at least 2 hours before slicing.

Prep: 25 min + chilling · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~310 per slice

TIP

Bake the filling at a LOW temperature (150°C). High heat cracks the surface and makes the filling grainy. Low and slow creates the velvet texture.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 18

■ ■ France

CRÊPES NATURE AU BEURRE

The most fundamental French crêpe — paper-thin, lacy, and eaten simply with melted butter and a squeeze of lemon. No jam, no Nutella, no toppings. Just the crêpe in its purest, most honest form. This is how Breton grandmothers eat them.

INGREDIENTS

- 125g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 2 large eggs
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 1 tbsp melted butter
- 1 tsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- Extra butter for the pan
- Lemon wedges and sugar to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, eggs, milk, melted butter, sugar, and salt in a blender. Blend 30 seconds until completely smooth. Alternatively, whisk vigorously by hand.
2. Pass through a fine sieve. Rest batter 30 minutes minimum at room temperature.
3. Heat a 24cm (9.5-inch) crêpe pan or non-stick pan over medium-high heat. Add a small knob of butter.
4. Pour a small ladleful (about 60ml) of batter. Immediately tilt and swirl the pan to spread it paper-thin in one circular motion.
5. Cook 60–90 seconds until the surface is dry and edges begin to color and lift. Flip with a spatula or your fingers (if brave).
6. Cook 30 seconds on the second side. Slide onto a plate.
7. Eat immediately with a squeeze of lemon and a sprinkle of sugar. Repeat.

Prep: 5 min + 30 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8–10 · Cal: ~120 per crêpe

TIP

The first crêpe is almost always a failure — the pan needs to calibrate its heat and butter. Consider it the cook's snack and proceed without guilt.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly] [Classic French]

RECIPE 19

■ ■ France

YOGOURT À LA FRANÇAISE

FRENCH-STYLE YOGURT BOWL

French-style whole-milk yogurt served in a glass jar with chestnut honey, crushed pistachios, and seasonal fresh fruit. Simple, elegant, and done in 3 minutes — the weekday French breakfast when there is no time for croissants but quality is non-negotiable.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) French-style whole milk yogurt (or Greek yogurt)
- 2 tbsp chestnut honey or floral honey
- 30g (¼ cup) crushed roasted pistachios
- 1 tsp rose water (optional)
- 150g fresh fruit: raspberries, sliced fig, or stone fruit
- Pinch of fine salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spoon yogurt into two bowls or glass jars.
2. Drizzle honey over the top. Add a tiny pinch of salt — it enhances the sweetness and cuts the acidity.
3. Scatter fresh fruit over the yogurt.
4. Sprinkle crushed pistachios generously.
5. Add a small splash of rose water for a Parisian patisserie touch if desired.
6. Serve immediately with a small espresso.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~260 per serving

TIP

The tiny pinch of salt on the honey is a professional patissier trick. It makes the sweetness taste more complex and the fruit taste brighter.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Low-Effort] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 20

■ ■ France

ŒUFS BROUILLÉS À LA TRUFFE

TRUFFLED SCRAMBLED EGGS

Slow-cooked French scrambled eggs — impossibly creamy and soft, infused with the earthy perfume of black truffle. The French method cooks eggs over a double boiler in a constant, gentle stir, creating a texture closer to loose custard than conventional scrambled eggs.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs, room temperature
- 3 tbsp cold unsalted butter, diced
- 2 tbsp crème fraîche
- 10g (¼ oz) fresh black truffle or 1 tsp truffle oil
- Salt and white pepper
- Brioche toasts, to serve
- Fresh chives, finely snipped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Crack eggs into a small heavy-bottomed saucepan. Add cold butter cubes, salt, and white pepper. Do NOT beat — they will combine during cooking.
2. Place saucepan over very low heat (or over a pot of barely simmering water — bain-marie method).
3. Stir constantly with a silicone spatula, scraping the bottom and sides. Never stop stirring.
4. The eggs will gradually form small, creamy, luscious curds over 8–12 minutes. Do not rush.
5. When nearly done (still slightly wet), remove from heat. Stir in crème fraîche to stop cooking.
6. Fold in sliced fresh truffle or a few drops of truffle oil.
7. Immediately spoon onto warm brioche toasts. Scatter chives. Serve at once.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

Cold butter cubes added directly to raw eggs regulate the cooking temperature from within, preventing overcooking. Remove from heat slightly before done — residual heat finishes the eggs to perfection.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 21

■ ■ France (Brittany)

KOUIGN-AMANN

Pronounced "KWEEN ah-MAHN" — Breton for "butter cake." A yeast-leavened pastry folded with copious salted butter and sugar until it caramelizes into a lacquered, crunchy, deeply golden slab. Invented accidentally in 1860 by a Breton baker, now beloved worldwide.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- ½ tsp salt
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 150g (⅓ cup) unsalted butter, cold
- 150g (¾ cup) granulated sugar
- ½ tsp fleur de sel

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, and salt. Add warm water. Knead 5–6 minutes until smooth and elastic. Proof 1 hour until doubled.
2. Pound cold butter between sheets of parchment into a 15cm (6-inch) square. Keep cold.
3. Roll dough into a rectangle twice the size of the butter. Place butter in the center, fold dough over to encase.
4. Roll out long. Sprinkle with ⅓ of the sugar. Fold into thirds. Repeat twice more with remaining sugar. Work quickly.
5. Press into a buttered 25cm (10-inch) round cake tin.
6. Sprinkle fleur de sel over the top. Proof 45 minutes.
7. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 25–30 minutes until deeply caramelized — it should look almost dangerously dark.
8. IMMEDIATELY invert onto parchment. The caramel will flow. Cool 20 minutes before cutting.

Prep: 30 min + 1 hr 45 min proofing · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~380 per slice

TIP

Invert the tin immediately upon removal from the oven. If you wait, the caramel sets and the pastry will stick permanently to the tin.

[Vegetarian] [Weekend Project] [Indulgent] [Classic French]

RECIPE 22

■ ■ France

CHOCOLAT CHAUD À LA FRANÇAISE

THICK FRENCH HOT CHOCOLATE

French café hot chocolate is an entirely different creature from the powdered packet variety. Thick, glossy, intensely chocolatey — made with real chopped chocolate and hot milk — it is consumed in a small cup with a croissant and qualifies as one of life's great simple pleasures.

INGREDIENTS

- 70g (2.5 oz) dark chocolate (70% cocoa), finely chopped
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 2 tbsp heavy cream
- 1 tsp sugar (or to taste)
- Tiny pinch of fleur de sel
- Pinch of cinnamon (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat milk and heavy cream in a small saucepan over medium heat until it just begins to steam. Do not boil.
2. Remove from heat. Add chopped chocolate all at once.
3. Let sit 1 minute, then whisk vigorously until the chocolate is completely melted and the mixture is smooth and glossy.
4. Return to low heat. Whisk constantly 2–3 minutes until slightly thickened and very smooth.
5. Add sugar and pinch of fleur de sel.
6. Pour into a small warmed cup. Dust with cinnamon if desired.
7. Serve immediately alongside a croissant or madeleine.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~340 per cup

TIP

Quality of chocolate is everything here. Use a good 70% dark chocolate bar, not baking chips. The fat content in a good chocolate bar creates the characteristic thickness.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 23

■ ■ Italy

CORNETTO CLASSICO

The Italian cornetto is the country's answer to the croissant — but softer, sweeter, and enriched with orange and vanilla. Unlike the French version, it is meant to be dunked into your cappuccino. This is the breakfast of 50 million Italians every morning.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 2 large eggs
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- Zest of 1 orange
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp salt
- Apricot jam or Nutella for filling
- Egg wash and honey for glazing

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, sugar, yeast, and salt. Add warm milk, eggs, orange zest, and vanilla. Knead 8 minutes.
2. Add softened butter bit by bit. Knead until smooth and elastic (another 5 minutes). Dough will be quite soft.
3. Cover and refrigerate overnight (minimum 8 hours).
4. Roll chilled dough into a large circle. Cut into triangles (like a pizza, 12 slices).
5. Place a small spoonful of jam at the wide base of each triangle.
6. Roll toward the tip, stretching gently. Curve ends slightly.
7. Place on lined baking trays. Proof 2–3 hours until noticeably puffed.
8. Brush with egg wash. Bake 190°C (375°F) for 16–18 minutes until golden.
9. While still hot, brush with warm honey for shine.

Prep: 30 min + overnight · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~280 per cornetto

TIP

Unlike croissants, cornetti dough has no lamination step — the butter is worked directly into the dough. This makes them softer and more bread-like. They should feel pillowy, not flaky.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Italian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 24

■■ Italy

CAPPUCCINO PERFETTO

The cappuccino — one-third espresso, one-third steamed milk, one-third foam — is Italy's most famous export and the gold standard morning coffee worldwide. Made correctly, it is warm, velvety, and never bitter. In Italy, it is always served before noon. Always.

INGREDIENTS

- 18g (2 tbsp) freshly ground espresso
- 150ml (■ cup) cold whole milk (full fat is non-negotiable)
- Water for the machine

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pull a double espresso shot into a preheated 150ml cup. Target: 30–35ml espresso in 25–30 seconds.
2. Pour cold milk into a cold metal steaming pitcher (fill to just below the spout).
3. Purge the steam wand briefly. Submerge the tip just below the milk surface.
4. Steam milk: keep the tip near the surface to create "microfoam" — incorporated, velvety foam, not large bubbles. Target temperature: 65°C (150°F).
5. Tap the pitcher on the counter and swirl to integrate. Milk should look like wet paint — glossy and silky.
6. Pour immediately over the espresso using a small circular motion. The ratio should be even thirds.
7. Dust with cocoa powder if desired. Drink within 2 minutes.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~80 per cappuccino

TIP

Cold milk creates better microfoam. Never add cold milk to already-steamed milk. Always start fresh. The glossier the foam, the better the cappuccino.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic Italian] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 25

■■ Italy

FRITTATA ALLE VERDURE

Italy's signature open-faced omelette — started on the stovetop and finished under the broiler. Unlike a French omelette, the frittata is firm, sliceable, and deeply flavored. It can be eaten hot, warm, or cold — making it the ultimate Italian make-ahead breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 2 tbsp whole milk
- 60g (■ cup) Parmigiano-Reggiano, grated
- 1 small zucchini, thinly sliced
- ½ red bell pepper, diced
- 1 small onion, thinly sliced
- 80g (3 oz) cherry tomatoes, halved
- 2 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh basil leaves

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat broiler to high.
2. Heat olive oil in a 24cm (9.5-inch) ovenproof skillet over medium heat. Sauté onion 3 minutes until soft.
3. Add zucchini and bell pepper. Cook 5 minutes until tender and slightly colored. Season with salt and pepper.
4. Add cherry tomatoes. Cook 2 minutes more.
5. Beat eggs with milk, Parmigiano, salt, and pepper. Pour evenly over the vegetables.
6. Cook undisturbed over medium-low heat 4–5 minutes until edges are set and bottom is golden.
7. Transfer to broiler. Broil 3–4 minutes until top is golden and set.
8. Rest 5 minutes. Scatter fresh basil. Slice into wedges.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

The frittata is the Italian answer to emptying the refrigerator. Leftover pasta, sautéed greens, cold potato — anything works. Think of this recipe as a template, not a prescription.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Vegetarian]

RECIPE 26

■■ Italy

BRUSCHETTA AL POMODORO

Grilled sourdough rubbed with raw garlic while still hot, then piled with ripe diced tomatoes dressed in olive oil, salt, and basil. The original Italian antipasto is also one of the world's great breakfasts. Four ingredients, zero compromise.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices sourdough or ciabatta
- 2 large garlic cloves, halved
- 400g (14 oz) ripe Roma tomatoes, diced
- 3 tbsp premium extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp flaky sea salt
- Fresh black pepper
- 10–12 fresh basil leaves, torn
- Optional: aged balsamic vinegar, for drizzling

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grill or toast bread under a hot broiler until golden with slightly charred edges.
2. IMMEDIATELY (while still searing hot), rub the cut side of a garlic clove firmly over the surface of each slice. The rough bread acts like a grater — the garlic melts right in.
3. Combine diced tomatoes with olive oil, sea salt, and fresh pepper in a bowl. Let sit 5 minutes.
4. Spoon tomatoes generously over each bruschetta.
5. Scatter torn basil over the top.
6. Drizzle with balsamic vinegar if desired.
7. Eat immediately — bruschetta waits for no one.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~220 per bruschetta

TIP

Salt the tomatoes 10 minutes before serving and let them drain slightly. This concentrates the flavor and prevents the bread from going soggy immediately.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Classic Italian] [5 Ingredients]

RECIPE 27

■■ Italy

CROSTATA DI MARMELLATA

Italy's most beloved home breakfast bake — a crumbly sweet pastry shell filled with jam and topped with a classic lattice. Every Italian grandmother makes a crostata differently. Every Italian grandmother's version is the best. This is how it's done.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PASTA FROLLA (ITALIAN SHORTCRUST)

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 150g (■ cup) cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 120g (1 cup) powdered sugar
- 2 egg yolks
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 1–2 tbsp cold milk if needed

FILLING

- 300g (1 cup) good quality jam: apricot, cherry, or fig

INSTRUCTIONS

1. In a food processor, pulse flour, sugar, and salt. Add cold butter. Pulse until the texture of fine sand.
2. Add egg yolks, lemon zest, and vanilla. Pulse until dough begins to come together. Add cold milk only if needed.
3. Turn out, press into a disc, wrap. Chill 30 minutes.
4. Roll ■ of dough to 3mm. Line a 25cm (10-inch) tart tin. Trim edges.
5. Spread jam evenly over the base.
6. Roll remaining dough and cut into strips. Lay over jam in a classic lattice pattern.
7. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 35–40 minutes until pale golden.
8. Cool completely in the tin before removing and slicing.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min chill · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~280 per slice

TIP

Don't overwork pasta frolla — it becomes tough. Mix only until it barely comes together. The crumbly, "sandy" texture of well-made pasta frolla is distinctive and exactly right.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Italian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 28

■■ Italy

CIAMBELLA AL LIMONE

A ring-shaped Italian breakfast cake scented with lemon — tender, moist, and lightly sweet. Made in nearly every Italian home on Sunday mornings, the ciambella is sliced thick and eaten with coffee. Simple, honest, unforgettable.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 200g (1 cup) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk
- 120ml (½ cup) light olive oil or sunflower oil
- Zest of 2 large lemons
- Juice of 1 lemon
- 1 packet (16g) Italian baking powder (or 2 tsp standard)
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- Powdered sugar, for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 175°C (345°F). Grease a 24cm (9.5-inch) bundt or ring pan.
2. Beat eggs and sugar together 3 minutes until pale and slightly thickened.
3. Add oil, milk, lemon zest, lemon juice, and vanilla. Mix to combine.
4. Sift flour, baking powder, and salt over the wet ingredients. Fold until just combined — a few lumps are fine.
5. Pour into the prepared pan.
6. Bake 35–40 minutes until a skewer inserted comes out clean and the top is golden.
7. Cool in pan 10 minutes. Invert onto a rack.
8. Dust with powdered sugar before serving.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~260 per slice

TIP

Use a good olive oil (not extra-virgin) for a delicate, slightly fruity background flavor that enhances the lemon. Sunflower oil works but olive oil is more Italian.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Italian] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 29

■■ Italy

PANE E OLIO

BREAD, OIL & SALT

Three ingredients. Zero cooking. Infinite satisfaction. Fresh bread dipped in extra-virgin olive oil and sprinkled with flaky sea salt is how countless Italians — particularly in the south — begin their day. A reminder that great food requires great ingredients, not great skill.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ loaf fresh rustic Italian bread (pane pugliese or ciabatta)
- 4 tbsp best quality extra-virgin olive oil you own
- Flaky sea salt (Maldon or fleur de sel)
- Optional: dried oregano, chilli flakes, or a garlic clove

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Tear or slice bread into thick pieces. Lightly toast if preferred — not required.
2. Pour olive oil into a small, wide bowl or plate.
3. Dip bread directly into oil. Let it soak a few seconds.
4. Sprinkle flaky salt generously over the oil-soaked bread.
5. Add oregano or chilli flakes if using.
6. Eat with espresso or a glass of cold water. That is the entire recipe.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

This recipe is only as good as its olive oil. Use the best bottle you have — a fresh, grassy, peppery Sicilian or Tuscan oil will make this transcendent. Old, flat olive oil will make it forgettable.

[Vegan] [Quick] [5 Ingredients] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 30

■■ Italy (Naples)

SFOGLIATELLE RICCE

The holy grail of Neapolitan pastry — a shell-shaped, shatteringly crispy pastry with hundreds of paper-thin dough layers, filled with a warm orange-scented semolina and ricotta cream. Every bite crumbles and shatters. Best eaten standing outside a Neapolitan pasticceria at 8am.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) durum wheat semolina flour
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 1 tsp salt
- 200g (¾ cup) lard or shortening (for lamination)

FOR THE FILLING

- 250g (1 cup) fresh ricotta
- 150g (¾ cup) cooked fine semolina
- 150g (¾ cup) sugar
- 2 egg yolks
- Zest of 1 orange
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- 50g (¼ cup) candied orange peel, finely diced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix semolina flour, warm water, and salt into a stiff dough. Knead 10 minutes. Rest 30 minutes covered.
2. Using a pasta machine, roll dough as thin as possible. Spread very thin layer of lard over the entire surface.
3. Roll into a tight log. Refrigerate 1 hour.
4. Slice log into 1cm rounds. Press each round from the center outward to form a cone shape.
5. Mix all filling ingredients until smooth.
6. Fill each cone with ricotta filling. Press edges to seal.
7. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 20–25 minutes until deeply golden and shattery.
8. Dust with powdered sugar. Serve immediately while warm.

Prep: 60 min + 1 hr chilling · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~240 per pastry

TIP

This is an advanced recipe requiring patience. The more layers in the log, the better the final result. Roll the dough as thin as absolutely possible — translucent is the goal.

[Classic Italian] [Advanced] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 31

■■ Italy

UOVA IN PURGATORIO

EGGS IN PURGATORY

Eggs poached directly in a spicy, bubbling tomato sauce — a fiery, rustic southern Italian breakfast that combines the gentle with the dramatic. The eggs cook nestled in the sauce, absorbing its heat and flavor. Eat directly from the pan with crusty bread.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) crushed San Marzano tomatoes
- 1 small onion, finely diced
- 3 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- ½ tsp red chilli flakes (or more, to taste)
- 2 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 4 large eggs
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh basil, torn
- Crusty bread to serve
- Parmigiano-Reggiano, grated (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide skillet over medium heat. Add onion and cook 5 minutes until soft and translucent.
2. Add garlic and chilli flakes. Cook 1 minute until fragrant.
3. Add crushed tomatoes. Season with salt and pepper. Simmer 10 minutes until sauce thickens slightly.
4. Create 4 small wells in the sauce with the back of a spoon.
5. Crack one egg carefully into each well.
6. Cover the pan. Cook over medium-low heat 5–7 minutes until whites are just set and yolks are still runny.
7. Remove from heat. Scatter fresh basil.
8. Serve immediately from the pan with crusty bread for dipping into the sauce and breaking the yolks.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

Use the best canned San Marzano tomatoes available. They are sweeter, less acidic, and deeper in flavor than standard canned tomatoes. This dish has four ingredients — each one must be excellent.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 32

■■ Italy

BOMBOLONI ALLA CREMA

Italian filled doughnuts — round, golden, deeply fried, and filled with silky vanilla custard cream then rolled in sugar. A staple of Italian bars and beach kiosks, the bombolone is best eaten warm so the cream is still almost liquid inside.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- ½ tsp salt
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 2 eggs
- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- Zest of 1 lemon

FOR THE CREMA PASTICCIERA FILLING

- 4 egg yolks
- 80g (⅓ cup) sugar
- 40g (⅓ cup) cornstarch
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Vegetable oil for frying, plus granulated sugar for rolling

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make dough: combine flour, sugar, yeast, salt, milk, eggs, and lemon zest. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Cover and proof 1½ hours until doubled.
3. Make crema: whisk yolks, sugar, and cornstarch in a saucepan. Gradually add warm milk. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until thick and smooth. Stir in vanilla. Cover surface with plastic wrap. Cool completely.
4. Roll dough to 2cm thick. Cut rounds (6cm diameter). Proof 30–45 minutes on lined trays.
5. Deep fry in oil at 170°C (340°F) for 2–3 minutes per side until deep golden. Drain on paper towels.
6. Roll immediately in sugar.
7. Inject crema through a small hole using a piping bag with a long narrow nozzle.

Prep: 30 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 14 · Cal: ~280 per bombolone

TIP

Fill bomboloni only when ready to serve — the cream makes the dough soggy over time. They are a "right now" food. Eat while warm.

[Vegetarian] [Indulgent] [Classic Italian]

RECIPE 33

■■ Italy

TORTA DI MELE DELLA NONNA

GRANDMOTHER'S APPLE CAKE

Every Italian grandmother has a torta di mele recipe — a moist, dense apple cake scented with cinnamon and lemon that fills the kitchen with warmth. Made in a single bowl, no mixer required, served in thick slices at breakfast for a week. Unfussy, reliable, and deeply comforting.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large apples (Golden or Fuji), peeled, cored, diced
- 3 large eggs
- 180g (¾ cup + 2 tbsp) sugar
- 150ml (⅔ cup) milk
- 100ml (⅓ cup + 1 tbsp) vegetable oil
- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 packet (16g) Italian baking powder
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Zest of 1 lemon
- Pinch of salt
- Powdered sugar, for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Grease and flour a 24cm (9.5-inch) springform cake pan.
2. In a large bowl, whisk together eggs and sugar until pale.
3. Add milk and oil. Whisk to combine.
4. Sift in flour, baking powder, cinnamon, and salt. Fold until just combined — do not overmix.
5. Fold in diced apples and lemon zest.
6. Pour batter into prepared pan.
7. Bake 45–50 minutes until a skewer comes out clean and the top is deeply golden.
8. Cool 15 minutes before releasing from pan.
9. Dust with powdered sugar before serving.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 10 slices · Cal: ~270 per slice

TIP

This cake is better the next day — the apple moisture permeates the crumb overnight, making it more dense and flavorful. Make it Sunday evening for Monday breakfast.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Italian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 34

■■ Italy

POLENTA DOLCE AL MIELE

SWEET HONEY POLENTA

Creamy, slow-cooked northern Italian polenta prepared as a sweet breakfast porridge — enriched with butter, stirred with chestnut honey, and topped with fresh berries or stewed fruit. A warming, gluten-free alternative to oatmeal with a deeply comforting Italian soul.

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (1 cup) fine instant polenta (or regular polenta)
- 750ml (3 cups) whole milk
- 250ml (1 cup) water
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 tbsp chestnut honey or wildflower honey
- Pinch of salt
- Fresh berries or stewed figs, to serve
- Extra honey and mascarpone, to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring milk, water, and salt to a gentle simmer in a heavy-bottomed saucepan.
2. Pour polenta in a slow, steady stream while whisking constantly to prevent lumps.
3. Reduce heat to very low. Cook, stirring with a wooden spoon every 2 minutes, for 5 minutes (instant polenta) or 30 minutes (coarse polenta) until thick, smooth, and creamy.
4. Remove from heat. Stir in butter and honey.
5. Divide into warm bowls.
6. Top with fresh berries and a teaspoon of mascarpone.
7. Drizzle with extra honey to serve.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 10 min (instant) · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

Use fine polenta for a smooth porridge texture. Coarse polenta creates a grainier, more rustic result. Both are delicious — choose based on your preference.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 35

■■ Italy

CROSTINI CON RICOTTA E MIELE

Grilled baguette slices spread with whipped, seasoned ricotta and drizzled with truffle honey or wildflower honey. A sophisticated Italian bar snack that works magnificently as a quick weekday breakfast — creamy, sweet, salty, and crunchy all at once.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 slices baguette or ciabatta
- 250g (1 cup) fresh whole-milk ricotta
- 2 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- Salt and black pepper
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 3 tbsp wildflower honey (or truffle honey if available)
- Handful of crushed pistachios or walnuts
- Fresh thyme leaves (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grill or toast bread slices until golden and crispy.
2. In a bowl, whisk ricotta with olive oil, lemon zest, salt, and pepper until light and slightly fluffy.
3. Spread the whipped ricotta generously over each crostino.
4. Drizzle honey over the ricotta.
5. Scatter crushed pistachios or walnuts.
6. Add a few fresh thyme leaves if using.
7. Serve immediately.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~230 per serving (2 crostini)

TIP

Whipping ricotta with olive oil and a fork for 2 minutes transforms it from a bland fresh cheese into something airy and luxurious. This step is worth doing.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [High Protein] [Elegant]

RECIPE 36

■■ Italy

GRANOLA ITALIANA CON MANDORLE

Italian-inspired granola loaded with almonds, pistachios, and hazelnuts — toasted with olive oil and wildflower honey. Served over thick yogurt with fresh seasonal fruit. Italy's answer to the breakfast bowl — more nuts, more flavor, less sugar.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (3 cups) rolled oats
- 100g (¾ cup) almonds, roughly chopped
- 60g (½ cup) pistachios, roughly chopped
- 60g (½ cup) hazelnuts, roughly chopped
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 4 tbsp wildflower honey
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- Pinch of salt
- 400g (1¾ cups) Greek yogurt, to serve
- Fresh figs, peaches, or berries, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 160°C (320°F). Line a large baking sheet.
2. Combine oats, all nuts, olive oil, honey, vanilla, cinnamon, and salt. Toss until every piece is coated.
3. Spread in a single even layer on baking sheet.
4. Bake 25–30 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until golden and fragrant. Watch carefully — nuts burn quickly.
5. Remove from oven. Let cool completely on the pan — it crisps significantly as it cools. Do not stir after removing from oven.
6. Store in an airtight jar up to 3 weeks.
7. Serve over thick yogurt with fresh seasonal fruit.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 8 (granola) · Cal: ~380 per serving with yogurt

TIP

Olive oil instead of butter gives this granola a subtle fruity, savory depth that makes it distinctly Italian. Don't substitute — it makes all the difference.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 37

■■ Italy

PANE TOSCANO CON PROSCIUTTO

Thick slices of unsalted Tuscan bread (pane sciocco) topped with paper-thin prosciutto di Parma and a drizzle of extra-virgin olive oil. The saltless bread is intentional — it lets the prosciutto's saltiness shine. The Tuscans have been

right about this for 700 years.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices Pane Toscano or any rustic white bread
- 100g (3.5 oz) Prosciutto di Parma or San Daniele, very thinly sliced
- 2 tbsp premium extra-virgin Tuscan olive oil
- Fresh black pepper
- Optional: 4 fresh basil leaves, a handful of arugula

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Lightly toast or grill bread until just warm with slight color. Do not over-toast.
2. Lay prosciutto slices over each piece of bread, folding them loosely to create layers and volume.
3. Drizzle olive oil over the top.
4. Add a few grinds of fresh black pepper.
5. Tuck basil leaves or arugula under the prosciutto if desired.
6. Serve immediately.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Never fold prosciutto flat against the bread — scrunch or ruffle it loosely so there are layers and pockets of air. This texture is essential.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Quick] [Classic Italian]

RECIPE 38

■■ Italy

FETTE BISCOTTATE CON BURRO

Fette biscottate are Italian twice-baked toast crackers — extremely crispy, neutral in flavor, and sold in every Italian supermarket. Spread with good butter and apricot jam, they are the weekday Italian breakfast standard. Humble, crunchy, and oddly satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 fette biscottate (Italian rusk crackers)
- 4 tbsp unsalted Italian butter, room temperature
- 4 tbsp apricot jam (Confettura di Albicocche)
- Optional: 1 tbsp honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Remove fette biscottate from packaging. They require no preparation — they are already crisp.
2. Spread butter on each cracker while the cracker is at room temperature — not warm.
3. Spoon jam over the butter.
4. Optional: drizzle honey over the jam.
5. Eat immediately with a cappuccino.
6. Dip into the cappuccino. This is acceptable. This is encouraged.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~180 per serving (4 crackers)

TIP

The entire ritual of the Italian bar breakfast — standing, espresso, dipping the cornetto or cracker — is part of the experience. Try eating this standing at your kitchen counter. It genuinely tastes different.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic Italian] [5 Ingredients]

RECIPE 39

■■ Italy

RISOTTO AL LATTE

MILK RICE PORRIDGE

Sweet risotto cooked in whole milk with vanilla and honey — the Italian answer to rice pudding for breakfast. A northern Italian farmhouse tradition, risotto al latte is warm, creamy, and deeply nourishing on cold mornings.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1 cup) Carnaroli or Arborio risotto rice
- 900ml (3¾ cups) whole milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Ground cinnamon, to serve
- Fresh berries or jam, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rice, milk, water, sugar, lemon zest, and salt in a medium saucepan over medium heat.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer, stirring. Reduce heat to low.
3. Cook 20–25 minutes, stirring every few minutes, until rice is tender and the mixture is thick and creamy. The milk will reduce and absorb gradually.
4. Remove from heat. Stir in vanilla extract and butter.
5. Serve immediately in warm bowls.
6. Top with a sprinkle of cinnamon and fresh berries or a spoonful of jam.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Use real risotto rice (Arborio or Carnaroli) — the high starch content creates a natural creaminess that no other rice can replicate in this dish.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Comfort Food] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 40

■■ Italy

MOKA POT CAFFÈ NERO

The Moka pot — invented in 1933 by Alfonso Bialetti — is the appliance that defines Italian domestic coffee culture. A stovetop pressure brewer that produces strong, concentrated coffee with a complexity between espresso and drip. In 90% of Italian homes, this is how breakfast coffee is made every single morning.

INGREDIENTS

- Fine-ground Italian espresso blend coffee
- (Lavazza Rossa or similar)
- Cold filtered water
- Optional: sugar added directly to the cup

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Unscrew the Moka pot into its three parts: base, filter basket, and top chamber.
2. Fill the base with cold water to just below the safety valve. Never fill above it.
3. Fill the filter basket with finely ground coffee. Do not pack or tamp — fill level and sweep smooth.
4. Screw the top firmly to the base.
5. Place on a stovetop burner over low-medium heat. Leave the lid open so you can watch.
6. After 4–5 minutes, coffee will begin to bubble up into the top chamber. When you hear it begin to splutter and hiss, remove from heat immediately.
7. Run the base under cold water to halt brewing.
8. Pour into small warmed cups. Add sugar if desired.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~5 per serving (black)

TIP

The moment it begins to sputter, remove it from the heat. Continuing to brew after the splutter creates bitter, over-extracted coffee. Pull early. Always.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Italian]

RECIPE 41

■■ Italy

TORTA DI RICOTTA

A creamy, dense Italian ricotta cheesecake — entirely different from New York style. Made with fresh whole-milk ricotta, lemon, and a hint of vanilla, this unfussy Italian cake is best made the night before and served in generous slices for breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (2 cups) whole-milk ricotta, drained
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 3 large eggs
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour
- Pinch of salt
- Powdered sugar, for finishing

FOR THE BASE

- 200g (7 oz) digestive biscuits or graham crackers, crushed
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 170°C (340°F). Mix crushed biscuits with melted butter. Press into the base of a 22cm springform pan. Refrigerate.
2. Beat ricotta and sugar together until smooth.
3. Add eggs one at a time, mixing well after each.
4. Add lemon zest, vanilla, flour, and salt. Mix until smooth.
5. Pour over the chilled base.
6. Bake 45–50 minutes until set but still with a slight wobble in the center.
7. Turn off oven. Leave the door ajar. Let the cake cool in the oven for 30 minutes.
8. Refrigerate at least 4 hours before serving.
9. Dust with powdered sugar.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hr chill · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~295 per slice

TIP

Drain the ricotta well before using — excess whey will make the cake wet and prevent proper setting. Place ricotta in a fine sieve over a bowl overnight in the fridge for perfectly dry ricotta.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Italian]

RECIPE 42

■■ Italy

PROSCIUTTO E MELONE

HAM AND MELON

The most elegant two-ingredient breakfast in the world — silky, salty prosciutto di Parma draped over cold, sweet cantaloupe melon. A combination born in Italy, perfected over centuries, and requiring nothing more than excellent ingredients and a sharp knife.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 ripe cantaloupe or honeydew melon
- 120g (4.5 oz) Prosciutto di Parma, very thinly sliced
- Fresh black pepper
- Optional: fresh mint, a drizzle of aged balsamic

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Select a perfectly ripe melon — it should smell sweet and give slightly at the stem end when pressed.
2. Halve the melon, scoop out seeds. Slice into long wedges. Remove the rind if desired.
3. Arrange melon slices on a plate or board.
4. Drape prosciutto slices loosely over and around the melon — do not lay flat.
5. Add a grind of fresh black pepper.
6. Add mint or a drizzle of aged balsamic if desired.
7. Serve immediately, chilled.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~180 per serving

TIP

Temperature is everything. The melon should be cold. The prosciutto should be room temperature. This contrast — the warm silkiness of the ham against the cool sweetness of the melon — is the whole point.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [No-Cook] [Quick]

RECIPE 43

■■ Italy (Sicily)

COLAZIONE SICILIANA —

The legendary Sicilian breakfast — a brioche col tuppo (a sweet round roll with a topknot) split and served alongside a granita, traditionally almond or coffee. The brioche is dipped directly into the semi-frozen granita and eaten as one. This is genius.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE GRANITA DI CAFFÈ (COFFEE GRANITA):
- 500ml (2 cups) strong brewed espresso or coffee, cooled
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- ½ tsp vanilla extract

FOR SERVING

- 4 Sicilian brioche col tuppo (or regular brioche rolls)
- Lightly sweetened whipped cream (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Stir sugar into warm coffee until fully dissolved. Add vanilla. Cool completely.
2. Pour into a shallow metal baking pan. Freeze for 30 minutes.
3. Remove, scrape with a fork, and return to freezer. Repeat every 30 minutes for 2–3 hours until you have coarse, icy crystals.
4. Just before serving, spoon granita into small bowls or wide cups.
5. Split brioche and place alongside.
6. To eat: break off a piece of brioche, dip into the granita, and eat together.

Prep: 10 min + 3 hr freezing · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The granita must be scraped into coarse, icy crystals — not blended smooth like a slushie. The texture is essential. Freeze in a shallow pan for faster, more even freezing.

[Vegetarian] [Seasonal] [Special Occasion] [Sicilian Classic]

RECIPE 44

■■ Italy (Tuscany)

CANTUCCI CON LATTE CALDO

Crunchy twice-baked Tuscan almond biscuits — cantucci — made with whole almonds, orange zest, and anise. Traditionally dipped in Vin Santo wine, they are equally magnificent dunked into hot milk or espresso for breakfast. Hard, fragrant, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 350g (2¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 2 large eggs + 1 egg yolk
- 1 tsp baking powder
- Zest of 1 orange + zest of 1 lemon
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp anise seeds or fennel seeds
- 180g (1¼ cups) whole blanched almonds
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tbsp Vin Santo or Amaretto (optional)
- Egg wash for glazing

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Line a baking sheet.
2. Mix flour, sugar, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Add eggs, yolk, vanilla, zests, anise seeds, and liqueur. Stir to form a stiff dough.
4. Fold in whole almonds.
5. Divide dough into 2 logs about 30cm long. Place on baking sheet. Brush with egg wash.
6. Bake 25 minutes until golden and firm.
7. Remove. Reduce oven to 150°C (300°F).
8. Cool logs 10 minutes, then slice diagonally into 1.5cm biscuits.
9. Lay flat on baking sheet. Bake 15 more minutes, turning once, until completely dry and crisp.
10. Cool completely. Store in a tin up to 3 weeks.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 30 cantucci · Cal: ~100 per biscuit

TIP

Cantucci must be hard — they are designed for dunking. If they seem too crunchy to eat dry, you are making them correctly. Dunk enthusiastically.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Italian] [Crowd-Pleaser]

Germany

RECIPE 45

■■ Germany

FRÜHSTÜCKSBROT MIT AUFSCHNITT

GERMAN BREAKFAST BREAD WITH COLD CUTS

The cornerstone of the German breakfast table — thick slices of dark rye or mixed-grain bread topped with an array of cold cuts, cheeses, and spreads. Called "Brotzeit" in Bavaria, this open-faced spread is eaten slowly, deliberately, and with great satisfaction every morning across all of Germany.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices dark rye bread (Roggenbrot) or mixed grain
- 4 slices Vollkornbrot (whole grain bread)
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter, room temperature
- 100g (3.5 oz) sliced Schwarzwälder Schinken (Black Forest ham)
- 100g (3.5 oz) sliced Leberkäse or Fleischwurst
- 100g (3.5 oz) aged Gouda or Emmental, sliced
- 2 tbsp Obatzda (Bavarian cream cheese spread)
- 4 radishes, thinly sliced
- 1 small cucumber, sliced
- Fresh chives, chopped
- German mustard (medium hot)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Arrange all breads on a large wooden board or plate.
2. Set out butter in a small ramekin.
3. Spread butter generously on each bread slice.
4. Top some slices with folded ham, others with Fleischwurst or cheese slices.
5. Add a spoonful of Obatzda to some slices.
6. Layer radishes, cucumber slices, and chives over the toppings.
7. Add a small bowl of German mustard on the side.
8. Serve with strong black coffee or tea.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~410 per serving

TIP

The German breakfast is about variety and abundance — the more types of bread, cheese, and cold cuts on the board, the more authentic the experience. Never use just one bread.

[High Protein] [Classic German] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 46

■■ Germany

RÜHREI MIT SPECK

SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH BACON

German-style scrambled eggs are cooked slowly over low heat until creamy and soft — never dry. Paired with crispy Speck (cured smoked bacon), fresh chives, and eaten with dark bread, this is a simple, deeply satisfying German breakfast that takes patience but rewards it completely.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 60ml (¼ cup) whole milk or cream
- 150g (5 oz) Speck or smoked bacon, diced
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt and white pepper
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, finely chopped
- Dark rye bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cook diced Speck in a dry skillet over medium heat until golden and crispy. Remove with a slotted spoon and set aside. Drain excess fat from pan.
2. Whisk eggs with milk, a pinch of salt, and white pepper until thoroughly combined.
3. Melt butter in the same pan over very low heat.
4. Pour in egg mixture. Stir slowly and constantly with a wooden spoon or silicone spatula — never stop moving.
5. Cook gently for 6–8 minutes until eggs form large, soft, glossy curds. They should look barely set.
6. Remove from heat while still slightly underdone — residual heat finishes them.
7. Fold in crispy Speck.
8. Scatter chives over the top.
9. Serve immediately on dark bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

The secret to German-style scrambled eggs is relentless low heat and constant stirring. The moment they look "done," they are already overdone. Pull early, always.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Quick]

RECIPE 47

■■ Germany / ■■ Switzerland

BIRCHER MÜSLI

Created by Swiss physician Dr. Maximilian Bircher-Benner in the 1900s, this overnight oat preparation became the template for every modern overnight oats recipe. Raw oats soaked in milk with grated apple, lemon, and honey — refreshing, nutritious, and endlessly adaptable. A German and Swiss breakfast staple.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats (not instant)
- 240ml (1 cup) whole milk or oat milk
- 2 tbsp plain yogurt
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp honey or maple syrup
- 1 large apple, freshly grated (with skin)
- 50g (¼ cup) mixed berries
- 2 tbsp mixed seeds (sunflower, pumpkin, flax)
- 2 tbsp chopped nuts (hazelnuts or almonds)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. NIGHT BEFORE: Combine oats, milk, yogurt, lemon juice, and honey in a bowl or jar. Stir well.
2. Cover and refrigerate overnight, minimum 8 hours.
3. MORNING: Remove from refrigerator.
4. Grate the apple directly into the oat mixture immediately before eating — this prevents browning.
5. Stir to combine. Add a splash more milk if too thick.
6. Top with fresh berries, seeds, and chopped nuts.
7. Serve cold.

Prep: 5 min + overnight · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The original Bircher Müsli used only 1 tablespoon of oats per person — it was primarily an apple dish with a little oat. Modern versions use more oats. Both approaches are delicious — try the original sometime.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [High Protein] [Vegan option]

RECIPE 48

■■ Germany

DEUTSCHES MÜSLI

GERMAN TOASTED MUESLI

Unlike the Swiss version which is soaked raw, German müsli is often lightly toasted for a nuttier, crunchier texture. Mixed with a generous variety of seeds, dried fruit, and nuts, then served with cold milk or yogurt. A staple in German health-food culture since the 1970s.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (3 cups) rolled oats
- 60g (½ cup) sunflower seeds
- 60g (½ cup) pumpkin seeds
- 80g (⅓ cup) hazelnuts, roughly chopped
- 60g (½ cup) almonds, roughly chopped
- 2 tbsp coconut oil or butter, melted
- 2 tbsp honey
- 100g (½ cup) dried apricots, chopped
- 80g (½ cup) raisins
- 50g (⅓ cup) dried cranberries
- Cold milk or yogurt, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 160°C (320°F). Line a large baking tray.
2. Mix oats, seeds, and nuts in a bowl.
3. Drizzle with melted coconut oil and honey. Toss until everything is lightly coated.
4. Spread in an even layer on the baking tray.
5. Toast in oven for 20–25 minutes, stirring every 8 minutes, until pale golden and fragrant.
6. Remove and cool completely.
7. Once cooled, stir in dried fruits.
8. Store in an airtight container for up to 4 weeks.
9. Serve with cold milk or yogurt.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~320 per serving (with milk)

TIP

Do not add dried fruits before toasting — they burn. Always add them after the toasted mixture has cooled completely.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free option]

RECIPE 49

■■ Germany

PFANNKUCHEN MIT APFELMUS

GERMAN PANCAKES WITH APPLE SAUCE

German Pfannkuchen are thicker and heartier than French crêpes, made with a simple egg-milk batter and cooked until golden on both sides. Rolled up with warm homemade apple sauce and dusted with cinnamon sugar — this is the German childhood breakfast that every adult still secretly wants on Sunday mornings.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PANCAKES

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 3 large eggs
- 350ml (1½ cups) whole milk
- 1 tbsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- Butter for cooking

FOR THE APPLE SAUCE

- 4 apples (Braeburn or Boskoop), peeled, cored, diced
- 3 tbsp sugar
- Juice of ½ lemon
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- 3 tbsp water
- Cinnamon sugar for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make apple sauce: combine apples, sugar, lemon juice, cinnamon, and water in a saucepan. Cook over medium heat 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until apples are completely soft. Mash roughly with a fork — leave some texture. Keep warm.
2. Whisk flour, eggs, milk, sugar, and salt until completely smooth. Rest batter 15 minutes.
3. Melt a small knob of butter in a large skillet over medium heat. Pour in a ladleful of batter and tilt to spread evenly (thicker than a crêpe).
4. Cook 2–3 minutes until bubbles form and edges are set. Flip and cook 1–2 more minutes until golden.
5. Transfer to a warm plate. Roll up.
6. Dust with cinnamon sugar. Serve with warm apple sauce.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Boskoop apples are the classic German cooking apple — tart, dense, and they hold their shape even when cooked down. Braeburn or Granny Smith are excellent substitutes outside Germany.

[Vegetarian] [Kid-Friendly] [Classic German] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 50

■■ Germany

BRÖTCHEN MIT FRISCHKÄSE

BREAD ROLLS WITH CREAM CHEESE

Fresh German bread rolls (Brötchen) are the backbone of the morning breakfast. Crusty outside, chewy inside, and best eaten within hours of baking — spread with cream cheese and topped with cucumber, radishes, or smoked salmon. Germans walk to their local bakery every single morning for fresh Brötchen. No exceptions.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 fresh German Brötchen (Kaiser rolls or crusty rolls)
- 150g (■ cup) Frischkäse (German cream cheese) or Philadelphia cream cheese
- ½ cucumber, thinly sliced
- 4 radishes, thinly sliced
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, chopped
- Salt and white pepper
- Optional: 80g (3 oz) smoked salmon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Slice Brötchen in half horizontally.
2. Spread Frischkäse generously on both halves.
3. Season the cream cheese with salt and white pepper.
4. Layer cucumber slices over the bottom half.
5. Add radish slices and scatter chives.
6. Add smoked salmon if desired.
7. Press the top half on and serve immediately.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per Brötchen

TIP

Brötchen must be eaten the day they are baked — they go stale rapidly. If you cannot get to a bakery, warm store-bought rolls in a 180°C oven for 5 minutes to refresh them. It is not the same, but it helps.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic German]

RECIPE 51

■■ Germany

GRIESSBREI

SEMOLINA PORRIDGE

Germany's most nostalgic breakfast — a smooth, creamy semolina porridge cooked in whole milk and finished with butter and jam. Every German has memories of Grießbrei from childhood. Simple, warming, and faster to make than oatmeal.

INGREDIENTS

- 750ml (3 cups) whole milk
- 80g (½ cup) fine semolina (Hartweizengrieß)
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Strawberry or cherry jam, to serve
- Ground cinnamon, optional

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pour milk into a saucepan. Add sugar, vanilla, and salt. Heat over medium heat until just beginning to steam.
2. Pour semolina in a slow, steady stream while whisking constantly to prevent lumps.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cook, stirring constantly with a wooden spoon, for 5–7 minutes until thick and smooth. Semolina thickens very quickly — do not walk away.
4. Remove from heat. Stir in butter.
5. Pour into warm bowls.
6. Make a small well in the center and fill with jam.
7. Dust with cinnamon if desired.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Grießbrei sets as it cools and becomes solid — eat it immediately while it is still creamy and pourable. A cold Grießbrei is a sad Grießbrei.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 52

■■ Germany

QUARK MIT FRÜCHTEN

GERMAN QUARK WITH FRUIT

German Quark — a fresh dairy product somewhere between yogurt and cream cheese — is one of the country's most consumed breakfast foods. Smooth, tangy, high in protein, and endlessly versatile. Served sweetened with fresh seasonal fruit, it is the German equivalent of the Greek yogurt bowl.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) German Quark or full-fat ricotta (as substitute)
- 3 tbsp honey or sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of ½ lemon
- 200g (1½ cups) mixed fresh fruit: strawberries, blueberries, peach slices
- 2 tbsp granola or crushed nuts for crunch
- Optional: 1 tbsp flaxseed or chia seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. In a bowl, combine Quark with honey, vanilla, and lemon zest. Stir until smooth and slightly lightened.
2. Taste and adjust sweetness.
3. Divide into two serving bowls.
4. Top generously with fresh fruit.
5. Scatter granola or crushed nuts over the top.
6. Add seeds if desired.
7. Serve immediately.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

If you cannot find German Quark, mix equal parts Greek yogurt and cream cheese to approximate its texture and slight tanginess. It is not identical, but it works extremely well.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 53

■■ Germany

STRAMMER MAX

A Berlin classic and one of Germany's most satisfying open-faced breakfast sandwiches. Dark bread topped with cured ham and a fried egg — robust, straightforward, and deeply Germanic. The name translates roughly to "stiff Max," a reference to the hearty, muscular nature of the dish.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 thick slices dark rye bread or Mischbrot
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 4 thin slices cured Schinken (German cured ham) or Schwarzwälder Schinken
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp lard or butter for frying
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh chives, chopped
- German mustard, on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Lightly toast bread slices.
2. Spread butter generously over each slice.
3. Layer ham slices over the buttered bread — fold them so they have volume and thickness.
4. Fry eggs in lard or butter over medium heat until whites are fully set but yolks are still runny.
5. Place one fried egg on top of each ham-covered bread.
6. Season with salt and pepper.
7. Scatter fresh chives over the top.
8. Serve with German mustard on the side.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The yolk of the fried egg must be runny — when broken, it runs down through the ham and onto the bread, creating its own sauce. A set yolk ruins the entire concept.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Classic German] [Quick]

RECIPE 54

■■ Germany (Bavaria / Swabia)

DAMPFNUDELN

STEAMED SWEET DUMPLINGS

Dampfnudeln — literally "steam noodles" — are large yeasted dumplings steamed directly in a covered pan with butter and milk until their bottoms caramelize gold while their tops become impossibly soft and pillowy. A deeply comforting Bavarian Sunday breakfast served with vanilla sauce or fruit compote.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DUMPLINGS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 250ml (1 cup) warm milk
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

FOR STEAMING

- 50g (3.5 tbsp) butter
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- 1 tsp sugar
- Vanilla custard sauce (Vanillesoße), to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk, eggs, vanilla, and softened butter. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic. Proof 1 hour until doubled.
2. Divide into 8–10 equal portions. Shape into smooth balls.
3. Melt steaming butter in a wide, deep pan with a tight lid. Add milk and sugar. Stir briefly.
4. Place dumplings in the pan, spacing slightly apart. They will expand.
5. Bring to a gentle simmer. Cover tightly.
6. Steam over low heat for 20–25 minutes without lifting the lid — this is essential. The bottoms will caramelize in the butter while tops steam.
7. Remove lid. You will hear and smell caramelization.
8. Serve immediately with warm vanilla custard.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~360 per dumpling

TIP

Never — under any circumstances — lift the lid during steaming. The steam pressure is what cooks the tops of the dumplings. One peek and they collapse. Trust the process completely.

[Vegetarian] [Classic German] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 55

■■ Germany

SCHWARZBROT MIT KÄSE UND

A classic German pairing that surprises many outsiders — dense, slightly sour dark rye bread topped with aged sharp cheese and a drizzle of floral honey. The sweet-salty-sour combination is deeply satisfying. A northern German specialty eaten daily in Hamburg and Schleswig-Holstein.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices Schwarzbrot (dark rye bread) or
- Pumpernickel
- 2 tbsp cold unsalted butter
- 100g (3.5 oz) aged sharp Gouda or Tilsiter, sliced
- 3 tbsp good quality floral honey
- Optional: fresh thyme leaves or walnuts

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spread cold butter thinly on each bread slice.
2. Lay cheese slices to cover the bread completely.
3. Drizzle honey generously over the cheese.
4. Add fresh thyme leaves or crushed walnuts for extra flavor if desired.
5. Eat immediately with a strong black coffee.

Prep: 4 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Use proper Pumpernickel — the very dense, almost black rectangular loaf made from 100% rye. It has a natural slight sweetness from the slow bake that makes the honey pairing particularly special.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [5 Ingredients] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 56

■■ Germany (Bavaria)

BAYERISCHE WEISSWURST MIT

The most famous Bavarian breakfast — a strict cultural institution. White veal sausages (Weisswurst) poached gently in hot water, served with a fresh pretzel and sweet Bavarian mustard. Must be eaten before noon — Bavaria's "breakfast laws" demand it. Eaten by sucking the meat from the skin — called "zuzeln."

INGREDIENTS

- 4 Weisswurst (Bavarian white veal sausages)
- 2 large soft Brezeln (Bavarian pretzels)
- or hard pretzels
- 4 tbsp süßer Senf (Bavarian sweet mustard)
- 1L (4 cups) hot water (not boiling — 75°C / 165°F)
- Optional: Weißbier (wheat beer) alongside —
- culturally appropriate at 10am in Bavaria

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat water in a pot to 75–80°C (165–175°F). Do NOT boil — boiling bursts the sausage skin.
2. Gently lower Weisswurst into the hot water. Heat for 8–10 minutes until thoroughly warmed.
3. Remove with tongs. Place in a deep bowl.
4. Serve immediately alongside warmed pretzels and a generous pot of sweet mustard.
5. To eat: make a shallow cut along the sausage skin, then suck or peel the meat out. This is correct. Using a fork is also acceptable for beginners.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~490 per serving (with pretzel)

TIP

Weisswurst must never be boiled — ever. They are delicate, already cooked sausages that only need to be warmed through. Boiling splits the skin and ruins the texture. Gentle heat only.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic German]

RECIPE 57

■■ Germany (Bavaria)

OBATZDA AUF LAUGENBRÖTCHEN

BAVARIAN CHEESE SPREAD ON PRETZEL ROLL

Obatzda is a Bavarian beer garden staple — a creamy, paprika-spiced cheese spread made from ripe Camembert, butter, and caraway seeds. Spread on a Laugenbrötchen (pretzel roll) with thinly sliced radishes and chives, it is the definitive Bavarian morning spread.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE OBATZDA

- 250g (9 oz) ripe Camembert or Brie, at room temperature
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 1–2 tsp sweet paprika
- ½ tsp caraway seeds
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp wheat beer or cream (to adjust consistency)

FOR SERVING

- 4 Laugenbrötchen (pretzel rolls) or Kaiser rolls
- 6 radishes, thinly sliced
- Fresh chives and flat-leaf parsley

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Remove rind from Camembert. Mash with a fork until smooth.
2. Beat in softened butter until combined.
3. Stir in finely diced onion, paprika, caraway seeds, salt, and pepper.
4. Add a splash of wheat beer or cream to reach a spreadable consistency.
5. Taste and adjust seasoning — Obatzda should be savory, slightly pungent, and paprika-forward.
6. Refrigerate 30 minutes to firm slightly.
7. Slice pretzel rolls. Spread Obatzda generously.
8. Top with radish slices and scatter chives.

Prep: 10 min + 30 min chill · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Obatzda is best made 24 hours in advance — the flavors intensify dramatically overnight in the refrigerator. Make it Sunday evening for a spectacular Monday breakfast.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Bavarian]

RECIPE 58

■■ Germany

HAFERFLOCKENBREI

GERMAN OATMEAL PORRIDGE

German oatmeal porridge is thicker and less sweet than its British or American counterparts, cooked with water or milk and topped with warm fruit compote or a drizzle of golden syrup. A cold-weather German staple that warms from the inside out.

INGREDIENTS

- 120g (1¼ cups) rolled oats (Haferflocken)
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk or water
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tbsp sugar or honey
- ½ tsp cinnamon

FOR TOPPING

- Warm cherry compote or stewed plums
- 1 tbsp flaxseed, ground
- Sliced banana or apple
- Drizzle of honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine oats, milk, water, and salt in a medium saucepan.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer over medium heat, stirring.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cook 5–7 minutes, stirring often, until oats are soft and porridge has thickened to your preferred consistency.
4. Stir in sugar and cinnamon.
5. Pour into warm bowls.
6. Top with warm cherry compote or stewed plums.
7. Add banana slices, ground flaxseed, and a drizzle of honey.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

*Germans often use a mix of *feine* (fine) and *kernige* (coarse) oats for a porridge that is creamy but with some textural interest. Try mixing them for the best result.*

[Vegan] [High Fiber] [Quick] [Budget-Friendly]

RECIPE 59

■■ Germany

GERMAN SOFT-BOILED EGGS

Weiche Eier — soft-boiled eggs — are a centerpiece of the German breakfast table. Served in egg cups with strips of dark rye bread for dipping, seasoned with salt and white pepper. This is breakfast in its most honest, universally satisfying form.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 4 slices dark rye or whole grain bread, buttered
- Salt and white pepper
- Optional: fresh chives, mild paprika

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring a saucepan of water to a full rolling boil.
2. Gently lower eggs using a spoon.
3. For soft-boiled with runny yolk: cook exactly 6 minutes. For jammy yolk: cook 7 minutes. For fully set: cook 10 minutes.
4. While eggs cook, toast and butter bread slices. Cut into strips (soldiers).
5. Transfer eggs to egg cups immediately.
6. Slice off the top of each egg with a sharp knife or egg slicer.
7. Season with salt and white pepper.
8. Serve with bread soldiers for dipping and the full breakfast spread.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~200 per serving

TIP

Room temperature eggs cook more predictably than cold eggs. Remove from refrigerator 20 minutes before cooking for consistently perfect results.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Quick] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 60

■■ Germany

KARTOFFELPUFFER

POTATO PANCAKES

Crispy, golden German potato pancakes — grated raw potato bound with egg and fried in hot oil until shatteringly crunchy on the outside, tender within. Eaten at Christmas markets and in German kitchens year-round, served with apple sauce or sour cream.

INGREDIENTS

- 800g (28 oz) starchy potatoes, peeled and grated
- 1 medium onion, finely grated
- 2 large eggs
- 3 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- ¼ tsp white pepper
- Pinch of nutmeg
- Vegetable oil for frying
- Sour cream and apple sauce, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grate potatoes and onion into a clean kitchen towel. Wring the towel tightly, squeezing out as much liquid as possible. Transfer to a bowl.
2. Add eggs, flour, salt, pepper, and nutmeg. Mix well.
3. Heat 1cm (½ inch) of vegetable oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat until shimmering.
4. Drop 3 tbsp of potato mixture into the oil. Press flat immediately to about 1cm thick.
5. Fry 3–4 minutes per side until deeply golden and crispy. Do not rush — the inside needs time to cook through.
6. Drain on paper towels. Season with salt immediately.
7. Serve hot with cold sour cream and warm apple sauce.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Squeezing every drop of moisture from the potato is the most important step. Wet potato mixture steams instead of frying — it will be soft, not crispy. Squeeze until you think you cannot squeeze any more, then squeeze again.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic German]

RECIPE 61

■■ Germany

APFELKUCHEN ZUM FRÜHSTÜCK

GERMAN APPLE BREAKFAST CAKE

A moist, dense German apple cake with a fine crumb and cinnamon sugar topping — baked in a round tin and served in slices for breakfast all week. Every German bakery sells a version. Every German family has a home recipe. This one is definitive.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 medium apples, peeled, cored, thinly sliced
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 3 large eggs
- 150ml (⅓ cup) vegetable oil
- 150ml (⅓ cup) whole milk
- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Pinch of salt
- Zest of 1 lemon

FOR TOPPING

- 2 tbsp sugar mixed with 1 tsp cinnamon
- Powdered sugar for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Grease a 26cm (10-inch) round springform cake pan.
2. Whisk eggs and sugar until pale and slightly thick.
3. Add oil and milk. Whisk to combine.
4. Sift flour, baking powder, cinnamon, and salt over the wet ingredients. Fold until just combined.
5. Add lemon zest. Fold in half the apple slices.
6. Pour into the prepared pan.
7. Arrange remaining apple slices decoratively on top.
8. Sprinkle cinnamon sugar over the apples.
9. Bake 45–55 minutes until a skewer comes out clean and top is golden. Cool in the pan before slicing.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 55 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~280 per slice

TIP

Use a mix of sweet and tart apples — Golden Delicious for sweetness, Boskoop or Granny Smith for tartness. The combination creates a more complex flavor than any single variety.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic German] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 62

■■ Germany

LEBKUCHEN-FRÜHSTÜCKSBREI

GINGERBREAD SPICED PORRIDGE

Inspired by the flavors of Nuremberg's famous Lebkuchen — oat porridge warmly spiced with gingerbread spices, sweetened with dark syrup, and topped with stewed prunes and crushed Lebkuchen crumbs. A deeply warming, festive winter breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 1 tbsp dark molasses or Zuckerrübensirup (beet syrup)
- 1 tsp Lebkuchen spice mix (or: ½ tsp cinnamon, ¼ tsp ginger, pinch each of clove, cardamom, nutmeg,
- anise, allspice)
- Pinch of salt

FOR TOPPING

- Stewed prunes or dried plum compote
- 1–2 crushed Lebkuchen cookies or ginger snaps
- Drizzle of honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine oats, milk, salt, and Lebkuchen spices in a saucepan over medium heat.
2. Bring to a gentle simmer, stirring.
3. Cook 5–6 minutes until thickened and creamy.
4. Stir in dark molasses or beet syrup. Taste and adjust sweetness.
5. Pour into warm bowls.
6. Top with stewed prunes, crushed Lebkuchen crumbs, and a drizzle of honey.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Zuckerrübensirup (sugar beet syrup) is a specifically German sweetener with a molasses-like depth. Use dark molasses or treacle as a substitute — the dark bitterness is what makes this porridge so special.

[Vegan] [Seasonal] [Comfort Food] [High Fiber]

Spain

RECIPE 63

Germany

ROHKOSTTELLER

GERMAN RAW VEGETABLE PLATE

A Rohkostteller — a plate of raw, fresh vegetables — is a traditional element of the German breakfast table, particularly in health-conscious households. Grated carrots, sliced radishes, cucumber, and tomato with a yogurt herb dip. Fresh, clean, and quintessentially German in its practicality.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large carrots, peeled and coarsely grated
- 1 small cucumber, sliced
- 6 radishes, thinly sliced
- 2 tomatoes, sliced
- 1 tbsp lemon juice (for carrots)
- 1 tsp sunflower oil (for carrots)
- FOR THE KRÄUTERQUARK DIP:
 - 200g (¾ cup) Quark or plain yogurt
 - 1 tbsp mayonnaise
 - 2 tbsp fresh chives, chopped
 - 1 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
 - 1 tbsp fresh parsley, chopped
 - Salt and white pepper
 - 1 tsp lemon juice

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make Kräuterquark: combine Quark, mayonnaise, all herbs, lemon juice, salt, and pepper. Mix well. Refrigerate 20 minutes.
2. Dress grated carrot with lemon juice and sunflower oil. Season with a pinch of salt.
3. Arrange grated carrot, cucumber slices, radishes, and tomato on a large plate.
4. Place Kräuterquark in a small bowl in the center or alongside.
5. Serve with dark bread for a complete German breakfast.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~160 per serving

TIP

Grated carrot dressed with a little lemon and oil is called Karottensalat — it is eaten as a side dish, on bread, or mixed into yogurt. It appears at nearly every German breakfast table.

[Vegetarian] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Vegan option]

RECIPE 64

Spain (Catalonia)

PAN CON TOMATE

BREAD WITH TOMATO

Pa amb tomàquet — the iconic Catalan breakfast that inspired a thousand imitations. Grilled sourdough rubbed with raw garlic while still hot, then rubbed vigorously with ripe tomato so the flesh saturates the bread, and finished with premium olive oil and sea salt. Four ingredients. Zero compromise. Perfection.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices sourdough, ciabatta, or crusty white bread
- 2 ripe, flavorful tomatoes, halved
- 2 garlic cloves, halved
- 3–4 tbsp premium extra-virgin Spanish olive oil
- (Arbequina variety preferred)
- Flaky sea salt (Sal Maldon)
- Optional: cured anchovies or jamón ibérico, to top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grill or toast bread under a broiler or on a griddle until golden with some char on the edges.
2. While bread is still very hot, rub the cut side of a garlic clove firmly across the entire surface. The heat opens the bread pores and the rough surface grates the garlic in.
3. Take a tomato half, cut-side down, and rub vigorously over the bread. Press firmly and drag slowly. The tomato flesh and juice should saturate the bread completely. Discard the skin.
4. Drizzle olive oil generously across the bread.
5. Sprinkle flaky sea salt.
6. Eat immediately. Do not wait.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~210 per serving

TIP

The tomato must be ripe — almost overripe. An underripe, watery, flavorless tomato will produce a pale imitation of this dish. The tomato IS the dish. Everything else is supporting it.

[Vegan] [Quick] [5 Ingredients] [Classic Spanish]

RECIPÉ 65

■ ■ Spain

CHURROS CON CHOCOLATE CALIENTE

The most dramatic Spanish breakfast — loops and sticks of fried dough dusted in cinnamon sugar, accompanied by a cup of chocolate so thick it holds a spoon upright. Eaten at the churrería after a long night in Spain, or on a cold winter morning when only chocolate and fried dough will do.

INGREDIENTS**FOR THE CHURROS**

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 300ml (1¼ cups) water, just boiled
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp baking powder
- Vegetable oil for deep frying
- 3 tbsp sugar + 1 tsp cinnamon (for rolling)

FOR THE THICK CHOCOLATE

- 200g (7 oz) dark chocolate (55–65%), chopped
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make the chocolate: whisk milk, sugar, and cornstarch in a saucepan until smooth. Heat over medium heat, stirring constantly, until it begins to thicken. Add chocolate. Stir until melted and very thick — it should coat the back of a spoon heavily. Add salt. Keep warm on lowest heat.
2. Make churro dough: mix flour, salt, and baking powder. Add just-boiled water all at once. Stir immediately and vigorously until a smooth, stiff dough forms.
3. Fill a piping bag with a large star nozzle (1.5cm). Fill with dough.
4. Heat oil to 180°C (355°F) in a deep pan.
5. Pipe 15cm lengths of dough directly into the oil. Cut with scissors. Fry 3–4 minutes, turning, until deep golden all over.
6. Drain briefly on paper towels.
7. Roll in cinnamon sugar immediately.
8. Serve hot with warm thick chocolate for dipping.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

Spanish chocolate for churros is meant to be very thick — almost like a drinking custard. If your chocolate is thin, add another teaspoon of cornstarch dissolved in a little cold milk and cook again.

[Vegan] [Classic Spanish] [Indulgent] [Special Occasion]

RECIPÉ 66

■ ■ Spain

TORTILLA ESPAÑOLA

Spain's most iconic dish — a golden, thick omelette of eggs and slowly confit potatoes. Eaten hot for breakfast, cold for lunch, at room temperature for a snack. The debate over whether to include onion is Spain's greatest culinary argument. This version includes onion. Adjust according to your convictions.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 600g (21 oz) waxy potatoes, peeled and thinly sliced
- 1 medium onion, thinly sliced (controversial, but correct)
- 200ml (¾ cup) extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp salt
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a 24cm (9.5-inch) skillet over medium-low heat. Add potato slices and onion.
2. "Confit" the potatoes: cook gently, stirring occasionally, 20–25 minutes until very tender but not browned. They should be soft and silky.
3. Season the potato-onion mixture with salt.
4. Beat eggs in a large bowl with a pinch of salt and pepper.
5. Drain potatoes, reserving the oil. Add hot potatoes and onion to the beaten eggs. Stir to combine. Let sit 5 minutes.
6. Return 2 tbsp of the reserved oil to the pan over medium heat. Pour in the egg-potato mixture.
7. Cook undisturbed 5–6 minutes until the bottom is set and golden. The top will still look wet.
8. Place a large plate over the pan. In one confident motion, flip the tortilla onto the plate.
9. Slide back into the pan, uncooked-side down. Cook 3–4 more minutes until set but still soft and slightly creamy in the center.
10. Rest 5 minutes. Slice into wedges to serve.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The center of a proper tortilla española should be ever so slightly undercooked — soft and custardy, not fully set. If it is firm all the way through, it is overdone. Aim for wobble.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Spanish]

RECIPE 67

■■ Spain (Andalusia)

TOSTADA CON ACEITE Y SAL

TOAST WITH OIL AND SALT

In Andalusia, the morning tostada is not bread with butter — it is bread with olive oil. Thick toast drizzled generously with premium extra-virgin olive oil and finished with sea salt. Sometimes tomato, sometimes jamón, but always oil. This is what Andalusians eat every morning of their lives.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices thick country bread or baguette
- 4 tbsp premium Andalusian extra-virgin olive oil
- (Picual or Arbequina variety)
- Flaky sea salt
- Optional: 1 garlic clove, tomato halves

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast bread under a broiler or in a toaster until deeply golden with some char.
2. If using garlic: rub the cut side across the hot toast surface.
3. Drizzle olive oil generously over the surface of the hot bread — do not be shy. This is Andalusia. Use more oil than feels comfortable.
4. Sprinkle sea salt over the oil.
5. Eat immediately, standing at a counter if possible.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

The olive oil for this dish must be good. This is perhaps the only breakfast recipe in the world where the single ingredient is the entire recipe. Use the best olive oil you own.

[Vegan] [5 Ingredients] [Quick] [Classic Andalusian]

RECIPE 68

■■ Spain

HUEVOS ROTOS CON JAMÓN

BROKEN EGGS WITH HAM AND POTATOES

One of Spain's most beloved breakfast-lunch dishes — crispy fried potato strips or wedges topped with wafer-thin jamón ibérico and runny fried eggs that are "broken" into the potatoes at the table, so the yolk becomes the sauce. Rustic, dramatic, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 600g (21 oz) potatoes, cut into thin strips or wedges
- 4 large eggs
- 100g (3.5 oz) jamón ibérico or serrano ham, thinly sliced
- Olive oil for frying
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat 2cm (¾ inch) of olive oil in a deep skillet over medium-high heat.
2. Fry potato strips in batches until golden and crispy, about 6–8 minutes. Drain and season with salt. Keep warm.
3. In a separate pan, fry eggs in olive oil over medium heat until whites are set but yolks remain completely runny.
4. Arrange crispy potatoes in the center of serving plates.
5. Drape jamón ibérico slices over the hot potatoes — the heat will slightly warm and soften the ham, releasing its fat.
6. Place fried eggs on top.
7. Break the egg yolks at the table, letting them run into the potatoes. Season with black pepper and parsley.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~550 per serving

TIP

Break the yolk dramatically and slowly at the table — this is the theatrical moment of the dish. The runny yolk is the "sauce" that ties everything together.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Spanish]

RECIPE 69

■ ■ Spain

MAGDALENAS CASERAS

SPANISH MUFFINS

Spanish magdalenas are not American muffins — they are lighter, more delicate, and scented with lemon and olive oil. Found in every Spanish bakery and coffee bar, they are the national breakfast pastry alongside the croissant. Their characteristic domed top is the mark of a well-made magdalena.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 150g (¾ cup) sugar
- 3 large eggs
- 90ml (6 tbsp) whole milk
- 90ml (6 tbsp) light olive oil or sunflower oil
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- Sugar for sprinkling on top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs and sugar vigorously for 3 minutes until thick, pale, and tripled in volume.
2. Add milk, oil, lemon zest, and vanilla. Whisk to combine.
3. Sift flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt over the wet mixture. Fold gently with a spatula until just combined — do not overmix.
4. Refrigerate batter 30 minutes minimum — this helps create the domed top.
5. Preheat oven to 210°C (410°F). Line a muffin tin with paper cases.
6. Fill cases ¾ full. Sprinkle sugar over each top.
7. Bake 15–18 minutes until domed, golden, and springy.
8. Cool 10 minutes before eating.

Prep: 15 min + 30 min chill · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~180 per magdalena

TIP

The sugar sprinkled on top before baking creates a sparkling, slightly crunchy crust — it is essential to the magdalena experience. Do not skip it.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Spanish] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 70

■ ■ Spain

CAFÉ CON LECHE ESPAÑOL

Café con leche — the Spanish breakfast coffee — is equal parts strong espresso and hot milk, served in a large cup. Simpler and less technical than the Italian cappuccino, it is ordered at bars across Spain every morning with a tostada, read while standing, and finished in under five minutes. Efficient. Essential.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 shots strong espresso (or very strong Moka pot coffee)
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk, heated to just below boiling
- 1 tsp sugar (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pull a double espresso shot, or brew very strong coffee in a Moka pot.
2. Heat milk in a small saucepan until almost boiling — Spanish café con leche uses hot milk, not steamed or frothed milk.
3. Pour hot milk into a large cup.
4. Add the espresso. The ratio should be equal — 50% coffee, 50% milk.
5. Stir in sugar if desired.
6. Drink immediately and efficiently.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~80 per serving

TIP

In Spain, coffee culture varies by time. Café con leche is morning. Cortado (espresso with a splash of milk) is midmorning. Solo (straight espresso) is after lunch. Follow the local schedule.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Spanish]

RECIPE 71

■■ Spain (Andalusia)

MIGAS ANDALUZAS

ANDALUSIAN BREADCRUMB BREAKFAST

Migas — literally "breadcrumbs" — is one of Spain's oldest and most satisfying peasant breakfasts. Day-old bread torn and fried in olive oil with garlic, chorizo, and paprika until golden and crunchy. A shepherds' breakfast that has survived for centuries. Eaten with grapes or melon on the side in Andalusia.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) stale white bread, torn into rough pieces
- 120ml (½ cup) water + 1 tsp salt (to dampen bread)
- 100ml (⅓ cup) extra-virgin olive oil
- 4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- 200g (7 oz) chorizo, diced
- 100g (3.5 oz) Iberian pork belly or bacon, diced
- 1 tsp sweet smoked paprika (pimentón dulce)
- Handful of fresh grapes or melon slices (for serving)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Sprinkle salted water over torn bread pieces. Toss to distribute evenly. Cover with a clean cloth and rest 30 minutes — the bread should be damp, not soaked.
2. Heat olive oil in a large, heavy skillet over medium heat. Add garlic and cook until golden (about 2 min). Remove garlic and set aside.
3. Add chorizo and pork belly to the oil. Fry until lightly crispy and the fat has rendered.
4. Add the dampened bread. Sprinkle paprika over everything.
5. Cook over medium heat, stirring and tossing constantly, for 15–20 minutes. The bread should gradually break down into irregular golden crumbs, some large, some small — never uniform.
6. Return fried garlic. Taste and season.
7. Serve hot with cold grapes or melon alongside.

Prep: 15 min + 30 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The key is relentless stirring and tossing over medium heat. High heat burns the outside before the inside crisps. Patience creates irregular texture — the hallmark of authentic migas.

[Classic Spanish] [Budget-Friendly] [One-Pan]

RECIPE 72

■■ Spain (Andalusia)

MOLLETES DE ANTEQUERA

Molletes are soft, slightly spongy bread rolls from Antequera, Andalusia — deliberately bland and porous so they absorb maximum olive oil. Split, griddled cut-side down until golden, then rubbed with tomato and drizzled with olive oil. The ultimate Andalusian breakfast roll — a vehicle for flavor.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE MOLLETES

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 350ml (1½ cups) warm water
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 tbsp olive oil

FOR SERVING

- 2 ripe tomatoes, halved
- Extra-virgin olive oil
- Flaky salt
- Optional: jamón serrano or cured anchovies

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm water and olive oil. Knead 8 minutes until smooth.
2. Proof 1 hour until doubled. Punch down.
3. Divide into 8 round, flat rolls. Place on lined trays.
4. Proof 30 more minutes.
5. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 15–18 minutes until pale golden — molletes should be soft, not crusty.
6. To serve: slice each mollete in half. Place cut-side down on a dry griddle or pan for 2–3 minutes until golden.
7. While hot, rub cut surfaces with ripe tomato.
8. Drizzle olive oil generously. Add salt.
9. Top with jamón or anchovies if desired.

Prep: 15 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~290 per mollete

TIP

Molletes are intentionally less crusty than standard rolls — their softness allows them to absorb olive oil and tomato efficiently. They are a delivery vehicle, not an end in themselves.

[Vegan] [Classic Andalusian] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 73

■■ Spain (Andalusia)

PORRA ANTEQUERANA

THICK COLD TOMATO SOUP

The thick cousin of gazpacho — a cold, bread-thickened tomato soup from Antequera that is so dense it can be eaten with a fork. Served at breakfast in Andalusia topped with jamón and hard-boiled egg, it is one of Spain's most uniquely satisfying morning foods.

INGREDIENTS

- 1kg (2.2 lbs) very ripe tomatoes, roughly chopped
- 200g (7 oz) stale white bread, crusts removed, soaked in water and squeezed
- 2 garlic cloves
- 100ml (■ cup) extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 tbsp sherry vinegar
- 1 tsp salt

FOR TOPPING

- 100g (3.5 oz) jamón serrano, diced
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, chopped
- Drizzle of olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend tomatoes, soaked bread, and garlic until completely smooth.
2. With blender running, drizzle in olive oil slowly to emulsify.
3. Add sherry vinegar and salt. Blend again.
4. Taste and adjust seasoning.
5. Refrigerate at least 2 hours until very cold. The soup should be thick — almost spreadable.
6. Serve in bowls topped with diced jamón, chopped egg, and a drizzle of olive oil.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hr chilling · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Porra is thicker than gazpacho due to more bread. The bread not only thickens the soup but also creates the characteristic creamy white color when emulsified with olive oil. Use good bread.

[High Protein] [No-Cook] [Make-Ahead] [Gluten-Free option]

RECIPE 74

■■ Spain

TOSTADA CON JAMÓN IBÉRICO

Spain's most luxurious breakfast toast — pan con tomate (bread rubbed with tomato and olive oil) topped with paper-thin, room- temperature Jamón Ibérico de Bellota. The acorn-fed ham melts on the warm toast, releasing fat and perfume. A Spanish benchmark for excellence in simplicity.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 thick slices sourdough or artisan bread
- 1 ripe tomato, halved
- 1 garlic clove, halved
- 2 tbsp premium extra-virgin olive oil
- 60–80g (2.5–3 oz) Jamón Ibérico de Bellota, very thinly sliced and at room temperature
- Flaky sea salt
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grill or toast bread until golden and slightly charred.
2. While still very hot, rub garlic firmly over the surface.
3. Rub tomato half vigorously over the bread until juices and flesh saturate it.
4. Drizzle olive oil generously.
5. Sprinkle flaky sea salt.
6. Immediately drape jamón ibérico slices loosely over the toast — fold them, do not lay flat.
7. Add a grind of black pepper.
8. Eat within 2 minutes — the warmth of the bread gently warms and softens the fat in the jamón.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Never refrigerate jamón ibérico and never heat it. It must be served at room temperature so the fat is soft and fragrant. Heating destroys its texture and mutes its flavor.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Spanish]

RECIPE 75

■■ Spain (Mallorca)

ENSAIMADA MALLORQUINA

Mallorca's extraordinary spiral pastry — a coiled, feather-light enriched dough made with saïm (pork lard), dusted in powdered sugar, and shaped into its distinctive snail coil. Protected by Spanish law as a product of origin, the ensaimada is served at breakfast across the Balearics and smuggled home by every tourist in a round box.

INGREDIENTS

- 450g (3¾ cups) strong bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 150ml (■ cup) warm water
- 80ml (■ cup) warm milk
- 2 large eggs
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 100g (7 tbsp) saïm (pork lard) or vegetable shortening,
- softened — plus extra for spreading
- Pinch of salt
- Powdered sugar, for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add water, milk, and eggs. Knead 10 minutes.
2. Add softened lard bit by bit, continuing to knead 5 more minutes until dough is soft, elastic, and slightly sticky. Proof 1 hour.
3. Divide dough into desired sizes (1 large or 8 small).
4. On an oiled surface, roll each portion into a very thin rectangle. Spread with a thin layer of softened lard.
5. Roll tightly into a long thin rope.
6. Coil the rope into a snail spiral on a lined baking sheet, leaving space for expansion.
7. Proof 6–8 hours (overnight) at room temperature — this long rise is non-negotiable for proper texture.
8. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 15–18 minutes (small) or 25–30 min (large) until pale golden — not dark.
9. Cool completely. Dust extravagantly with powdered sugar.

Prep: 30 min + overnight proof · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~340 per ensaimada

TIP

The overnight proof at room temperature is what creates the ensaimada's famously airy, feather-light texture. Refrigerating it changes the dough completely. Leave it out. Trust the process.

[Classic Spanish] [Weekend Project] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 76

■■ Spain (Andalusia)

GACHAS ANDALUZAS

ANDALUSIAN FLOUR PORRIDGE

Gachas is an ancient Andalusian peasant porridge made from toasted flour, olive oil, and water — thick, golden, and flavored with fennel and sweet paprika. Topped with crispy Iberan pork and drizzled with olive oil, it is winter food of the highest order. Simple, warming, and deeply Spanish.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (¾ cup) flour (traditionally "harina de almortas" /
- grass pea flour — or regular flour)
- 500ml (2 cups) water or broth
- 60ml (¼ cup) extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- 1 tsp sweet smoked paprika
- ½ tsp ground anise or fennel seeds
- Salt to taste

FOR TOPPING

- 100g (3.5 oz) pork belly or chorizo, diced and fried crispy
- Extra olive oil drizzle

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a heavy pot over medium heat. Add garlic and fry until golden.
2. Add flour to the oil. Stir constantly over medium heat 3–4 minutes, toasting the flour until it smells nutty and turns pale golden.
3. Add paprika and anise. Stir 30 seconds.
4. Gradually pour in water or broth while stirring vigorously to prevent lumps.
5. Bring to a simmer, stirring constantly. Cook 8–10 minutes until thick and smooth.
6. Season with salt.
7. Ladle into bowls. Top with crispy pork belly or chorizo.
8. Drizzle olive oil over everything.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Toasting the flour in olive oil before adding liquid is the key technique — it eliminates the raw flour taste and adds a nutty depth that makes gachas much more than the sum of its parts.

[Classic Spanish] [Budget-Friendly] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 77

■■ Spain (Mallorca)

COCA MALLORQUINA DE TRAMPÓ

Coca is the Mallorcan version of flatbread or pizza — topped with trampó, a fresh salad of peppers, tomatoes, and onions. Eaten at room temperature as a summer breakfast, this refreshing, crispy flatbread is everything a hot Mediterranean morning requires.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE COCA DOUGH

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 60ml (¼ cup) olive oil
- 7g yeast, ½ tsp salt
- FOR TRAMPÓ TOPPING:
- 2 ripe tomatoes, finely diced
- 1 green bell pepper, finely diced
- ½ onion, finely diced
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp dried oregano
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine dough ingredients, knead 8 minutes. Proof 1 hour.
2. Combine all trampó ingredients in a bowl. Season well. Rest 20 minutes to let flavors meld.
3. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F) with a baking tray inside.
4. Roll dough very thin — almost paper-thin — into a large irregular oval or rectangle.
5. Transfer to the hot tray. Bake 10 minutes until beginning to crisp.
6. Remove. Spread trampó over the hot coca immediately.
7. Return to oven 3–5 minutes more.
8. Cool to room temperature before serving.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr proof · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Coca should be thin and crispy — roll the dough as thin as you possibly can. A thick coca is a different (lesser) dish. Thin is the Mallorcan way.

[Vegan] [Classic Mallorcan] [No-Egg]

RECIPE 78

■■ Spain

BUÑUELOS DE VIENTO

SPANISH FRITTERS

Buñuelos de viento — "wind fritters" — are impossibly light, hollow fried choux pastry balls that puff up dramatically in the oil. Rolled in cinnamon sugar and eaten warm, these are among the most beloved Spanish breakfast pastries, especially during Semana Santa (Holy Week) and autumn festivals.

INGREDIENTS

- 250ml (1 cup) water
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 1 tbsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- 130g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 4 large eggs
- Vegetable oil for deep frying
- 100g (½ cup) sugar + 1 tsp cinnamon (for rolling)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. In a saucepan, bring water, butter, sugar, and salt to a full boil.
2. Remove from heat. Add flour all at once. Beat vigorously with a wooden spoon until dough pulls away from the sides cleanly.
3. Return to low heat. Stir vigorously 1–2 minutes to dry the dough slightly.
4. Transfer to a bowl. Cool 5 minutes.
5. Beat in eggs one at a time — the dough will look broken at first then come smooth. Add each egg only after the previous is fully incorporated.
6. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F). Drop rounded tablespoons of dough into the oil.
7. Fry 5–7 minutes, turning, until golden and hollow-sounding. They puff dramatically — give them room.
8. Drain. Roll immediately in cinnamon sugar.
9. Eat warm — they deflate and become leathery if left.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

Fry at 170°C, NOT higher. High heat browns the outside before the inside is cooked, creating dense, unpleasant fritters. Low and slow creates the hollow, puffed interior that defines a buñuelo de viento.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Spanish] [Special Occasion]

RECIPES 79

■ ■ Spain (Castilla-La Mancha)

PISTO CON HUEVO

SPANISH RATATOUILLE WITH EGG

Pisto Manchego — Spain's beloved vegetable stew of tomato, pepper, zucchini, and onion — served for breakfast with fried or poached eggs and crusty bread. Rich from slow-cooking in olive oil, intensely flavored, and thoroughly satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 zucchini, diced
- 1 red bell pepper, diced
- 1 green bell pepper, diced
- 1 onion, diced
- 3 ripe tomatoes, grated (or 400g tinned crushed)
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 60ml (¼ cup) olive oil
- 1 tsp sweet smoked paprika
- 1 tsp sugar (to balance acidity)
- Salt and black pepper
- 4 eggs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide skillet over medium heat. Add onion and garlic. Cook 8 minutes until soft.
2. Add peppers. Cook 8 more minutes.
3. Add zucchini. Cook 5 minutes until tender.
4. Add grated tomato, paprika, sugar, salt, and pepper.
5. Simmer uncovered over medium-low heat 20–25 minutes until very thick, reduced, and deeply flavored. Stir occasionally.
6. Create 4 wells in the pisto. Crack one egg into each.
7. Cover and cook 5–7 minutes until whites are set but yolks remain runny.
8. Serve directly from the pan with crusty bread.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Pisto needs time — slow cooking in olive oil concentrates the vegetables and creates a thick, jammy sauce that is incomparably more flavorful than a quickly cooked version. Do not rush it.

[Vegetarian] [Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein]

RECIPE 80

■ ■ Spain (Catalonia)

CATALAN CREMA SPREAD ON TOAST

Inspired by Crema Catalana — Spain's ancient egg custard predating the French crème brûlée — this breakfast version spreads a chilled vanilla-lemon custard onto toast and torches the sugar top. A dessert elevated to a remarkable breakfast experience.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE CREMA CATALANA

- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 4 egg yolks
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 30g (3½ tbsp) cornstarch
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 1 cinnamon stick
- 1 tsp vanilla

FOR SERVING

- 4 slices thick brioche or challah, toasted
- 4 tsp sugar for caramelizing
- Pinch of cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat milk with lemon zest and cinnamon stick until steaming. Remove cinnamon stick.
2. Whisk yolks, sugar, and cornstarch until smooth.
3. Gradually add warm milk to yolk mixture, whisking.
4. Return to pot. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until very thick (5–7 minutes). Add vanilla.
5. Pour into a shallow dish. Cover surface with plastic wrap. Refrigerate until firm (2+ hours).
6. Toast bread. Spread a thick layer of cold crema over each.
7. Sprinkle 1 tsp sugar mixed with pinch of cinnamon over each.
8. Torch with a kitchen torch until the sugar caramelizes.
9. Eat within 2 minutes.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hr chilling · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The crema must be very cold and firm before spreading — warm crema will soak into the bread. Make it the day before for best results.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Special Occasion] [Classic Catalan]

United Kingdom

RECIPE 81

■ ■ United Kingdom (England)

THE FULL ENGLISH BREAKFAST

The Full English — or "fry-up" — is Britain's most iconic morning meal. Back bacon, pork sausages, fried or poached eggs, grilled tomato, mushrooms, baked beans, black pudding, and buttered toast. Every element has its place. Every element matters. Nothing about this is optional.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 back bacon rashers
- 2 pork sausages (Cumberland or Lincolnshire)
- 1 slice black pudding, 1cm thick
- 2 large eggs
- 2 vine tomatoes, halved
- 4 button mushrooms or 2 large flat mushrooms
- 200g (7 oz) canned baked beans (Heinz, ideally)
- 2 slices thick white bread
- 2 tbsp salted butter
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oven to 100°C (210°F) to keep cooked items warm.
2. Heat oil in a large frying pan over medium heat. Add sausages and cook, turning regularly, 15–18 minutes until golden all over and cooked through. Move to oven.
3. Add bacon to the same pan. Cook 3–4 minutes per side to preference. Move to oven.
4. Add black pudding. Fry 2 minutes per side until crispy on the outside. Move to oven.
5. Place tomatoes and mushrooms cut-side down in the pan. Cook 3–4 minutes. Season with salt and pepper. Keep warm.
6. Warm baked beans in a small saucepan.
7. Fry or poach eggs to your preference.
8. Toast and butter bread.
9. Plate everything together on a warmed plate — beans in a separate small section so they don't touch what they shouldn't.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~850 per serving

TIP

The key to a great fry-up is sequencing. Start with sausages (longest cook time), then build backwards so everything finishes at roughly the same time. A cold element on a full English is an insult.

[High Protein] [Classic British] [Weekend Breakfast]

RECIPE 82

■ ■ United Kingdom (Scotland)

SCOTTISH PORRIDGE WITH

Scottish porridge is made with pinhead oats (not rolled), cooked slowly in water with salt — not sugar — then served with a cold pour of cream and a drizzle of golden syrup or heather honey. The oat texture is thicker, nuttier, and entirely different from instant oatmeal. This is the original.

INGREDIENTS

- 80g (¾ cup) Scottish pinhead oats (also called steel-cut oats) — not rolled or instant
- 500ml (2 cups) cold water
- ½ tsp fine salt
- 60ml (¼ cup) heavy cream or whole milk (cold, to serve)
- 1 tbsp golden syrup or heather honey
- Optional: 1 tbsp whisky (traditional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil in a heavy-bottomed saucepan.
2. Add pinhead oats and salt. Stir well.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cook, stirring frequently, 25–30 minutes until oats are tender and porridge is thick. Pinhead oats take much longer than rolled.
4. Add a splash more water if it becomes too thick before oats are fully cooked.
5. Pour into a warmed bowl.
6. Make a small well in the center. Pour cold cream into the well.
7. Drizzle golden syrup around the cream.
8. Add whisky if using (stir it in gently).

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Salt in porridge is not optional in Scotland — it is mandatory. The salt is added during cooking, not after. If you use sugar instead, you are making a different (non-Scottish) dish.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Fiber] [Classic Scottish]

RECIPE 83

■ ■ United Kingdom (Wales)

WELSH RAREBIT

Often called "cheese on toast" by those who have never had it — but Welsh Rarebit is an entirely different dish. Mature Cheddar melted into a savory sauce with ale, Worcestershire sauce, and mustard, then broiled on toast until bubbling

and golden. Wales's greatest culinary gift to the world.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices white or sourdough bread, toasted
- 200g (2 cups) mature Cheddar, grated
- 30g (2 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp plain flour
- 80ml (■ cup) dark ale or stout
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- 1 tsp English mustard (or Dijon)
- ½ tsp sweet paprika
- Pinch of cayenne
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Melt butter in a small saucepan over medium-low heat. Add flour and stir 1 minute to cook out raw taste.
2. Gradually add ale, stirring constantly until smooth.
3. Add Worcestershire sauce, mustard, paprika, and cayenne.
4. Remove from heat. Add grated Cheddar all at once. Stir until completely melted and smooth.
5. Season with black pepper.
6. Toast bread until golden on both sides.
7. Spoon rarebit sauce generously over each slice — spread to the edges.
8. Place under a very hot broiler for 3–4 minutes until bubbly, golden, and slightly charred at the edges.
9. Serve immediately.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~430 per serving

TIP

Use the sharpest, most mature Cheddar you can find — at least 18 months aged. Mild Cheddar produces a bland result that does not justify the name Rarebit. The cheese is everything.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic British] [Quick]

RECIPE 84

■ ■ United Kingdom

BEANS ON TOAST

Possibly the most derided dish in the British culinary canon by outsiders, and possibly the most beloved breakfast by those who grew up with it. Heinz baked beans heated and poured over thick buttered toast — simple, warming, nutritious, and profoundly comforting. Britain's everyday miracle.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) can Heinz baked beans in tomato sauce
- 2 thick slices white bread
- 2 tbsp salted butter
- Optional: 50g (2 oz) mature Cheddar, grated
- Optional: 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce added to beans
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Empty beans into a small saucepan over medium-low heat. Stir gently until heated through, about 3–4 minutes. Add Worcestershire sauce if using.
2. Toast bread to your preference — pale and soft, or dark and crunchy (the British debate is ongoing).
3. Spread butter generously on the toast while still hot.
4. Pour hot beans over the buttered toast.
5. Grate Cheddar over the top if desired.
6. Add a grind of black pepper.
7. Eat immediately — soggy beans on cold toast is a different (sadder) experience entirely.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

The beans must be Heinz. This is not brand loyalty — it is a cultural and flavor fact. Other baked beans taste different. The tomato sauce is sweeter, the beans firmer, the texture better. Use Heinz.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Quick] [Budget-Friendly]

RECIPE 85

■ ■ United Kingdom

CRUMPETS WITH BUTTER

A crumpet is a uniquely British yeast-leavened griddle cake with a spongy interior riddled with holes — engineered specifically to absorb maximum molten butter. Toasted until the surface is golden and the butter pools in every cavity. Eaten with tea. Essential.

INGREDIENTS

FOR HOMEMADE CRUMPETS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp baking powder
- 350ml (1½ cups) warm water
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) warm milk

FOR SERVING

- 4 tbsp good salted butter
- Honey or Marmite (to preference)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm water and milk. Whisk until completely smooth.
2. Cover and prove 45 minutes until very bubbly and doubled. The batter should be quite thin and elastic.
3. Stir in baking powder.
4. Heat a flat griddle or non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Grease generously. Grease metal crumpet rings (or use egg rings).
5. Place rings on the griddle. Pour batter to fill each ring about 1.5cm deep.
6. Cook 8–10 minutes over very low heat until the surface is completely dry and full of holes.
7. Remove rings. Flip crumpets briefly — 1 minute only — just to lightly color the top.
8. Toast finished crumpets in a toaster until golden.
9. Spread with excessive butter immediately.

Prep: 10 min + 45 min proof · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~270 per crumpet with butter

TIP

Crumpets are cooked entirely from the bottom on the griddle. The holes form as steam escapes upward through the batter. If you flip too early, you lose the holes. The surface must be completely set first.

[Vegetarian] [Classic British] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 86

■ ■ United Kingdom

KEDGEREE

A colonial-era Anglo-Indian breakfast of spiced rice, flaked smoked haddock, hard-boiled eggs, and fresh herbs. Brought back from India by British colonists in the 19th century and adopted as a Sunday breakfast institution. Warm, gently spiced, and thoroughly satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) smoked haddock (undyed preferred)
- 250g (1¼ cups) basmati rice
- 3 large eggs, hard-boiled, quartered
- 1 onion, finely diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp mild curry powder
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 50g (3.5 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 250ml (1 cup) whole milk (for poaching fish)
- 3 tbsp fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped
- Juice of 1 lemon
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place haddock in a shallow pan. Cover with milk. Simmer gently 8 minutes until just cooked through. Remove fish, cool slightly, then flake into large pieces. Reserve the cooking milk.
2. Cook basmati rice according to package instructions. Drain and set aside.
3. In a large pan, melt butter over medium heat. Add onion and cook 8 minutes until golden.
4. Add garlic, curry powder, cumin, and turmeric. Cook 1–2 minutes until fragrant.
5. Add cooked rice. Stir to coat every grain with the spiced butter.
6. Gently fold in flaked haddock.
7. Add 3–4 tbsp of the reserved poaching milk to loosen if needed.
8. Season with lemon juice, salt, and pepper.
9. Serve topped with quartered eggs and fresh parsley.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~410 per serving

TIP

Use undyed smoked haddock — the natural pale grey color indicates a traditionally smoked product. The bright yellow dyed version is smoked less and is more artificial. The flavor difference is significant.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic British]

RECIPE 87

■ ■ United Kingdom (Scotland)

SCOTTISH POTATO SCONES

TATTIE SCONES

Flat, golden potato cakes cooked on a dry griddle — a staple of the Scottish breakfast plate. Soft inside, slightly crisped on the outside, with a subtle potato flavor. Eaten with butter alongside a fried egg, or as part of a full Scottish breakfast. Made from leftover mashed potato in Scottish households.

INGREDIENTS

- 450g (1 lb) floury potatoes (Maris Piper or King Edward),
- peeled and cooked
- 75g (⅓ cup) all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp salted butter, melted
- ½ tsp salt
- Pinch of white pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rice or mash the warm cooked potatoes until very smooth — no lumps.
2. Add melted butter, salt, and pepper. Mix well.
3. Gradually add flour, mixing until a soft, slightly sticky dough forms. Do not add all the flour if the dough becomes too stiff — the exact amount depends on moisture content of your potato.
4. On a lightly floured surface, roll or press dough to about 5mm (¼ inch) thick.
5. Cut into triangles or rounds.
6. Heat a dry griddle or cast-iron pan over medium heat — no oil, no butter.
7. Cook tattie scones 3–4 minutes per side until golden patches appear and they are cooked through.
8. Serve warm with butter on top, or use immediately in a full Scottish breakfast.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~130 per scone

TIP

The potato must be warm when you work it — cold mashed potato doesn't combine with flour properly and produces dense, heavy scones. Work quickly while the potato retains heat.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Scottish] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 88

■ United Kingdom

ENGLISH MUFFINS FROM SCRATCH

Homemade English muffins — thick, yeast-leavened, cooked entirely on a griddle — with their characteristic nooks and crannies that trap melted butter perfectly. Split with a fork, never a knife, to preserve those crucial irregular holes. Toasted, buttered, and eaten with jam or as the base for Eggs Benedict.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm milk
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) warm water
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- Semolina or polenta, for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk, water, and oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and slightly sticky. This dough is softer than bread dough — do not add extra flour.
2. Prove 1–1.5 hours until doubled.
3. Turn out onto a semolina-dusted surface. Roll to 2cm (¾ inch) thick.
4. Cut rounds using a 9cm (3.5-inch) cutter. Dust tops and bottoms with semolina.
5. Prove on lined trays 30 minutes.
6. Heat a dry griddle or flat pan over very low heat.
7. Cook muffins without oil for 7–8 minutes per side — they must cook very gently all the way through. They will be pale gold, not dark.
8. Cool on a rack. To serve: split with a fork around the circumference (never cut) to preserve the interior texture. Toast and butter generously.

Prep: 20 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~200 per muffin

TIP

Always split English muffins with a fork, pulling them apart rather than cutting. The rough, torn interior creates vastly more surface area for butter to pool into. A knife creates a flat surface that does nothing.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic British]

RECIPE 89

■ ■ United Kingdom / ■ ■ USA

EGGS BENEDICT

A toasted English muffin half topped with Canadian-style back bacon, a perfectly poached egg, and a river of silky hollandaise sauce. Likely created in New York but adopted by the British as a weekend brunch centrepiece. The definitive celebration breakfast of the English-speaking world.

INGREDIENTS**FOR THE HOLLANDAISE**

- 3 egg yolks
- 1 tbsp water
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar (or lemon juice)
- 200g (¾ cup) unsalted butter, clarified or melted
- Salt, white pepper, and pinch of cayenne

FOR ASSEMBLY

- 4 English muffins, split and toasted
- 4–8 slices back bacon (Canadian-style), pan-fried
- 4–8 large eggs (for poaching)
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar (for poaching water)
- Chives and paprika, to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make hollandaise: Whisk egg yolks and water in a heatproof bowl. Place over barely simmering water (bain-marie) — the bowl must not touch the water.
2. Whisk constantly until yolks thicken and leave a trail — about 3–4 minutes.
3. Remove from heat. Slowly drizzle in warm clarified butter, whisking constantly, until thick and glossy. Add vinegar, salt, pepper, and cayenne. Keep warm over the pan of warm water (not heat).
4. Bring a wide saucepan of water with vinegar to a bare simmer. Stir to create a gentle vortex.
5. Crack an egg into a small cup. Slip into the vortex. Poach 3 minutes for runny yolk. Repeat for each egg.
6. Stack: toasted muffin → bacon → poached egg.
7. Spoon hollandaise generously over.
8. Garnish with chives and a pinch of paprika.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

Fresh eggs poach better — the white clings to the yolk. The vinegar in the water speeds white coagulation. For multiple guests, poach eggs in advance, keep in cold water, and reheat in warm water for 30 sec.

[High Protein] [Special Occasion] [Classic British-American]

RECIPE 90

■ ■ United Kingdom

SMOKED SALMON AND SCRAMBLED

British smoked salmon — lightly cured, cold-smoked, and silky — paired with softly scrambled eggs on thick sourdough toast. A luxury weekend breakfast that takes ten minutes from start to plate and looks like it took considerably longer.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp crème fraîche or cream cheese
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- 150g (5 oz) Scottish or Irish smoked salmon
- 2 thick slices sourdough, toasted
- 1 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 1 tbsp capers
- 1 lemon, sliced
- Salt and white pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast sourdough until golden and firm.
2. Beat eggs with crème fraîche, salt, and white pepper.
3. Melt butter in a non-stick pan over the lowest possible heat. Add egg mixture.
4. Stir very slowly and continuously with a silicone spatula, moving the curds gently.
5. Cook 5–7 minutes until soft, glossy, barely-set curds form. Remove from heat slightly before they look done — residual heat finishes them.
6. Pile scrambled eggs onto toast immediately.
7. Drape smoked salmon over the eggs.
8. Scatter dill and capers. Add lemon slices.
9. Season lightly — salmon is already salty.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Do not add salt to the egg mixture until just before cooking — salt draws out moisture and can make scrambled eggs weep and become watery if left to sit.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Quick]

RECIPE 91

■ ■ United Kingdom (England)

TRADITIONAL SCONES WITH

The classic British scone — light, flaky, barely sweetened — served warm with clotted cream and strawberry jam. The Cornish put cream first, then jam. The Devonians put jam first, then cream. Both sides are passionately, immovably correct. This is England's most enduring food debate.

INGREDIENTS

- 350g (2¾ cups) self-raising flour
- (or plain flour + 1½ tsp baking powder)
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 85g (6 tbsp) cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 3 tbsp caster (superfine) sugar
- 175ml (¾ cup) cold whole milk
- 1 large egg, for egg wash

FOR SERVING

- Clotted cream or thick double cream
- Good strawberry jam
- Extra butter (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F). Line a baking tray.
2. Sift flour and baking powder together.
3. Rub cold butter into flour using fingertips until it resembles fine breadcrumbs. Work quickly to keep butter cold.
4. Stir in sugar.
5. Make a well. Add cold milk all at once. Mix with a cutlery knife (not hands) until a rough, shaggy dough comes together.
6. Turn onto a lightly floured surface. Press — do not roll — to 3cm (1.2-inch) thick.
7. Cut straight down with a fluted cutter (no twisting — twisting prevents rising). Reroll scraps once only.
8. Brush tops lightly with beaten egg.
9. Bake 12–15 minutes until well risen and golden.
10. Eat warm. Stack with cream and jam.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~280 per scone (with cream and jam)

TIP

Cold ingredients, light handling, no rolling (only pressing), and no twisting of the cutter. These four rules produce light, tall, flaky scones. Break any of them and you get hockey pucks.

[Vegetarian] [Classic British] [Make-Ahead] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 92

■ ■ United Kingdom (Northern Ireland)

NORTHERN IRISH SODA BREAD

Ireland's most democratic bread — no yeast, no kneading, no proofing. Buttermilk and bicarbonate of soda react instantly, producing a dense, tender loaf with a hard crust and a flavor that is slightly tangy and deeply wheaty. Made and eaten the same day. Best warm with salted butter and nothing else.

INGREDIENTS

- 450g (3½ cups) plain flour (or mix of white and wholemeal)
- 1 tsp bicarbonate of soda (baking soda)
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 1 tsp sugar (optional)
- 400ml (1■ cups) cold buttermilk
- Optional: 1 tbsp rolled oats for the top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F).
2. Mix flour, bicarbonate of soda, and salt in a bowl.
3. Make a well in the center. Pour in buttermilk.
4. Stir with a fork until a rough, shaggy dough forms. It should be sticky — do not add more flour.
5. Turn onto a lightly floured surface. With floured hands, shape quickly into a round, about 5cm high. Handle as little as possible.
6. Place on a floured baking tray.
7. Using a sharp knife, deeply score a cross in the top — the cross allows the heat to penetrate the center.
8. Dust with oats if desired.
9. Bake 30 minutes until well risen and the base sounds hollow when tapped.
10. Wrap in a clean damp tea towel and cool on a rack — this softens the crust slightly.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 10 slices · Cal: ~185 per slice

TIP

Speed is everything with soda bread. Once buttermilk meets bicarbonate, the reaction starts immediately. Mix, shape, and get it in the oven within 5 minutes. Dawdling produces flat bread.

[Vegetarian] [No-Yeast] [Quick] [Classic Irish]

RECIPE 93

■■ United Kingdom

MARMALADE ON THICK TOAST

Seville orange marmalade on thick white toast with cold salted butter is Britain's most traditional morning condiment combination. Made from bitter Seville oranges available only in January, good marmalade has a complex bittersweet intensity that no other preserve can replicate. Churchill, Paddington Bear, and James Bond all agreed: marmalade on toast is non-negotiable.

INGREDIENTS

FOR QUICK MARMALADE

- 500g (18 oz) Seville oranges (or regular orange + 1 lemon)
- 800g (4 cups) granulated sugar
- 800ml (3■ cups) water

FOR SERVING

- 4 thick slices white bread, toasted
- 4 tbsp cold salted butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Scrub oranges. Halve and squeeze juice into a bowl. Collect pips and tie in muslin.
2. Slice peel thinly (or thickly — preference applies).
3. Combine juice, sliced peel, pips in muslin, and water in a large saucepan. Simmer 1.5–2 hours until peel is completely soft.
4. Remove pips. Add sugar. Stir over low heat to dissolve.
5. Boil rapidly until setting point is reached — 104°C (220°F) — or use the cold plate test (drizzle on a cold plate; it wrinkles when pushed after 1 minute cooling).
6. Cool 10 minutes. Pot into sterilized jars.
7. Toast bread. Spread cold salted butter.
8. Spread marmalade generously. Eat with tea.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 2 hrs · Serves: 4 jars

TIP

Seville oranges are only available in January and early February. They freeze whole beautifully — buy extra in season, freeze them, and make marmalade year-round. Thaw and proceed with the same recipe.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [Classic British] [Preserves]

RECIPE 94

United Kingdom

YORKSHIRE TEA AND THE

Britain runs on tea. Not herbal, not green — builder's tea: strong, dark, made with Yorkshire or PG Tips teabags, brewed properly, and served with milk (added second, always second). The ritual of making tea is as important as drinking it. This is the most British recipe in this entire book.

INGREDIENTS

- 1–2 good quality black teabags (Yorkshire, PG Tips,
- or Tetley — not loose leaf for a builder's cup)
- Freshly boiled water (just off the boil — 95°C)
- 30ml (2 tbsp) cold whole milk
- Sugar (optional)
- A proper mug — never a cup and saucer for builder's

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Fill the kettle with fresh cold water. Boil.
2. Warm the mug first — pour a little boiling water in, swirl, discard. This matters.
3. Add the teabag to the warm, empty mug.
4. Pour freshly boiled water over the teabag immediately — do not let the kettle sit. Off-boil water extracts poorly.
5. Brew 3–4 minutes. Do not squeeze — squeezing releases tannins that make tea bitter and tannic.
6. Remove teabag. Set aside (do not bin — the bag goes in the compost or is used for a second cup).
7. Add cold milk. Stir.
8. The tea should be the color of a paper bag. Not pale beige. Not black. Paper bag brown.
9. Add sugar if desired. Drink hot.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~25 per cup

TIP

Milk goes in second — after the tea is brewed. Milk-in-first was historically for bone china to prevent cracking and has no place in a builder's mug. This is not a debate — it is fact.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic British] [5 min]

RECIPE 95

United Kingdom (Wales)

WELSH LAVERBREAD WITH BACON

Laverbread — bara lawr — is boiled, pureed seaweed (laver) mixed with oatmeal and formed into patties, then fried in bacon fat until crispy. Intensely umami, deeply oceanic, and served as part of the traditional Welsh breakfast with bacon and cockles. Described by Richard Burton as "Welshman's caviar."

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) prepared laverbread (tinned or fresh —
- found at Welsh or British specialty shops)
- 4 tbsp fine or medium oatmeal
- 4 rashers streaky or back bacon
- Salt and black pepper
- Lemon wedge to serve
- Optional: 100g (3.5 oz) cockles alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix laverbread with oatmeal until it forms a firm paste that holds its shape. Season.
2. Form into flat patties, about 1cm (½ inch) thick.
3. Fry bacon in a dry pan until crispy. Remove and reserve the bacon fat in the pan.
4. Fry laverbread patties in the bacon fat over medium heat, 3–4 minutes per side until golden and crispy on the outside.
5. Serve alongside the crispy bacon.
6. Add cockles and a squeeze of lemon if available.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Laverbread is intensely savory and oceanic — the oatmeal tempers it slightly and gives the patties body. Frying in bacon fat rather than oil is traditional and adds an essential smoky richness.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Welsh] [Regional]

RECIPE 96

Greece

GREEK YOGURT WITH THYME

The definitive Greek breakfast — strained whole-milk yogurt, tart and thick as clotted cream, drizzled with dark thyme honey from the mountains, and topped with crushed walnuts. Eaten in villages and five-star hotels alike. Three ingredients, eaten with a dessert spoon, in reverent silence.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) full-fat Greek strained yogurt
- (whole-milk, 10% fat if available)
- 3 tbsp Greek thyme honey (or any good floral honey)
- 60g (½ cup) walnut halves, lightly toasted
- Optional: 1 tbsp sesame seeds, pinch of cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Divide yogurt into two bowls. It should be thick enough to hold a spoon upright — if not, it has not been properly strained.
2. Drizzle thyme honey generously over the yogurt in a slow, deliberate pour.
3. Scatter toasted walnut halves on top.
4. Add sesame seeds and cinnamon if using.
5. Eat slowly with a dessert spoon.
6. Drink strong Greek coffee alongside.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

If buying yogurt outside Greece, strain it yourself overnight — line a sieve with a coffee filter, add yogurt, refrigerate. The liquid (whey) that drips out reveals the yogurt's true quality. The thicker the final yogurt, the richer the breakfast.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Vegetarian] [Quick]

RECIPE 97

■■ Greece

TIROPITA

GREEK CHEESE PIE

Golden, shatteringly crispy phyllo pastry encasing a savory filling of crumbled feta, eggs, and herbs — the iconic Greek cheese pie found in every bakery, on every corner, at every hour of the day. Eaten warm with a coffee, it is Greece's most perfect portable breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) Greek feta cheese, crumbled
- 3 large eggs
- 200g (¾ cup) anothytros or ricotta cheese
- 3 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh mint, chopped
- Black pepper (no salt — feta is salty enough)
- 10 sheets phyllo dough
- 100ml (⅓ cup) good olive oil, for brushing
- Sesame seeds for topping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Brush a 30x20cm (12x8-inch) baking tray with oil.
2. Mix crumbled feta, ricotta, eggs, dill, mint, and black pepper. Taste — it should be salty, herby, and rich.
3. Layer 5 phyllo sheets in the tray, brushing each generously with olive oil. Let edges overhang.
4. Spread cheese filling evenly over the phyllo.
5. Layer remaining 5 sheets on top, each brushed with olive oil. Fold the overhanging edges in and crimp to seal.
6. Score the top layer into portions with a sharp knife. Brush with oil. Sprinkle sesame seeds.
7. Bake 40–45 minutes until deep golden and shatteringly crispy.
8. Cool 10 minutes before cutting.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~340 per piece

TIP

Keep unused phyllo sheets covered with a slightly damp tea towel — they dry and crack in minutes when exposed to air. Work with one sheet at a time and keep the rest covered always.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Greek]

Greece

BOUGATSA THESSALONIKI

Thessaloniki's most famous morning food — crispy phyllo pastry layers encasing a warm, slightly wobbly semolina custard, dusted with powdered sugar and cinnamon. Made fresh every morning at bougatsa shops and eaten standing at the counter. The city's edible identity.

INGREDIENTS

- 10 sheets phyllo dough
- 80ml (■ cup) unsalted butter, melted
- 80ml (■ cup) olive oil (mixed with butter for brushing)

FOR THE CUSTARD FILLING

- 1L (4 cups) whole milk
- 120g (■ cup) fine semolina
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 3 egg yolks
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 30g (2 tbsp) unsalted butter

FOR SERVING

- Icing sugar, sifted
- Ground cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make custard: heat milk and sugar until steaming. Whisk in semolina gradually. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until very thick (8–10 min).
2. Remove from heat. Beat in egg yolks one at a time. Add vanilla and butter. Mix until smooth.
3. Press plastic wrap against the surface. Cool.
4. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Grease a baking tray.
5. Lay 5 phyllo sheets in the tray, brushing each with butter-oil mix, overlapping edges.
6. Spread cooled semolina custard over phyllo.
7. Top with remaining 5 phyllo sheets, each brushed. Fold edges in and seal.
8. Bake 40–45 minutes until golden and crispy.
9. Cool 5 minutes. Dust heavily with icing sugar and cinnamon. Cut into portions immediately.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 50 min • Serves: 8 • Cal: ~360 per piece

TIP

The semolina custard must be very cold before assembly — warm custard will steam the phyllo before baking and make it soggy. If short on time, spread the custard in a thin layer on a tray to cool faster.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Greek] [Special Occasion]

AVGOLEMONO BREAKFAST SOUP

Avgolemono — the silky Greek egg-lemon soup — made with chicken broth and rice, thickened by the emulsification of eggs and lemon juice into a smooth, velvety, bright soup. Served as a breakfast in rural Greece, it is one of the world's most elegant soups achievable in 20 minutes.

INGREDIENTS

- 1L (4 cups) strong homemade or good-quality chicken broth
- 80g (■ cup) short-grain rice or orzo pasta
- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- Juice of 1.5–2 lemons (about 80ml / ■ cup)
- Salt and white pepper
- Fresh dill or flat-leaf parsley, to serve
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring chicken broth to a boil in a saucepan.
2. Add rice or orzo. Cook 15–18 minutes until tender. Reduce heat to lowest setting.
3. In a bowl, whisk eggs vigorously until frothy — at least 2 minutes. They should be pale and airy.
4. Whisk lemon juice into the eggs.
5. Ladle about 250ml (1 cup) of hot broth very slowly into the egg-lemon mixture while whisking constantly. Then add another ladle. This tempers the eggs.
6. Pour the tempered egg mixture back into the soup pot. Stir gently.
7. Heat over very low heat 2–3 minutes — do not boil. The soup will thicken and turn creamy.
8. Season with salt and white pepper.
9. Scatter fresh dill. Serve with crusty bread.

Prep: 5 min • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~190 per serving

TIP

Temperature control is everything. If the soup boils after you add the egg-lemon mixture, the eggs scramble and the silky texture is destroyed. Keep the heat very low and patience very high.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Greek]

RECIPE 100

■ ■ Greece

ELLINIKOS KAFES*GREEK COFFEE*

Greek coffee — made in a small copper briki, simmered slowly until a thick foam (kaimaki) rises — is one of the world's most ancient coffee traditions. Served in a small cup with a glass of cold water, the thick grounds settle at the bottom. Never drink the last sip. Never rush this coffee.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 heaped tsp finely ground Greek coffee
- (Loumidis or similar — ground to a powder)
- 100ml (■ cup + 1 tbsp) cold water
- Sugar: none (sketo), medium (metrio), or sweet (glykos)
- 1 glass ice-cold water, to serve alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Add cold water to a small copper or stainless briki (or small saucepan).
2. Add coffee and sugar according to preference: — Sketo: no sugar — Metrio: 1 level tsp sugar — Glykos: 2 tsp sugar
3. Stir once to combine.
4. Place over the lowest possible heat.
5. Watch it carefully — do not stir again. As it heats, a foam (kaimaki) will rise slowly.
6. Just as the foam reaches the top of the briki, remove from heat and pour immediately into a small cup — tilt to preserve the foam on top.
7. Wait 2 minutes for grounds to settle.
8. Sip slowly alongside ice-cold water.
9. When the grounds appear, stop drinking.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~5 (sketo)

TIP

Greek coffee is also used for tasseography — reading the coffee grounds. After finishing, invert the cup onto the saucer, wait 5 minutes, and read the shapes left behind. Greece's original morning ritual.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Greek] [Quick]

RECIPE 101

■ ■ Greece (Crete)

DAKOS (CRETAN BARLEY RUSK)

Crete's most famous food — a dry barley rusk (paximadi) briefly soaked in water, topped with grated ripe tomato, crumbled feta, olive oil, and dried oregano. Eaten for breakfast, lunch, and as a meze. The Cretan diet's most celebrated ambassador.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large barley rusks (paximadi — found at Greek delis
- or specialty stores)
- 3 large ripe tomatoes, grated
- 150g (5 oz) barrel-aged Greek feta, crumbled
- 4 tbsp premium Cretan extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp dried Greek oregano
- Flaky sea salt
- Black pepper
- Optional: 50g (2 oz) Kalamata olives
- Optional: handful of fresh basil or mint

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Briefly run each rusk under cold water for 3–5 seconds — just enough to slightly soften the surface without making it soggy. They should still have significant crunch.
2. Grate ripe tomatoes directly over each rusk, letting the juice soak in.
3. Crumble feta generously over the tomato.
4. Drizzle olive oil over everything.
5. Sprinkle dried oregano and black pepper.
6. Add olives and fresh herbs if using.
7. Add a pinch of flaky sea salt.
8. Eat immediately.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

The barley rusk must retain most of its crunch — wet it for 3 seconds maximum. A soggy dakos is not dakos. The contrast of the crunchy base against the juicy tomato is the entire point of the dish.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Cretan] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 102

■ ■ Greece

STRAPATSADA

GREEK SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH TOMATO

Strapatsada is Greece's answer to shakshuka and menemen — eggs scrambled directly into a thick, reduced tomato sauce seasoned with oregano and olive oil. Simple, fast, and intensely flavorful. The Greek summer breakfast when tomatoes are at their peak.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 4 large ripe tomatoes, grated or blended
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp dried oregano
- Salt and black pepper
- 80g (3 oz) feta, crumbled (optional, added after)
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a skillet over medium heat.
2. Add grated tomatoes. Season with salt and oregano.
3. Simmer 8–10 minutes until the tomato sauce is thick and jammy — most liquid should have evaporated.
4. Beat eggs briefly and pour over the tomato.
5. Stir gently over medium heat, folding eggs and tomato together until eggs are softly scrambled but still slightly underdone.
6. Remove from heat. Crumble feta over if using.
7. Season with black pepper.
8. Serve immediately with crusty bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The tomato sauce must be very thick before you add the eggs — if it's watery, the eggs will steam rather than scramble and the texture will be wrong. Reduce boldly and confidently.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Quick]

RECIPE 103

■ ■ Greece

LOUKOUMADES

GREEK HONEY DOUGHNUTS

Ancient Greek honey puffs — small, irregularly shaped fried dough balls drenched in thyme honey and sprinkled with cinnamon and crushed walnuts. Sold from street stalls since antiquity, awarded at the ancient Olympic Games, and still eaten for breakfast in Greek villages and city squares.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

FOR SERVING

- 4 tbsp Greek thyme honey, warmed
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 50g (½ cup) walnuts, crushed
- Optional: 2 tbsp sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm water. Whisk until completely smooth — it should be a thick, sticky batter, not a kneadable dough.
2. Cover and prove 1 hour until bubbly and slightly puffed.
3. Heat oil to 180°C (355°F) in a deep pan.
4. Using two wet spoons (or an ice cream scoop), drop rounded tablespoons of batter into the oil.
5. They will be irregular — this is correct and beautiful.
6. Fry 3–4 minutes, turning, until golden all over.
7. Drain on paper towels.
8. Pile into bowls. Drizzle warm honey generously.
9. Sprinkle cinnamon, crushed walnuts, and sesame seeds.
10. Eat immediately while hot and fragrant.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr proof • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP The batter should be thick enough to hold a rough shape when dropped from a spoon but not so thick it doesn't spread at all. Add water by the tablespoon if too stiff.

[Vegan] [Classic Greek] [Street Food] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 104

■■ Greece

KOULOURI THESSALONIKI

GREEK SESAME BREAD RING

Koulouri — the chewy, sesame-encrusted bread rings sold from carts throughout Thessaloniki and Athens every morning. Breakfast for millions of Greeks who grab one on their way to work. Somewhere between a soft pretzel and a bagel, but uniquely Greek.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 280ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp olive oil

FOR COATING

- 200ml (¾ cup) water mixed with 2 tbsp grape molasses
- or dark syrup
- 150g (1 cup) sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and olive oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide dough into 12 pieces. Roll each into a long rope about 40cm (16 inches).
4. Form into a ring, pressing ends firmly together.
5. Dip each ring completely in the molasses-water mixture. Shake off excess.
6. Immediately roll in sesame seeds to coat completely.
7. Place on lined baking trays. Prove 30 minutes.
8. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 18–20 minutes until the sesame seeds are golden and fragrant.
9. Eat warm or at room temperature. They last one day.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hr proof • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 12 • Cal: ~240 per koulouri

TIP The molasses dip is what makes koulouri distinctively different from a plain bread ring — it creates a slightly sweet, lacquered surface that toasts the sesame perfectly. Do not skip this step.

[Vegan] [Classic Greek] [Street Food] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 105

■■ Greece

FETA WITH OLIVE OIL AND

A thick slab of PDO barrel-aged Greek feta drizzled with olive oil, sprinkled with dried oregano, and served alongside sliced ripe tomatoes and crusty bread. One of the simplest and most satisfying breakfasts in existence. Greece in four ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) Greek feta cheese in a block
- (PDO barrel-aged, not crumbled)
- 2 large ripe tomatoes, thickly sliced
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin Greek olive oil
- 1 tsp dried Greek oregano
- Black pepper
- A few Kalamata olives
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Remove feta from its brine. Pat dry gently.
2. Place the whole block on a plate — do not crumble.
3. Drizzle olive oil generously over the feta.
4. Sprinkle dried oregano over the top.
5. Add a few grinds of black pepper.
6. Arrange tomato slices alongside.
7. Add olives.
8. Serve with crusty bread for tearing and scooping.

Prep: 4 min • Cook: 0 min • Serves: 2 • Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The feta must be in brine — not pre-crumbled "salad cheese." Barrel-aged feta has a complexity and saltiness that is entirely different from the mild, crumbly versions sold elsewhere.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Low Carb] [No-Cook] [Quick]

RECIPE 106

■ ■ Greece

TAHINOSOUPA

TAHINI SOUP

A surprisingly warming and nutritious Greek breakfast soup — vegetable or chicken broth whisked with good tahini and lemon, creating a silky, sesame-rich, golden soup. Common in northern Greece, particularly during Lent, and intensely satisfying on a cold morning.

INGREDIENTS

- 1L (4 cups) vegetable or light chicken broth
- 80g (■ cup) good-quality tahini (well stirred)
- Juice of 1.5 lemons
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin
- Salt and white pepper
- Fresh parsley, chopped
- Drizzle of olive oil
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring broth to a gentle simmer.
2. In a bowl, whisk tahini with lemon juice until smooth — it will seize and thicken initially, then loosen.
3. Whisk in minced garlic and cumin.
4. Ladle about 200ml (¾ cup) of warm broth into the tahini mixture, whisking constantly to temper it.
5. Pour the tahini mixture back into the broth, whisking while pouring.
6. Simmer gently 3–4 minutes, stirring — do not boil.
7. Season with salt and white pepper.
8. Serve in bowls drizzled with olive oil and scattered with parsley. Eat with crusty bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~220 per serving

TIP

Tahini must be well-stirred before use — the oil separates in the jar. Unstirred tahini creates an uneven soup. Stir from the bottom of the jar until the tahini is smooth and uniform before measuring.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Lenten]

RECIPE 107

■ ■ Greece

REVITHIA SOUPA

GREEK CHICKPEA SOUP

From the island of Sifnos — chickpeas slow-cooked overnight in olive oil and rosemary in a clay pot in the village oven, eaten as a Sunday breakfast after church. Thick, creamy, and deeply flavored. One of the ancient world's most perfect soups.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) dried chickpeas, soaked overnight
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 4 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil + extra to serve
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- 2 sprigs fresh rosemary
- Juice of 1 lemon
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked chickpeas. Rinse well.
2. Place chickpeas, onion, olive oil, rosemary, and water in a heavy pot.
3. Bring to a boil. Skim off any foam.
4. Reduce heat to very low. Cover and simmer 1.5–2 hours until chickpeas are completely tender and creamy.
5. Remove rosemary sprigs.
6. Use the back of a spoon to crush a quarter of the chickpeas against the side — this thickens the soup naturally.
7. Add lemon juice. Season generously with salt and pepper.
8. Serve in deep bowls with a significant pour of olive oil on top. Scatter parsley. Add crusty bread.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soak · Cook: 2 hrs · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

This soup is traditionally cooked in a clay pot in a wood oven overnight on Sifnos. At home, use a heavy Dutch oven over the lowest heat. The slow, gentle heat creates a depth impossible to rush.

[Vegan] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 108

■ ■ Portugal

PASTÉIS DE NATA

PORTUGUESE CUSTARD TARTS

Created by monks at the Jerónimos Monastery in Belém in the early 19th century, the pastel de nata is arguably the world's most perfect pastry. A shatteringly flaky puff pastry shell, a silky-sweet custard filling, and the crucial burned and blistered top that comes only from a blazing-hot oven.

INGREDIENTS**FOR THE PASTRY SHELLS**

- 500g (18 oz) all-butter puff pastry, thawed

FOR THE CUSTARD FILLING

- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) heavy cream
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 4 tbsp water
- 6 egg yolks
- 30g (3½ tbsp) cornstarch
- 1 cinnamon stick
- Peel of ½ lemon

FOR SERVING

- Ground cinnamon
- Icing sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make the syrup: combine sugar and water in a saucepan. Bring to a boil and cook until it reaches 107°C (225°F) — about 3 minutes. Remove from heat.
2. Warm milk, cream, cinnamon stick, and lemon peel until steaming. Remove cinnamon and lemon.
3. Whisk egg yolks and cornstarch until smooth. Gradually whisk in the warm milk mixture.
4. Return to heat. Cook over medium, stirring constantly, until thickened. Remove from heat. Pour in the sugar syrup. Stir to combine. Cool completely.
5. Preheat oven to its maximum — 250°C (480°F) at minimum. Use a pizza stone or metal baking tray preheated inside.
6. Roll puff pastry tightly into a log. Slice into 12 rounds.
7. Press each round into a lightly greased muffin tin, working it up the sides with your thumbs to form a cup.
8. Fill each shell ¾ full with cooled custard.
9. Bake 15–18 minutes until the custard is deeply blistered and charred in places. The tops should be almost burned.
10. Cool 5 minutes. Dust with cinnamon and icing sugar. Eat warm.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~220 per tart

TIP

The charring is not a mistake — it is the entire point. A pale, uncharred nata is undercooked. The maximum oven temperature and preheated tray are essential to achieve the authentic blistered top.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Portuguese] [Special Occasion]

Portugal

RECIPE 109

■ ■ Portugal

GALÃO

PORTUGUESE COFFEE WITH MILK

Galão — the Portuguese tall coffee with foamed milk — is served in a long glass and is the country's most popular breakfast coffee. Lighter than a latte, the galão is ¾ foamed milk and ¼ espresso, ordered in every café in Lisbon and Porto since the 19th century.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 shot (30ml) freshly pulled espresso
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk, steamed and foamed
- to a lightly frothy consistency

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pull one espresso shot into the bottom of a tall heat-proof glass (a latte glass works well).
2. Steam milk until hot with a light, silky foam — not the thick, stiff foam of a cappuccino. The milk should be hot and pourable.
3. Gently pour steamed milk over the espresso, allowing a little foam to collect on top.
4. The ratio is approximately 1 part espresso to 3 parts milk. The result should be a pale gold.
5. Do not stir. Drink as is.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~80 per glass

TIP

In Portugal, the galão is always served in a glass — never a cup. If you want it in a cup, you order a meia de leite (a shorter version). These distinctions matter in Portuguese café culture.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Portuguese]

RECIPE 110

■ ■ Portugal

TORRADA COM MANTEIGA

PORTUGUESE PRESSED TOAST

Torrada is not regular toast — it is thick white bread pressed flat in a sandwich maker, emerging golden and slightly compressed with a crunchy exterior and soft, chewy interior. Spread with cold salted butter while still hot. The Portuguese café breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices Portuguese white bread (pão de forma)
- or brioche
- 4 tbsp salted butter, cold
- Optional: strawberry jam or dulce de leite

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat a sandwich press or panini maker until very hot.
2. Place bread slices in the press — no butter in the press.
3. Close and press firmly for 3–4 minutes until golden, crispy, and slightly compressed. The bread should be toasted all the way through with no soft spots.
4. Remove immediately. Spread cold salted butter generously over the hot surface — the butter melts dramatically into the crispy bread.
5. Add jam or dulce de leite if desired.
6. Serve with a galão coffee. Eat while hot.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The bread must be thick — thin bread becomes overly compressed and dry. Portuguese pão de forma is specifically made thicker than standard sliced bread for this purpose.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic Portuguese] [5 Ingredients]

RECIPE 111

■ ■ Portugal

BOLA DE BERLIM

PORTUGUESE BERLINER DOUGHNUT

Portugal's beloved beach doughnut — a large, round, fried yeasted dough filled with bright yellow crema de pasteleiro (pastry cream), rolled in coarse sugar. Sold on Portuguese beaches since the 1950s, these are now eaten year-round at breakfast in pastelarias across the country.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 3 large eggs
- 100ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- Zest of 1 lemon

FOR THE FILLING

- 4 egg yolks
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 40g (⅓ cup) cornstarch
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 1 tsp vanilla
- 1 tbsp butter
- Vegetable oil for deep frying, coarse sugar for rolling

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, eggs, warm milk, and lemon zest. Knead 8 minutes. Add butter gradually. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth. Prove 1.5 hours.
2. Make pastry cream: whisk yolks, sugar, cornstarch. Heat milk; pour slowly into yolk mixture. Return to heat; stir until thick. Add vanilla and butter. Cool completely.
3. Divide dough into 10 balls. Flatten slightly. Prove on trays 45 minutes.
4. Fry at 170°C (340°F) for 3–4 minutes per side until deep golden.
5. Roll immediately in coarse sugar.
6. Cool slightly. Cut a horizontal slit in each.
7. Fill generously with cold pastry cream using a piping bag.

Prep: 30 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~390 per doughnut

TIP

The pastry cream must be very cold before filling — warm cream melts out of the doughnut. Make it the night before and refrigerate. Cold cream holds its shape perfectly when piped.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Portuguese] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 112

■ ■ Portugal (Alentejo)

AÇORDA À ALENTEJANA

PORTUGUESE BREAD SOUP

Açorda is Portugal's ancient bread soup — stale bread soaked in garlicky, coriander-scented olive oil broth, with poached eggs broken in at the end. From the Alentejo plains, this is peasant food that tastes like a Michelin-starred revelation.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) stale crusty bread, torn into pieces
- 4 large eggs
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- Large bunch of fresh coriander, chopped
- 80ml (⅓ cup) good extra-virgin olive oil
- 800ml (3⅓ cups) hot water or light broth
- 1 tsp white wine vinegar (for poaching)
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place torn bread in a large deep bowl or pot.
2. Crush garlic with a pinch of salt to a paste. Mix with coriander and olive oil in a bowl.
3. Bring broth to a boil. Season with salt.
4. Pour hot broth over the bread — enough to fully soak it. Stir to combine.
5. Stir in the garlic-coriander-oil mixture.
6. Taste and season generously. The açorda should be thick, porridge-like, and deeply fragrant.
7. Meanwhile, poach eggs in separate simmering water with vinegar, 3 minutes for runny yolk.
8. Place a poached egg in each bowl of açorda.
9. Drizzle with extra olive oil. Serve immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

The quantity of coriander in this dish should feel almost excessive to a non-Portuguese cook. Alentejo cooking uses coriander lavishly and without apology. Be generous or the dish loses its identity.

[Vegan option] [High Protein] [Classic Portuguese] [Budget-Friendly]

RECIPE 113

■ ■ Portugal

PÃO DE DEUS

PORTUGUESE COCONUT SWEET ROLL

"Bread of God" — a soft, enriched Portuguese bread roll topped with a sweet coconut and sugar crust that caramelizes during baking. Found in pastelarias across Portugal, eaten warm for breakfast with coffee. The coconut topping is the defining, irresistible feature.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE ROLLS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 large eggs
- 150ml (■ cup) warm milk
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- Zest of 1 lemon

FOR THE COCONUT TOPPING

- 100g (1 cup) desiccated coconut
- 80g (■ cup) sugar
- 2 eggs, beaten
- 2 tbsp milk
- 1 tbsp butter, melted

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make dough: combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, eggs, warm milk, and lemon zest. Knead 8 minutes. Add butter gradually. Prove 1.5 hours.
2. Divide into 10 rolls. Shape into smooth balls. Place on lined trays. Prove 30 minutes.
3. Make topping: mix coconut, sugar, eggs, milk, and butter into a thick paste.
4. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
5. Place a generous tablespoon of coconut mixture on top of each roll, spreading slightly.
6. Bake 18–20 minutes until rolls are golden and coconut topping is set and lightly caramelized.
7. Cool 10 minutes. Eat warm.

Prep: 25 min · 2 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~320 per roll

TIP

The coconut topping should be placed onto the rolls before they go into the oven — not after. The oven heat sets and toasts the coconut simultaneously with the roll baking. Timing is synchronized.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Portuguese] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 114

■ ■ Portugal

OVOS MEXIDOS COM CHOURIÇO

PORTUGUESE SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH CHORIZO

Portuguese scrambled eggs — ovos mexidos — cooked with sliced chouriço that releases its paprika-rich fat into the eggs, coloring them gold and infusing them with a smoky, deeply savory flavor. Eaten with crusty bread in cafés throughout Portugal. Fast, bold, and completely satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 150g (5 oz) Portuguese chouriço, sliced into rounds
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped
- Crusty bread or torrada, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a skillet over medium heat. Add chouriço slices. Cook 2–3 minutes until lightly crisped and the fat has rendered — the oil will turn a deep orange-red from the paprika.
2. Add butter to the pan.
3. Beat eggs with salt and pepper.
4. Pour eggs over the chouriço.
5. Stir gently over medium-low heat, folding chouriço into the eggs as they set.
6. Cook slowly to creamy, soft curds — about 5 minutes.
7. Remove from heat while still slightly glossy.
8. Scatter parsley. Serve immediately with bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Portuguese chouriço is different from Spanish chorizo — it is more heavily smoked and garlicky. Look for linguiça or chouriço de vinho at Portuguese delis. The right sausage makes this dish exceptional.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Quick]

RECIPE 115

■ ■ Portugal

RABANADAS

PORTUGUESE FRENCH TOAST

Portugal's version of French toast — thick slices of stale bread soaked in warm spiced milk and eggs, fried golden in olive oil, and rolled in cinnamon sugar. Traditionally eaten at Christmas but now an all-year breakfast staple in Portuguese homes.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 thick slices stale white bread
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 1 cinnamon stick
- Peel of ½ lemon
- 2 large eggs
- Olive oil for frying
- 100g (½ cup) sugar mixed with 2 tsp ground cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Warm milk with cinnamon stick and lemon peel over low heat until steaming. Let infuse 10 minutes. Remove cinnamon and lemon.
2. Pour warm infused milk into a shallow dish. Beat in eggs until combined.
3. Dip bread slices in the milk-egg mixture, soaking each side thoroughly — 2 minutes per side.
4. Heat a generous pour of olive oil (not butter — olive oil is traditional and essential) in a wide skillet over medium heat.
5. Fry soaked bread 3 minutes per side until deeply golden.
6. Drain briefly. Immediately roll in cinnamon sugar on all sides.
7. Serve warm — they are best eaten within 15 minutes.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving (2 slices)

TIP

Frying in olive oil rather than butter creates a distinctly Portuguese flavor — slightly fruity and savory — that complements the cinnamon sugar coating in a way that butter-fried versions cannot replicate.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Portuguese] [Seasonal] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 116

■ ■ Portugal (Alentejo)

MIGAS À PORTUGUESA

PORTUGUESE BREADCRUMB FRYUP

Portuguese migas — different from the Spanish version — are a thick, fried mass of dampened stale bread cooked in pork fat with garlic and coriander until golden and slightly crispy in parts. Served with fried eggs and chouriço, this is the Alentejo farmer's breakfast that has sustained generations.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) stale alentejo bread or crusty white bread,
- crumbled into rough pieces
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 1 tsp salt
- 4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- Large handful fresh coriander, chopped
- 3 tbsp lard or olive oil
- 100g (3.5 oz) chouriço, sliced
- 4 fried eggs, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Sprinkle bread with salted water. Toss to dampen evenly. Cover with a cloth and rest 20 minutes — bread should be moist but not soaked.
2. Heat lard in a large, wide pan over medium heat. Add garlic and cook until golden.
3. Add chouriço. Cook 2 minutes until slightly crispy.
4. Add dampened bread all at once.
5. Press and stir with a wooden spoon, breaking pieces and moving constantly, for 12–15 minutes until the migas are golden in places and hold together.
6. Stir in fresh coriander. Season with salt.
7. Serve alongside fried eggs.

Prep: 10 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The texture of migas should be irregular — some parts slightly crispy, others soft and bread-like. Do not stir too aggressively or everything becomes uniform crumbs. Some chunkiness is desirable.

[Classic Portuguese] [Budget-Friendly] [One-Pan]

RECIPE 117

■ ■ Portugal

QUEIJO FRESCO COM MEL

FRESH CHEESE WITH HONEY

Queijo fresco — Portuguese fresh white cheese, mild and slightly grainy — drizzled with dark honey and eaten with bread. Common across Portugal as a light breakfast or afternoon snack. The honey's floral sweetness contrasts beautifully with the cheese's mild tang.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) queijo fresco (or fresh ricotta / mozzarella
- as substitute)
- 3 tbsp dark floral honey or eucalyptus honey
- Fresh mint leaves (optional)
- Crusty bread or crackers, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Slice queijo fresco into thick rounds. Arrange on a plate.
2. Drizzle dark honey generously over the cheese.
3. Add fresh mint leaves if using.
4. Serve with crusty bread or water crackers.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~220 per serving

TIP

Portuguese eucalyptus honey is one of the world's most distinctive honeys — dark, slightly medicinal, and deeply complex. If you can source it, this simple dish becomes genuinely extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [High Protein] [No-Cook] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 118

■ ■ Portugal

CALDO VERDE MATINAL

MORNING KALE SOUP

Portugal's most beloved soup — a silky potato and kale broth with sliced chouriço — eaten not just at dinner but for breakfast in the north of Portugal on cold mornings. Simple, nourishing, and built from the most honest ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) floury potatoes, peeled and diced
- 200g (7 oz) couve galega (Galician kale) or cavolo nero,
- very thinly shredded
- 150g (5 oz) chouriço, sliced
- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1.2L (5 cups) water or light broth
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a large pot over medium heat. Add onion and garlic. Cook 5 minutes until soft.
2. Add potatoes and broth. Bring to a boil. Simmer 15–18 minutes until potatoes are very tender.
3. Blend the potato soup until very smooth using an immersion blender.
4. Return to medium heat. Season with salt and pepper.
5. Add shredded kale — it must be shredded extremely thin (chiffonade). Simmer 3–4 minutes only — the kale should be bright green, not grey.
6. Add sliced chouriço. Heat 2 minutes.
7. Serve in deep bowls drizzled with olive oil.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The kale must be cut into the thinnest possible ribbons — almost translucent. This is not optional. Thickly cut kale takes too long to cook and turns grey. A very sharp knife and patience create the distinctive texture of authentic Caldo Verde.

[Gluten-Free] [High Fiber] [Classic Portuguese] [Make-Ahead]

Sweden

RECIPE 119



KANELBULLAR

SWEDISH CINNAMON BUNS

Sweden's most iconic pastry — soft, pillowy, cardamom-scented dough rolled with cinnamon butter, cut into individual buns, and adorned with pearl sugar. The kanelbulle is the centerpiece of every Swedish fika and breakfast table. October 4th is officially Kanelbullens Dag in Sweden — Cinnamon Bun Day.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 1 tsp ground cardamom (essential — do not omit)
- ½ tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm whole milk
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 large egg

FOR THE FILLING

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, very soft
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 2 tbsp ground cinnamon
- 1 tsp ground cardamom

FOR TOPPING

- 1 egg, beaten (egg wash)
- Pearl sugar (pärlsocker)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, cardamom, and salt. Add warm milk, softened butter, and egg. Knead 10 minutes until smooth, elastic, and slightly tacky. It will pull away from the bowl.
2. Cover and prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Mix filling: beat soft butter, sugar, cinnamon, and cardamom until a smooth paste forms.
4. Roll dough on a lightly floured surface into a large rectangle, approximately 40x60cm (16x24 inches).
5. Spread filling evenly across the entire surface, reaching every edge.
6. Fold the long side of the dough in thirds (like a letter). Then roll out again to about 40x30cm.
7. Cut into strips approximately 2cm wide. Twist each strip tightly, then coil it around two fingers into a snail shape. Tuck the end underneath.
8. Place on lined baking trays. Cover and prove 30–45 minutes until clearly puffed.
9. Brush gently with egg wash.
10. Scatter pearl sugar over each bun.
11. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 10–12 minutes until golden and fragrant. Do not overbake — they dry out quickly.

Prep: 30 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 20 · Cal: ~210 per bun

TIP

Cardamom is what separates a Swedish kanelbulle from every other cinnamon bun in the world. It must be in both the dough AND the filling. Freshly ground cardamom from whole pods is transformatively better than pre-ground.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Swedish] [Make-Ahead] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 120



FILMJÖLK MED FLINGOR

SWEDISH CULTURED MILK WITH CEREAL

Filmjöl — Sweden's beloved cultured, slightly sour buttermilk — poured over crunchy müsli or whole-grain flakes. Cold, tangy, and deeply nourishing, this is the most common Swedish weekday breakfast. Swedes consume more filmjöl per capita than almost any other nation. For good reason.

INGREDIENTS

- 400ml (1■ cups) filmjök (Swedish cultured milk —
- substitute: kefir or thin plain yogurt)
- 100g (1 cup) Swedish müsli (oats, rye flakes, seeds, dried fruit)
- 1 tbsp honey or lingonberry jam
- Fresh blueberries, raspberries, or sliced banana
- Optional: 1 tbsp flaxseed

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pour cold filmjök into a deep bowl.
2. Add müsli over the top.
3. Drizzle honey or add a spoonful of lingonberry jam.
4. Top with fresh berries and flaxseed.
5. Eat immediately — filmjök will start softening the müsli within minutes.
6. Pair with strong black coffee.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Filmjök is pourable — thinner than yogurt — making it perfect for cereals. If using kefir as a substitute, thin it slightly with milk for the right consistency. Greek yogurt is too thick and too sour to work well here.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Swedish]

RECIPE 121

■■ Sweden

SMÖRGÅS MED GRAVLAX

OPEN SANDWICH WITH CURED SALMON

The Swedish open-faced sandwich — a thick slice of dark rye or sourdough rye, generously buttered, then layered with homemade or good-quality gravlax, a dill-mustard sauce, cucumber, and fresh dill. Eaten with a fork and knife. Never — under any circumstances — picked up.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR QUICK GRAVLAX (make 24 hrs ahead):
- 400g (14 oz) very fresh salmon fillet, skin on
- 3 tbsp coarse sea salt
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp black pepper, coarsely crushed
- Large bunch fresh dill

FOR THE SANDWICH

- 4 slices dark Swedish rye (limpa or rågsurdeg)
- 4 tbsp good salted butter, room temperature
- Gravlax (from above), thinly sliced
- ½ cucumber, thinly sliced
- DILL MUSTARD SAUCE (Hovmästarsås):
- 2 tbsp Swedish or Dijon mustard
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar
- 4 tbsp neutral oil
- 3 tbsp fresh dill, finely chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MAKE GRAVLAX: Mix salt, sugar, and pepper. Lay half the dill in a dish. Place salmon skin-side up. Pack salt mixture over flesh. Cover with remaining dill. Wrap tightly. Refrigerate 24–48 hours, turning once. Scrape off cure before slicing paper-thin.
2. MAKE SAUCE: Whisk mustard, sugar, and vinegar. Slowly drizzle in oil while whisking. Fold in dill.
3. ASSEMBLE: Butter rye bread generously to every edge. Layer gravlax slices, overlapping. Add cucumber. Drizzle dill mustard sauce over top. Eat with fork and knife.

Prep: 20 min + 24 hrs curing · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per sandwich

TIP

Homemade gravlax is dramatically better than store-bought. The 24-48 hour cure concentrates the salmon and the dill permeates the fish completely. Use the freshest possible salmon — sashimi grade if available.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Swedish]

RECIPE 122

■■ Sweden

HAVREGRYNSGRÖT

SWEDISH OATMEAL PORRIDGE

Creamy Swedish oat porridge — slow-stirred in milk, finished with butter, and served with cold filmjök poured over, a drizzle of golden syrup, and jam. The Swedish approach to porridge is more indulgent than the Scottish — milk-based, slightly sweet, and served at every age from infancy onward.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats (large flake)
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter

FOR SERVING

- Cold filmjök or kefir, poured alongside
- 1 tbsp golden syrup (Swedish Ljus sirap) or honey
- Lingonberry jam or fresh berries
- Optional: cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine oats, milk, water, and salt in a heavy saucepan over medium heat.
2. Bring slowly to a simmer, stirring frequently.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cook 6–8 minutes, stirring often, until thick and creamy.
4. Stir in butter at the end.
5. Pour into a warm bowl.
6. Add cold filmjök poured in a ring around the edges.
7. Drizzle golden syrup in the center.
8. Add lingonberry jam or fresh berries.
9. Dust with cinnamon if desired.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

The cold filmjök poured alongside hot porridge is a Swedish tradition that seems counterintuitive but creates the perfect temperature balance for eating. The contrast — hot porridge meeting cold sour milk — is the point. Do not warm the filmjök.

[Vegetarian] [High Fiber] [Gluten-Free] [Quick]

RECIPE 123

■■ Sweden

ÄGGRÖRA PÅ KNÄCKEBRÖD

SCRAMBLED EGGS ON CRISPBREAD

Swedish-style scrambled eggs — creamy, slow-cooked with crème fraîche and dill — piled on crispy Swedish knäckebröd (crispbread) and topped with a slice of smoked salmon or pickled shrimp. Elegant, protein-rich, and ready in ten minutes.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp crème fraîche or sour cream
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- Salt and white pepper

FOR SERVING

- 4 sheets Swedish knäckebröd (Wasa or similar)
- 100g (3.5 oz) smoked salmon or pickled shrimp
- Extra dill sprigs
- Lemon wedge

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs with crème fraîche, salt, and white pepper.
2. Melt butter in a non-stick pan over very low heat.
3. Pour in egg mixture. Stir gently and continuously with a silicone spatula — small slow circles — for 5–7 minutes until soft, barely-set curds form.
4. Remove from heat while still slightly glossy. Fold in fresh dill.
5. Spoon generously onto knäckebröd.
6. Top with smoked salmon or pickled shrimp.
7. Add dill sprigs and a squeeze of lemon.
8. Eat immediately — knäckebröd softens within minutes.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Swedish crispbread (knäckebröd) goes soft very quickly once topped with moist ingredients. Assemble and eat immediately — there is no waiting.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Quick]

RECIPE 124

■■ Sweden

SMÖRGÅSTÅRTA

SWEDISH SANDWICH CAKE

A uniquely Swedish creation — a savory "cake" made from layers of crustless white bread, cream cheese, and various fillings (shrimp, egg salad, smoked salmon), frosted with cream cheese and decorated to look exactly like a dessert cake. Served at Swedish celebrations and special breakfasts. Extraordinary.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 loaf sliced white sandwich bread, crusts removed
- 200g (¾ cup) cream cheese, softened
- 100ml (⅓ cup) sour cream (for frosting)
- 150g (5 oz) smoked salmon
- 150g (5 oz) cooked shrimp
- 3 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- 1 avocado, sliced
- 4 tbsp mayonnaise
- 2 tbsp fresh dill + more for decoration
- Cucumber slices, lemon slices, caviar or roe (garnish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LAYER 1: Spread bread slices with cream cheese and mayonnaise. Arrange smoked salmon on top. Cover with another layer of bread.
2. LAYER 2: Spread cream cheese and mayonnaise. Top with sliced hard-boiled eggs and dill. Cover with bread.
3. LAYER 3: Spread cream cheese and mayonnaise. Top with shrimp and avocado slices. Cover with final bread layer.
4. FROSTING: Beat cream cheese with sour cream until smooth. Spread evenly over the entire outside of the cake — top and sides — like frosting a layer cake.
5. DECORATE: Arrange cucumber slices, lemon, shrimp, dill, and roe on top decoratively.
6. Refrigerate 2+ hours before slicing.
7. Slice like a cake to serve.

Prep: 30 min + 2 hr chilling · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~380 per slice

TIP

The smörgåstårta must be refrigerated at least 2 hours before serving — the layers need time to meld and the structure needs to firm. Make it the night before for a special breakfast occasion.

[High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Special Occasion] [Classic Swedish]

RECIPE 125

■ ■ Sweden

RÅGSURDEGSBRÖD

SWEDISH SOURDOUGH RYE BREAD

Dense, dark, slightly tangy sourdough rye bread that is the foundation of the Swedish breakfast table. Made from a live rye starter, this long-fermented loaf develops a complex, deeply satisfying flavor over days, not hours. Sliced thin, buttered, and loaded with toppings.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) dark rye flour
- 200g (1½ cups) bread flour
- 100g (½ cup) active rye sourdough starter
- 350ml (1½ cups) warm water
- 10g (2 tsp) salt
- 1 tbsp dark molasses or syrup
- 1 tbsp caraway seeds (optional)
- Vegetable oil for the pan

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine all ingredients in a large bowl. Mix thoroughly — the dough will be very wet and sticky, unlike wheat bread dough. Do not add more flour.
2. Cover and ferment at room temperature for 12–16 hours (overnight is ideal).
3. Grease a loaf pan generously.
4. Pour the bubbly, fermented dough into the pan. Smooth the surface with wet hands.
5. Cover and prove another 2–4 hours until the dough has risen slightly above the rim.
6. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F).
7. Bake 45–50 minutes until deeply dark on top and a thermometer reads 95°C (200°F) internally.
8. Remove from pan. Cool completely — minimum 8 hours — before slicing. It slices better cold.

Prep: 15 min + overnight · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 14 slices · Cal: ~155 per slice

TIP

Rye sourdough must cool completely — often overnight — before slicing. The interior continues to set as it cools. Slicing a warm rye loaf results in a gummy, unpleasant texture. Patience here is non-negotiable.

[Vegan] [High Fiber] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Swedish]

RECIPE 126

■ ■ Sweden

PEPPARKAKOR MED OST

GINGER THINS WITH CHEESE

A distinctly Swedish breakfast combination — crispy gingerbread thins (pepparkakor) eaten with sharp aged cheese. The spice of the gingerbread against the saltiness of the cheese is one of Scandinavia's most unexpected and entirely addictive flavor pairings. Common at Christmas but eaten year-round at fika.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PEPPARKAKOR

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 2 tsp ground ginger
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1 tsp ground cloves
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 150g (¾ cup) sugar
- 1 large egg
- 3 tbsp dark golden syrup or molasses
- 2 tbsp cold water

FOR SERVING

- 200g (7 oz) aged Västerbotten cheese or sharp Cheddar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat butter and sugar until light and fluffy.
2. Add egg and golden syrup. Mix well.
3. Sift flour, baking soda, and all spices over the butter mixture. Add water. Mix until a soft, smooth dough forms.
4. Wrap and refrigerate 1 hour (essential — dough needs to be firm to roll thinly).
5. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F).
6. Roll dough extremely thin — 2mm or less. Thinner cookies are crispier and better.
7. Cut into rounds or traditional shapes.
8. Bake 6–8 minutes until the edges are just beginning to darken.
9. Cool on rack — they crisp as they cool.
10. Serve with sliced aged cheese.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr chill · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 40 biscuits · Cal: ~120 per serving (5 biscuits + cheese)

TIP

The pairing of sweet-spiced gingerbread with salty aged cheese is the quintessential Swedish contrast. Västerbotten — a hard, intensely flavored Swedish cheese with a slightly granular texture — is the traditional partner. Aged Parmesan is the best substitute.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Swedish] [Seasonal]

RECIPE 127

■ ■ Sweden

SVENSKA PANNAKAKOR

SWEDISH PANCAKES

Swedish pancakes are thinner than American versions but thicker than French crêpes — rich with egg and butter, golden, and traditionally served with lingonberry jam and whipped cream. Every Swedish household makes them on Saturday mornings. A childhood ritual that extends to adulthood without apology.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs
- 400ml (1½ cups) whole milk
- 150ml (¾ cup) water
- 150g (1¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter, melted + extra for the pan

FOR SERVING

- Lingonberry jam (fresh or from a jar)
- Lightly whipped cream
- Optional: powdered sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, milk, and water together.
2. Add flour, salt, and sugar. Whisk until completely smooth with no lumps.
3. Stir in melted butter.
4. Rest batter 20 minutes at room temperature.
5. Heat a 22–24cm (9-inch) non-stick pan over medium-high heat. Add a small knob of butter.
6. Pour a ladleful of batter (about 80ml) and immediately tilt to spread into a thin, even round.
7. Cook 1.5–2 minutes until edges begin to lift and center is set. Flip.
8. Cook 45–60 seconds on the second side until pale golden patches appear.
9. Stack on a warm plate. Repeat with remaining batter.
10. Serve with lingonberry jam and whipped cream. Roll or fold as preferred.

Prep: 10 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The first pancake is the test — adjust heat and butter before proceeding. Swedish pannkakor should be pale gold, not browned. If they color too quickly, reduce heat slightly.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Swedish] [Kid-Friendly] [Weekend]

RECIPE 128

■ ■ Sweden

TOAST SKAGEN

Created by Swedish restaurateur Tore Wretman at the legendary Operakällaren in Stockholm in the 1950s — a fried bread round topped with a creamy mixture of Nordic shrimp, dill, and crème fraîche. Named after the Skagen fishing town in Denmark. Sweden's most elegant breakfast toast.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick round slices white bread, fried golden in butter
- 300g (10 oz) cooked, peeled Nordic cold-water shrimp
- 3 tbsp crème fraîche
- 2 tbsp good mayonnaise
- 2 tbsp fresh dill, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh chives, finely snipped
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Salt and white pepper

FOR GARNISH

- 4 tsp bleak roe or salmon roe (löjrom or caviar)
- Lemon wedge
- Extra dill sprigs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Fry bread rounds in generous butter over medium heat until golden and crispy on both sides. Drain briefly.
2. Combine shrimp with crème fraîche, mayonnaise, dill, chives, lemon juice, salt, and white pepper. Fold gently — do not overmix.
3. Taste and adjust seasoning. The mixture should be creamy, bright with lemon, and heavily perfumed with dill.
4. Pile the shrimp mixture generously onto warm fried bread rounds.
5. Top each with a spoonful of roe.
6. Garnish with dill sprigs and a lemon wedge.
7. Serve immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

Use Nordic cold-water shrimp — small, sweet, and intensely flavored — not the large warm-water shrimp used in other cuisines. The difference in flavor is profound. Buy them already cooked and peeled.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Classic Swedish] [Elegant]

Norway

RECIPE 129



HAVREGRØT MED BRUNOST

NORWEGIAN PORRIDGE WITH BROWN CHEESE

Norwegian oat porridge served the traditional way — with a thick slice of brunost (brown cheese) melting over the top. Brunost, made from caramelized whey, has a unique sweet-sour, fudge-like flavor that melds spectacularly with warm porridge. Norway's most distinctive breakfast combination.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats
- 500ml (2 cups) water
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- ½ tsp salt

FOR SERVING

- 4 thin slices brunost (Norwegian brown cheese — Gudbrandsdalsost brand is most traditional)
- Lingonberry jam or cloudberry jam
- Butter (optional)
- Cold whole milk, to pour alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil in a saucepan.
2. Add oats and salt. Stir and reduce heat to medium.
3. Add milk. Cook, stirring, for 6–8 minutes until thick and creamy.
4. Pour into a warm bowl.
5. Immediately lay 1–2 thin slices of brunost over the hot porridge — the heat will begin to melt it slightly.
6. Add lingonberry jam on the side.
7. Pour cold milk around the edges.
8. Eat before the brunost fully melts — the contrast of cold milk, warm porridge, and semi-melted brunost is the experience.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Brunost is unlike any other cheese in the world. Made by boiling whey until the lactose caramelizes, it has a sweet, slightly savory, fudge-like quality. Outside Norway, find it at Scandinavian specialty shops or IKEA food markets.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Norwegian] [High Fiber]

RECIPE 130



MATPAKKE

NORWEGIAN PACKED LUNCH SANDWICH

The matpakke — literally "food packet" — is Norway's most iconic breakfast and lunch tradition. Two slices of dark bread with simple open-faced toppings, wrapped in paper and carried to school or work. No refrigeration, no heating. Simple, reliable, Norwegian. Children carry matpakke until they leave home.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices Norwegian knekkebrød (crispbread)
- or dark Norwegian bread
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 4 slices Norwegian brown goat cheese (geitost)
- or brunost
- 4 slices leverpostei (liver pâté)
- 2 tbsp sweet Norwegian mustard (søt sennep)
- Sliced cucumber and radish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Butter two crispbread or bread slices lightly.
2. Lay brunost slices on one, trimmed to fit perfectly.
3. Lay leverpostei slices on the other, spread with a little sweet mustard.
4. Add cucumber and radish slices to both.
5. Wrap individually in wax paper or parchment.
6. Carry to the fjord. Eat while looking at mountains. This step is optional but recommended.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The matpakke is never refrigerated — it is eaten at room temperature within a few hours. Norwegian children carry them in a small container called a "matboks" and consider this completely normal.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Norwegian] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 131



LEFSE

NORWEGIAN POTATO FLATBREAD

Lefse — thin, soft Norwegian potato flatbreads — are cooked on a dry griddle and eaten for breakfast with butter and sugar, or with smoked salmon and cream cheese. A Norwegian culinary tradition that Norwegian-Americans carry with fierce pride to Midwestern Christmas tables.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) floury potatoes, boiled and riced
- (or mashed very smoothly while hot)
- 150g (1¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 2 tbsp heavy cream
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp sugar

FOR SERVING

- Salted butter
- White sugar or cinnamon sugar
- OR: smoked salmon + cream cheese + dill

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rice potatoes while still hot (or mash very smoothly). Spread on a tray to steam off excess moisture. Cool to room temperature — this step is critical.
2. Combine cooled potato with melted butter, cream, salt, and sugar. Mix well.
3. Gradually add flour, mixing until a soft, workable dough forms. Add only as much flour as needed to prevent sticking.
4. Divide into 12 balls. Keep covered with a cloth.
5. On a generously floured surface, roll each ball paper-thin — 2–3mm maximum. Use a special grooved lefse rolling pin if available.
6. Heat a dry griddle or large pan over medium-high heat — no oil, no butter.
7. Cook lefse 1–2 minutes per side until pale brown spots appear. They cook very quickly.
8. Stack under a damp towel to keep soft.
9. Serve immediately with butter and sugar, or roll around salmon and cream cheese.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~170 per lefse

TIP

Cold potatoes are critical — hot potatoes absorb too much flour and the lefse becomes heavy. Rice the potatoes the night before and refrigerate. The flour ratio should be as low as possible while still being rollable.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Norwegian]

RECIPE 132

■■ Norway

RØMMEGRØT

NORWEGIAN SOUR CREAM PORRIDGE

Rømmegrøt is Norway's most celebrated traditional porridge — made entirely from sour cream (rømme) and flour, which release their own butter as they cook. Thick, rich, and intensely tangy, it is served with cinnamon, sugar, and a drizzle of the extracted butter. Eaten at celebrations and considered Norway's finest comfort food.

INGREDIENTS

- 500ml (2 cups) full-fat Norwegian rømme or
- very thick sour cream (35%+ fat)
- 150ml (⅔ cup) whole milk
- 80g (⅓ cup) all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt

FOR SERVING

- Ground cinnamon
- Sugar
- The extracted butter (it separates during cooking)
- Optional: lingonberry jam

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pour rømme into a heavy-bottomed saucepan. Bring to a simmer over medium heat, stirring.
2. Add flour in two additions, stirring vigorously each time. The porridge will become very thick.
3. Continue stirring and cooking — after 5–8 minutes butter will begin to pool on the surface and sides. This is exactly right. Spoon the butter off and set aside in a small bowl.
4. Add warm milk gradually, stirring, until the porridge is smooth and creamy.
5. Cook 3–5 more minutes. Season with salt.
6. Serve in bowls. Drizzle the reserved melted butter over the top. Dust generously with cinnamon and sugar.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

This recipe requires full-fat, very thick sour cream — 35% fat minimum. Standard supermarket sour cream (18–20% fat) will not release enough butter and the texture will be wrong. This is a dish that cannot be made lighter without becoming something else.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Norwegian] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 133

■■ Norway

GRAVLAKS MED SENNEPSSAUS

NORWEGIAN CURED SALMON WITH MUSTARD SAUCE

Norwegian gravlaks — salt-and-dill cured salmon — served with a sweet mustard-dill sauce on dark rye bread or toasted lefse. The Norwegian method uses less sugar than Swedish gravlax, producing a more salt-forward, pure salmon flavor. A breakfast fit for a Viking chief.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE GRAVLAKS

- 600g (21 oz) very fresh center-cut salmon, skin on
- 3 tbsp coarse sea salt
- 1.5 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp white pepper, coarsely ground
- 1 tbsp aquavit or vodka (optional)
- Large bunch fresh dill
- MUSTARD SAUCE (Sennepssaus):
- 3 tbsp Norwegian mustard or whole grain mustard
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar
- 100ml (■ cup) neutral oil
- 4 tbsp fresh dill, finely chopped
- Salt and white pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CURE SALMON: Mix salt, sugar, pepper, and aquavit. Lay half the dill in a deep dish. Place salmon on top flesh-side up. Pack salt mixture over the flesh. Cover with remaining dill. Wrap tightly in plastic.
2. Refrigerate 36–48 hours, turning once at 18 hours. It is ready when the flesh firms noticeably.
3. Scrape off the cure. Pat dry. Slice paper-thin on a diagonal, away from the skin.
4. SAUCE: Whisk mustard, sugar, and vinegar. Drizzle in oil while whisking. Fold in dill. Season with salt and white pepper.
5. SERVE: Arrange gravlaks on dark rye or crispbread. Drizzle sauce over. Garnish with extra dill.

Prep: 15 min + 36-48 hrs curing · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The quality of the salmon determines everything. Use the freshest possible salmon — ideally sashimi grade. The curing process does not cook the fish; it preserves it through salt and acid. Fresh fish is a safety priority.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Norwegian]

RECIPE 134

■■ Norway

SVELE

NORWEGIAN THICK PANCAKES

Svele are thick, puffy Norwegian pancakes made with sour cream (or kefir) for a distinctive tang — thicker than a crêpe but softer than an American pancake. Eaten warm with butter and brunost, they are a western Norwegian coastal specialty sold from ferries and fish markets.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs
- 300ml (1¼ cups) kefir or sour cream
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp butter, melted
- Butter and brunost (brown cheese) for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, kefir, and milk together.
2. Add flour, sugar, baking soda, baking powder, salt, and melted butter. Whisk until just smooth. Do not overmix.
3. Rest batter 5 minutes.
4. Heat a flat griddle or non-stick pan over medium heat. Add a small amount of butter.
5. Pour batter in small amounts — svele are about 12cm (5 inches) in diameter and notably thick.
6. Cook until bubbles form and edges look set, about 3–4 minutes.
7. Flip carefully. Cook 2–3 minutes on the second side.
8. Serve warm with a slice of cold butter placed on top (it melts in), and thin slices of brunost.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The baking soda reacts with the kefir to create the airy, slightly tangy crumb that defines svele. Using regular milk instead of kefir produces a noticeably blander pancake. The sourness is integral.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Norwegian] [Quick] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 135

■■ Norway

FISKEBOLLER PÅ BRØD

NORWEGIAN FISH BALLS ON BREAD

Fiskeboller — tender Norwegian fish balls in a light cream sauce — served on open dark bread for breakfast. Beloved by Norwegian children and adults alike, canned fiskeboller are a Norwegian pantry staple. Made from scratch, they are extraordinary. Either way, this is a uniquely Norwegian morning.

INGREDIENTS

FOR HOMEMADE FISKEBOLLER

- 400g (14 oz) fresh cod or pollock, minced
- 2 eggs
- 100ml (■ cup) heavy cream
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- 1 tsp salt
- White pepper and nutmeg
- Poaching broth: water + vegetable stock

FOR THE CREAM SAUCE

- 2 tbsp butter
- 2 tbsp flour
- 300ml (1¼ cups) fish or vegetable broth
- 100ml (■ cup) cream
- Salt, white pepper, nutmeg

FOR SERVING

- 4 thick slices dark Norwegian bread, buttered

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FISH BALLS: Blend minced fish with eggs, cream, cornstarch, salt, pepper, and nutmeg until smooth.
2. Bring broth to a gentle simmer. Form fish mixture into rounded balls using two wet spoons.
3. Poach in simmering broth 6–8 minutes until firm and cooked through. Do not boil — gentle simmering only.
4. SAUCE: Melt butter, add flour, stir 1 minute. Add warm broth gradually. Cook until smooth and thick. Add cream. Season with salt, pepper, nutmeg.
5. Add fish balls to the sauce.
6. Serve over buttered dark bread in a deep bowl.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

The fish mixture must be very cold when formed. If it becomes warm and sticky, refrigerate the bowl for 10 minutes before continuing. Cold mixture holds its shape better during poaching.

[High Protein] [Classic Norwegian] [Gluten-Free option]

RECIPE 136

■■ Norway

SOLBÆRSAFT OG

The Norwegian childhood breakfast — a glass of cold blackcurrant juice diluted with water alongside knäckebröd spread with soft prim (a spreadable whey cheese similar to brunost but softer). Simple, nostalgic, and completely representative of everyday Norwegian morning culture.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 sheets knekkebrød (Norwegian crispbread)
- 4 tbsp prim (soft spreadable whey cheese) or
- soft brunost/cream cheese mixed with brown sugar
- 2 tbsp soft salted butter

FOR THE JUICE

- 4 tbsp concentrated blackcurrant syrup
- (Norwegian Solbær saft)
- 400ml (1½ cups) cold water
- Ice cubes (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spread each crispbread with soft butter, then a generous layer of prim.
2. Dilute blackcurrant syrup with cold water. Adjust to taste — Norwegian versions are intensely purple and quite sweet.
3. Pour into glasses over ice.
4. Serve crispbread and juice together.
5. Eat while listening to the rain. In Norway, this is most mornings.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

Prim — soft, spreadable whey cheese — is sweeter and softer than brunost. It can be found at Scandinavian specialty stores or made by cooking whey with a little sugar until it reaches a spreadable consistency. Nutella on crispbread is the Norwegian children's acceptable alternative.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic Norwegian] [Kid-Friendly]

Denmark

RECIPE 137

■ ■ Denmark

WIENERBRØD

DANISH PASTRY

The original "Danish" — laminated yeast dough with 27 or more butter layers, shaped into spirals, pinwheels, and envelopes, filled with remonce (almond butter cream), custard, or jam. Danish bakers are among the world's most technically skilled pastry makers, and Wienerbrød is their masterpiece.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 50g (¼ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp ground cardamom
- 250ml (1 cup) cold whole milk
- 1 large egg

FOR LAMINATION

- 250g (1 cup + 2 tbsp) cold unsalted butter,
- beaten into a flat square

FOR REMONCE FILLING

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 100g (1 cup) ground almonds
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 egg

FOR FINISHING

- 1 egg + 1 tbsp milk (egg wash)
- Pearl sugar or icing sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make dough: combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, cardamom, cold milk, and egg. Knead briefly — just until smooth. Do not overdevelop gluten. Refrigerate overnight wrapped tightly.
2. Cold lamination: pound cold butter into a 20cm square. Enclose in the chilled dough.
3. Perform 4 letter folds, refrigerating 30 minutes between each. Work quickly — keep cold.
4. Make remonce: beat soft butter, ground almonds, sugar, and egg until smooth.
5. Roll dough to 5mm thick. Cut into 10cm squares.
6. Place a spoonful of remonce in the center of each. Fold in two opposite corners to overlap in the center, pressing firmly (Danish spandauer shape). OR: cut strips, spread remonce, roll into spirals.
7. Prove on trays 45–60 minutes until puffed.
8. Brush with egg wash. Bake 200°C (390°F) for 14–16 minutes until deep golden.
9. Cool slightly. Dust with icing sugar or drizzle glaze.

Prep: 40 min + overnight · Cook: 16 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~340 per pastry

TIP

Danish lamination requires discipline with cold. The moment butter begins to break through the dough or feels soft, stop and refrigerate immediately. Warm butter absorbed into the dough means no layers.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Danish] [Weekend Project] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 138

■ ■ Denmark

SMØRREBRØD MED LEVERPOSTEJ

DANISH OPEN SANDWICH WITH LIVER PÂTÉ

Smørrebrød — buttered dark rye bread with toppings — is Denmark's greatest culinary contribution. The leverpostej (liver pâté) version is Denmark's most commonly eaten open sandwich: rich, dark pâté on cold butter on rugbrød (sourdough rye), topped with crispy bacon and sautéed mushrooms.

INGREDIENTS

FOR QUICK LEVERPOSTEJ

- 300g (10 oz) chicken livers
- 1 onion, diced
- 3 anchovy fillets
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1 tsp thyme
- 1 tsp allspice
- 100ml (¼ cup) cream
- Salt and pepper
- FOR THE SMØRREBRØD:
- 4 slices Danish rugbrød (dark sourdough rye)
- 3 tbsp cold salted butter
- 4 strips crispy bacon
- 4 button mushrooms, sautéed in butter
- Fresh thyme leaves
- Sliced cornichon pickles

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LEVERPOSTEJ: Sauté onion in butter until soft. Add chicken livers and anchovies. Cook 5–6 minutes. Add thyme, allspice, cream. Blend until very smooth. Season well. Pour into a mold. Refrigerate 4+ hours.
2. SMØRREBRØD: Spread cold butter on rugbrød, pressing firmly to every edge.
3. Spread a generous, thick layer of cold leverpostej over the butter.
4. Top with sautéed mushrooms and crispy bacon.
5. Garnish with fresh thyme and sliced cornichons.
6. Eat with a knife and fork. Never with your hands.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hr chilling · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~390 per smørrebrød

TIP

In Denmark, smørrebrød is not convenience food — it is a carefully constructed dish eaten at a table with cutlery. The toppings must be arranged attractively and precisely. Danish food culture takes this seriously.

[High Protein] [Classic Danish] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 139

■ ■ Denmark

ÆGGEKAGE

DANISH THICK OMELETTE

Æggekage is the Danish version of a thick, set omelette — cooked in an oven rather than on a stovetop, producing a puffed, souffle-like result topped with chives, tomatoes, and crispy bacon. Eaten directly from the pan at the breakfast table, sliced into wedges. Homely, generous, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 3 tbsp whole milk
- 1 tbsp all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- White pepper
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter

TOPPINGS

- 6 slices streaky bacon, cooked until crispy
- 2 small tomatoes, sliced
- 3 tbsp fresh chives, chopped
- Salt and pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F).
2. Whisk eggs, milk, flour, salt, and white pepper until smooth and slightly aerated.
3. Melt butter in a 25cm (10-inch) ovenproof skillet over medium heat until foaming.
4. Pour in egg mixture. Cook on the stovetop 2–3 minutes until the edges begin to set.
5. Transfer pan to the oven. Bake 8–10 minutes until puffed, golden on top, and set throughout. It will deflate slightly when removed.
6. Immediately top with crispy bacon, tomato slices, and chives.
7. Season with salt and pepper.
8. Serve directly from the pan, sliced into wedges.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The flour in the egg mixture is a Danish touch that gives æggekage more body and structure than a regular omelette — it holds together when sliced and eaten with a fork. Do not omit it.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Danish]

RECIPE 140

■ ■ Denmark

RUGBRØD MED MAKREL

DARK RYE WITH SMOKED MACKEREL

One of Denmark's most iconic smørrebrød combinations — dark sourdough rye bread with smoked mackerel, creamy horseradish, sliced radish, lemon, and dill. The mackerel's richness against the sour rye and sharp horseradish is a triumphant flavor combination that Danes eat for breakfast with great frequency.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices dark Danish rugbrød
- 4 tbsp cold salted butter
- 2 smoked mackerel fillets, flaked into large pieces
- 2 tbsp fresh horseradish, grated (or prepared horseradish)
- 2 tbsp crème fraîche
- 6 radishes, thinly sliced
- Fresh dill
- 1 lemon, sliced into wedges
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Butter each slice of rugbrød cold and generously.
2. Mix horseradish with crème fraîche into a creamy sauce.
3. Spread horseradish cream over the butter.
4. Arrange flaked smoked mackerel attractively over the horseradish cream.
5. Add radish slices and fresh dill.
6. Season with black pepper.
7. Serve with lemon wedges for squeezing.
8. Eat with a knife and fork.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per smørrebrød

TIP

Fresh horseradish is dramatically more potent than the prepared version in jars. If you can find fresh horseradish root, grate it finely and use immediately — the heat fades within hours of grating.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Danish]

RECIPE 141

■ ■ Denmark

ØLLEBRØD

DANISH BEER BREAD PORRIDGE

Øllebrød — literally "beer bread" — is one of Denmark's most ancient breakfast foods. Dark rye bread soaked in dark Danish ale until completely soft, then cooked into a thick, malt-scented porridge, sweetened with sugar and served with cold cream. A dish from the working-class Danish tradition that is deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) stale dark rye bread, torn into pieces
- 400ml (1½ cups) Danish dark ale or stout
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 3 tbsp sugar or dark syrup (mørk sirup)
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FOR SERVING

- 200ml (¾ cup) cold heavy cream or whipped cream
- Optional: a pinch of cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine torn rye bread, ale, and water in a saucepan. Leave to soak for 20–30 minutes until bread is completely softened and has absorbed the ale.
2. Bring to a simmer over medium heat, stirring. Cook, stirring frequently, for 10–12 minutes until the mixture is a thick, uniform porridge. Add more water if it becomes too thick.
3. Stir in sugar, lemon zest, and vanilla.
4. Taste — it should be malty, slightly bitter from the ale, gently sweet, and deep in flavor.
5. Serve in warm bowls with cold cream poured over or lightly whipped cream on top.

Prep: 5 min + 30 min soaking · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Use a good dark Danish ale or stout — the quality of the beer directly determines the quality of the porridge. A thin, flavorless beer produces a thin, flavorless øllebrød. Invest in a good bottle.

[Vegan option] [Classic Danish] [Budget-Friendly] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 142

■ ■ Denmark

MORGENBRØD

DANISH MORNING ROLLS

Fresh Danish breakfast rolls — softer than French rolls, slightly enriched with butter, scored across the top. Bought every morning from the Danish bakeri and eaten with butter and jam or various toppings. The Danes take their bread rolls as seriously as anyone in Europe.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) strong bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- Optional: sesame or poppy seeds for topping

FOR SERVING

- Salted butter
- Strawberry or rhubarb jam
- Sliced cheese

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and knead 5 minutes. Add softened butter. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide into 10 pieces. Shape each into a smooth ball.
4. Flatten slightly into an oval shape.
5. Place on lined baking trays.
6. Score a deep line down the center of each roll. Brush with water. Sprinkle seeds if using.
7. Prove 30 minutes.
8. Bake at 220°C (430°F) for 15–18 minutes until golden and the base sounds hollow when tapped.
9. Cool 10 minutes before eating.
10. Serve with butter, jam, and sliced cheese.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~205 per roll with butter

TIP

The deep center score on a Danish morgenbrød is a signature — it creates the characteristic split when baked, giving the roll its traditional Danish shape. Score deeply and confidently with a sharp blade.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Danish] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 143

■ ■ Denmark

GRØD MED ÆBLE OG KANEL

DANISH APPLE CINNAMON PORRIDGE

The Copenhagen porridge movement — spearheaded by the restaurant Grød — elevated simple oat porridge to an art form. This version, simmered with apple juice instead of water, topped with stewed apple and toasted seeds, represents the modern Danish approach to ancient morning food.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats
- 300ml (1¼ cups) fresh apple juice
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FOR TOPPINGS

- 2 apples, peeled, diced, cooked with 1 tbsp butter,
- 1 tsp cinnamon, 1 tbsp sugar (stewed apples)
- 2 tbsp toasted pumpkin seeds
- 1 tbsp sunflower seeds
- Drizzle of dark honey or apple balsamic syrup
- Pinch of cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine oats, apple juice, milk, salt, and vanilla in a saucepan over medium heat.
2. Bring to a simmer while stirring. Reduce heat to low.
3. Cook 6–8 minutes, stirring frequently, until thick and creamy. The apple juice creates a naturally sweeter, more complex flavor than water alone.
4. Make stewed apples: cook diced apple in butter, cinnamon, and sugar over medium heat 8 minutes until tender and caramelized.
5. Pour porridge into bowls. Top with stewed apple.
6. Scatter pumpkin and sunflower seeds.
7. Drizzle honey. Dust with cinnamon.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Apple juice instead of water changes this porridge fundamentally — it adds a natural sweetness and slight acidity that eliminates the need for much added sugar. Use freshly pressed juice if possible.

[Vegan] [High Fiber] [Gluten-Free] [Modern Danish]

RECIPE 144

■ ■ Denmark

ÆBLESKIVER

DANISH PANCAKE BALLS

Æbleskiver — "apple slices" — are spherical Danish pancakes cooked in a specially designed cast-iron pan, fluffy inside and golden outside. Originally made with apple inside (hence the name), they are now most often served plain with powdered sugar and strawberry jam. A Christmas tradition and beloved weekend breakfast throughout Denmark.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- 3 large eggs, separated
- 400ml (1■ cups) buttermilk
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Butter for the pan

FOR SERVING

- Icing (powdered) sugar
- Strawberry or raspberry jam

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk flour, baking powder, baking soda, sugar, salt, and cardamom together.
2. In a separate bowl, whisk egg yolks, buttermilk, melted butter, and vanilla.
3. Add wet ingredients to dry. Stir until just combined.
4. Whip egg whites to firm peaks. Gently fold into batter in two additions. The batter will be airy and light.
5. Heat an æbleskiver pan over medium heat. Add a small knob of butter to each depression.
6. Fill each depression ¾ full with batter.
7. As the edges set and the bottom is golden (about 2 minutes), use a wooden skewer or knitting needle to rotate each pancake 90°.
8. Continue cooking, rotating as needed, until a complete golden sphere has formed — about 4–5 minutes total.
9. Remove. Dust with icing sugar immediately. Serve with jam for dipping.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 24 balls · Cal: ~80 per ball

TIP

An æbleskiver pan is essential — the round depressions create the spherical shape impossible to achieve in a regular pan. They are available online and at kitchen stores. Once you have one, you will use it constantly.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Danish] [Kid-Friendly] [Seasonal]

RECIPE 145

■ ■ Denmark

FRANSKBRØD MED KAVIAR

WHITE BREAD WITH DANISH CAVIAR SPREAD

A beloved Danish breakfast — toasted franskbrød (white bread) spread thickly with Danish kaviar (a mild, slightly smoky smoked cod roe paste sold in tubes), topped with sliced hard-boiled egg and fresh chives. A distinctly Danish combination that is served at Danish breakfast tables daily.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices white Danish franskbrød or brioche
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter
- 4 tbsp Danish kaviar (tube cod roe paste)
- or other smoked roe paste
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, finely snipped
- Lemon wedge
- White pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast bread until golden and crispy.
2. Spread butter generously while still hot.
3. Spread a thick layer of Danish kaviar over the butter — do not be sparing.
4. Arrange hard-boiled egg slices over the kaviar.
5. Scatter fresh chives generously.
6. Add a squeeze of lemon and white pepper.
7. Eat immediately while toast is still warm.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Danish kaviar in a tube is a pantry staple in Denmark — milder and smokier than traditional caviar. Kalles Kaviar (Swedish, but equally popular in Denmark) is the most widely available version outside Scandinavia.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Danish]

Finland

RECIPE 146

■■ Finland

RUISPUURO

FINNISH RYE PORRIDGE

Finland's most traditional breakfast — a thick, dark, earthy porridge made from whole rye grains or cracked rye, cooked slowly in water until smooth. Deeply nourishing, slightly sour from the rye, and eaten with a knob of cold butter and cold milk. Finnish simplicity at its most profound.

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (1 cup) cracked rye or rye flakes
- (not rye flour — the whole grain or cracked form)
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- ½ tsp salt

FOR SERVING

- 2 tbsp cold unsalted butter
- Cold whole milk
- Lingonberry jam or cloudberry jam
- Optional: pinch of cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil in a heavy saucepan.
2. Add cracked rye and salt. Stir well.
3. Reduce heat to very low. Cover with a lid.
4. Cook 20–25 minutes, stirring every 5 minutes, until rye is tender and the porridge is thick. If using whole rye grains, soaking overnight first is strongly recommended.
5. The porridge should be thick, dense, and slightly sticky — not thin and soupy.
6. Pour into bowls. Make a well in the center.
7. Add cold butter to the well — it melts slowly.
8. Pour cold milk around the edges.
9. Add a spoonful of lingonberry jam.

Prep: 2 min (+ overnight soak if using whole rye) · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Cracked rye produces a porridge with more texture than rye flakes. Rye flakes cook faster but create a smoother result. Both are correct — choose based on time available and texture preference.

[Vegan] [High Fiber] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Finnish]

RECIPE 147

■■ Finland

KARJALANPIIRAKKA

KARELIAN PASTIES

Finland's most famous food — thin, oval rye pastry shells filled with a creamy rice porridge, crimped with distinctive pleated edges, and served warm with munavoi (egg butter). Born in the Karelia region and now eaten across Finland, these are among the most distinctive pastries in northern European cooking.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE RYE PASTRY

- 200g (1■ cups) dark rye flour
- 100ml (■ cup) cold water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vegetable oil

FOR THE RICE FILLING

- 100g (½ cup) short-grain rice
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp butter
- FOR EGG BUTTER (Munavoi):
- 3 hard-boiled eggs, finely chopped
- 80g (6 tbsp) salted butter, softened
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Cook rice in milk with salt, stirring frequently, 20–25 minutes until very thick (thicker than rice pudding). Stir in butter. Cool completely.
2. MUNAVOI: Mix finely chopped hard-boiled eggs with softened butter and salt until combined. Refrigerate until needed.
3. PASTRY: Mix rye flour, water, salt, and oil into a stiff dough. Do not rest — work quickly.
4. Divide dough into 12 balls. Roll each very thin (2mm) into an oval shape.
5. Place 2 tbsp of cold rice filling in the center.
6. Fold long edges up and over the filling. Crimp edges firmly with your fingers to create the characteristic pleated border.
7. Place on lined trays. Brush with butter-milk mixture (equal parts melted butter and milk).
8. Bake at 250°C (480°F) for 12–15 minutes until edges are crispy and golden.
9. Brush again with butter-milk immediately from oven.
10. Serve warm with egg butter spread over the top.

Prep: 45 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~190 per pastry

TIP

The rye pastry dries and cracks extremely quickly when exposed to air. Keep unused dough covered with a damp cloth at all times. Work one pastry at a time and keep others completely covered.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Finnish] [Make-Ahead] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 148

■■ Finland

PANNUKAKKU

FINNISH OVEN PANCAKE

Pannukakku is Finland's beloved oven-baked pancake — poured into a buttered pan and baked until puffed and golden, with a custardy center and crispy edges. Different from all other pancakes, it is sliced into squares and served with jam and whipped cream. Every Finnish family has a cast-iron pan reserved for pannukakku.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 500ml (2 cups) whole milk
- 150g (1¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 50g (3.5 tbsp) unsalted butter (for the pan)

FOR SERVING

- Lingonberry jam or strawberry jam
- Lightly whipped cream
- Powdered sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 225°C (435°F).
2. Whisk eggs, milk, flour, sugar, salt, and vanilla until completely smooth. Let rest 10 minutes.
3. Place a 30x20cm (12x8-inch) baking dish or cast-iron pan in the hot oven for 5 minutes.
4. Add butter to the hot pan — it should melt and sizzle immediately.
5. Pour the batter over the melted butter all at once.
6. Return to oven immediately.
7. Bake 20–25 minutes until puffed, deep golden, and slightly crispy at the edges.
8. It will deflate immediately upon removal — this is completely normal.
9. Cut into squares. Serve with jam and cream. Add powdered sugar if desired.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

The hot pan and melted butter before adding batter are essential — they create the crispy edges and prevent sticking. Do not add butter to a cold pan. The sizzle when the batter hits the butter is the beginning of a perfect pannukakku.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Finnish] [Kid-Friendly] [Weekend]

RECIPE 149

■■ Finland

MUSTIKKAPUURO

FINNISH BLUEBERRY PORRIDGE

Mustikkapuuro — a vibrantly purple Finnish porridge made from semolina and fresh or frozen wild blueberries. One of Finland's most beautiful breakfast dishes, it turns the color of a Nordic summer sky and tastes like the forest. Eaten with cold milk poured over — the purple-white contrast is magnificent.

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (2 cups) fresh or frozen wild blueberries
- 700ml (3 cups) water
- 80g (½ cup) fine semolina
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt

FOR SERVING

- Cold whole milk
- Optional: extra fresh blueberries on top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine blueberries and water in a saucepan. Bring to a boil. Cook 5 minutes until blueberries burst and release their juice.
2. The water will turn a stunning deep purple.
3. Using an immersion blender, blend the blueberries and liquid until smooth.
4. Return to heat. Add sugar and salt. Bring to a simmer.
5. Pour semolina in a slow, steady stream while whisking constantly to prevent lumps.
6. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring, for 5 minutes until thick and creamy.
7. Pour into bowls.
8. Immediately pour cold milk around the edges — the temperature and color contrast is the presentation.
9. Add extra fresh blueberries on top.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

Wild Finnish blueberries are much smaller, more intensely flavored, and more purple than cultivated blueberries — if you can find them (frozen is perfect), use them. The color and flavor are incomparable.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Finnish] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 150

■■ Finland

KAHVI JA PULLA

FINNISH COFFEE AND CARDAMOM BUN

Finnish pulla — light, cardamom-scented sweet buns braided or formed into knots — is the centerpiece of Finnish coffee culture. Finland drinks more coffee per person than any other country, and pulla is the eternal companion. The cardamom in Finnish pulla is more restrained than Swedish kanelbullar — aromatic, delicate, and incomparably comforting.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp ground cardamom
- ½ tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm whole milk
- 2 large eggs (1 for dough, 1 for egg wash)
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- Pearl sugar for topping
- Sliced almonds (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, cardamom, and salt. Add warm milk and 1 egg. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth, elastic, and pulls from bowl.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide dough into 12 portions.
4. FOR KNOTS: Roll each piece into a 40cm rope. Tie into a loose knot and tuck ends under.
5. FOR BRAID: Divide into thirds. Roll three long ropes. Braid together. Pinch and tuck ends.
6. Place on lined trays. Prove 30–45 minutes.
7. Brush with beaten egg wash.
8. Scatter pearl sugar and sliced almonds generously.
9. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 12–15 minutes until golden. Do not overbake — they dry quickly.
10. Serve warm with strong black Finnish coffee.

Prep: 25 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~230 per pulla

TIP

Finnish pulla should be light, airy, and pillowy — not heavy or dense. If yours is dense, the butter was added too early (before enough gluten developed) or the dough was not kneaded long enough.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Finnish] [Make-Ahead] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 151

■■ Finland

RAHKA JA MARJAT

FINNISH QUARK WITH WILD BERRIES

Rahka — Finnish fresh quark — eaten with fresh wild berries and a drizzle of honey is one of the most refreshing and simple Finnish breakfasts. Rahka is smoother and less tangy than German Quark, with a texture between yogurt and cream cheese. Paired with Arctic cloudberry, it is sublime.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) Finnish rahka or fresh quark
- (substitute: strained Greek yogurt mixed with a little cream cheese)
- 2 tbsp honey or cloudberry jam
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 200g (1½ cups) fresh wild berries: cloudberry, lingonberry, bilberry, or regular blueberry and raspberry
- 2 tbsp granola or crushed digestive biscuits

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Stir rahka with honey and vanilla until smooth and slightly lightened.
2. Divide into two bowls.
3. Top generously with fresh wild berries.
4. Scatter granola or crushed biscuits for crunch.
5. Add an extra drizzle of honey.
6. Serve immediately with strong black coffee.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~260 per serving

TIP

Cloudberry (lakka in Finnish) are the Arctic gold of Finnish cuisine — tart, intensely aromatic, and only available in late summer or frozen year-round. They are worth every effort to find. Their unique flavor makes this dish extraordinary.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Finnish]

RECIPE 152

■■ Finland

LOHIKEITTO AAMULLA

FINNISH SALMON SOUP FOR BREAKFAST

Lohikeitto — Finland's celebrated creamy salmon soup — is traditionally served at lunch, but in fishing communities along Finland's vast coastline and lake systems, a bowl of this silky, dill-scented salmon chowder with potatoes and cream is an entirely acceptable and deeply warming breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) fresh salmon fillet, cut into chunks
- 4 medium potatoes, peeled and diced
- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 medium carrots, sliced
- 1L (4 cups) fish or vegetable broth
- 200ml (¾ cup) heavy cream
- 3 tbsp butter
- 3 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 2 bay leaves
- Salt and white pepper
- Crusty bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Melt butter in a large pot over medium heat. Add onion and cook 5 minutes until soft.
2. Add carrots and potatoes. Stir to coat in butter.
3. Add broth and bay leaves. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat. Simmer 12–15 minutes until potatoes are just tender.
5. Remove bay leaves. Reduce heat to very low.
6. Add cream. Stir gently.
7. Add salmon chunks. Cook very gently 5–6 minutes until salmon is just cooked through — it should be barely opaque and tender, not overcooked.
8. Season generously with salt and white pepper.
9. Stir in fresh dill.
10. Serve in deep bowls with crusty bread.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~410 per serving

TIP

Add the salmon at the very end and cook it gently — overcooked salmon becomes chalky and falls apart into the soup. It should be barely cooked through, remaining in large, tender pieces.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Finnish] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 153

■■ Finland

MYSLI JA JOGURTTI

FINNISH MUESLI WITH YOGURT

A simple Finnish breakfast bowl — homemade toasted muesli over thick natural yogurt with fresh berries and a spoonful of cloudberry or lingonberry jam. The Finnish approach to the breakfast bowl is understated but deeply nourishing.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE MUESLI

- 200g (2 cups) rolled oats
- 50g (½ cup) rye flakes
- 50g (¼ cup) sunflower seeds
- 50g (¼ cup) pumpkin seeds
- 50g (½ cup) hazelnuts, roughly chopped
- 2 tbsp maple syrup or honey
- 2 tbsp coconut oil, melted
- Pinch of salt

FOR THE BOWL

- 300g (1¼ cups) natural full-fat yogurt or rahka
- 150g (1 cup) fresh or frozen wild berries
- 1 tbsp cloudberry or lingonberry jam
- Drizzle of honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 160°C (320°F).
2. Toss oats, rye flakes, seeds, and nuts with maple syrup, coconut oil, and salt.
3. Spread on a lined baking sheet. Bake 20–25 minutes, stirring halfway through, until golden.
4. Cool completely — muesli crisps as it cools.
5. Store in an airtight container up to 3 weeks.
6. BOWL: Spoon yogurt into a bowl.
7. Scatter muesli generously over the top.
8. Add fresh berries and a spoonful of jam.
9. Drizzle with honey.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 8 (muesli) · Cal: ~320 per serving (with yogurt)

TIP

Rye flakes in the muesli add a distinctly Nordic character — slightly earthy, more fibrous than oats alone. They are widely available in health food stores and worth seeking out.

[Vegetarian] [High Fiber] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Finnish]

Russia

RECIPE 154

■■ Russia

SYRNIKI

RUSSIAN COTTAGE CHEESE PANCAKES

Syrniki are Russia's most beloved breakfast — golden, crispy- edged cottage cheese pancakes with a tender, creamy interior. Made from tvorog (Russian farmer's cheese), they are pan-fried and served with cold sour cream and jam. Every Russian grandmother makes them slightly differently. Every version is the right one.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (2¼ cups) tvorog or well-drained ricotta
- (dry cottage cheese works well too)
- 2 large eggs
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp lemon zest
- 5 tbsp all-purpose flour + extra for shaping
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter + 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- (for frying)

FOR SERVING

- Cold smetana (Russian sour cream) or crème fraîche
- Strawberry jam or cherry jam
- Fresh berries (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If tvorog or ricotta has excess liquid, drain overnight in a fine sieve lined with cheesecloth. Dry cheese produces the best syrniki.
2. In a bowl, mix drained cheese with eggs, sugar, vanilla, and lemon zest until smooth.
3. Add flour and salt. Mix until just combined — the dough will be soft and slightly sticky.
4. Flour your hands generously. Take a heaped tablespoon of dough, roll into a ball, and flatten gently into a disc about 1.5cm thick. Coat lightly with flour on both sides.
5. Heat butter and oil in a non-stick skillet over medium-low heat.
6. Fry syrniki 4–5 minutes per side until deep golden and cooked through. Resist the urge to rush — medium-low heat ensures the inside cooks fully.
7. Serve immediately with cold sour cream and jam.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The drier the cheese, the better the syrniki. Wet cheese makes sticky, shapeless dough that falls apart in the pan. Drain overnight if in doubt. The flour should be the minimum needed to bind — too much flour makes dense, heavy syrniki.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Classic Russian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 155

■■ Russia

BLINI S IKROI I SMETANOI

BUCKWHEAT BLINI WITH CAVIAR

Russia's most celebrated breakfast — yeasted buckwheat blini, thin and slightly tangy, topped with cold smetana (sour cream) and black caviar or red salmon roe. The ritual of blini with caviar dates to ancient Slavic sun festivals. In Russia, no celebration begins without them.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE BLINI

- 150g (1¼ cups) buckwheat flour
- 100g (¾ cup) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 500ml (2 cups) warm whole milk
- 2 large eggs, separated
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 tbsp melted unsalted butter

FOR SERVING

- 200g (¾ cup) cold smetana or crème fraîche
- 100g (3.5 oz) black caviar or red salmon roe
- Optional: fresh dill sprigs, sliced green onion

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix buckwheat flour, all-purpose flour, yeast, and sugar in a large bowl. Make a well in the center.
2. Add warm milk and egg yolks. Whisk until smooth.
3. Cover with a towel and prove in a warm place 1–1.5 hours until bubbly and doubled.
4. Stir in salt and melted butter.
5. Whip egg whites to firm peaks. Fold gently into the batter. This gives blini their characteristic lightness.
6. Rest batter 15 minutes after adding whites.
7. Heat a small, lightly buttered pan (15cm) over medium heat. Pour a small ladleful of batter — blini should be about 12cm diameter and thin.
8. Cook 1.5–2 minutes until bubbles form and the surface is mostly set. Flip. Cook 30 seconds more.
9. Stack on a warm plate. Keep covered.
10. Serve with cold smetana and caviar on the side — let guests top their own.

Prep: 15 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving (without caviar)

TIP

Folded egg whites are the secret to airy blini. Many shortcuts skip them — don't. The difference between blini made with and without whipped whites is the difference between very good and extraordinary.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Russian] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 156

■■ Russia

KASHA GRECHNEVAYA

BUCKWHEAT PORRIDGE

Buckwheat kasha is the cornerstone of the Russian breakfast — whole toasted buckwheat grains cooked in water until fluffy and tender, finished with butter. Nutty, earthy, deeply nourishing, and eaten since the 9th century. Russians eat kasha at every age, in every region, in every season.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1 cup) toasted buckwheat groats (grechka)
- 400ml (1½ cups) water or light broth
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- FOR SERVING (choose your style):

SWEET VERSION

- Warm milk, honey, fresh berries

SAVORY VERSION

- Fried onion, soft-boiled egg, pickled cucumber

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse buckwheat briefly. If using untoasted buckwheat, toast in a dry pan over medium heat 4–5 minutes until fragrant and slightly darkened. Pre-toasted (brown) grechka is preferred.
2. Combine buckwheat, cold water, and salt in a saucepan.
3. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat to the lowest possible. Cover with a tight lid.
4. Cook 15 minutes without lifting the lid.
5. Remove from heat. Keep covered and rest 10 minutes — the steam finishes the cooking.
6. Fluff with a fork. Add butter and stir through.
7. Serve in the style of your choosing.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~290 per serving (with butter)

TIP

Never stir buckwheat during cooking — each grain should remain separate and fluffy, not clumped. The lid-on, no-stir method allows steam to work perfectly. Lift the lid and you release the steam. Keep it shut.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Fiber] [Classic Russian]

RECIPE 157

■■ Russia

OLADYI

RUSSIAN FLUFFY MINI PANCAKES

Oladyi are Russia's small, thick, cloud-soft pancakes — puffed from kefir and baking soda, golden at the edges, airy within. Unlike thin blini, they are substantial, slightly tangy, and eaten in stacks with sour cream, jam, or honey. The weekday Russian breakfast when there is no time for yeasted blini.

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 300ml (1¼ cups) kefir (room temperature)
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Vegetable oil for frying

FOR SERVING

- Cold smetana or sour cream
- Jam (strawberry, apricot, or blackcurrant)
- Honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk kefir, eggs, sugar, salt, and vanilla together.
2. Sift flour and baking soda over the wet mixture. Fold until just combined — batter will be thick and slightly lumpy. Do not overmix.
3. Rest batter 5 minutes — small bubbles will form on the surface from the kefir-soda reaction.
4. Heat 1–2 tbsp vegetable oil in a non-stick skillet over medium heat.
5. Drop heaped tablespoons of batter into the pan, spacing apart. They should be small — about 6cm (2.5 inches) diameter.
6. Cook 2–3 minutes until bubbles cover the surface and edges look set. Flip.
7. Cook 1–2 minutes on the second side until golden.
8. Keep warm. Serve in stacks with sour cream and jam.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Oladyi batter should be thick enough that it holds its shape when dropped — not pourable like crêpe batter. If it spreads too thin, add a tablespoon more flour. Thickness creates the airy, puffed interior.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Russian] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 158

■■ Russia

ZAPEKANKA TVOROZHNYAYA

RUSSIAN BAKED CHEESECAKE CASSEROLE

Zapekanka is Russia's beloved baked cheese casserole — sliceable and golden on the outside, creamy and custardy within. Made from tvorog, eggs, semolina, and vanilla, it is both breakfast and children's favorite. Eaten warm or cold, with sour cream and jam. Every Russian school cafeteria serves it. Every Russian loves it.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (2¼ cups) tvorog or well-drained ricotta
- 3 large eggs
- 80g (⅓ cup) sugar
- 3 tbsp semolina (fine)
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon
- ½ tsp salt
- 80g (½ cup) raisins (soaked in warm water 10 min)
- Butter for greasing + breadcrumbs for the dish

FOR SERVING

- Cold smetana or sour cream
- Cherry or strawberry jam

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Butter a loaf pan or 20cm (8-inch) round baking dish generously. Dust with breadcrumbs to coat — this creates a golden crust.
2. Beat tvorog with a fork or hand mixer until smooth.
3. Add eggs one at a time, mixing well after each.
4. Stir in sugar, semolina, vanilla, lemon zest, and salt. Mix until combined.
5. Drain raisins and fold in.
6. Pour batter into the prepared dish. Smooth the top.
7. Bake 40–45 minutes until the surface is golden and a skewer inserted comes out clean.
8. Cool in the pan 15 minutes before turning out.
9. Slice and serve warm or at room temperature with cold smetana and jam.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~270 per serving

TIP

Semolina is what binds the zapekanka and gives it structure — do not substitute flour. The semolina also creates a slightly gritty, pleasant texture in the finished casserole. Let it rest after baking — warm zapekanka slices much more cleanly.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Russian]

RECIPE 159

■■ Russia

MANKA NA MOLOKE

SEMOLINA PORRIDGE IN MILK

Manka — semolina porridge cooked in whole milk — is the defining breakfast of Russian childhood. Smooth, creamy, and comforting, it divides Russians into passionate camps: those who love it and those who were forced to eat it cold at school. Made correctly at home, it wins over everyone.

INGREDIENTS

- 750ml (3 cups) whole milk
- 60g (¼ cup) fine semolina
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter

FOR SERVING

- Jam (strawberry or raspberry)
- Fresh berries
- A small knob of extra cold butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pour milk into a heavy-bottomed saucepan. Add sugar and salt. Heat over medium, stirring, until just beginning to steam and barely simmer.
2. Pour semolina in a slow, very thin stream while whisking constantly to prevent lumps. This step requires focus — pour slowly and whisk vigorously.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cook, stirring constantly with a wooden spoon, for 5–7 minutes. The porridge thickens quickly.
4. Add vanilla extract and butter. Stir well.
5. Remove from heat immediately — manka continues to thicken as it cools.
6. Pour into warm bowls. Top with jam, berries, and a small knob of cold butter in the center.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~260 per serving

TIP

The most common mistake with manka is lumps. The solution: always add semolina to moving milk (whisking), never to still liquid. Pour the semolina in the thinnest possible stream while whisking without stopping. Lumps cannot form if the milk is moving.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly] [Classic Russian]

RECIPE 160

■■ Russia

PIROZHKI S YAYTSOM I

Small Russian hand pies — soft yeasted dough filled with chopped hard-boiled eggs, spring onions, and dill. Baked golden in the oven and eaten warm as a portable breakfast. Sold from street kiosks across Russian cities and made in home kitchens every weekend. The egg-green onion combination is perfectly classic.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm milk
- 1 large egg
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened

FOR THE FILLING

- 6 hard-boiled eggs, roughly chopped
- 1 bunch spring onions (green onions), sliced
- 3 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 2 tbsp mayonnaise or sour cream
- Salt and white pepper

GLAZE

- 1 egg, beaten

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and egg. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes. Cover and prove 1 hour.
2. FILLING: Mix chopped eggs, spring onions, dill, and mayonnaise. Season with salt and white pepper. The filling should be creamy but not wet.
3. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
4. Divide dough into 16 equal pieces. Roll each into a ball, then flatten into a circle about 10cm (4 inches) in diameter.
5. Place 1 heaped tbsp of filling in the center. Bring edges up and pinch tightly to seal — form into an oval shape, seam-side down.
6. Place on lined baking trays. Brush with beaten egg.
7. Prove 20 minutes.
8. Bake 20–22 minutes until deep golden brown.
9. Cool 5 minutes before eating.

Prep: 30 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~210 per pirozhok

TIP

The filling must be completely cold before shaping — warm filling makes the dough steam and become sticky inside. Make the filling an hour ahead and refrigerate. Cold filling = cleaner shaping.

[High Protein] [Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Russian]

RECIPE 161

■■ Russia

TVOROG S MEDYOM I OREKHAMI

QUARK WITH HONEY AND WALNUTS

One of Russia's simplest and most nutritious breakfasts — tvorog (Russian cottage cheese) served with a generous drizzle of buckwheat honey and a scattering of toasted walnuts. Quick, protein-rich, and eaten as a morning ritual in health-conscious Russian households. Buckwheat honey has a dark, earthy intensity that elevates this simple dish to something special.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) tvorog or ricotta
- (well-drained, smooth)
- 3 tbsp buckwheat honey or dark floral honey
- 80g (¾ cup) walnut halves, lightly toasted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Optional: 1 tbsp smetana stirred in for creaminess
- Fresh berries (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If using tvorog, pass through a fine sieve or beat with a fork for a smoother texture.
2. Add vanilla and smetana if using. Mix well.
3. Divide into two bowls.
4. Drizzle buckwheat honey generously over the top.
5. Scatter toasted walnuts over the honey.
6. Add fresh berries if desired.
7. Eat immediately with black tea or coffee.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Buckwheat honey — grechishny myod — is Russia's most famous honey variety. Dark, thick, and intensely flavored with a slightly bitter, malty edge, it has a complexity that lighter honeys lack. If unavailable, use any dark, strong honey.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Low Carb]

RECIPE 162

■■ Russia

RASSOLNIK UTRENNI

MORNING PICKLE SOUP

Rassolnik — Russia's briny, warming soup made with pickled cucumbers, pearl barley, and root vegetables in a rich broth — is traditionally a restorative breakfast after festivities. The cucumber brine gives it a distinctive sour punch that wakes up the senses. Deeply, unashamedly Russian.

INGREDIENTS

- 60g (■ cup) pearl barley
- 3 large pickled cucumbers (dill pickles),
diced + 100ml (■ cup) cucumber pickling brine
- 1 onion, diced
- 2 carrots, diced
- 3 medium potatoes, diced
- 1 stick celery, sliced
- 1.5L (6 cups) beef or chicken broth
- 2 tbsp butter
- 2 bay leaves
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh dill and smetana, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak pearl barley in cold water 30 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Heat butter in a large pot over medium heat. Sauté onion and carrots 5–6 minutes until soft.
3. Add broth, barley, and bay leaves. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer 20 minutes.
5. Add potatoes and celery. Simmer 10 more minutes until all vegetables are tender.
6. Add diced pickled cucumbers and pour in the brine. Stir to combine.
7. Simmer 5 more minutes. Taste — it should be pleasantly sour, briny, and warming.
8. Remove bay leaves. Season with black pepper. Add salt only if needed — brine is already salty.
9. Serve with fresh dill and a spoonful of smetana.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

The pickling brine is the soul of rassolnik. Use proper Russian-style dill pickle brine — from barrel pickles if possible. Commercial pickle brine from a jar works well. Never use sweet pickle brine — it completely changes the character of the soup.

[Gluten-Free option] [Classic Russian] [Make-Ahead] [High Fiber]

RECIPE 163

■ ■ Russia

YAITSA VKRUTUYU

Russia's simplest working breakfast — perfectly hard-boiled eggs, peeled at the table, eaten with thick slices of black Borodinsky bread spread with good butter and sea salt. No fuss, no ceremony, maximum nourishment. The Russian version of eggs on toast — darker, denser, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 4 thick slices Borodinsky or dark Russian rye bread
- 3 tbsp good unsalted butter, cold
- Flaky sea salt
- Fresh chives or green onion, sliced
- Optional: pickled cucumber on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring a saucepan of water to a rolling boil.
2. Lower eggs gently. Boil 10 minutes for fully set yolk with no grey ring — the Russian standard.
3. Transfer immediately to cold water. Peel when cool.
4. Slice bread thickly. Spread cold butter generously.
5. Halve or quarter the peeled eggs.
6. Season eggs with flaky sea salt.
7. Arrange on plate alongside the buttered bread.
8. Scatter chives over the eggs.
9. Serve with pickled cucumber on the side.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Borodinsky bread — Russia's most famous dark bread — is made from rye with molasses and coriander seeds. It has a sweet, slightly spicy flavor that pairs spectacularly with salty butter and egg. Find it at Eastern European delicatessens.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Quick] [Classic Russian]

Poland

RECIPE 164

■ ■ Russia

KISSEL S YAGODAMI

RUSSIAN BERRY KISSEL

Kissel is Russia's ancient fruit drink-dessert — somewhere between a thick juice and a pudding, thickened with potato starch. Served warm as a breakfast drink or chilled as a dessert, it has been eaten in Russia for over a thousand years. Made with whatever berry is in season or available frozen.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3 cups) mixed berries: cranberries, raspberries,
- cherries, or blackcurrants (fresh or frozen)
- 800ml (3■ cups) water
- 100g (½ cup) sugar (adjust to berry tartness)
- 3 tbsp potato starch (or cornstarch)
- 60ml (¼ cup) cold water (for starch)
- Optional: squeeze of lemon juice

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine berries, water, and sugar in a saucepan. Bring to a boil. Simmer 8–10 minutes until berries are completely soft.
2. Mash berries with a potato masher, or blend. Pass through a fine sieve for a smoother kissel.
3. Return fruit liquid to the saucepan. Bring to a boil.
4. Dissolve potato starch in cold water completely. No lumps allowed.
5. Remove fruit liquid from heat. Pour starch mixture in a thin stream while stirring constantly.
6. Return to medium heat. Stir constantly 2–3 minutes until the kissel thickens and becomes glossy.
7. Do not boil after adding starch — it becomes cloudy.
8. Serve warm in bowls or glasses. Or cool completely and serve chilled.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~160 per serving

TIP

Thick vs thin kissel is a choice: more starch = thicker (pudding consistency, eaten with a spoon), less starch = thinner (drunk from a glass). Russians traditionally serve it as a drinkable accompaniment to breakfast. Adjust starch to your preference.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Russian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 165

■ ■ Russia

OVSYANYE BLINCHIKI

OATMEAL CRÊPES

A modern Russian health-conscious breakfast — thin crêpes made from blended oats, eggs, and kefir, with no wheat flour needed. Naturally gluten-flexible, protein-rich, and incredibly easy. Rolled with low-fat tvorog and fresh berries inside, they are popular in contemporary Russian wellness culture.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (1 cup) rolled oats
- 2 large eggs
- 200ml (¾ cup) kefir or plain yogurt
- 100ml (■ cup) whole milk
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Vegetable oil for cooking

FOR FILLING

- 300g (1¼ cups) tvorog or ricotta
- 2 tbsp honey
- 1 tsp vanilla
- Fresh berries

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend oats, eggs, kefir, milk, sugar, salt, and vanilla until completely smooth — about 1 minute. The batter should be thin and pourable.
2. Rest 10 minutes — oats continue to hydrate.
3. Heat a non-stick pan over medium heat. Brush lightly with oil.
4. Pour a small ladleful of batter and swirl to coat the pan in a thin layer — these are thinner than oladyi but thicker than blini.
5. Cook 1.5–2 minutes until surface is set and edges begin to lift. Flip. Cook 1 more minute.
6. Stack on a warm plate.
7. Mix tvorog with honey and vanilla.
8. Fill each crêpe with a spoonful of tvorog mixture and berries. Roll or fold.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Blending oats into a fine flour creates a smooth, pancake-like batter. If your blender is less powerful, soak the oats in kefir for 20 minutes first — they will blend more easily to a smooth texture.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Vegetarian] [Modern Russian]

RECIPE 166

■■ Poland

JAJECZNICA Z BOCZKIEM

POLISH SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH BACON

Polish scrambled eggs are made with smoked boczek (bacon), butter, and nothing more — cooked slowly until soft and golden. Served on dark bread with sliced tomato, pickled cucumber, and fresh chives. The definitive Polish working breakfast, eaten at kitchen tables across the country every morning.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 150g (5 oz) Polish boczek (smoked bacon) or streaky bacon, diced
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, sliced
- Dark Polish bread, toasted, to serve
- 2 tomatoes, sliced
- 2 pickled cucumbers, sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cook diced boczek in a dry pan over medium heat until crispy and the fat has rendered. Remove bacon.
2. Discard most of the bacon fat, leaving about 1 tbsp. Add butter.
3. Beat eggs with salt and pepper. Pour into the pan.
4. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring gently with a spatula, 4–5 minutes until soft, creamy curds form.
5. Return crispy boczek to the pan. Stir through.
6. Top with chives. Serve immediately on dark bread alongside sliced tomato and pickled cucumbers.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Polish smoked boczek has a more intense, complex smokiness than standard bacon — closer to German Speck. If unavailable, use thickly-cut smoked streaky bacon. The smokiness is essential to the dish.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Polish] [Quick]

RECIPE 167

■■ Poland

KANAPKI

POLISH OPEN SANDWICHES

Kanapki — Polish open sandwiches — are the backbone of the Polish breakfast table. Thick dark bread or whole-grain bread spread with butter and piled with cold cuts, cheeses, pickled vegetables, and hard-boiled eggs. Made with care, assembled generously, and eaten with a knife and fork or picked up with both hands.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices dark Polish chleb  ytni (rye bread)
- or whole-grain bread
- 4 tbsp cold unsalted butter
- 100g (3.5 oz) kabanos or kielbasa, sliced
- 100g (3.5 oz) Gouda or Polish Edam, sliced
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- 1 tomato, sliced
- 4 slices pickled cucumber (or gherkins)
- Fresh chives or radishes
- Polish mustard (musztarda) on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Slice bread thickly and spread generously with butter.
2. SANDWICH 1: Layer kielbasa slices, top with mustard, add a pickled cucumber slice.
3. SANDWICH 2: Layer Gouda slices, top with sliced hard-boiled egg, tomato, and chives.
4. SANDWICH 3: Spread thinly with twaróg (Polish quark) and top with radish slices and chives.
5. Arrange all on a board or plate.
6. Serve with hot black tea or coffee.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

In Poland, kanapki are an art form — the toppings should be arranged attractively and generously. A thin, mean kanapka is considered an insult to guests. Be lavish.

[High Protein] [Classic Polish] [No-Cook] [Quick]

RECIPE 168

 Poland

NALENIKI Z TWAROGIEM

POLISH CRÊPES WITH COTTAGE CHEESE

Polish naleniki — thin, golden crêpes filled with sweetened twaróg (farmer's cheese) mixed with vanilla and raisins, then either served as-is or pan-fried in butter until golden on the outside. Poland's beloved weekend breakfast that children request and adults admit they crave.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE CRÊPES:
- 200g (1  cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 large eggs
- 350ml (1½ cups) whole milk
- 100ml ( cup) sparkling water (for lightness)
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 tbsp melted butter + extra for the pan
- FOR THE TWARÓG FILLING:
- 400g (1¾ cups) twaróg or dry-curd cottage cheese
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 80g (½ cup) raisins

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk flour, eggs, milk, sparkling water, sugar, salt, and butter until smooth. Rest 15 minutes.
2. FILLING: Mix twaróg with sugar, vanilla, lemon zest, and raisins until combined.
3. Cook crêpes in a lightly buttered pan over medium heat — thin and pale gold.
4. Lay each crêpe flat. Place 2 tbsp filling along one edge. Roll tightly. Tuck in the sides.
5. EAT AS-IS with sour cream, OR: Pan-fry in butter 2–3 minutes per side until golden and slightly crispy on the outside (this is the preferred Polish method).
6. Serve with sour cream or powdered sugar.

FOR SERVING

- Sour cream or powdered sugar
- Fruit jam

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Sparkling water in the crêpe batter creates a noticeably lighter, more delicate result. This is a Polish baker's trick. Do not substitute with still water — the bubbles matter.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Polish] [Weekend]

RECIPE 169

 Poland

UREK PORANNY

MORNING SOUR RYE SOUP

Poland's most iconic soup — **■urek** — made from fermented rye starter, served with white sausage and hard-boiled egg. Eaten at Easter breakfast, at weddings, and on cold weekday mornings in Polish homes and milk bars (bar mleczny). Sour, creamy, and deeply warming — Poland in a bowl.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE **■UREK** BASE:
- 200ml (¾ cup) prepared **■urek** starter
- (fermented rye — buy at Polish shops or make
- by fermenting 4 tbsp rye flour + 400ml water + garlic
- in a jar for 3–4 days at room temperature)
- 1L (4 cups) strong broth (meat or vegetable)
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp marjoram (essential)
- 100ml (■ cup) sour cream or cream
- Salt and white pepper

FOR SERVING

- 4 white kielbasa or bratwurst sausages, boiled
- 4 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Fresh horseradish, grated
- Fresh marjoram

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring broth to a simmer in a large pot.
2. Whisk **■urek** starter into the broth.
3. Add minced garlic and marjoram.
4. Simmer 10 minutes. The soup will turn cloudy and develop a pleasantly sour aroma.
5. Reduce heat to very low. Whisk in sour cream — do not boil after this point or it will curdle.
6. Season generously with salt and white pepper.
7. Taste — it should be tangy, warming, and savory.
8. Serve in deep bowls with boiled white sausage, halved hard-boiled egg, and fresh horseradish.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

*Marjoram is the defining herb of **■urek** — it is not optional. Dried marjoram works but fresh marjoram stirred in at the end is transformatively better. If you cannot find white kielbasa, use any good pork sausage.*

[High Protein] [Classic Polish] [Make-Ahead] [Seasonal]

RECIPE 170

■■ Poland

KASZA MANNA Z JAB■KAMI

SEMOLINA PORRIDGE WITH CARAMELIZED APPLE

Polish kasza manna — creamy semolina porridge cooked in whole milk — topped with caramelized apple slices and cinnamon. A childhood staple in Polish schools and homes that adults return to when they need comfort. Quick, nutritious, and nostalgic in the most satisfying way.

INGREDIENTS

- 750ml (3 cups) whole milk
- 70g (½ cup) fine semolina
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter

FOR THE CARAMELIZED APPLES

- 2 large apples, peeled, cored, and diced
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Pinch of nutmeg

INSTRUCTIONS

1. APPLES: Melt butter in a pan over medium heat. Add apple, sugar, cinnamon, and nutmeg. Cook 8–10 minutes until apples are soft, golden, and caramelized. Set aside.
2. PORRIDGE: Heat milk in a heavy saucepan over medium heat until just beginning to steam.
3. Add sugar and salt. Whisk to dissolve.
4. Pour semolina in a very thin stream while whisking constantly.
5. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring, 5 minutes until very thick and smooth.
6. Remove from heat. Stir in vanilla and butter.
7. Pour into bowls. Top generously with caramelized apples. Serve immediately.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Polish kasza manna is meant to be thick — thicker than most people expect from semolina porridge. If it seems too thick, add a splash of warm milk and stir vigorously. The apple topping thins it perfectly when mixed in at the table.

[Vegetarian] [Kid-Friendly] [Classic Polish] [Quick]

RECIPE 171

■■ Poland

RACUCHY Z JABŁKAMI

POLISH APPLE FRITTERS

Racuchy — thick, yeast-risen apple fritters — are one of Poland's most beloved weekend breakfasts. Grated apple is folded into a lightly sweetened yeasted batter, then pan-fried in butter until golden and puffed. Dusted in cinnamon sugar and served with sour cream. Old-fashioned Polish comfort at its finest.

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 1 egg
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 large apples, peeled and grated
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Vegetable oil and butter for frying
- Cinnamon sugar (3 tbsp sugar + 1 tsp cinnamon)
- Sour cream to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and egg. Mix into a smooth batter. Cover and prove 45 minutes until bubbly.
2. Squeeze grated apple to remove excess juice. Fold into proved batter with cinnamon.
3. Rest 5 more minutes.
4. Heat equal parts butter and oil in a skillet over medium heat.
5. Drop heaped tablespoons of batter into the pan. Gently press into round shapes.
6. Cook 3–4 minutes per side until deep golden. The batter will be quite thick — cook slowly to ensure inside is fully cooked.
7. Drain briefly. Immediately roll in cinnamon sugar.
8. Serve warm with cold sour cream.

Prep: 15 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Squeezing excess moisture from the grated apple is essential — wet apple makes a loose batter that spreads too thin and doesn't hold its shape. Squeeze thoroughly using a clean kitchen towel for best results.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Polish] [Weekend] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 172

■■ Poland

BUŁECZKI MAŁANE

POLISH BUTTER ROLLS

Soft, tender Polish butter rolls — enriched with eggs and butter, with a golden, slightly glossy crust — eaten for breakfast with cold butter and jam or a slice of cheese. Found in every Polish piekarnia (bakery) every morning, these are the everyday bread roll of Poland: simple, reliable, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm milk
- 1 large egg
- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 egg beaten (egg wash)
- Poppy seeds or sesame seeds for topping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and egg. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Cover and prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide into 10 equal pieces. Shape into smooth rounds or oval rolls.
4. Place on lined baking sheets, spaced apart.
5. Prove 30 minutes until noticeably puffed.
6. Brush with beaten egg wash.
7. Sprinkle with poppy seeds or sesame seeds.
8. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 15–18 minutes until golden and glossy.
9. Cool 10 minutes on a rack before serving with cold butter and jam.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~215 per roll

TIP

The poppy seed topping is the most traditional Polish choice — poppy seeds (*mak*) appear everywhere in Polish baking and have a distinctly Polish quality. Sesame is an acceptable modern alternative.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Polish] [Kid-Friendly]

Switzerland

RECIPE 173

■■ Poland

TWARÓG Z RZODKIEWKAMI

A classic Polish breakfast preparation — soft twaróg (fresh farmer's cheese) mixed with sliced radishes, fresh chives, and a touch of sour cream. Spread thickly on dark bread or eaten from a bowl. Fresh, protein-rich, and unmistakably Polish. Found on kitchen tables across Poland every spring and summer.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (1¾ cups) Polish twaróg półtłusty or
- semi-fat ricotta
- 6 radishes, thinly sliced
- 3 tbsp fresh chives, finely snipped
- 2 tbsp smetana or sour cream
- Salt and white pepper
- Optional: 1 tbsp fresh dill
- Dark Polish bread, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place twaróg in a bowl. Add smetana and mash together with a fork until creamy but with some texture remaining — not completely smooth.
2. Season with salt and white pepper.
3. Fold in sliced radishes, chives, and dill.
4. Taste and adjust seasoning — twaróg needs generous salt to taste its best.
5. Spread thickly on dark bread or serve in a bowl.
6. Garnish with a few extra radish slices and chives.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Polish twaróg półtłusty (semi-fat) has the ideal texture for this spread — not too dry, not too wet. Full-fat twaróg tłusty is creamier; low-fat twaróg chudy is grainier. All versions work — adjust smetana quantity.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free]

RECIPE 174

■■ Poland

KAWA Z CIASTECZKAMI

Crispy Polish oat biscuits — thin, buttery, and scented with vanilla and a hint of honey — eaten with morning coffee or tea. Made in large batches and stored in a tin, they are ready every morning throughout the week. Simple, honest, and thoroughly satisfying when dunked into hot coffee.

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (1½ cups) rolled oats
- 100g (¾ cup) all-purpose flour
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted
- 80g (⅓ cup) sugar
- 2 tbsp honey
- 1 large egg
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp baking powder
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Line two baking sheets.
2. Mix oats, flour, sugar, baking powder, and salt in a large bowl.
3. Add melted butter, honey, egg, and vanilla. Mix until a stiff dough forms.
4. Take tablespoon-sized portions and flatten into thin rounds on the baking sheet — about 5mm (¼ inch) thick.
5. Bake 12–14 minutes until golden at the edges.
6. Cool completely on the tray — they will crisp significantly as they cool.
7. Store in an airtight tin up to 2 weeks.
8. Serve with strong black Polish coffee.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 14 min · Serves: 20 biscuits · Cal: ~90 per biscuit

TIP

These biscuits must be pressed very thin — thicker biscuits cook unevenly and remain soft in the center. Press firmly. The thinner they are, the crispier they become after cooling.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Polish] [High Fiber]

RECIPE 175

■■ Poland

GROCHÓWKA NA ■NIADANIE

SPLIT PEA SOUP FOR BREAKFAST

Grochówka — Poland's thick, smoky split pea soup — is traditionally a military ration and army kitchen staple. Thick, warming, and deeply flavored with smoked sausage, it serves equally well as a winter breakfast for those who need to withstand the cold. Poland is not a country that believes breakfast should be light.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (1½ cups) yellow split peas, rinsed
- 1.5L (6 cups) water or light broth
- 200g (7 oz) smoked kielbasa or smoked ham, diced or sliced
- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 carrots, diced
- 2 sticks celery, sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 bay leaves
- 1 tsp marjoram
- 1 tsp smoked paprika
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh parsley

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place split peas in a large pot. Add water or broth, onion, carrots, celery, garlic, and bay leaves.
2. Bring to a boil. Skim any foam.
3. Reduce heat. Simmer 40–50 minutes until peas are completely soft and beginning to disintegrate.
4. Remove bay leaves. Use an immersion blender to partially blend — leave some texture.
5. Add smoked kielbasa, marjoram, and smoked paprika.
6. Simmer 10 more minutes for the flavors to meld.
7. Season generously with salt and black pepper.
8. Serve in deep bowls scattered with fresh parsley and crusty bread on the side.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 60 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Grochówka thickens as it cools — if it becomes too thick, thin with a little hot broth or water. The soup improves dramatically the next day as flavors deepen. Make double and refrigerate for tomorrow's breakfast.

[High Protein] [Classic Polish] [Make-Ahead] [Budget-Friendly]

RECIPE 176

■■ Switzerland

ZOPF MIT KONFITÜRE

SWISS BRAIDED BREAD WITH JAM

Zopf — Switzerland's magnificent braided butter bread — is a Sunday morning institution. Shiny, golden, and richly flavored from butter and egg, it is torn into thick slices and eaten with cultured butter and good fruit jam. Every Swiss family makes Zopf on Saturday evening for Sunday breakfast. It is non-negotiable.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 280ml (1¾ cups) warm whole milk
- 1 large egg
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 egg beaten (egg wash)
- Salted butter and jam, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm milk and egg. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter in pieces. Knead 6 more minutes until the dough is very smooth and satiny.
2. Cover and prove 1.5 hours until doubled.
3. Divide into 2 equal pieces. Roll each into a rope approximately 60cm (24 inches) long.
4. Cross the two ropes in the center. Braid tightly, working outward from the center in both directions — this creates the even Swiss braid.
5. Pinch and tuck both ends under firmly.
6. Place on a lined baking sheet.
7. Prove 45 minutes until clearly puffed.
8. Brush generously with egg wash — brush twice for a deep, glossy crust.
9. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 35–40 minutes until a deep mahogany gold.
10. Cool on a rack. Tear rather than slice. Serve with salted butter and jam.

Prep: 25 min + 2 hrs proofing · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~230 per thick slice with butter

TIP

A double coat of egg wash — once before proving and once just before baking — is the secret to the extraordinary glossy, lacquered crust that makes Swiss Zopf unmistakable. One coat is acceptable; two coats is perfection.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Swiss] [Make-Ahead] [Weekend Project]

RECIPE 177

■ ■ Switzerland

BIRCHERMÜESLI ORIGINAL

ORIGINAL BIRCHER MUESLI

Dr. Maximilian Bircher-Benner created this recipe at his Zurich clinic in 1900 as a medicinal preparation. Far simpler than modern overnight oats — mostly apple, a little oat, fresh lemon, and condensed milk — the original Birchermüesli is a masterpiece of restraint. The apple is the star. Everything else supports it.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 tbsp rolled oats (not instant)
- 3 tbsp cold water
- 1 tbsp fresh lemon juice
- 1 tbsp sweetened condensed milk
- (or 1 tbsp cream + 1 tsp honey)
- 3 large apples, freshly grated
- (do NOT peel — the skin goes in too)
- 1 tbsp ground hazelnuts or almonds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak the oats in cold water for 5–10 minutes until softened. This is the only soaking required — the original is not an overnight recipe.
2. Add lemon juice and condensed milk to the soaked oats. Stir to combine.
3. Grate the apple (including skin) directly into the oat mixture immediately — do not let it sit. Grate using the large holes of a box grater.
4. Stir well to coat the apple with lemon juice — this prevents browning.
5. Divide into bowls.
6. Scatter ground nuts over the top.
7. Eat immediately — the texture is at its best within 5 minutes of assembly.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~220 per serving

TIP

The original Birchermüesli has almost no oats — it is predominantly fresh apple. Dr. Bircher-Benner prescribed it as a raw food cure. Modern interpretations with 80g oats per serving have lost the original philosophy entirely. Start with less oat than you think.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Swiss]

RECIPE 178

■ ■ Switzerland

RÖSTI MIT EI

SWISS POTATO CAKE WITH FRIED EGG

Rösti — Switzerland's iconic golden potato cake — is served as a hearty breakfast across the German-speaking cantons. Made from parboiled grated potato fried in butter until deeply golden and crispy, topped with a fried egg and fresh chives. Switzerland's breakfast equivalent of hash browns — vastly superior.

INGREDIENTS

- 600g (21 oz) waxy potatoes, parboiled whole
- the day before, then refrigerated
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter + 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- Salt and pepper
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, snipped
- Optional: 50g (2 oz) smoked Gruyère, grated

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Peel the cold parboiled potatoes. Grate them coarsely using a box grater. Season with salt and pepper. Do not squeeze — unlike German potato pancakes, rösti should retain moisture.
2. Heat butter and oil in a 24cm (9.5-inch) non-stick pan over medium heat.
3. Add grated potato. Press firmly into an even disc shape with a spatula.
4. Cook over medium heat 8–10 minutes without touching until the bottom is deeply golden.
5. Place a large plate over the pan. Flip the rösti confidently onto the plate.
6. Slide back into the pan. Cook another 8 minutes until the other side is equally golden.
7. Slide onto a serving board.
8. Fry eggs in a separate pan to your preference.
9. Place eggs on top of rösti. Scatter chives. Add Gruyère if using.

Prep: 10 min (+ parboiling day before) · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Parboiling the potatoes the night before and refrigerating is the Swiss professional method. Cold, partially cooked potato grates more evenly, holds its shape better in the pan, and produces a crispier rösti. Never make rösti from raw potato — you will be disappointed.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Swiss] [High Protein]

RECIPE 179

■ ■ Switzerland

ÄLPLERMAGRONEN MIT

Switzerland's most beloved mountain dish — macaroni baked with potato, Gruyère, cream, and caramelized onions — served alongside cold apple sauce. Eaten in Alpine huts at all hours, including breakfast after early morning hikes. Rich, warming, and entirely suited to mountain mornings.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) macaroni or short pasta
- 200g (7 oz) potatoes, peeled and diced
- 200g (2 cups) Swiss Gruyère, grated
- 200ml (¾ cup) heavy cream
- 2 large onions, thinly sliced
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt, pepper, and nutmeg

FOR THE APPLE SAUCE

- 4 apples, peeled, cored, diced
- 2 tbsp sugar
- Juice of ½ lemon
- 1 tsp cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **APPLE SAUCE:** Cook apples with sugar, lemon, and cinnamon 12–15 minutes until soft. Mash to a rough sauce. Set aside cold.
2. **ONIONS:** Caramelize sliced onions in butter over low heat 25–30 minutes until deeply golden.
3. Cook macaroni and diced potato together in salted boiling water until both are tender. Drain.
4. Transfer to a large baking dish.
5. Pour cream over. Season with salt, pepper, nutmeg.
6. Top with grated Gruyère.
7. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 20 minutes until golden and bubbling.
8. Top with caramelized onions.
9. Serve with cold apple sauce alongside.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

The cold apple sauce alongside hot, rich Äplermagronen is essential — it cuts through the richness with cool sweetness and acidity. Do not serve it warm. The temperature contrast is deliberate.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Swiss] [Comfort Food] [High Protein]

RECIPE 180

■ ■ Switzerland (Basel)

LECKERLI-FRÜHSTÜCK

BASEL SPICED HONEY CAKE BREAKFAST

Leckerli — Basel's iconic chewy spiced honey cake studded with almonds and candied peel — is Switzerland's oldest confection, made since the medieval spice trade. Eaten for breakfast in Basel with black coffee, a slice of Leckerli is warming, aromatic, and a direct connection to the city's 600-year baking tradition.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (1 cup) good honey
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking soda dissolved in 2 tbsp Kirsch
- or water
- 100g (¾ cup) ground almonds
- 100g (½ cup) candied orange and lemon peel, chopped
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground cloves
- ½ tsp ground allspice
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- ½ tsp ground ginger

GLAZE

- 100g (1 cup) icing sugar + 2 tbsp hot water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat honey and sugar in a saucepan until sugar dissolves. Do not boil. Cool to lukewarm.
2. Mix flour, ground almonds, candied peel, and all spices together.
3. Add warm honey mixture and dissolved baking soda to the flour. Mix into a stiff, fragrant dough.
4. Refrigerate overnight — essential for proper texture.
5. Preheat oven to 170°C (340°F). Line baking sheets.
6. Roll cold dough to 1cm thick. Cut into rectangles.
7. Bake 15–18 minutes until lightly golden but still slightly soft — they firm on cooling.
8. Immediately brush with icing sugar glaze while hot.
9. Cool completely. Store in an airtight tin — they improve significantly after 3–5 days.

Prep: 25 min + overnight · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 24 pieces · Cal: ~175 per piece

TIP

Leckerli must rest in a tin for several days after baking — fresh from the oven they are too firm. The humidity in the tin softens them to the correct chewy texture. Authentic Leckerli is a patient baker's reward.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Swiss] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 181

■ ■ Switzerland (Graubünden)

BÜNDNER NUSSTORTE

From Switzerland's Engadine valley — a buttery shortcrust tart filled with a dense, caramelized walnut filling. Served in thin slices for breakfast with espresso, one slice is deeply rich and entirely sufficient. A mountain pastry of extraordinary intensity that has been made in Graubünden for centuries.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PASTRY

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 150g (⅓ cup) cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 80g (⅓ cup) icing sugar
- 1 large egg
- Pinch of salt

FOR THE WALNUT FILLING

- 300g (3 cups) walnuts, roughly chopped
- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 150ml (⅓ cup) heavy cream
- 2 tbsp honey
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PASTRY: Pulse flour, butter, and sugar in a food processor until sandy. Add egg and salt. Pulse until dough comes together. Divide ■ and ■. Wrap both. Chill 1 hour.
2. FILLING: Melt sugar in a saucepan without stirring until it caramelizes to a deep amber. Remove from heat. Add cream carefully (it will bubble). Stir in honey and salt. Add walnuts. Mix to coat completely. Cool until spreadable.
3. Roll ■ of pastry and line a 24cm (9.5-inch) tart tin, pressing up the sides.
4. Spread walnut filling evenly.
5. Roll remaining ■ of pastry and lay over the filling. Press edges to seal. Trim neatly.
6. Prick the top. Score a crosshatch pattern.
7. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 35–40 minutes until deeply golden.
8. Cool completely — minimum 4 hours — before slicing.

Prep: 30 min + 1 hr chilling · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~380 per thin slice

TIP

This tart is extremely rich — a thin slice is genuinely all that is needed. Cut it with a very sharp knife and serve slim wedges. The filling becomes firmer after 24 hours — the tart slices best on day two.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Swiss] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 182

■■ Switzerland

SCHWEIZER FRÜHSTÜCKSEI

A distinctly Swiss breakfast — soft-boiled eggs cracked open at the table and served alongside a thick slice of Appenzeller cheese (the world's most intensely herbed Swiss cheese), dark bread, and cornichons. The Appenzeller's herbal brine aging creates a flavor that pairs extraordinarily with the egg yolk.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs, at room temperature
- 4 slices dark Swiss bread or whole-grain bread
- 3 tbsp Swiss butter (Emmental or Gruyère valley)
- 150g (5 oz) Appenzeller cheese, thinly sliced
- 8 cornichons (small pickled gherkins)
- Coarse salt
- Fresh chives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a full boil.
2. Lower eggs gently. Boil 5.5–6 minutes for a soft-set white with runny, jammy yolk.
3. While eggs cook, toast and butter bread.
4. Arrange Appenzeller slices alongside.
5. Add cornichons on the plate.
6. Transfer eggs to egg cups. Slice off the top. Season with coarse salt.
7. Scatter chives over the open egg.
8. Eat with buttered bread and cheese alternating between bites of egg.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~390 per serving

TIP

Appenzeller is aged in a secret herbal brine that gives it an intensely spicy, aromatic character unlike any other cheese. It is at its best at room temperature — take it from the refrigerator 20 minutes before serving.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Swiss] [Quick]

Austria

RECIPE 183

■■ Switzerland (Vaud)

MALAKOFF

FRIED CHEESE CROQUETTE

Malakoff is a Vaudois specialty — a deep-fried cylinder of Gruyère batter, crispy on the outside and molten-cheesy within. Eaten as an amuse-bouche at wine festivals and now served at Swiss breakfasts in the Vaud and Geneva regions. Rich, decadent, and deeply Swiss in its commitment to using as much Gruyère as possible.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (2 cups) Gruyère, finely grated
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 1 large egg, beaten
- 1 tsp dry white wine or Kirsch
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- White pepper
- Pinch of nutmeg
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

FOR SERVING

- Cornichons
- Fresh bread
- Cold white wine (if morning permits) or coffee

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix grated Gruyère, flour, beaten egg, wine, garlic powder, white pepper, and nutmeg.
2. The mixture should be thick and moldable — like a very stiff paste.
3. With wet hands, shape into short cylinders about 4cm long and 2cm diameter.
4. Refrigerate 30 minutes — they must be cold before frying or they will fall apart.
5. Heat oil to 180°C (355°F) in a deep pan.
6. Fry cold malakoff in batches for 2–3 minutes until deeply golden all over.
7. Drain briefly on paper towels.
8. Eat immediately — the molten cheese cools quickly.
9. Serve with cornichons and fresh bread.

Prep: 15 min + 30 min chilling · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Malakoff must be eaten immediately — the cheese begins to firm within minutes of coming from the oil. Have everything ready before frying and eat standing at the kitchen counter. There is no waiting.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Swiss] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 184

■■ Austria

WIENER FRÜHSTÜCK

VIENNESE CAFÉ BREAKFAST

The classic Viennese breakfast — served in every Kaffeehaus since the 18th century. A Melange (espresso with steamed milk), a fresh Semmel roll with cold butter, jam, and honey, a glass of cold water, and a newspaper. This combination, unchanged for centuries, is one of the great cultural breakfast rituals of the world.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE MELANGE

- 1 shot freshly pulled espresso
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk, steamed into a velvet microfoam
- The Melange should be approximately 50% espresso, 50% milk with foam
- FOR THE FRÜHSTÜCK PLATE:
- 2 fresh Semmel (Viennese Kaiser rolls), warm
- 2 tbsp cold salted Austrian butter
- 2 tbsp good strawberry or apricot jam
- 1 tbsp honey
- 1 hard-boiled egg
- 1 glass cold water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pull a single espresso shot into a preheated glass or wide cup (190ml capacity).
2. Steam milk to 65°C with silky foam — Melange foam is less stiff than cappuccino foam. It should pour slowly, leaving the espresso visible beneath.
3. Pour steamed milk gently over the espresso. The foam sits on top.
4. Warm Semmel rolls in a 100°C oven for 3 minutes.
5. Set out butter, jam, and honey in separate small dishes.
6. Hard-boil egg 10 minutes; serve in an egg cup.
7. Serve everything together on a tray.
8. Open a newspaper. Sit. Do not rush. The Wiener Frühstück takes no less than 20 minutes.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~480 per full breakfast

TIP

In Vienna, it is considered rude to rush a Kaffeehaus breakfast. The waiter will not bring the bill until you ask. You may sit for hours. This is the entire philosophy of the Viennese Kaffeehaus — unhurried, civilized, and irreplaceable.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Austrian] [Elegant] [Cultural Experience]

RECIPE 185

■ ■ Austria

KAISERSCHMARRN

EMPEROR'S TORN PANCAKE

Created (allegedly) for Emperor Franz Joseph I — a light, airy soufflé-like pancake torn into pieces in the pan and caramelized in butter and sugar until golden, fluffy, and slightly crispy at the edges. Dusted in icing sugar and served with warm plum sauce. Austria's greatest sweet breakfast creation.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs, separated
- 120g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- 2 tbsp sugar + 2 tbsp for caramelizing
- 1 tbsp rum or vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tbsp raisins, soaked in rum (optional)
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- Icing sugar for dusting
- PLUM SAUCE (Zwetschenröster):
- 400g (14 oz) plums, pitted and halved
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- Splash of water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SAUCE: Cook plums with sugar, cinnamon, and water 8–10 minutes until soft but still holding shape. Set aside warm.
2. Whisk egg yolks, flour, milk, sugar, and rum until smooth.
3. Whip egg whites with salt to firm peaks. Fold into the yolk mixture gently.
4. Melt 2 tbsp butter in a large ovenproof pan. Pour in batter. Scatter raisins over.
5. Cook over medium heat 3–4 minutes until the base is set and golden.
6. Transfer to 200°C (390°F) oven. Bake 5–6 minutes until puffed and just set on top.
7. Return to stovetop over medium heat. Using two forks, tear the pancake into rough pieces.
8. Add remaining butter and 2 tbsp sugar. Toss and caramelize over high heat 2–3 minutes until pieces are golden and slightly crispy.
9. Dust generously with icing sugar.
10. Serve immediately with warm plum sauce.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~390 per serving

TIP

The tearing with two forks is the defining technique of Kaiserschmarrn. The pieces should be irregular — some large, some small. Uniform cutting with a knife is wrong. Tearing creates the rough edges that caramelize beautifully in the second frying step.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Austrian] [Special Occasion] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 186

■ ■ Austria

TOPFENSTRUDEL ZUM FRÜHSTÜCK

QUARK-FILLED STRUDEL FOR BREAKFAST

Austria's Topfenstrudel — tissue-thin stretched strudel dough wrapped around a creamy, vanilla-scented Topfen (quark) filling with raisins — baked golden and served warm with a vanilla sauce. Less famous than Apfelstrudel but arguably more delicious as a breakfast, with its protein-rich cheese filling.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE STRUDEL DOUGH

- 200g (1■ cups) bread flour
- 100ml (■ cup) warm water
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil
- Pinch of salt

FOR THE TOPFEN FILLING

- 500g (2¼ cups) Topfen (quark) or drained ricotta
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 2 egg yolks
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 80g (½ cup) raisins
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) sour cream

FINISHING

- 60g (4 tbsp) melted butter (for brushing dough)
- 50g (½ cup) fresh breadcrumbs, fried in butter
- 1 egg white, lightly beaten (for top)
- Icing sugar to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Knead flour, warm water, oil, and salt into a smooth, elastic, silky dough — 10 minutes. This dough must be very well-kneaded to stretch without tearing. Rest covered 30 minutes.
2. FILLING: Mix Topfen, sugar, yolks, vanilla, lemon zest, raisins, and sour cream.
3. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
4. Lay a clean, floured tablecloth on a large table. Roll dough, then use the backs of your hands (fists under the dough) to stretch it paper-thin from the center outward. It should be translucent.
5. Brush with melted butter. Scatter fried breadcrumbs.
6. Spoon filling in a line along one short edge.
7. Use the tablecloth to roll the strudel tightly.
8. Place on a buttered baking sheet. Brush with lightly beaten egg white and melted butter.
9. Bake 35–40 minutes until deeply golden.
10. Dust with icing sugar. Serve warm.

Prep: 40 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The strudel dough must stretch to near- transparency. Any tearing indicates under-kneading. Use the backs of your hands (not fingertips) — it is gentler and prevents tearing. A tablecloth makes rolling infinitely easier.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Austrian] [Weekend Project]

RECIPE 187

■ ■ Austria (Tyrol)

TIROLER BRETTLJAUSE

TYROLEAN BREAKFAST BOARD

The Tiroler Brettljause — Tyrolean mountain board — is the Alpine version of a charcuterie board. Dark bread, smoked Tiroler Speck (cured ham), aged mountain cheese, hard-boiled eggs, pickled vegetables, and gherkins. Eaten before or after a hike. Substantial, honest, and deeply satisfying at altitude.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices Tiroler Graubrot (grey bread) or dark rye
- 3 tbsp cold salted butter
- 100g (3.5 oz) Tiroler Speck, thinly sliced
- (or prosciutto)
- 100g (3.5 oz) aged Tiroler Bergkäse or aged Gouda
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- 4 cornichons or gherkins
- 4 radishes, sliced
- Pickled vegetables (beetroot, cauliflower)
- 1 tbsp mild Austrian mustard (Senf)
- Fresh chives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Arrange all elements on a large wooden board.
2. Butter bread slices generously.
3. Fold Speck into loose ruffles on the board — do not lay flat.
4. Slice Bergkäse thickly.
5. Place hard-boiled eggs alongside.
6. Arrange cornichons, radishes, and pickled vegetables around the meats and cheese.
7. Add a small pot of mustard.
8. Serve the board in the center of the table — this is shared food.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~450 per serving

TIP

Tiroler Speck is fundamentally different from Italian prosciutto. It is cold-smoked and aged in mountain air — firmer, more intensely smoky, and deeply savory. Find it at Austrian or German delicatessens. It is worth the effort.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Classic Austrian] [No-Cook] [Sharing]

BUCHTELN MIT MARILLENMARMELADE

AUSTRIAN SWEET BUNS WITH APRICOT JAM

Buchteln — soft, yeasted sweet buns baked touching each other in a buttered dish, filled with apricot jam inside, and served in a golden pull-apart cluster with vanilla sauce or sour cream. A Viennese and Bohemian tradition that turns simple dough and jam into something transcendently comforting.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm whole milk
- 2 egg yolks
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FILLING AND ASSEMBLY

- 200g (■ cup) good apricot jam (Marillenmarmelade)
- 80g (6 tbsp) melted butter (for rolling)
- Icing sugar for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk, egg yolks, and vanilla. Knead 8 minutes. Add soft butter in pieces. Knead 5 more minutes.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Melt 60g butter in a 30x20cm (12x8-inch) baking dish.
4. Divide dough into 16 balls.
5. Flatten each ball in your palm. Place ½ tsp apricot jam in the center.
6. Close the dough around the jam, pinching firmly. Roll each filled ball in the remaining melted butter to coat completely.
7. Place seam-side down, snugly packed together, in the buttered baking dish.
8. Prove 30–45 minutes until noticeably puffed.
9. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 25–30 minutes until deep golden on top.
10. Dust generously with icing sugar.
11. Serve from the dish, pulling apart at the table.

Prep: 30 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The seam must be pinched very tightly — if jam leaks during baking, it burns in the dish. Pinch with confidence, seal with commitment, and place seam-side down always.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Austrian] [Weekend] [Crowd-Pleaser]

GRIESNOCKERL IN MILCH

SEMOLINA DUMPLINGS IN WARM MILK

Austrian semolina dumplings — light, airy, and perfectly oval — poached in sweetened vanilla milk for a breakfast that sits somewhere between porridge and pasta. Beloved by Austrian children and an enduring comfort food for adults who grew up in Austrian kitchens. Delicate, nourishing, and wholly unique.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE NOCKERL

- 200g (1■ cups) fine semolina
- 2 large eggs
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FOR THE POACHING MILK

- 1L (4 cups) whole milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

FOR SERVING

- Cinnamon sugar
- A small knob of cold butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. NOCKERL MIXTURE: Beat softened butter until fluffy. Add eggs one at a time. Add semolina, salt, and vanilla. Mix into a stiff paste. Rest 10 minutes — semolina will absorb and stiffen.
2. Heat sweetened vanilla milk in a wide saucepan until barely simmering.
3. Using two wet tablespoons, scoop oval shapes from the semolina mixture and slide gently into the barely simmering milk.
4. Poach over very gentle heat for 12–15 minutes, turning carefully once. They should be puffed and firm when done.
5. Serve nockerl in wide bowls with the warm milk poured over.
6. Dust with cinnamon sugar.
7. Add a small knob of cold butter on top.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

The milk must never boil during poaching — a rolling boil breaks the nockerl apart. Keep the heat low enough that the milk trembles but does not bubble significantly. Patience produces perfect nockerl.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Austrian] [Kid-Friendly] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 190

■■ Austria

LIPTAUER AUFSTRICH

Liptauer — Austria's beloved spiced fresh cheese spread — is a mixture of Topfen (quark), butter, paprika, caraway, mustard, and onion. Spread generously on dark bread and eaten for breakfast with radishes and gherkins, it is one of Austria's most distinctive and beloved morning foods. Simultaneously simple and complex.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (¾ cup) Topfen or cream cheese
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tbsp sweet paprika (Edelsüß)
- ½ tsp hot paprika
- 1 tsp caraway seeds
- 1 tbsp Austrian mustard or Dijon
- ½ small onion, very finely diced
- 1 tbsp capers, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh chives, finely snipped
- Salt and white pepper

FOR SERVING

- Dark Austrian bread (Vollkornbrot or Schwarzbrot)
- Radishes, gherkins, sliced cucumber

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat Topfen and softened butter together until completely smooth and airy.
2. Add sweet paprika, hot paprika, caraway seeds, mustard, diced onion, and capers.
3. Mix well. Season with salt and white pepper.
4. Stir in fresh chives.
5. Taste — it should be savory, slightly spicy, and redolent with paprika and caraway.
6. Refrigerate 1 hour minimum to meld flavors — overnight is better.
7. Spread thickly on dark bread.
8. Serve alongside radishes, gherkins, and cucumber.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr chilling · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~210 per serving

TIP

Liptauer is always better the next day — the paprika, caraway, and onion need hours to meld into a harmonious spread. Make it the evening before for a markedly superior breakfast spread the following morning.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Austrian]

RECIPE 191

■■ Austria

MARILLENKNÖDEL

AUSTRIAN APRICOT DUMPLINGS

Austrian apricot dumplings — soft, enriched potato dough wrapped around a whole fresh apricot with a sugar cube hidden inside that caramelizes during cooking. Boiled and then rolled in cinnamon breadcrumbs, they are served at breakfast and dessert without any apology for the sweet-savory line they straddle.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 400g (14 oz) floury potatoes, boiled and riced while hot
- 120g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 1 egg yolk
- 1 tbsp butter, softened
- ½ tsp salt

FILLING

- 8 ripe but firm apricots, stones removed
- 8 small sugar cubes

COATING

- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 100g (1¼ cups) fresh breadcrumbs
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Icing sugar for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Rice hot potatoes and spread to cool and steam off moisture. Once cool, mix with flour, egg yolk, butter, and salt into a smooth dough. Add flour only as needed — keep it soft.
2. Replace each apricot stone with a sugar cube.
3. Divide dough into 8 portions. Flatten each in your palm. Wrap around one apricot, sealing firmly with no gaps.
4. Bring a large pot of lightly salted water to a boil. Reduce to a simmer. Add dumplings carefully.
5. Poach 10–12 minutes until they float and look slightly puffed.
6. Meanwhile: melt butter in a pan. Toast breadcrumbs until golden. Add sugar and cinnamon.
7. Roll hot drained dumplings in cinnamon breadcrumbs until completely coated.
8. Dust with icing sugar. Serve immediately.

Prep: 35 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

The dough must be made from cold potatoes that have had time to steam off their moisture — hot, wet potato makes the dough too sticky. Rice them hot, spread on a tray, and cool completely before mixing. Cold, dry potato = perfect dough.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Austrian] [Seasonal] [Special Occasion]

Netherlands

RECIPE 192

■■ Netherlands

HAGELSLAG OP BROOD

DUTCH CHOCOLATE SPRINKLES ON BREAD

Hagelslag — real chocolate sprinkles made from actual chocolate — poured generously over thickly buttered white bread. This is not a children's treat in the Netherlands. This is a daily adult breakfast eaten without embarrassment by 17 million people. Outsiders are baffled. Participants are entirely satisfied.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices thick white Dutch bread (or any soft white sandwich bread)
- 4 tbsp good salted butter, room temperature
- 4–6 tbsp real chocolate hagelslag
- (Dutch chocolate sprinkles — not generic cake sprinkles.
- Venz or De Ruijter brands are the authentic choice)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Lay bread slices flat.
2. Spread butter generously and evenly to every edge. The butter must be thick — hagelslag needs a surface to adhere to.
3. Pour or sprinkle hagelslag generously over the butter. It should cover the bread completely — do not be conservative.
4. Press very gently with the back of a spoon to help it adhere slightly.
5. Eat immediately and without guilt.
6. Drink a glass of milk or a cup of coffee alongside.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Dutch hagelslag is made from real chocolate — it is fundamentally different from the colored sugar sprinkles used on cakes elsewhere. The distinction is non-negotiable for authenticity. Venz pure chocolade hagelslag is 35% cocoa minimum. Accept no substitutes.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Classic Dutch] [5 Ingredients] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 193

■ ■ Netherlands

UITSMIJTER

DUTCH FRIED EGGS ON BREAD

Uitsmijter — literally "bouncer" — is the Netherlands' most satisfying breakfast and lunch dish. Three fried eggs on buttered bread with ham and Gouda, served open-faced. The name reportedly comes from the dish being what Dutch café owners served to guests being shown the door at closing time. It survived the origin story.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 slices thick white bread or whole-grain bread
- 3 tbsp cold salted butter
- 4 slices good Dutch ham or cooked ham
- 4 slices aged Gouda, thinly sliced
- 4 large eggs
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter (for frying eggs)
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast bread lightly if desired, or leave plain. Spread generously with cold salted butter.
2. Layer ham slices over each buttered bread slice.
3. Layer Gouda slices over the ham.
4. In a non-stick skillet, melt butter over medium heat.
5. Fry eggs two at a time, sunny-side up, until whites are fully set but yolks remain completely runny.
6. Place two fried eggs on each open sandwich — the eggs sit directly on the cheese.
7. Season with salt and black pepper.
8. Scatter fresh parsley. Serve immediately on the bread — this is eaten with a knife and fork.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

The yolk must be completely runny — when broken, it flows over the ham and cheese, creating the sauce for the dish. A set yolk makes a fundamentally different and inferior uitsmijter. Guard the yolk with care.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Dutch]

RECIPE 194

■ ■ Netherlands

POFFERTJES

DUTCH SILVER DOLLAR PANCAKES

Tiny, fluffy Dutch pancakes made in a special cast-iron poffertjes pan — yeasted with buckwheat flour for a distinctive, slightly earthy flavor, and served in quantities (minimum 12 per person) with melted butter and a snowfall of icing sugar. Sold at Dutch markets and eaten at breakfast tables across the Netherlands.

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (1¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 50g (½ cup) buckwheat flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm whole milk
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tbsp melted butter
- Butter for the poffertjes pan

FOR SERVING

- 3 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 4 tbsp icing (powdered) sugar
- Optional: fresh strawberries

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk both flours, yeast, sugar, and salt together.
2. Add warm milk, eggs, and melted butter. Whisk until completely smooth.
3. Cover and rest 30–45 minutes until slightly bubbly and the yeast has activated.
4. Heat a poffertjes pan over medium heat. Brush each depression generously with butter.
5. Fill each depression ¾ full with batter.
6. When the edges are set and bottoms are golden (about 1.5 minutes), flip each poffertje using a skewer or small fork.
7. Cook another 1 minute until golden and cooked through.
8. Serve in a pile. Pour melted butter over generously.
9. Sift icing sugar in a thick layer over everything.
10. Eat hot — poffertjes cool and deflate quickly.

Prep: 10 min + 45 min rest · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

A poffertjes pan is specifically designed for this recipe and cannot truly be replicated without one. However, a cast-iron blini pan, a Swedish æbleskiver pan, or even a deep-pitted waffle iron can approximate the result. The authentic pan produces a crispier bottom edge.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Dutch] [Kid-Friendly] [Weekend]

RECIPE 195

■ ■ Netherlands

BOTERHAM MET KAAS EN MOSTERD

DUTCH BREAD WITH CHEESE AND MUSTARD

The everyday Dutch breakfast — bread with a thick slice of aged Gouda and a smear of Dutch mustard. The Netherlands produces some of the world's finest aged cheese, and every Dutch kitchen contains a minimum of three varieties. This is not a recipe — it is a cultural practice performed twice daily by millions of Dutch people.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices Dutch white bread or whole-grain bread
- 3 tbsp cold salted butter
- 150g (5 oz) aged Dutch Gouda (Oud or Extra Belegen),
 - thinly sliced
- 1 tbsp Dutch medium mustard (Dutch mustard is
 - distinctively mild and slightly sweet)
- Optional: sliced tomato, cucumber, or pickled gherkin
- Hot tea or coffee alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Lay bread slices flat. Spread butter to every edge.
2. Add a thin smear of mustard over the butter on half.
3. Layer thick slices of aged Gouda over each bread.
4. Add tomato, cucumber, or gherkin alongside if desired.
5. The Dutch eat this open-faced and pick it up. A knife and fork are acceptable but not required.
6. Drink hot tea or coffee alongside.

Prep: 4 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP

Use properly aged Gouda — Oud Gouda (minimum 18 months) or Extra Belegen (minimum 8 months). Young Gouda is rubbery and lacks the crystalline texture and complex caramel-salt flavor of aged cheese. Age matters.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Dutch] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 196

■ ■ Netherlands

WENTELTEEFJES

DUTCH FRENCH TOAST

Wentelteefjes — literally "turnovers" — is the Dutch version of French toast, made from stale white bread soaked in a spiced egg- milk mixture and fried in butter. Rolled in cinnamon sugar and eaten with jam. Simple, deeply nostalgic, and made across Dutch households every weekend morning when bread has gone stale.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices stale white bread
- 2 large eggs
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter (for frying)
- Cinnamon sugar: 3 tbsp sugar + 1 tsp cinnamon
- Jam or stroop (Dutch treacle), to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, milk, sugar, cinnamon, vanilla, and salt in a shallow wide bowl until combined.
2. Soak bread slices in the egg mixture, 2 minutes per side, until thoroughly saturated.
3. Melt butter in a skillet over medium heat until foaming.
4. Add soaked bread. Cook 2–3 minutes per side until deeply golden and cooked through.
5. Immediately roll or sprinkle both sides generously with cinnamon sugar.
6. Serve with jam or Dutch stroop for drizzling.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~360 per serving

TIP Use genuinely stale bread — at least two days old. Fresh bread absorbs too much liquid and falls apart in the pan. Stale bread holds its structure while still absorbing enough custard to become rich and custardy.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Dutch] [Quick] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 197

■■ Netherlands

STROOPWAFEL MET KOFFIE

DUTCH SYRUP WAFFLE WITH COFFEE

The stroopwafel — two thin wafer rounds sandwiched with a caramel-treacle filling — is Holland's most exported food product. The correct way to eat a stroopwafel for breakfast: balance it on top of a hot cup of coffee for 45 seconds so the steam softens the caramel filling. Then eat while the center is warm and gooey.

INGREDIENTS

FOR HOMEMADE STROOPWAFELS

- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 125g (½ cup + 1 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 75g (⅓ cup) sugar
- 1 large egg
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tsp cinnamon

STROOP FILLING

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 200g (1 cup) brown sugar
- 100g (5 tbsp) golden syrup or treacle
- 1 tsp cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Beat butter and sugar. Add egg. Mix in flour, yeast, salt, and cinnamon into a stiff dough. Rest 30 minutes covered.
2. STROOP: Melt butter, brown sugar, golden syrup, and cinnamon in a saucepan over medium heat. Stir until smooth and slightly thickened. Keep warm and fluid.
3. Preheat a stroopwafel iron (or thin waffle iron). No oil needed.
4. Take a walnut-sized ball of dough. Press in the iron. Cook 45–60 seconds until golden and cooked through.
5. While still warm and pliable, split each wafer horizontally with a sharp thin knife.
6. Spread warm stroop on one half. Press the other half firmly on top.
7. Cool completely. The stroop sets as it cools.
8. TO EAT: Balance stroopwafel on a hot coffee cup rim for 45 seconds. Eat immediately.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~210 per stroopwafel

TIP The steam-softening ritual is not optional — it is the entire Dutch stroopwafel experience. A cold, un-softened stroopwafel is a lesser version of itself. The 45-second balance on the coffee cup transforms it.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Dutch] [Make-Ahead] [Cultural Ritual]

RECIPE 198

■■ Netherlands

ROGGEBROOD MET HARING

DUTCH RYE BREAD WITH HERRING

Dense, dark Dutch roggebrood with cold salted butter and a fillet of Hollandse Nieuwe — the first young herring of the season, mild, lightly salt-cured, and eaten raw. The Dutch hold the herring by the tail and lower it whole into the mouth at street stalls, but on bread is the civilized breakfast version.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices dark Dutch roggebrood (100% rye, dense and
- very dark — not pumpernickel but similar)
- 3 tbsp cold salted butter
- 4 fillets Hollandse Nieuwe (Dutch cured herring) or
- quality pickled herring
- 1 small white onion, very finely diced
- 4 cornichons, sliced
- Fresh dill or chives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spread cold butter generously on each roggebrood slice.
2. Lay one herring fillet on each buttered slice.
3. Scatter a spoonful of finely diced white onion over the herring.
4. Add sliced cornichons alongside.
5. Garnish with fresh dill or chives.
6. Eat with a glass of cold milk or strong black coffee.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Hollandse Nieuwe is only available from late May to July — the first catch of the season when young herring have the highest fat content. At other times of year, use quality pickled herring (matjes). The flavor difference is significant but both are excellent.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Classic Dutch] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 199

■■ Netherlands

ONTBIJTKOEK MED BOTER

DUTCH SPICED BREAKFAST CAKE

Ontbijtkoek — Dutch spiced breakfast cake — is a dense, moist, dark loaf scented with cloves, cinnamon, anise, and ginger. Sliced thickly, spread with cold butter, and eaten at breakfast. Sold pre-made in every Dutch supermarket and eaten so commonly that Dutch people consider it unremarkable. It is remarkable.

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 150g (¾ cup) dark brown sugar
- 150g (½ cup) dark treacle or golden syrup
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp bicarbonate of soda
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1 tsp ground ginger
- ½ tsp ground cloves
- ½ tsp ground anise or anise seeds
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- Pinch of salt
- Cold salted butter for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 160°C (320°F). Grease a 24cm (9.5-inch) loaf tin and line with parchment.
2. Mix flour, sugar, baking powder, baking soda, all spices, and salt.
3. Add warm milk and treacle. Mix until completely smooth — no lumps. The batter will be thick and very dark.
4. Pour into prepared tin.
5. Bake 50–60 minutes until a skewer comes out clean and the top is deeply dark brown.
6. Cool completely in the tin before turning out — minimum 2 hours. The cake slices much better cold.
7. Slice 1.5cm thick. Spread cold salted butter.
8. Store in an airtight container — improves with age up to 5 days.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 55 min · Serves: 14 slices · Cal: ~195 per slice with butter

TIP

Ontbijtkoek improves dramatically over 2–3 days as the spices deepen and the crumb becomes more moist. Bake it on a Sunday for a spectacular Monday-through- Wednesday breakfast. The patience is worth it.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Dutch] [High Fiber]

RECIPE 200

■■ Belgium

GAUFRE DE BRUXELLES

BRUSSELS WAFFLE

The Brussels waffle — light, airy, rectangular, and deeply pocketed — is the original Belgian waffle. Made from a yeasted batter with stiffly beaten egg whites folded in for maximum lift, it is eaten fresh with simple toppings: fresh strawberries, whipped cream, and a dusting of icing sugar. Perfect in its restraint. Nothing heavy. Just a magnificent waffle.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm whole milk
- 150ml (⅓ cup) warm water
- 3 large eggs, separated
- 150g (⅓ cup) unsalted butter, melted and cooled
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FOR SERVING

- Fresh strawberries, halved
- Lightly whipped cream
- Icing sugar
- Optional: Belgian chocolate sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk flour, yeast, sugar, and salt together.
2. Add warm milk, warm water, egg yolks, cooled melted butter, and vanilla. Whisk until smooth.
3. Cover and prove in a warm place 1 hour until bubbly and risen.
4. Whip egg whites to firm peaks.
5. Fold egg whites into the proved batter in two additions, working gently to preserve the air.
6. Heat a waffle iron to medium-high. Brush with melted butter.
7. Pour batter to fill the iron (they should be generous and slightly overflow for crispy edges).
8. Cook 4–5 minutes until deep golden on both sides.
9. Serve immediately on a plate — Brussels waffles do not wait.
10. Top with strawberries, whipped cream, and icing sugar.

Prep: 15 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~380 per waffle

TIP

Brussels waffles must be eaten immediately — they go soft within 10 minutes of leaving the iron. Never make them in advance. The entire point is the shattering crispy exterior against the airy interior, which only exists in the first minutes after cooking.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Belgian] [Weekend] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 201

■ ■ Belgium

GAUFRE DE LIÈGE

LIÈGE WAFFLE

The Liège waffle is the street version — oval, dense, chewy, made from a brioche-like yeasted dough studded with Belgian pearl sugar that caramelizes in the iron creating crunchy, almost candy-like pockets. Eaten from the hand, no toppings needed. The contrast of caramelized exterior and soft, buttery interior is one of food's great simple pleasures.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp honey
- 2 large eggs
- 3 tbsp warm water
- 150g (⅓ cup) unsalted butter, softened
- 150g (¾ cup) Belgian pearl sugar
- (cassonade Belge — large crystal sugar essential)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt.
2. Add vanilla, honey, eggs, and warm water.
3. Knead 5 minutes until a smooth dough forms.
4. Add softened butter in pieces, kneading between each addition — like making brioche. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth and elastic.
5. Cover and prove 1.5 hours until doubled.
6. Knock back the dough. Gently fold in the pearl sugar — do not overwork or sugar will dissolve.
7. Divide into 8 oval portions. Rest 30 minutes.
8. Cook in a preheated waffle iron over medium heat for 3–4 minutes. The caramelization of the pearl sugar creates incredible golden, sticky pockets.
9. Remove carefully — the caramel is very hot. Eat within 5 minutes while warm.

Prep: 25 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~360 per waffle

TIP

Belgian pearl sugar is large, hard crystal sugar that does not dissolve — it caramelizes. Regular sugar completely dissolves into the dough and will not create the characteristic crunchy pockets. Pearl sugar is available online and at specialty food stores. Do not substitute.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Belgian] [Street Food] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 202

■ ■ Belgium

PISTOLET MET HESP EN KAAS

BELGIAN BREAD ROLL WITH HAM AND CHEESE

The pistolet — Belgium's small, crusty round bread roll with a distinctive scored top — is the Belgian breakfast roll. Filled with sliced ham (hesp) and aged cheese, it is bought fresh from the bakery every morning and eaten at the kitchen table. Simple, absolutely reliable, and representing Belgian breakfast at its most everyday and satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

FOR HOMEMADE PISTOLETS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil

FOR FILLING

- 4 tbsp cold salted butter
- 8 slices good quality ham (Jambon d'Ardenne preferred)
- 8 slices aged Belgian cheese (Orval or aged Gouda)
- Optional: sliced tomato and lettuce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide into 8 smooth balls. Place on lined trays.
4. Flatten slightly into round shapes.
5. Using a sharp blade, score a deep single line across the top of each roll from edge to edge.
6. Prove 30 minutes.
7. Bake at 220°C (430°F) for 15–18 minutes until golden and crusty, with the score split open.
8. Cool 10 minutes. Split and fill with butter, ham, and cheese. Serve immediately.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~360 per filled pistolet

TIP

The score across the top of a pistolet is its defining feature — it splits during baking, creating the characteristic crust. Score it deeply and confidently with a very sharp blade immediately before baking.

[High Protein] [Classic Belgian] [Make-Ahead]

Belgium

RECIPE 203

■ ■ Belgium (Brussels)

PAIN À LA GRECQUE BELGE

BELGIAN SPICED BREAD RING

Despite the name ("Greek bread"), this is a uniquely Brussels specialty with no Greek connection. A rectangular, pearl-sugar encrusted sweet bread ring scented with cinnamon and anise, sold by street vendors near Grand Place since the 18th century. Eaten for breakfast with coffee, broken into pieces, and deeply spiced in the Belgian tradition.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3¼ cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 100g (½ cup) dark brown sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp anise seeds, crushed
- ½ tsp cardamom
- ½ tsp salt
- 150ml (⅔ cup) warm water
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 egg
- Pearl sugar for coating the outside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, brown sugar, cinnamon, anise, cardamom, and salt.
2. Add warm water and egg. Knead 5 minutes.
3. Add softened butter in pieces. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth, elastic, and fragrant with spice.
4. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
5. Divide into 4 logs. Roll each into a rope about 50cm long.
6. Form each into a rectangle by folding and pressing — or simply form elongated oval rings.
7. Press pearl sugar firmly into all surfaces.
8. Place on lined baking sheets. Prove 30 minutes.
9. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 20–25 minutes until deep golden.
10. Cool before eating — the spices intensify as the bread cools.

Prep: 25 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Pain à la Grecque improves dramatically the day after baking — the spices meld and deepen overnight. Make it Saturday evening and eat Sunday morning for the best result.

[Vegan] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Belgian] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 204

■ ■ Belgium

CRAMIQUE

BELGIAN RAISIN BRIOCHE BREAD

Cramique is Belgium's beloved enriched raisin loaf — a brioche-like bread studded with plump raisins and flavored with vanilla. Sliced thick and spread with salted butter, it is the centerpiece of a Belgian Sunday family breakfast. Every Belgian bakery bakes it every morning. Every Belgian family eats it on weekends.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 large eggs
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm whole milk
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 200g (1¼ cups) raisins, soaked in warm water
- 30 minutes and drained
- 1 egg (egg wash)
- Coarse sugar for the top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add eggs, warm milk, and vanilla. Knead 8 minutes.
2. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth, glossy, and elastic.
3. Gently fold in drained raisins.
4. Cover and prove 1.5 hours until doubled.
5. Shape into a round loaf or place in a greased loaf tin.
6. Prove 45 minutes until clearly puffed.
7. Brush with beaten egg wash.
8. Scatter coarse sugar over the top.
9. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 30–35 minutes until deep golden. The base should sound hollow when tapped.
10. Cool 20 minutes before slicing.

Prep: 25 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 12 slices · Cal: ~265 per thick slice

TIP

Soaking the raisins before adding them is essential — dry raisins absorb moisture from the dough during baking, creating dry spots in the crumb. Plump, soaked raisins stay tender and distribute evenly.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Belgian] [Make-Ahead] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 205

■ ■ Belgium

CHOCOLAT CHAUD BELGE

BELGIAN HOT CHOCOLATE

Belgian hot chocolate is made from real Belgian chocolate — not cocoa powder. Rich, dark, and unashamedly thick, it is served in a small cup alongside a square of Belgian chocolate on the saucer. The country that produces the world's finest chocolate takes its hot chocolate with corresponding seriousness.

INGREDIENTS

- 80g (3 oz) Belgian dark chocolate (70%), finely chopped (Callebaut or Côte d'Or preferred)
- 300ml (1¼ cups) whole milk
- 100ml (■ cup) heavy cream
- 1 tsp sugar (or to taste)
- Tiny pinch of salt
- Optional: 1 tsp Belgian praline paste
- for a hazelnut-chocolate version

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine milk and cream in a small saucepan. Heat over medium until just beginning to steam.
2. Remove from heat. Add chopped chocolate and salt.
3. Let stand 1 minute without stirring.
4. Whisk vigorously until chocolate is completely melted and the mixture is smooth and glossy.
5. Return to low heat. Whisk 2–3 minutes until slightly thickened. Add sugar to taste.
6. Pour into warmed small cups.
7. Serve immediately with a square of Belgian chocolate on the saucer.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per cup

TIP

Belgian chocolate has a higher cocoa butter content than most chocolate — this is what creates the silky, glossy finish when melted into hot milk. Use couverture-grade Belgian chocolate for the most luxurious result. The quality is directly tasted in the cup.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Belgian] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 206

■ ■ Belgium

TARTINE BELGE AU FROMAGE

A distinctly Belgian combination that surprises outsiders — thick toast with aged cheese AND a drizzle of Sirop de Liège (a dark, intensely fruity apple-pear syrup). The sweet-salty- savory combination is one of Belgium's most characteristic flavor signatures. Eaten for breakfast in Liège and across Wallonia without a trace of irony.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices thick country white bread, toasted
- 4 tbsp cold salted Belgian butter
- 150g (5 oz) aged Belgian Herve cheese or aged Gouda
- 3 tbsp Sirop de Liège (Belgian apple-pear dark syrup)
- — substitute: a thick dark apple butter or treacle

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast bread until golden and firm.
2. Spread cold butter generously while still hot.
3. Layer aged cheese slices over the butter.
4. Drizzle Sirop de Liège over the cheese.
5. The combination of sharp aged cheese meeting the dark, fruity syrup should be experienced in one bite — do not eat separately.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Sirop de Liège is a reduction of apples and pears cooked for hours until thick and dark — with a complex flavor combining treacle, dried fruit, and caramel. Find it at Belgian specialty shops. It cannot truly be substituted — it is the point of the recipe.

[Vegetarian] [Quick] [Classic Belgian] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 207

■ ■ Belgium

OEUFS BENEDICTINE BELGE

BELGIAN EGGS BENEDICT WITH ARDENNES HAM

Belgium's take on Eggs Benedict uses Jambon d'Ardenne — the Wallonian air-dried and smoked ham with PGI status and a complex, deeply savory flavor — in place of Canadian bacon. The result is a more intensely flavored hollandaise combination that reflects Belgium's serious approach to charcuterie and brunch culture.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 slices thick country bread or pistolets, toasted
- 8 slices Jambon d'Ardenne or quality prosciutto
- 4 large eggs, poached
- Optional: handful baby spinach, wilted

HOLLANDAISE

- 3 egg yolks
- 1 tbsp cold water
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar
- 150g (■ cup) clarified butter, warm
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Salt, white pepper, cayenne

INSTRUCTIONS

1. HOLLANDAISE: Whisk egg yolks with cold water and vinegar over a bain-marie (gentle simmering water). Whisk until pale, thick, and doubled — 3–4 minutes.
2. Remove from heat. Very slowly drizzle in warm clarified butter while whisking constantly until thick and glossy. Season with lemon, salt, pepper, and cayenne. Keep warm over the bain-marie.
3. POACH EGGS: Bring salted water with a splash of vinegar to a bare simmer. Stir gently. Crack eggs in one at a time. Poach 3 minutes for runny yolk.
4. ASSEMBLE: Toast → wilted spinach (if using) → Jambon d'Ardenne → poached egg → hollandaise.
5. Serve immediately.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~540 per serving

TIP

Jambon d'Ardenne has a stronger, smokier character than regular cooked ham — its intensity stands up beautifully against the rich hollandaise. Do not be tempted to use mild ham here. The contrast is the entire point.

[High Protein] [Classic Belgian] [Special Occasion] [Elegant]

RECIPE 208

■ ■ Hungary

LÁNGOS

HUNGARIAN DEEP-FRIED BREAD

Lángos — Hungary's iconic deep-fried yeasted flatbread — is the definitive Hungarian street food eaten at every outdoor market, lake resort, and festival since the 16th century. Served warm with a vigorous rubbing of raw garlic, a smear of sour cream, and a generous grating of cheese, it is simultaneously crude and magnificent.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm whole milk or water
- 100g (3.5 oz) mashed potato or potato purée
- (the secret to perfect lángos texture)
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

FOR TOPPING

- 4 garlic cloves, halved
- 200g (¾ cup) sour cream (tejföl)
- 100g (1 cup) aged Edam or Trappista cheese, grated
- Salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and mashed potato. Mix into a soft, sticky dough — it should be quite loose, not a firm ball.
2. Cover and prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. With well-oiled hands, tear off portions (tennis ball sized). Stretch and flatten gently into ovals about 1cm thick.
4. Heat oil in a deep pan to 170°C (340°F).
5. Carefully lower lángos into the oil. Fry 2–3 minutes per side until deep golden and puffed. They should be cooked through.
6. Drain briefly on paper towels.
7. While very hot, rub the cut side of a raw garlic clove aggressively over the surface.
8. Spread sour cream generously.
9. Grate cheese abundantly over the sour cream.
10. Add a pinch of salt. Eat immediately.

Prep: 15 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per lángos

TIP

Mashed potato in lángos dough is the original Hungarian method — it creates an extraordinarily soft, almost pillowy interior while maintaining a crispy exterior. Do not make lángos without it. The difference is remarkable.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hungarian] [Street Food] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 209

■ ■ Hungary

TÚRÓS TÁSKA

HUNGARIAN CHEESE PASTRY

Túrós táska — "curd cheese handbag" — is a flaky puff pastry envelope filled with sweetened túró (Hungarian curd cheese), vanilla, and raisins. Found at every Hungarian cukrászda (patisserie) and sold warm every morning. Hungary's most beloved sweet pastry and the breakfast of choice for commuters across Budapest.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) puff pastry, thawed
- 1 egg beaten (egg wash)
- Icing sugar for dusting

FILLING

- 300g (1¼ cups) túró (Hungarian curd cheese)
- or well-drained ricotta
- 3 tbsp sour cream (tejföl)
- 4 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 egg yolk
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 80g (½ cup) raisins

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix túró, sour cream, sugar, vanilla, egg yolk, lemon zest, and raisins until combined. Taste — it should be sweet, lemony, and creamy.
2. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F). Line baking sheets.
3. Roll puff pastry to 3mm thick. Cut into 12cm (5-inch) squares.
4. Place 1.5 tbsp filling diagonally on each square.
5. Fold corners over to create an envelope shape, or simply fold in half diagonally to make a triangle. Press edges firmly.
6. Place on baking sheets. Brush with beaten egg wash.
7. Bake 18–20 minutes until deeply golden and puffed.
8. Cool 5 minutes. Dust with icing sugar.
9. Best eaten warm.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~260 per pastry

TIP

Hungarian túró has a drier, grainier texture than Italian ricotta. For the most authentic result, drain ricotta overnight through a fine sieve. The drier the filling, the better the pastry holds its shape.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hungarian] [Make-Ahead] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 210

■ ■ Hungary

TOJÁSRÁNTOTTA PAPRIKÁVAL

HUNGARIAN SCRAMBLED EGGS WITH PAPRIKA

Hungarian scrambled eggs — rántotta — are colored deep golden with sweet Hungarian paprika and enriched with tejföl (sour cream). Cooked in lard (not butter) in the traditional version, they are profoundly flavorful, distinctly Hungarian, and eaten with dark bread or a fresh breakfast roll.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp tejföl (sour cream) or crème fraîche
- 1 tbsp lard or unsalted butter
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 1 tsp sweet Hungarian paprika (Édes paprika)
- ¼ tsp hot Hungarian paprika (Erős paprika)
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped
- Dark bread or fresh rolls, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat lard in a skillet over medium heat. Add diced onion. Cook 5 minutes until soft and golden.
2. Add sweet and hot paprika. Stir 30 seconds — paprika fries briefly in the fat to develop depth and color. Do not burn it.
3. Beat eggs with tejföl, salt, and pepper.
4. Pour over the paprika onions.
5. Stir gently over medium-low heat until soft, slightly creamy curds form — 4–5 minutes.
6. Remove while still slightly underdone.
7. Scatter fresh parsley. Serve immediately with dark bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Frying the paprika briefly in hot fat for 30 seconds — called "red gold activation" — is the fundamental technique of Hungarian cooking. It releases the fat-soluble pigments and flavor compounds, creating a depth impossible to achieve by simply stirring cold paprika into a dish.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Hungarian] [Quick]

Hungary

RECIPE 211

■■ Hungary

POGÁCSA

HUNGARIAN SAVOURY SCONES

Pogácsa — small, flaky, savory Hungarian scones made with lard and sour cream — are eaten at breakfast, as snacks, and at every Hungarian gathering. The lard creates a distinctive tender, slightly flaky crumb unlike any butter scone. Sprinkled with cheese, sesame, or caraway, they are one of Hungary's most beloved baked goods.

INGREDIENTS

- 350g (2¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 150g (⅓ cup) lard (zsír) or cold butter (for a less authentic but acceptable substitute)
- 150ml (⅓ cup) sour cream (tejföl)
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 egg yolk
- TOPPING OPTIONS (choose one):
- Grated Edam or Parmesan
- Sesame seeds
- Caraway seeds
- Poppy seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Rub in cold lard until mixture resembles breadcrumbs.
2. Add sour cream and egg yolk. Mix into a soft, pliable dough. Do not overwork.
3. Wrap and refrigerate 30 minutes.
4. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
5. On a lightly floured surface, roll dough to 1.5–2cm thick.
6. Using a 5cm (2-inch) round cutter, cut out rounds. Collect scraps, re-roll, and cut again.
7. Criss-cross the top of each pogácsa with a knife.
8. Brush with beaten egg yolk. Sprinkle chosen topping.
9. Bake 18–22 minutes until golden and cooked through.
10. Cool 5 minutes. Eat warm or at room temperature.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min chilling · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 20 · Cal: ~145 per pogácsa

TIP

Lard is the traditional and superior fat for pogácsa — it creates a distinctive tender, slightly rich crumb that butter cannot replicate. Good-quality rendered pork lard is available at butchers and Eastern European delicatessens. Use it.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Hungarian] [Crowd-Pleaser]

RECIPE 212

■ ■ Hungary

KÖRÖZÖTT KENYÉREN

HUNGARIAN PAPRIKA CHEESE SPREAD ON BREAD

Körözött is Hungary's quintessential cheese spread — túró beaten with butter, sweet paprika, caraway seeds, and onion. Bright orange from the paprika, aromatic with caraway, and spread thickly on fresh white bread or pogácsa. Eaten at breakfast and as a snack throughout Hungary. Austria's Liptauer is its close cousin — both are magnificent.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (¾ cup) túró or ricotta (well-drained)
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 tsp sweet Hungarian paprika
- ½ tsp caraway seeds, lightly crushed
- 1 tsp mild mustard
- ½ small onion, very finely grated
- Salt and white pepper
- Fresh chives
- Sliced radishes and fresh bread for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat softened butter until light and creamy.
2. Add túró and beat until smooth and combined.
3. Add sweet paprika, caraway seeds, mustard, and grated onion.
4. Season with salt and white pepper.
5. Mix thoroughly until spread is uniform in color — it should be a bright, even orange.
6. Taste — adjust paprika and salt as needed.
7. Refrigerate 1 hour to meld flavors.
8. Serve spread thickly on fresh bread, topped with sliced radishes and chives.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr chilling · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Körözött must be seasoned very generously — túró is quite bland and absorbs flavors deeply. Season more aggressively than feels comfortable, then taste. Refrigerate and taste again — the flavors mellow slightly after chilling.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Low Carb] [Classic Hungarian] [Quick]

RECIPE 213

■ ■ Hungary

RÉTES ALMÁVAL

HUNGARIAN APPLE STRUDEL

Hungarian rétes — strudel — is the Hungarian interpretation of the Austro-Hungarian pastry tradition. Thin, hand-stretched dough wrapped around sweet-tart spiced apple and breadcrumbs, baked golden and served for breakfast warm with sour cream. In Hungary, rétes is eaten at all hours, but Sunday morning is sacred.

INGREDIENTS

STRUDEL DOUGH

- 250g (2 cups) bread flour
- 130ml (½ cup) warm water
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp white wine vinegar (for elasticity)

APPLE FILLING

- 800g (28 oz) tart apples, peeled, cored, thinly sliced
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 80g (½ cup) raisins
- 60g (¼ cup) breadcrumbs, toasted in butter
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted
- Icing sugar for serving
- Sour cream (tejföl) to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Knead flour, warm water, oil, salt, and vinegar 10 minutes until very smooth, elastic, and silky. The vinegar helps extensibility. Rest covered 30 minutes — essential.
2. FILLING: Mix apple slices, sugar, cinnamon, lemon zest, and raisins.
3. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
4. Lay a floured tablecloth on a large table. Roll dough, then stretch it by hand from the center outward until translucent — you should be able to read through it. It takes practice and confidence.
5. Brush stretched dough with melted butter. Scatter toasted breadcrumbs over one half.
6. Pile apple filling on the breadcrumb half.
7. Use the tablecloth to roll the strudel tightly.
8. Curve gently onto a buttered baking sheet. Brush with melted butter.
9. Bake 35–40 minutes until deeply golden.
10. Dust with icing sugar. Serve warm with tejföl.

Prep: 40 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The breadcrumbs toasted in butter are not decoration — they absorb apple juices during baking and prevent the bottom pastry from becoming soggy. They are essential. Use stale white breadcrumbs toasted until golden.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hungarian] [Weekend Project]

RECIPE 214

■■ Hungary (Transylvania)

KÜRT■SKALÁCS

HUNGARIAN CHIMNEY CAKE

Kürt■skalács — chimney cake — is a spit-roasted Hungarian sweet bread, wound around a cylinder, basted with sugar, and rotated over heat until the sugar caramelizes into a golden, crispy shell. The inside is soft and brioche-like; the outside crackles with caramelized sugar. A Transylvanian tradition now eaten across Hungary and Central Europe as the definitive festival food.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm milk
- 2 eggs
- 80g (6 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

COATING

- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 1 tbsp cinnamon
- 60g (4 tbsp) melted butter (for basting)
- Optional toppings: ground walnuts, desiccated coconut,
- cocoa powder

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk, eggs, vanilla, and butter in pieces. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic. Prove 1 hour.
2. Mix coating sugar with cinnamon in a flat tray.
3. Roll proved dough into a long thin rope.
4. Wind the rope tightly around a buttered cylindrical mold (a rolling pin wrapped in foil works for home).
5. Brush with melted butter. Roll in cinnamon sugar, pressing to adhere.
6. OVEN METHOD: Place on a baking rack over a tray. Bake at 200°C (390°F) for 20–25 minutes, turning the mold every 5 minutes to brown evenly.
7. While still hot, brush again with butter and roll in extra sugar.
8. Remove from mold immediately by twisting.
9. Eat warm — pull apart in rings.

Prep: 25 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The turning during baking is essential for even caramelization. Every side must face the heat source. In Hungary, proper *kürtőskalács* is cooked over charcoal on a rotating spit — the oven version is a worthy home adaptation but requires diligent turning.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hungarian] [Street Food] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 215

■ ■ Hungary

RAKOTT KRUMPLI REGGEL

HUNGARIAN LAYERED POTATO CASSEROLE

Rakott krumpli — layered potato bake with hard-boiled eggs, sour cream, and smoked sausage — is one of Hungary's great comfort dishes, equally at home at breakfast and dinner. Eaten warm in slices from the baking dish, it is a hearty, paprika-tinged, deeply satisfying Hungarian morning meal.

INGREDIENTS

- 800g (28 oz) waxy potatoes, boiled, cooled, sliced
- 5 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- 200g (7 oz) smoked Hungarian kolbász or chorizo, sliced
- 400g (1¾ cups) tejföl (sour cream)
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp butter (for the dish)
- Optional: grated cheese for the top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Butter a deep baking dish generously.
2. Mix tejföl with paprika, salt, and pepper.
3. FIRST LAYER: Arrange overlapping potato slices. Spread with ■ of paprika sour cream.
4. SECOND LAYER: Arrange egg slices over potato. Spread with another ■ of sour cream.
5. THIRD LAYER: Arrange sausage slices. Spread remaining sour cream over everything.
6. Dot with butter. Add grated cheese if using.
7. Bake uncovered 30–35 minutes until bubbling, golden, and fragrant.
8. Rest 5 minutes before serving from the dish.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

The potatoes must be fully cooled before layering — warm potatoes release moisture that makes the sour cream watery. Boil them the day before and refrigerate overnight for the cleanest slicing and best result.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Hungarian] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 216

■ ■ Czech Republic

CHLEBÍČEK

CZECH OPEN SANDWICHES

Chlebíček — the Czech open sandwich — is an art form. Small baguette slices topped with precise, elegant arrangements of ham, egg, cheese, vegetables, and potato salad. Eaten at every Czech celebration breakfast and sold in every Czech deli. The presentation is minimal but deliberate — each element has its place and purpose.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 French baguette, sliced into 1.5cm rounds
- 3 tbsp good unsalted butter, softened
- TOPPINGS (traditional Czech selection):
- 100g (3.5 oz) šunka (Czech cooked ham), rolled
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- 4 tbsp Czech potato salad (brambory salát)
- 50g (2 oz) Czech salami or Hermelín cheese
- Sliced gherkin (cornichon)
- 1 small tomato, sliced
- Mayonnaise
- Fresh parsley sprigs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spread butter on each baguette round.
2. TRADITIONAL ARRANGEMENTS — each chlebíček has ONE primary topping and 2–3 garnishes: VERSION A: Ham + egg slice + gherkin slice + parsley VERSION B: Potato salad + rolled ham + tomato + parsley VERSION C: Salami + egg + cornichon + parsley VERSION D: Hermelín cheese + gherkin + parsley
3. Arrange toppings attractively and neatly — presentation matters in Czech chlebíček culture.
4. Serve immediately on a plate or wooden board.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~280 per serving (3 chlebíky)

TIP

Czech chlebíky are always garnished with a fresh sprig of flat-leaf parsley — this is non-negotiable. It adds both color and a subtle herby freshness. Without parsley, it is simply bread with toppings. With parsley, it is a chlebíek.

[High Protein] [Classic Czech] [No-Cook] [Crowd-Pleaser]

Czech Republic

RECIPE 217

■ Czech Republic

ROHLÍKY S MÁSLEM A MEDEM

CZECH CRESCENT ROLLS WITH BUTTER AND HONEY

Rohlíky — the Czech crescent roll — is the country's most popular breakfast roll. Light, with a crispy thin crust and soft, airy interior, they are bought fresh from the pekárna (bakery) every morning and eaten with butter and local honey. Their distinctive crescent shape and scored top make them immediately recognizable across Central Europe.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil
- 1 egg beaten (egg wash)
- Caraway seeds (optional traditional topping)

FOR SERVING

- Good salted butter
- Czech wildflower honey or Bohemian forest honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide dough into 12 balls. Roll each ball into a triangle shape. Roll from the wide end to the tip.
4. Curve the ends slightly to form a crescent shape.
5. Place on lined baking sheets.
6. Prove 30 minutes until clearly puffed.
7. Brush with beaten egg wash.
8. Sprinkle caraway seeds if using.
9. Bake at 220°C (430°F) for 14–16 minutes until golden with a crispy thin crust.
10. Cool 5 minutes. Serve with cold butter and honey.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 16 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~185 per roll with butter

TIP

Rohlíky should have a thin, shatteringly crispy crust — achieved by the high oven temperature and a hot baking environment. For extra crispiness, place a small dish of hot water in the oven during the first 5 minutes of baking to create steam.

[Vegan] [Classic Czech] [Make-Ahead] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 218

■ Czech Republic

TVARHOVÉ LÍVANCE

CZECH QUARK PANCAKES

Czech lívance — thick, yeasted quark pancakes — are soft, golden, and slightly tangy from the tvaroh (Czech quark). Smaller and fluffier than American pancakes, they are served stacked with jam and sour cream. A beloved Czech weekend breakfast, they require patience but reward it generously.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (¾ cup) tvaroh or ricotta (well-drained)
- 200g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm milk
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 2 eggs, separated
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon
- Pinch of salt
- Butter for frying

FOR SERVING

- Smetana (Czech sour cream) or crème fraîche
- Strawberry or plum jam
- Powdered sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dissolve yeast in 3 tbsp of the warm milk with a pinch of sugar. Rest 10 minutes until foamy.
2. Beat tvaroh, remaining milk, egg yolks, sugar, vanilla, and lemon zest until smooth.
3. Add yeast mixture and flour. Mix until smooth. Cover and prove 45 minutes.
4. Whip egg whites with salt to firm peaks. Fold gently into proved batter.
5. Heat butter in a skillet over medium-low heat.
6. Drop tablespoon-sized rounds of batter. Cook 3 minutes until bubbles appear and edges set.
7. Flip carefully. Cook 2 minutes more.
8. Serve stacked with smetana, jam, and powdered sugar.

Prep: 15 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Czech tvaroh has a very dry, crumbly texture — much drier than Italian ricotta. Blend it briefly before using if very lumpy, or pass through a fine sieve for the smoothest livance. Drain ricotta well overnight for a good approximation.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Czech] [Weekend]

RECIPE 219

■ ■ Czech Republic

VEJCE NA HNÍZDEČKU

CZECH EGGS IN A BREAD NEST

A charming Czech breakfast — a thick slice of bread with the center pressed down to form a nest, butter rubbed in, and an egg cracked directly into the well, then baked until the white is set and yolk is perfectly runny. Simple, elegant, and deeply satisfying. Czech children's breakfast royalty.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices white bread or brioche
- (at least 3cm / 1.2-inch thick)
- 4 tbsp salted butter, softened
- 4 large eggs
- Salt and white pepper
- Fresh chives, chopped
- Optional: grated cheese to sprinkle on top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 190°C (375°F).
2. Lay bread slices on a lined baking sheet.
3. Using your fist or a small glass, press firmly in the center of each slice to create a deep well — leaving a border of bread around the edge.
4. Rub softened butter generously into the center well and all over the bread surface.
5. Crack one egg carefully into each bread well.
6. Season with salt and white pepper.
7. Sprinkle grated cheese over the egg if using.
8. Bake 12–15 minutes until egg whites are set but yolks remain runny.
9. Scatter fresh chives. Serve immediately on the baking sheet or transfer to plates.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 14 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~295 per serving

TIP

The well must be deep enough to contain the egg without it sliding off the bread. Press firmly and confidently. The border of bread crisps in the oven while the center becomes custardy from the egg — the textural contrast is the pleasure.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Czech] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 220

■ ■ Czech Republic

BUCHTY S POVIDLÝ

CZECH PLUM JAM BUNS

Buchty — soft Czech sweet buns baked tightly together, each one hiding a dark, intensely concentrated Czech povidla (plum jam) inside — are one of the great Central European breakfast bakes. Pull-apart, pillowy, and fragrant with vanilla and lemon, they are to Czech breakfast culture what cinnamon rolls are to American.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 80g (6 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 250ml (1 cup) warm milk
- 2 egg yolks
- 80g (6 tbsp) butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Zest of 1 lemon

FILLING AND ASSEMBLY

- 200g (¾ cup) Czech povidla (thick, dark, unsweetened
- plum jam) — or regular plum jam reduced to thicken
- 80g (6 tbsp) melted butter (for rolling)
- Icing sugar to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk, egg yolks, vanilla, and lemon zest. Knead 8 minutes. Add butter gradually. Knead 5 more minutes.
2. Prove 1.5 hours.
3. Melt butter in a 30x20cm baking dish.
4. Divide dough into 16 balls. Flatten each in your palm.
5. Place 1 tsp plum jam in the center of each.
6. Fold dough around the jam and seal firmly.
7. Roll each filled ball in melted butter to coat.
8. Arrange seam-side down, touching, in the buttered dish.
9. Prove 30–45 minutes until puffed and filling the dish.
10. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 28–32 minutes until deep golden.
11. Dust with icing sugar. Pull apart at the table.

Prep: 30 min + 2 hr proofing · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Czech povidla is not sweet jam — it is a deeply concentrated, tart, almost savory plum reduction cooked for hours without added sugar. This intensity contrasts with the sweet dough. Using regular sweet plum jam makes buchty acceptable. Using authentic povidla makes them extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Czech] [Make-Ahead] [Weekend]

RECIPE 221

■ ■ Czech Republic

ŠUNKOVÁ ROLKA

CZECH HAM ROLL WITH HORSERADISH

A simple Czech breakfast preparation — slices of good cooked ham rolled around a filling of cream cheese and freshly grated horseradish. Placed on buttered dark bread and garnished with chives and pickled cucumber. No cooking required. Elegant in its simplicity and bold in its flavors.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 large thin slices cooked Czech šunka (ham)
- 150g (¾ cup) cream cheese or tvaroh
- 2 tbsp freshly grated horseradish (křen)
- or prepared horseradish
- 1 tbsp fresh chives, snipped
- Salt and white pepper
- 4 slices dark Czech rye bread, buttered
- 4 cornichon pickles, sliced
- Radish slices for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix cream cheese with freshly grated horseradish, chives, salt, and white pepper. Taste — it should have a prominent horseradish kick.
2. Lay ham slices flat on a board.
3. Spread a thin layer of horseradish cream across each ham slice.
4. Roll each ham slice into a tight cylinder.
5. Butter dark rye bread.
6. Place 2 ham rolls on each bread slice.
7. Garnish with cornichon slices and radish.
8. Add a small mound of extra cream cheese on the side.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

Fresh horseradish root — grated just before serving — is dramatically more pungent and aromatic than prepared horseradish in a jar. Find fresh horseradish at farmers markets or Eastern European stores in autumn. Grate finely and use immediately before the volatile compounds dissipate.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Czech] [Quick]

RECIPE 222

■ ■ Czech Republic

ŽEMLOVKA

CZECH BREAD AND APPLE BAKE

Žemlovka is Czech stale bread pudding — layers of day-old rolls, sweetened apple, cinnamon, and a vanilla-egg custard baked until golden and set. Eaten warm for breakfast or as a sweet supper, it is one of Czech cuisine's most practical and comforting recipes. A masterpiece of turning leftover bread into something beautiful.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) day-old Czech rohlíky (crescent rolls)
- or white bread rolls, sliced
- 700g (25 oz) apples, peeled, cored, sliced thinly
- 80g (■ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- 100g (½ cup) raisins

EGG CUSTARD

- 3 large eggs
- 400ml (1■ cups) whole milk
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter (for the dish + dotting)
- Icing sugar for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F). Butter a deep baking dish generously.
2. Mix sliced apple with sugar, cinnamon, and raisins.
3. Whisk eggs, milk, sugar, and vanilla until smooth.
4. LAYER 1: Arrange bread slices in the dish, overlapping.
5. LAYER 2: Spread half the apple mixture over bread.
6. LAYER 3: Another layer of bread.
7. LAYER 4: Remaining apple mixture on top.
8. Pour custard mixture evenly over everything. Press bread down gently to help it absorb.
9. Rest 15 minutes for bread to soak up the custard.
10. Dot with butter. Bake 40–45 minutes until golden and set.
11. Cool slightly. Dust with icing sugar. Serve warm.

Prep: 20 min + 15 min soaking · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Day-old bread is essential — fresh bread does not absorb the custard properly and remains breadly and separate from the apple layers. Give stale bread 15 minutes to soak before baking, pressing it down gently to ensure full absorption.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Czech] [Make-Ahead] [Budget-Friendly]

ASIA

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Japan

RECIPE 223

■■ Japan

TRADITIONAL JAPANESE

The complete traditional Japanese breakfast set — ichiju sansai (one soup, three sides) — built around a bowl of short-grain rice. Miso soup, grilled salmon, tamagoyaki, pickled vegetables, and natto. Eaten mindfully, each component fulfilling a specific nutritional and aesthetic role. This is Japanese breakfast at its most authentic and most complete.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups Japanese short-grain rice, steamed
- Miso soup (see Recipe 224)
- 1 grilled salted salmon fillet (see Recipe 225)
- 1 serving tamagoyaki (see Recipe 226)
- 2 tbsp pickled vegetables (tsukemono):
 - — Pickled daikon (takuan), sliced
 - — Pickled cucumber or kimchi
- 1 pack natto (fermented soybeans) with
- soy sauce and mustard
- Green tea (hot, to accompany)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Start rice in a rice cooker or pot 30 minutes before eating.
2. Prepare each component in sequence.
3. ARRANGEMENT: Place rice bowl at center left. Miso soup at center right. Fish at back. Tamagoyaki at front right. Pickles at front left. Natto in a small dish to the side.
4. Serve green tea in a small separate cup.
5. Begin with a small sip of miso soup. Then alternate between rice, fish, and sides throughout the meal.
6. Itadakimasu (■■■■■■■) — said before eating in gratitude for the meal.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~580 per complete set

TIP

The Japanese breakfast is about balance — no single element dominates. Each item is consumed in small bites, alternating between savory, sweet, and sour throughout the meal. This approach makes even simple ingredients feel harmonious and complete.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Complete Meal]

RECIPE 224

■■ Japan

MISO SHIRU

JAPANESE MISO SOUP

Miso shiru is Japan's most essential breakfast — a warm, deeply umami broth of dashi and fermented soybean paste with silken tofu, wakame seaweed, and scallions. Drunk directly from the bowl without a spoon. Prepared in under 10 minutes and consumed at nearly every Japanese breakfast, every day, without exception.

INGREDIENTS

- 800ml (3■ cups) dashi stock (from kombu + katsuobushi, or from dashi powder)
- 3–4 tbsp white miso paste (shiro miso)
 - — or red miso (aka miso) for stronger flavor
- 150g (5 oz) silken tofu, cut into 1.5cm cubes
- 1 tbsp dried wakame seaweed
- 2 green onions (scallions), thinly sliced
- Optional: 1 small fresh mushroom, sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak dried wakame in cold water 5 minutes until rehydrated and bright green. Drain.
2. Bring dashi stock to just below a simmer — never a rolling boil.
3. Place miso paste in a ladle. Lower the ladle into the hot dashi. Use chopsticks to dissolve the miso through the ladle into the broth — this prevents miso lumps. Never add miso to boiling soup — it kills the beneficial bacteria.
4. Add silken tofu and wakame gently.
5. Heat over lowest heat 1–2 minutes until tofu is warmed through. Do not boil.
6. Divide into small bowls. Top with green onion.
7. Drink directly from the bowl, using chopsticks to guide the tofu.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~60 per bowl

TIP

Never boil miso soup after the miso is added. Miso contains live beneficial cultures (koji mold) that are destroyed above 60°C (140°F). Keep the heat very low after adding miso — just warm enough to heat the tofu. This is the single most important rule of miso soup.

[Vegan] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Quick]

RECIPE 225

■■ Japan

SHIOYAKI SAKE

SALT-GRILLED SALMON

The most fundamental Japanese breakfast fish — a salmon fillet liberally salted the night before, left to cure, then grilled at high heat until the skin is shatteringly crispy and the flesh is just cooked through. Served alongside rice and miso soup with grated daikon and a wedge of lemon. Japan's most beloved morning protein and a masterclass in simplicity.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 salmon fillets (skin-on, 150g each)
- 1 tsp fine sea salt per fillet
- Grated fresh daikon radish
- 1 lemon, cut into wedges
- Soy sauce for drizzling (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. NIGHT BEFORE: Pat salmon completely dry with paper towels. Salt generously on both sides — approximately 1 tsp total per fillet.
2. Place skin-side up on a rack over a plate. Refrigerate uncovered overnight (minimum 4 hours).
3. MORNING: Remove salmon from refrigerator. Pat dry again — the salt will have drawn out moisture.
4. Heat a grill pan, broiler, or fish grill to high heat.
5. Grill salmon skin-side up first, 4 minutes. Flip. Cook 3–4 minutes on the flesh side.
6. The skin should be deeply charred and crispy. The flesh should be just barely cooked through — slightly translucent at the very center.
7. Serve with grated daikon, lemon wedge, and rice.
8. A drizzle of soy sauce over the daikon adds a beautiful umami note.

Prep: 5 min + overnight salting · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~240 per fillet

TIP

Overnight salting is the key — it firms the flesh slightly, draws out moisture for crispier skin, and seasons the fish deeply throughout. A fillet salted one hour before cooking tastes completely different (and inferior) to one salted overnight. Plan ahead.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese]

RECIPE 226

■■ Japan

TAMAGOYAKI

JAPANESE ROLLED OMELETTE

Tamagoyaki — Japan's layered, rolled omelette — is cooked in a rectangular pan, building layer upon golden layer of sweetened, dashi-scented egg until a tight, cylindrical log forms. Sliced crosswise to reveal beautiful concentric rings, it is served at every Japanese breakfast table and in every bento box. The technique is simple once you understand it. The result is stunning.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp dashi stock (or water)
- 1 tbsp mirin
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- Neutral oil (vegetable or sesame) for the pan
- Grated fresh daikon, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, dashi, mirin, soy sauce, and sugar together thoroughly. Strain through a fine sieve for a perfectly smooth result.
2. Heat a tamagoyaki pan (rectangular) or a small non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Oil very lightly with a folded paper towel.
3. Pour ■ of the egg mixture into the pan, tilting to spread in a thin, even layer.
4. When the egg is 80% set but still slightly wet on top, begin rolling from the far edge toward you using chopsticks or a spatula.
5. Push the roll to the far edge. Re-oil the exposed pan surface lightly.
6. Pour in another ■ of the egg mixture, lifting the existing roll to allow raw egg to flow underneath.
7. When 80% set, roll the new egg layer over the existing roll — forward again.
8. Repeat with the final ■.
9. Shape the log in a bamboo sushi mat. Press firmly. Cool 2 minutes.
10. Slice crosswise into 3–4 rounds. Serve with grated daikon.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~180 per serving

TIP

The egg must be 80% set — not fully set — before rolling. Fully set egg tears and creates ugly gaps between layers. Slightly wet egg bonds to the next layer seamlessly. Trust this instruction and practice — the first attempt is rarely perfect. The tenth is magnificent.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese]

RECIPE 227

■■ Japan

ONIGIRI

JAPANESE RICE BALLS

Onigiri — hand-pressed rice triangles with fillings hidden inside, wrapped in crispy nori — are Japan's most beloved portable breakfast. Found at every convenience store (konbini) in Japan, purchased by millions daily, they represent Japan's genius for making simple food deeply satisfying. Homemade onigiri, with the warmth of freshly cooked rice, is incomparably better.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups Japanese short-grain rice, freshly cooked
- Fine sea salt (for hands)
- Water (for hands)
- FILLING OPTIONS (choose 1–2):
- Umeboshi (salted pickled plum) — most traditional
- Tuna mayonnaise: canned tuna + Kewpie mayo + soy
- Salmon: poached salmon flaked with soy and sesame
- Okaka: bonito flakes (katsubushi) with soy sauce
- Nori (toasted seaweed sheets), cut into strips

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Prepare your filling of choice.
2. Let freshly cooked rice cool slightly until it can be handled comfortably — 5 minutes.
3. Fill a small bowl with cold water. Wet your hands thoroughly.
4. Rub a generous pinch of fine salt evenly over your wet palms.
5. Take approximately 80g ($\frac{3}{4}$ cup loosely packed) of warm rice in one hand.
6. Make a dent in the center with your thumb. Place 1 tbsp filling in the dent.
7. Close the rice around the filling completely.
8. Using both hands, press and shape the rice firmly into a triangular shape. Apply even, firm pressure — the triangle must hold together. Rotate and re-press 4–5 times.
9. Wrap the base of the triangle with a strip of nori.
10. Eat immediately, or wrap in plastic and eat within 2–3 hours.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 30 min (rice) · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~185 per onigiri

TIP

The rice must be freshly cooked and still warm — cold rice does not stick properly and creates crumbly onigiri that falls apart. Salt your hands before every onigiri. If your onigiri are too soft, press more firmly. They should hold their shape with no support.

[Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Quick] [Portable]

RECIPE 228

■■ Japan

TAMAGO KAKE GOHAN (TKG)

RAW EGG ON RICE

Tamago kake gohan — raw egg beaten into steaming hot rice with a drizzle of soy sauce — is Japan's most minimalist breakfast. The heat of the rice partially cooks the egg into a silky, clinging custard that coats every grain. Three ingredients. Zero cooking. Infinite comfort. Japan has produced eggs specifically safe for raw consumption just for this dish since 1948.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 bowl freshly steamed hot Japanese short-grain rice
- (approximately 150g)
- 1 very fresh large egg
- 1 tbsp Japanese soy sauce (preferably tamari
- or a soy sauce specifically for TKG)
- ½ tsp sesame oil (optional)
- Toppings (optional):
- — Sliced green onion
- — Sesame seeds
- — Sheet of nori, torn into small pieces
- — Furikake rice seasoning
- — A tiny dab of mentaiko (spicy pollack roe)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Fill a bowl with freshly steamed hot rice. The rice must be very hot — if using leftover rice, reheat until steaming.
2. Create a small well in the center of the rice.
3. Crack the egg directly into the well.
4. Drizzle soy sauce over the egg.
5. Add sesame oil if using.
6. Stir vigorously with chopsticks — the heat of the rice gently cooks the egg white, creating a creamy, silky sauce that clings to the rice.
7. Top with green onion, sesame seeds, and nori.
8. Eat immediately, before the egg cools.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~290 per bowl

TIP

Use the absolute freshest egg available — ideally labeled safe for raw consumption. The yolk should be bright orange and stand tall when cracked. Old eggs have watery whites that don't create the same silky texture when stirred. TKG lives or dies by egg freshness.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Quick] [Low-Effort]

RECIPE 229

■■ Japan

OCHAZUKE

GREEN TEA POURED OVER RICE

Ochazuke — hot green tea or dashi poured directly over steamed rice with simple toppings — is the Japanese breakfast of minimal effort and maximum comfort. Used to warm cold leftover rice, or simply as a light, cleansing morning meal. Fragrant with green tea, brightened with pickled plum, and finished with wasabi — a bowl that takes 3 minutes and requires almost nothing.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 bowl cooked Japanese short-grain rice
- (150g — warm or leftover)
- 200ml (¾ cup) freshly brewed strong green tea
- (or dashi broth for richer flavor)
- TOPPINGS (traditional selection):
- 1 umeboshi (salted pickled plum)
- 1 sheet nori, torn into strips
- ½ tsp wasabi
- 1 tsp white sesame seeds
- Furikake seasoning
- 1 tbsp arare (small rice crackers, optional)
- 1 tsp soy sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew green tea strong (sencha or hojicha preferred) in water at 75°C — not boiling, as boiling water makes green tea bitter.
2. Place room-temperature or warm rice in a bowl.
3. Arrange toppings attractively on the rice: umeboshi in center, nori strips on the side, wasabi beside the plum.
4. Pour hot green tea slowly over the rice until the rice is submerged to about halfway.
5. Add soy sauce and sesame seeds.
6. Eat while still hot, using chopsticks to mix toppings into the rice as you eat.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 2 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~210 per bowl

TIP

Hojicha (roasted green tea) makes a nuttier, less astringent ochazuke than standard sencha. It pairs particularly well with salmon flakes or pickled ginger. For an even richer bowl, use hot dashi instead of tea — technically different but deeply satisfying.

[Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Japanese] [Low-Effort]

RECIPE 230

■■ Japan

NATTO GOHAN

FERMENTED SOYBEAN RICE

Natto — whole fermented soybeans with a pungent aroma, sticky texture, and intensely savory flavor — served over hot rice with raw egg yolk, Japanese mustard, and soy sauce. Deeply divisive even among Japanese people. Those who love it eat it daily. Those who don't respect it enormously anyway. One of the world's most nutritious fermented foods.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 pack natto (fermented soybeans, 45–50g)
- 1 bowl freshly steamed hot Japanese rice
- 1 egg yolk
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp karashi (Japanese mustard) or regular mustard
- Included tare sauce packet from natto package
- Toppings:
- — Sliced green onion
- — Nori strips
- — Sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Open natto pack. Using chopsticks, stir vigorously in circular motions 50 times — this develops the characteristic sticky strands and reportedly improves flavor. The more you stir, the stickier it becomes.
2. Add the included tare sauce and karashi. Stir 30 more times.
3. Place hot rice in a bowl.
4. Spoon stirred natto over the rice.
5. Make a small well in the natto. Place egg yolk inside.
6. Drizzle soy sauce around the edges.
7. Top with green onion, nori strips, and sesame seeds.
8. Eat by scooping rice and natto together — allow the strands to stretch dramatically. This is correct.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~310 per bowl

TIP

Stirring natto vigorously before eating is essential — not optional. The stirring creates glutamic acid through mechanical action, developing the umami flavor and characteristic strands simultaneously. 50 stirs is the traditional minimum. Don't skip this.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Fermented] [Quick]

RECIPE 231

■■ Japan

JAPANESE SOUFFLÉ PANCAKES

Japan's viral breakfast innovation — impossibly tall, jiggy, cloud-like pancakes that wobble when the plate is shaken. Made by folding stiffly beaten egg whites into a thin pancake batter and steam-cooking slowly in ring molds. Their extraordinary height and custardy interior are achieved through technique, not magic. Patience is the only special ingredient.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large eggs, separated (very important — must separate)
- 3 tbsp whole milk
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- 4 tbsp all-purpose flour, sifted
- ½ tsp baking powder
- ¼ tsp cream of tartar (helps stabilize whites)
- 2 tbsp sugar (added to egg whites)
- Neutral oil for greasing pan and ring molds

FOR SERVING

- Whipped cream
- Fresh seasonal fruit (strawberries, blueberries)
- Maple syrup or honey
- Icing sugar (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix egg yolks, milk, and vanilla until combined.
2. Sift flour and baking powder into the yolk mixture. Stir gently until smooth. Set aside.
3. Whip egg whites and cream of tartar in a clean bowl with an electric whisk until foamy. Add sugar gradually and continue whipping to very stiff, glossy peaks — the bowl can be turned upside down without the whites moving. This is the key step.
4. Fold ■ of egg whites into yolk mixture to lighten. Then fold in remaining whites very gently in two additions — use a large spatula, fold from the bottom, rotating the bowl. Preserve as much air as possible. Some white streaks are fine.
5. Heat a non-stick pan over very low heat (this is critical). Brush with oil. Place 2 greased ring molds (7cm / 3-inch diameter) in the pan.
6. Spoon batter generously into each mold — fill to just over the top (they will rise significantly).
7. Cover pan with a lid. Cook 5 minutes.
8. Carefully flip molds and pancakes together. Cover. Cook 4 more minutes.
9. Slide out of molds. Serve immediately.
10. Top with whipped cream, fresh fruit, and a dusting of icing sugar.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~270 per pancake

TIP

Very low heat is the absolute secret. If you hear sizzling, the heat is too high. These pancakes are steam-cooked from the inside out — the lid traps steam that cooks the interior gently while the base develops a pale golden crust. Too much heat burns the base before the inside is cooked. Go lower than you think necessary.

[Vegetarian] [Modern Japanese] [Special Occasion] [Weekend]

RECIPE 232

■■ Japan

KATSU SANDO

JAPANESE PORK CUTLET SANDWICH

Japan's perfect sandwich — a juicy, panko-crumbed pork cutlet inside pillowy milk bread (shokupan) with tonkatsu sauce and finely shredded cabbage. Sold at every Japanese convenience store, department store food hall, and sandwich shop as the undisputed king of the Japanese breakfast sandwich. Simple ingredients assembled with Japanese precision.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 pork loin cutlets (150g each, about 1.5cm thick)
- Salt and black pepper
- 3 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 2 eggs, beaten
- 100g (1¼ cups) panko breadcrumbs
- Vegetable oil for frying

FOR ASSEMBLY

- 4 slices Japanese milk bread (shokupan) —
- or any soft, pillowy white sandwich bread
- 4 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise
- 4 tbsp tonkatsu sauce (Bulldog brand is standard)
- 1 cup (80g) cabbage, very finely shredded

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pound pork cutlets to an even thickness using a meat mallet or rolling pin. Season with salt and black pepper on both sides.
2. Set up a breading station: flour, then beaten egg, then panko. Coat each cutlet in this order, pressing panko firmly to adhere.
3. Heat 2cm (¾ inch) of oil in a pan to 170°C (340°F).
4. Fry cutlets 3–4 minutes per side until deeply golden and cooked through. The panko should be an even, rich bronze color.
5. Rest on a rack 2 minutes.
6. Slice each cutlet into 2cm strips.
7. ASSEMBLE: Spread mayo on one bread slice, tonkatsu sauce on the other.
8. Layer shredded cabbage over the mayo.
9. Place sliced katsu on the cabbage.
10. Close sandwich. Press firmly. Using a very sharp knife, remove crusts and halve diagonally.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~620 per sandwich

TIP

Resting the katsu on a rack for 2 minutes before slicing keeps the crust crispy — cutting immediately traps steam and softens the breading. The combination of Kewpie mayo and tonkatsu sauce on opposite bread slices ensures every bite has both elements.

[High Protein] [Classic Japanese] [Convenience Store Icon]

RECIPE 233

■■ Japan

H■JICHA LATTE

ROASTED GREEN TEA LATTE

H■jicha — green tea roasted at high heat until it turns a deep reddish-brown — has a nutty, toasty, caramel-like flavor with lower caffeine than regular green tea. Blended with steamed milk into a warm latte, it is Japan's most comforting morning beverage and has become a global café sensation. Deep, warming, and entirely unlike standard tea.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp loose h■jicha tea leaves
- (or 2 h■jicha tea bags)
- 150ml (■ cup) water, just off the boil (90°C)
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk (or oat milk for a nuttier, dairy-free version)
- 1–2 tsp honey or sugar (to taste)
- Optional: ½ tsp matcha powder for a "dirty" version

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew h■jicha in hot water for 2–3 minutes. Strain into a cup or small saucepan. The tea should be a deep amber-brown color.
2. Heat milk in a small saucepan over medium heat until steaming. Do not boil.
3. Froth milk using a milk frother, hand whisk, or by shaking in a sealed jar.
4. Pour brewed h■jicha into a mug.
5. Add honey or sugar to the tea. Stir.
6. Pour steamed frothed milk over the tea, holding back the foam with a spoon.
7. Spoon foam on top.
8. Dust with extra h■jicha powder if available.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~95 per latte

TIP

H■jicha is roasted at extremely high temperatures (around 200°C), which reduces its caffeine content significantly — making it an excellent morning choice for those who are caffeine-sensitive. It is also soothing for the stomach and traditionally drunk after meals in Japan.

[Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [Low Caffeine] [Modern Japanese]

RECIPE 234

■■ Japan

YAKIMOCCHI

GRILLED RICE CAKES

Yakimochi — rice cakes grilled until puffed and charred, then brushed with soy sauce — are one of Japan's most primal and satisfying breakfast foods. The plain kirimochi (rectangular dried rice cakes) transform under heat, expanding dramatically, developing a charred, crispy exterior and a molten, chewy interior. Wrapped in nori with a brush of soy — extraordinary.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 kirimochi (packaged rectangular dried rice cakes)
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp mirin
- 1 tsp sugar
- 4 strips nori (toasted seaweed), cut to fit

OPTIONAL TOPPINGS

- Sweet red bean paste (anko)
- Kinako (roasted soybean powder) + sugar
- Soy sauce + sugar syrup (isobe-yaki style)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make the soy glaze: combine soy sauce, mirin, and sugar in a small saucepan. Warm until sugar dissolves and the glaze thickens very slightly. Set aside.
2. METHOD 1 (Toaster oven — recommended): Place mochi on a foil-lined tray. Toast at 200°C (390°F) for 8–10 minutes until puffed and golden, turning once.
3. METHOD 2 (Dry pan): Cook mochi in a dry non-stick pan over medium heat, lid on, 4–5 minutes per side until puffed and golden with char marks.
4. Brush grilled mochi generously with soy glaze. Return to heat briefly (30 seconds per side) to caramelize the glaze.
5. Wrap each mochi with a strip of nori.
6. Eat immediately — mochi firms quickly as it cools.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~190 per mochi

TIP

Mochi expands dramatically under heat — double its original volume sometimes. Leave space between pieces. The interior goes from solid to completely molten — bite carefully. New Year's in Japan sees thousands of elderly hospitalizations from mochi — chew thoroughly and eat slowly.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Quick]

RECIPE 235

■■ Japan

DORAYAKI

JAPANESE PANCAKE SANDWICHES

Dorayaki — two fluffy, honey-scented pancakes sandwiching a generous layer of sweet red bean paste — is one of Japan's most beloved confections, famously associated with the cartoon character Doraemon. Eaten as a breakfast snack with green tea, the combination of soft, honey-flavored cake and earthy sweet bean is deeply satisfying and completely Japanese.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PANCAKES

- 2 large eggs
- 80g (■ cup) sugar
- 1 tbsp honey
- 1 tsp mirin
- 120g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 2–3 tbsp water (to adjust consistency)

FILLING

- 200g (¾ cup) sweet red bean paste (anko —
- tsubu-an for chunky, koshi-an for smooth)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs, sugar, honey, and mirin together until pale and slightly thickened — 2 minutes.
2. Sift flour and baking powder over the egg mixture. Fold gently until just combined.
3. Add water tablespoon by tablespoon until batter is the consistency of thick cream — it should flow slowly from a spoon.
4. Rest batter 15 minutes — allows flour to fully hydrate and baking powder to activate.
5. Heat a non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Lightly oil with a paper towel.
6. Pour a small ladle of batter to form a 10cm (4-inch) round circle. Do not spread.
7. Cook until bubbles cover the entire surface and edges look dry — about 1.5 minutes.
8. Flip carefully. Cook 30 seconds more.
9. The pancakes should be pale bronze — not golden brown. Adjust heat if they color too fast.
10. Sandwich two pancakes with 2 tbsp anko between. Press gently. Serve with green tea.

Prep: 10 min + 15 min rest · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~195 per dorayaki

TIP

Mirin in the batter is the traditional touch — it adds a subtle savory depth and beautiful color to the pancakes. Do not substitute with more sugar. The mirin is what makes dorayaki taste distinctly Japanese rather than generically sweet.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Japanese] [Make-Ahead] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 236

■ ■ Japan

OKAYU

JAPANESE RICE PORRIDGE

Okayu is Japan's healing breakfast — rice cooked in a very high water ratio (1:7 or 1:10) until the grains dissolve into a silky, congee-like porridge. Eaten when ill, when recovering, or simply when a gentle, nourishing breakfast is needed. Topped with umeboshi, sesame, and nori, it is profoundly comforting and deeply Japanese in its quiet restraint.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup Japanese short-grain rice, washed
- 1L (4 cups) water or light dashi stock
- ½ tsp salt

TOPPINGS

- 1 umeboshi (pickled plum), pitted
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- Nori strips, torn
- Sliced green onion
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- A few drops sesame oil
- Optional: soft-boiled egg, sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine washed rice and water (or dashi) in a medium saucepan with salt.
2. Bring to a boil over medium heat, stirring once.
3. Reduce heat to very low. Cover with a lid slightly ajar (to prevent boil-over).
4. Cook 45–50 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice has completely broken down into a smooth, creamy porridge. It should be significantly thinner than Western porridge — almost soup-like.
5. Adjust consistency with hot water if needed.
6. Season with salt.
7. Ladle into bowls. Top with umeboshi, nori, green onion, and sesame seeds.
8. Drizzle a little soy sauce and sesame oil.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~175 per bowl

TIP

Okayu is traditionally made with a 1:7 ratio (rice to water) for standard texture, or 1:10 for a very thin, soupy consistency traditional for the very young or unwell. The correct texture should pour slowly from a ladle rather than drop in globs.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Healing] [High Fiber]

RECIPE 237

■■ Japan

TSUKEMONO

JAPANESE QUICK PICKLES

Tsukemono — Japanese pickled vegetables — are an essential component of the traditional Japanese breakfast table. Quick- pickled cucumber, daikon, and carrot in a light vinegar or salt brine provide a crunchy, bright counterpoint to the richness of rice and fish. Made in minutes, ready in an hour, they elevate every Japanese breakfast from adequate to complete.

INGREDIENTS

- QUICK SALT PICKLES (Asazuke):
- 1 Japanese or regular cucumber, thinly sliced
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- ½ tsp rice vinegar
- A few drops sesame oil
- Optional: thin slices of fresh ginger
- DAIKON PICKLES (Quick Takuan):
- 200g (7 oz) daikon radish, peeled and thinly sliced
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp rice vinegar
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp turmeric (for color)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CUCUMBER PICKLES:
2. Sprinkle salt over cucumber slices. Massage gently.
3. Rest 20–30 minutes until cucumber releases water.
4. Squeeze out excess liquid firmly.
5. Toss with sesame seeds, rice vinegar, sesame oil, and ginger slices.
6. Taste — adjust salt and vinegar as needed.
7. Serve immediately or refrigerate up to 3 days. DAIKON PICKLES:
8. Toss daikon slices with salt. Rest 30 minutes.
9. Squeeze out liquid firmly.
10. Whisk rice vinegar, sugar, and turmeric until sugar dissolves.
11. Toss daikon with the vinegar mixture.
12. Ready in 1 hour. Keeps refrigerated 1 week.

Prep: 15 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~35 per serving

TIP

The salt massage and squeeze for both pickles is essential — it removes bitterness, softens the texture slightly while maintaining crunch, and creates space for the pickle brine to penetrate deeply. Never skip the squeeze.

[Vegan] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Japanese]

RECIPE 238

■■ Japan

JAPANESE EGG SANDWICH

TAMAGO SANDO

The tamago sando — Japan's iconic egg salad sandwich — is a masterclass in simplicity. Creamy, generously seasoned egg salad made with Kewpie mayonnaise, sandwiched between crustless, pillowy Japanese milk bread (shokupan). Found at every Japanese convenience store and sold millions of times daily. The humble egg salad sandwich elevated to an art form through quality of ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs, hard-boiled (7 minutes for a slightly jammy center — the Japanese preferred method)
- 3 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise (essential — not regular mayo)
- 1 tsp Dijon mustard
- Salt and white pepper
- 4 slices Japanese milk bread (shokupan), crusts removed
- — or any soft white sandwich bread

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Hard-boil eggs: bring water to boil, lower eggs, cook 7 minutes for slightly jammy center or 10 minutes for fully set. Transfer immediately to ice water. Peel when cool.
2. SEPARATE METHOD: slice 2 eggs into thin rounds. Mash remaining 2 eggs with Kewpie mayo, mustard, salt, and white pepper until creamy but with some texture remaining.
3. Spread mashed egg mixture generously on 2 bread slices.
4. Lay sliced egg rounds neatly on the egg salad, creating a beautiful cross-section when cut.
5. Close sandwiches. Press firmly.
6. Using a very sharp knife in one clean motion, cut diagonally. The cut reveals the beautiful egg cross-section.
7. Serve immediately or wrap in plastic for 30 minutes (the Japanese convenience store approach — the bread softens slightly and becomes better).

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per sandwich

TIP

Kewpie mayonnaise is the non-negotiable ingredient — its higher egg yolk content, rice vinegar acidity, and MSG depth create a completely different flavor profile from Western mayo. Using regular mayo creates a good egg sandwich. Kewpie creates a tamago sando.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Japanese] [Convenience Store Icon]

RECIPE 239

■ ■ Japan

DASHIMAKI TAMAGO

DASHI-ROLLED OMELETTE — REFINED VERSION

The more refined, dashi-forward version of tamagoyaki — made with more dashi and less sugar, creating a savory, trembling rolled omelette with a custardy center that barely holds its shape when sliced. The signature dish of traditional Japanese sushi restaurants served at their morning kaiseki breakfasts, and the standard by which Japanese chefs are judged.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 80ml (■ cup) dashi stock (ichiban dashi — first brew)
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce (usukuchi)
- 1 tsp mirin
- ½ tsp salt
- Neutral oil for cooking
- Grated daikon, ponzu sauce, and shiso leaf to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, dashi, soy sauce, mirin, and salt together thoroughly. Strain through a fine mesh sieve. The higher dashi ratio creates a softer, more custard-like result than standard tamagoyaki.
2. Heat tamagoyaki pan over medium-low heat. Very lightly oil with a paper towel.
3. Pour ¼ of the egg mixture into the pan. Swirl to spread evenly in a thin layer.
4. When the surface is just barely set (still wet on top), roll from the far end toward you — gently. The roll will be very soft and delicate.
5. Push to the far end. Re-oil pan lightly.
6. Pour another ¼ of the mixture, lifting the roll to allow egg to flow underneath.
7. When barely set, roll forward again onto the previous roll. Repeat with remaining batter.
8. Place the roll on a bamboo mat. Roll tightly. Rest 3 minutes to set shape.
9. Slice into 3cm rounds.
10. Serve with grated daikon, ponzu, and shiso.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~175 per serving

TIP

More dashi = softer, more delicate omelette. This version is harder to roll than the sweeter tamagoyaki because the high liquid content makes each layer very fragile. Cook on lower heat than you think necessary and move with patience and confidence.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Advanced]

RECIPE 240

■■ Japan

SAKURA MOCHI

CHERRY BLOSSOM RICE CAKE

A cherry blossom season specialty — pink-tinted glutinous rice steamed around sweet red bean paste, wrapped in a salt-preserved cherry blossom leaf. The leaf imparts a faint, delicately floral and salty note to the sweet mochi. Eaten at hanami (flower-viewing) picnics as a breakfast sweet and sold at Japanese confectioneries throughout spring. Extraordinarily beautiful and subtly flavored.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1 cup) glutinous rice (or 150g domyoji)
- — coarser ground glutinous rice, traditional)
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp red food coloring or a few drops beetroot juice
- (for the pink color)
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 150g (½ cup) sweet red bean paste (anko)
- 8 salt-preserved cherry blossom leaves
- (sakura no ha — rinse and pat dry before using)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse salt-preserved leaves. Soak in water 15 minutes to remove excess salt. Pat dry.
2. Rinse glutinous rice. Soak 1 hour.
3. Drain and steam rice 20 minutes until just cooked.
4. While still hot, mix in sugar and a few drops of food coloring or beetroot juice until evenly pink.
5. Divide rice into 8 portions (approximately 50g each).
6. Wet your hands. Flatten each portion into an oval.
7. Place 1–2 tbsp anko in the center.
8. Fold rice around the filling, sealing completely. Shape into an oval log.
9. Wrap each rice cake in a prepared cherry blossom leaf, pressing the leaf gently to adhere.
10. Serve at room temperature. Eat the entire thing — leaf and all — or unwrap as preferred.

Prep: 20 min + 1 hr soaking · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~140 per mochi

TIP

Salt-preserved sakura leaves are available at Japanese grocery stores and online. The salt brine gives them a unique floral-saline character that cannot be replicated with fresh cherry leaves. Do not skip the soaking step — excess salt overwhelms the mochi.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Seasonal] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 241

■■ Japan

Y■KAN WITH MATCHA

SWEET RED BEAN JELLY WITH GREEN TEA

Y■kan — firm, glossy, deeply sweet red bean jelly — is Japan's most traditional confection, eaten in thin slices alongside a bowl of bitter matcha tea for breakfast. The combination of intensely sweet anko jelly and bitter frothy matcha creates a perfect counterbalance that Japanese aesthetics call "hikitatsu" — making each element shine through contrast.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE YOKAN

- 300g (1¼ cups) sweet red bean paste (anko)
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 3g (1½ tsp) agar-agar powder
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp kuzu starch dissolved in 2 tbsp cold water
- (optional — for extra glossiness)

FOR MATCHA TEA

- 1 tsp ceremonial grade matcha powder
- 80ml (⅓ cup) hot water at 75°C
- Optional: 1 tbsp hot water for making a paste first

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Y■KAN:** Combine water, agar-agar, and sugar in a saucepan. Bring to a boil, stirring.
2. Simmer 2 minutes until agar-agar is fully dissolved.
3. Add anko. Stir until smooth and combined.
4. Add dissolved kuzu if using. Cook 1 minute more.
5. Pour into a rectangular mold (a loaf tin works).
6. Cool to room temperature then refrigerate 2+ hours until firm and sliceable.
7. **MATCHA:** Sift matcha into a small bowl. Add a few drops of hot water. Mix to a smooth paste.
8. Add remaining hot water. Whisk in a zigzag motion with a chasen (bamboo whisk) or small regular whisk until frothy.
9. Slice cold y■kan thinly (about 1cm).
10. Serve 2 slices alongside the matcha tea.

Prep: 10 min + 2 hr setting · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~145 per serving

TIP

Ceremonial grade matcha is brighter green, less bitter, and smoother than culinary grade. For drinking, it makes a significant difference. The water temperature must be around 75°C — boiling water scalds matcha and creates a harsh, vegetal bitterness.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Make-Ahead] [Cultural]

RECIPE 242

■ ■ Japan

COLD BREW KYOTO COFFEE

Japan's Kyoto-style cold brew coffee — steeped in cold water for 12–24 hours in a slow drip method — produces a coffee of extraordinary smoothness, sweetness, and complexity with zero bitterness. The Japanese cold brew method is widely considered the world's finest. Drunk black over ice, it requires nothing added — it is already perfect.

INGREDIENTS

- 60g (4 tbsp) high-quality medium-dark roast coffee,
- coarsely ground (single origin preferred)
- 500ml (2 cups) cold filtered water
- Ice for serving
- Optional: a thin strip of lemon peel

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine coarsely ground coffee with cold filtered water. Stir gently to ensure all grounds are moistened.
2. Cover and refrigerate 18–24 hours. Do not shake or stir during steeping.
3. Strain slowly through a coffee filter in a fine mesh sieve. Do not press the grounds — let gravity do the work. Pressing extracts bitterness.
4. The result should be a very dark, deeply concentrated cold brew.
5. To serve: fill a glass with ice. Pour cold brew over ice — approximately 100ml coffee per serving, diluted with 50–80ml cold water to taste.
6. Add a strip of lemon peel for a subtle citrus note.
7. Drink without milk or sugar — the natural sweetness of properly cold-brewed coffee needs nothing added.

Prep: 5 min + 18-24 hr steeping · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~5 per serving (black)

TIP

Grind size matters enormously for cold brew. Too fine creates over-extraction and bitterness. Too coarse produces weak, watery coffee. Aim for a grind slightly coarser than drip coffee — a coarse sea salt consistency. A good burr grinder makes this achievable.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Make-Ahead] [Modern Japanese] [Low Effort]

China

RECIPE 243

■■ Japan

ANPAN

JAPANESE RED BEAN BUN

Anpan — soft, enriched bread buns filled with sweet red bean paste — were created in 1875 by Kimuraya Bakery in Tokyo and presented to Emperor Meiji. Japan's first Western-style bread became immediately beloved and has been eaten for breakfast every day since. A sesame seed on top marks the belly button of the bun. It is Japan's version of the pastry — and it is perfect.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 40g (3 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 1 egg
- 40g (3 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened

FILLING

- 200g (¾ cup) tsubu-an (chunky sweet red bean paste)
- or koshi-an (smooth) — your preference

TOPPING

- 1 egg beaten (egg wash)
- Black sesame seeds (for the "navel")
- White sesame seeds (alternative)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and egg. Knead 8 minutes.
2. Add softened butter in pieces. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth, elastic, and pulls cleanly from bowl.
3. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
4. Divide into 10 equal pieces. Roll each into a ball.
5. Flatten each ball in your palm to a circle.
6. Place 1.5 tbsp anko filling in the center.
7. Gather edges of dough and pinch firmly closed — like closing a purse. Seal completely. No gaps.
8. Place seam-side down on lined baking trays.
9. Prove 30–40 minutes until noticeably puffed.
10. Brush very gently with egg wash.
11. Place 5–6 black sesame seeds in the exact center of each bun — the traditional "navel" marking.
12. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 14–16 minutes until pale golden (not dark — anpan should be soft).
13. Cool on a rack. Best eaten same day.

Prep: 25 min + 1.5 hr proofing · Cook: 16 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~235 per bun

TIP

The filling must be in the center and fully sealed — any gap in the dough allows anko to bubble out during baking and creates a messy, sticky result. Pinch the seam with conviction. Wet fingertips help the dough seal more reliably.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Japanese] [Make-Ahead] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 244

■■ Japan

KOROKKE PAN

JAPANESE CROQUETTE BREAD

A beloved Japanese bakery breakfast — a soft, pillowy bread roll stuffed with a crispy panko-coated potato croquette (korokke), drizzled with tonkatsu sauce and shredded cabbage inside. Sold warm from the oven at every Japanese bakery and eaten standing at the counter. Japan's most satisfying portable breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE KOROKKE

- 400g (14 oz) potatoes, boiled and mashed
- 150g (5 oz) minced pork
- 1 small onion, finely diced, sautéed
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- Salt, pepper, and nutmeg
- Flour, beaten egg, panko — for breading
- Oil for frying

FOR ASSEMBLY

- 4 soft Japanese dinner rolls or milk buns
- 4 tbsp tonkatsu sauce
- 2 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise
- 1 cup finely shredded cabbage

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KOROKKE: Mix mashed potato with sautéed onion, cooked minced pork, soy sauce, salt, pepper, and nutmeg. Cool.
2. Shape into ovals (one per roll).
3. Bread in order: flour → beaten egg → panko. Press panko firmly.
4. Deep fry at 170°C (340°F) for 3 minutes until deep golden. Drain on rack.
5. Split rolls without cutting all the way through.
6. Spread mayo on one side, tonkatsu sauce on the other.
7. Add shredded cabbage inside.
8. Place a hot korokke inside the roll.
9. Serve immediately — the croquette's heat warms the bread and softens it perfectly.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per roll

TIP

The korokke must be served immediately after frying inside the bread — a cold korokke in bread is a disappointing experience. Japanese bakeries fry korokke in batches throughout the morning to ensure freshness. Time your frying to coincide with serving.

[High Protein] [Classic Japanese] [Street Food] [Bakery Icon]

RECIPE 245

■■ Japan

WARABI MOCHI

BRACKEN STARCH JELLY WITH KINAKO

Warabi mochi — a trembling, translucent jelly made from bracken fern starch, served coated in kinako (roasted soybean flour) and drizzled with dark kuromitsu (black sugar syrup) — is Kyoto's most beloved summer confection but eaten year-round as a breakfast sweet. It has the most unusual, ethereal texture in Japanese cuisine — between jello and cloud.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) warabimochiko
- (bracken starch) — or potato starch as substitute
- 500ml (2 cups) cold water
- 50g (¼ cup) sugar

FOR SERVING

- 4 tbsp kinako (roasted soybean flour)
- 2 tbsp sugar (mixed with kinako)
- Kuromitsu (black sugar syrup):
 - — 50g (¼ cup) Okinawan black sugar (kokuto) or
 - dark muscovado sugar
 - — 50ml (3½ tbsp) water — simmer 5 min until syrupy

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KUROMITSU: Dissolve black sugar in water over medium heat. Simmer 5 minutes until slightly syrupy. Cool.
2. MOCHI: Whisk warabimochiko, water, and sugar in a saucepan until no lumps remain.
3. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly with a silicone spatula. It will begin to thicken.
4. Continue stirring vigorously as it thickens. When it becomes very thick, translucent, and glossy (about 10–12 minutes), remove from heat.
5. Pour into a wet, flat container. Spread evenly.
6. Cool to room temperature. Then refrigerate 1 hour.
7. Cut into cubes using a wet knife or wet spoon.
8. Roll cubes in kinako-sugar mixture.
9. Arrange on a plate. Drizzle kuromitsu over.
10. Serve cold — warabi mochi must be eaten the same day it is made. It loses its texture after 24 hours.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr chilling · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~185 per serving

TIP

Warabi mochi cannot be made ahead more than one day — it retrogrades (hardens and loses its texture). Make it, coat it in kinako, serve it within hours. The kinako coating also prevents the pieces from sticking together when arranged on a plate.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Japanese] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 246

■■ China

ZHOU / CONGEE

CHINESE RICE PORRIDGE

Zhou — Chinese congee — is a silky, slow-cooked rice porridge that forms the foundation of breakfast across southern and central China. Unlike Japanese okayu, Chinese congee is cooked in chicken or pork broth and served with an elaborate array of toppings. The rice should be completely dissolved — each bowl a smooth, nourishing canvas for whatever the morning requires.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup jasmine rice (not short grain — long grain gives
- better texture in Chinese congee)
- 1.5L (6 cups) light chicken or pork bone broth
- 2cm piece fresh ginger, thinly sliced
- 1 tsp salt
- TOPPING OPTIONS (arrange all on a board):
- Century egg (pi dan), sliced
- Sliced pork meatballs or thin pork slices
- Fried you tiao (Chinese dough sticks), pieces
- Sesame oil drizzle
- Soy sauce
- White pepper
- Sliced green onions
- Chili oil
- Fried shallots
- Grated fresh ginger

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse rice well. Soak in cold water 30 minutes — this speeds breakdown.
2. Bring broth to a boil in a large pot with ginger.
3. Add drained rice. Bring back to a boil.
4. Reduce heat to very low. Cover loosely — leave a gap to prevent overflow.
5. Cook 45–60 minutes, stirring every 15 minutes, until rice has completely disintegrated and the congee is smooth, creamy, and silky.
6. Season with salt.
7. Serve in deep bowls with all toppings arranged beside them. Each person tops their own.

Prep: 5 min + 30 min soaking · Cook: 60 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~195 per bowl (without toppings)

TIP

The 1:12 ratio (rice to liquid) is the key to proper Chinese congee. Too little liquid produces a thick, stodgy result. The finished congee should be pourable — thinner than Western porridge — and completely smooth with no visible grain texture.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein option] [Classic Chinese] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 247

■■ China (Beijing / Tianjin)

JIAN BING GUOZI

CHINESE STREET CRÊPE

Jian bing guozi — China's most beloved street breakfast crêpe — is a daily ritual for millions of Beijingers. A thin mung bean crêpe cooked on a flat griddle, spread with beaten egg, scallions, and sesame seeds, slathered with hoisin and chili bean paste, then wrapped around a crispy fried cracker (guozi) for crunch. Assembled in 90 seconds by street vendors who have perfected it over decades.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE CRÊPE BATTER:
 - 100g (¾ cup) mung bean flour (lùdou fen)
 - 50g (½ cup) all-purpose flour
 - 300ml (1¼ cups) cold water
 - ½ tsp salt
- PER CRÊPE:
 - 1 large egg, beaten
 - 1 tbsp sesame seeds
 - 2 tbsp sliced green onions (scallions)
- SAUCE (per crêpe):
 - 1 tbsp hoisin sauce
 - 1 tsp sweet bean paste (tianmian jiang)
 - ½ tsp chili bean paste (doubanjiang) — or to taste

FILLING

- 1 Chinese fried cracker (baocui, guozi,
or wonton wrapper fried flat — see tip)
- Optional: sliced lettuce, pickled vegetables

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk mung bean flour, all-purpose flour, water, and salt until completely smooth. Rest 15 minutes.
2. Heat a flat griddle or large non-stick pan over medium-high heat. Brush very lightly with oil.
3. Pour a thin ladleful of batter and spread immediately in a large thin circle (30cm).
4. After 30 seconds, when the surface starts to dry, pour beaten egg over the entire surface. Spread with the back of a spoon.
5. Sprinkle sesame seeds and green onions over the egg.
6. After 1 minute, when egg is set, flip the entire crêpe.
7. Work quickly on the bottom side: — Spread hoisin, sweet bean paste, and chili paste over the now-upward surface. — Place crispy cracker on the center. — Add lettuce or pickled vegetables if using.
8. Fold the sides in, then roll or fold the crêpe around the cracker into a rectangle.
9. Cut in half. Serve immediately, wrapped in paper.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 3 min per crêpe · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per crêpe

TIP

The crispy cracker (guozi) inside creates the essential crunch that makes jian bing extraordinary. At home, fry a wonton wrapper flat in oil until golden and crispy — it replicates the function perfectly. The contrasting textures (crispy cracker + soft crêpe) define the eating experience.

[Vegan option] [Classic Chinese] [Street Food] [Quick]

RECIPE 248

■■ China

YOU TIAO

CHINESE FRIED DOUGH STICKS

You tiao — long, golden, airy fried dough sticks — are eaten for breakfast across China, dunked in warm soy milk, tucked inside congee, or wrapped in rice noodle rolls. Made with minimal ingredients and a crucial overnight rest, they puff dramatically in hot oil into light, crispy, hollow tubes. One of China's most ancient street foods, unchanged since the Song dynasty.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp neutral oil
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and sugar. Add oil and warm water.
2. Mix into a shaggy dough. Knead briefly — just until it comes together (3 minutes).
3. Coat the dough in oil. Cover tightly.
4. Rest at room temperature 4 hours minimum, or refrigerate overnight. This rest is essential — the gluten must relax completely for the dough to stretch without snapping back.
5. NEXT MORNING: Turn rested dough onto an oiled surface. Roll gently to 1cm thick. Cut into 3cm wide strips.
6. Stack two strips on top of each other. Press a chopstick or dowel firmly down the center, lengthwise, to join the two layers.
7. Gently stretch each piece to 25cm length.
8. Heat oil to 190°C (375°F) in a deep pan or wok.
9. Slip stretched dough into the hot oil. Using chopsticks, flip and rotate continuously.
10. Fry 2–3 minutes until puffed, golden, and airy — they should increase 3–4x in volume.
11. Drain. Eat immediately.

Prep: 10 min + overnight rest · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~230 per stick

TIP

The double-layer + chopstick press technique forces the two strips to cook as one unit while a steam channel forms through the center — this is what creates the characteristic hollow interior. Single layers never hollow out the same way. The technique is the secret.

[Vegan] [Classic Chinese] [Street Food] [Make-Ahead (dough)]

RECIPE 249

■ ■ China (Shanghai / Suzhou)

DOU JIANG

CHINESE WARM SOY MILK

Dou jiang — freshly made warm soy milk — has been the breakfast drink of eastern China for over 2,000 years. Served sweet (tian dou jiang) or savory (xian dou jiang, with vinegar and soy), it is drunk with you tiao for dunking. Freshly made dou jiang has an incomparably creamy, clean, grassy flavor that carton soy milk cannot approach.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1 cup) dried soybeans
- 1.5L (6 cups) water (for blending)
- Additional water for soaking

FOR SWEET DOU JIANG

- 2–3 tbsp sugar (or rock sugar)
- Optional: pandan leaf during cooking
- FOR SAVORY DOU JIANG (Xian Dou Jiang):
- 2 tbsp rice vinegar or black vinegar
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- Dried shrimp (optional)
- Sesame oil
- You tiao pieces, cut small
- Sliced green onion
- Chili oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak soybeans in plenty of cold water overnight or for minimum 8 hours. They will triple in size.
2. Drain soybeans. Place in a blender with 750ml of the fresh water.
3. Blend on highest speed 2–3 minutes until very smooth.
4. Strain through a fine cheesecloth or nut milk bag. Squeeze every drop of liquid from the pulp.
5. Combine strained soy liquid with remaining 750ml water in a saucepan.
6. Bring to a simmer over medium heat, stirring. The foam that rises must be skimmed.
7. Simmer 10 minutes — raw soybeans contain anti-nutrients that must be deactivated by cooking.
8. FOR SWEET: Add sugar; stir until dissolved. Serve hot in bowls.
9. FOR SAVORY: Pour vinegar into a bowl. Pour hot soy milk over — it will partially curdle into silken curds. Top with soy sauce, sesame oil, you tiao, green onion, and chili oil.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soak · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~110 per bowl (sweet)

TIP

The vinegar in savory dou jiang must be added to the bowl first, then the hot soy milk poured over — never the other way around. The heat of the soy milk and the acidity of the vinegar together create the characteristic silken curds. Reversing the order creates flat, un-curdled soup.

[Vegan] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Chinese] [Ancient Recipe]

RECIPE 250

■■ China (Shanghai)

XIAOLONGBAO

SHANGHAI SOUP DUMPLINGS

Shanghai's most famous contribution to food culture — translucent thin-skinned dumplings filled with pork and a pool of savory soup that forms from jellied stock dissolved by steam. Eaten for breakfast at every xiaolongbao specialist in Shanghai since the 19th century. The technique of creating soup inside a dumpling by adding jellied stock to the filling is one of China's greatest culinary innovations.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE JELLIED STOCK (make day before):
- 500g (18 oz) pork bones and skin
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 2 tbsp Shaoxing wine
- 2 slices fresh ginger
- 2 green onions
- Soy sauce and salt

FOR THE DUMPLING SKIN

- 250g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 130ml (½ cup) boiling water
- Pinch of salt

FOR THE FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) minced pork (not too lean — fat matters)
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp Shaoxing rice wine
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 2 green onions, finely sliced
- 150g (⅓ cup) jellied pork stock, cut into cubes
- Salt and white pepper
- Dipping sauce: black vinegar + julienned fresh ginger

INSTRUCTIONS

1. JELLIED STOCK (day before): Simmer all stock ingredients 3–4 hours until very reduced. Strain into a shallow container. Refrigerate overnight until set firm (like pork Jell-O).
2. FILLING: Mix minced pork with all seasonings. Add cold jellied stock cubes — they will melt into soup during steaming. Mix gently. Refrigerate until needed.
3. DOUGH: Pour boiling water over flour and salt. Mix immediately with chopsticks. Knead 5 minutes until smooth. Cover. Rest 20 minutes.
4. Roll dough very thin. Cut into 8cm circles.
5. PLEATING: Place 1 rounded tbsp filling in center. Hold skin in one hand. Using the other, pleat and fold the edge around the filling in small, even folds (12–18 pleats for a proper XLB). Twist the final pleat to seal — the "top knot."
6. Place each XLB on a small square of parchment in a bamboo steamer. Space 2cm apart.
7. Steam over high heat 8–10 minutes.
8. EATING PROTOCOL: Pick up gently with chopsticks. Place in a spoon. Bite a tiny hole in the skin. Sip the soup first. Then eat the dumpling.

Prep: 60 min + overnight stock · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving (4 XLB)

TIP

The jellied stock is non-negotiable — it is the source of the soup inside. Without properly gelled stock mixed into the cold filling, there is no soup. The stock must set completely firm before being diced into the filling. Firm stock = soup inside. Soft or liquid stock = no soup.

[High Protein] [Classic Chinese] [Advanced] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 251

■■ China (Guangdong / Cantonese)

CHAR SIU BAO

CANTONESE BBQ PORK BUNS

Char siu bao — the pillowy white steamed buns filled with sweet Cantonese BBQ pork — are the most recognized dim sum item in the world. Made from a uniquely soft, cloud-like dough that is almost fluorescently white, they are served at every dim sum breakfast from Hong Kong to Vancouver. The filling is sweet, savory, sticky, and intensely pork-forward.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE DOUGH (milk dough):
- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour (low-protein cake flour
- produces the whitest, softest result)
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 50g (¼ cup) sugar
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 2 tbsp lard or shortening (for the characteristic
- white color and soft texture)

FOR THE CHAR SIU FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) char siu (Chinese BBQ pork), diced small
- — buy from a Chinese BBQ shop for best results
- 2 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tbsp hoisin sauce
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp cornstarch dissolved in 2 tbsp water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Combine oyster sauce, hoisin, soy sauce, sugar, and sesame oil in a pan over medium heat. Add diced char siu. Stir to coat.
2. Add cornstarch slurry. Stir until sauce thickens and clings to the pork. Cool completely.
3. DOUGH: Combine flour, baking powder, yeast, and sugar. Add warm milk and lard. Knead 8 minutes until smooth. Prove 45 minutes.
4. Divide into 12 portions. Roll each into a circle. Place 1.5 tbsp filling in center.
5. Gather and pleat edges — the pleats should be at the top (unlike XLB where pleats also seal). Twist and seal firmly at the top.
6. Place each bun on a square of parchment.
7. Prove 20 minutes until slightly puffed.
8. Steam over high heat for 12–15 minutes.
9. The buns should be white, pillowy, and slightly split at the top — this split is the mark of a well-made bao.

Prep: 30 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~215 per bun

TIP

Lard in the dough is what creates the characteristic bright-white, tissue-soft texture of authentic char siu bao. Butter cannot replicate this. Vegetable shortening is the nearest vegan substitute. The slightly split top that reveals the filling is intentional and desirable — not a mistake.

[High Protein] [Classic Cantonese] [Dim Sum] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 252

■■ China / Taiwan

DAN BING

TAIWANESE EGG CRÊPE

Dan bing — Taiwan's most popular breakfast crêpe — is a thin flour crepe cooked on a flat iron griddle with a beaten egg poured over the surface, then filled with green onions, soy sauce, and optional cheese or ham. Made in under 3 minutes by breakfast shop (zaocan dian) vendors who flip hundreds before 8am each day.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE BATTER (make ahead):
- 200g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 400ml (1½ cups) cold water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vegetable oil
- PER CRÊPE:
- 1 large egg, beaten
- 1 tbsp sliced green onion (scallion)
- Soy sauce (for drizzling)
- Sesame oil (a few drops)

OPTIONAL FILLINGS

- 1 slice American cheese (very Taiwanese)
- 1 slice ham
- Pork floss (rou song)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk all batter ingredients until completely smooth. Rest 20 minutes minimum (or refrigerate overnight — makes a better crêpe).
2. Heat a flat griddle or large non-stick pan over medium heat. Brush very lightly with oil.
3. Pour a ladleful of batter and spread immediately into a large, very thin circle using a spatula or the back of the ladle.
4. Pour beaten egg over the entire surface. Spread egg evenly with the back of a spoon while it is still raw.
5. Sprinkle green onion over the egg.
6. When the egg is nearly set (30–45 seconds), flip the entire crêpe gently.
7. On the now-upward surface: drizzle soy sauce, a few drops of sesame oil. Add cheese and ham if using.
8. After 30 seconds, fold the crêpe into thirds (like a letter fold) so the egg side is outside.
9. Transfer to a board. Cut into 3 pieces.
10. Serve with extra soy sauce and chili sauce.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 3 min per crêpe · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per crêpe

TIP

The batter must be thin — thinner than you expect. It should spread to a 30cm circle from one ladleful. Thick batter creates a doughy crêpe that doesn't fold cleanly. Practice thinning it until it flows easily from the ladle.

[Quick] [Classic Chinese] [Street Food] [Customizable]

RECIPE 253

■ ■ China (Shanghai)

SHENGJIAN MANTOU

SHANGHAI PAN-FRIED PORK BUNS

Shengjian bao — Shanghai's pan-fried and steamed pork buns — have a completely different character from steamed bao. The bottom is fried in oil until shatteringly crispy and golden, while the top is steamed soft by added water in the pan. Filled with pork and soup-creating jelly, they are denser and more substantial than XLB — eaten for breakfast in Shanghai with a bowl of hot soy milk since the early 20th century.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 1 tbsp oil

FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) minced pork
- 100g (½ cup) jellied pork stock, diced (see XLB recipe)
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp Shaoxing wine
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- 2 green onions, minced
- 3 tbsp neutral oil (for pan-frying)
- 120ml (½ cup) water (for steaming)
- Sesame seeds and sliced green onion (for topping)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make dough: combine ingredients, knead 5 minutes, prove 45 minutes.
2. Mix filling: combine all ingredients, including cold jellied stock cubes. Refrigerate.
3. Divide dough into 16 pieces. Roll each into a circle.
4. Fill and pleat like XLB (see Recipe 250) — but these pleats can be less refined. Seal at the top.
5. Heat oil in a large non-stick pan or wok over medium.
6. Place buns close together, pleated-side up.
7. Fry 2–3 minutes until bottoms are golden.
8. Pour water into the pan carefully — it will sizzle dramatically. Cover immediately.
9. Steam on medium heat 8–10 minutes until water has mostly evaporated and tops are cooked through.
10. Remove lid. Continue cooking 1 minute to crisp the bottoms further.
11. Scatter sesame seeds and green onion on top.
12. Serve with black vinegar for dipping.

Prep: 30 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving (4 buns)

TIP

The water addition to hot oil creates immediate intense steam — have the lid ready in the same hand as the water before you pour, and cover instantly. The steam cooks the top and sides of the buns while the bottom continues to crisp. The dual texture — shatteringly crispy bottom, soft steamed top — is precisely the point.

[High Protein] [Classic Chinese] [Shanghai Icon] [Street Food]

RECIPE 254

■■ China (Hunan)

HONG SHAO ROU MANTOU

RED-BRAISED PORK WITH STEAMED BUN

Chairman Mao's favorite dish — hong shao rou (red-braised pork belly) — served between plain white steamed buns (mantou) as a breakfast sandwich. The pork is braised until meltingly tender in soy sauce, rice wine, rock sugar, and star anise until glossy, dark, and intensely flavored. Tucked inside a plain steamed bun, it is one of China's most satisfying breakfast sandwiches.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE RED-BRAISED PORK (make the day before):
- 600g (21 oz) pork belly, cut into 4cm cubes
- 3 tbsp oil
- 3 tbsp rock sugar (or brown sugar)
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp dark soy sauce (lao chou — for color)
- 3 tbsp Shaoxing rice wine
- 2 star anise
- 1 cinnamon stick
- 3 slices fresh ginger
- 2 green onions
- Enough water to barely cover pork

FOR SERVING

- 8 plain steamed mantou buns (buy or make, see base bun recipe from Char Siu Bao without filling)
- Sliced cucumber
- Pickled mustard greens (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PORK (day before): Blanch pork belly cubes in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Heat oil in a wok. Add rock sugar. Melt to a golden amber caramel over medium heat.
3. Add blanched pork. Stir to coat in caramel — it will spit and sizzle.
4. Add soy sauce, dark soy sauce, Shaoxing wine, star anise, cinnamon, ginger, and green onions.
5. Add just enough water to barely cover.
6. Bring to a boil. Reduce to very low heat. Cover and braise 1.5 hours.
7. Uncover. Increase heat slightly. Reduce sauce until thick and glossy — 20 more minutes. The pork should be very tender and deeply colored.
8. SERVING: Split steamed buns. Fill generously with braised pork. Add cucumber and mustard greens.
9. The pork fat will melt into the soft bun — extraordinary.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 2 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~510 per serving

TIP

Dark soy sauce is the secret to the deeply lacquered color of hong shao rou. It is thicker, less salty, and more caramel-like than regular soy sauce. Using only regular soy sauce produces a pale, less visually dramatic result. Use both for best results.

[High Protein] [Classic Chinese] [Make-Ahead] [Hunan Regional]

RECIPE 255

■■ China

MANTOU (STEAMED PLAIN BUNS)

Plain white steamed buns — mantou — are the northern Chinese bread staple, eaten at every meal including breakfast alongside congee, braised pork, or simply dipped in condensed milk. Fluffy, slightly sweet, and pillowy white, they require no filling to be satisfying. The technique creates an impossibly soft crumb through a combination of yeasted rise and steam cooking.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- (or cake flour for whiter, softer result)
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- ½ tsp baking powder
- 1 tbsp neutral oil
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dissolve yeast and sugar in warm milk. Rest 5 minutes.
2. Combine flour, baking powder, and salt. Add yeast mixture and oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth, elastic, and slightly sticky.
3. Cover and prove 1 hour until doubled.
4. Punch down. Knead briefly 1–2 minutes to smooth.
5. Roll dough into a long log. Slice into 10–12 equal rounds.
6. Place each round on a small square of parchment.
7. Cover. Rest 20–30 minutes — they will puff slightly.
8. Steam over high heat in a bamboo or metal steamer for 12–15 minutes.
9. DO NOT open the lid during the first 10 minutes — steam escape causes collapse.
10. When done, turn off heat and wait 3 minutes before opening the lid — this prevents sudden temperature change from wrinkling the surface.

Prep: 15 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~140 per mantou

TIP

Baking powder added alongside yeast is the Chinese bakery secret for extra height and especially soft texture. The double leavening creates a lighter crumb than yeast alone. The 3-minute resting period after turning off heat is also critical — sudden temperature drops cause the beautiful white surface to wrinkle permanently.

[Vegan] [Classic Chinese] [Make-Ahead] [Northern China]

RECIPE 256

■■ China

SCALLION PANCAKES

CONG YOU BING

Cong you bing — flaky, layered scallion pancakes — are one of China's most beloved street breakfast foods. Made from a hot-water dough that creates a uniquely chewy-tender texture, brushed with sesame oil and green onions, rolled and folded to create layers, then pan-fried until golden and shatteringly crispy. A technique-driven recipe that rewards the effort magnificently.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 180ml (¾ cup) just-boiled water
- 30ml (2 tbsp) cold water
- 1 tsp salt
- 3 tbsp sesame oil (for the layers)
- 1 tsp five-spice powder (optional — traditional)
- 4 large green onions (scallions), thinly sliced
- Vegetable oil for frying
- Soy sauce + rice vinegar dipping sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place flour and salt in a bowl. Pour boiling water over while stirring with chopsticks or a fork. Add cold water and mix.
2. Knead 5 minutes until smooth. The hot water partially gelatinizes the starch — creating the characteristic chewy-tender texture. Rest covered 30 minutes — essential.
3. Divide into 4 portions. Roll each thin (3mm).
4. Brush generously with sesame oil.
5. Sprinkle five-spice powder if using.
6. Scatter sliced scallions over the entire surface.
7. Roll up tightly into a log, keeping scallions inside.
8. Coil the log into a spiral snail shape.
9. Press the spiral flat with your palm.
10. Roll again to 5mm thick — the layered spiral creates beautiful flaky layers.
11. Fry in 3–4mm of hot oil over medium heat, 3–4 minutes per side until deeply golden.
12. Press gently while frying to create even contact.
13. Serve hot with soy-vinegar dipping sauce.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min rest • Cook: 15 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~295 per pancake

TIP

The hot-water technique is what differentiates scallion pancake dough from other flatbreads. The boiling water partially cooks the starch, creating a dough that is both chewy and tender simultaneously — impossible to achieve with cold water. Never use cold water for this recipe.

[Vegan] [Classic Chinese] [Street Food] [Customizable]

RECIPE 257

■■ China (Guangdong)

DIM SUM: HAR GOW

CANTONESE SHRIMP DUMPLINGS

Har gow — translucent steamed dumplings with a crystalline skin and juicy whole shrimp filling — are the test piece of every dim sum chef. The skin should be thin enough to see the pink shrimp inside, with at least seven pleats on one side, and a texture that is simultaneously slippery, chewy, and delicate. Eaten at every Cantonese dim sum breakfast since the 20th century.

INGREDIENTS

- HAR GOW SKIN (wheat starch dough):
- 150g (1¼ cups) wheat starch (tang mian fen —
- NOT regular flour — wheat starch is gluten-free)
- 50g (¼ cup) tapioca starch
- 200ml (¾ cup) boiling water
- 1 tbsp lard or shortening (for softness and translucency)

SHRIMP FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) raw shrimp, peeled, deveined
- (½ kept whole, ½ roughly chopped)
- 50g (2 oz) water chestnuts, finely diced
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp Shaoxing wine
- 1 tsp cornstarch
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp white pepper
- ½ tsp sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Mix chopped and whole shrimp with water chestnuts, sesame oil, Shaoxing wine, cornstarch, salt, pepper, and sugar. Refrigerate 30 minutes — the chill firms the shrimp.
2. HAR GOW SKIN: Combine wheat starch and tapioca starch in a bowl. Pour boiling water over while stirring immediately. Add lard. Knead while still hot for 3–4 minutes into a smooth, translucent dough. Keep covered with a damp cloth — it dries quickly.
3. Pinch off marble-sized pieces of dough. Press flat with the side of a cleaver or a small disk-shaped object oiled to prevent sticking. They should be paper-thin and almost translucent.
4. Place 1 tbsp filling in the center of each skin.
5. PLEATING: Fold one side of the skin over the filling. Pinch 7 small pleats along the folded edge, pressing each firmly. Seal the straight back edge.
6. Place on oiled parchment in a steamer.
7. Steam over HIGH heat for 7–8 minutes.
8. Serve immediately with soy sauce.

Prep: 45 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~195 per serving (4 har gow)

TIP

Wheat starch (tang mian fen) is absolutely essential — it is NOT the same as regular wheat flour. Wheat starch contains no gluten, which is why har gow skins are translucent and glass-like. Using regular flour creates an opaque, chewy skin that is not har gow. Find wheat starch at any Chinese grocery store.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Cantonese] [Advanced] [Dim Sum]

RECIPE 258

■■ China (Guangdong / Hong Kong)

DIM SUM: CHEUNG FUN

CANTONESE RICE NOODLE ROLLS

Cheung fun — silky, paper-thin rice noodle sheets rolled around shrimp, beef, or you tiao (fried dough), and drizzled with sweet soy sauce and sesame oil — are one of Hong Kong's most beloved breakfast dim sum items. The noodle sheets should be glass-like, almost translucent, and the roll should tremble when shaken. A breakfast that requires respect and proper rice flour.

INGREDIENTS

RICE NOODLE BATTER

- 150g (1¼ cups) rice flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) wheat starch (or tapioca starch)
- 15g (2 tbsp) cornstarch
- 450ml (2 cups) cold water
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- ½ tsp salt
- FILLING (choose one):
- Shrimp: 12 large shrimp, marinated with soy + sesame + white pepper
- You tiao: 1 full you tiao, cut in half
- Beef: 150g thin-sliced beef + soy + oyster sauce

SAUCE

- 3 tbsp sweet soy sauce (or soy sauce + sugar heated)
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp hoisin sauce (optional)
- Sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk all batter ingredients until completely smooth. Strain through a sieve. Rest 20 minutes.
2. OIL a flat tray (a stainless steel rectangular tray is traditional — a 30x20cm baking tray works).
3. Pour a thin layer of batter into the oiled tray — just enough to cover the bottom (3mm thick).
4. Add chosen filling across the center of the batter.
5. Steam in a wok with a tight lid for 3–4 minutes until the noodle sheet is set and glossy.
6. Using a wide, flat scraper or spatula, roll the noodle sheet from one edge (like rolling a crêpe).
7. Slide onto a serving plate.
8. Cut into 4cm sections.
9. Drizzle sweet soy sauce, sesame oil, and hoisin over the rolls. Scatter sesame seeds.

Prep: 15 min + 20 min rest • Cook: 4 min per roll • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

The batter layer in the tray must be very thin — the sheet should be almost translucent when held to light. Too thick creates a heavy, doughy roll instead of the glass-like, silky texture that defines cheung fun. Less is always more here.

[Gluten-Free option] [Classic Cantonese] [Dim Sum] [High Protein]

RECIPE 259

■■ China (Hong Kong)

HONG KONG FRENCH TOAST

XIANGGANG FASI TUSI

Hong Kong-style French toast — a cha chaan teng (Hong Kong diner) classic — takes two slices of thick white toast, sandwiches them with peanut butter, dips the entire thing in beaten egg, and deep-fries to golden perfection. Served on a plate with a thick pat of butter melting over the top and drizzled with golden syrup. Intensely, unashamedly indulgent.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices white sandwich bread
- (don't use artisan bread — plain commercial bread
- creates the authentic soft interior)
- 3 tbsp smooth peanut butter (or kaya coconut jam)
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 2 tbsp whole milk
- Vegetable oil for deep frying (2–3cm depth)
- 2 tbsp salted butter
- 3 tbsp golden syrup or condensed milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Spread peanut butter generously on 2 bread slices.
2. Sandwich with the remaining 2 bread slices. Press firmly.
3. Cut each sandwich diagonally into 2 triangles.
4. Beat eggs with milk until combined.
5. Dip each triangle completely in egg mixture, turning to coat all sides. Allow to soak 30 seconds — the bread should absorb egg on all sides.
6. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a pan deep enough to submerge the sandwiches halfway.
7. Fry sandwiches 2 minutes per side until deeply golden and the bread is cooked through.
8. Drain on paper towels.
9. Transfer to a plate immediately.
10. Place a thick pat of salted butter on top. Let it melt dramatically.
11. Drizzle golden syrup generously over everything.
12. Eat while hot — the contrast of crispy exterior, soft interior, melting butter, and sweet syrup is the entire point.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~540 per serving

TIP

Deep frying rather than pan-frying is what creates the uniquely crispy, uniformly golden exterior on all surfaces simultaneously. Pan-frying produces two golden sides and pale, soft edges — completely different in texture. Use enough oil and trust the process.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hong Kong] [Cha Chaan Teng Icon] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 260

■■ China (Hong Kong)

HONG KONG EGG TART

DAN TA

Hong Kong egg tarts — a Portuguese pastel de nata reimagined through 1940s British Hong Kong — feature a buttery shortcrust or puff pastry shell with a smooth, slightly wobbly, lightly sweet egg custard. The Hong Kong version is slightly less sweet and less charred than its Portuguese cousin — softer, more delicate, and specifically designed to be eaten with milk tea at a cha chaan teng breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

WATER DOUGH

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 80g (6 tbsp) lard (or butter — lard is more traditional)
- 50g (¼ cup) icing sugar
- 1 egg yolk
- 2 tbsp cold water

CUSTARD FILLING

- 4 large eggs
- 200ml (¾ cup) whole milk
- 100ml (■ cup) heavy cream
- 80g (■ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PASTRY: Rub lard into flour until sandy. Add icing sugar, egg yolk, and cold water. Bring together into a smooth dough. Chill 30 minutes.
2. CUSTARD: Dissolve sugar in warm milk (do not boil). Cool to room temperature. Beat eggs with cream and vanilla. Slowly combine milk and egg mixture. Strain through a fine sieve — essential for smoothness.
3. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F).
4. Roll pastry to 3mm. Cut circles to fit individual egg tart tins (8–10cm). Press into tins, building up the sides. Prick the base.
5. Fill each tart shell ¾ full with strained custard.
6. Bake 15–18 minutes until: — Pastry is pale golden — Custard is set at the edges but trembles in the center when shaken gently
7. Cool 10 minutes before unmolding.
8. Best eaten warm on the same day.

Prep: 25 min + 30 min chilling · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~185 per tart

TIP

The custard must be strained through a fine sieve — unstrained custard has air bubbles and egg stringers that create an uneven, pitted surface when baked. Strained custard bakes into a perfectly smooth, mirror-like surface. This step takes 2 minutes and makes a dramatic visual difference.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Hong Kong] [Make-Ahead] [Dim Sum]

RECIPE 261

■■ China (Hong Kong)

HONG KONG MILK TEA

GANG STYLE SILK STOCKING TEA

Hong Kong-style milk tea — brewed with a blend of Ceylon black teas and "pulled" through a silk stocking filter to create a smooth, intensely flavored tea — is one of the world's great tea drinks. The "pulling" aerates the tea and creates a silky texture that no ordinary teapot method can replicate. Served hot or iced, always with evaporated milk, never fresh milk.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp loose Ceylon black tea
- (a blend of Sri Lanka teas — Lipton Yellow Label
- is the authentic brand used in Hong Kong)
- 600ml (2½ cups) water, just boiled
- 150ml (■ cup) evaporated milk
- (NOT fresh milk — evaporated milk is essential)
- 2 tsp sugar (or to taste)

EQUIPMENT

- A tea sock (cloth filter) or fine strainer

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew tea by pouring boiling water over leaves in the tea sock. Steep 5 minutes — strong.
2. PULLING TECHNIQUE: Pour the brewed tea from height into another vessel, then pour it back into the tea sock from height, then into the vessel again. Repeat 3–4 times. This aeration creates the characteristic smooth, "silky stocking" texture.
3. Add evaporated milk and sugar to the hot tea.
4. Stir vigorously.
5. Taste — it should be strong, creamy, and slightly sweet with a smooth, velvety mouthfeel.
6. Serve in a ceramic cup (hot) or over ice (iced).

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~120 per cup

TIP

The pulling technique is not ceremonial — it is functional. Each pour from height incorporates air bubbles that smooth the tannins and create a more rounded, less astringent flavor. More pulls = smoother tea. Three pulls minimum for authenticity.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Hong Kong] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 262

■■ China

CENTURY EGG WITH TOFU

PI DAN TOFU

A beloved Chinese breakfast cold dish — silken tofu topped with quartered century eggs (pi dan), drizzled with soy sauce, sesame oil, and chili oil, then scattered with fried shallots and sesame seeds. The crystalline, jelly-like egg white and creamy, dark yolk of the century egg contrast magnificently with the silken tofu beneath. No cooking required — just assembly and confidence.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 block (300g) silken tofu, cold
- 2 century eggs (pi dan), peeled and quartered
- 2 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp chili oil (or more, to taste)
- 1 tbsp fried shallots
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, finely julienned
- 1 green onion, sliced
- Optional: 1 tsp black vinegar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Remove silken tofu from packaging carefully — it is very fragile. Place gently on a serving plate.
2. Quarter or halve the tofu using a sharp knife. Do not press or break it — serve in chunks.
3. Peel century eggs carefully under cold running water. Quarter them — the dark, gelatinous white and creamy grey-green yolk are the attraction.
4. Arrange century egg quarters on top of the tofu.
5. Add julienned ginger over the eggs.
6. Drizzle soy sauce, sesame oil, and chili oil generously over everything.
7. Scatter fried shallots, sesame seeds, and green onion over the top.
8. Add black vinegar if using.
9. Serve cold, immediately.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~185 per serving

TIP

Century eggs are preserved in a mixture of clay, ash, salt, quicklime, and rice straw for weeks to months — despite the name, not a century. The process transforms the egg chemically rather than through heat. The result has a uniquely complex flavor — rich, slightly sulfurous, and deeply umami. Approach with genuine curiosity.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Chinese] [No-Cook]

India

RECIPE 263

■■ India (Tamil Nadu / Karnataka)

MASALA DOSA

South India's most celebrated breakfast — a paper-thin, golden, shatteringly crispy crêpe made from fermented rice and lentil batter, filled with spiced potato masala, and served with coconut chutney and sambar. The fermentation gives the dosa a complex sourness that no quick recipe can replicate. Worth every hour of waiting.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE DOSA BATTER (make 24 hrs ahead):
- 2 cups short-grain rice or idli rice
- ½ cup urad dal (black gram, skinned)
- ¼ tsp fenugreek seeds
- Salt to taste

FOR THE POTATO MASALA FILLING

- 4 large potatoes, boiled and roughly mashed
- 1 large onion, thinly sliced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 10 curry leaves
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Salt to taste

FOR THE COCONUT CHUTNEY

- 1 cup fresh grated coconut (or frozen)
- 2–3 green chillies
- 1 small garlic clove
- 1 tsp fresh ginger
- Salt to taste
- TEMPERING: 1 tsp mustard seeds + 8 curry leaves
- + 1 dried red chilli + 1 tsp oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BATTER (night before): Rinse rice and dal separately. Soak rice with fenugreek seeds in cold water 6 hours. Soak dal separately in cold water 4 hours.
2. Grind rice (with its soaking water) in a blender until completely smooth. Transfer to a large bowl.
3. Grind dal with just enough fresh water until very smooth and fluffy — add water gradually. The dal batter should be lighter and airier than the rice batter.
4. Combine both batters. Add salt. Mix well.
5. Cover loosely and ferment at room temperature 12–16 hours until the batter has risen slightly and smells pleasantly sour.
6. POTATO MASALA: Heat oil in a pan. Add mustard seeds. When they pop, add cumin seeds, curry leaves, ginger, and chillies.
7. Add sliced onion. Cook 8 minutes until golden.
8. Add turmeric. Stir 30 seconds.
9. Add mashed potato. Mix well. Season with salt. Fold in fresh coriander. Set aside warm.
10. COCONUT CHUTNEY: Blend coconut, chillies, garlic, ginger, and salt with enough water to form a thick, pourable chutney. Transfer to a bowl. Make tempering: heat oil, add mustard seeds until they pop, add curry leaves and dried chilli, pour over chutney.
11. COOKING DOSA: Heat a heavy flat pan or tawa over medium-high heat until very hot. Sprinkle a few drops of water — they should evaporate immediately.
12. Pour a ladleful of batter in the center. Using the bottom of the ladle, spread immediately in concentric circles — thin and even. The circle should be 25–30cm (10–12 inches).
13. Drizzle 1 tsp oil around the edges and over the surface. Cook 2–3 minutes until the edges lift and the surface looks set and slightly golden.
14. Flip briefly (10–15 seconds) OR serve as is with the cooked side facing up.
15. Place potato masala along one edge. Fold dosa over the filling or roll into a cylinder.
16. Serve immediately with coconut chutney and sambar.

Prep: 30 min + 24 hrs fermentation · Cook: 5 min per dosa · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~285 per dosa

TIP

Fermentation is the irreplaceable step. The lactic acid bacteria that develop during the 12–16 hours of room-temperature fermentation create the unique sour flavor, the crispy texture when cooked, and the complex depth that makes dosa extraordinary. Skipping this step produces a crêpe — not a dosa.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic South Indian]

POHA

Poha — flattened rice cooked with mustard seeds, curry leaves, onion, turmeric, green chilli, and lemon — is Maharashtra's most beloved quick breakfast. Light, fragrant, and ready in 15 minutes, it is the weekday morning staple of millions. The flattened rice absorbs the flavors perfectly while maintaining a light, slightly chewy texture that is completely its own.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups thick poha (flattened rice — "thick" variety)
- holds its shape better than thin)
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 2 green chillies, slit lengthwise
- 10–12 fresh curry leaves
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- 1 tsp sugar (crucial — balances the flavor)
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Juice of 1 lemon
- Salt to taste

GARNISHES

- Fresh coriander leaves, chopped
- Thin sev (fried chickpea noodles — optional)
- Pomegranate seeds (optional)
- Grated fresh coconut (optional)
- Roasted peanuts, coarsely crushed

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place poha in a colander or fine sieve. Run cold water over it for 30 seconds, tossing gently to moisten every flake. The poha should feel soft but not mushy — it should hold its shape. Do NOT soak — rinse only. Set aside to drain.
2. Check the poha texture: it should easily compress between your fingers without resistance. If still very hard, sprinkle 1–2 tbsp water and toss again.
3. Heat oil in a heavy-bottomed pan or kadai over medium heat.
4. Add mustard seeds. Wait until they pop and splutter.
5. Add cumin seeds. Let sizzle 10 seconds.
6. Add curry leaves — they will pop dramatically in the hot oil. Stand back slightly.
7. Add green chillies. Fry 30 seconds.
8. Add diced onion. Cook 5–7 minutes until soft and translucent — not browned.
9. Add turmeric. Stir 20 seconds.
10. Add roasted peanuts. Stir briefly.
11. Add the softened poha. Season with salt and sugar.
12. Mix gently using a folding motion — do not stir aggressively or the poha will become mushy.
13. Cover and cook on low heat 2 minutes.
14. Remove from heat. Squeeze lemon juice over.
15. Garnish with fresh coriander, sev, pomegranate seeds, and grated coconut.
16. Serve hot immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

The sugar is not optional in poha — it is the crucial ingredient that balances the heat of the chilli and the sourness of the lemon, rounding all the flavors into a harmonious whole. Without it, poha is sharp and flat. With it, poha is complete.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Maharashtra]

IDLI SAMBAR

Steamed rice and lentil cakes — soft, spongy, and cloud-white — served with a tangy tamarind and lentil soup (sambar) and coconut chutney. The trinity of idli-sambar-chutney is South India's most nourishing and beloved breakfast, eaten by hundreds of millions daily. The fermented batter and slow steaming create an impossibly light texture.

INGREDIENTS

- IDLI BATTER (same as dosa — see Recipe 263):
- 2 cups idli rice
- ½ cup urad dal
- ¼ tsp fenugreek seeds
- Salt (fermented overnight — see Dosa recipe)

FOR THE SAMBAR

- 1 cup toor dal (split pigeon peas)
- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 medium tomatoes, chopped
- 1 cup mixed vegetables (drumstick, carrot, eggplant)
- 2 tbsp sambar powder
- 1 tbsp tamarind paste
- ½ tsp turmeric
- Salt to taste

SAMBAR TEMPERING

- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 2 dried red chillies
- 10 curry leaves
- ½ tsp asafoetida (hing)
- 2 tsp ghee or oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. TOOR DAL: Cook toor dal in 3 cups water with turmeric in a pressure cooker (3 whistles) or in a pot (45 minutes) until very soft and creamy. Mash well.
2. SAMBAR: In a separate pot, sauté onion in oil 5 minutes. Add tomatoes and vegetables. Cook 5 min.
3. Add sambar powder, tamarind paste, and salt. Stir well.
4. Add cooked mashed dal and 2 cups water. Simmer 15 minutes until vegetables are tender and sambar has thickened to a soup consistency.
5. Make tempering: heat ghee in a small pan. Add mustard seeds until they pop. Add dried chillies, curry leaves, and asafoetida. Fry 20 seconds. Pour immediately over the sambar. Stir in.
6. IDLI: Grease idli moulds generously with oil. Fill each mould ¾ full with fermented batter.
7. Steam over high heat for 10–12 minutes. Do not open the lid during steaming.
8. Cool 2 minutes. Unmold with a wet spoon. They should release cleanly.
9. Serve 2–3 idli per person in a wide plate or bowl with sambar ladled generously over and coconut chutney on the side.

Prep: 20 min + overnight fermentation · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

Idli texture depends entirely on the batter being correctly fermented and aerated. The dal must be ground much smoother and fluffier than the rice — it provides the lift. During grinding, add cold water gradually and blend the dal for at least 10 minutes until white, fluffy, and almost doubled in volume.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Tamil Nadu]

RECIPE 266

■■ India (Punjab)

ALOO PARATHA

Punjab's most beloved breakfast — a whole-wheat flatbread stuffed with spiced mashed potato, cooked on a tawa with generous ghee until golden and slightly charred at the edges. Served with cold yogurt, mango pickle, and white butter. The combination of crispy, flaky bread, spiced potato filling, cool yogurt, and fiery pickle is one of the world's great breakfasts.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DOUGH

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- ½ tsp salt
- Water (approximately 180ml) to make a soft dough
- 1 tsp oil

FOR THE POTATO FILLING

- 3 large potatoes, boiled and mashed while hot
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 1 tsp cumin seeds (roasted and crushed)
- ½ tsp garam masala
- ½ tsp amchur (dry mango powder) or lemon juice
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- Salt to taste

FOR COOKING AND SERVING

- Ghee (generous — do not be conservative)
- Plain yogurt, cold
- Mango pickle (aam ka achaar)
- White butter (makhan) — optional

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine atta, salt, and oil. Gradually add water while kneading until a very soft, smooth, pliable dough forms — softer than bread dough. The softer the dough, the easier to roll. Cover and rest 20 minutes.
2. FILLING: Mash hot potatoes until completely smooth — no lumps whatsoever. Lumps tear the dough when rolling. Mix in all filling ingredients. Taste and adjust seasoning. Cool to room temperature.
3. Divide dough into 8 balls. Divide filling into 8 portions.
4. Roll a dough ball into a 12cm circle. Place a filling portion in the center.
5. Bring the edges up around the filling. Pinch firmly closed. You now have a filled ball.
6. Flatten gently with your palm. Using a rolling pin, roll very gently to 20cm — go slowly and apply even, gentle pressure. If filling breaks through, pinch closed and continue rolling.
7. Heat a tawa or cast-iron pan over medium-high heat.
8. Place paratha on the dry tawa. Cook 1 minute until bubbles appear. Flip.
9. Add 1 tsp ghee. Spread over the paratha. Press with a spatula. Cook 1–2 minutes until golden.
10. Flip again. Add another tsp ghee on this side. Press and cook 1–2 minutes until both sides are golden with dark, slightly charred spots.
11. Serve hot immediately with cold yogurt, mango pickle, and a generous pat of white butter on top.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 6 min per paratha · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per paratha

TIP

The potato must be completely lump-free before stuffing — any lump creates a weak spot in the dough that tears during rolling and the filling spills. Mash the potato while still hot (much easier) through a fine sieve if necessary for perfect smoothness.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Punjabi] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 267

■■ India (Tamil Nadu / Karnataka)

UPMA

South India's most practical breakfast — semolina dry-roasted then cooked with mustard seeds, curry leaves, onion, green chilli, and vegetables into a thick, savory porridge. Ready in 20 minutes, nutritious, and deeply aromatic with curry leaves and mustard. Every South Indian home makes upma differently — this is the classic version that satisfies always.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup coarse semolina (rava / sooji)
- 1 medium onion, finely diced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tbsp chana dal (split chickpeas — optional)
- 1 tbsp urad dal (optional)
- 2 tbsp roasted cashews or peanuts
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 2 cups hot water
- 2 tbsp ghee or neutral oil
- Salt to taste
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Fresh coriander to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DRY ROAST SEMOLINA: Heat a dry pan over medium heat. Add semolina and roast, stirring constantly, for 4–5 minutes until it turns pale golden and smells nutty and toasted. Transfer to a plate. This step prevents clumping and adds flavor.
2. Heat ghee in the same pan over medium heat.
3. Add mustard seeds. When they pop, add cumin seeds.
4. Add chana dal and urad dal. Fry 30 seconds until light golden (if using).
5. Add curry leaves — they will pop and splutter.
6. Add green chillies and onion. Cook 6–7 minutes until onion is soft and golden.
7. Add turmeric. Stir 20 seconds.
8. Add cashews. Stir briefly.
9. Pour in hot water. Add salt. Bring to a rolling boil.
10. Reduce heat to low. Add roasted semolina in a thin steady stream while stirring constantly to prevent lumps from forming.
11. Stir vigorously for 2–3 minutes until semolina absorbs all the water and becomes a thick, non-sticky mass that leaves the pan sides clean.
12. Cover. Cook on lowest heat 2 minutes.
13. Remove lid. Squeeze lemon juice. Mix.
14. Garnish with fresh coriander.
15. Serve hot with coconut chutney.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~265 per serving

TIP

Roasting the semolina first is the most important step — it prevents the finished upma from being gluey or sticky. Roast until you can smell the nuttiness, even before it takes on much color. Cold water added to the pan creates lumps. Always use hot or boiling water when adding to the pan.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Classic South Indian] [Budget-Friendly]

RECIPE 268

■■ India (Maharashtra / North India)

PURI BHAJI

Deep-fried puffed wheat bread (puri) served with a spiced potato curry (bhaji) — India's most festive and celebratory breakfast. Eaten at weddings, festivals, temples, and Sunday mornings when someone feels the family deserves something extraordinary. The puri must puff dramatically — a perfectly puffed puri is a source of genuine pride.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PURI

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp semolina (rava — for crispness)
- 1 tsp oil
- Water to make a stiff dough
- Oil for deep frying

FOR THE BHAJI

- 4 medium potatoes, boiled and cubed
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 2 tomatoes, finely chopped
- 2 green chillies, slit
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 10 curry leaves
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp cumin powder
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- ½ tsp garam masala
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 3 tbsp oil
- Fresh coriander
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BHAJI: Heat oil in a pan. Add mustard seeds until they pop. Add cumin seeds and curry leaves.
2. Add ginger and chillies. Fry 30 seconds.
3. Add onion. Cook 8 minutes until golden.
4. Add tomatoes and all spice powders. Cook 5 minutes until tomatoes break down completely.
5. Add potato cubes. Mash some partially against the side of the pan for a textured bhaji. Mix well. Add a splash of water if too dry. Simmer 5 minutes. Season with salt. Add coriander.
6. PURI DOUGH: Combine flour, semolina, salt, and oil. Add water gradually to make a stiff, smooth dough — stiffer than chapati dough. Knead 5 minutes. Rest covered 15 minutes.
7. Divide into 12 balls. Roll each into a small circle (12cm) — not too thin (3–4mm).
8. Heat oil in a deep pan to 180°C (355°F). Test with a tiny piece of dough — it should rise immediately and sizzle vigorously.
9. Slide a puri gently into the oil. Immediately begin pressing it gently with a slotted spoon — submerging and releasing rhythmically. This encourages puffing.
10. When the puri puffs completely (10–15 seconds), flip and cook the other side 10 seconds more.
11. Remove while still pale gold — they darken rapidly.
12. Drain on paper towels. Serve immediately alongside warm bhaji.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Puffing is achieved by pressing the puri gently with a slotted spoon as soon as it enters the oil. The pressing creates steam inside that forces the layers apart. Oil temperature is critical — if too cool, puris absorb oil; if too hot, they color too fast without puffing. Keep a thermometer nearby.

[Vegan] [Classic Indian] [Celebration Breakfast] [Festive]

RECIPE 269

■ India (Andhra Pradesh)

PESARATTU

A uniquely Andhra breakfast — crispy green crêpes made from whole green moong dal (mung beans) ground with ginger and green chilli. Unlike the fermented dosa batter, pesarattu requires no fermentation — just soaking. High in protein, naturally green, and distinctly earthy in flavor, served with ginger chutney or upma stuffed inside.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE BATTER

- 1 cup whole green moong dal (green mung beans)
-
- do not use the split yellow version)
- 2–3 green chillies, roughly chopped
- 1 inch fresh ginger, roughly chopped
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- Salt to taste
- Water for grinding

FOR COOKING

- Oil or ghee for the pan
- TOPPING (traditional):
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 1 green chilli, thinly sliced
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Cumin seeds
- GINGER CHUTNEY (quick version):
- 50g fresh ginger, peeled
- 2 tbsp tamarind paste
- 1 tsp jaggery or sugar
- Salt, red chilli powder
- Blend all together with minimal water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Wash green moong dal thoroughly. Soak in cold water for 6–8 hours (or overnight). They will soften and swell but do not sprout significantly.
2. Drain. Transfer to a blender.
3. Add green chillies, ginger, cumin seeds, and salt.
4. Blend, adding just enough water to create a thick, pourable batter — thicker than dosa batter. The batter should coat the back of a spoon.
5. Heat a flat pan or tawa over medium-high heat. Brush lightly with oil.
6. Pour a ladleful of batter in the center. Spread in concentric circles to a 20cm crêpe. Pesarattu is thicker than dosa — do not spread too thin.
7. Immediately scatter diced onion, chilli, cumin seeds, and coriander over the surface. Press lightly.
8. Drizzle 1 tsp oil around the edges and over the top.
9. Cook 2–3 minutes until the bottom is golden and the edges lift.
10. Flip carefully. Cook 1–2 minutes more.
11. Fold or serve flat alongside ginger chutney.

Prep: 15 min + 6-8 hrs soaking · Cook: 5 min per pesarattu · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~210 per pesarattu

TIP

Whole green moong (not the split or hulled version) is essential — the green skin and whole grain give pesarattu its distinctive color, texture, and nutritional richness. Grinding with minimal water creates a thicker batter that spreads into a more substantial, protein-dense crêpe.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Andhra]

RECIPE 270

■■ India (Gujarat)

METHI THEPLA

Gujarat's signature breakfast flatbread — thin, soft, spiced whole-wheat flatbreads loaded with fresh fenugreek (methi) leaves, sesame seeds, and yogurt. Unlike paratha, thepla is slightly thinner and drier — making it the ideal travel food. Gujaratis pack thepla for long journeys because they stay fresh for 2–3 days. Eaten with yogurt, pickle, and a cup of chai.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- ½ cup chickpea flour (besan — adds flavor and protein)
- 1 cup fresh fenugreek leaves (methi), finely chopped
- (or 2 tbsp dried kasuri methi)
- 2 tbsp plain yogurt
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp coriander powder
- 1 tbsp oil (in the dough)
- Salt to taste
- Water as needed
- Oil or ghee for cooking

FOR SERVING

- Plain yogurt
- Aam ka achaar (mango pickle)
- Masala chai

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine whole wheat flour, chickpea flour, sesame seeds, cumin seeds, turmeric, red chilli, coriander powder, and salt in a bowl.
2. Add chopped methi leaves. Mix to distribute evenly.
3. Add yogurt and oil. Begin incorporating water gradually — mix with your hands.
4. Knead into a smooth, soft dough — softer than chapati dough. The yogurt adds tenderness. Add more water if needed.
5. Cover and rest 15–20 minutes.
6. Divide into 10–12 balls.
7. On a lightly floured surface, roll each ball into a thin circle (18–20cm) — thinner than paratha, thicker than a crêpe (3mm approximately).
8. Heat a tawa over medium-high heat.
9. Place thepla on dry tawa. Cook 1 minute until small bubbles appear.
10. Flip. Apply ½ tsp oil or ghee with a spoon or brush. Spread over the entire surface.
11. Flip again. Apply oil on this side. Press with a spatula. Cook until golden patches appear on both sides — 1–2 minutes total.
12. Serve hot with yogurt and mango pickle.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 4 min per thepla · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~215 per thepla

TIP

Fresh methi (fenugreek leaves) have a slightly bitter edge that is integral to thepla's character. Do not be tempted to reduce the quantity. The bitterness mellows during cooking and becomes complex and aromatic. Dried kasuri methi can substitute but fresh is significantly more vibrant and flavorful.

[Vegetarian] [High Fiber] [Classic Gujarati] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 271

■■ India (Maharashtra)

SABUDANA KHICHDI

A Maharashtrian fasting breakfast made from tapioca pearls cooked with peanuts, green chilli, ghee, and cumin — each pearl should be separate, translucent, and slightly chewy. This dish is eaten during Hindu fasting days but is so delicious it has become an everyday breakfast. The key is perfectly soaked sabudana — the technique is the entire recipe.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup sabudana (tapioca pearls — medium sized)
- ½ cup raw peanuts, roasted and coarsely crushed
- 2–3 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- 1 medium potato, boiled and diced into 1cm cubes
- ½ tsp sugar
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 2 tbsp ghee or oil
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **SOAKING** (most critical step): Wash sabudana 2–3 times until water runs clear. Drain completely. Place in a bowl. Sprinkle just enough water to barely cover — approximately 4 tbsp. The sabudana should absorb the water without sitting in it. Cover and rest 4–6 hours or overnight. After soaking, each pearl should be: — Soft when pressed (no hard center) — Separate (not clumped together) — Slightly translucent If they clump, they were over-soaked and will become paste when cooked. Use less water next time.
2. Mix soaked sabudana with crushed peanuts, sugar, and salt. Toss to combine. Set aside.
3. Heat ghee in a wide pan over medium heat.
4. Add cumin seeds. Let sizzle 10 seconds.
5. Add curry leaves and green chillies. Pop briefly.
6. Add boiled potato cubes. Cook 2 minutes, tossing until lightly golden.
7. Add the sabudana-peanut mixture.
8. Cook over medium heat, stirring gently every 30 seconds, for 5–7 minutes. The sabudana pearls should turn translucent and slightly sticky when pressed. Do not stir too aggressively or they will break.
9. Remove from heat when each pearl is translucent but still distinct — not mashed together.
10. Add lemon juice. Toss gently.
11. Garnish with fresh coriander.
12. Serve immediately — sabudana khichdi firms as it cools.

Prep: 10 min + 4-6 hrs soaking · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Over-soaking is the most common mistake with sabudana — it creates a paste instead of individual pearls. The correct amount of soaking water is just enough for the pearls to absorb without sitting in excess water. They should feel like soft beads when pressed, with no hard center remaining.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Fasting Food] [Classic Maharashtra]

RECIPE 272

■■ India (Tamil Nadu / Karnataka)

UTTAPAM

A thick, spongy South Indian rice pancake — made from the same fermented dosa batter but cooked slowly into a thick, pancake-like disc with vegetables pressed into the surface. Called the "Indian pizza" for its appearance, uttapam is softer, more filling, and more forgiving than dosa. The vegetable toppings cook directly into the batter creating a rustic, colorful, one-pan breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups fermented dosa/idli batter
- (same as Recipe 263 — use slightly older, more sour batter
- which works better for uttapam than fresh batter)
- Salt to taste
- TOPPINGS (customize freely):
- 1 small onion, finely diced
- 1 medium tomato, finely diced (deseed to reduce moisture)
- 1 green chilli, very thinly sliced
- ½ small green or red pepper, finely diced
- Fresh coriander leaves, chopped
- 1 tsp grated fresh ginger
- Oil for cooking

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Season batter with salt if not already seasoned. The batter should be slightly thick — thicker than dosa batter. If too thin, stir in 1–2 tbsps rice flour to thicken slightly.
2. Mix all topping vegetables together in a bowl.
3. Heat a tawa or heavy flat pan over medium heat. Brush lightly with oil.
4. Pour a generous ladleful (about 80ml) of batter onto the center of the pan. DO NOT spread thin like a dosa. Let it settle into a thick circle naturally — about 15–18cm and 8–10mm thick.
5. Immediately scatter a generous handful of the vegetable mixture over the entire wet surface. Press gently with the back of a spoon so they embed slightly into the batter.
6. Drizzle 1 tsp oil around the edges.
7. Cover with a lid. Cook on medium-low heat 4–5 minutes until the surface looks mostly set (not wet) and edges turn slightly golden.
8. Flip carefully — the vegetable side is now the bottom. Cook 2 minutes uncovered.
9. Serve hot with coconut chutney and sambar.

Prep: 5 min (batter already made) · Cook: 7 min per uttapam · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per uttapam

TIP

The lid during cooking is essential for uttapam — unlike dosa which is cooked uncovered. The trapped steam cooks the thick batter from the top while the bottom develops its crust. Without the lid, the center stays raw while the edges overcook.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic South Indian] [Customizable]

RECIPE 273

■■ India (Karnataka / Tamil Nadu)

RAVA KESARI

A South Indian temple sweet served as a breakfast item in Karnataka — golden semolina cooked with ghee, sugar, saffron, and cashews into a fragrant, slightly sticky sweet porridge. Eaten at weddings, religious celebrations, and temple breakfasts, it is simultaneously simple and deeply satisfying. The saffron turns it a vivid amber-gold.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup fine semolina (rava / sooji)
- 1 cup sugar (adjust to taste)
- 3 cups hot water
- 4 tbsp ghee (generous — this is a celebration dish)
- ¼ tsp saffron strands, bloomed in 2 tbsp warm milk
- ½ tsp cardamom powder
- 10 cashews, halved
- 2 tbsp raisins
- A few drops orange food color (optional — traditional
- for the vibrant color)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat 2 tbsp ghee in a heavy pan over medium heat.
2. Add cashews. Fry until golden. Remove and set aside.
3. Add raisins to the same ghee. Fry 30 seconds until they puff. Remove and set aside.
4. Add remaining 2 tbsp ghee to the pan.
5. Add semolina. Roast over medium heat, stirring constantly, 5–6 minutes until: — Color turns slightly golden — Aroma becomes nutty and fragrant — Individual grains feel dry and separate This step is crucial for preventing lumps.
6. Meanwhile, bring water to a rolling boil separately.
7. Reduce heat under semolina to low. CAREFULLY pour boiling water into the roasted semolina all at once while stirring vigorously. The mixture will splutter — stand back slightly.
8. Stir constantly 2 minutes until water is absorbed and semolina is cooked.
9. Add sugar. Stir well — the mixture will loosen as sugar dissolves, then thicken again.
10. Add bloomed saffron with its milk. Stir.
11. Add cardamom powder and food color if using.
12. Continue stirring on low heat 3–4 more minutes until kesari comes together and leaves the sides of the pan cleanly.
13. Mix in fried cashews and raisins.
14. Serve warm. Optionally shape into small mounds using a greased bowl or cup for presentation.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Pouring boiling (not warm) water creates a fundamental difference in texture — the sudden heat cooks the roasted semolina instantly on contact, preventing lumps from forming. Warm water causes the semolina to clump before it can absorb evenly. Always boil the water separately.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Karnataka] [Festive]

RECIPE 274

■■ India (Delhi / Punjab)

CHOLE BHATURE

Delhi's most iconic street breakfast — a rich, deeply spiced chickpea curry (chole) alongside a puffy, deep-fried leavened bread (bhatura) that puffs dramatically in hot oil. Eaten at street stalls throughout Old Delhi and Chandni Chowk since the 1940s, accompanied by kulcha, raw onions, and achaar. The bhatura must be eaten immediately — it deflates within minutes.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE CHOLE

- 2 cups dried chickpeas, soaked overnight (or 2 cans)
- 2 tea bags (for dark color — traditional method)
- 2 large onions, finely diced
- 3 medium tomatoes, blended or finely chopped
- 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste
- 2 tbsp chole masala powder
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp cumin powder
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp amchur (dry mango powder)
- 1 tsp black cardamom powder
- 3 tbsp oil
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander, raw onion rings, lemon wedge to serve

FOR THE BHATURE

- 2 cups all-purpose flour (maida)
- ½ cup semolina (rava)
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- ½ cup plain yogurt
- 2 tbsp oil
- Warm water as needed
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CHOLE (cook ahead): Pressure cook soaked chickpeas with tea bags and enough water, 20–25 minutes until very tender. Drain (keep liquid). Discard tea bags.
2. Heat oil in a large pan. Add onion. Cook 10 minutes until deep golden — this depth of color is essential.
3. Add ginger-garlic paste. Cook 2 minutes.
4. Add blended tomatoes and all spice powders except amchur. Cook 8–10 minutes until oil separates from the masala.
5. Add cooked chickpeas and enough cooking liquid to reach a thick gravy consistency.
6. Simmer 20 minutes. Mash some chickpeas against the side of the pan. Add amchur. Season. The chole should be dark, thick, and intensely spiced.
7. BHATURE DOUGH: Combine flour, semolina, sugar, baking powder, baking soda, and salt.
8. Add yogurt and oil. Mix. Add warm water gradually to form a soft, smooth dough — slightly softer than roti dough.
9. Cover with a damp cloth. Rest 30 minutes minimum.
10. Divide into 8 balls. Roll each into an oval — slightly thicker than a puri (4mm).
11. Heat oil in a deep pan to 185°C (365°F).
12. Slide bhatura into hot oil. Immediately press gently with a slotted spoon to encourage puffing.
13. Fry 30–45 seconds per side until golden and puffed.
14. Drain. Serve IMMEDIATELY alongside hot chole, raw onion rings, green chilli, and lemon wedge.

Prep: 30 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~560 per serving

TIP

The dark color of authentic Delhi chole comes from cooking onions to a very deep golden-brown (nearly dark), using tea bags during chickpea cooking, and using a good quality dark chole masala. Each step adds depth and darkness. Do not rush the onions.

[Vegan] [High Protein] [Classic Delhi] [Street Food]

RECIPE 275

■■ India

MASALA CHAI

India's national beverage — strong black tea simmered with fresh ginger, cardamom, cinnamon, clove, and whole milk until a deep, spiced tea-milk is created. Served scalding hot in small glasses or ceramic cups. Drunk at every Indian breakfast, every chai break, at every train station, and on every occasion. No recipe in this book is made more often by more people.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups water
- 2 cups whole milk
- 2 tbsp loose Assam or CTC (crush, tear, curl) black tea
- leaves (not bags — the tannins are different)
- 3cm fresh ginger, grated or crushed
- 4 green cardamom pods, lightly crushed
- 1 small cinnamon stick
- 2 cloves
- ¼ tsp fennel seeds (optional — for sweetness)
- 1–2 black peppercorns (optional — for heat)
- Sugar to taste (2–3 tsp typically)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine water, crushed ginger, cardamom pods, cinnamon stick, cloves, and peppercorns in a saucepan.
2. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat.
3. Reduce heat slightly. Let spices simmer in the water for 2–3 minutes to steep their flavors.
4. Add loose tea leaves. Let boil for 1 minute.
5. Add milk all at once.
6. Increase heat. Bring the entire mixture to a full boil. Watch carefully — it will rise quickly.
7. As soon as it rises to the rim of the pan, reduce heat. Let simmer 1–2 minutes.
8. For a stronger, more brewed chai: bring to a boil a second time (known as "double boiling").
9. Add sugar. Stir to dissolve.
10. Strain through a fine mesh sieve into cups.
11. Serve piping hot. Drink immediately.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~130 per cup

TIP

CTC tea (the pellet-form of tea used by chai vendors across India) creates a stronger, more robust brew that stands up to boiling with milk and spices. Regular tea bags or loose leaf Darjeeling produce a more delicate result. For street chai character, use CTC Assam — available at any Indian grocery store.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Indian] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 276

■ ■ India (Mumbai)

ANDA BHURJI

Mumbai's legendary spiced scrambled eggs — cooked in oil with onions, tomatoes, ginger, garlic, and a masala blend until the eggs are soft, slightly dry, and packed with flavor. Eaten with pav (soft bread rolls) or paratha, anda bhurji is the quintessential Mumbai street breakfast — ready in 10 minutes and supremely satisfying at any hour.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 1 medium onion, finely diced
- 2 medium tomatoes, finely diced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tsp ginger-garlic paste
- ½ tsp turmeric powder
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp coriander powder
- ¼ tsp garam masala
- 2 tbsp oil or butter
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Pav (Indian soft rolls) or buttered bread to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oil in a pan over medium heat.
2. Add diced onion. Cook 5–6 minutes until golden.
3. Add ginger-garlic paste. Cook 1 minute until raw smell disappears.
4. Add green chillies. Stir 30 seconds.
5. Add diced tomatoes, turmeric, red chilli powder, coriander powder, and salt.
6. Cook 5 minutes, pressing tomatoes, until they completely break down and the masala looks dry with oil separating at the edges.
7. Beat eggs lightly with a fork. Pour over the masala.
8. Stir immediately and continuously with a spatula, folding the egg into the masala as it cooks.
9. Cook over medium heat 3–4 minutes until eggs are just set — slightly soft and moist. Do not overcook to a dry, rubbery texture.
10. Add garam masala. Stir briefly.
11. Scatter fresh coriander generously.
12. Serve hot with buttered pav, paratha, or toast.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The masala base must be cooked completely dry before adding eggs — wet masala steams the eggs rather than scrambling them, creating a watery result. Cook until you can see the oil separating at the edges of the tomato mixture. That is the moment to add eggs.

RECIPE 277

■■ India (Gujarat)

DHOKLA

Gujarat's pride — light, spongy steamed savory cake made from fermented chickpea flour and yogurt batter, with a tempering of mustard seeds, green chilli, and curry leaves poured over the warm cake, finished with fresh coriander and grated coconut. High in protein, naturally gluten-free, and ready in 30 minutes using instant fermentation (no overnight wait required for this quick version).

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE DHOKLA BATTER

- 1 cup chickpea flour (besan), sifted
- ¼ cup fine semolina (rava)
- ¾ cup plain yogurt (not too sour)
- ¼ cup warm water
- 1 tsp ginger paste
- 1 tsp green chilli paste
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp turmeric
- Salt to taste
- 1½ tsp Eno fruit salt (or 1 tsp baking soda with ½ tsp citric acid) — added just before steaming

FOR THE TEMPERING

- 2 tbsp oil
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- 2 green chillies, slit
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- 2 tbsp sugar dissolved in 4 tbsp water
- (sugar water — for moisture and shine)
- Fresh coriander and grated coconut to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine besan, semolina, yogurt, warm water, ginger paste, chilli paste, sugar, turmeric, and salt. Mix until completely smooth. The batter should be thick but pourable.
2. Set the batter aside 10 minutes.
3. Grease a round baking dish or thali (22cm) very well with oil.
4. Set up a steamer — bring water to a full boil.
5. Just before steaming: Add Eno fruit salt directly to the batter. Add 1 tbsp water over the Eno. Mix quickly and vigorously for 10 seconds only — the batter will foam. Do not over-mix.
6. IMMEDIATELY pour into the greased dish.
7. Place in the steamer. Cover tightly.
8. Steam over high heat 15–18 minutes until a toothpick inserted in the center comes out clean.
9. Cool 5 minutes. Run a knife around the edges. Cut into diamond or square shapes in the dish.
10. TEMPERING: Heat oil in a small pan. Add mustard seeds until they pop. Add sesame seeds and curry leaves. Sizzle 10 seconds. Add green chillies. Pour the hot tempering over the cut dhokla.
11. Drizzle sugar water evenly over the dhokla — this prevents it from drying and adds the shine.
12. Garnish with fresh coriander and grated coconut.
13. Serve with green chutney and tamarind chutney.

Prep: 15 min • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 6 • Cal: ~185 per serving

TIP

Eno fruit salt (antacid) is the instant leavening that replaces the traditional overnight fermentation. It must be added LAST — immediately before the batter goes into the steamer. Every second of delay after adding Eno reduces the lift it provides. Mix quickly, pour immediately, cover fast.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Gujarati]

RECIPE 278

■■ India (Kerala)

APPAM WITH COCONUT MILK

Kerala's most beautiful breakfast — a bowl-shaped rice crêpe with a crispy, lacy edge and a soft, pillow-like center, made from fermented rice batter with coconut milk. Served in pairs alongside warm, sweet coconut milk poured into the hollow center. The combination of the sour crêpe and the sweet, fragrant coconut milk is one of the world's most elegant breakfast pairings.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE APPAM BATTER (make the night before):
- 2 cups raw rice (not parboiled), soaked 4–6 hours
- ½ cup freshly grated coconut (or frozen)
- ½ tsp instant yeast OR 3 tbsp cooked rice
- (the cooked rice method is traditional)
- 1 tsp sugar
- Salt to taste
- Water as needed for blending

FOR THE SWEET COCONUT MILK

- 400ml (1 can) coconut milk (full fat)
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 2 green cardamom pods, crushed
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BATTER: Drain soaked rice. Blend with grated coconut and just enough water to create a very smooth, silky batter — no grit when rubbed between fingers.
2. Dissolve yeast and sugar in 3 tbsp warm water. Add to the batter. OR add cooked rice to the blender with the raw rice for traditional fermentation.
3. Batter consistency should resemble thin pancake batter. Cover and ferment at room temperature overnight (10–12 hours). The batter will rise slightly and develop a pleasant sourness.
4. Next morning: add salt and stir. If batter seems too thick, add a little water to thin slightly.
5. COCONUT MILK: Warm coconut milk with sugar, crushed cardamom, and a pinch of salt. Do not boil — just warm until sugar dissolves. Keep warm on very low heat.
6. COOKING APPAM: Heat a traditional appachatti (appam pan — a small, deep, rounded wok-like pan) or a small non-stick wok over medium heat. Brush very lightly with oil.
7. Pour a small ladleful of batter into the center.
8. IMMEDIATELY pick up the pan and swirl it in a circular motion — the batter should travel up the sides, leaving a thick center and thin edges. This must be done in one quick, confident swirl.
9. Cover with a lid.
10. Cook 2–3 minutes until the edges are golden, lacy, and crispy — and the center is cooked through but soft and slightly custardy.
11. Do NOT flip — appam is cooked on one side only.
12. Slide onto a plate. The center should be white, soft, and slightly puffy. The edges should be crispy and golden.
13. Serve immediately with warm sweet coconut milk poured alongside (or into the center hollow).

Prep: 20 min + overnight fermentation · Cook: 3 min per appam · Serves: 4

TIP

The swirling technique is the art of appam — the pan must be hot enough that the batter sets immediately on contact but not so hot that it burns. Practice with the first two appam before expecting perfection. The right heat level is when the batter sizzles upon contact and sets within 10 seconds of being swirled.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Kerala] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 279

■■ India (Kerala)

PUTTU AND KADALA CURRY

Kerala's most traditional breakfast — cylindrical steamed rice cakes (puttu) made in a bamboo or metal steamer, alternating layers of rice flour and grated coconut, served alongside a dark, intensely spiced black chickpea curry. The puttu's gentle sweetness from the coconut against the robust spiced chickpeas creates one of South India's most complete and satisfying breakfast combinations.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PUTTU

- 2 cups rice flour (puttu podi — roasted rice flour
- specifically for puttu, or roast regular rice flour
- in a dry pan 5 minutes until fragrant)
- 1 cup freshly grated coconut (or frozen)
- Pinch of salt
- Warm water, as needed

FOR THE KADALA CURRY (BLACK CHICKPEA CURRY)

- 1½ cups kala chana (black chickpeas), soaked overnight
- 2 medium onions, thinly sliced
- 2 medium tomatoes, chopped
- 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste
- ½ cup freshly grated coconut (for grinding)
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp black pepper powder
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp garam masala
- 1 tsp coriander seeds (for tempering)
- TEMPERING: coconut oil + mustard seeds + curry leaves
- + dried red chilli
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KADALA CURRY (make ahead or the day before): Pressure cook black chickpeas with turmeric and salt until very tender (4–5 whistles). Drain, reserving cooking liquid.
2. Roast grated coconut (the ½ cup for grinding) in a dry pan until golden. Grind with a little water to a smooth paste.
3. Heat coconut oil in a deep pan. Add onions. Cook 12–15 minutes until very dark golden.
4. Add ginger-garlic paste. Cook 2 minutes.
5. Add tomatoes, coriander powder, pepper, red chilli, and garam masala. Cook 8 minutes until oil separates.
6. Add ground coconut paste. Cook 3 minutes.
7. Add cooked chickpeas with enough cooking liquid to create a thick, dark gravy.
8. Simmer 15 minutes. Season with salt.
9. Make tempering: heat coconut oil, add mustard seeds until they pop, add dried red chillies and curry leaves. Pour over curry. Stir in.
10. PUTTU: Mix rice flour with salt. Sprinkle warm water over the flour — a little at a time — rubbing between your fingers as you go. The texture should be like wet sand — moist but not wet. When you press a handful, it should hold shape but break apart when pressed harder.
11. Fill a puttu maker: start with a layer of grated coconut, then rice flour, then coconut, then flour, ending with coconut. Do not pack tight.
12. Steam over boiling water 5–7 minutes until steam comes through the holes at the top.
13. Push the puttu cylinder out onto a plate.
14. Serve 2 puttu cylinders per person alongside a generous bowl of hot kadala curry.

Prep: 25 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~410 per serving

TIP

The moisture level of puttu flour is everything. Too wet and the puttu becomes a dense, solid brick. Too dry and it crumbles when pushed from the mold. The correct texture is "wet sand" — hold a handful, press firmly, and it should hold its shape just barely before crumbling. Adjust with water or dry flour.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Kerala]

RECIPE 280

■■ India (Maharashtra)

MISAL PAV

Maharashtra's most fierce and beloved breakfast — sprouted moth beans cooked in a fiery coconut-and-spice gravy (misal), topped with crunchy farsan (fried snack mix), raw diced onion, fresh coriander, and a squeeze of lime, served alongside buttered pav rolls. Pune, Nashik, Kolhapur, and Mumbai all claim the definitive version. All are extraordinary. All are dangerously spicy.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE SPROUTED MOTH BEANS (matki):
- 1 cup moth beans (matki) OR mixed sprouts —
- soaked 8 hours, then drained and left in a cloth
- for 24 hours to sprout
- ½ tsp turmeric
- Salt
- FOR THE MISAL GRAVY (rassa):
- 2 onions, finely diced
- 2 tomatoes, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste
- ½ cup freshly grated coconut (roasted)
- 2 tbsp goda masala OR regular garam masala
- 1 tsp red chilli powder (Kolhapuri chilli preferred)
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp cumin powder
- ¼ tsp turmeric
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- Salt to taste
- 400ml hot water
- TOPPINGS (essential — these define misal):
- Farsan (fried chickpea noodle snack mix) — generous
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 lime, cut in wedges
- 4 pav buns (Indian soft rolls), buttered and lightly toasted

INSTRUCTIONS

1. COOK SPROUTS: Pressure cook sprouted matki with turmeric, salt, and 1 cup water for 1 whistle — they should be cooked but hold their shape. Or boil 15 minutes until just tender. Set aside.
2. GRAVY: Dry roast the grated coconut in a pan until golden brown. Cool and grind with minimal water to a smooth paste.
3. Heat oil in a deep pan. Add onions. Cook 10 minutes until deep golden.
4. Add ginger-garlic paste. Cook 2 minutes.
5. Add tomatoes. Cook 6 minutes until completely broken down.
6. Add all spice powders. Cook 2 minutes.
7. Add ground coconut paste. Cook 3–4 minutes until oil separates clearly.
8. Add hot water. Bring to a boil.
9. Add cooked sprouts. Simmer 10 minutes.
10. The gravy should be thin and soupy (rassyacha misal) — not thick. Adjust with water.
11. Taste — it should be fiery, complex, and deeply spiced.
12. ASSEMBLY (done at the table, individually): — Ladle generous misal with sprouts into a bowl — Pour extra gravy alongside or into the bowl — Pile farsan generously on top — it will soften — Scatter raw diced onion and fresh coriander — Squeeze lime over everything — Eat with buttered pav, breaking off pieces to scoop up the misal

Prep: 20 min + 24 hrs sprouting · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~460 per serving

TIP

Goda masala is Maharashtra's unique spice blend — darker, slightly sweeter, and more complex than garam masala. It contains dry coconut, sesame, stone flower, and other spices not found in standard garam masala. Find it at Indian grocery stores. It makes an enormous difference to the depth of the misal.

[Vegan] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Maharashtra]

RECIPE 281

■■ India (North India / Rajasthan)

BESAN CHILLA

CHICKPEA FLOUR SAVORY PANCAKE

Besan chilla — thin, crispy, protein-packed savory pancakes made entirely from chickpea flour batter with vegetables and spices — are one of North India's most nutritious quick breakfasts. No fermentation, no soaking, no waiting. Mix the batter, rest 5 minutes, and cook. Each pancake is a complete protein meal. Eaten with green chutney and yogurt, they are deeply satisfying and astonishingly simple.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE CHILLA BATTER

- 1 cup chickpea flour (besan), sifted
- ½ cup water (approximately)
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 1 medium tomato, very finely diced
- 1 green chilli, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tsp grated fresh ginger
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp ajwain (carom seeds — for digestion)
- Salt to taste
- Oil for cooking
- FILLING (optional — for stuffed chilla):
- 3 tbsp paneer, crumbled
- Pinch of chilli powder and salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Sift chickpea flour into a bowl.
2. Add all vegetables, spices, and seasonings.
3. Add water gradually, whisking, to create a smooth, lump-free batter — the consistency of thin cream. It should spread easily on a pan. Not too thick (doughy result) and not too thin (won't hold together).
4. Rest 5 minutes — besan absorbs water slowly.
5. Heat a flat non-stick pan or tawa over medium heat. Brush with ½ tsp oil.
6. Pour a small ladleful of batter into the center. Using the back of the ladle, spread in circles to a 20cm crêpe — slightly thicker than dosa (about 5mm).
7. Drizzle ½ tsp oil around the edges.
8. Cook 2–3 minutes until edges look set, the surface looks dry, and the bottom is golden.
9. FOR STUFFED VERSION: Place 1 tbsp crumbled seasoned paneer in the center before flipping.
10. Flip carefully. Cook 1–2 minutes on the second side. The chilla should be golden and slightly crispy — not pale and doughy.
11. Serve hot with fresh green mint-coriander chutney and a bowl of cold yogurt.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 5 min per chilla · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~210 per chilla

TIP

Besan batter thickens as it rests because the flour absorbs water gradually. If the batter seems too thick after resting, add a tablespoon of water and stir. Always check consistency before cooking the second chilla — adjust with water as needed throughout the cooking session.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Quick] [Classic North Indian]

RECIPE 282

■■ India (Karnataka)

AKKI ROTTI

Karnataka's beloved rice flour flatbread — mixed with onion, grated coconut, curry leaves, green chilli, and coriander, then pressed directly onto a hot greased griddle with wet fingers into a thin, irregular circle. The edges become crispy and golden while the center stays soft. Eaten with coconut chutney and a smear of butter — this is Bangalore's morning staple.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups rice flour (fine, white)
- 1 cup freshly grated coconut (or frozen)
- 1 medium onion, very finely diced
- 2–3 green chillies, finely chopped
- 10 fresh curry leaves, finely torn
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tsp sesame seeds (optional)
- Salt to taste
- Warm water, as needed (approximately 200ml)
- Oil for the griddle

FOR SERVING

- Fresh coconut chutney
- Good quality salted butter
- Plain yogurt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rice flour, grated coconut, diced onion, green chillies, curry leaves, coriander, cumin seeds, sesame seeds, and salt in a large bowl.
2. Add warm water gradually, mixing with your hands, until a soft, pliable dough forms — softer than chapati dough, slightly stickier. The dough should hold together when pressed but not be overly wet.
3. Divide into 6–8 balls.
4. Heat a flat griddle (tawa) or cast iron pan over medium-high heat. Brush generously with oil.
5. Place one dough ball in the center of the hot, oiled pan.
6. With WET FINGERS (dip fingers in water frequently), press and pat the dough outward from the center into a thin circle — about 18–20cm. The wetness prevents sticking. Work quickly.
7. Make a small hole in the center (allows even cooking).
8. Drizzle ½ tsp oil around the edges and over the surface.
9. Cover with a lid. Cook on medium heat 3 minutes until the surface looks set and edges are golden.
10. Flip carefully — it should release cleanly from a well-oiled pan.
11. Cook uncovered 2 minutes on the second side until crispy and golden patches appear.
12. Serve hot with coconut chutney and butter.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 6 min per rotli · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~230 per rotli

TIP

Wet fingers are the essential technique for pressing akki rotli — dry hands cause the dough to stick to your fingers and tear. Keep a bowl of water beside the stove and wet your fingers before every press. The more generously the pan is oiled, the more cleanly the rotli flips.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Karnataka] [Quick]

RECIPE 283

■■ India (Punjab / North India)

LACHHA PARATHA

The most beautiful of Indian flatbreads — layers upon delicate layers of whole wheat, created by rolling, folding, and coiling the dough before final rolling, so each cooked paratha shatters into separating flaky layers like an Indian mille-feuille. The technique takes 10 minutes to learn and produces a flatbread of extraordinary texture. Served with dal, pickle, or simply ghee.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp oil
- Warm water to make a soft dough

FOR LAYERING

- Ghee or soft butter — very generous (3–4 tbsp total)
- Dry wheat flour for dusting

FOR SERVING

- Ghee
- Dal makhani or any lentil dish
- Mango pickle
- Plain yogurt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **DOUGH:** Combine atta, salt, and oil. Add warm water gradually while kneading until a very soft, smooth, pliable dough forms — softer than you think necessary. Knead 5 minutes. Cover. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Divide into 4 balls.
3. Roll one ball into a thin circle (20cm / 8 inches).
4. **LAYERING TECHNIQUE:** — Spread ½ tsp ghee/butter evenly over the entire surface. — Dust lightly with dry flour. — Fold in half (semicircle). Apply more ghee. Dust with flour. — Fold in half again (quarter). Apply a touch more ghee. — Now: take the triangular quarter and roll it out into a thin circle again (20cm). — **ALTERNATIVELY:** After the first ghee spread and flour, pleat the circle accordion-style from one edge to the other, creating a long pleated strip. Then coil this strip into a spiral snail. Flatten the spiral with your palm. Roll into a 20cm circle.
5. **COOKING:** Heat a tawa over medium-high heat.
6. Place paratha on the dry tawa. Cook 1 minute until bubbles appear.
7. Flip. Spread ½ tsp ghee on the upward surface. Spread over the entire paratha.
8. Cook 1 minute. Flip again. Spread ghee on this side.
9. Press firmly with a spatula. Cook until golden patches form on both sides — the ghee should sizzle.
10. Remove. Immediately crush gently with both hands (or clap the paratha between your palms) — this separates the layers dramatically.
11. Serve with a drizzle of extra ghee on top.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 5 min per paratha · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per paratha

TIP

The crushing of the freshly cooked paratha between your palms is the final, crucial step — it separates and reveals the layers, creating the characteristic fluffy, pull-apart texture of lachha paratha. Skip this step and you have a flat paratha. Do it and you have a masterpiece.

[Vegetarian] [Classic North Indian] [Weekend Project] [Bread]

RECIPE 284

■■ India (Rajasthan / UP)

KACHORI WITH ALOO SABZI

Jaipur's iconic street breakfast — flaky, crispy deep-fried pastry rounds stuffed with a spiced lentil filling (dal kachori), served alongside a thin spiced potato curry (aloo sabzi) and tamarind chutney. Eaten at every corner shop and street stall in Rajasthan from 6am, kachori is one of India's most satisfying deep-fried breakfast pastries — worth every moment of preparation.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE KACHORI DOUGH

- 2 cups all-purpose flour (maida)
- ½ tsp salt
- ¼ tsp baking powder
- 4 tbsp ghee or oil
- Cold water to bind (approximately 120ml)

FOR THE LENTIL FILLING

- ½ cup urad dal (black gram, skinned), soaked 2 hours
- 1 tsp fennel seeds (saunf)
- 1 tsp coriander seeds, crushed
- ½ tsp garam masala
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- 1 tsp amchur (dry mango powder)
- ½ tsp ginger powder (sonth)
- Salt and 1 tsp oil

FOR THE ALOO SABZI

- 3 medium potatoes, boiled and cubed
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- ¼ tsp asafoetida (hing)
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp garam masala
- 1 tsp amchur
- 2 tbsp oil
- Salt
- Fresh coriander and green chilli
- Oil for deep frying
- Tamarind chutney and green chutney to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Rub ghee into flour until it resembles breadcrumbs. Add salt and baking powder. Add cold water gradually — bind into a stiff dough (stiffer than regular dough). DO NOT knead. Just bring together and press into a flat disc. Cover. Rest 30 minutes. Note: Minimal handling prevents gluten development — this keeps kachori flaky and delicate.
2. FILLING: Drain soaked dal. Grind coarsely — not completely smooth, some texture is good.
3. Heat 1 tsp oil in a pan. Add coarsely ground dal. Fry stirring 3–4 minutes until it dries out.
4. Add fennel, coriander, garam masala, red chilli, amchur, and ginger powder. Mix well. Cook 2 minutes. Remove from heat. Cool completely.
5. ALOO SABZI: Heat oil in a pan. Add cumin seeds and asafoetida. Add boiled potato cubes. Add all spice powders. Toss to coat. Add a splash of water. Simmer 5 minutes. Season. Add coriander.
6. SHAPE KACHORI: Divide dough into 10 balls. Flatten each into a small cup shape with your thumb. Place 1 tbsp filling in the center. Bring edges together and press firmly to seal. Roll gently into a flat disc (6cm diameter, 1cm thick). Do not roll too thin — kachori must be substantial.
7. Heat oil to 160°C (320°F) — important: lower than usual. Kachori must fry slowly to puff properly.
8. Slide kachori gently into the oil. Fry 8–10 minutes, turning occasionally, until deep golden all over. Low temperature = slow fry = maximum puffing.
9. Drain. Rest 2 minutes.
10. Serve alongside hot aloo sabzi and both chutneys.

Prep: 35 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 5 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Low frying temperature (160°C) is the secret to kachori that puffs beautifully and cooks all the way through without burning. High temperature browns the outside while the dough inside stays raw and doughy. If your oil is too hot (kachori browns in under 3 minutes), reduce the heat immediately.

[Vegan] [Classic Rajasthan] [Street Food] [Festive]

RECIPE 285

■■ India (Tamil Nadu)

ADAI

A Tamil Nadu mixed lentil crêpe — thicker and more substantial than dosa, made from a blend of rice and multiple lentils ground with red chillies and asafoetida. Unlike dosa, adai requires no fermentation — just soaking and grinding. Protein-rich, robust in flavor, and eaten with aviyal (mixed vegetable dish) or jaggery and butter in Tamil homes every morning.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE ADAI BATTER (soak 4-6 hours):
 - ¾ cup raw rice
 - ¼ cup chana dal (split chickpeas)
 - ¼ cup toor dal (split pigeon peas)
 - ¼ cup urad dal (black gram, skinned)
 - 3 dried red chillies (or adjust to taste)
 - ½ tsp asafoetida (hing — very important for flavor)
 - 1 tsp cumin seeds
 - 3 green chillies (optional — for extra heat)
 - 1 inch fresh ginger, roughly chopped
 - Salt to taste
- ADDITIONS TO BATTER (after grinding):
 - 1 small onion, very finely diced
 - 10 fresh curry leaves, finely torn
 - 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
 - 3 tbsp freshly grated coconut (optional)
 - Oil for cooking

FOR SERVING

- Jaggery (traditional pairing) and butter
- OR Aviyal (mixed vegetable curry)
- OR Coconut chutney

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak rice and all three dals together in cold water for 4–6 hours. Do NOT soak separately — soak all together.
2. Drain. Transfer to a blender.
3. Add dried red chillies, asafoetida, cumin seeds, green chillies, and ginger.
4. Grind with minimal water to a COARSE, thick batter — this is different from dosa batter. The texture should be rougher, with some pieces of dal still slightly visible. Not completely smooth. This coarser texture creates the characteristic holes and crunchiness of adai.
5. The batter should be much thicker than dosa batter — it should fall slowly from a ladle, not flow freely.
6. Add salt. Stir in diced onion, curry leaves, fresh coriander, and coconut.
7. COOKING: Heat a tawa or iron griddle over medium heat. Oil generously.
8. Pour a generous ladleful of thick batter. Spread into a circle (18cm) using the back of the ladle in concentric circles — it will be thicker than a dosa and will not spread as thin.
9. Make a few small holes in the surface with the tip of a spoon (this helps even cooking and oil can pool in the holes).
10. Drizzle 1 tsp oil around the edges and into the holes.
11. Cook 3–4 minutes over medium heat until the surface looks completely set and the edges are golden.
12. Flip carefully. Cook 2 minutes — the second side develops more color and crunch.
13. Serve hot with jaggery + butter OR with coconut chutney.

Prep: 15 min + 4-6 hrs soaking · Cook: 6 min per adai · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~265 per adai

TIP

Adai must be ground coarse — the opposite of dosa batter. The rough texture creates the distinctive holes that form during cooking, allowing oil to seep in and create the characteristic crispy, lacy edges. A completely smooth adai batter produces a flat, dense result with none of the textural complexity that makes adai special.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Tamil Nadu]

RECIPE 286

■■ India (Maharashtra)

THALIPEETH

Maharashtra's multi-flour breakfast flatbread — made from a specially prepared flour blend (bhajani) of roasted rice, jowar, wheat, chickpea, and lentil flours, mixed with onion, green chilli, and spices. Pressed directly onto the tawa with a wet hand and cooked until golden. Thalipeeth is more nutritious than any single-grain bread — a complete protein and carbohydrate meal in one flat disc.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR BHAJANI (multi-grain flour — make a large batch):
- ½ cup rice, roasted
- ½ cup jowar (sorghum) flour or sorghum grain, roasted
- ½ cup whole wheat, roasted
- ¼ cup chana dal, roasted
- ¼ cup urad dal, roasted
- ¼ cup dried coriander seeds (roasted with the grains)
- 1 tsp cumin seeds (roasted)
- 2 dried red chillies (roasted)
- Grind all together to a coarse flour — this is bhajani

FOR ONE BATCH OF THALIPEETH DOUGH

- 2 cups bhajani flour
- 1 medium onion, very finely diced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 10 fresh curry leaves, finely torn
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tsp sesame seeds
- Salt to taste
- Warm water as needed
- Oil for cooking
- Butter or ghee to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BHAJANI: If making fresh, roast each grain and dal separately in a dry pan until golden and fragrant. Cool completely. Grind together with coriander seeds, cumin, and red chillies to a coarse flour. Store excess in an airtight jar — it keeps 2 months.
2. THALIPEETH DOUGH: Combine bhajani, onion, green chillies, curry leaves, coriander, turmeric, cumin, sesame, and salt.
3. Add warm water gradually, kneading gently, until a soft but not sticky dough forms. The dough will feel rougher than wheat dough — this is expected from the multigrain flour.
4. Rest 10 minutes covered.
5. Divide into 4 balls.
6. Place a piece of oiled plastic wrap or banana leaf on the tawa (helps with pressing and prevents sticking). Oil the surface well.
7. Place a dough ball in the center. With a WET HAND, press outward from the center into a thin circle (18–20cm). Keep wetting your hand as you press.
8. Make 3–4 small holes in the surface.
9. Remove the plastic (if used). Heat the tawa to medium-high. Place the pressed thalipeeth on it.
10. Drizzle oil into the holes and around the edges.
11. Cook 3 minutes until golden on the bottom.
12. Flip. Add a little oil. Cook 2–3 minutes.
13. Serve hot with a generous blob of butter or ghee melting on top, alongside yogurt and pickle.

Prep: 25 min (excluding bhajani prep) • Cook: 6 min per thalipeeth • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~290 per thalipeeth

TIP

Bhajani flour is the heart of thalipeeth and cannot be substituted with any single flour. The combination of roasted multigrain creates a deeply nutty, complex flavor impossible to replicate with a single grain. Make a large batch of bhajani at once — it stores well and thalipeeth can then be made in 15 minutes on any morning.

[Vegan] [High Fiber] [High Protein] [Classic Maharashtra]

RECIPE 287

■■ India (Pan-Indian)

SHEERA / SOOJI HALWA

India's most universally loved sweet breakfast — roasted semolina cooked with ghee, sugar, and warm milk into a golden, fragrant halwa with cardamom and garnished with cashews and raisins. Called sheera in Maharashtra, sooji halwa in North India, and kesari bath in Karnataka. Made at weddings, festivals, temples, and on any morning that deserves sweetness — which is all of them.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup coarse semolina (suji / rava)
- ½ cup sugar (adjust to taste)
- 3 cups warm milk or water (or a mix of both)
- 4 tbsp ghee (generous — do not reduce)
- ¼ tsp cardamom powder (freshly ground preferred)
- 10 cashews, halved
- 2 tbsp raisins
- Pinch of saffron bloomed in 2 tbsp warm milk
- Optional: a few drops yellow food color

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring milk (or water) to a near boil. Keep warm.
2. Heat 3 tbsp ghee in a heavy-bottomed pan over medium heat.
3. Add cashews. Fry until golden. Remove and set aside.
4. Add raisins to the same ghee. Fry 20 seconds until they puff. Remove and set aside.
5. Add remaining 1 tbsp ghee to the pan.
6. Add semolina. Roast over medium-low heat, stirring CONSTANTLY, 6–8 minutes until: — Color changes to pale golden — Each grain looks slightly separated and toasted — The aroma is nutty and warm — A few grains pressed between fingers feel dry Do NOT rush this step. Underroasted semolina creates a raw, starchy halwa.
7. Reduce heat to very low.
8. CAREFULLY pour warm milk/water over the roasted semolina all at once while stirring immediately. The mixture will splutter and steam dramatically. Keep stirring — no lumps should form.
9. Add sugar. Stir vigorously.
10. The mixture will loosen initially as sugar dissolves, then thicken as it cooks.
11. Add saffron milk and cardamom powder.
12. Cook 3–4 minutes on low heat, stirring, until the halwa leaves the sides of the pan and comes together as a mass.
13. Add fried cashews and raisins. Mix.
14. Serve warm in small bowls.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~390 per serving

TIP

The ratio of liquid to semolina determines the final consistency. 3 cups liquid to 1 cup semolina gives a soft, spoonable halwa. Use 2½ cups for a firmer halwa that can be shaped into portions. Both versions are correct — the difference is regional preference.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indian] [Festive] [Quick]

RECIPE 288

■■ India (Pan-Indian)

DAHI VADA

Soft, pillowy deep-fried urad dal dumplings soaked in cold, sweetened yogurt and topped with tamarind chutney, green chutney, roasted cumin powder, and red chilli. India's most popular breakfast chaat — simultaneously cool, warm, tangy, sweet, and spiced. Each component adds a different dimension, and the whole is unmistakably, joyfully Indian.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE VADA

- 1 cup urad dal (black gram, skinned), soaked 4 hours
- ½ inch fresh ginger
- 2 green chillies
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- Salt to taste
- Oil for deep frying

FOR SERVING

- 400g (1¾ cups) cold plain yogurt, whisked smooth
- 2 tbsp sugar (stirred into yogurt)
- 1 tsp roasted cumin powder
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- Black salt (kala namak) — a pinch
- 3 tbsp tamarind chutney (sweet and tangy)
- 2 tbsp green mint-coriander chutney
- Sev (thin fried chickpea noodles) — for topping
- Fresh coriander leaves — for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked urad dal completely. Grind with ginger, green chillies, and minimal water to a very smooth, fluffy, white batter. The key: add as little water as possible. The batter should be very thick and hold its shape.
2. Beat the batter vigorously with a hand or spoon for 3–4 minutes — this incorporates air and makes the vadas light. A small ball of batter dropped in water should float — this indicates enough air.
3. Add cumin seeds, curry leaves, and salt. Mix.
4. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F) in a deep pan.
5. Wet your hand with water. Take a small amount of batter (golf ball size) and slide it gently into the oil. OR: use two wet spoons to form and drop the vada.
6. Fry 4–5 minutes, turning, until golden and cooked through — break one open to check the center.
7. Drain vadas immediately on paper towels.
8. While still hot, soak vadas in a bowl of warm salted water for 5–8 minutes — they will swell.
9. Remove. Gently squeeze out excess water by pressing between your palms (do this gently — they are fragile).
10. Arrange soaked vadas in a serving dish.
11. Pour cold sweetened yogurt generously over the vadas — they should be well-covered.
12. Drizzle tamarind chutney and green chutney.
13. Sprinkle cumin powder, red chilli, and black salt.
14. Top with sev and fresh coriander.
15. Serve immediately, or refrigerate and serve chilled.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hrs soaking · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Soaking the fried vadas in warm water is the step most people skip — but it transforms them from crispy fried balls to the soft, spongy, pillow-like texture essential to authentic dahi vada. The water soak rehydrates the interior while the yogurt provides the cold, creamy exterior contrast.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Indian] [Chaat]

RECIPE 289

■■ India (Mumbai)

VADA PAV

Mumbai's soul food and cheapest breakfast — a spiced potato patty coated in chickpea flour batter and deep-fried, tucked into a soft pav roll with dry garlic chutney, green chutney, fried green chilli, and tamarind chutney. The "Mumbai burger" costs less than a dollar at street stalls and is eaten by 10 million Mumbaikars daily. No food better represents the city.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE VADA (potato patty):
- 4 large potatoes, boiled and mashed (hot)
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tsp mustard seeds
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tsp lemon juice
- Salt to taste
- 1 tsp oil for tempering

FOR THE BATTER

- 1 cup chickpea flour (besan)
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- Pinch of asafoetida (hing)
- Salt
- Water to make a thick coating batter

FOR SERVING

- 6 pav buns (soft Indian dinner rolls)
- Dry garlic chutney (sukhi lasun chutney):
- — 8 garlic cloves + 3 tbsp dried coconut (roasted)
- + 1 tsp red chilli powder + salt — grind coarse
- Green coriander chutney
- Tamarind chutney
- 3 whole green chillies, deep fried
- Oil for frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. VADA FILLING: Heat 1 tsp oil. Add mustard seeds until they pop. Add curry leaves, ginger, garlic, and green chillies. Fry 30 seconds.
2. Add turmeric. Immediately add hot mashed potato.
3. Mix well. Add coriander, lemon juice, and salt.
4. Cool the mixture enough to handle. Shape into 6 smooth round flattened patties.
5. DRY GARLIC CHUTNEY: Grind all ingredients coarsely. No water. It should be a dry powder/paste. Set aside.
6. BATTER: Combine besan, turmeric, red chilli, asafoetida, and salt. Add water gradually to make a thick batter — it should coat the back of a spoon thickly without dripping.
7. Heat oil to 180°C (355°F).
8. Dip each potato patty in the batter, coating all over.
9. Slide gently into hot oil. Fry 3–4 minutes, turning once, until golden and crispy.
10. Fry whole green chillies (uncut) for 30 seconds alongside — they will pop and blister.
11. ASSEMBLY: — Split pav almost fully open. — Spread dry garlic chutney on the inside of both halves — generous. — Add a smear of green chutney on one half. — A drizzle of tamarind chutney on the other. — Place a hot vada inside. — Add a fried green chilli alongside the vada. — Press closed. Eat immediately.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~410 per vada pav

TIP

The dry garlic chutney is the defining element of a great vada pav — it provides the sharp, roasted garlic heat that no liquid chutney can replicate. It must be applied directly to the dry surface of the pav before any other chutney. Make it fresh and use generously.

[Vegan] [Classic Mumbai] [Street Food] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 290

■■ India (Maharashtra)

KANDA BHAJI

ONION PAKORAS

Maharashtra's irresistible monsoon breakfast — thin onion strips coated in a spiced chickpea flour batter and deep-fried into crunchy, golden fritters. Eaten with a cup of hot masala chai while watching the rain, kanda bhaji is the definitive Mumbai monsoon experience. Made in every household, sold on every street corner, and consumed with complete joy at any hour.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large onions, very thinly sliced
- (using a mandoline slicer if possible)
- 1½ cups chickpea flour (besan)
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp ajwain (carom seeds — important)
- 10 fresh curry leaves, finely chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tsp lemon juice
- Salt to taste
- Minimum water (onions release their own moisture)
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place thinly sliced onions in a large bowl. Add salt generously — 1½ tsp. Toss well. Let sit 10 minutes — the salt draws moisture from the onions. They will wilt and become very flexible.
2. Add green chillies, ginger, turmeric, red chilli, cumin, ajwain, curry leaves, and coriander.
3. Add besan. Mix well with your hands. The onion moisture will help bind the flour. Do NOT add water yet.
4. Mix until the besan coats all the onion strands. Add lemon juice. Mix again.
5. The mixture should now be moist enough to hold together loosely when squeezed. If very dry, add just 1–2 tbsp water. The batter should be thick and clingy — not thin and pourable.
6. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F).
7. Take a generous handful of the onion mixture. Drop it loosely into the oil — do not compress into a ball. The fritter should be irregular, with strands of onion sticking out — this creates the maximum surface area for crispiness.
8. Fry 4–5 minutes, turning, until deep golden all over. Each bhaji should be crunchy throughout.
9. Drain on paper towels.
10. Serve immediately with green chutney and a cup of masala chai. Do not delay.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The critical technique is using MINIMUM water — the onion moisture should provide almost all the binding needed. Watery batter creates soft, oil-absorbing bhajis rather than the shatteringly crunchy fritters desired. If you add too much water, spread the mixture on a tray and dust with extra besan to compensate.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Maharashtra] [Street Food] [Monsoon Food]

RECIPE 291

■■ India (Mumbai Street Food)

BREAD OMELETTE

The Mumbai street food genius — a spiced omelette cooked around or alongside buttered bread slices on the same pan, so the bread absorbs the egg and becomes unified with the omelette. Topped with chilli sauce, tomato ketchup, and butter, served piping hot from a griddle cart at dawn. India's fastest, cheapest, and most satisfying on-the-go breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs
- 2 slices white bread (soft sandwich bread)
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 1 medium tomato, finely diced
- 1–2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ¼ tsp red chilli powder
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp butter (for bread and for cooking)

FOR SERVING

- Butter (spread on finished bread omelette)
- Red chilli sauce or Sriracha
- Tomato ketchup
- Extra fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs with turmeric, red chilli, salt, and pepper.
2. Add diced onion, tomato, green chillies, and coriander. Mix into the egg.
3. Heat a flat pan or griddle over medium heat. Add 1 tbsp butter.
4. Butter both sides of the bread slices lightly.
5. Pour the egg mixture into the center of the pan — it should spread to the size of about 2 bread slices.
6. Immediately place both buttered bread slices on top of the egg mixture, pressing gently so each slice is embedded in the wet egg.
7. Cook 2–3 minutes until egg is set on the bottom.
8. Flip EVERYTHING together — bread and egg flip as one. The bread is now facing down in the pan.
9. Add a little more butter. Cook 1–2 minutes until the bread is golden and slightly toasted, and the remaining egg is cooked through.
10. Transfer to a plate with the bread facing up.
11. Spread butter generously over the toast surface.
12. Apply chilli sauce and ketchup in stripes.
13. Fold in half or serve flat. Scatter fresh coriander.
14. Eat immediately, ideally standing at a street cart.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The bread must be placed on the WET egg — not the set egg. The wet egg bonds to the bread as it cooks, making them inseparable when flipped. If you place bread on already-set egg, it simply sits on top and falls off when flipped — the street vendor trick is timing the bread placement perfectly.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Mumbai] [Street Food] [Budget]

RECIPE 292

■■ India (Karnataka)

BONDA SOUP

One of Karnataka's most unusual and beloved breakfast dishes — crispy urad dal bondas (deep-fried dumplings) dropped into a light, peppery, tamarind-tinged broth. The bonda softens slightly in the soup, creating alternating textures of crispy shell and soft interior with each spoonful. A specialty of Udupi and Mangalore that has spread across Karnataka and found a passionate following.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE BONDA

- ¾ cup urad dal, soaked 4 hours and ground smooth
- (same method as dahi vada — thick, fluffy batter)
- 1 tsp grated ginger
- 1 green chilli, finely chopped
- 8 fresh curry leaves, chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- ½ tsp black pepper, coarsely ground
- Salt to taste
- Oil for deep frying

FOR THE SOUP

- 1 large onion, thinly sliced
- 2 medium tomatoes, chopped
- 1 tsp black pepper, coarsely cracked
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tbsp tamarind paste
- 3 cups water or light vegetable broth
- 5 fresh curry leaves
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SOUP: Heat oil in a saucepan. Add cumin seeds and curry leaves. Let sizzle.
2. Add sliced onion. Cook 7 minutes until soft.
3. Add tomatoes. Cook 5 minutes until broken down.
4. Add turmeric and cracked black pepper. Stir.
5. Add water/broth and tamarind paste. Bring to a boil.
6. Simmer 10 minutes. Season with salt. The soup should be thin, peppery, and tangy. Strain if preferred (many serve it unstrained).
7. BONDA: Beat the urad dal batter vigorously. Add ginger, chilli, curry leaves, coriander, pepper, and salt. Mix.
8. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F).
9. Wet your hand. Take a small amount of batter and slide it into the oil as a small ball.
10. Fry 4 minutes until golden and cooked through.
11. Drain on paper towels.
12. SERVING: Pour hot soup into deep bowls. Immediately drop 2–3 fresh hot bondas into the soup — they begin absorbing the broth.
13. Garnish with fresh coriander.
14. Eat immediately — the bondas soften progressively the longer they sit, so eat while the contrast of textures is at its best.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hrs soaking · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~295 per serving

TIP

The beauty of bonda soup is the textural evolution — at first bite the bonda is crispy. After 2 minutes in the soup, it is soft and fully soaked. Both states are delicious for different reasons. Many Kannadigas prefer eating it after 2–3 minutes when the bonda has absorbed the peppery broth.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Karnataka] [Unique]

RECIPE 293

■■ India (Tamil Nadu / Karnataka)

SADA DOSA WITH GHEE

The purist's dosa — a sada (plain) dosa without any filling, cooked paper-thin and crispy, drizzled with homemade ghee and served with coconut chutney and sambar. For dosa connoisseurs, the sada dosa tests the batter and technique without the distraction of a filling. Achieved correctly, it is one of the most beautiful things that can emerge from a hot iron pan.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups fermented dosa batter (from Recipe 263)
- — the batter should be 2–3 days old if possible —
- more sour = more flavorful and crispier
- Homemade ghee or good clarified butter (essential)
- Salt (if batter needs adjusting)
- COCONUT CHUTNEY (fresh):
- 1 cup fresh grated coconut
- 2 green chillies
- 1 inch ginger
- Salt and a little water to blend
- TEMPERING: mustard seeds + curry leaves in 1 tsp oil

SAMBAR

- As per Recipe 265 — make ahead

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Allow batter to come to room temperature if refrigerated (30 minutes).
2. Stir the batter well. It should be pourable — like thin buttermilk. If too thick, add water tablespoon by tablespoon.
3. Heat a cast iron tawa or flat non-stick pan on high heat until very hot — water drops should bead and skitter immediately.
4. Reduce to medium-high.
5. Drizzle a few drops of oil and wipe with a cloth or paper towel — the surface should have a barely perceptible film of oil.
6. Pour a ladleful of batter in the center of the pan.
7. IMMEDIATELY spread with the back of the ladle in circular motions from center outward — spiraling quickly to achieve a very thin, even layer. Do this in one fluid, continuous motion. The dosa should be 28–30cm (11–12 inches) wide.
8. Drizzle ¼ tsp ghee around the edges. Drizzle another ¼ tsp ghee over the surface.
9. Cook undisturbed 2–3 minutes until: — The edges turn golden and lift naturally — The surface changes from shiny-wet to matte-dry — The bottom is an even, golden, spotty pattern
10. Do NOT flip a sada dosa. It is served unflipped, crispy side down.
11. Fold in half or roll into a cylinder. Drizzle additional ghee if desired.
12. Serve immediately with fresh coconut chutney and hot sambar.

Prep: 5 min (batter already made) · Cook: 3 min per dosa · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~235 per dosa

TIP

The iron tawa (griddle) must be properly seasoned over weeks of use — this is why restaurant dosas are always crispier than home versions. To improve a new pan: rub with oil and cook on high heat 10 minutes before using. After cooking, do not wash with soap — only wipe clean. Season repeatedly. The pan improves with every use.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic South Indian] [Advanced Technique]

Thailand

RECIPE 294

■ ■ Thailand

KHAO TOM

THAI RICE SOUP

Thailand's most comforting breakfast — jasmine rice simmered in clear chicken broth until very soft and silky, served with minced pork balls, soft-boiled egg, crispy fried garlic, fresh ginger, and fish sauce. Gentler and more delicate than Chinese congee, khao tom is the Thai healing breakfast — eaten when recovering from illness, celebrating a new morning, or simply wanting something warm and deeply nourishing.

INGREDIENTS

- 1½ cups cooked jasmine rice (leftover works perfectly)
- 1.5L (6 cups) good quality chicken broth
- 200g (7 oz) minced pork or chicken
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp white sugar
- 1 tsp white pepper (freshly ground)
- 2cm fresh ginger, julienned finely
- 3 stalks Chinese celery or regular celery, sliced
- 3 green onions, thinly sliced
- GARNISHES (serve all at once — essential):
- 3 tbsp fried garlic (garlic sliced thin, fried in oil until pale golden — not dark)
- 2 tbsp fried shallots
- 1 century egg (pi dan), sliced (optional)
- Soft-boiled eggs, halved
- Crispy you tiao or Chinese dough sticks, sliced
- Fish sauce and white pepper on the side
- Chili vinegar (sliced chillies in rice vinegar)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Season minced pork/chicken with 1 tbsp fish sauce, a pinch of sugar, and white pepper. Roll into small, loose balls (do not compact too firmly).
2. Bring chicken broth to a gentle simmer in a large pot.
3. Add the rice. Stir to separate grains.
4. Simmer 8–10 minutes until rice softens and the broth becomes lightly cloudy and slightly thick. The soup should be thinner than congee — individual grains should still be visible.
5. Add meatballs. Simmer 5 minutes until cooked through.
6. Add remaining fish sauce, sugar, and adjust seasoning. The broth should be clean, lightly savory, and fragrant from the ginger. Not heavily spiced.
7. Ladle into deep bowls.
8. Add julienned ginger, celery, and green onion directly into each bowl.
9. TOPPING: Arrange all garnishes beside the bowl — each person adds their own. This customization is integral to the Thai khao tom experience.
10. Drizzle chili vinegar and fish sauce to taste.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~265 per bowl

TIP

Fried garlic is the defining aroma of Thai khao tom. Slice garlic paper-thin (a mandoline helps), fry in neutral oil over medium heat until pale gold — remove the moment they color since they continue cooking in the residual oil. Dark fried garlic is bitter. Pale gold fried garlic is transcendent.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Thai] [Healing] [Quick]

RECIPE 295

■ ■ Thailand

PAD KRA PAO KAI DAO

HOLY BASIL STIR-FRY WITH FRIED EGG

Thailand's national dish and most commonly ordered breakfast — minced pork stir-fried with holy basil, garlic, and bird's eye chillies in a soy-oyster sauce, served over jasmine rice with a perfectly fried egg whose white is shatteringly crispy at the edges while the yolk remains completely runny. Eaten at every meal, at every hour, by every Thai. Simple, fiery, and magnificent.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) minced pork (not too lean — some fat creates better flavor)
- 5 garlic cloves, roughly chopped
- 4–8 bird's eye chillies (prik kee noo), chopped
- — adjust ruthlessly to heat preference
- 1 cup Thai holy basil leaves (bai kra pao)
- — MUST be holy basil. Thai basil is different.
- Italian basil is also different. If unavailable,
- use Thai basil and accept a slightly different result.
- 1 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce (see ew khao)
- 1 tsp dark soy sauce (see ew dam — for color)
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 tbsp neutral oil (for stir-fry) + oil for egg
- 2 cups cooked jasmine rice per person
- 2 large eggs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. RICE: Have hot jasmine rice ready before starting the stir-fry — the dish cooks in under 3 minutes.
2. FRY THE EGG first, separately: Heat a generous amount of oil (3–4 tbsp) in a small pan until nearly smoking. Crack egg in. It will spit. Baste continuously with the hot oil using a spoon. The white should be set with deeply crispy, golden edges and lacey frills. The yolk must be runny. This high-oil method is the authentic Thai street way. Remove. Set on rice immediately.
3. STIR-FRY: Heat 2 tbsp oil in a wok over very high heat until just smoking.
4. Add garlic and chillies all at once. Stir-fry vigorously 15 seconds — fragrant but not burned.
5. Add minced pork. Press against the wok to sear. Break apart and stir-fry 2–3 minutes until cooked through and beginning to caramelize.
6. Add oyster sauce, light soy, dark soy, fish sauce, and sugar. Toss to coat everything evenly.
7. Add holy basil all at once. Toss for 20 seconds — it wilts immediately in the hot wok.
8. Taste: it should be intensely savory, slightly sweet, fragrant with basil, and fiery.
9. Immediately spoon over rice beside the fried egg.
10. Serve at once — this dish does not wait.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

Wok hei — the "breath of the wok" — is the high-heat caramelization that makes pad kra pao taste like a restaurant. Achieve it by preheating your wok until nearly smoking before any ingredient touches it, then never reducing the heat. Home stoves are less powerful than restaurant burners — work in small batches and keep the heat as high as it will go.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Street Food] [Quick]

RECIPE 296

■ ■ Thailand

OLIANG

THAI ICED COFFEE

Thailand's essential morning beverage — strong coffee blended with corn, soybeans, and sesame, brewed through a traditional cloth filter sock, then poured over ice with sweetened condensed milk. The result is darker, more complex, and earthier than standard coffee — with a caramel sweetness that makes it simultaneously refreshing and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 tbsp Thai oliang powder (Thai coffee blend with corn, soybean, and sesame — available at Asian stores)
- OR: 3 tbsp dark-roast ground coffee + 1 tsp ground
- chicory as a substitute
- 300ml (1¼ cups) hot water, just off the boil
- 3 tbsp sweetened condensed milk
- 1 tbsp evaporated milk (optional — for creamier result)
- Plenty of ice

EQUIPMENT

- A traditional Thai coffee sock filter (tungtom)
- OR a fine-mesh pour-over filter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place coffee sock filter over a heatproof pitcher.
2. Add oliang powder to the filter.
3. Pour hot water slowly through the coffee. Allow to drip completely — do not rush or press.
4. The brewed coffee should be very dark and strong.
5. For Thai street style: add condensed milk to a tall glass. Pour brewed coffee directly over. The coffee cascades through the condensed milk creating a beautiful swirling effect.
6. Fill glass with ice.
7. Add evaporated milk on top if using.
8. Stir vigorously or leave unstirred for layered effect.
9. Drink through a straw.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~185 per glass

TIP

Thai oliang powder specifically blended with corn and sesame creates the characteristic roasted, slightly caramel flavor that distinguishes it from regular coffee. The condensed milk provides sweetness while the evaporated milk adds creaminess without diluting the coffee's strength. Both are required for the authentic Bangkok street cart experience.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Thai] [Street Food]

RECIPE 297

■ ■ Thailand

KHANOM KROK

COCONUT RICE PANCAKE BALLS

Thailand's beloved street breakfast sweet — small, spherical coconut rice pancakes cooked in a special dimpled cast-iron pan, with a crispy shell, custardy coconut cream interior, and a topping of corn, green onion, or taro. Each bite delivers a contrast of crunch and molten coconut creaminess that is entirely unique to this dish. Sold from street carts by vendors who have cooked thousands before 8am.

INGREDIENTS

BASE BATTER

- 200g (1■ cups) rice flour
- 50g (■ cup) tapioca starch
- 400ml (1■ cups) thin coconut milk
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp sugar
- TOPPING BATTER (poured into each depression after base):
- 200ml (¾ cup) thick coconut cream
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- Optional fillings: sweet corn kernels, thinly
- sliced green onion, diced taro (cooked)
- Coconut oil or neutral oil for the pan

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix base batter: combine rice flour, tapioca starch, thin coconut milk, salt, and sugar. Whisk until completely smooth. Rest 15 minutes.
2. Mix topping: stir thick coconut cream, sugar, and salt until sugar dissolves. Set aside separately.
3. Heat a khanom krok pan (takoyaki pan works too) over medium heat. Brush each depression generously with coconut oil.
4. Pour base batter to fill each depression ¾ full.
5. Immediately place a small amount of chosen filling into the center of each depression (a few corn kernels, a pinch of green onion, or a small piece of taro).
6. After 1 minute when the base batter begins to set at the edges, spoon 1 tsp of thick coconut topping into the center of each.
7. Cover with a lid. Cook 3–4 minutes until the shell is set and lightly crispy.
8. Check with a wooden skewer: if the pancake releases cleanly from the sides, it is ready.
9. Scoop out carefully with a rounded spoon or toothpick.
10. Serve warm in pairs — one plain, one with filling.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per serving

TIP

The pan temperature is critical — if too hot, the shell burns before the inside sets; if too low, the shell stays raw and pale. Test with one pancake first: it should sizzle gently upon contact and the edges should begin setting within 60 seconds. Adjust heat before proceeding with the full batch.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Street Food] [Sweet]

RECIPE 298

■ ■ Thailand

JOKE

THAI CONGEE WITH PORK BALLS

Thailand's version of congee — smoother and more broken-down than khao tom, simmered until the rice completely dissolves into a silky, thick porridge. Served with minced pork balls, a raw egg cracked into the hot soup, sliced ginger, crispy fried garlic, and a drizzle of sesame oil. Bangkok's ultimate dawn breakfast — ladled from enormous pots at market stalls from 5am.

INGREDIENTS

- ¾ cup jasmine rice
- 2L (8 cups) pork or chicken broth
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp white pepper

PORK BALLS

- 200g (7 oz) minced pork
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- ½ tsp white pepper
- ½ tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp cornstarch

TOPPINGS

- 2 large eggs (one raw cracked per bowl)
- 3 tbsp fried garlic (made fresh — see Recipe 294)
- 2 tbsp fried shallots
- 3cm fresh ginger, very finely julienned
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- Fish sauce and white pepper on the side
- Fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse rice well. Combine with cold broth in a large heavy pot.
2. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat to a very low simmer.
3. Cook uncovered 60–75 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice has completely dissolved into a smooth, thick, silky porridge. Add more broth or water if it thickens too much.
4. The finished joke should be completely smooth — no visible rice grains. It should coat the back of a spoon thickly but still pour slowly.
5. Season with salt and white pepper.
6. **PORK BALLS:** Mix all ingredients until combined. Roll into small balls (2cm). Poach in simmering joke for 5 minutes until cooked through.
7. **SERVING:** Ladle hot joke into deep bowls.
8. Crack one raw egg directly into the center of each bowl — the heat of the joke will partially cook it into silky ribbons.
9. Arrange pork balls, fried garlic, fried shallots, and ginger julienne on top.
10. Drizzle sesame oil. Add green onion and coriander.
11. Each person seasons further with fish sauce and white pepper at the table.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 75 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~285 per bowl

TIP

The raw egg is added to the bowl, not to the pot — the residual heat of the porridge gently cooks it into silky soft strands if stirred, or into a partially set sunny-side-up if left. Most Thais stir the egg in immediately for even distribution. Using a very fresh egg is important for safety.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 299

■ ■ Thailand

KANOM JEEB

THAI STEAMED DUMPLINGS

Thailand's dim sum — steamed dumplings with pork and shrimp filling, gathered into a cup shape with the top left open and garnished with golden fried garlic. Less pleated than Chinese dumplings, simpler to make, and served with a sweet soy dipping sauce. Found at every Thai morning market from Bangkok to Chiang Mai — eaten in groups of four or five with tea.

INGREDIENTS

- 20 round wonton wrappers
- (or gyoza wrappers — slightly thicker is good)

FILLING

- 200g (7 oz) minced pork
- 100g (3.5 oz) raw shrimp, peeled and roughly chopped
- 50g (2 oz) water chestnuts, finely diced
- 2 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 1 tsp cornstarch
- 2 green onions, finely sliced
- GARNISH & DIPPING:
 - 3 tbsp fried garlic (the defining Thai garnish)
 - Fresh coriander leaves
 - Sweet soy sauce (see ew wan): 3 tbsp soy sauce
 - + 2 tbsp sugar, heated until sugar dissolves, cooled

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Combine all filling ingredients. Mix well until slightly sticky and holding together. Refrigerate 20 minutes.
2. DIPPING SAUCE: Combine soy sauce and sugar in a small pan. Heat until sugar dissolves. Cool. Add 1 tbsp rice vinegar for acidity.
3. ASSEMBLE: Place a wonton wrapper in your palm.
4. Add 1 tbsp filling in the center.
5. Gather the wrapper upward around the filling — pleating loosely so the top is open and the filling is visible. Squeeze the wrapper gently at the waist to secure.
6. Tap each dumpling on the work surface so it sits flat and stable.
7. Lightly oil the steamer rack or line with parchment paper.
8. Place dumplings without touching.
9. Steam over high heat for 10–12 minutes until wrapper is translucent and filling is cooked through.
10. Transfer carefully to a plate.
11. Place one small mound of fried garlic on top of each dumpling.
12. Garnish with fresh coriander. Serve with dipping sauce.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~270 per serving (5 dumplings)

TIP

The fried garlic is not a decoration — it is the single most important garnish in Thai cooking. Made fresh (not from a jar), pale golden, and fragrant, it adds a dimension to every Thai dish it touches. Make a large batch, store in oil, and use on everything for the next week.

[High Protein] [Classic Thai] [Dim Sum Style] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 300

■ ■ Thailand

KHAO MAN GAI

THAI HAINANESE CHICKEN RICE

Thailand's version of the Hainanese chicken rice — poached chicken served over fragrant rice cooked in the chicken poaching broth with garlic and ginger, alongside the definitive Thai ginger sauce. Eaten throughout the day but especially beloved as a breakfast that is simultaneously light and deeply satisfying. Every Thai city has its legendary khao man gai specialist.

INGREDIENTS

POACHED CHICKEN

- 1 whole chicken or 4 chicken breast halves
- 6 cups water
- 4 garlic cloves, crushed
- 3 slices fresh ginger
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- RICE (cooked in chicken broth):
- 2 cups jasmine rice
- 2 tbsp chicken fat (skimmed from broth) or neutral oil
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp salt
- 3 cups chicken broth (from poaching above)
- 1 pandan leaf, knotted (optional)
- GINGER SAUCE (naam jim khao man gai):
- 3 tbsp yellow soybean paste (tao jiao)
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- 2 tsp dark soy sauce
- 2 tbsp fresh ginger, very finely minced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tsp sugar
- 1 tbsp rice vinegar
- 1 red chilli, minced

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Sliced cucumber
- Fresh coriander sprigs
- Hot chicken broth (in a separate small bowl)
- White pepper and fish sauce on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. POACH CHICKEN: Place chicken in a pot with water, garlic, ginger, and salt. Bring to a gentle simmer. NEVER boil — the chicken must poach gently.
2. Simmer 20 minutes (breasts) or 45 minutes (whole).
3. Remove chicken. Reserve broth. Ice bath the chicken 5 minutes — this firms the skin and stops cooking, creating silky texture.
4. Skim chicken fat from surface of broth. Reserve.
5. RICE: Heat chicken fat in a pan. Add minced garlic. Cook 2 minutes until fragrant.
6. Add rice. Toss to coat each grain in the fat.
7. Add 3 cups chicken broth, pandan leaf, and salt.
8. Bring to a boil, then cover and reduce to lowest heat.
9. Cook 15 minutes. Rest off heat 10 minutes covered.
10. GINGER SAUCE: Combine all sauce ingredients. Mix until sugar dissolves. Taste — it should be salty, sweet, sour, gingery, and slightly funky from the soybean paste.
11. ASSEMBLE: Mound rice in a bowl or on a plate.
12. Slice chicken thinly and arrange over or beside rice.
13. Add cucumber slices and coriander.
14. Pour a small bowl of hot broth (seasoned with fish sauce and white pepper) alongside.
15. Serve ginger sauce on the side for dipping or drizzling.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

Never boil the chicken during poaching — a rapid boil toughens the protein and creates rubbery breast meat. The water should tremble, not bubble. The ice bath after cooking is equally important — it creates the silky, almost gelatinous chicken skin texture that defines great khao man gai.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Complete Meal]

RECIPE 301

■ Thailand

THAI ROTI WITH EGG

A Thai street adaptation of Malaysian roti canai — a paper-thin flaky flatbread cooked on a flat griddle with an egg cracked and spread on one side, folded into a square parcel, and served drizzled with sweetened condensed milk and sugar. One of Bangkok's most popular dawn street foods, eaten with cha yen (Thai iced tea) for an indulgent sweet breakfast that defies all nutritional logic yet achieves complete morning perfection.

INGREDIENTS

ROTI DOUGH

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 large egg
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 3 tbsp sweetened condensed milk
- 4 tbsp vegetable oil or ghee

FOR COOKING AND FILLING

- 4 eggs
- 4 tbsp ghee or vegetable oil
- (generous amounts — essential for the right texture)

SWEET TOPPINGS

- Sweetened condensed milk (drizzled generously)
- Granulated sugar (sprinkled)
- Optional: banana slices, Nutella

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, egg, salt, sugar, condensed milk, and warm water. Knead 10 minutes until very smooth and elastic. Coat with oil. Cover.
2. Rest minimum 2 hours at room temperature — the longer the better (overnight is ideal). The gluten must relax completely for the thin stretching that follows.
3. Divide rested dough into 8 balls. Coat each ball generously with oil.
4. On an oiled surface, flatten a dough ball with your palm. Using oiled fingertips, stretch the dough from the center outward — gently and progressively — until paper-thin and almost translucent (30–35cm / 12–14 inches wide).
5. Fold the edges in to create a loose square.
6. Heat a flat griddle or pan over medium-high heat. Add 1 tbsp ghee. Place the folded roti.
7. As it cooks (1–2 minutes), crack one egg over the center. Spread the egg evenly with the back of a spoon over the entire roti surface.
8. After 1 minute when egg starts to set, fold all four sides over the center to create a square parcel (egg side is now inside, crispy roti outside).
9. Add more ghee to the pan. Cook 1 minute each side until deeply golden and crispy.
10. Transfer to a plate. Drizzle condensed milk. Sprinkle sugar generously. Serve immediately.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hrs resting · Cook: 5 min per roti · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~460 per roti

TIP

The oil during dough resting is not optional — the oil keeps the gluten relaxed and prevents the dough from drying out. When stretching, work from the center outward with oiled fingertips, letting gravity do some of the work. Tearing indicates under-rested dough — cover and rest 30 more minutes before trying again.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Thai] [Street Food] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 302

■ ■ Thailand

MANGO STICKY RICE

KHAO NIAO MAMUANG

Thailand's most famous dessert — also a beloved breakfast. Sweet glutinous rice cooked with coconut milk and salt, served alongside fresh ripe mango slices and drizzled with a salted coconut cream sauce. During mango season (April–June), this appears at every Thai breakfast table and market stall. The combination of sweet rice, creamy coconut, and perfumed mango is one of Southeast Asia's great flavor combinations.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups Thai glutinous rice (khao niao — the specific Thai variety essential to this dish)
- 400ml (1 can) coconut milk, divided
- 3 tbsp sugar (for the rice)
- ½ tsp salt (for the rice)
- 2–3 ripe champagne mangoes, peeled and sliced
- 1 tbsp toasted mung beans or sesame seeds (garnish)
- Pandan leaf (optional — for fragrance)
- COCONUT SAUCE (pour over at serving):
- 100ml (■ cup) thick coconut cream
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp rice flour dissolved in 1 tbsp water
- (for thickening)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak glutinous rice in cold water overnight (minimum 4 hours).
2. Drain completely.
3. Line a steamer basket with a damp muslin cloth or cheesecloth. Add the soaked rice.
4. Steam over high heat 20–25 minutes, turning the rice once halfway through, until cooked, glossy, and translucent.
5. Meanwhile: heat 300ml of the coconut milk with sugar, salt, and pandan leaf (if using) until sugar dissolves. Do not boil.
6. Transfer hot cooked rice to a bowl.
7. Pour the warm coconut milk mixture over the hot rice. Stir gently to incorporate.
8. Cover and rest 20–30 minutes — the rice absorbs the coconut milk completely and becomes rich, fragrant, and slightly sticky.
9. COCONUT SAUCE: Combine coconut cream, sugar, and salt in a small pan. Bring to a gentle simmer. Add rice flour mixture. Stir until slightly thickened. Remove from heat. Cool to room temperature.
10. PLATE: Mound coconut rice on a plate or banana leaf. Arrange fresh mango slices alongside or on top.
11. Drizzle coconut sauce over the rice and mango.
12. Sprinkle toasted mung beans or sesame seeds.
13. Serve at room temperature — not cold.

Prep: 15 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 25 min + 30 min resting · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The rice must be steamed — not boiled. Boiling glutinous rice creates a gluey, wet, heavy texture. Steaming creates a light, chewy, individual-grain texture. If using a rice cooker, use the sticky rice setting with very little water. The salt in both the rice and the sauce is essential — it balances the sweetness and makes the coconut flavor more pronounced and complex.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Seasonal] [Sweet]

RECIPE 303

■ ■ Thailand

KAI JEOW MOO SAP

THAI CRISPY PORK OMELETTE

Thailand's everyday hero omelette — eggs beaten with fish sauce and minced pork, then poured into very hot oil that creates an extraordinary puffed, crispy-edged, golden omelette in 60 seconds. The high oil and very high heat are essential — this is not a delicate French omelette but a bold, shattery, golden Thai one. Served over rice with sriracha and sliced cucumber. Eaten daily.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs
- 100g (3.5 oz) minced pork
- 1 tbsp fish sauce
- ½ tsp white pepper
- ½ tsp sugar
- 1 green onion, finely sliced
- 2–3 tbsp neutral oil for frying
- (more oil than makes you comfortable — it is essential)
- 1 cup jasmine rice per person
- Sliced cucumber
- Sriracha or sweet chili sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs thoroughly with fish sauce, white pepper, and sugar until well combined.
2. Add minced pork. Mix so pork is distributed throughout the egg — it will cook in small pieces.
3. Add sliced green onion. Stir.
4. Heat oil in a wok or deep-sided pan over HIGH heat until nearly smoking — the oil must be very hot. Test with a drop of water: it should spit immediately.
5. Pour the egg mixture into the very hot oil. It will puff and splutter dramatically.
6. Using a spatula, immediately begin folding the edges of the omelette inward while the center is still wet — this creates the puffed, irregular, cloud-like shape of an authentic Thai omelette.
7. Flip the omelette once — cook 30 seconds. It should be deeply golden, puffy, and slightly crispy on the outside.
8. Remove immediately to a plate of hot rice.
9. Add sliced cucumber alongside.
10. Drizzle sriracha or sweet chili sauce over the top.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~480 per serving (with rice)

TIP

More oil than seems rational and higher heat than seems safe are both essential. The oil temperature and volume create the dramatic puffing that defines Thai omelette. A small amount of tepid oil creates a flat, French-style omelette — entirely different. The oil is also responsible for the crispy, shattered texture of the edges.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Quick]

RECIPE 304

■ ■ Thailand

KHAO NIAO SANGKHAYA

STICKY RICE WITH COCONUT CUSTARD

A traditional Thai morning sweet — warm coconut sticky rice served with a steamed coconut-egg custard (sangkhaya) that is silky, fragrant with pandan, and gently sweet. The custard is traditionally steamed inside a young coconut shell or a small pumpkin. The contrast of chewy rice and trembling custard makes this one of Thailand's most elegant breakfast sweets.

INGREDIENTS

STICKY RICE

- 1 cup Thai glutinous rice (soaked overnight, steamed)
- 20 minutes — see Recipe 302 method)
- 150ml (⅔ cup) coconut milk
- 2 tbsp sugar + ½ tsp salt (stirred into warm coconut milk)

SANGKHAYA CUSTARD

- 4 eggs
- 200ml (¾ cup) thick coconut cream
- 3 tbsp palm sugar (or light brown sugar)
- 2 tbsp white sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 pandan leaves, tied into a knot (or 1 tsp pandan extract for intense color and fragrance)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. STICKY RICE: Follow steaming method from Recipe 302. Mix with sweetened coconut milk. Rest 20 minutes.
2. CUSTARD: Beat eggs gently — do not incorporate too much air (bubbles create a pitted surface).
3. Add coconut cream, palm sugar, white sugar, and salt. Stir until sugars dissolve.
4. Add pandan leaves to the mixture. Leave to infuse 15 minutes for fragrance and green tinge. Remove pandan leaves. Strain through a fine sieve.
5. Pour into ramekins, a small baking dish, or if available: the inside of a small cleaned pumpkin or young coconut (traditional vessels).
6. Steam over medium heat (NOT high — high heat creates bubbles and pitting in the custard surface) for 20–25 minutes until just set — it should wobble like set Jell-O when shaken gently.
7. Cool 10 minutes. Refrigerate if not eating immediately.
8. SERVE: Mound coconut sticky rice on a plate. Spoon cold sangkhaya custard alongside.
9. The combination of warm rice and cool custard is an intentional temperature contrast.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Steaming the custard over medium heat — not high heat — is essential for a smooth, bubble-free surface. High heat causes the custard protein to overcook and seize, creating a cottage cheese-like texture with visible pitting. Patience and medium heat create the mirror-smooth surface of perfect sangkhaya.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Sweet] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 305

■ ■ Thailand

PAT WOON SEN SAI KAI

GLASS NOODLE STIR-FRY WITH EGG

A quick, light Thai breakfast stir-fry of soaked glass noodles (woon sen) with egg, vegetables, oyster sauce, and white pepper. More delicate than other Thai noodle dishes, glass noodles absorb the sauce beautifully and remain slippery and light. Eaten at home on weekday mornings when something quick, satisfying, and not too heavy is required before work.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (3.5 oz) glass noodles (woon sen — mung bean vermicelli), soaked in cold water
- 15 minutes until soft, then drained
- 3 large eggs
- 100g (3.5 oz) chicken breast, thinly sliced
- OR 100g (3.5 oz) shrimp, peeled
- 1 medium carrot, julienned
- 2 stalks celery (Chinese or regular), sliced
- 3 green onions, cut into 3cm pieces
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 2 tbsp neutral oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Have all ingredients prepared and beside the wok before heating — this cooks in under 5 minutes.
2. Heat wok over very high heat. Add oil.
3. Add garlic. Stir-fry 15 seconds until fragrant.
4. Add chicken or shrimp. Stir-fry until just cooked.
5. Push protein to the side. Add eggs to the center. Scramble roughly — stop while still slightly wet.
6. Add carrot. Stir-fry 1 minute.
7. Add drained glass noodles. They will immediately absorb moisture from the wok.
8. Add oyster sauce, soy sauce, fish sauce, sugar, and white pepper. Toss to coat everything.
9. Add celery and green onion. Toss 30 seconds.
10. Taste: adjust with fish sauce (saltier) or sugar (sweeter) as needed.
11. Remove from heat. Transfer to a plate immediately.
12. Serve with sriracha on the side.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Do not over-soak the glass noodles — 15 minutes in cold water is sufficient to soften them. Over-soaked noodles become too soft and break apart during stir-frying. Drain thoroughly before adding to the wok — excess water steams the ingredients instead of stir-frying them.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Thai]

RECIPE 306

■ ■ Thailand

PATONGO

THAI FRIED DOUGH STICKS

Thailand's version of Chinese you tiao — crispy, golden fried dough sticks sold by street vendors at dawn. Eaten dipped into khao tom (rice soup), dunked into warm soy milk, or served with pandan custard sauce (sangkhaya) for a sweet breakfast. The Thai version is slightly sweeter and lighter than the Chinese original, with a chewier interior and crispier shell.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 large egg
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 1 tbsp neutral oil
- Vegetable oil for deep frying
- SERVED WITH (choose one or all):
- Warm soy milk (dou jiang — Recipe 249)
- Pandan custard sauce (sangkhaya)
- Rice congee (khao tom)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and sugar together.
2. Add egg, warm water, and oil. Mix until a soft, slightly sticky dough forms.
3. Knead gently 3 minutes — minimal kneading keeps the dough tender.
4. Coat with oil. Cover loosely. Rest 4–6 hours at room temperature. The rest is essential for the dough to relax and develop the right texture.
5. Heat oil to 185°C (365°F) in a deep pan.
6. On an oiled surface, roll rested dough to 1cm thick.
7. Cut into 4cm wide strips.
8. Stack two strips on top of each other.
9. Press a chopstick firmly down the center — lengthwise — joining the two strips.
10. Gently stretch each piece to 25cm.
11. Slide into hot oil. Immediately turn with chopsticks or tongs — the patongo must be rotated continuously as it fries so it cooks and colors evenly.
12. Fry 2–3 minutes until golden, puffed, and crispy.
13. Drain on paper towels. Eat immediately.

Prep: 10 min + 4-6 hrs resting · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~265 per serving (3 sticks)

TIP

The continuous rotation during frying is what creates even golden color on all sides of the patongo. A patongo left stationary in the oil will have a pale underside and dark top. Rotate gently and constantly using chopsticks — the Thai vendor technique that takes minutes to learn.

[Vegan] [Classic Thai] [Street Food] [Make-Ahead (dough)]

RECIPE 307

■ ■ Thailand

KHAO TOM MAT

STICKY RICE AND BANANA IN BANANA LEAF

A traditional Thai breakfast parcel — sweet glutinous rice mixed with coconut milk and black beans, wrapped with a whole banana inside a banana leaf and steamed or grilled. Eaten unwrapped at dawn from market stalls across Thailand, the banana leaf imparts a subtle grassy fragrance to the rice, and the banana softens into the coconut rice during cooking. Simple, sustainable, and perfect.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups Thai glutinous rice, soaked 4 hours and drained
- 300ml (1¼ cups) coconut milk
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ cup cooked black beans (nam phao — or black-eyed peas as substitute)
- 6 small lady finger bananas or 3 regular bananas, halved lengthwise
- 6 banana leaves, cleaned and wilted over heat (to make pliable)
- Twine or toothpicks for securing

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine drained glutinous rice with coconut milk, sugar, and salt in a heavy saucepan.
2. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until the coconut milk is absorbed — about 8–10 minutes. The rice will be partially cooked and sticky. Remove from heat.
3. Fold in the cooked black beans gently.
4. ASSEMBLE: Lay one banana leaf flat.
5. Place 3–4 tbsp coconut rice in the center.
6. Place a banana piece on the rice.
7. Add another 2 tbsp rice on top to cover the banana.
8. Fold the banana leaf over into a tight rectangular parcel. Secure with twine or toothpicks.
9. STEAM method: Steam parcels 20–25 minutes. OR GRILL method: Grill over charcoal or a gas flame, turning every few minutes, 15–20 minutes until the banana leaf chars slightly on the outside — this adds a smoky, grassy aroma to the rice.
10. Rest 5 minutes before unwrapping.
11. Open at the table — the steam and fragrance that escapes is part of the experience.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hrs soaking · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per parcel

TIP

Wilting banana leaves over a flame or in boiling water makes them pliable and prevents cracking when folding. If banana leaves are unavailable, use aluminum foil as a substitute — the fragrance will be absent but the dish is otherwise unchanged.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Street Food] [Portable]

RECIPE 308

■ ■ Thailand

KHAO NIAO DAM SANGKHAYA

BLACK GLUTINOUS RICE PUDDING WITH CUSTARD

A stunning Thai breakfast sweet — black glutinous rice slow-cooked in coconut milk until thick, dark, and aromatic, topped with salted coconut cream. The black rice has a slightly nutty, earthy flavor and maintains a pleasantly chewy texture even when fully cooked. The color is a dramatic deep purple-black, making it one of the world's most visually striking breakfast bowls.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup black glutinous rice (khao niao dam),
- soaked in cold water overnight
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- 300ml (1¼ cups) coconut milk
- 3–4 tbsp palm sugar (or light brown sugar)
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 pandan leaves, knotted

COCONUT CREAM TOPPING

- 150ml (■ cup) thick coconut cream
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar (just a little)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked black rice. Rinse until water runs clear.
2. Combine with water and pandan leaves in a saucepan.
3. Bring to a boil. Reduce to low heat.
4. Simmer 30–40 minutes, stirring occasionally, until rice is completely tender and most water is absorbed. The liquid will turn a beautiful deep purple from the rice pigment.
5. Add coconut milk and palm sugar. Stir well.
6. Continue cooking 10–15 minutes until thick and creamy — the rice should hold its shape but the mixture should have a porridge-like consistency.
7. Remove pandan leaves. Taste and adjust sweetness.
8. COCONUT TOPPING: Gently heat coconut cream with salt and sugar until barely warm — just enough to dissolve the sugar. Do not boil.
9. SERVE: Ladle warm black rice pudding into bowls.
10. Pour a generous drizzle of coconut cream on top.
11. The cream pools in the dark rice — beautiful.
12. Serve warm for breakfast, or chilled as a snack.

Prep: 5 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~360 per bowl

TIP

Black glutinous rice takes significantly longer to cook than white glutinous rice — the black bran layer slows moisture absorption. Never substitute with regular black rice (wild rice) — it has a completely different texture and does not create the same thick, sticky result. Look for khao niao dam at Asian grocery stores.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Sweet] [Stunning Presentation]

RECIPE 309

■ ■ Thailand

KUAY JABB NAM SAI

ROLLED RICE NOODLE SOUP

A Teochew-Chinese influenced Thai breakfast soup — rolled rice noodle sheets in a clear peppery pork broth with crispy pork belly, offal (for the traditional version), hard-boiled egg, and fresh garlic. One of Bangkok's most comforting dawn soups, found at specialist stalls open only in the mornings. The clear broth is deceptively complex — built from slow-simmered pork bones and heavily seasoned with white pepper and fish sauce.

INGREDIENTS

BROTH

- 500g (18 oz) pork bones
- 2 cinnamon sticks
- 3 star anise
- 5 garlic cloves, crushed
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp white pepper (this is generous — white pepper
- defines the character of this soup)
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1.5L (6 cups) water

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 200g (7 oz) dried rolled rice noodle sheets
- (kuay jabb — thick, rolled up, found at Asian stores)
- OR substitute: wide rice noodles, briefly blanched
- 200g (7 oz) crispy pork belly (moo krob —
- roasted until very crispy, sliced)
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Fresh garlic, thinly sliced and fried golden
- Fresh coriander
- White pepper on the side
- Vinegar with sliced chillies (prik nam som)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: Blanch pork bones in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Combine with fresh cold water, cinnamon, star anise, and garlic. Bring to a boil.
3. Skim foam. Simmer 90 minutes.
4. Strain broth. Discard bones and spices.
5. Season broth with fish sauce, soy sauce, white pepper, and sugar. The broth should be clear, golden, mildly savory, and strongly peppery. Adjust generously.
6. NOODLES: Soak rolled rice noodle sheets in cold water until they unfurl (10–15 minutes). Blanch in boiling water 1–2 minutes until tender. Drain.
7. ASSEMBLE: Place noodles in deep bowls.
8. Ladle hot, fragrant broth over the noodles.
9. Add crispy pork belly slices and halved eggs.
10. Top with fried garlic and fresh coriander.
11. Serve with white pepper, vinegar-chilli on the side.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 90 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per bowl

TIP

White pepper — in considerable quantity — is the defining flavor of this broth. Do not reduce it. It provides the characteristic warmth and complexity that black pepper cannot replicate in this recipe. The broth should taste distinctly, intentionally, and aggressively peppery.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Thai] [Dawn Breakfast]

RECIPE 310

■ ■ Vietnam

PHO BO

VIETNAMESE BEEF NOODLE SOUP

Vietnam's most iconic breakfast — a fragrant, deeply spiced beef bone broth with flat rice noodles, paper-thin beef slices, and a full herb and garnish plate. The broth takes hours to build but the result is one of the world's most complex and satisfying soups. Eaten for breakfast in Hanoi by millions every single morning — the lines at legendary pho shops form before dawn.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE PHO BROTH (6+ hours — make day before):
- 1.5kg (3.3 lbs) beef marrow bones, cut into pieces
- 500g (18 oz) beef brisket or chuck, whole
- 1 large yellow onion, halved
- 6cm (2.5-inch) piece fresh ginger, halved
- 5 star anise
- 1 cinnamon stick
- 4 cloves
- 1 black cardamom pod (crushed)
- 1 tsp coriander seeds
- 1 tbsp rock sugar or sugar
- 2 tbsp fish sauce (or more to taste)
- Salt to taste
- 2.5L (10 cups) water

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) dried flat rice noodles (bánh phở), soaked in cold water 30 minutes, blanched 1 minute
- 200g (7 oz) beef sirloin, sliced paper-thin (partially freeze first for easier slicing)
- Cooked brisket from the broth, thinly sliced
- HERB PLATE (served alongside — essential):
- Fresh Thai basil sprigs
- Fresh bean sprouts
- Sliced fresh chilli
- Lime wedges
- Sawtooth herb (ngò gai) if available
- Optional: fresh coriander

CONDIMENTS

- Hoisin sauce
- Sriracha chilli sauce
- Fish sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: Blanch beef bones in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain and rinse thoroughly under cold water. This removes impurities for a clear broth.
2. Char the onion and ginger: hold directly over a gas flame or place under a broiler until the exterior is blackened in spots. This adds smokiness and sweetness.
3. Toast the spices (star anise, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, coriander) in a dry pan 2 minutes until fragrant.
4. Combine blanched bones, brisket, charred onion and ginger, toasted spices, and water in a large pot.
5. Bring to a boil. Skim any foam aggressively. Reduce to the barest simmer.
6. Simmer uncovered 4–6 hours. Never let it boil — boiling makes the broth cloudy and less refined.
7. Remove brisket after 2 hours (it will be cooked). Cool, then slice thinly for serving.
8. Continue simmering the broth.
9. After cooking: strain through a fine mesh sieve lined with cheesecloth.
10. Season with fish sauce, sugar, and salt. The broth should be clear, golden, deeply fragrant, and intensely savory with a clean, sweet finish.
11. SERVING: Divide blanched noodles into bowls.
12. Add cooked brisket slices. Layer raw sirloin slices on top (they cook in the hot broth).
13. Ladle BOILING broth over the raw beef — the heat of the broth must be sufficient to cook the thin raw beef immediately. Check broth temperature.
14. Serve with the full herb plate on the side.
15. Each person adds herbs, bean sprouts, lime, hoisin, and sriracha to their own bowl.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 6 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per bowl

TIP

Charring the onion and ginger is not optional — it is the technique that creates the distinctive sweetness and slight smokiness that separates authentic pho broth from a plain beef soup. The blackened exterior dissolves into the broth during the long simmer, contributing depth that cannot be replicated any other way.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Weekend Project]

Vietnam

RECIPE 311

■ Vietnam

BÁNH MÌ P LA

VIETNAMESE BAGUETTE WITH FRIED EGG

The simplest and most beloved Vietnamese breakfast — a fried egg (sunny-side up, with crispy edges) served in or alongside a fresh Vietnamese baguette, with pâté, Maggi seasoning, fresh herbs, and pickled vegetables. The Vietnamese baguette's extreme airiness and thin crust make it uniquely suited to this egg breakfast — no other bread

can replicate the experience.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 Vietnamese baguettes (bánh mì — lighter, airier, and crispier than French baguettes
- due to rice flour in the dough. If unavailable, use the crustiest French baguette you can find.)
- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp chicken fat or vegetable oil (for frying)
- 2 tbsp chicken liver pâté (Vietnamese-style)
- 1 tbsp Maggi seasoning sauce (essential)
- 1 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise (optional)
- PICKLED VEGETABLES (do chua — make ahead):
- 1 cup julienned daikon radish and carrot
- ½ cup rice vinegar
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- ¼ cup warm water

FRESH GARNISHES

- Fresh coriander sprigs
- Sliced cucumber
- Sliced fresh red chilli or jalapeño
- Green onion

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PICKLED VEGETABLES (make 24 hrs ahead): Sprinkle daikon and carrot with salt. Toss. Rest 10 minutes. Rinse. Dissolve sugar in warm water. Add vinegar. Pour over vegetables. Refrigerate overnight. They keep 2 weeks and improve with time.
2. EGGS: Heat oil in a small pan until nearly smoking. Crack eggs in. The white should sizzle dramatically. Baste with hot oil using a spoon. The white should be set with golden, slightly crispy edges. The yolk remains completely runny.
3. Season immediately with Maggi seasoning sauce poured directly over the egg in the pan — it will sizzle and caramelize on the egg surface.
4. BAGUETTE: Slice lengthwise without cutting fully through.
5. Spread pâté on one side. Spread mayo on the other.
6. Layer pickled vegetables and cucumber inside.
7. Place the egg inside (or serve alongside).
8. Add fresh coriander, sliced chilli, and green onion.
9. Drizzle a little more Maggi over everything.
10. Eat immediately — Vietnamese baguettes go soft quickly.

Prep: 10 min (pickles need 24 hrs ahead) · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~460 per sandwich

TIP

Maggi seasoning sauce (the Vietnamese/Southeast Asian version) is the signature condiment of bánh mì — its fermented wheat and soy flavor with MSG depth cannot be substituted. Pour it over the egg while still in the hot pan so it caramelizes slightly. This technique is used at every bánh mì stall in Saigon.

[High Protein] [Classic Vietnamese] [Street Food] [Quick]

RECIPE 312

■ ■ Vietnam

XÔI MÌ

VIETNAMESE SAVORY STICKY RICE

Vietnam's most popular portable morning food — steamed glutinous rice topped with Chinese sausage, fried shallots, pork floss, a fried or steamed egg, and scallion oil. Sold by vendors carrying bamboo baskets through neighborhoods at dawn and wrapped in banana leaves or lotus leaves for eating on the move. Deeply satisfying and uniquely Vietnamese in its combination of textures and flavors.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups glutinous rice (gạo nếp), soaked overnight
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vegetable oil (mixed into rice before steaming)

TOPPINGS

- 2 lap cheong (Chinese sausages), sliced diagonally
- and pan-fried until caramelized
- 3 tbsp fried shallots (hành phi — a Vietnamese staple,
- thin shallot rings fried golden and crispy)
- 3 tbsp ruốc / pork floss (dried pork shredded into
- a fluffy, savory cloud)
- 2 large eggs, fried sunnyside up or hard-boiled, halved
- SCALLION OIL (mỡ hành — essential):
- 4 green onions, thinly sliced
- 3 tbsp neutral oil, heated until just smoking
- (pour over green onions — they will sizzle)
- ½ tsp salt
- Soy sauce or Maggi for drizzling

INSTRUCTIONS

- 1.SCALLION OIL: Place sliced green onion with salt in a small bowl. Pour hot oil over them — they will sizzle and wilt immediately. Stir. Cool. This can be made in advance and stored.
- 2.RICE: Drain soaked glutinous rice. Mix with salt and oil.
3. Line a steamer with a damp cloth or cheesecloth.
4. Add rice in an even layer. Steam over high heat 25–30 minutes until cooked, glossy, and fully tender.
- 5.ASSEMBLE: Mound hot sticky rice in a bowl or on a plate.
6. Drizzle scallion oil generously over the rice.
7. Top with caramelized Chinese sausage slices.
8. Add fried or hard-boiled egg.
9. Pile pork floss generously — it should form a soft, savory cloud over the entire bowl.
10. Scatter fried shallots over everything.
11. Drizzle soy sauce or Maggi. Eat immediately.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

Scallion oil (mỡ hành) is used in Vietnamese cooking like butter — it goes on sticky rice, congee, grilled meat, and soups. Making it fresh takes 2 minutes: heat oil until smoking, pour over sliced green onion. The immediate sizzle softens and sweetens the onion while the hot oil becomes fragrant and vivid green. Never use cold oil for this.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Portable]

RECIPE 313

■ ■ Vietnam

BÁNH CUỐN

VIETNAMESE STEAMED RICE ROLLS

Silky, paper-thin steamed rice rolls filled with seasoned minced pork and wood ear mushrooms, drizzled with fried shallots, scallion oil, and served with nuoc cham dipping sauce. Made fresh to order at bánh cuốn shops from early morning, the rolls are impossibly delicate — translucent and trembling. One of Vietnam's most refined breakfast dishes and technically one of its most demanding.

INGREDIENTS

RICE BATTER

- 200g (1½ cups) rice flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) tapioca starch (for translucency)
- 15g (1½ tbsp) cornstarch
- 600ml (2½ cups) cold water
- 1 tsp vegetable oil
- ½ tsp salt

FILLING

- 200g (7 oz) minced pork
- 50g (2 oz) dried wood ear mushrooms, rehydrated
- and finely chopped
- 2 shallots, finely minced
- 1 tbsp fish sauce
- ½ tsp sugar
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 2 tbsp neutral oil for sautéing

GARNISH AND SAUCE

- 3 tbsp fried shallots
- Scallion oil (see Recipe 312)
- Chả lụa (Vietnamese steamed pork sausage), thinly sliced

NUOC CHAM DIPPING SAUCE

- 3 tbsp fish sauce
- 3 tbsp lime juice
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 100ml (½ cup) warm water
- 1 garlic clove, minced
- 1 fresh red chilli, minced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. NUOC CHAM: Dissolve sugar in warm water. Add fish sauce, lime juice, garlic, and chilli. Mix well. Taste — it should be balanced: sweet, sour, salty, and spicy in equal measure. Adjust each element.
2. FILLING: Sauté shallots in oil until golden. Add minced pork. Cook, breaking up, until done. Add wood ear mushrooms. Cook 2 minutes. Season with fish sauce, sugar, pepper, and sesame oil. Cool completely.
3. BATTER: Whisk all batter ingredients until smooth. Strain through a fine sieve. Rest 20 minutes.
4. STEAMING: Oil a flat, round metal tray or non-stick pan. Heat in a steamer until very hot.
5. Ladle a thin layer of batter (2–3mm) onto the hot tray. Cover immediately.
6. Steam 60–90 seconds until the rice sheet is set and translucent.
7. Remove tray from steamer. Working quickly, place 1 tbsp filling along one edge of the rice sheet.
8. Using a spatula, carefully roll the rice sheet around the filling into a loose cylinder.
9. Transfer to a plate. Repeat.
10. Arrange rolls on a serving plate.
11. Drizzle scallion oil and scatter fried shallots.
12. Add sliced chả lụa alongside.
13. Serve with nuoc cham for dipping.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 3 min per roll · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The batter layer must be extremely thin — the thinner the sheet, the more delicate and translucent the finished roll. The tray must be very hot before adding batter and the lid must be closed immediately. A slow steam creates a thick, gummy sheet; intense steam creates a perfect, translucent, silky wrapper.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Advanced]

RECIPE 314

■ ■ Vietnam (Hue, Central Vietnam)

BÚN BÒ HUẾ

SPICY BEEF NOODLE SOUP FROM HUE

Central Vietnam's fiery answer to pho — a deeply spiced beef and pork broth with lemongrass, shrimp paste, and annatto oil, served with round rice noodles, sliced beef, pork, and crispy spring rolls. Bun bo Hue is louder and brasher than pho — spicier, more complex, and proudly Hue in its fierce flavors. It has a passionate, devoted following that considers it superior.

INGREDIENTS

BROTH

- 500g (18 oz) beef bones
- 500g (18 oz) pork hock (cut into rounds)
- 200g (7 oz) beef brisket
- 4 lemongrass stalks, bruised and knotted
- 4 shallots, halved and charred
- 3 garlic cloves
- 2L (8 cups) water
- SPICE PASTE (s■t ■t s■):
- 3 tbsp dried chilli flakes (adjust to heat tolerance)
- 2 lemongrass stalks, white part only, minced finely
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp shrimp paste (m■m ru■c Hu■)
- 2 tbsp annatto oil (for color — heat 3 tbsp oil with 1 tbsp annatto seeds, strain, use the red oil)
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 2 tbsp fish sauce

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) round rice vermicelli (bún)
- Cooked pork hock rounds
- Sliced cooked beef brisket
- Optional: Vietnamese pork patty (ch■), sliced
- Optional: pork blood cake (if available)

GARNISH PLATE

- Fresh bean sprouts
- Lime wedges
- Shredded banana blossom (or cabbage)
- Fresh herbs: Vietnamese mint (húng qu■), saw leaf herb
- Sliced chilli
- Shrimp paste paste on the side (for the brave)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: Blanch beef bones and pork hock in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Combine with brisket, lemongrass, charred shallots, garlic, and fresh water. Bring to a boil.
3. Skim foam. Simmer 2–3 hours until pork hock is tender.
4. Remove meats. Strain broth.
5. SPICE PASTE: Heat annatto oil in a small pan. Add minced lemongrass and garlic. Fry 2 minutes. Add dried chilli flakes and shrimp paste. Fry 1 minute. Add sugar and fish sauce. Stir.
6. Add spice paste to the strained broth. Stir well. Simmer 10 minutes. Season to taste. The broth should be spicy, aromatic with lemongrass, slightly funky from shrimp paste, and bright orange-red.
7. Slice pork hock rounds and brisket thinly.
8. NOODLES: Cook bún noodles in boiling water 2 minutes. Drain. Divide into bowls.
9. Add sliced meats to each bowl.
10. Ladle hot boiling broth over everything.
11. Serve with the full garnish plate and condiments.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 3 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~450 per bowl

TIP

M■m ru■c (fermented shrimp paste from Hue) is the ingredient that distinguishes authentic Bun Bo Hue from a generic spicy beef soup. It has a pungent, fermented depth that is irreplaceable. Use just a small amount — it is very strong — and temper it by frying it with the lemongrass first to mellow its intensity.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Hue Regional] [Spicy]

RECIPE 315

■■ Vietnam (Ho Chi Minh City)

C■M T■M S■■N BÌ CH■

BROKEN RICE WITH PORK DISHES

Saigon's most iconic breakfast — broken rice (c■m t■m) served with a grilled pork chop (s■■n), shredded pork skin salad (bì), steamed pork and egg meatloaf (ch■ tr■ng h■p), fresh cucumber, pickled vegetables, and scallion oil. Sold at com tam shops that open at 5am and close when the rice runs out. The combination of textures and flavors is uniquely, irreplaceably Saigonese.

INGREDIENTS

BROKEN RICE

- 2 cups broken rice (gạo tẻ — specifically broken)
- jasmine rice. Regular jasmine rice is an acceptable
- but inferior substitute)
- GRILLED PORK CHOP (sườn):
- 4 thin pork rib chops or loin chops
- MARINADE: 2 tbsp lemongrass (minced) + 2 tbsp
- fish sauce + 1 tbsp sugar + 1 tbsp soy sauce +
- 2 garlic cloves (minced) + 1 shallot (minced) +
- 1 tsp sesame oil + ½ tsp black pepper
- Marinate minimum 4 hours, ideally overnight
- CHỨNG HẤP (steamed pork egg meatloaf):
- 200g (7 oz) minced pork
- 2 eggs + 2 extra egg yolks
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 2 tbsp glass noodles, soaked and roughly chopped
- 2 tbsp dried wood ear mushrooms, soaked and minced
- BÌ (shredded pork skin):
- 200g (7 oz) cooked pork skin and lean pork,
- cooled and shredded into thin strips
- 3 tbsp toasted rice powder (khô) —
- made by toasting raw rice in a dry pan until golden,
- then grinding to a coarse powder
- 1 tbsp fish sauce + 1 tsp sugar + lime juice

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Scallion oil (mỡ hành — see Recipe 312)
- Nộm chả (see Recipe 313)
- Sliced cucumber
- Pickled daikon and carrot (see Recipe 311)
- Fried egg (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PORK CHOPS: Marinate overnight. Grill over charcoal or on a very hot grill pan 3–4 minutes per side until slightly charred and caramelized.
2. CHỨNG: Mix minced pork with fish sauce, sugar, pepper, glass noodles, and mushrooms. Beat 2 eggs and yolks into the mixture. Pour into a greased ramekin or pan. Steam 15–20 minutes until set and cooked through. Cool slightly. Slice into pieces.
3. BÌ: Toss shredded pork skin and meat with toasted rice powder, fish sauce, sugar, and lime. The rice powder coats everything and creates the characteristic slightly dry, slightly crunchy texture.
4. BROKEN RICE: Cook as regular rice, using slightly less water (broken rice absorbs less).
5. ASSEMBLE: Mound broken rice on a large plate. Drizzle scallion oil over rice.
6. Arrange grilled pork chop, chả slice, and bì alongside the rice.
7. Add cucumber slices and pickled vegetables.
8. Pour nộm chả in a small dish on the side.
9. Serve immediately — com tam waits for no one.

Prep: 30 min + overnight marinating · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

Toasted rice powder (thính) is the defining element of the bì — without it, the shredded pork skin is just cold, bland pork. The coarse powder coats each strand, absorbs the fish sauce dressing, and creates the dry, fragrant, slightly crunchy texture that makes bì immediately recognizable. Make extra and keep in a jar.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Saigon Icon]

RECIPE 316

■ ■ Vietnam

BÁNH MÌ THẬT

VIETNAMESE PORK BAGUETTE

Vietnam's greatest sandwich and one of the world's greatest street foods — a Vietnamese baguette layered with pâté, mayo, cold cuts, pickled vegetables, fresh cucumber, coriander, chilli, and Maggi sauce. The genius of bánh mì is the French-Vietnamese synthesis of baguette and local ingredients that creates a breakfast sandwich unlike anything that

exists elsewhere.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 Vietnamese baguettes (or crusty French baguettes)
- 2 tbsp chicken liver pâté
- 2 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise
- 4 slices chả lụa (Vietnamese steamed pork sausage — mild, springy, available at Vietnamese grocery stores)
- 4 slices Vietnamese ham (giò thủ — head cheese) or regular cooked ham
- Pickled daikon and carrot (do chua — see Recipe 311)
- ½ cucumber, cut into thin lengthwise strips
- Maggi seasoning sauce
- Fresh coriander sprigs (generous — do not be shy)
- Sliced fresh chilli (1–2 per sandwich)
- Optional: sliced jalapeño

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Slice baguette lengthwise, almost but not completely through — it should open like a book.
2. Use a spoon to remove some of the interior soft bread from both halves — this creates space for the fillings and prevents the sandwich from being too breadly.
3. Spread pâté on one inside surface.
4. Spread mayo on the other inside surface.
5. Layer chả lụa slices on the pâté side.
6. Layer ham slices over the sausage.
7. Add well-drained pickled vegetables generously.
8. Add cucumber strips.
9. Drizzle Maggi seasoning sauce over the meats — about ½ tsp per sandwich.
10. Add a generous amount of fresh coriander.
11. Add sliced chilli.
12. Press the sandwich closed firmly.
13. Wrap tightly in paper if eating on the go.
14. Eat within 5 minutes — the bread absorbs moisture.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~490 per sandwich

TIP

Removing some of the interior bread is the Vietnamese street vendor technique — it prevents the sandwich from being overly doughy and allows each filling to be tasted distinctly. Be generous with the coriander — Vietnamese bánh mì uses more fresh coriander than most people expect. The herbs are not a garnish; they are a primary filling.

[High Protein] [Classic Vietnamese] [Street Food] [Portable] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 317

■ ■ Vietnam

CHÈ CHU XANH

SWEET MUNG BEAN PUDDING

Vietnam's beloved sweet breakfast dessert-soup — split mung beans slow-cooked with rock sugar and pandan leaf into a fragrant, thick, golden pudding. Served warm in the morning or chilled in the afternoon. The pandan leaf imparts a distinctive vanilla-like, grassy fragrance that is immediately recognizable and entirely Vietnamese. Simple, beautiful, nourishing.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup split mung beans (■ ■ u xanh — skinless, the yellow/green split variety)
- 800ml (3■ cups) water
- 3 pandan leaves, tied into knots
- 4 tbsp rock sugar (■ ■ ■ ng phèn — crushed) or regular sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 200ml (¾ cup) thick coconut cream, to serve cold
- OR the pudding served warm as is

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse mung beans until water runs clear. Soak in cold water 2 hours (optional but reduces cooking time significantly).
2. Drain. Combine with 800ml fresh water and pandan leaves in a saucepan.
3. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat.
4. Simmer 20–25 minutes until beans are completely soft and beginning to fall apart. They should have absorbed most of the water and be thick and slightly creamy.
5. Remove pandan leaves.
6. Add rock sugar and salt. Stir until sugar dissolves.
7. Taste — it should be gently sweet, fragrant with pandan, and the beans should be completely tender.
8. Add a little more water and simmer 5 more minutes if the consistency is too thick.
9. WARM SERVING: Ladle into small bowls. Eat as is.
10. COLD SERVING: Cool completely. Refrigerate. Serve in bowls topped with cold coconut cream — drizzle it over the cold pudding.

Prep: 5 min + 2 hrs soaking · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~220 per bowl

TIP

Pandan leaf is to Southeast Asian cooking what vanilla is to Western baking — the fundamental sweet fragrance of the region. Fresh pandan is available at Asian grocery stores. Frozen is an acceptable substitute. Pandan extract can be used (½ tsp) but fresh leaves provide a more subtle, complex fragrance.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Vietnamese] [Sweet]

RECIPE 318

■ ■ Vietnam

CHÁO GÀ

VIETNAMESE CHICKEN RICE PORRIDGE

Vietnam's healing congee — silky jasmine rice cooked in rich chicken broth until completely dissolved, served with poached shredded chicken, fresh ginger, green onion, coriander, and fried shallots. Simpler than Chinese congee and less spiced than Thai khao tom, cháo gà has a clean, pure flavor that is restorative and deeply satisfying. Eaten for breakfast when ill, during monsoon season, and on any morning that demands comfort.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup jasmine rice, rinsed
- 1.5L (6 cups) rich chicken broth
- 200g (7 oz) poached chicken breast, shredded
- (poach in the broth for maximum flavor)
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp fish sauce

GARNISHES

- 3cm fresh ginger, finely julienned
- 3 green onions, sliced
- Fresh coriander and Vietnamese mint
- 3 tbsp fried shallots
- White pepper
- Lime wedge
- Chilli sauce on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring chicken broth to a boil in a large pot. Add whole chicken breast. Reduce to gentle simmer. Poach 20 minutes until cooked through. Remove chicken. Shred into thin pieces.
2. Add rinsed rice to the broth. Bring back to a boil.
3. Reduce heat to low-medium. Simmer 40–50 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice completely dissolves and the porridge is silky and smooth.
4. Season with salt and fish sauce.
5. Adjust consistency with hot water or broth if needed. Cháo gà is thinner than Chinese congee — it should pour slowly from a ladle.
6. Ladle into deep bowls.
7. Top with shredded chicken, julienned ginger, green onions, and fresh herbs.
8. Scatter fried shallots generously.
9. Drizzle a few drops of fish sauce.
10. Add white pepper to taste.
11. Squeeze lime juice before eating.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 60 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~255 per bowl

TIP

Cooking the chicken directly in the broth creates a double extraction of flavor — the broth becomes richer and the chicken absorbs the seasoned broth simultaneously. Always poach the chicken first, then add the rice to the flavored broth rather than cooking both together from the beginning.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Healing] [Comfort]

RECIPE 319

■ ■ Vietnam

TRỨNG CHI LÀ NẾM C MỀM

VIETNAMESE FRIED EGG WITH FISH SAUCE

Vietnam's simplest and most satisfying breakfast — a fried egg with crispy, golden edges cooked in a liberal amount of oil, then finished with a tablespoon of fish sauce and black pepper poured directly over the sizzling egg. Served over rice or with a baguette. The fish sauce caramelizes on contact with the hot egg surface creating an intensely savory glaze. Three ingredients. Infinite satisfaction.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large eggs
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- 1 tbsp fish sauce (poured directly into the hot pan)
- ½ tsp black pepper, freshly ground
- 1 green onion, sliced (optional garnish)
- 1 cup cooked jasmine rice or half a Vietnamese baguette

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oil in a small pan over high heat until nearly smoking.
2. Crack eggs in. They will spit and spatter — the high heat creates the crispy edges.
3. Baste the top of the eggs with the hot oil using a spoon — this cooks the top of the yolk while keeping it runny underneath.
4. When whites are fully set and edges are golden and crispy (about 90 seconds), pour the fish sauce directly into the hot oil, not onto the egg. It will sizzle dramatically.
5. The fish sauce reduces in the hot oil within seconds, caramelizing slightly.
6. Immediately pour the caramelized fish sauce oil over the egg surface.
7. Add freshly ground black pepper.
8. Remove immediately to rice or baguette.
9. Garnish with green onion. Eat immediately.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~290 per serving (with rice)

TIP

The fish sauce must be added to the hot oil — not poured directly onto the egg from a bottle. Oil + fish sauce + heat creates a brief but dramatic caramelization that transforms raw fish sauce into a complex, sticky, umami glaze. Add it to cold oil and you get nothing. Add it to hot oil and you get one of Vietnamese cooking's great simple effects.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Vietnamese]

RECIPE 320

■ ■ Vietnam

BÁNH TIÊU

VIETNAMESE HOLLOW SESAME DOUGHNUTS

A beloved Vietnamese breakfast sweet — round, hollow, sesame- encrusted dough rings that puff dramatically during frying into a completely hollow sphere, crispy and golden outside, completely hollow inside. Eaten warm from street carts in Ho Chi Minh City, dipped in hoisin sauce or eaten plain. The hollow interior is the achievement — achieved through the right dough hydration and oil temperature working in perfect concert.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 50g (■ cup) rice flour (adds crispiness)
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 130ml (½ cup) warm water (approximately)
- 1 tbsp neutral oil

COATING

- 1 egg white, lightly beaten
- 100g (¾ cup) sesame seeds (white or black or mixed)
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine all-purpose flour, rice flour, baking powder, baking soda, sugar, and salt.
2. Add warm water and oil gradually. Mix to form a soft, slightly sticky dough — do not overwork.
3. Cover and rest 20 minutes.
4. Divide into 10–12 balls.
5. Roll each ball into a smooth sphere, then flatten slightly into a thick disc (1.5cm thick, 5cm wide).
6. Brush the surface of each disc with beaten egg white.
7. Press both sides firmly into sesame seeds, coating completely. Reshape into a disc.
8. Heat oil to 160°C (320°F) — very important: low temperature for slow, even puffing.
9. Gently slide discs into the oil. DO NOT touch them for the first 2 minutes — let them puff undisturbed.
10. After 2 minutes, begin turning gently with tongs. Continue cooking 5–6 minutes total, turning regularly, until golden all over and completely hollow — they sound hollow when tapped.
11. Remove. Drain. Eat within 15 minutes while crispy.

Prep: 15 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~265 per serving

TIP

The low frying temperature (160°C) is essential — it gives the interior steam time to build pressure gradually and push the dough walls outward, creating the hollow sphere. High temperature browns the outside before the interior can puff, resulting in a dense, unhollow doughnut. Patience at low heat creates the magic.

[Vegan] [Classic Vietnamese] [Street Food] [Sweet] [Weekend]

RECIPE 321

■ ■ Vietnam (Qu■ng Nam)

MÌ QU■NG

TURMERIC NOODLES WITH PORK AND SHRIMP

Central Vietnam's extraordinary noodle dish — thick, turmeric- yellow rice noodles with very little broth (unlike pho's abundance), topped with braised pork and shrimp, roasted peanuts, sesame rice crackers, and fresh herbs. Mì Qu■ng has more texture, more color, and a more complex accompaniment than any other Vietnamese noodle dish. A breakfast that rewards full attention and uninterrupted eating.

INGREDIENTS

NOODLES

- 400g (14 oz) fresh or dried wide flat rice noodles
- tinted with turmeric (or plain wide rice noodles)

TOPPING

- 300g (10 oz) pork shoulder, cut into 3cm cubes
- 200g (7 oz) large shrimp, peeled and deveined
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 3 shallots, sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- 1 cup chicken or pork broth (just enough for a small amount of sauce — not a full bowl of soup)
- 1 tsp annatto oil (for color)

ESSENTIAL ACCOMPANIMENTS

- 3 tbsp roasted peanuts, coarsely crushed
- Crispy sesame rice crackers (bánh tráng mè)
- Fresh herbs: Vietnamese mint, perilla, banana blossom
- Bean sprouts
- Lime wedges
- Sliced green onion
- Fresh red chilli

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Marinate pork with 1 tbsp fish sauce, sugar, and turmeric. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Heat oil in a pan. Add shallots. Cook 3 minutes. Add garlic. Cook 1 minute.
3. Add marinated pork. Sear on all sides until browned.
4. Add annatto oil, remaining fish sauce, oyster sauce, and enough broth to barely cover the pork.
5. Simmer 20–25 minutes until pork is tender.
6. Add shrimp in the last 3 minutes. Cook until pink.
7. NOODLES: Blanch in boiling water 2 minutes. Drain. Divide into bowls.
8. ASSEMBLE: Place noodles in each bowl. Arrange pork pieces and shrimp on top.
9. Ladle just 3–4 tbsp of the broth/sauce over — mì Quế uses very little liquid. This is not soup.
10. Top with crushed peanuts, sliced green onion, and a drizzle of chilli oil.
11. Serve with the herb plate, bean sprouts, lime, and sesame rice crackers alongside.
12. Break sesame crackers into pieces and add to the bowl.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The sesame rice cracker (bánh tráng mè) is not a garnish — it is a structural component. Broken into pieces and mixed into the bowl, it absorbs the small amount of broth and adds crunch, sesame fragrance, and a textural contrast that makes mì Quế completely unlike any other noodle dish. Never omit it.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Central Vietnam]

RECIPE 322

■ ■ Vietnam

SỮA NÀNH NÓNG

VIETNAMESE HOT SOY MILK

Freshly made hot soy milk — richer, creamier, and more fragrant than any carton version — drunk alongside a bánh tiêu (hollow sesame doughnut) or patongo for breakfast in Vietnamese cities. Sold by street vendors who grind the soybeans fresh before dawn. The Vietnamese version is slightly sweeter than Chinese dou jiang and always served piping hot.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1 cup) dried soybeans
- 1.5L (6 cups) cold water (for blending)
- Additional cold water for soaking overnight
- 3–4 tbsp sugar (to taste)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 pandan leaf, knotted (optional — Vietnamese addition)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak soybeans in cold water overnight. They will roughly triple in volume.
2. Drain. Rinse well.
3. Blend soybeans with 750ml of the fresh cold water in a high-powered blender — 2–3 minutes until completely smooth with no visible grain.
4. Strain through a fine cheesecloth or nut milk bag stretched over a large bowl. Squeeze every drop of liquid from the pulp — the pulp (okara) is discarded or saved for another use.
5. Add remaining water to the strained soy liquid.
6. Pour into a saucepan with pandan leaf.
7. Bring to a boil over medium heat, stirring. A foam will rise — this is normal.
8. Reduce heat. Simmer 10 minutes — raw soybeans contain enzymes that must be deactivated by heat.
9. Remove pandan leaf.
10. Add sugar and salt. Stir until dissolved.
11. Taste and adjust sweetness.
12. Ladle into cups or bowls. Serve piping hot.
13. Pair with hollow sesame doughnuts for dipping.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~120 per cup

TIP

The 10 minutes of simmering after bringing to a boil is non-negotiable — raw soybeans contain trypsin inhibitors that interfere with protein digestion. These are deactivated by heat. Properly cooked soy milk is also noticeably less bitter than insufficiently cooked versions.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Vietnamese] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 323

■ ■ Vietnam (Central Vietnam / Hue)

BÁNH BÈO

STEAMED RICE CAKE WITH SHRIMP

A delicate Hue breakfast specialty — small, steamed rice cakes shaped like water fern leaves in shallow ceramic dishes, topped with dried shrimp, crispy pork skin, and scallion oil. The rice cakes have a translucent, slightly wobbly texture and a subtle savory flavor from the rice flour. Served with a sweet-sour fish sauce. Eaten in sets of six or eight small cakes, scraping each out with a small spoon or chopstick.

INGREDIENTS

RICE CAKE BATTER

- 200g (1½ cups) rice flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) tapioca starch
- 500ml (2 cups) water
- ½ tsp salt

TOPPINGS

- 100g (3.5 oz) dried shrimp (tom kho) — soaked
- in warm water 10 minutes, drained, then stir-fried
- in 1 tsp oil until fragrant and slightly crispy
- 3 tbsp scallion oil (mỡ hành — see Recipe 312)
- Crispy pork skin (da heo chien phong — fried pork
- cracklings), broken into small pieces

DIPPING SAUCE

- 3 tbsp fish sauce
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 2 tbsp lime juice
- 100ml (½ cup) warm water
- 1 garlic clove, minced
- 1 red chilli, minced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DIPPING SAUCE: Dissolve sugar in warm water. Add fish sauce, lime juice, garlic, and chilli. Taste: balance sweet, sour, and savory.
2. BATTER: Whisk rice flour, tapioca starch, water, and salt until completely smooth. Strain through a fine sieve.
3. Oil small ceramic saucers or ramekins (6–8cm wide).
4. Bring steamer water to a boil.
5. Place saucers in steamer. Heat 1 minute.
6. Stir batter (it settles). Pour batter into each heated saucer — fill only to 5mm depth. The cakes should be thin, not thick.
7. Cover steamer. Steam over high heat 4–5 minutes until set and translucent.
8. Remove. While still in saucers, top immediately: — Spoon dried shrimp over each cake — Drizzle scallion oil generously — Place a piece of crispy pork skin on each
9. Serve the saucers directly on the table.
10. Diners use a small spoon to scrape each cake out of the saucer, dip in sauce, and eat.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~220 per serving (6 cakes)

TIP

Heating the saucers in the steamer before adding batter is the professional technique — hot saucers cause the batter to begin setting immediately on contact, preventing it from running to one side. Cold saucers create uneven cakes that pool to the edges.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Hue Regional] [Elegant]

RECIPE 324

■ ■ Vietnam

CÀ PHÊ SỮA LẠ

VIETNAMESE ICED COFFEE

Vietnam's most iconic drink — strong, dark drip coffee brewed through a traditional phin filter (a small stainless steel single- cup dripper) directly over sweetened condensed milk, then poured over ice. The result is intensely strong, sweet, and cold — a perfect antidote to Vietnam's humid mornings. Drunk slowly at a plastic table on a street corner while watching the world pass. No morning in Vietnam is complete without it.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp coarse-ground Vietnamese coffee
- (Trung Nguyen G7 or Saigon Phin Deli — dark roast
- with some chicory. This specific type of coffee
- matters greatly to the final flavor.)
- 180ml (¾ cup) hot water (just off the boil)
- 2 tbsp sweetened condensed milk (per glass)
- Ice (plenty)

EQUIPMENT

- Vietnamese phin filter (aluminum or stainless steel
- drip filter — inexpensive and available everywhere)
- OR: use an Aeropress or Moka pot for stronger,
- faster results.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Add 2 tbsp sweetened condensed milk to the bottom of a glass.
2. Assemble the phin filter on top of the glass.
3. Add ground Vietnamese coffee to the filter.
4. Place the press disk on top of the grounds. Tamp very gently — just enough to settle, not press.
5. Pour 30ml (2 tbsp) of hot water over the coffee. Wait 30 seconds — this blooms the grounds and prepares them for full extraction.
6. Pour remaining water (about 150ml) into the filter.
7. Place the lid on the phin. Wait.
8. The coffee drips slowly through — approximately 5–8 minutes for full extraction. Do not rush. Slow drip = strong, sweet, complex coffee.
9. Once dripping has stopped, stir the condensed milk and coffee together briefly.
10. Pour the hot coffee over a glass packed with ice.
11. Stir. Drink immediately through a straw.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min (drip time) · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~120 per glass

TIP

Vietnamese phin coffee takes patience — the slow drip is intentional. The pressure and slow extraction create a coffee concentrate that is much stronger, less bitter, and more complex than a quickly brewed cup. Rushing with more water or a faster method dilutes the result dramatically. Trust the phin. Wait.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Vietnamese] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 325

■ ■ Vietnam

BÁP XÀO TÔM KHÔ

STIR-FRIED CORN WITH DRIED SHRIMP

A beloved Vietnamese street breakfast snack — fresh corn kernels stir-fried with dried shrimp, spring onion, butter, and lime in a hot wok. Sold in small paper cups from street carts, eaten standing up throughout Ho Chi Minh City from morning to midnight. The sweetness of fresh corn against the salty, umami depth of dried shrimp creates an irresistible combination that has been sold on Saigon streets for generations.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 ears fresh corn, kernels cut from the cob
- (approximately 3 cups of kernels)
- 50g (2 oz) dried shrimp (tôm khô), soaked in warm
- water 10 minutes, drained, and roughly chopped
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 green onions, thinly sliced
- 1 red chilli, finely sliced
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- ½ tsp white pepper
- Juice of ½ lime
- Fresh coriander to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak dried shrimp in warm water 10 minutes. Drain. Roughly chop or leave whole depending on size.
2. Heat a wok or wide pan over high heat.
3. Add butter. Let it melt and begin to foam.
4. Add dried shrimp. Stir-fry 1 minute until fragrant and beginning to caramelize slightly in the butter.
5. Add corn kernels all at once.
6. Stir-fry over high heat 3–4 minutes until corn is cooked through and some kernels are lightly caramelized and golden.
7. Add sugar, fish sauce, and white pepper. Toss.
8. Add green onion and red chilli. Toss briefly.
9. Remove from heat. Squeeze lime juice over.
10. Taste: it should be sweet from corn, salty and savory from shrimp and fish sauce, and bright with lime.
11. Transfer to small cups or a bowl.
12. Garnish with fresh coriander.
13. Eat immediately while hot.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Fresh corn is non-negotiable — frozen corn lacks the sweetness and juiciness that defines this dish. The kernels should burst when bitten. Cut them from the cob as close to serving time as possible, as fresh corn loses sweetness rapidly after cutting.

[Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Vietnamese] [Street Food] [Vegetarian option]

RECIPE 326

■ ■ Vietnam

BÚN THẬT NƯỚNG

COLD RICE NOODLES WITH GRILLED PORK

A southern Vietnamese breakfast bowl — room-temperature rice vermicelli noodles topped with caramelized grilled pork, fresh herbs, crispy spring roll pieces, bean sprouts, crushed peanuts, and a generous pour of sweetened fish sauce. Unlike pho, this is not a soup — it is a composed noodle salad eaten at breakfast throughout Ho Chi Minh City and the Mekong Delta.

INGREDIENTS**GRILLED PORK MARINADE**

- 300g (10 oz) pork shoulder or pork belly, thinly sliced
- 3 tbsp fish sauce
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 2 tbsp lemongrass, minced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 shallot, minced
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp annatto oil (for color)

NOODLE BOWL

- 300g (10 oz) dried rice vermicelli (bún),
- cooked according to package, rinsed in cold water
- Fresh bean sprouts
- Fresh lettuce, torn
- Fresh Vietnamese mint, perilla, and coriander
- 3 tbsp roasted peanuts, crushed
- 2 crispy spring rolls (chả giò), sliced
- (store-bought is fine)
- Scallion oil (see Recipe 312)
- Fried shallots
- NƯỚC CHẤM:
- 3 tbsp fish sauce + 2 tbsp sugar + 2 tbsp lime juice
- + 100ml warm water + garlic + chilli (see Recipe 313)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PORK: Combine all marinade ingredients. Add sliced pork. Marinate minimum 2 hours or overnight.
2. Grill marinated pork over very high heat (charcoal preferred) or in a very hot grill pan. 2–3 minutes per side until caramelized, slightly charred, and fragrant. The sugar in the marinade should caramelize and create a beautiful glaze.
3. Slice into bite-sized pieces. Set aside.
4. NOODLES: Cook and rinse vermicelli. It should be at room temperature — not hot, not cold.
5. ASSEMBLE: Place noodles in a bowl or on a plate.
6. Drizzle scallion oil over the noodles and toss to prevent sticking and add flavor.
7. Arrange bean sprouts and fresh herbs on top.
8. Add grilled pork slices.
9. Place crispy spring roll pieces alongside.
10. Scatter crushed peanuts and fried shallots.
11. Pour nước chấm generously over everything — about 3–4 tbsp per serving.
12. Mix everything together before eating — or eat as individual bites combining elements.

Prep: 20 min + 2 hrs marinating · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

The caramelization of the grilled pork is what makes this dish. The sugar-fish sauce marinade must be allowed to char slightly on the grill — the slightly burned edges create a smoky, sweet, intensely savory quality that defines Vietnamese grilled pork. A char-less, pale pork result is significantly inferior.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Vietnamese] [Southern Vietnam]

South Korea

RECIPE 327

■ ■ South Korea

KOREAN BREAKFAST TABLE

ACHIM BAPSANG — THE MORNING MEAL SET

The traditional Korean breakfast is not a single dish but a composed table — steamed short-grain rice, a warm soup (usually doenjang jjigae or miyeok guk), and three to five small banchan side dishes. This recipe teaches the complete morning table: balanced, nourishing, and assembled from components that can be made ahead. The Korean breakfast at its most authentic.

INGREDIENTS

STEAMED RICE

- 2 cups Korean short-grain rice (bap)
- 2 cups cold water
- SIMPLE BANCHAN (make ahead — all improve overnight):
 - Baechu kimchi (napa cabbage kimchi — store-bought
 - or homemade, always present)
 - Sigumchi namul: blanched spinach seasoned with
 - soy sauce, sesame oil, garlic, and sesame seeds
 - Kongnamul: blanched bean sprouts with sesame oil,
 - salt, and green onion
 - Gamja jorim: braised potato cubes in soy, sugar, and sesame (recipe below)
 - Gyeran mari or fried egg
- DOENJANG JJIGAE (soybean paste soup — the heart):
 - 700ml (3 cups) anchovy or vegetable broth
 - 3 tbsp doenjang (Korean fermented soybean paste)
 - 150g (5 oz) firm tofu, cubed
 - 1 small zucchini, diced
 - 1 potato, small dice
 - ½ onion, diced
 - 2 garlic cloves, minced
 - 1 tsp sesame oil
 - 1 green chilli, sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. RICE: Rinse rice 3–4 times until water runs clear. Combine with cold water. Bring to a boil. Reduce to lowest heat. Cover tightly. Cook 12 minutes. Rest off heat 10 minutes without opening.
2. SIGUMCHI NAMUL: Blanch spinach 30 seconds. Squeeze completely dry. Toss with 1 tsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sesame oil, 1 minced garlic clove, sesame seeds.
3. KONGNAMUL: Blanch bean sprouts 2 minutes. Drain. Toss with ½ tsp sesame oil, pinch salt, sliced green onion, sesame seeds.
4. GAMJA JORIM: Boil diced potato 5 minutes. Drain. Pan-fry in 1 tsp oil until lightly golden. Add 1 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sugar, 1 tsp sesame oil. Toss until glazed. Scatter sesame seeds.
5. DOENJANG JJIGAE: Bring broth to a simmer. Dissolve doenjang in a ladle of hot broth. Stir back into the pot. Add onion, potato, and garlic. Simmer 8 minutes. Add zucchini and tofu. Simmer 5 minutes. Add green chilli. Finish with sesame oil.
6. SET THE TABLE: Rice bowl on the left. Soup on the right. Banchan in small dishes around them. Kimchi always present.
7. Begin with a sip of soup. Alternate between rice, soup, and banchan. Do not pour soup over rice — eat them separately in Korean tradition.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~520 per complete set

TIP

Korean meals — including breakfast — follow specific placement rules: rice on the left, soup on the right, banchan behind them. This placement is not decorative — it reflects thousands of years of Korean dining culture. Setting the table correctly transforms cooking into ritual.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Complete Meal]

RECIPE 328

■ ■ South Korea

KIMCHI BOKKEUMBAP

KIMCHI FRIED RICE

Korea's greatest use of leftovers — day-old rice stir-fried with well-fermented kimchi, gochujang, sesame oil, and butter, topped with a fried egg whose runny yolk becomes the sauce. Kimchi fried rice is a Korean breakfast institution, born from practicality and elevated by umami. The older and more sour the kimchi, the better the fried rice. This is the rule without exception.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups day-old cooked short-grain rice
- (cold, refrigerated rice only — fresh rice steams instead of frying)
- 1 cup kimchi, roughly chopped + 3 tbsp kimchi juice
- 2 tbsp gochujang (Korean chilli paste)
- 1 tbsp butter (the Korean secret ingredient)
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 2 tsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 2 large eggs (fried sunnyside up)
- 1 sheet gim (toasted Korean seaweed), torn or sliced
- 1 tbsp sesame seeds
- Optional: spam or bacon, diced — a Korean favorite

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat a wok or large pan over high heat.
2. Add butter. Let it melt and foam.
3. If using spam or bacon: add now and fry until slightly crispy. Remove and set aside.
4. Add chopped kimchi to the hot butter. Stir-fry vigorously 2 minutes until kimchi caramelizes slightly and the liquid mostly evaporates.
5. Add cold rice. Break up any clumps immediately using the back of a spatula.
6. Stir-fry over HIGH heat 2–3 minutes until each grain is coated and beginning to caramelize.
7. Add kimchi juice, gochujang, soy sauce, and sugar. Toss to coat everything evenly. The rice should turn a vibrant orange-red.
8. Add sesame oil. Toss once more.
9. Taste: it should be intensely savory, slightly spicy, and deeply flavored with kimchi.
10. Divide into bowls. Top each with a fried egg.
11. Scatter green onions, sesame seeds, and torn gim.
12. Serve immediately. Break the egg yolk into the rice.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~510 per serving

TIP

Butter in kimchi fried rice is the Korean home cook's secret — it creates a richer, more caramelized result than oil alone and softens the sharp acidity of the kimchi into something rounder and more complex. Never skip the butter. This is not a health sacrifice — it is a flavor decision.

[High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Korean] [One-Pan]

RECIPE 329

■■ South Korea

HAEMUL PAJEON

KOREAN SEAFOOD AND GREEN ONION PANCAKE

Korea's beloved savory pancake — a large, crispy-edged round pancake loaded with green onions and mixed seafood, served with a soy-vinegar dipping sauce. The batter is extraordinarily thin so the pancake is mostly green onion and seafood with just enough batter to hold it together. Best made on rainy days — the sound of rain on a Korean roof is said to resemble the sizzle of pajeon in oil, creating an inseparable association.

INGREDIENTS

FOR THE PANCAKE BATTER

- 120g (1 cup) all-purpose flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) rice flour (for extra crispiness)
- 1 large egg
- 200ml (¾ cup) ice-cold water
- (COLD is critical — warm water creates tough pancakes)
- ½ tsp salt

FILLINGS

- 10 green onions, halved lengthwise, then cut into
- 10cm pieces — these form the structure of the pancake
- 150g (5 oz) mixed seafood: squid rings, shrimp,
- clams, or oysters (thawed if frozen, patted dry)
- 1 red chilli, thinly sliced (optional — for color and heat)
- 3–4 tbsp neutral oil for frying

DIPPING SAUCE

- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp rice vinegar
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp gochugaru (Korean chilli flakes)
- 1 tsp toasted sesame seeds
- 1 green onion, minced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DIPPING SAUCE: Combine all sauce ingredients. Set aside.
2. BATTER: Whisk flour, rice flour, egg, ice-cold water, and salt until just combined — a few lumps are fine. Do NOT overmix. Over-mixed batter develops gluten and creates tough, chewy pancakes. Mix minimally.
3. Heat a 25cm (10-inch) non-stick pan or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Add 2 tbsp oil.
4. Arrange green onion pieces in the hot pan parallel to each other in a single layer — they form the base structure of the pancake.
5. Pour batter over the green onions — just enough to bind them. The batter should barely cover them.
6. Arrange seafood pieces over the batter surface. Press slightly to embed in the batter.
7. Add chilli slices if using.
8. Cook over medium-high heat without touching — 5–6 minutes until the edges are golden and set.
9. Add another 1–2 tbsp oil around the edges. Flip confidently using a large spatula.
10. Press down firmly with the spatula on the seafood side. Cook 4–5 minutes until deeply golden and crispy.
11. Flip one more time briefly to reheat the green onion side.
12. Transfer to a cutting board. Cut into pieces. Serve with dipping sauce.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Ice-cold water is the most important ingredient in pajeon batter. Cold water inhibits gluten development, creating a more tender, crispier pancake. Use water with ice cubes — seriously. Additionally, the generous amount of oil is not optional: it creates the characteristic lacey, crispy edge that defines a well-made pajeon.

[High Protein] [Classic Korean] [Comfort Food] [Rainy Day]

RECIPE 330

■ ■ South Korea

DOENJANG JJIGAE

KOREAN SOYBEAN PASTE SOUP

Korea's most fundamental soup — fermented soybean paste dissolved in anchovy broth with tofu, zucchini, mushrooms, and potato. Boiled vigorously and served bubbling at the table. Unlike Japanese miso soup (which must never boil), Korean doenjang jjigae is purposefully and forcefully boiled — the vigorous cooking extracts maximum depth from the doenjang and creates a stronger, more robust, earthier soup. Eaten daily by millions as the morning anchor.

INGREDIENTS

ANCHOVY BROTH

- 10 dried anchovies (myeolchi), heads and guts removed
- 1 small piece dried kelp (dasima), 5x5cm
- 1L (4 cups) cold water

SOUP

- 3 tbsp doenjang (Korean fermented soybean paste) —
- do NOT substitute with Japanese miso — the flavor
- profile is fundamentally different)
- 1 tsp gochugaru (Korean chilli flakes) — optional
- 200g (7 oz) firm tofu, cut into 2cm cubes
- 1 medium zucchini (courgette), half-moon slices
- 1 small potato, 1cm dice
- ½ onion, roughly chopped
- 4 button mushrooms, quartered
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1–2 green chillies, sliced
- 1 green onion, sliced (garnish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ANCHOVY BROTH: Combine dried anchovies, kelp, and cold water in a pot.
2. Bring to a boil. Boil 5 minutes.
3. Remove kelp (overcooking makes it slimy). Continue boiling anchovies 5 more minutes.
4. Strain. Discard anchovies. Reserve clear broth.
5. SOUP: Bring anchovy broth to a boil.
6. Dissolve doenjang in a ladleful of hot broth. Pour back into the pot. Stir.
7. Add gochugaru if using. Add onion, potato, and garlic. Boil vigorously 8 minutes.
8. Add zucchini and mushrooms. Boil 5 minutes.
9. Add tofu. Boil 3 more minutes.
10. Add green chillies.
11. Finish with sesame oil.
12. Serve in the ttukbaegi (Korean clay pot) if available — it retains heat and arrives bubbling. Or serve in deep bowls. Garnish with green onion.
13. Serve immediately alongside rice and banchan.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~180 per bowl

TIP

Doenjang must be boiled — this is the fundamental difference between it and Japanese miso. The boiling releases compounds from the fermented paste that create depth impossible in a gently heated soup. Korean grandmothers boil doenjang jjigae hard and long. Follow their example.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Daily Breakfast]

RECIPE 331

■■ South Korea

GYERANMARI

KOREAN ROLLED EGG OMELETTE

Korea's rolled omelette — similar in technique to Japanese tamagoyaki but with distinctly Korean flavors: seasoned with salt, sesame oil, and green onion instead of the Japanese dashi-mirin combination. The result is slightly more rustic, more robustly flavored, and often filled with carrot, spinach, and cheese. A Korean breakfast banchan staple served alongside rice and soup every morning.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 green onions, finely sliced
- ½ carrot, finely julienned
- ½ tsp sesame oil
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp sugar
- Pinch of white pepper
- 1 slice processed cheese (very Korean — optional but beloved)
- Neutral oil for the pan

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs with sesame oil, salt, sugar, and white pepper until well combined but not frothy.
2. Stir in sliced green onion and julienned carrot.
3. Heat a non-stick rectangular pan (tamagoyaki pan) or regular non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Oil lightly with a paper towel.
4. Pour ■ of the egg mixture into the pan. Swirl to spread evenly.
5. Lay cheese slice over the center if using.
6. When egg is 80% set on the surface — still slightly wet on top — begin rolling from the far edge toward you. Use chopsticks or a spatula. Roll slowly and firmly.
7. Push the rolled egg to the far edge of the pan.
8. Oil the empty pan surface.
9. Pour another ■ of the egg. Lift the existing roll to allow raw egg to flow underneath.
10. When 80% set, roll the new layer over the existing roll.
11. Repeat with the final ■.
12. Shape the log by pressing gently with the spatula on all sides. Cool 2 minutes.
13. Slice into 2cm rounds. Serve as part of the morning banchan.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~210 per serving

TIP

The Korean gyeranmari is intentionally more chunky and filled than Japanese tamagoyaki — the carrot and green onion create visible color inside each slice. The rolled eggs should reveal a beautiful spiral of yellow egg, orange carrot, and green onion when cut. This visual cross-section is part of the pleasure.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Quick]

RECIPE 332

■■ South Korea

HOBAKJUK

KOREAN PUMPKIN PORRIDGE

A sweet, vibrant orange porridge made from Korean kabocha pumpkin — silky smooth with small glutinous rice balls (saealsim) floating within, sweet from the pumpkin, and subtly salty. One of Korea's most warming and visually beautiful breakfast dishes, often eaten during colder months or when someone needs gentle nourishment. The small rice balls add a delightful chewy contrast to the velvet pumpkin puree.

INGREDIENTS

- 600g (21 oz) kabocha or butternut squash,
- peeled, seeded, and roughly cubed
- 800ml (3 cups) water
- 3 tbsp sugar (adjust to pumpkin sweetness)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sesame oil (finishing touch)
- SAEALSIM (small glutinous rice balls):
- 100g (¾ cup) glutinous rice flour (chapssalgaru)
- 60ml (¼ cup) hot water
- Pinch of salt
- Optional: ½ tsp sugar for slightly sweet balls
- Pine nuts or black sesame seeds (garnish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SAEALSIM: Mix glutinous rice flour with hot water and salt until a smooth, pliable dough forms. Knead 2 minutes until soft and not sticky. Roll into small balls — the size of large peas. Set aside on a lightly floured surface.
2. Combine pumpkin cubes and water in a pot. Bring to a boil. Simmer 15–20 minutes until pumpkin is completely soft — a chopstick should pass through without resistance.
3. Blend until completely smooth using an immersion blender. Return to the pot over medium heat.
4. Add sugar and salt. Stir until dissolved. Taste.
5. The porridge should be thick and smooth — thinner than a smoothie, thicker than a soup. Add a splash of water if too thick.
6. Bring to a gentle simmer. Drop in the rice balls.
7. Cook 5–7 minutes until the rice balls float to the surface and are cooked through — they will puff slightly and become translucent.
8. Finish with a drizzle of sesame oil. Stir gently.
9. Ladle into bowls. Garnish with pine nuts or black sesame seeds — the contrast on the orange porridge is beautiful.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 25 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~240 per bowl

TIP

Kabocha pumpkin (Korean dan hobak) is denser and sweeter than butternut squash — it creates a more vibrant orange color and a richer porridge with less water needed. If using butternut squash, reduce water by 100ml. The glutinous rice ball size is important: too large and they don't cook through evenly; too small and they dissolve. Pea-sized is perfect.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Korean] [Healing] [Sweet]

RECIPE 333

■■ South Korea

SUNDUBU JJIGAE

SILKEN TOFU STEW

Soft tofu stew — silken tofu simmered with seafood, gochugaru, and sesame oil in a clay pot that arrives at the table still actively boiling, with a raw egg cracked in at the last moment. One of Korea's most dynamic breakfast dishes — the contrast of fiery red broth, trembling soft tofu, and the barely-cooked egg yolk pooling on top is one of Korean food's great pleasures.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 package (300g) silken soft tofu (sundubu — the extra-soft variety, not regular firm tofu)
- 150g (5 oz) mixed seafood: clams, shrimp, squid
- 3 tbsp gochugaru (Korean chilli flakes — this is the primary flavor, not an afterthought)
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- ½ onion, finely diced
- 300ml (1¼ cups) anchovy broth
- (see Recipe 330 for method)
- 1 large egg (cracked in at serving)
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 1 tbsp neutral oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oil in a ttukbaegi (Korean clay pot) or small heavy saucepan over medium heat.
2. Add gochugaru. Stir-fry in the oil 30 seconds until the oil turns a vivid red — this is the essential Korean "blooming" technique.
3. Add garlic and onion. Cook 2 minutes.
4. Add seafood. Toss briefly in the chilli oil.
5. Add anchovy broth. Bring to a vigorous boil.
6. Add soy sauce. Season. The broth should be powerfully spiced and deeply savory.
7. Spoon tofu directly into the boiling broth in large irregular chunks — do not cube it neatly. Korean sundubu is added roughly for rustic texture.
8. Simmer 3–4 minutes until tofu is heated through and has absorbed some of the broth flavor.
9. Drizzle sesame oil.
10. REMOVE FROM HEAT. Crack raw egg directly into the center of the bubbling stew.
11. Do NOT stir. The residual heat cooks the egg partially — the white should just set, the yolk remain completely liquid.
12. Scatter green onion. Serve immediately and directly in the clay pot.
13. Eat with steamed rice alongside.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The clay pot (ttukbaegi) is worth owning for this dish — it retains heat intensely and arrives at the table still vigorously boiling, creating the theatrical arrival that makes sundubu jjigae memorable. In a clay pot, the egg cooks gently from the residual heat alone. In a regular pot, you must remove it slightly earlier.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Quick] [Spicy]

RECIPE 334

■■ South Korea

DDALGI TTEOK

STRAWBERRY RICE CAKE

A Korean patisserie breakfast innovation — a fresh ripe strawberry encased entirely in sweet white rice cake (tteok) with a layer of sweet red bean paste between the fruit and the rice cake. The result is simultaneously custardy, chewy, fruity, and subtly sweet. Made famous by Korean dessert cafés and now found at morning markets. Beautiful to look at, extraordinary to eat.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 large, fresh ripe strawberries, hulled

RICE CAKE DOUGH

- 200g (1  cups) sweet glutinous rice flour
- (chapssalgaru)
- 160ml ( cup) water
- 3 tbsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- Cornstarch for dusting (prevents sticking)

FILLING

- 150g ( cup) smooth sweet red bean paste (anko)
- — divide into 8 portions

INSTRUCTIONS

1. RICE CAKE: Combine glutinous rice flour, water, sugar, and salt in a microwave-safe bowl. Mix until smooth.
2. Microwave on high for 1 minute. Stir well.
3. Microwave another 30 seconds. Stir vigorously — the mixture should be thick, glossy, and slightly translucent. Microwave 30 more seconds if needed. The dough should be cooked through and stretchy.
4. Alternatively: steam the mixture over boiling water in a heatproof bowl for 20 minutes, stirring halfway.
5. Cool until handleable but still warm (not hot). Dust your work surface generously with cornstarch.
6. ASSEMBLY: With cornstarch-dusted hands, divide dough into 8 portions.
7. Flatten each portion into a round disc (10cm).
8. Place one portion of red bean paste in the center. Press flat over the dough, leaving a 2cm border.
9. Place one hulled strawberry on the bean paste, pointed tip facing down.
10. Gather dough edges upward around the strawberry. Press and seal tightly — no gaps.
11. Shape into a round. Roll gently in cornstarch.
12. Serve immediately or refrigerate up to 4 hours. Best eaten the same day.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 3 min (microwave) · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~145 per piece

TIP

The strawberry must be completely dry before assembly — any moisture will separate the bean paste from the rice cake during storage. Pat dry thoroughly after hulling. Choose uniform, symmetrical strawberries so the finished tteok looks professional and even.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Modern Korean] [Sweet] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 335

 **South Korea**

GUKBAP

RICE IN BROTH

One of Korea's oldest breakfast traditions — cooked rice dropped directly into hot broth and eaten as one. Unlike Japanese ochazuke (tea over rice) or Chinese congee (rice cooked in broth), gukbap is simply hot soup poured over separately cooked rice at the table. The rice remains distinct, the broth fragrant, and the combination warming and deeply satisfying. Dwaeji Gukbap (pork rice soup) is the most famous version from Busan.

INGREDIENTS

PORK BROTH

- 400g (14 oz) pork ribs or pork bones
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 3 garlic cloves, crushed
- 2 green onions, whole
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp doenjang (soybean paste — small amount)
- 1½ cups cooked short-grain rice (per bowl)

TOPPINGS AND ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Sliced cooked pork from the broth
- 2 green onions, thinly sliced
- 1 tbsp gochugaru (chilli flakes) mixed with
- 1 tbsp soy sauce (bibimbap sauce style)
- Coarse sea salt
- White pepper
- Kimchi (always alongside)
- Perilla leaves (kkaennip) — optional

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blanch pork ribs in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Combine with fresh water, garlic, green onions, and salt. Bring to a boil.
3. Add a small spoonful of doenjang — it enriches and deepens the broth without overpowering.
4. Simmer 60–90 minutes until pork is tender and broth is milky-white and savory.
5. Remove pork. Pull meat from bones. Slice.
6. Strain broth. Season with salt and white pepper. The broth should be clean, mildly savory, and slightly milky from the pork collagen.
7. SERVING: Place a full bowl of rice in a deep bowl.
8. Pour boiling hot broth directly over the rice — enough to surround but not completely submerge.
9. Top with sliced pork.
10. Scatter green onion.
11. Add a spoonful of gochugaru-soy sauce on the side for stirring in to taste.
12. Serve with kimchi alongside.
13. Season at the table with salt and white pepper.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 90 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~480 per bowl

TIP

The broth for gukbap should be milky white — this cloudiness comes from pork collagen dissolving during the long simmer. Never skim the fat entirely — the fat carries flavor and creates the characteristic richness. The combination of fat-rich broth and seasoned chilli sauce added at the table is the complete flavor of authentic Busan gukbap.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Busan Regional]

RECIPE 336

■■ South Korea

TTEOKGUK

RICE CAKE SOUP — NEW YEAR SOUP

Korea's New Year breakfast soup — thin oval rice cake slices in a clear beef broth, garnished with egg strips, beef, seaweed, and sesame oil. Eating tteokguk on the first morning of the lunar new year is believed to grant one more year of age and good fortune. But it is so good that many Koreans eat it year-round as a warming breakfast soup — no occasion required.

INGREDIENTS

BEEF BROTH

- 300g (10 oz) beef brisket, whole
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- 3 garlic cloves
- ½ onion
- 2 green onions
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- Salt and white pepper
- 400g (14 oz) sliced rice cake ovals
- (tteok for tteokguk — thin, white, oval slices.
- Soak in cold water 30 minutes to soften if dried.)

GARNISHES

- 2 eggs, beaten and made into thin omelette strips
- (jidan — cook thin, roll, slice thin)
- Cooked beef brisket, thinly sliced
- 2 sheets gim (roasted Korean seaweed), crumbled
- 2 green onions, thinly sliced
- Sesame oil (a few drops per bowl)
- Soy sauce and salt at the table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Simmer beef brisket with water, garlic, onion, and green onion for 60 minutes until tender.
2. Remove brisket. Slice thin when cooled.
3. Strain broth. Season with soy sauce, salt, and white pepper. The broth should be clear, golden, and cleanly savory.
4. Bring broth to a boil. Add soaked rice cake slices.
5. Boil 3–4 minutes until rice cakes are softened and floating — they become slightly translucent. Do not overcook or they become mushy.
6. JIDAN (egg garnish): Beat 2 eggs with a pinch of salt. Cook a thin omelette in a lightly oiled pan. Roll up. Slice crosswise into thin strips.
7. Ladle soup and rice cakes into bowls.
8. Arrange sliced beef, egg strips, and crumbled gim on top.
9. Scatter green onion. Drizzle sesame oil.
10. Serve immediately — rice cakes continue to soften in the hot broth.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 70 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per bowl

TIP

Rice cakes for tteokguk should be eaten immediately after the soup is assembled — they continue absorbing broth and soften beyond the ideal texture within 5 minutes. For groups, keep the broth and rice cakes separate and combine individual portions only when each person is ready to eat.

[High Protein] [Classic Korean] [Seasonal] [New Year]

RECIPE 337

■ ■ South Korea

NURUNGJI

SCORCHED RICE BREAKFAST

Korea's most humble breakfast — the golden, crispy layer of scorched rice left at the bottom of the pot after cooking, either eaten as-is as a crunchy snack or simmered with water to create a nutty, golden rice soup (nurungji tang). Every Korean grandmother treasures the scorched rice layer. Nothing is wasted. Everything becomes something better.

INGREDIENTS

- Leftover scorched rice from the bottom of a rice pot
- (the golden crust left after cooking rice in a pot)
- OR: make intentionally (method below)

TO MAKE INTENTIONAL NURUNGJI

- 1½ cups cooked short-grain rice
- Small amount of water
- FOR NURUNGJI TANG (scorched rice tea/soup):
- 500ml (2 cups) hot water per serving
- Salt (optional — just a tiny pinch)
- Optional garnish: toasted sesame seeds,
- thinly sliced green onion

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MAKING NURUNGJI (intentional):
2. Spread a thin, even layer of cooked rice (5mm thick) across the bottom of a heavy pot or cast-iron pan.
3. Add 1–2 tbsp water around the edges.
4. Cover with a lid. Cook over medium-low heat.
5. After 5 minutes, reduce heat to low.
6. Continue cooking 10–15 minutes until you hear a dry, crackling sound — the rice is toasting.
7. Check: lift an edge with a spatula. The bottom should be golden, crispy, and slightly charred.
8. Remove from heat. Allow to cool in the pot.
9. Peel away from the pot in sheets. NURUNGJI TANG (scorched rice soup):
10. Break nurungji into pieces. Place in a saucepan.
11. Add hot water. Bring to a simmer.
12. Simmer 5–10 minutes — the nurungji softens and dissolves into a golden, fragrant soup.
13. The liquid turns a toasted, nutty golden color.
14. Season with a tiny pinch of salt.
15. Serve in bowls. Garnish with sesame and green onion.
16. The remaining undissolved pieces are eaten as they are — some crispy, some softened.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~185 per bowl

TIP

The nutty, slightly smoky flavor of nurungji comes from the Maillard reaction of rice starch against the hot metal pot — the same reaction that creates flavor in roasted coffee, baked bread crusts, and grilled meat. Nurungji tang has a digestive-soothing quality that Korean traditional medicine values highly — it is recommended for upset stomachs and recovery.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Zero Waste] [Healing]

RECIPE 338

■■ South Korea

JAPCHAE

GLASS NOODLE AND VEGETABLE STIR-FRY

Korea's celebratory noodle dish served at every significant occasion including holiday breakfasts — sweet potato glass noodles stir-fried with colorful vegetables, beef, and sesame oil in a soy-sesame sauce. The glass noodles have a silky, slightly chewy texture unlike any other noodle. Served at room temperature, which makes it ideal for a Korean holiday breakfast table where dishes are prepared ahead and served communally.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) dangmyeon (Korean sweet potato glass noodles)
- — soaked in cold water 30 minutes, then boiled
- 6 minutes until just tender. Drain. Cut into
- 15cm lengths. Season immediately with 1 tsp sesame oil
- and 1 tsp soy sauce to prevent sticking.
- 150g (5 oz) beef sirloin or rib-eye, thinly sliced
- MARINADE: 1 tbsp soy sauce + 1 tsp sugar + 1 tsp
- sesame oil + 1 minced garlic clove
- VEGETABLES (prepare each separately):
- 1 large carrot, julienned — stir-fried 2 min with salt
- 100g (3.5 oz) spinach, blanched and squeezed —
- seasoned with salt, sesame oil, garlic
- 5 shiitake mushrooms, sliced — stir-fried with
- soy sauce, sugar, garlic
- ½ onion, thinly sliced — stir-fried until golden
- 1 red bell pepper, julienned — briefly stir-fried
- 2 green onions, cut into 5cm pieces

FINAL SEASONING

- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 2 tbsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Prepare all vegetables separately as described above. This step ensures each vegetable retains its own texture and color.
2. Cook marinated beef in a hot pan 2 minutes per side. Slice into thin pieces.
3. In a large bowl or wok, combine cooked noodles, all prepared vegetables, and beef.
4. Add soy sauce, sugar, and sesame oil. Toss well.
5. Taste: adjust soy (saltier), sugar (sweeter), or sesame oil (nuttier) to your preference.
6. Scatter sesame seeds generously.
7. Serve at room temperature — japchae is always served at room temperature, never hot or cold.
8. Pairs beautifully with rice and other banchan.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Each vegetable must be cooked and seasoned separately — this is not optional, it is the entire philosophy of japchae. Cooking everything together creates a muddy, indistinct dish. The individual seasoning of each component creates a dish where every bite delivers multiple distinct flavors.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Holiday] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 339

■■ South Korea

SIKHYE

SWEET RICE DRINK

Korea's traditional sweet rice punch — malt barley water poured over cooked rice and fermented at a warm temperature for hours until the enzyme in the malt converts some of the rice starches to sugar, creating a lightly sweet, clean-tasting beverage with rice grains floating in it. Served cold as a morning drink alongside breakfast or as a palate cleanser. Ancient, digestive, and completely unique to Korea.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup barley malt powder (yeotgireum — Korean malt)
- powder available at Korean grocery stores)
- 1.5L (6 cups) warm water (55–60°C / 130–140°F)
- 1 cup cooked short-grain rice
- 4 tbsp sugar
- Optional garnish: pine nuts floating on surface

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dissolve barley malt powder in warm water. Stir well. Let sit 30 minutes.
2. Strain through a fine cloth or cheesecloth to remove solids. You should have a pale, slightly cloudy liquid — this is the malt water.
3. Combine malt water and cooked rice in a large bowl or pot. The temperature should be 55–60°C — warm, not hot. Use a thermometer. If too hot, the enzymes are destroyed. If too cold, the enzymes are inactive.
4. Cover and keep warm for 4–5 hours. In a traditional Korean home: place near an ondol (heated floor). At home: use a rice cooker on "keep warm" setting or a low (55°C) oven. Check temperature.
5. After 4–5 hours: the rice grains should be floating — this indicates successful enzymatic conversion. The liquid will taste lightly sweet and clean.
6. Strain out the rice grains. Reserve them separately.
7. Add sugar to the strained liquid. Stir.
8. Bring to a boil briefly to stop the enzymatic process.
9. Cool completely. Refrigerate.
10. **SERVE:** Pour cold sikhye into cups. Add a small spoonful of the reserved cooked rice grains. Float 2–3 pine nuts on top. Drink cold.

Prep: 15 min + 4-5 hrs fermentation · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~120 per cup

TIP

Temperature maintenance during fermentation is the critical variable. Too hot (above 65°C) and the amylase enzymes in the malt are denatured — no conversion. Too cold (below 45°C) and the enzymes are too slow — the process fails or takes much longer. 55–60°C for 4–5 hours is the Korean grandmother's recipe.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Korean] [Make-Ahead] [Digestive]

RECIPE 340

■■ Indonesia

NASI GORENG

INDONESIAN FRIED RICE

Indonesia's national dish and most eaten breakfast — day-old rice stir-fried with shrimp paste, sweet soy sauce (kecap manis), chilli, and garlic, topped with a fried egg, cucumber slices, and prawn crackers. The kecap manis creates a dark, lacquered color and caramel sweetness unlike any other fried rice in Asia. Indonesia consumes more kecap manis per capita than any other country — and nasi goreng is the primary vehicle.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups day-old cooked long-grain rice (cold)
- 2 large eggs (1 beaten into rice, 1 fried on top)
- 100g (3.5 oz) shrimp or chicken, diced
- 4 shallots, thinly sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 red chillies, finely sliced
- 1 tsp shrimp paste (terasi/belacan — small amount,
- wrap in foil and toast in dry pan 1 minute first)
- 3 tbsp kecap manis (Indonesian sweet soy sauce —
- non-negotiable for authentic flavor)
- 1 tbsp regular soy sauce
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Salt to taste

GARNISHES AND SIDES

- 1 fried egg (per serving)
- ½ cucumber, sliced
- 2 tomatoes, sliced or halved
- Prawn crackers (kerupuk)
- Fried shallots (bawang goreng)
- Fresh red chilli slices
- Achar (pickled cucumber and carrot — optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast shrimp paste wrapped in foil in a dry pan or directly over a flame 1 minute per side. Unwrap and set aside — it will smell very pungent. This is correct and essential.
2. Heat oil in a wok over very high heat until smoking.
3. Add shallots. Stir-fry 2 minutes until golden.
4. Add garlic and chilli. Stir-fry 30 seconds.
5. Add shrimp or chicken. Stir-fry until cooked.
6. Add toasted shrimp paste — crumble into the wok. Stir-fry 30 seconds, breaking it up.
7. Add cold rice all at once. Press and toss vigorously.
8. Push rice to the sides. Add 1 beaten egg to the center. Scramble briefly then fold into the rice.
9. Add kecap manis and regular soy sauce. Toss to coat. The rice should turn a deep, glossy brown-black from the kecap manis.
10. Taste: it should be savory, slightly sweet, and aromatic with shrimp paste.
11. Season with salt. Transfer to plates.
12. Top with fried egg (separate pan).
13. Arrange cucumber and tomato alongside.
14. Scatter fried shallots. Add prawn crackers.
15. Serve immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~540 per serving

TIP

Kecap manis is what makes Indonesian nasi goreng completely different from every other fried rice. It is thick, dark, and sweet — almost like molasses — and creates the characteristic dark color and caramel sweetness. Do not substitute with Chinese dark soy sauce — the sweetness is the essential differentiator.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [National Dish]

RECIPE 341

■■ Indonesia

BUBUR AYAM

INDONESIAN CHICKEN RICE PORRIDGE

Indonesia's most beloved breakfast porridge — soft, silky rice cooked in chicken broth until very smooth, topped with shredded poached chicken, crispy fried shallots, celery, soy sauce, and a swirl of chilli sauce. Sold from push-carts (gerobak) in every Indonesian city from 5am, ladled from enormous pots by vendors who have been doing the same thing since before sunrise.

INGREDIENTS

PORRIDGE

- 1 cup jasmine rice, rinsed
- 1.5L (6 cups) chicken broth
- 2cm fresh ginger, sliced
- 1 stalk lemongrass, bruised
- 1 tsp salt

CHICKEN TOPPING

- 2 chicken breast halves, poached in the broth
- until tender (20 min), then shredded finely
- TOPPINGS (all critical — do not omit):
- 3 tbsp fried shallots (bawang goreng — buy pre-made
- at Asian stores or make fresh)
- 2 stalks Chinese celery or regular celery, sliced
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 2 tbsp crispy fried shallots
- Kecap manis (sweet soy sauce) — drizzle
- Sambal (Indonesian chilli sauce) — to serve
- Soy sauce — at the table
- Kerupuk (prawn crackers) — alongside
- Fried tofu cubes (optional)
- Sliced ginger (pickled, optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. POACH CHICKEN: Add chicken breasts to broth with ginger and lemongrass. Simmer 20 minutes. Remove chicken. Reserve broth.
2. Shred chicken finely with two forks. Season lightly.
3. PORRIDGE: Combine rinsed rice with strained broth (remove ginger and lemongrass). Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce to low heat. Simmer 40–50 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice completely dissolves into a smooth, silky porridge.
5. Add salt. Adjust consistency with broth or water. Indonesian bubur ayam is slightly thicker than Chinese congee — substantial but still pourable.
6. SERVE: Ladle hot porridge into deep bowls.
7. Arrange shredded chicken over the center.
8. Scatter fried shallots, celery, and green onion.
9. Add fried tofu if using.
10. Drizzle kecap manis and soy sauce lightly.
11. Add sambal on the side.
12. Place prawn crackers alongside.

Prep: 10 min • Cook: 60 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~355 per bowl

TIP

Indonesian fried shallots (bawang goreng) are the single most important topping — they provide crunch, sweetness, and a toasty depth that no other garnish can replicate. Buy a large bag pre-made from any Asian grocery store. They keep for months and improve almost every Indonesian and Malaysian dish they touch.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 342

Indonesia (Betawi / Jakarta)

NASI UDUK

COCONUT MILK RICE WITH ACCOMPANIMENTS

Jakarta's most beloved street breakfast — rice cooked entirely in coconut milk with lemongrass, pandan, and bay leaves until fragrant and silky. Served wrapped in banana leaf with fried chicken, tempe orek (sweet braised tempeh), sambal, and a boiled egg. The coconut-scented rice is the foundation — rich, aromatic, and deeply satisfying in the way only coconut-cooked rice can be.

INGREDIENTS

COCONUT RICE

- 2 cups jasmine rice, rinsed
- 400ml (1 can) coconut milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 2 stalks lemongrass, bruised
- 2 pandan leaves, knotted
- 2 bay leaves (daun salam)
- 1 tsp salt
- TEMPE OREK (sweet braised tempeh — make ahead):
- 200g (7 oz) tempeh, thinly sliced and deep-fried
- until golden and crispy
- 3 shallots, thinly sliced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp kecap manis
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 red chilli, sliced
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tbsp oil

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Ayam goreng (Indonesian fried chicken — marinate
- chicken pieces in garlic, coriander, ginger, salt; boil until cooked; deep-fry until golden)
- Hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Sambal (Indonesian chilli sauce)
- Fried shallots (bawang goreng)
- Kerupuk (prawn crackers)
- Sliced cucumber and tomato

INSTRUCTIONS

1. COCONUT RICE: Combine all coconut rice ingredients in a pot. Bring to a boil, stirring gently.
2. Reduce heat to very low. Cover tightly. Cook 15 min.
3. Remove lid. Remove lemongrass, pandan, bay leaves.
4. Fluff gently. The rice should be cooked through, slightly sticky, and fragrant with coconut.
5. TEMPE OREK: Heat oil in a pan. Add shallots and garlic. Cook 3 minutes. Add fried tempeh, kecap manis, soy sauce, sugar, and chilli. Toss to coat everything. Cook 2 minutes until glazed and sticky. Cool.
6. SERVE: Pile coconut rice on a plate or in a banana leaf wrapper.
7. Arrange fried chicken, tempe orek, and halved egg alongside.
8. Add sambal and cucumber.
9. Scatter fried shallots. Add prawn crackers.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~620 per serving

TIP

The tempeh must be deep-fried until golden and crispy BEFORE braising in kecap manis — this creates a crunchy texture that holds its shape when coated in the sweet sauce. Unfried tempeh in kecap manis becomes soggy. The two-step process (fry then braise) creates the characteristic crispy-chewy texture of authentic tempe orek.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [Jakarta Street Food]

Indonesia

RECIPE 343

■■ Indonesia

MARTABAK MANIS

INDONESIAN SWEET STUFFED PANCAKE

Indonesia's most beloved street sweet — a thick, fluffy yeasted pancake cooked in a special mold until one side is golden, then filled with butter, sugar, chocolate sprinkles, crushed peanuts, and condensed milk before being folded. The result is a warm, buttery, crunchy, sweet parcel that Indonesians eat for breakfast and as an evening snack with equal enthusiasm. Every Indonesian city has its legendary martabak manis maker.

INGREDIENTS

BATTER

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 egg
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 100ml (■ cup) warm milk
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- FILLINGS (choose combination):
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 tbsp granulated sugar
- 3 tbsp chocolate sprinkles OR
- 3 tbsp Nutella OR
- 3 tbsp peanut butter
- 3 tbsp crushed roasted peanuts
- 2 tbsp sweetened condensed milk
- Optional: grated cheddar cheese (very Indonesian —
- cheese on sweet things is beloved in Indonesia)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dissolve yeast in warm water with a pinch of sugar. Rest 10 minutes until foamy.
2. Combine flour, baking powder, baking soda, sugar, and salt. Add egg, warm milk, vanilla, and yeast mixture. Whisk until completely smooth.
3. Cover and rest 30 minutes until bubbly.
4. Heat a large, round, high-sided pan or wok over medium-low heat. Grease generously with butter.
5. Pour all the batter in — the martabak should be thick (2–3cm). Indonesian martabak is much thicker than regular pancakes.
6. Cover with a lid. Cook over medium-low heat 10–12 minutes until the surface is completely dry and full of holes, and the bottom is golden.
7. DO NOT FLIP. Martabak manis is only cooked on one side.
8. Working quickly while the pancake is still in the pan: spread butter generously over the entire surface.
9. Sprinkle sugar, chocolate sprinkles, and crushed peanuts.
10. Drizzle condensed milk over everything.
11. Add grated cheese if using.
12. Use a knife to cut the martabak in half, then fold one half onto the other (like closing a book).
13. Press gently. Remove from pan. Cut into sections.
14. Serve immediately — best eaten hot with filling melting.

Prep: 10 min + 30 min rest · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The batter must rest 30 minutes so the yeast activates and creates bubbles that rise to the surface during cooking. These bubbles become the characteristic honeycomb holes in the surface — essential for the filling to pool into. Under-rested batter creates a flat, dense pancake without the signature holes.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Indonesian] [Street Food] [Sweet] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 344

■■ Indonesia (East Java)

SOTO AYAM LAMONGAN

INDONESIAN CHICKEN TURMERIC SOUP

East Java's famous golden chicken soup — a fragrant turmeric- scented broth with shredded chicken, glass noodles, hard-boiled egg, fried shallots, and sambal. The broth is cooked with galangal, lemongrass, and kaffir lime leaves, giving it a complexity that makes it one of Indonesia's most celebrated regional soups. Eaten for breakfast in Lamongan and found at soto stalls throughout Indonesia from dawn.

INGREDIENTS

BROTH

- 1 whole chicken or 4 pieces
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- 2 stalks lemongrass, bruised
- 3 kaffir lime leaves
- 2 bay leaves (daun salam)
- 2cm galangal, sliced
- 1 tsp turmeric powder (or 2cm fresh turmeric)
- Salt to taste
- SPICE PASTE (bumbu):
- 6 shallots
- 4 garlic cloves
- 3 candlenuts (kemiri) or macadamias
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 2 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp ginger
- 2 tbsp oil (for frying the paste)

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Glass noodles (soun), soaked and blanched
- Rice or rice cakes (lontong)
- Hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Fried shallots (bawang goreng)
- Celery leaves, sliced
- Tomato, diced
- Sambal (chilli sauce)
- Kecap manis and lime wedges at the table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend all spice paste ingredients into a smooth paste.
2. Fry paste in oil over medium heat 5 minutes until very fragrant and oil separates.
3. Add chicken pieces. Coat in the fried paste.
4. Add water, lemongrass, kaffir lime, bay, and galangal.
5. Bring to a boil. Simmer 30–40 minutes until chicken is very tender.
6. Remove chicken. Shred when cool.
7. Strain broth. Return to pot. Season. The broth should be a beautiful golden-yellow from turmeric and richly flavored.
8. SERVE: Place blanched glass noodles in deep bowls.
9. Add shredded chicken.
10. Ladle hot, golden broth over everything.
11. Top with fried shallots, celery, tomato, and egg.
12. Add sambal and lime on the side.
13. Serve with rice or lontong alongside.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~395 per bowl

TIP

Frying the spice paste (bumbu) in oil until the oil separates — a technique called "tumis" — is the foundation of Indonesian cooking. The paste must be cooked long enough that the raw shallot and garlic smell is gone and the aroma becomes sweet, fragrant, and toasted. Under-fried bumbu creates a raw, sharp, unpleasant flavor in the final dish.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [East Java]

RECIPE 345

Indonesia

LONTONG SAYUR

RICE CAKE IN COCONUT VEGETABLE CURRY

A celebratory Indonesian breakfast traditionally eaten at Eid al-Fitr — dense, compressed rice cake (lontong) sliced and served in a rich coconut milk vegetable curry with long beans, chayote, and boiled egg. Eaten throughout Indonesia as a special occasion breakfast that has crossed into everyday dining. The contrast of firm rice cake and creamy coconut curry is deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- LONTONG (compressed rice cake):
- 2 cups jasmine rice, rinsed
- Water for cooking
- Banana leaves (or aluminum foil) for wrapping

COCONUT CURRY

- 300ml (1¼ cups) coconut milk
- 300ml (1¼ cups) water
- 100g (3.5 oz) long beans, cut into 3cm pieces
- 1 chayote (labu siam), peeled and cubed
- (or zucchini)
- 5 shallots, sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 lemongrass stalk, bruised
- 2 kaffir lime leaves
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp galangal powder
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp white pepper
- Salt to taste
- 2 tbsp oil

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Fried tempe or tofu
- Sambal
- Fried shallots
- Shredded chicken (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LONTONG: Fill banana leaf cylinders (or foil tubes) ■ full with rinsed rice. Seal both ends tightly. Boil in water for 60–90 minutes until rice is very compressed and dense. Cool. Slice into rounds. (Shortcut: use store-bought lontong or ketupat.)
2. CURRY: Fry shallots and garlic in oil 4 minutes.
3. Add lemongrass, kaffir lime, turmeric, galangal, coriander, and pepper. Fry 2 minutes.
4. Add vegetables. Toss to coat in spices.
5. Add coconut milk and water. Bring to a simmer.
6. Cook 15 minutes until vegetables are tender and curry has thickened slightly.
7. Season with salt.
8. SERVE: Slice lontong into rounds. Place in deep bowls.
9. Ladle hot coconut curry over the lontong.
10. Add boiled egg, fried tempe/tofu, and shredded chicken.
11. Scatter fried shallots. Add sambal on the side.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 90 min (lontong) · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~445 per serving

TIP

The lontong must be very firmly packed — the rice should compress under pressure during boiling, creating a dense, sliceable cake that holds its shape when cut. Loosely packed lontong falls apart in the curry. When wrapping, press rice down firmly and seal tightly before boiling.

[Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [Festive]

RECIPE 346

■■ Indonesia

PISANG GORENG

INDONESIAN FRIED BANANAS

Indonesia's most universal street snack and breakfast sweet — ripe bananas dipped in a batter of rice flour and coconut milk and deep-fried until golden and crispy outside while the banana inside caramelizes and softens to an almost custard-like sweetness. Sold by street vendors throughout Indonesia from breakfast to midnight. The secret: rice flour creates a uniquely light, crispy batter that no all-purpose flour version can replicate.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large ripe bananas (pisang kepok or pisang raja — Indonesian varieties, or regular cavendish bananas)
- slightly overripe for best results)
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

BATTER

- 100g (¾ cup) rice flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ¼ tsp vanilla extract
- 150ml (⅔ cup) coconut milk (not water — coconut milk creates a richer, slightly crispy result)
- ½ tsp baking powder

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk all batter ingredients until smooth. Rest 10 minutes — rice flour absorbs moisture slowly. The batter should coat the back of a spoon but still flow easily. Adjust with coconut milk if thick.
2. Peel bananas. For Indonesian-style: — Halve lengthwise and crosswise for smaller pieces, — Leave whole if using smaller finger bananas.
3. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a deep pan.
4. Dip banana pieces in batter — coat all sides, allowing excess to drip off.
5. Gently lower into hot oil.
6. Fry 3–4 minutes until the batter is golden and crispy and the banana inside is soft and caramelized.
7. Drain on paper towels.
8. Eat immediately while hot — the banana continues to soften inside as it cools, and the batter softens within 10 minutes.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~225 per serving

TIP

The banana must be fully ripe — the yellow stage is acceptable but the slightly overripe, soft stage is ideal. The natural sugars in a ripe banana caramelize during frying, creating a golden interior that a firm, underripe banana cannot achieve. Under-ripe pisang goreng tastes starchy and disappointing.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Indonesian] [Street Food] [Sweet]

RECIPE 347

■ ■ Malaysia

NASI LEMAK

COCONUT MILK RICE WITH SAMBAL

Malaysia's national breakfast and soul food — fragrant coconut milk rice with pandan and lemongrass, served with sambal ikan bilis (anchovy chilli sauce), half a hard-boiled egg, roasted peanuts, fried ikan bilis (crispy anchovies), and sliced cucumber. Wrapped in banana leaf at street stalls and served warm. Every element of nasi lemak has a purpose — the combination is one of Southeast Asia's most perfectly balanced breakfast compositions.

INGREDIENTS

COCONUT RICE

- 2 cups jasmine rice, washed
- 300ml (1¼ cups) coconut milk (full fat)
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 2 pandan leaves, knotted
- 1 stalk lemongrass, bruised
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 slices fresh ginger

SAMBAL IKAN BILIS

- 50g (2 oz) dried ikan bilis (dried anchovies), rinsed and deep-fried until crispy — set aside some
- for topping
- 8 dried red chillies, soaked in hot water
- 4 shallots
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 tbsp shrimp paste (belacan) — toasted in foil
- 2 tbsp tamarind paste
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 3 tbsp oil
- ACCOMPANIMENTS (all essential):
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- 50g (2 oz) roasted peanuts
- ½ cucumber, sliced into rounds
- Crispy fried ikan bilis (from above)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **SAMBAL:** Blend soaked chillies, shallots, garlic, and shrimp paste into a smooth paste.
2. Fry paste in oil over medium heat 5–8 minutes until oil separates and the paste turns dark and deeply fragrant — this "tumis" step is essential.
3. Add tamarind paste, sugar, and salt. Stir.
4. Add crispy fried ikan bilis. Toss to coat.
5. Cook 2–3 minutes. The sambal should be thick, deeply red, sweet, sour, and savory. Cool. Store — improves overnight.
6. **COCONUT RICE:** Combine all ingredients in a rice cooker or pot. Bring to a boil.
7. Reduce to lowest heat. Cover tightly. Cook 15 minutes.
8. Rest covered 10 minutes. Remove pandan and lemongrass.
9. Fluff gently. The rice should be slightly sticky, fragrant with coconut and pandan.
10. **SERVE:** Mound coconut rice on banana leaf or plate.
11. Arrange sambal alongside the rice — generous.
12. Add boiled egg, cucumber, roasted peanuts, and crispy ikan bilis around the rice.
13. Wrap in banana leaf for the authentic experience.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 30 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~540 per serving

TIP

The sambal must be cooked until the oil separates visibly — this indicates the raw ingredients have fully transformed and the paste is cooked through. Under-cooked sambal tastes raw and sharp. Properly cooked sambal is dark, glossy, sweet, and complex. The color should deepen from bright red to dark brownish-red.

[Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [National Dish] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 348

■ ■ Malaysia

ROTI CANAI WITH DHAL

Malaysia's beloved mamak (Indian Muslim) breakfast — paper-thin, flaky flatbread made from a highly laminated dough, stretched and flipped dramatically on a hot griddle until shatteringly crispy, eaten with a rich yellow lentil dhal and fish curry. The roti canai maker (roti man) at any Malaysian mamak stall is a performer — the dough is spun in the air, slapped against the griddle, and folded in seconds. One of Southeast Asia's greatest breakfasts.

INGREDIENTS

ROTI CANAI DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 large egg
- 250ml (1 cup) warm water
- 4 tbsp ghee or butter (worked into the dough)
- Extra ghee for laminating and cooking (generous)
- DHAL (yellow lentil curry):
- 1 cup yellow split lentils (chana dal or toor dal)
- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 tomatoes, diced
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp garam masala
- 1 dried red chilli
- 2 tbsp ghee or oil
- Salt and fresh coriander
- 400ml (1½ cups) water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DHAL: Cook lentils with turmeric in 400ml water until very soft and creamy. Mash partially. Fry onion in ghee until golden. Add ginger, garlic, cumin seeds, coriander, and garam masala. Fry 3 min. Add tomatoes. Cook until broken down. Add mashed dal. Simmer 10 minutes. Season. Garnish with coriander.
2. ROTI DOUGH: Combine flour, salt, and sugar. Add egg and warm water. Knead 8 minutes. Work ghee into the dough. Knead 5 more minutes.
3. Divide into 8 balls. Coat each with ghee. Cover and rest minimum 2 hours — overnight is better. The long rest is what creates the extensibility needed for thin stretching.
4. SHAPING: Oil a smooth surface generously with ghee. Take a rested ball. Using oiled fingertips, press and stretch the dough outward from the center in all directions until paper-thin and almost translucent.
5. Fold the thin edges into the center, then fold again to create a layered square or rectangle.
6. OR: Stretch into a thin rope. Coil into a snail shape. Press flat. This creates spiral layers.
7. Heat a flat griddle or pan with generous ghee over medium-high heat.
8. Cook the folded roti 2–3 minutes per side, pressing with a spatula, until golden and crispy with some char marks.
9. IMMEDIATELY after removing: clap the roti between your palms to separate and fluff the layers.
10. Serve with dhal and fish curry for dipping.

Prep: 20 min + 2 hrs resting · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The palm-clapping after removing from the griddle is the mamak technique that creates the fluffy, separated interior layers of roti canai. Clap firmly 4–5 times. The steam inside the layers is released and the layers separate into a light, airy structure. Without this step, the roti is flatter and denser — good but not iconic.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Malaysian] [Mamak Culture] [Street Food]

RECIPE 349

■ ■ Malaysia

KOPITIAM BREAKFAST

MALAYSIAN COFFEE SHOP SPREAD

The classic Malaysian kopitiam (coffee shop) breakfast — strong coffee or tea with evaporated milk, two soft-boiled eggs in a cup seasoned with dark soy sauce and white pepper, and thick toast spread with kaya (coconut jam) and salted butter. Every element is essential. The soft-boiled eggs are dunked into the remaining soy sauce and eaten in one or two sips. This combination has been served unchanged at Malaysian kopitiam since the early 20th century.

INGREDIENTS

- KOPI (Malaysian Coffee):
- 2 tbsp kopi powder (Malaysian robusta coffee, darker
- roasted and blended with butter/sugar during roasting)
- 200ml (¾ cup) boiling water
- 3 tbsp evaporated milk (not fresh milk)
- 1 tbsp sweetened condensed milk (adjust sweetness)
- OR: specify "kopi-O" (black) / "kopi-C" (evaporated only)
- SOFT-BOILED EGGS (half-cooked, setengah masak):
- 2 large eggs, room temperature

KAYA TOAST

- 4 slices thick white bread or milk bread (toast golden)
- 3 tbsp kaya (coconut jam — buy at Asian stores
- or make: blend 4 eggs, 200ml coconut milk, 100g sugar,
- 4 pandan leaves, pinch salt; cook slowly stirring
- until thick custard)
- 2 tbsp cold salted butter

EGG SEASONING

- 1 tsp thick dark soy sauce (kicap pekat)
- Pinch of white pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KOPI: Brew strong Malaysian kopi through a cloth filter or very fine mesh. The brew should be extremely dark and strong. Add condensed and evaporated milk. Stir. Serve hot in a ceramic cup on a saucer.
2. HALF-COOKED EGGS: Bring a small pot of water to a boil. Turn off heat. Add eggs. Cover. REST exactly 8–10 minutes (they cook in the residual heat). Remove. Crack both eggs into a small deep cup.
3. The whites should be barely set — translucent, jiggy, and silky. The yolk should be completely liquid. This "half-cooked" texture is the entire point.
4. Add dark soy sauce and white pepper into the cup.
5. Drink/eat the eggs directly from the cup.
6. KAYA TOAST: Toast bread until golden. While hot, spread a thin layer of cold butter — it melts slightly.
7. Spread kaya generously over the butter.
8. Cut toast diagonally. Dip into the soft egg cups or eat separately.

Prep: 5 min • Cook: 10 min • Serves: 2 • Cal: ~420 per set

TIP

The egg timing for kopitiam soft-boiled eggs is precise — too long and the white fully sets (wrong), too short and even the white is completely raw (also wrong). 8–10 minutes in residual boiling water produces the specifically Malaysian "half-cooked" texture — silky, barely-set whites with liquid yolk. Use room temperature eggs and adjust by 1 minute for refrigerator-cold eggs.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Malaysian] [Kopitiam Culture] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 350

■ ■ Malaysia (Penang)

CHAR KWAY TEOW

STIR-FRIED FLAT RICE NOODLES

Penang's most iconic dish — wide flat rice noodles stir-fried with shrimp, cockles, bean sprouts, Chinese chives, egg, and lap cheong in dark soy sauce and chilli paste, at extremely high heat over charcoal. The wok hei (breath of the wok) creates a smoky, caramelized depth impossible to achieve on a home stove — but achievable enough to be extraordinary. A breakfast dish by origin, now eaten at all hours at Penang hawker stalls.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) fresh kway teow (wide flat rice noodles)
- — separate noodles gently before cooking
- 200g (7 oz) large prawns/shrimp, peeled
- 100g (3.5 oz) cockles or clams, shelled
- (if unavailable, use extra shrimp)
- 2 lap cheong (Chinese pork sausages), thinly sliced
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup bean sprouts (tauge)
- 1 cup Chinese chives (kucai), cut into 5cm pieces
- (or regular chives)
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp dark soy sauce (kicap hitam — thick and sweet)
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1–2 tbsp sambal belacan (shrimp paste chilli paste)
- or chilli paste — adjust to heat preference
- 3 tbsp lard (traditional) or neutral oil
- (lard creates the authentic Penang flavor)
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Prepare everything before starting — char kway teow cooks in under 3 minutes and requires full attention.
2. Heat wok over the highest heat possible until nearly smoking. Add lard or oil.
3. Stir-fry lap cheong 30 seconds until slightly caramelized.
4. Add garlic. Fry 15 seconds.
5. Add shrimp. Stir-fry 1 minute until nearly cooked.
6. Push ingredients to the side. Add eggs. Scramble briefly. Mix into the other ingredients.
7. Add noodles. Toss and press against the hot wok.
8. Add dark soy sauce, light soy sauce, oyster sauce, and sambal/chilli paste. Toss aggressively to coat.
9. Add cockles. Toss briefly — they only need 30 seconds.
10. Add bean sprouts and Chinese chives. Toss twice.
11. The dish should have some char and caramelization — the dark soy sauce burns slightly on the hot wok.
12. Remove immediately. Serve on a plate. Add extra sambal on the side.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 4 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~540 per serving

TIP

The highest possible heat is non-negotiable. Char kway teow's defining flavor comes from the dark soy sauce caramelizing and slightly burning against the screaming-hot wok surface — creating the smoky, complex "wok hei." On a home stove, achieve this by cooking in smaller portions (one serving at a time) to maintain temperature, and by preheating the wok 3–4 minutes before adding any ingredient.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [Penang Icon]

RECIPE 351

■ ■ Malaysia

LAKSA LEMAK

MALAYSIAN COCONUT CURRY NOODLE SOUP

Malaysia's most celebrated noodle soup — rice noodles in a rich, coconut milk-based curry broth scented with lemongrass, galangal, and shrimp paste, topped with shrimp, tofu puffs, and cockles. Laksa lemak (coconut laksa) is the Kuala Lumpur version — creamy, rich, and complex in a way that few soups in the world can match. Eaten for breakfast and lunch at hawker stalls throughout peninsular Malaysia. The broth alone takes an hour to build.

INGREDIENTS

LAKSA PASTE

- 6 dried red chillies, soaked
- 4 shallots
- 3 garlic cloves
- 2cm galangal
- 2cm turmeric (fresh) or 1 tsp powder
- 2 stalks lemongrass, white part only
- 1 tbsp shrimp paste (belacan) — toasted
- 3 candlenuts or macadamias
- 1 tsp coriander seeds

LAKSA BROTH

- 500ml (2 cups) coconut milk (full fat)
- 500ml (2 cups) water
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- Salt to taste
- 3 tbsp oil (for frying paste)

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) thick rice vermicelli or laksa noodles, soaked and blanched
- 200g (7 oz) large shrimp/prawns, cooked
- 100g (3.5 oz) tofu puffs (tau pok), halved
- Bean sprouts, blanched briefly
- Cockles or fish cake, sliced
- Hard-boiled egg, halved
- Fresh laksa leaves (Vietnamese mint)
- Sambal belacan and lime wedges (essential)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LAKSA PASTE: Blend all paste ingredients until smooth, adding minimal water.
2. Fry paste in oil over medium heat 8–10 minutes until very fragrant and oil separates completely. The paste should be dark red and deeply aromatic.
3. Add coconut milk and water. Bring to a gentle simmer. Never boil hard — coconut milk can split.
4. Add tofu puffs — simmer 5 minutes so they absorb broth.
5. Season with fish sauce, sugar, and salt. The broth should be rich, creamy, spicy, and fragrant.
6. ASSEMBLE: Divide blanched noodles into deep bowls.
7. Add shrimp, cockles, and fish cake.
8. Ladle hot laksa broth generously over.
9. Add bean sprouts and halved egg.
10. Top with fresh laksa leaves and a spoonful of sambal.
11. Serve with lime wedge to squeeze over.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per bowl

TIP

Frying the laksa paste until the oil fully separates is the technique that creates the depth of Malaysian laksa. This typically takes 8–10 minutes of constant stirring over medium heat — much longer than feels comfortable. The color should deepen from bright red to a dark, almost brown-red. The aroma should be toasted and deeply fragrant, not raw and sharp.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [Hawker Food]

Malaysia

RECIPE 352

■ ■ Malaysia

CONGEE WITH CENTURY EGG

A Malaysian kopitiam classic from the Chinese-Malaysian community — creamy rice congee topped with the unique combination of century egg (pidan) and salted egg, creating an extraordinary interplay of textures and umami. The century egg's dark, translucent jelly white and creamy yolk alongside the salty, granular salted egg yolk and the neutral congee base creates one of Asia's most complex and satisfying breakfast combinations.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup jasmine rice
- 1.5L (6 cups) chicken or pork broth
- 1 tsp salt
- 2cm fresh ginger, julienned

TOPPINGS

- 2 century eggs (pidan), peeled and quartered
- 2 salted duck eggs, halved
- (hard boil 10 min, crack and peel carefully — the yolk is bright orange and intensely salty)
- 3 tbsp fried shallots
- 2 green onions, thinly sliced
- Sliced fresh ginger (very thin)
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- White pepper
- Light soy sauce
- 2–3 strips you tiao (Chinese dough sticks), sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse rice. Combine with cold broth and ginger in a pot. Bring to a boil.
2. Reduce heat to very low. Simmer 50–60 minutes, stirring every 10–15 minutes, until rice completely dissolves and congee is silky and smooth.
3. Season with salt.
4. SALTED EGGS: Hard-boil salted duck eggs 10 minutes. Cool in cold water. Peel carefully. Halve. The white is extremely salty — the yolk is rich and intensely flavored.
5. SERVE: Ladle hot congee into deep bowls.
6. Arrange century egg quarters and salted egg halves on top — create a visual contrast.
7. Add you tiao slices alongside.
8. Scatter fried shallots and julienned ginger.
9. Drizzle sesame oil.
10. Add white pepper, green onion, and soy sauce to taste.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 60 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per bowl

TIP

The combination of century egg (pungent, rich, complex) and salted egg (intensely briny, vivid orange) against neutral congee is the achievement of this dish. Neither egg alone creates the same effect — it is the contrast between them, and their contrast with the plain congee, that makes this a unique breakfast experience.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian Chinese] [Kopitiam]

RECIPE 353

■ ■ Malaysia

MEE REBUS

MALAY YELLOW NOODLES IN SPICED GRAVY

A Malaysian Malay breakfast specialty — yellow egg noodles in a thick, sweet-spiced gravy made from sweet potato, beef broth, and dried shrimp, topped with boiled egg, fried tofu, bean sprouts, and green chilli. The gravy is uniquely thick and slightly sweet from the sweet potato — completely unlike any other noodle sauce in Southeast Asia. Found at Malay breakfast stalls throughout peninsular Malaysia and Singapore.

INGREDIENTS

MEE REBUS GRAVY

- 200g (7 oz) sweet potato, boiled and mashed
- 500ml (2 cups) beef or chicken broth
- 3 tbsp dried shrimp (udang kering), soaked and blended
- 1 onion, blended
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- 1 tsp cumin powder
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 2 tbsp curry powder (Malaysian meat curry powder)
- 2 tbsp kecap manis
- 1 tbsp fish sauce
- 2 tbsp oil
- Salt and sugar to taste

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) fresh yellow egg noodles (mee kuning),
- blanched in boiling water 1 minute
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- 2 squares firm tofu, deep-fried until golden
- 1 cup bean sprouts, blanched
- 2 green chillies, sliced
- 2 tbsp fried shallots
- Lime wedge
- Fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Fry blended onion and garlic in oil 5 minutes.
2. Add blended dried shrimp. Fry 3 minutes.
3. Add all spice powders. Fry 2 minutes.
4. Add broth. Bring to a boil.
5. Add mashed sweet potato. Stir well. The sweet potato thickens the gravy naturally.
6. Simmer 10 minutes. Stir constantly — the thick gravy catches easily.
7. Add kecap manis and fish sauce. Season with salt and sugar. The gravy should be thick, sweet, savory, and spiced — almost a thick sauce, not soup.
8. SERVE: Place blanched noodles in bowls.
9. Pour thick gravy generously over the noodles.
10. Add fried tofu, boiled egg, and bean sprouts.
11. Scatter fried shallots and green chilli slices.
12. Add fresh coriander. Squeeze lime.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The sweet potato is the unique ingredient that differentiates mee rebus from all other noodle gravies. It must be very well cooked (soft and mashable) before adding to the broth. Undercooked sweet potato creates a grainy, starchy texture. Properly cooked sweet potato dissolves into a silky thickener.

[High Protein] [Classic Malaysian] [Malay Heritage] [Street Food]

RECIPE 354

■ ■ Malaysia

APAM BALIK

MALAYSIAN PEANUT PANCAKE TURNOVER

Malaysia's most nostalgic street sweet — a thick, crispy-edged yeasted pancake cooked in a round mold with creamed corn and crushed peanuts with sugar, then folded in half when the surface is still slightly soft. The result is simultaneously crunchy at the edges and soft in the center, with sweet corn and peanut creating the quintessentially Malaysian flavor combination. Found at every night market and morning pasar (market) throughout Malaysia.

INGREDIENTS

BATTER

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) warm milk
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp butter, melted

FILLING PER PANCAKE

- 1 tbsp unsalted butter (spread over cooked surface)
- 1 tbsp sugar (sprinkled)
- 2 tbsp creamed corn (from a can — essential)
- 2 tbsp roasted peanuts, roughly crushed
- Optional: grated cheddar cheese (the Malaysian way)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dissolve yeast in warm water with sugar. Rest 10 min.
2. Combine flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt.
3. Add yeast mixture, egg, warm milk, vanilla, and butter. Whisk until smooth. Cover and rest 30–45 minutes until bubbles form.
4. Heat a round, flat-bottomed pan (20cm) or a traditional apam balik griddle over medium-low heat. Grease with butter.
5. Pour batter to fill the pan — apam balik is thicker than a regular pancake, about 1.5cm.
6. Cover with a lid. Cook over medium-low heat 8–10 minutes until the surface is completely covered in holes and looks dry at the edges.
7. DO NOT FLIP. Work on the still-wet surface: — Spread butter over the entire surface — Sprinkle sugar evenly — Spread creamed corn — Scatter crushed peanuts generously — Add grated cheese if using
8. Fold the pancake in half (like a turnover) using a spatula, pressing gently to seal.
9. Cook 1 more minute. Remove.
10. Cut into pieces. Serve warm immediately.

Prep: 10 min + 45 min rest · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~395 per serving

TIP

Creamed corn is the non-negotiable Malaysian ingredient in apam balik — not fresh corn, not corn kernels, but tinned creamed corn. Its sweetness and creaminess penetrate the soft inner surface of the pancake during the final covered cooking, creating a uniquely moist, sweet-savory layer. This is not a substitutable ingredient.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Malaysian] [Street Food] [Sweet] [Night Market]

RECIPE 355

■ ■ Malaysia

BIHUN GORENG

MALAYSIAN STIR-FRIED RICE VERMICELLI

Malaysia's everyday breakfast noodle dish — thin rice vermicelli stir-fried with egg, vegetables, shrimp, and a combination of soy sauce and sambal, topped with fried shallots and lime. Faster than mee goreng, lighter than laksa, bihun goreng is the practical Malaysian breakfast that appears at every warung (small stall), school canteen, and home kitchen throughout the country from Monday to Sunday.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (10 oz) dried rice vermicelli (bihun), soaked in cold water 15 minutes, drained
- 200g (7 oz) shrimp, peeled
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 1 cup bean sprouts
- 2 stalks Chinese chives or green onion, cut into 5cm pieces
- ½ carrot, julienned
- 3 shallots, thinly sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp sambal oelek or chilli paste
- 2 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tbsp dark soy sauce
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- Salt to taste
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- Fried shallots and lime to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat wok over high heat until smoking. Add oil.
2. Add shallots and garlic. Stir-fry 1 minute.
3. Add shrimp. Cook until just pink. Push to side.
4. Add beaten egg. Scramble in the center. Mix.
5. Add carrot. Toss briefly.
6. Add drained vermicelli. It will absorb the flavors.
7. Add sambal, light soy, and dark soy. Toss.
8. Add bean sprouts and chives. Toss twice — they should remain slightly crunchy.
9. Add sesame oil. Season with salt.
10. Transfer to plates. Top with fried shallots.
11. Serve with lime wedge to squeeze over.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~440 per serving

TIP

Soaking the vermicelli in cold water (not hot) for exactly 15 minutes creates the right al dente texture — it softens without going mushy, allowing it to finish cooking in the wok. Hot-water soaking overcooks the vermicelli before it even reaches the wok, creating a soft, clumping noodle that breaks during stir-frying.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [Quick] [Everyday]

RECIPE 356

■ ■ Malaysia

KUIH SERI MUKA

PANDAN CUSTARD OVER STICKY RICE

A Malay-Peranakan kuih (cake) that is one of Malaysia's most beautiful breakfast sweets — a two-layer creation of sticky glutinous rice on the bottom and a vibrant emerald pandan custard on top. The contrast of the white, slightly salty rice layer and the fragrant, smooth, sweet pandan custard layer is definitive of the Peranakan pastry tradition. Cut into diamonds and served cold — a breakfast that doubles as edible art.

INGREDIENTS

- GLUTINOUS RICE LAYER (bottom):
- 2 cups glutinous rice, soaked overnight and drained
- 200ml (¾ cup) coconut milk
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 pandan leaf, knotted
- PANDAN CUSTARD LAYER (top):
- 4 large eggs
- 300ml (1¼ cups) coconut milk
- 100ml (■ cup) pandan juice:
- (blend 6–8 pandan leaves with 100ml water, strain.
- Or: ½ tsp pandan extract with green food coloring)
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 40g (■ cup) all-purpose flour
- 20g (2 tbsp) tapioca starch
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. RICE LAYER: Steam soaked rice with coconut milk, salt, and pandan leaf 20–25 minutes until cooked and sticky. The rice absorbs the coconut milk and pandan flavor.
2. Press cooked rice firmly into a greased 20x20cm (8x8-inch) square baking tin — compress it into a flat, 2cm-thick layer. Press FIRMLY.
3. PANDAN CUSTARD: Blend eggs, coconut milk, pandan juice, sugar, flour, tapioca, and salt until smooth.
4. Strain through a fine sieve into a saucepan.
5. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring constantly, until the mixture thickens to a pourable custard — about 8–10 minutes. It should coat a spoon thickly but still pour slowly.
6. Pour hot custard directly over the compressed rice. The custard layer should be about 1.5cm thick.
7. Cover the tin. Steam over medium heat 20 minutes until the custard is set but still has a very slight wobble.
8. Cool completely. Refrigerate minimum 2 hours.
9. Unmold. Cut into diamonds using a wet knife.
10. Serve cold or at room temperature.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 45 min + 2 hrs chilling · Serves: 16 pieces · Cal: ~165 per piece

TIP

The rice must be pressed very firmly into the tin — loose rice will crumble when the kuih is cut into diamonds. Press with a flat-bottomed glass or the back of a wet spoon. The resulting rice layer should be dense and sliceable, not crumbly. Fresh pandan juice creates a deeper fragrance and a brighter natural green than extract — worth the extra effort.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [Peranakan] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 357

■ ■ Malaysia

TOSAI / THOSAI

SOUTH INDIAN CRÊPE IN MALAYSIA

Malaysia's Indian community has brought the dosa (called to sai in Malaysian Tamil) to every mamak stall and Indian restaurant in the country. The Malaysian version is slightly thinner and crispier than the South Indian original, and the chutney is often adapted to local tastes with coconut and fresh curry leaves. Eaten for breakfast by millions of Malaysians of all ethnicities — the dosa has become as Malaysian as nasi lemak.

INGREDIENTS

- Fermented dosa batter — exactly as Recipe 263
- (rice + urad dal + fenugreek, fermented overnight)

MALAYSIAN COCONUT CHUTNEY

- 1 cup fresh grated coconut
- 3 green chillies
- 1 tsp fresh ginger
- 1 garlic clove
- 1 tbsp fried chana dal (roasted chickpeas — Malaysian addition for texture and nuttiness)
- Salt and lime juice to taste
- Water to blend
- TEMPERING: curry leaves + mustard seeds + dried red
- chilli + oil — poured over finished chutney
- SAMBAR (Malaysian style):
- As Recipe 265 — slightly more tamarind for
- the Malaysian preference toward sourness

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Ferment dosa batter as per Recipe 263 — overnight at room temperature.
2. MALAYSIAN COCONUT CHUTNEY: Blend coconut, chillies, ginger, garlic, fried chana dal, salt, lime, and water until smooth. Adjust consistency. Make tempering: heat oil, pop mustard seeds, add curry leaves and dried chilli — pour over chutney.
3. COOKING TOSAI: Heat a flat tawa over medium-high heat.
4. Sprinkle water to check temperature — drops should sizzle and evaporate immediately.
5. Reduce to medium. Oil lightly.
6. Pour batter and spread in very thin, concentric circles to a 25–30cm circle.
7. At Malaysian mamak stalls, tosai is thinner and crispier than Indian dosa — spread as thin as possible.
8. Drizzle oil around the edges and over the surface.
9. Cook 2–3 minutes until edges lift and bottom is golden and crispy.
10. Serve without flipping (paper tosai — crispy style) OR flip briefly for regular tosai.
11. Serve with Malaysian coconut chutney and sambar.

Prep: 15 min + overnight fermentation · Cook: 4 min per tosai · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~220 per tosai

TIP

The Malaysian mamak tosai is made on a well-seasoned iron tawa that has been used for years — the seasoning creates a naturally non-stick surface. At home, use a well-seasoned cast-iron pan or high-quality non-stick. Never use cold water to "clean" between tosai — simply wipe with an oiled cloth.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian Indian] [Mamak Culture]

RECIPE 358

■ ■ Malaysia

TAU FU FA

SILKEN TOFU PUDDING WITH GINGER SYRUP

Malaysia's beloved morning tofu dessert — silken-smooth soybean curd set with gypsum (food-grade calcium sulfate) into a trembling, white pudding, served in a bowl with warm ginger syrup or pandan sugar syrup. Sold from push-carts by vendors who carry enormous pots of freshly made tau fu fa through morning neighborhoods calling "tau fu fa!" The combination of clean, mild soy curd and fragrant warm syrup is one of breakfast's most delicate pleasures.

INGREDIENTS

- TAU FU FA (soy curd):
- 1L (4 cups) fresh soy milk (homemade — see Recipe 322,
- or high-quality store-bought without additives)
- 1 tbsp food-grade gypsum (calcium sulfate) dissolved
- in 3 tbsp cold water — COAGULANT
- (available at Chinese grocery stores)
- OR: ½ tbsp nigari (magnesium chloride) in 3 tbsp water

GINGER SYRUP

- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 100g (½ cup) rock sugar or regular sugar
- 3cm fresh ginger, peeled and bruised
- 1–2 pandan leaves (optional)

ALTERNATIVE PANDAN SYRUP

- Same as above but with pandan leaves and omit ginger

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GINGER SYRUP: Combine water, sugar, ginger (and pandan). Simmer 10 minutes until sugar dissolves and syrup is fragrant. Strain. Keep warm.
2. TAU FU FA: Heat soy milk in a pot to 85–90°C (185–195°F) — the specific temperature is important. Too hot or too cold and the curd won't set properly.
3. COAGULATION: Place the dissolved gypsum in a large, heatproof vessel (big enough for all the soy milk).
4. Prepare a second vessel (also large enough).
5. From height (30–40cm), pour the hot soy milk into the vessel containing the gypsum water. The distance causes mixing without stirring.
6. Do NOT stir, touch, or move after pouring.
7. Cover immediately. Rest undisturbed 15–20 minutes.
8. The soy milk will coagulate into a silky, trembling curd.
9. SERVE: Using a large, flat spoon, gently scoop tau fu fa into bowls with sweeping, shallow motions. The curd should fold in gentle sheets.
10. Pour warm ginger syrup over the curd.
11. Serve immediately while the curd is still warm.

Prep: 10 min + 20 min setting · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~155 per bowl

TIP

The "pour from height" technique mixes the gypsum coagulant with the hot soy milk through the mechanical action of falling — no stirring required and no stirring permitted afterward. Any agitation after the initial pour breaks up the delicate curd network as it forms, creating a grainy, broken curd instead of the smooth, trembling pudding.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Malaysian Chinese]

RECIPE 359

■ ■ Malaysia / ■ ■ Singapore

KAYA TOAST WITH BUTTER

While Recipe 349 covered the kopitiam breakfast set, this recipe focuses on homemade kaya (coconut pandan jam) — the ingredient that transforms the simple toast into something extraordinary. Kaya is a slowly stirred coconut-egg custard jam with pandan, and making it at home creates a depth of flavor and fragrance that no commercial version can replicate.

INGREDIENTS

HOMEMADE KAYA

- 4 large eggs
- 200ml (¾ cup) coconut cream (full fat)
- 150g (¾ cup) sugar
- 4–6 pandan leaves, blended with 50ml water and strained
- — to extract 3 tbsp bright green pandan juice
- Pinch of salt

FOR SERVING

- 4 slices thick white toast, toasted golden
- 4 tbsp cold salted butter
- Homemade kaya
- Soft-boiled eggs (as Recipe 349 method)
- Dark soy sauce and white pepper for eggs
- Malaysian kopi or kopi-C (coffee with milk)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KAYA: Combine eggs, coconut cream, sugar, pandan juice, and salt in a heatproof bowl.
2. Whisk until smooth.
3. Place bowl over a bain-marie (pot of simmering water). The bowl must NOT touch the water.
4. Stir continuously with a silicone spatula using figure-eight motions — NEVER stop stirring.
5. The mixture will thicken gradually over 25–35 minutes. This cannot be rushed. Medium heat. Constant stirring.
6. When kaya coats the back of a spoon thickly and a trail drawn with your finger remains for 3 seconds — it is done. The texture should be between jam and custard.
7. The color should be a rich egg-yolk yellow with a green tinge from the pandan — not brown.
8. Remove from heat immediately. Cool. Refrigerate in a glass jar — keeps 2 weeks.
9. TOAST AND SERVE: Toast bread. Spread cold butter. Spread kaya generously.
10. Prepare soft-boiled eggs in cups as Recipe 349.
11. Season eggs with dark soy and white pepper.
12. Serve the full set: kaya toast + eggs + kopi.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 8 (kaya) · Cal: ~380 per serving (full set)

TIP

Kaya is made over a bain-marie — not direct heat. Direct heat cooks the eggs too fast, creating scrambled eggs in coconut milk (wrong). The bain-marie's gentle, even heat cooks the eggs slowly into a smooth custard over 25–35 minutes. When it feels like it will never thicken — it will. The moment it starts, it happens quickly. Watch it closely in the final 5 minutes.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Malaysian] [Kopitiam] [Make-Ahead] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 360

■■ Malaysia

CENDOL

MALAYSIAN GREEN RICE FLOUR JELLY DRINK

Malaysia's most refreshing morning sweet drink — green worm-shaped rice flour jelly made with pandan, served over shaved ice with Gula Melaka (palm sugar syrup) and thick coconut milk. On a humid Malaysian morning, cendol is simultaneously breakfast, hydration, and dessert. The green jellies are squeezed through a mold into cold water — their squiggling shape gives cendol its whimsical character and the children who eat it their joy.

INGREDIENTS

CENDOL JELLY

- 100g (¾ cup) green pea flour or rice flour
- 400ml (1½ cups) water
- 3 tbsp pandan juice (blend pandan leaves with water,
- strain for bright green color — or ½ tsp pandan extract)
- 1 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- Large bowl of cold water with ice (for setting)

GULA MELAKA SYRUP

- 150g (¾ cup) Gula Melaka (Malaysian palm sugar),
- roughly chopped
- 100ml (⅓ cup) water
- 1 pandan leaf
- Simmer until dissolved and slightly thickened. Strain.

FOR SERVING

- Finely shaved ice or crushed ice
- 200ml (¾ cup) thick coconut cream, lightly salted
- Red bean (optional)
- Corn kernels (optional — a popular Malaysian addition)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CENDOL JELLY: Whisk rice flour/green pea flour, water, pandan juice, sugar, and salt until smooth.
2. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until the mixture becomes very thick, smooth, and pulls away from the sides of the pot — 8–10 minutes.
3. The mixture should be glossy and hold its shape.
4. While still hot, press the mixture through a cendol mold (available at Asian stores — a flat disk with holes) directly into a bowl of cold, iced water. OR: use a sieve with large holes, pressing the hot mixture through with the back of a spoon.
5. The cendol jellies will set immediately in the cold water into their characteristic worm shapes.
6. SERVE: Fill glasses or bowls with shaved ice.
7. Drain cendol jellies. Scatter generously over ice.
8. Pour Gula Melaka syrup over the ice and cendol.
9. Pour cold salted coconut cream over everything.
10. Add red beans or corn if using.
11. Mix slightly at the table. Eat immediately.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

Gula Melaka (palm sugar) has a deep, complex caramel-coconut flavor that is irreplaceable in cendol. Light brown sugar creates a flat, one-dimensional syrup. Gula Melaka creates a syrup with toffee, vanilla, and caramel notes that makes cendol completely distinct from any other shaved ice dessert. Find it at Asian stores.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Malaysian] [Sweet] [Street Food]

RECIPE 361

■ ■ Malaysia

PAN MEE

MALAYSIAN HAND-PULLED NOODLE SOUP

A Hakka Chinese-Malaysian breakfast specialty — flat, hand-torn wheat noodles in an anchovy broth topped with pork mince, dried anchovies, mushrooms, and poached egg. The noodles can be hand- torn into irregular pieces (ban mian) or cut into flat strips (pan mee) — both are served in the clear, umami-rich broth that gets its depth from slow-simmered dried anchovies and sweet vegetables. Found at Chinese breakfast shops throughout KL and the Klang Valley.

INGREDIENTS

NOODLE DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 large egg
- 1 tbsp oil
- 80–100ml (⅓ cup) water
- ½ tsp salt

ANCHOVY BROTH

- 60g (2 oz) dried anchovies (ikan bilis), rinsed
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 1 corn cob, cut into rounds (for sweetness)
- 100g (3.5 oz) ikan bilis for frying (separate batch)
- 2 tbsp oil for frying

SOUP TOPPINGS

- 200g (7 oz) pork mince, seasoned with soy and pepper
- 5 dried black mushrooms, soaked and sliced
- 2 cups sweet potato leaves or spinach
- 2 eggs (poached one per bowl)
- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- Salt and white pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: Simmer anchovies, corn rounds, and water 30 minutes. Strain — the broth should be clear and lightly savory with corn sweetness.
2. FRY ikan bilis: Heat oil in a pan. Fry a second batch of dried anchovies until golden and crispy. Drain. Set aside as crunchy topping.
3. NOODLE DOUGH: Combine flour, egg, oil, water, salt. Knead 8 minutes into a smooth, firm dough. Rest covered 20 minutes.
4. Roll dough thin. Either cut into flat noodle strips (pan mee style) OR tear into rough pieces by hand (ban mian / mee hoon kueh style).
5. Bring anchovy broth to a boil. Blanch noodle pieces until cooked (2–3 minutes). They float when done.
6. ASSEMBLE: Place cooked noodles in bowls.
7. Cook pork mince in 1 tsp oil until browned. Add soy.
8. Ladle hot broth over noodles.
9. Add pork mince, mushroom slices, sweet potato leaves.
10. Poach an egg in the broth. Add to each bowl.
11. Top with crispy fried ikan bilis generously.
12. Drizzle dark chilli sauce on the side.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~460 per bowl

TIP

The corn cob simmered in the anchovy broth is the Malaysian Hakka secret — it adds a natural sweetness that balances the salty anchovies and creates a broth with more complexity than anchovy alone. Remove the corn before serving but save the broth — it is the foundation of this excellent soup.

[High Protein] [Classic Malaysian Chinese] [Hakka Heritage]

Philippines

RECIPE 362

■■ Philippines

TAPSILOG

CURED BEEF, GARLIC RICE, AND EGG

The crown prince of Filipino silog breakfasts — tapa (sweet, garlicky cured beef slices) pan-fried until caramelized and slightly charred at the edges, served alongside sinangag (day-old garlic fried rice) and a fried egg. With vinegar for dipping the beef. The sweet-sour contrast of cured meat and sharp vinegar is the genius of Filipino breakfast flavor. Eaten at every Filipino carinderia from 5am, and at every Filipino home on weekends without fail.

INGREDIENTS

- BEEF TAPA (marinate overnight):
- 500g (18 oz) beef sirloin or tenderloin,
- sliced very thin (3–4mm) against the grain
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 3 tbsp sugar (white or brown)
- 1 tbsp calamansi juice or lime juice
- 1 tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp salt

SINANGAG (GARLIC FRIED RICE)

- 3 cups day-old cooked white rice
- (cold, refrigerated — essential)
- 8 garlic cloves, minced very fine
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 green onions, sliced

PER SERVING

- 2 large eggs, fried sunnyside up
- 2 tbsp white cane vinegar (sukang maasim) or
- spiced vinegar for dipping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. TAPA: Combine all marinade ingredients. Add beef. Mix thoroughly. Marinate covered overnight in the refrigerator. Minimum 4 hours but overnight is exponentially better — the sugar cures the meat while the garlic permeates fully.
2. SINANGAG: Heat oil in a wok over medium heat. Add all minced garlic at once — do NOT wait for the oil to get smoking hot.
3. Fry garlic slowly over medium heat, stirring, until it turns pale golden and fragrant — about 3–4 minutes. The garlic must be golden, not raw (bitter) and not dark brown (burned).
4. Increase heat to high. Add cold rice immediately. Break up all clumps with the back of a spoon.
5. Stir-fry vigorously 3–4 minutes until each grain is coated in garlic oil and heated through.
6. Add salt and green onion. Toss once. Set aside warm.
7. TAPA: Heat a pan over medium-high heat with 1 tbsp oil.
8. Add marinated beef in a single layer. DO NOT crowd — cook in batches.
9. Fry 2 minutes per side until the beef caramelizes darkly — the sugar should create char at the edges.
10. ASSEMBLE: Mound sinangag on a plate. Arrange tapa slices alongside. Add fried egg.
11. Serve with vinegar in a small dish for dipping the tapa.

Prep: 15 min + overnight marinating · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~570 per serving

TIP

The vinegar dip is not optional — it is the flavor counterpoint that makes tapa extraordinary. Spiced vinegar (sukang lloco) with crushed garlic and whole peppercorns is the Filipino standard. The sweet, slightly charred, garlicky beef dipped in sharp vinegar is the essential Filipino breakfast flavor contrast.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino] [National Dish]

RECIPE 363

■■ Philippines

TOCILOG

SWEET PORK, GARLIC RICE, AND EGG

Tocino — the sweeter, pinker silog variety — made from pork cured in sugar, garlic, and annatto for days until deeply flavored and slightly fermented. Pan-fried until caramelized and sticky, the surface glistening with caramelized sugar. Served with sinangag and fried egg. Filipino children grow up on tocilog — the sweetness makes it the most accessible silog variety, and the one most associated with Sunday mornings in Filipino households.

INGREDIENTS

- PORK TOCINO (marinate 2–3 days for best results):
- 500g (18 oz) pork shoulder or pork belly,
- thinly sliced (5mm)
- 6 garlic cloves, minced
- 4 tbsp sugar (white — generous)
- 1 tsp salt
- ¼ tsp annatto powder (atsüete — for the pink color)
- dissolved in 1 tbsp water
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 1 tbsp soy sauce

FOR COOKING

- 2–3 tbsp water (added to pan while frying tocino —
- prevents burning of the sugar)
- Sinangag (garlic fried rice) — as Recipe 362
- 2 eggs, fried per serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. TOCINO: Combine garlic, sugar, salt, annatto water, pepper, and soy sauce. Add pork slices. Mix well until every piece is evenly coated.
2. Cover and refrigerate 2–3 days — the longer the cure, the more flavorful and tender the tocino becomes. After 3 days, the sugar partially ferments with the pork, creating the characteristic slightly funky, intensely sweet flavor of authentic tocino. Overnight is acceptable but delivers less depth.
3. COOKING: Heat a pan over medium heat. Do NOT add oil — the pork has enough fat.
4. Add tocino pieces in a single layer.
5. Add 3 tbsp water immediately — this prevents the sugar from burning while the pork cooks through.
6. Cook over medium heat 8–10 minutes, flipping occasionally, as the water evaporates and the tocino begins to caramelize in its own rendered fat.
7. In the final 2 minutes, increase heat slightly and let the sugar caramelize to a deep, glossy brown.
8. Watch carefully — caramelized sugar burns quickly.
9. Serve alongside sinangag and fried egg.

Prep: 10 min + 2-3 days curing · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

The water-cooking method for tocino is essential — dry-frying in oil burns the sugar before the pork is cooked through. Adding water first creates a braising effect that cooks the pork, and as the water evaporates, the pork caramelizes in its own fat. Three days of curing creates a fundamentally different (superior) tocino than overnight. Plan ahead.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino] [Sweet]

RECIPE 364

■ ■ Philippines

LONGSILOG

LONGANISA SAUSAGE, GARLIC RICE, AND EGG

The most fragrant silog — Filipino longanisa (sweet or garlicky pork sausage) pan-fried with water until caramelized and bursting, served with sinangag and egg. Every Philippine region has its longanisa style: Vigan longanisa is pungently garlicky and sour; Pampanga longanisa is sweet and herbed; Cebu longanisa is small, dense, and deeply caramelized. Each is correct within its region. This recipe covers the sweet Pampanga style.

INGREDIENTS

- HOMEMADE LONGANISA (Pampanga sweet style):
- 500g (18 oz) ground pork (not too lean — 20% fat ideal)
- 6 garlic cloves, minced very fine
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp paprika (for color)
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp calamansi juice or lime juice
- Hog casings (soaked) OR form into small patties
- without casings (simpler)

FOR COOKING

- Water for poaching before frying
- Oil if using patties

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Sinangag — as Recipe 362
- Fried eggs (2 per person)
- Spiced vinegar for dipping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LONGANISA: Combine all ingredients. Mix until completely homogeneous — the mixture should be sticky and hold together.
2. IF USING CASINGS: Tie one end. Stuff loosely (longanisa expands). Twist into 5cm links. Refrigerate overnight for flavors to meld. IF MAKING PATTIES: Form into small flattened rounds.
3. COOKING LONGANISA IN CASINGS: Place in a pan. Add water to cover halfway. Bring to a boil.
4. Simmer until water evaporates — 8–10 minutes. The longanisa will cook through in the steam.
5. When water is gone, add 1 tbsp oil. Fry in the rendered fat and oil until deeply caramelized all over — 3–4 minutes. The casing will burst slightly — this is correct and desirable. The bursting creates crispy, caramelized edges that are the best part.
6. IF USING PATTIES: Pan-fry in oil 3 minutes per side.
7. SERVE: Alongside sinangag, fried egg, and vinegar.

Prep: 20 min + overnight resting · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~550 per serving

TIP

The water-first cooking method is the traditional Filipino technique for longanisa — it ensures the sausage cooks through before the casing chars. The sweetness in the longanisa means it caramelizes very quickly once the water is gone. Stay close and watch the heat — the transition from perfectly caramelized to burned takes about 30 seconds.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino]

RECIPE 365

■ ■ Philippines

BANGSILOG

DAING NA BANGUS, GARLIC RICE, AND EGG

The seafood silog — daing na bangus (vinegar-marinated milkfish, butterfly-cut and dried or cured) fried until the skin is shatteringly crispy and the flesh inside still moist. Bangus (milkfish) is the Philippine national fish, and daing na bangus is its most beloved breakfast preparation. The vinegar-garlic marinade gives it a tangy depth that makes the crispy skin addictive and the white flaky flesh irresistible.

INGREDIENTS

- DAING NA BANGUS (marinate overnight):
- 1 whole milkfish (bangus), butterflied and deboned
- (ask your fishmonger — or use salmon trout as substitute)
- 6 garlic cloves, minced
- 120ml (½ cup) white cane vinegar (sukang maasim)
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp salt

FOR FRYING

- Neutral oil for shallow frying
- Sinangag — as Recipe 362
- Fried eggs (2 per person)
- Sliced tomatoes and salted egg (itlog na maalat) —
- the essential accompaniments
- White vinegar with garlic on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MARINADE: Combine vinegar, garlic, pepper, and salt.
2. Place butterflied bangus flesh-side down in a flat container. Pour marinade over. Ensure all surfaces are coated.
3. Marinate refrigerated overnight — minimum 8 hours. The vinegar partially cures the fish.
4. Remove fish. Pat very thoroughly dry with paper towels. The drier the surface, the crispier the frying.
5. Heat generous oil (2–3cm depth) in a pan over medium-high heat until shimmering.
6. Slide fish in SKIN SIDE DOWN. Fry without moving 4–5 minutes until skin is deeply golden and shatteringly crispy.
7. Flip carefully. Fry flesh side 3–4 minutes until golden and cooked through.
8. Drain on a rack (not paper towels — steam softens the crispy skin).
9. Serve alongside sinangag, fried eggs, sliced tomato, and a sprinkle of salt on the tomato.
10. Place vinegar-garlic on the side for dipping.

Prep: 10 min + overnight marinating · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

Thoroughly drying the marinated fish before frying is the single most important step for crispy skin. The vinegar marinade adds moisture — any surface moisture creates steam instead of fry, resulting in a soft, pale skin instead of the shatteringly crispy result that defines great daing na bangus. Pat dry obsessively.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino]

RECIPE 366

■■ Philippines

CHAMPORADO

FILIPINO CHOCOLATE RICE PORRIDGE

The Filipino sweet breakfast that surprises everyone who tries it — glutinous rice cooked with tablea (pure Philippine cacao tablets) into a thick, dark, intensely chocolatey porridge, served with condensed milk drizzled over and — the Filipino genius move — a side of salty dried fish (tuyo). The sweet-salty-chocolate combination is one of food's most unexpected and completely successful contrasts.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup glutinous rice (malagkit), rinsed
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- 3–4 tablea (Philippine pure cacao tablets, roughly chopped) OR: 4 tbsp unsweetened dark cocoa powder
- + 30g dark chocolate (70%), chopped
- 3–4 tbsp sugar (tablea is not sweet — adjust)
- ½ tsp salt
- 200ml (¾ cup) evaporated milk or condensed milk
- (drizzled over at serving)

THE ESSENTIAL ACCOMPANIMENT

- Tuyo (dried salted fish) — pan-fried until crispy and golden. The saltiness of the fish against the
- sweet chocolate porridge is the defining Filipino
- breakfast experience.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rinsed glutinous rice and water in a pot.
2. Bring to a boil, stirring once.
3. Reduce heat to medium-low. Cook 20–25 minutes, stirring every 5 minutes, until rice is fully cooked and the porridge is thick and sticky.
4. Add chopped tablea (or cocoa powder + dark chocolate). Stir well until completely melted and incorporated.
5. Add sugar and salt. Taste — it should be dark, bittersweet, and rich. Adjust sugar if needed.
6. Continue cooking 5–7 minutes until champorado is thick enough to coat the back of a spoon. It will thicken further as it cools.
7. FRY TUYO: Heat 2 tbsp oil in a small pan. Fry dried fish until golden and crispy — 2 minutes per side. The oil will be very aromatic.
8. Ladle champorado into bowls.
9. Drizzle condensed milk or evaporated milk generously in a circular pattern over the chocolate porridge.
10. Serve crispy tuyo on the side — the combination must be experienced in the same bite.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Philippine tablea is pure roasted cacao — not sweetened, not processed. It creates a darker, more complex chocolate flavor with bitter notes that cocoa powder cannot replicate. Find it at Filipino grocery stores. When it melts into the porridge, the fat from the cacao creates a richness that transforms the champorado from good to extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino] [Sweet] [Unique]

RECIPE 367

■ ■ Philippines

LUGAW

FILIPINO RICE CONGEE

The Philippine healing porridge — lugaw is rice cooked with ginger until completely smooth and silky, topped with fried garlic, green onion, and toasted kasubha (Filipino saffron). Served with a side of hard-boiled quail eggs or chicken, and a drizzle of fish sauce and calamansi. Eaten when ill, on cold mornings, at hospitals, and at street lugaw carts that are among the earliest and most comforting sights in any Filipino town.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup long-grain white rice
- 1.5L (6 cups) chicken or pork broth
- 3cm fresh ginger, julienned
- 1 tsp turmeric or pinch of kasubha (safflower/
- Filipino saffron — gives the characteristic
- golden yellow color)
- 1 tsp fish sauce (patis)
- Salt and white pepper

TOPPINGS

- 3 tbsp fried garlic (deep-fried sliced garlic)
- 3 green onions, sliced
- 6 hard-boiled quail eggs or 2 chicken eggs, halved
- 1 tbsp toasted sesame seeds
- Tokwa (fried tofu cubes) — optional
- Chicharron (pork crackling) — optional

CONDIMENTS

- Fish sauce (patis)
- Calamansi (Philippine lime) or regular lime
- Spiced vinegar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rinsed rice with cold broth and ginger.
2. Add turmeric or kasubha for color.
3. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat to very low.
4. Simmer 40–50 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice has completely dissolved and the lugaw is smooth, silky, and slightly thicker than water.
5. The consistency should be pourable and smooth — not grainy.
6. Season with fish sauce, salt, and white pepper.
7. FRIED GARLIC: Slice garlic paper-thin. Fry in neutral oil over medium heat until pale golden. Remove immediately — it continues to cook in residual heat.
8. SERVE: Ladle lugaw into deep bowls.
9. Add fried garlic generously on top.
10. Add green onion, quail eggs, and sesame seeds.
11. Serve fish sauce, calamansi, and spiced vinegar on the side.
12. Each person seasons their own bowl.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~235 per bowl

TIP

Kasubha (Philippine safflower, also called azafrán) gives lugaw its characteristic golden color and a subtle floral note completely different from turmeric. Find it dried at Filipino grocery stores — a small amount goes a long way. If unavailable, turmeric provides color but a different flavor. The fried garlic is the essential topping without which lugaw feels incomplete.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein option] [Classic Filipino] [Healing]

RECIPE 368

■■ Philippines

PANDESAL

FILIPINO MORNING BREAD ROLLS

The Filipino morning bread — small, slightly sweet, soft-centered bread rolls with a thin, crispy-crumbed exterior from a generous coating of breadcrumbs. Bought fresh from the local panaderya (bakery) every morning, eaten with butter, cheese, or dipped into coffee or hot chocolate. The scent of fresh pandesal baking is one of the defining sensory memories of Filipino childhood. No Filipino breakfast is complete without it.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm milk
- 1 large egg
- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

COATING

- 150g (1½ cups) fine dry breadcrumbs
- (panko, blended finer, or store-bought fine breadcrumbs)
- FOR SERVING (choose):
- Salted butter
- Filipino cheese (Eden cheese — processed, very salty, melts beautifully into warm pandesal)
- Condensed milk for dipping
- Coffee or hot tsokolate (Filipino hot chocolate)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt.
2. Add warm milk, egg, and vanilla. Mix.
3. Knead 8 minutes into a smooth dough.
4. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until the dough is smooth, elastic, and slightly tacky.
5. Prove covered 1 hour until doubled.
6. Punch down. Divide into 14–16 equal pieces.
7. Roll each piece into a smooth oval shape — Filipino pandesal is oval, not perfectly round.
8. Roll each shaped piece immediately in dry breadcrumbs, coating thoroughly on all surfaces.
9. Place on lined baking trays, crumb-side up, touching each other slightly — Filipino pandesal bakes close together so the sides remain soft.
10. Prove 30–40 minutes until noticeably puffed.
11. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 15–17 minutes until pale golden on top. They should NOT be dark — pandesal is pale, soft, and gentle in color.
12. Serve immediately while warm.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 17 min · Serves: 15 · Cal: ~185 per pandesal

TIP

The breadcrumb coating is what makes pandesal uniquely Filipino — it creates a thin, crispy, textured shell around the soft interior. Apply the breadcrumbs before the second proof, not after — this allows the crumbs to adhere to the dough as it rises, becoming part of the bread's surface rather than falling off.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Filipino] [Bakery] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 369

■ ■ Philippines

SINANGAG

FILIPINO GARLIC FRIED RICE — STANDALONE

The constant, unchanging foundation of every silog breakfast — sinangag deserves its own standalone recipe. Day-old rice fried with an almost absurd quantity of minced garlic until every grain is glossy and fragrant. The garlic must be fried separately until golden before the rice is added — this caramelized garlic is what transforms plain leftover rice into the most aromatic, satisfying thing a wok can produce. Eaten as part of every Filipino silog, but also perfectly excellent eaten alone with just a fried egg.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups day-old cooked long-grain white rice
- (refrigerated — cold and dry is the requirement)
- 8–10 garlic cloves, minced very fine
- (more garlic than feels reasonable — this is correct)
- 3 tbsp neutral oil or lard
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 green onions, sliced
- Optional: 1 tsp toasted sesame oil (finish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Break up cold rice with your hands before cooking — remove any clumps. Cold, dry, separated grains are the foundation of great sinangag.
2. Heat oil in a wok or wide pan over medium heat. Note: medium, not high — garlic must be fried gently, not scorched.
3. Add ALL the minced garlic at once.
4. Fry slowly over medium heat, stirring constantly, 3–4 minutes until garlic turns pale golden and the kitchen fills with a deeply fragrant, toasted aroma. The garlic should be uniformly golden — no raw pieces, no burned pieces. This is the critical moment.
5. IMMEDIATELY increase heat to high.
6. Add all the cold rice at once.
7. Press rice against the wok with the back of a spoon. Break up any remaining clumps.
8. Stir-fry vigorously 3–4 minutes until every grain is coated in garlicky oil and heated through.
9. Season with salt. Toss to distribute.
10. Add green onion. Toss once.
11. Optional: drizzle sesame oil over the finished rice.
12. Serve immediately alongside any silog protein.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Filipino sinangag uses far more garlic than any Chinese or Southeast Asian fried rice — typically 8–10 cloves for 3 cups of rice. This is not a mistake. The garlic is the entire flavor. The oil-fried garlic creates a toasty, caramelized flavor that permeates every grain. Using the correct quantity is the difference between sinangag and generic fried rice.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino] [Quick] [Foundation Recipe]

RECIPE 370

■ ■ Philippines

GOTO BAKA

FILIPINO BEEF TRIPE CONGEE

Manila's famous comfort congee — goto is lugaw (rice porridge) cooked with beef tripe and ginger until the tripe is meltingly soft and the porridge is deeply flavored. Served at goto shops (goteria) throughout Manila from the early hours of morning. Topped with fried garlic, green onion, tokwa (fried tofu), and a sprinkle of black pepper with a squeeze of calamansi — a breakfast as bold and generous as the city it comes from.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) cleaned beef tripe, cut into strips
- ½ cup glutinous rice or long-grain rice
- 1.5L (6 cups) beef broth or water
- 3cm fresh ginger, julienned
- 1 onion, quartered
- 4 garlic cloves
- 1 tbsp fish sauce (patis)
- Salt and white pepper

TOPPINGS

- Fried garlic (generous)
- Green onions, sliced
- Tokwa (firm tofu), cubed and deep-fried until golden
- Hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Chicharron (pork cracklings), optional
- Toasted kasubha or turmeric (for color)

CONDIMENTS

- Fish sauce (patis)
- Calamansi or lime
- Black pepper
- Spiced vinegar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Clean tripe thoroughly under running water. Blanch in boiling water 10 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Pressure cook tripe with onion and garlic in broth or water 45 minutes until very tender. OR: boil conventionally 2–3 hours.
3. Remove tripe. Cut into 3cm pieces. Reserve broth.
4. Strain broth. Combine with rinsed rice and ginger.
5. Bring to a boil. Reduce to low heat.
6. Simmer 40–50 minutes stirring occasionally until rice is completely dissolved and porridge is silky.
7. Add cooked tripe. Season with fish sauce, salt, and white pepper.
8. Add a pinch of kasubha or turmeric for the characteristic golden color.
9. Simmer 5 more minutes for flavors to meld.
10. SERVE: Ladle goto into deep bowls.
11. Top with fried garlic, green onion, fried tofu, and cracklings.
12. Place condiments on the side.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 90 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~310 per bowl

TIP

Cleaning tripe thoroughly before cooking is essential — soak in cold water with calamansi or lime juice for 30 minutes before blanching. The blanching step removes any remaining impurities and the slightly funky smell that raw tripe can have. After proper cleaning and long cooking, good tripe has a mild, clean flavor and a uniquely silky, slightly chewy texture.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Filipino] [Manila Street Food]

RECIPE 371

■ ■ Singapore

SINGAPORE LAKSA

KATONG STYLE

Singapore's most celebrated noodle dish — Katong laksa uses cut-short rice vermicelli (so it can be eaten with a spoon, not chopsticks, as a Peranakan innovation) in a rich coconut curry broth with shrimp, cockles, tofu puffs, and fish cake. The difference from Malaysian laksa: the Singaporean version uses a specific spice paste and coconut ratio that is richer, more orange, and distinctly its own. Singapore residents are passionate about whose laksa is better. The Katong tradition dates to the 1950s.

INGREDIENTS

SINGAPOREAN LAKSA PASTE

- 8 dried red chillies, soaked
- 6 shallots
- 4 garlic cloves
- 3 stalks lemongrass, white part only
- 2cm galangal
- 2cm fresh turmeric (or 1 tsp powder)
- 1 tbsp belachan (toasted shrimp paste)
- 8 candlenuts (or macadamias)
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- 2 tbsp dried shrimp (blended into paste)

LAKSA BROTH

- 600ml (2½ cups) coconut milk (full fat)
- 400ml (1■ cups) prawn/shrimp broth
- (simmer prawn shells and heads 20 min)
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- Salt
- 3 tbsp oil for frying paste

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 300g (10 oz) thin rice vermicelli, soaked and blanched,
- then CUT SHORT with scissors into 5cm lengths
- (the Katong innovation — eaten with a spoon)
- 200g (7 oz) prawns, cooked and halved
- 100g (3.5 oz) cockles, blanched
- 4 tofu puffs (tau pok), halved and squeezed
- 2 fish cake rounds, sliced
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Bean sprouts, blanched
- Laksa leaves (Vietnamese mint / daun kesum) —
- essential, cannot be substituted
- Sambal on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PASTE: Blend all paste ingredients until very smooth.
2. Fry paste in oil 8–10 minutes until oil separates and paste is dark, fragrant, and rich.
3. Add shrimp broth. Bring to a simmer.
4. Add coconut milk. Bring to a very gentle simmer. NEVER boil hard — coconut milk will split.
5. Add tofu puffs — simmer 5 minutes to absorb flavor.
6. Season with fish sauce, sugar, and salt.
7. Taste: rich, creamy, spicy, deeply complex.
8. SERVE: Place cut vermicelli in deep bowls.
9. Add prawns, cockles, fish cake, and egg.
10. Ladle hot laksa broth generously over.
11. Add bean sprouts. Scatter laksa leaves generously.
12. Serve with sambal on the side.
13. Eat with a spoon — the Katong way.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~510 per bowl

TIP

Laksa leaves (Vietnamese mint / daun kesum) are the herb that defines Singaporean laksa — their peppery, slightly medicinal, intensely aromatic quality is irreplaceable. Do not substitute with regular mint or Thai basil — the flavor is completely different. Find daun kesum at Southeast Asian grocery stores.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Singaporean] [Peranakan] [Hawker Food]

Singapore

RECIPE 372

■■ Singapore

SINGAPORE ROTI PRATA

SINGAPOREAN FLAKY FLATBREAD

Singapore's version of roti canai — a supremely laminated flatbread cooked on a flat iron griddle by Indian Muslim (mamak) hawkers who spin, stretch, and fold the dough with hypnotic speed. Singapore's prata is thinner, crispier, and

more layered than the Malaysian version. Eaten plain (kosong), with egg (telur), or with sugar and condensed milk as a sweet option. Served with dhal and fish curry, and consumed passionately by Singaporeans of every background at every hawker centre.

INGREDIENTS

- Roti Canai dough — exactly as Recipe 348
- (the dough is identical; the difference is technique and cooking style)
- GHEE for cooking (generous — prata uses more ghee than feels reasonable. This is correct.)
- FILLINGS (choose):
- Plain (kosong) — no filling
- Egg (telur) — one egg per prata, cracked onto stretched dough
- Cheese and egg — processed cheese slice + egg
- Banana and sugar — Singapore sweet prata innovation

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Fish curry (Singapore-style — thinner and more tamarind-forward than Indian fish curry)
- Yellow dhal (as Recipe 348)
- Sugar for sweet prata

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make roti canai dough. Rest overnight. Cold, well-rested dough is essential.
2. SINGAPORE PRATA SHAPING: On an oiled surface, take a rested ball. Press flat with oiled palm.
3. Using the backs of your oiled fingers, work the dough outward from center — stretching rapidly and confidently to a very thin, nearly translucent sheet. Singapore prata is thinner than Malaysian roti.
4. FOR PLAIN PRATA: Fold edges inward multiple times to create a multi-layered square or round.
5. FOR EGG PRATA: Crack egg onto center of stretched dough. Fold edges over the egg, enclosing it inside.
6. COOKING: Heat griddle with generous ghee over medium heat.
7. Place folded prata on griddle. Press firmly and evenly.
8. Cook 2 minutes until golden on the bottom.
9. Flip. Add more ghee. Cook 1.5 minutes.
10. Flip once more. Press with a metal spatula to ensure even contact and caramelization. 30 seconds more.
11. Remove. IMMEDIATELY clap vigorously between palms to fluff and separate layers — the Singapore prata should shatter slightly at the clap.
12. Serve with fish curry and dhal.

Prep: 20 min + overnight resting · Cook: 5 min per prata · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~420 per prata

TIP

Singapore prata is traditionally eaten dipped into fish curry (not just dhal) — the thin, sour curry is the Singaporean accompaniment that distinguishes Singapore prata culture from Malaysian roti canai culture. The fish curry provides an acidity that cuts through the richness of the ghee-laminated bread beautifully.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Singaporean] [Mamak Culture] [Hawker Icon]

RECIPE 373

■ Singapore

SINGAPORE CHICKEN RICE

Singapore's national dish — poached chicken of extraordinary silkiness served over rice cooked in the chicken's own broth with ginger and garlic. Accompanied by three essential sauces: dark soy with sesame, chilli garlic ginger sauce, and fresh ginger oil. Singapore's version of Hainanese chicken rice is considered by many to be the world's finest — the obsessive attention to broth quality, chicken texture, and rice fragrance elevates this simple dish into something transcendent.

INGREDIENTS

POACHED CHICKEN

- 1 whole chicken (1.5–1.8kg)
- 2 tsp fine salt (for rubbing inside and out)
- 5 slices fresh ginger
- 4 green onions, whole
- Water to cover

CHICKEN RICE

- 2 cups jasmine rice, washed and drained
- Chicken fat from the broth (or 2 tbsp neutral oil)
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 2cm fresh ginger, minced
- Chicken broth from poaching (for cooking rice)
- 1 tsp salt, 1 pandan leaf

THREE SAUCES

- Chilli sauce:
 - 6 red bird's eye chillies
 - 3 garlic cloves
 - 2cm fresh ginger
 - 3 tbsp lime juice
 - 1 tsp sugar + 1 tsp sesame oil + salt
- Dark soy sauce:
 - 3 tbsp dark soy + 1 tsp sesame oil + 1 tsp sugar
- Ginger oil:
 - 3cm ginger, grated finely + 2 tsp salt
 - + 3 tbsp neutral oil, just below smoking, poured over

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Sliced cucumber
- Bean sprouts, blanched
- Clear chicken broth soup with ginger and green onion
- Oyster sauce for drizzling (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rub chicken inside and out with salt. Rest 20 min.
2. Bring a deep pot of water to a boil with ginger and green onions.
3. Lower chicken BREAST SIDE DOWN. Return to a bare simmer.
4. Poach at the lowest possible simmer for 35–40 minutes for whole chicken.
5. REMOVE chicken. Immediately submerge in ice water 5 minutes — this creates the signature silky, just-set skin and stops cooking precisely at the right moment.
6. Reserve poaching broth. Skim chicken fat from surface.
7. RICE: Heat chicken fat in a pot. Add garlic and ginger. Cook 2 minutes until fragrant.
8. Add washed rice. Toss to coat every grain.
9. Add 2 cups chicken broth, pandan leaf, and salt. Bring to boil, cover, reduce to lowest heat, cook 12 minutes, rest 10 minutes covered.
10. THREE SAUCES: Make each separately (blend chilli sauce ingredients; combine dark soy ingredients; prepare ginger oil by pouring hot oil over grated ginger).
11. Slice or chop chicken. Arrange on plate with cucumber.
12. Serve alongside rice, sauces, and a bowl of clear broth.
13. Drizzle dark soy and a little ginger oil over chicken.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~560 per serving

TIP

The ice water bath after poaching is what creates Singapore chicken rice's legendary silky, slightly gelatinous skin that separates it from ordinary poached chicken. The rapid cooling contracts the skin, creating an almost glass-like texture. Skipping the ice bath results in a softer, less defined skin that lacks the textural pleasure that defines great chicken rice.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Singaporean] [National Dish]

RECIPE 374

■ ■ Singapore

SINGAPORE CARROT CAKE

CHAI TOW KWAY

Singapore's most confusingly named dish — Singaporean "carrot cake" contains no carrot. It is a steamed radish (white carrot, or chai tow in Hokkien) and rice flour cake, cubed and stir-fried with eggs, preserved radish, and bean sprouts. Served in two styles: white (uncolored, with white egg crust) or black (with kecap manis creating a dark, sweet-savory caramel version). A hawker staple for over a century, eaten for breakfast throughout Singapore without the slightest confusion from locals.

INGREDIENTS

- STEAMED RADISH CAKE (chai tow kway):
- 400g (14 oz) white daikon radish (chai tow),
- peeled and grated
- 200g (1■ cups) rice flour
- 400ml (1■ cups) water
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp white pepper
- FOR STIR-FRYING:
- 2 tbsp lard or neutral oil
- 3 large eggs, beaten
- 3 tbsp preserved radish (chai poh — rinsed to
- reduce saltiness, then squeezed dry)
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 cup bean sprouts
- 2 green onions, sliced

FOR BLACK VERSION

- 2 tbsp kecap manis (sweet dark soy sauce)

FOR WHITE VERSION

- 1 tbsp light soy sauce
- Fish sauce to taste
- Chilli sauce for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. RADISH CAKE: Combine grated radish, rice flour, water, salt, and pepper. Mix well.
2. Pour into a greased 20x20cm baking tin.
3. Steam over high heat 30–35 minutes until set. Test by inserting a skewer — it should come out clean.
4. Cool completely. Refrigerate until firm (at least 2 hours).
5. Cut into 2cm cubes. The cake must be cold and firm.
6. STIR-FRY: Heat oil or lard in a wok over high heat.
7. Add radish cake cubes. Fry without moving for 2 minutes until a golden crust forms on the bottom.
8. Flip cubes. Fry 2 more minutes. Add garlic.
9. Push cubes aside. Add beaten eggs. Let sit 10 seconds then scramble and fold into the radish cake.
10. Add preserved radish. Toss briefly.
11. FOR BLACK: Add kecap manis. Toss vigorously until everything is evenly coated in dark sauce. FOR WHITE: Add light soy. Toss.
12. Add bean sprouts and green onion. Toss twice.
13. Serve immediately with chilli sauce.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hrs chilling · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The steamed radish cake must be completely cold and firm before cutting and frying — warm cake crumbles in the wok instead of developing the golden, crispy crust that gives this dish its essential texture. Cold refrigerator temperature (at least 2 hours) creates a firm, sliceable cake that holds together under high heat.

[Vegan option] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Singaporean] [Hawker Food]

RECIPE 375

■ ■ Singapore

SINGAPORE HOKKIEN MEE

Singapore's prawn-forward stir-fried noodle dish — egg noodles and rice vermicelli braised in an intensely flavorful prawn and pork broth until the noodles absorb every drop of flavor, then finished with sambal, pork lard, and lime. The distinguishing technique: the noodles are braised (not stir-fried dry) in broth, creating a wet, intensely flavored result. Served on a banana leaf with sambal belachan and fresh lime — one of Singapore's most passionately loved hawker dishes.

INGREDIENTS

- PRAWN-PORK BROTH:
- Shells and heads from 400g prawns (reserve flesh)
- 100g (3.5 oz) pork ribs or pork bones
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 1 tsp salt

NOODLES AND PROTEIN

- 200g (7 oz) fresh yellow egg noodles (mee)
- 150g (5 oz) rice vermicelli (beehoon), soaked
- 300g (10 oz) medium prawns, peeled and deveined
- 150g (5 oz) sliced pork belly, blanched
- 100g (3.5 oz) squid, cleaned and sliced into rings
- 4 eggs, beaten
- 2 cups bean sprouts
- 3 tbsp pork lard + rendered lard oil (or neutral oil
- — lard is traditional and makes a significant difference)
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- Fish sauce and white pepper
- 2 tsp sambal belachan for cooking

SERVING

- Sambal belachan (shrimp paste chilli sauce)
- Lime wedges
- Fried lard bits (crunchy pork cracklings)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PRAWN BROTH: Fry prawn shells and heads in 1 tbsp oil until deeply red and very fragrant. Add pork ribs and water. Simmer 30 minutes. Strain. The broth should be a deep reddish-orange from the shells.
2. STIR-FRY: Heat lard in a large wok over very high heat.
3. Add garlic. Fry 15 seconds.
4. Add prawns and squid. Stir-fry until just cooked. Remove and set aside.
5. Add pork belly. Toss briefly.
6. Add both types of noodles. Toss to mix.
7. Add sambal. Toss into noodles.
8. Pour 250–300ml of prawn broth over the noodles.
9. BRAISE: reduce heat to medium. Cover with a lid or wok cover. Let noodles absorb the broth 2–3 minutes.
10. Uncover. Push noodles to sides. Add beaten eggs. Scramble partially. Fold into noodles.
11. Add bean sprouts. Return prawns and squid.
12. Season with fish sauce and white pepper.
13. Add more broth if noodles look dry — the finished dish should be moist but not soupy.
14. Transfer to banana leaf. Top with fried lard bits.
15. Serve with sambal and lime.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

The braising step — adding broth and covering the wok — is what makes Singapore Hokkien Mee different from other stir-fried noodles. The noodles absorb the intensely flavored prawn broth, becoming saturated with flavor from the inside out. Dry-frying the noodles without broth creates a good dish; braising in prawn broth creates Singapore's great dish.

[High Protein] [Classic Singaporean] [Hawker Food] [Hokkien Heritage]

RECIPE 376

■ Singapore

SINGAPORE POPIAH

FRESH SPRING ROLLS

Singapore's Hokkien-Peranakan fresh spring rolls — thin, delicate wheat crepes filled with braised jicama (bangkuang) and bamboo shoot, egg omelette strips, bean sprouts, tofu, prawns, and a smear of sweet plum sauce and garlic paste, assembled fresh at the table. Eaten for breakfast and lunch, the making of popiah is a communal activity — each person assembles their own from dishes laid out family-style. Singapore's most social breakfast food.

INGREDIENTS

- POPIAH SKIN (thin wheat crepes):
- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 large eggs
- 400ml (1■ cups) water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp oil
- BRAISED FILLING (bangkuang):
- 400g (14 oz) jicama (bangkuang / turnip),
peeled and julienned
- 100g (3.5 oz) bamboo shoots, julienned
- 3 tbsp dried shrimp, soaked and blended
- 3 shallots, sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 tbsp oil
- Salt and white pepper
- GARNISHES AND SAUCES (all essential):
- 2 tbsp sweet plum sauce or hoisin
- 2 tbsp chilli sauce
- 3 garlic cloves, minced into a paste with salt
- 4 eggs, made into thin omelette, julienned
- 1 cup bean sprouts, blanched briefly
- 150g (5 oz) prawns, cooked and halved
- Firm tofu, sliced and pan-fried until golden
- Fried shallots (bawang goreng)
- Lettuce leaves (optional — add first as a liner)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. POPIAH SKIN: Whisk flour, eggs, water, salt, and oil until completely smooth. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Heat a non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Brush very lightly with oil.
3. Pour just enough batter to make a very thin, translucent crepe (20cm). Cook 1.5 minutes until edges lift. Remove without flipping.
4. Stack with parchment between layers.
5. BRAISED JICAMA: Heat oil. Fry shallots and garlic. Add blended dried shrimp. Fry 2 minutes.
6. Add jicama and bamboo shoots. Toss to coat.
7. Add soy sauce, sugar, and 100ml water. Cover.
8. Braise over medium heat 20–25 minutes until jicama is very soft and slightly translucent. Season with salt and pepper. Set aside.
9. ASSEMBLE (at the table): — Lay one popiah skin flat. — Smear sweet sauce, then chilli sauce, then garlic paste. — Add a lettuce leaf (if using) as a liner. — Add 2 tbsp braised jicama filling. — Add egg strips, bean sprouts, prawns, and tofu. — Scatter fried shallots. — Fold the side nearest to you over the filling. Fold in left and right sides. Roll away from you. — The popiah should be a tight cylinder.
10. Eat immediately, seam-side down.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per popiah

TIP

The braised jicama filling must be cooked until very soft and almost translucent — undercooked jicama is fibrous and unpleasant inside the thin skin. After braising, the filling should be moist but not wet. If too wet, the skin tears; if too dry, the popiah lacks moisture. The correct consistency is yielding and silky with just enough sauce to moisten each bite.

[High Protein] [Classic Singaporean] [Peranakan] [Communal Breakfast]

RECIPE 377

■ ■ Singapore

SINGAPORE KOPI

SINGAPOREAN COFFEE CULTURE

Singapore kopi (kopitiam coffee) is a world unto itself — a specific lexicon of orders that determines the exact ratio of coffee, evaporated milk, condensed milk, and whether it is hot or cold. Kopi-O (black, no milk), Kopi-C (evaporated milk, no condensed), Kopi Gah Dai (extra sweet), Kopi Peng (iced) — each designation is precise and universally understood. Made from dark-roasted Robusta beans blended with butter or sugar during roasting, brewed through a cloth sock filter into a dense, powerful cup. Singapore's most important morning ritual.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp Singapore kopi powder (dark-roasted Robusta
- blended with butter and/or sugar during roasting —
- available at Singapore grocery stores or online.
- These roasted-with-butter beans are what create
- the characteristic kopi flavor)
- 200ml (¾ cup) boiling water
- 2 tbsp sweetened condensed milk (Kopi standard)
- OR: 2 tbsp evaporated milk + 1 tsp sugar (Kopi-C)
- OR: nothing (Kopi-O black)

EQUIPMENT

- A kopi sock (cloth filter — traditional) or
- a fine-mesh pour-over dripper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place kopi sock over your cup. Add kopi powder.
2. Pour boiling water through slowly. The brew should be very dark, thick, and extremely strong.
3. Steep 2 minutes for maximum extraction.
4. FOR KOPI (standard): place condensed milk in the cup first. Pour hot coffee over. Stir.
5. FOR KOPI-C: place evaporated milk and sugar in cup. Pour coffee over.
6. FOR KOPI PENG (iced): make stronger brew (1.5x coffee). Add condensed milk. Pour over tall glass packed with ice.
7. THE ART OF POURING: Singaporean kopi aunties and uncles pour coffee from height between two vessels to aerate and cool — this creates a smoother, more rounded cup. Pour from 30cm height between vessels 3 times before serving. This is called "pulling."
8. Drink immediately. Kopi is meant to be consumed hot.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~130 per cup (with condensed milk)

TIP

The butter-roasted kopi powder used in Singapore is unlike any other coffee — roasted with butter and sometimes sugar during the process, creating a rounded, less acidic, deeply caramelized coffee base that is incomparable to Western coffee approaches. This specific roasting method is why Singapore kopi has a flavor that no Italian espresso or pour-over coffee can replicate. Seek out the authentic product.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Singaporean] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 378

■ ■ Taiwan

SHAO BING YOU TIAO

SESAME FLATBREAD WITH FRIED DOUGH STICK

Taiwan's most traditional breakfast combination — shao bing (a crispy, sesame-encrusted flatbread baked in a tandoor-style oven until shatteringly flaky) split open and stuffed with a freshly fried you tiao (Chinese fried dough stick). The crunch of the sesame bread against the airy, pillowy dough stick with a drizzle of sweet soy sauce is one of Taiwan's great breakfast pleasures. Eaten at every traditional breakfast shop alongside warm soy milk.

INGREDIENTS

SHAO BING DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water
- SCALLION OIL PASTE (flaky layers):
- 3 tbsp sesame paste (zhima jiang) mixed with
- 1 tbsp neutral oil and ½ tsp salt
- — OR: 2 tbsp sesame oil + ½ tsp salt

COATING

- 2 tbsp sesame paste, thinned with water to
- brushing consistency (for the exterior)
- 50g (¼ cup) white sesame seeds

YOU TIAO

- Make as Recipe 248 (Chinese fried dough sticks)
-
- the dough rested overnight
- Sweet soy sauce or hoisin for drizzling

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SHAO BING DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt. Add warm water. Knead 8 minutes into smooth dough. Prove 45 minutes.
2. Roll proved dough into a large rectangle (30x20cm).
3. Spread sesame paste thinly over the entire surface.
4. Roll up tightly from the long end into a cylinder.
5. Slice crosswise into 8 equal rounds.
6. Stand each round on its flat side. Press flat into a round disc (8–10cm).
7. Brush the tops generously with thinned sesame paste.
8. Dip the sesame-coated side into a tray of sesame seeds. Press to adhere. Coat generously.
9. Bake at 220°C (430°F) on a very hot baking stone or heavy baking sheet for 12–15 minutes until deep golden and shatteringly crispy. The high temperature creates the layers.
10. FRY YOU TIAO while shao bing bakes (see Recipe 248).
11. Split hot shao bing along the equator (like a burger bun).
12. Stuff with a full length of hot you tiao.
13. Add a drizzle of sweet soy or hoisin. Close.
14. Eat immediately while the shao bing is hot and crackling.

Prep: 25 min + 45 min proofing + overnight you tiao · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~380 per set

TIP

The very hot oven (220°C+) is essential for shao bing — the high heat creates rapid steam that separates the sesame paste layers from within, producing the characteristic flaky, shattering texture. A lower temperature creates a harder, denser bread without the layers. Use a preheated baking stone if possible — the bottom heat is crucial.

[Vegan] [Classic Taiwanese] [Traditional Breakfast] [Make-Ahead (dough)]

RECIPE 379

■ ■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE DAN BING

SCALLION EGG CRÊPE

Taiwan's most popular breakfast shop item — a thin, soft wheat flour crêpe cooked on a flat griddle with a beaten egg spread over its surface, scallions pressed in, and the whole thing folded into a cylinder. Eaten with sweet soy sauce. Distinct from Chinese jian bing (which uses mung bean flour and is crispier), Taiwan's dan bing is softer, thicker, and more custardy from the egg. It takes 90 seconds to make and is eaten by millions before 8am every day across Taiwan.

INGREDIENTS

DAN BING BATTER

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 40g (■ cup) tapioca starch (creates the characteristic
- soft, slightly chewy texture)
- 1 tsp salt
- 500ml (2 cups) cold water
- 1 tsp neutral oil
- PER CRÊPE:
- 1 large egg, beaten
- 2 tbsp sliced green onion (scallion)
- Pinch of salt and white pepper
- SAUCE (essential):
- 3 tbsp soy sauce paste (■■■■■ — thicker and
- sweeter than regular soy sauce, find at Taiwanese
- stores OR: 2 tbsp soy sauce + 1 tbsp hoisin mixed)
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tsp chilli sauce (optional)

OPTIONAL ADDITIONS

- Pork sung (dried pork floss) — very Taiwanese
- Ham slice
- Cheese slice

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BATTER: Whisk flour, tapioca starch, salt, water, and oil until completely smooth. No lumps. Rest 20 minutes — tapioca needs time to hydrate.
2. SAUCE: Mix soy sauce paste with sesame oil. Set aside.
3. Heat a flat griddle or large non-stick pan over medium heat. Brush lightly with oil.
4. Pour a ladleful of batter (about 80ml) and spread quickly into a thin 25cm circle using the back of a spoon or a batter spreader.
5. After 30 seconds, when edges begin to dry, pour beaten egg over the entire surface.
6. Spread egg evenly with the back of a spoon.
7. Scatter sliced green onion over the egg. Press lightly.
8. Season with salt and white pepper.
9. After 45–60 seconds when the egg is almost fully set, flip the entire crêpe.
10. Cook bottom 20 seconds.
11. Fold the crêpe into thirds (letter fold) to form a rectangular shape — egg inside, crêpe outside.
12. Transfer to a cutting board. Cut into 3–4 pieces.
13. Drizzle soy sauce paste over the cut pieces.
14. Serve immediately with extra sauce on the side.

Prep: 5 min + 20 min resting · Cook: 3 min per crêpe · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~235 per crêpe

TIP

Tapioca starch in the batter is the Taiwanese technique that creates the distinctive soft, slightly stretchy texture of dan bing — distinct from Chinese mung bean jian bing or French crêpes. Without tapioca, the crêpe is perfectly edible but lacks the specific chewiness that makes Taiwanese dan bing uniquely satisfying. Do not substitute with cornstarch.

[High Protein] [Classic Taiwanese] [Quick] [Breakfast Shop Icon]

RECIPE 380

■■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE TURNIP CAKE

LUO BO GAO

Pan-fried turnip (radish) cake — steamed white daikon and rice flour cake cut into thick slices and pan-fried until golden and crispy on both sides with a soft, custardy interior. Taiwan's version differs from the Hong Kong dim sum dish by being pan-fried more aggressively and served with a sweet soy dipping sauce and chilli. Found at every traditional Taiwanese breakfast shop (■■■■■) alongside soy milk and dan bing.

INGREDIENTS

TURNIP CAKE

- 500g (18 oz) white daikon radish, peeled and grated
- 200g (1½ cups) rice flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) tapioca starch
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp white pepper
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 50g (2 oz) dried shrimp, soaked and roughly chopped
- 3 dried shiitake mushrooms, soaked and finely diced
- 2 Chinese sausages (lap cheong), finely diced
- FOR PAN-FRYING:
 - 3 tbsp neutral oil per batch

SAUCE

- 3 tbsp soy sauce paste (as Recipe 379)
- 1 tsp sriracha
- 1 tsp sesame oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Squeeze grated daikon gently — reserve the liquid.
2. Combine rice flour and tapioca starch in a large bowl.
3. Add the reserved daikon liquid plus enough water to make 350ml total. Mix into the flour until smooth.
4. Stir in grated daikon, salt, white pepper, and sesame oil.
5. Heat 1 tbsp oil in a pan. Fry diced Chinese sausage 2 minutes. Add shiitake and dried shrimp. Fry 2 min.
6. Add the cooked sausage-mushroom mixture to the batter.
7. Grease a 20x20cm baking tin generously.
8. Pour batter in. Cover with foil.
9. Steam over high heat 40–45 minutes until set. Test with skewer — it should come out clean.
10. Cool completely. Refrigerate 2 hours until very firm.
11. Slice into 1.5cm thick rectangles.
12. Heat oil in a non-stick pan over medium-high heat.
13. Fry slices 3–4 minutes per side until deeply golden and very crispy. Do not move too early — the crust must form before flipping.
14. Serve immediately with soy sauce paste dipping sauce.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hrs chilling · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

The slice thickness determines the texture — 1.5cm creates a crispy exterior with a soft, custardy center. Thinner slices become entirely crispy (good for some, too dry for others). Thicker slices remain too soft inside without enough crust. 1.5cm is the optimum for the traditional Taiwanese breakfast shop experience.

[Gluten-Free] [Classic Taiwanese] [Make-Ahead] [Traditional Breakfast]

Taiwan

RECIPE 381

■■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE SALTY SOY MILK

XIAN DOU JIANG

Taiwan's most beloved and controversial breakfast — freshly made hot soy milk poured over a bowl containing black vinegar, soy sauce, sesame oil, dried shrimp, and scallion, causing the soy milk to partially curdle into silky ribbons. Topped with you tiao pieces, preserved mustard vegetables, and chilli oil. The curdled soy milk absorbs all the toppings' flavors into every silky bite. Passionately debated: sweet soy milk vs salty soy milk is a Taiwanese breakfast identity question.

INGREDIENTS

- FRESH SOY MILK (make as Recipe 322 — essential fresh):
- 1L (4 cups) hot, freshly made soy milk
- (must be very hot — 85°C+ for the curdling to work)
- Unsweetened for this recipe.
- BASE IN BOWL (per serving):
- 1 tbsp black vinegar (the acidic component that causes curdling — Chinese Chinkiang vinegar preferred)
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- ½ tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp dried shrimp, soaked briefly and drained
- 1 green onion, sliced
- ½ tsp chilli oil (optional)

TOPPINGS

- You tiao (Chinese dough sticks — Recipe 248), sliced
- Zha cai (Sichuan preserved mustard root), rinsed and sliced
- Fried shallots
- Extra sesame oil
- Extra chilli oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make soy milk as per Recipe 322. Keep it very hot — do not let it cool below 80°C before serving.
2. ASSEMBLE: Place black vinegar, soy sauce, sesame oil, dried shrimp, and green onion in a deep bowl.
3. DO NOT STIR YET.
4. From a height of 20–30cm, pour the very hot soy milk in a steady stream directly into the bowl. The acid from the vinegar reacts with the heat to partially curdle the soy milk into silky ribbons.
5. The surface should show curdled white wisps among clear, lightly colored liquid.
6. Add you tiao pieces on top — they will begin to soften.
7. Scatter zha cai and fried shallots.
8. Drizzle chilli oil.
9. Eat immediately, stirring gently just before each spoonful — the toppings and curdled milk combine in each bite.

Prep: 10 min + soy milk making (20 min) · Cook: 0 min after soy milk is made · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~195 per bowl

TIP

The soy milk must be HOT — not warm, not just steaming, but actively at 85°C+ when it hits the vinegar. Below this temperature, the curdling is minimal and the dish lacks the characteristic silky-curd texture. If the soy milk has cooled below 80°C, reheat it before pouring. The pour height also matters — more height creates more turbulence and better mixing with the acid.

[Vegan] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Taiwanese] [Traditional]

RECIPE 382

■ ■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE BEEF NOODLE SOUP

HONG SHAO NIU ROU MIAN

Taiwan's national dish and the bowl every Taiwanese person eats for breakfast on special cold mornings — thick wheat noodles in a deeply spiced, soy-braised beef broth with meltingly tender braised beef shank. The broth is built from soy sauce, bean paste, doubanjiang (spicy bean paste), star anise, and fermented black bean, reduced for hours into one of Asia's most complex and satisfying soup bases. Every family's recipe is the definitive one.

INGREDIENTS

BRAISED BEEF

- 800g (28 oz) beef shank or beef tendon, whole
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 3cm fresh ginger, sliced
- 3 tbsp doubanjiang (Sichuan spicy bean paste)
- 2 tbsp sweet bean paste (甜豆豉)
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp dark soy sauce
- 2 tbsp Shaoxing rice wine
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 3 star anise
- 1 cinnamon stick
- 2 bay leaves
- 3 dried red chillies
- 1L (4 cups) water or beef broth

NOODLES AND SERVING

- 400g (14 oz) thick fresh or dried wheat noodles
- (Taiwan-style wide noodles preferred)
- Blanched bok choy (per bowl)
- Suan cai (Taiwanese preserved sour mustard greens),
 - sliced — the essential garnish
- Sliced green onion
- Chilli oil (optional)
- Fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blanch beef shank in boiling water 10 minutes. Drain and rinse — removes impurities.
2. Heat oil in a large, heavy pot over medium heat.
3. Add garlic and ginger. Fry 1 minute.
4. Add doubanjiang. Fry 2 minutes until fragrant and the oil turns red from the chilli.
5. Add sweet bean paste. Fry 1 minute.
6. Add blanched beef shank. Turn to coat in the paste.
7. Add soy sauce, dark soy, Shaoxing wine, sugar, star anise, cinnamon, bay, dried chillies, and water.
8. Bring to a boil. Skim foam.
9. Reduce to the lowest simmer. Cover.
10. Braise 2.5–3 hours until beef is very tender — a chopstick should slide through without resistance.
11. Remove beef. Slice into 2cm thick rounds. Strain broth. Taste — it should be intensely rich, spiced, deeply savory with a balanced sweetness. Season if needed.
12. NOODLES: Cook noodles per package directions. Drain.
13. ASSEMBLE: Noodles in bowl + bok choy.
14. Ladle hot braising broth over.
15. Add sliced beef on top.
16. Add suan cai, green onion, and coriander.
17. Drizzle chilli oil if desired.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 3 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~590 per bowl

TIP

Suan cai (Taiwanese pickled mustard greens) is the ingredient that transforms Hong Shao Niu Rou Mian from a rich soup into a perfectly balanced one — its sourness cuts through the deeply savory broth and prevents flavor fatigue. Never skip it. Find it at Taiwanese or Chinese grocery stores. It keeps refrigerated for weeks and makes the soup every time.

[High Protein] [Classic Taiwanese] [Weekend Project] [National Dish]

RECIPE 383

■ ■ Taiwan

BA WAN

TAIWANESE STEAMED PORK MEATBALL

One of Taiwan's most iconic street foods — a translucent, gelatinous sweet potato starch wrapper encasing a filling of pork, bamboo shoots, and shiitake mushrooms, steamed until gloriously wobbly and served with a sweet-savory sauce. Ba wan (包丸) is Changhua County's greatest culinary contribution to Taiwan, eaten since the Japanese colonial era. The wrapper's texture — simultaneously gelatinous, chewy, and almost transparent — is unique in all of Asian breakfast cuisine.

INGREDIENTS

WRAPPER DOUGH

- 200g (1¾ cups) sweet potato starch (■■■■ — specifically sweet potato starch, not regular starch)
- 50g (■ cup) tapioca starch
- 300ml (1¼ cups) cold water
- 200ml (¾ cup) boiling water
- 1 tsp salt

FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) minced pork
- 100g (3.5 oz) fresh or canned bamboo shoots, finely diced
- 3 dried shiitake mushrooms, soaked and finely diced
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp oyster sauce
- 2 green onions, minced
- SAUCE (sweet-savory dipping):
- 3 tbsp soy sauce
- 2 tbsp hoisin sauce
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 1 tsp sesame oil
- 3 tbsp water — simmer together until slightly thickened

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Combine all filling ingredients. Mix well. Sauté in 1 tbsp oil 5–7 minutes until pork is cooked and filling is fragrant. Cool completely.
2. WRAPPER: Mix sweet potato starch and tapioca starch. Add cold water. Stir until combined.
3. Pour boiling water over the starch mixture while stirring rapidly — a portion of the starch will partially cook and thicken.
4. Add salt. Mix until smooth — the dough should be thick and translucent, slightly gelatinous.
5. Grease small bowls or ramekins (10cm) generously.
6. Pour a 5mm layer of dough into each bowl. Place 2 tbsp filling in the center.
7. Pour enough dough over the filling to cover completely, building to about 2cm total depth.
8. Steam over high heat 12–15 minutes until the wrapper is cooked through and translucent.
9. SAUCE: Combine all sauce ingredients in a small pan. Simmer 3 minutes until slightly thickened. Cool.
10. Serve ba wan in the bowls or unmolded on plates.
11. Pour sweet-savory sauce generously over each ba wan.
12. Eat with a spoon — they are eaten from the bowl or scraped off the plate with a spoon.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~285 per ba wan

TIP

Sweet potato starch is non-negotiable for the correct texture — it creates the characteristic gelatinous, almost glassy wrapper that wobbles when shaken. Regular cornstarch or tapioca starch alone creates a harder, less translucent wrapper. The combination of hot-water partial cooking during mixing is also essential — it creates the initial structure that the steaming finishes.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Taiwanese] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 384

■■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE OYSTER OMELETTE

E-A JIAN / O-A-JIAN

Taiwan's most celebrated night market and morning street food — plump, briny oysters cooked with a sweet potato starch mixture that creates a thick, chewy, slightly gelatinous pancake base, scrambled egg folded over, and served with a sweet-spicy red sauce and garlic and coriander. The texture is unlike any Western omelette — simultaneously crispy at the edges, gelatinous in the center, and intensely savory from the oysters. A Taiwanese breakfast masterpiece.

INGREDIENTS

STARCH MIXTURE

- 3 tbsp sweet potato starch
- 100ml (■ cup) cold water
- Mix together until dissolved — this mixture is poured
- into the pan with the oysters

FILLING AND COOKING

- 150g (5 oz) fresh oysters (the small, plump variety —
- Pacific oysters, drained)
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 1 cup garland chrysanthemum leaves or baby spinach
- 2 tbsp neutral oil (or lard — traditional)
- Salt and white pepper
- SAUCE (non-negotiable):
- 3 tbsp ketchup
- 2 tbsp hoisin sauce
- 1 tbsp sweet chilli sauce
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp garlic, minced
- Mix together until smooth

GARNISH

- Fresh coriander
- Sliced fresh red chilli

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SAUCE: Combine all sauce ingredients. Mix until smooth. Set aside in a squeeze bottle if possible — it should be drizzled in loops over the finished dish.
2. Heat oil in a wide pan over medium-high heat.
3. Add oysters in a single layer. Fry 1 minute until edges begin to curl slightly.
4. Pour starch-water mixture over and around the oysters. The mixture will spread and begin to cook into a translucent, slightly gelatinous base.
5. While the starch base is still partially wet, pour beaten egg over the entire surface.
6. As the egg begins to set, fold the omelette in half — the egg should encase the oysters and starch.
7. Add garland chrysanthemum or spinach around the edges. Let wilt briefly.
8. Flip the omelette carefully. Cook 1 minute more.
9. Transfer to a plate, green leaves on top.
10. Drizzle sauce in a zigzag pattern over the entire dish.
11. Scatter fresh coriander and sliced chilli.
12. Serve immediately.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The starch-water mixture creates the gelatinous base that distinguishes this from a regular omelette. The starch must be added to the pan before the egg — it needs to be partially set before the egg goes over it. If egg goes in first, the dish becomes a standard omelette without the characteristic texture. Work in sequence: oil → oysters → starch → egg.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Taiwanese] [Night Market Icon]

RECIPE 385

■ ■ Taiwan

TIAN BU LA

TAIWANESE FISH CAKE SKEWERS IN BROTH

A beloved Taiwanese morning snack — fish cakes, fried tofu, and daikon simmered in a light, kombu-dashi broth and served on skewers with a thick, sweet-savory sauce. Inspired by Japanese oden brought during the colonial era, Taiwan's tian bu la has evolved into its own distinct street food culture. Sold at dedicated tian bu la stalls with enormous pots of fragrant broth from which customers select their preferred items. Eaten for breakfast and at all hours.

INGREDIENTS

TIAN BU LA BROTH

- 1.5L (6 cups) dashi broth (kombu + dried bonito flakes)
- or light chicken broth
- 3 tbsp light soy sauce
- 1 tbsp mirin or sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- ITEMS FOR SIMMERING (choose your selection):
- Taiwanese fish cake (鱼丸), sliced into rounds
- Fried tofu puffs (炸豆腐)
- Daikon radish, thick rounds, blanched 10 min first
- Konjac knots or konjac cake
- Boiled eggs, peeled
- Fish balls
- Pork blood cake (optional)

DIPPING SAUCE

- 3 tbsp miso paste
- 2 tbsp tahini or sesame paste
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp chilli paste
- 2 tbsp warm water
- Mix until smooth

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: Combine dashi or chicken broth with soy sauce, mirin, and salt. Bring to a gentle simmer.
2. Add blanched daikon first (it takes longest to flavor). Simmer 30 minutes.
3. Add fish cakes, tofu puffs, konjac, and fish balls. Simmer 15 minutes.
4. Add boiled eggs. Simmer 10 minutes. All items should be fully flavored by the broth.
5. DIPPING SAUCE: Mix all sauce ingredients until smooth. Add warm water to reach a drizzling consistency.
6. SERVING: Skewer individual items on bamboo skewers.
7. Arrange in a bowl. Ladle a small amount of broth over the items.
8. Drizzle or smear the dipping sauce generously.
9. Serve with a small bowl of broth on the side for sipping.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The broth for tian bu la improves significantly with time — leftover items soaked in broth overnight absorb deeper flavor and are considered superior the next morning. Taiwanese stall operators keep their broth pots running continuously, adding new stock and items throughout the day. The "old" broth at a famous tian bu la stall is a mark of quality, not neglect.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Taiwanese] [Japanese Influence]

RECIPE 386

■■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE PINEAPPLE CAKE

FENG LI SU

Taiwan's most famous export food and beloved breakfast pastry — a buttery, crumbly shortbread shell encasing a thick, jammy pineapple filling with a perfect balance of sweet and tart. Eaten for breakfast with Taiwanese oolong or green tea throughout Taiwan, and given as gifts to visitors because one bite communicates everything essential about Taiwanese pastry craft. The best feng li su are made with fresh pineapple jam, not canned — and the difference is immediately and dramatically apparent.

INGREDIENTS

- PINEAPPLE JAM FILLING (make 1–2 days ahead):
- 1 whole fresh pineapple (about 800g flesh),
- finely grated or processed
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- 2 tbsp maltose syrup (■■■■) or golden syrup
- (creates the characteristic sticky, jammy texture)
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Pinch of salt

SHORTBREAD SHELL

- 200g (1½ cups + 2 tbsp) all-purpose flour
- 30g (3 tbsp) milk powder
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, cold, cubed
- 50g (¼ cup) powdered sugar
- 2 large egg yolks
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PINEAPPLE JAM: Grate or process pineapple finely. Squeeze out and discard half the juice — too much liquid creates a watery jam.
2. Combine pineapple flesh, sugar, maltose, butter, and salt in a heavy saucepan.
3. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, 30–40 minutes until the jam is thick, deep golden, and does not spread when dropped on a cold plate. It should be sticky and hold its shape.
4. Cool. Refrigerate. Divide into 16 portions.
5. SHORTBREAD SHELL: Beat cold butter and powdered sugar until pale and fluffy. Add egg yolks and vanilla.
6. Sift flour, milk powder, and salt over the mixture. Fold until just combined — a crumbly dough.
7. Divide into 16 equal portions.
8. ASSEMBLE: Flatten a dough portion in your palm. Place one filling portion in the center. Wrap dough carefully around the filling, pressing to seal completely.
9. Shape into a rectangle using a rectangular mold (traditional) or by hand.
10. Place on lined baking sheet.
11. Bake at 170°C (340°F) for 15–18 minutes until the shell is pale golden and firm.
12. Cool completely before eating — they firm and improve dramatically after cooling.
13. Best eaten at room temperature with oolong tea.

Prep: 30 min + 1 hr jam making · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~185 per cake

TIP

Cooking the pineapple jam until it is truly thick and concentrated — not just soft — is the most critical step. Under-cooked jam is wet and makes the shortbread shell soggy from within. The jam should be dense enough to hold its shape when rolled into a ball between your palms. If it sticks and spreads, cook longer.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Taiwanese] [Pastry] [Cultural Export] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 387

■■ Taiwan

BROWN SUGAR BOBA MILK TEA

HEIHONG TANG ZHENZU NAICHA

Taiwan's most globally recognized export — the Tiger Sugar style brown sugar boba milk tea that launched the worldwide bubble tea obsession. Freshly cooked black tapioca pearls simmered in brown sugar syrup until thick, glossy, and deeply caramelized, layered in a cup with fresh whole milk (no tea in the classic version — pure milk and brown sugar pearls). Drunk through a wide straw, the pearls rush up first — chewy, sweet, warm — then the cold milk.

INGREDIENTS

BLACK TAPIOCA PEARLS

- 100g (½ cup) dried large black tapioca pearls
- (boba — specifically large, 8–10mm, black variety)
- Water for boiling (plenty)

BROWN SUGAR SYRUP

- 100g (½ cup) brown sugar (dark, unrefined preferred)
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) water
- Simmer 5 minutes until thick syrup forms.

PER GLASS

- 80–100g cooked tapioca pearls
- 150ml (⅔ cup) full cream fresh milk, cold
- 2 tbsp brown sugar syrup
- Ice (optional for cold version)
- No tea — this is pure milk and caramelized pearls

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **COOK PEARLS:** Bring a large pot of water to a full boil. Add dried tapioca pearls. Do NOT reduce heat.
2. Boil over high heat 20–25 minutes, stirring every 5 minutes to prevent sticking.
3. When pearls are cooked through (test by biting — should be uniformly chewy with no hard white center), drain and rinse briefly in cold water.
4. Immediately add hot drained pearls to the brown sugar syrup pot. Toss to coat completely.
5. Cook pearls in the syrup over medium heat 3–5 minutes until deeply caramelized and the syrup thickens and coats each pearl in a glossy shell.
6. The syrup will reduce and turn very thick.
7. **ASSEMBLE:** Drizzle extra brown sugar syrup in streaks down the inside of a glass — this creates the tiger stripe pattern.
8. Add hot caramelized pearls to the glass.
9. Pour cold full cream milk over the pearls from the opposite side of the glass.
10. The layers will separate briefly — milk above, dark pearls below — before mixing as you drink.
11. Serve with an oversized boba straw.
12. Drink without stirring first — experience the layers.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per glass

TIP

Tapioca pearls must be cooked and served immediately — they harden within 4 hours and cannot be rehydrated once they firm up. Cook only what you need. The brown sugar syrup coating keeps them slightly softer for longer than unseasoned pearls, but still — eat within 2 hours for the ideal texture.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Taiwanese] [Global Icon] [Sweet]

RECIPE 388

■■ Taiwan

TAIWANESE SCALLION PANCAKE

Taiwan's breakfast sandwich evolution — a freshly cooked scallion pancake (cong you bing) layered with a fried egg, cheese, ham, and sweet soy sauce, the whole thing folded into a warm parcel. The Taiwanese breakfast shop (■■■■) version of fast food — assembled in 2 minutes from components kept warm throughout the morning rush. The layered scallion pancake creates crunch and flaky texture that no bread can replicate.

INGREDIENTS

- SCALLION PANCAKE (make as Recipe 256 or buy frozen):
- Scallion pancake dough (see Recipe 256)
- OR: frozen scallion pancakes (green onion pancakes),
- widely available at Asian grocery stores

PER SANDWICH

- 1 large egg
- 1 slice processed cheese (the Taiwanese way — sharp American-style cheese works too)
- 1–2 slices ham or roasted pork (char siu)
- ½ tsp sweet soy sauce (as Recipe 379)
- ½ tsp sriracha or chilli sauce (optional)
- 1 tsp Kewpie mayonnaise (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. COOK SCALLION PANCAKE: Follow Recipe 256 method, or cook frozen pancake according to package. Cook until very crispy and golden.
2. WHILE PANCAKE IS COOKING: Crack egg onto the same pan alongside the pancake (or in a separate pan). Break the yolk. Fry until fully set on both sides — the Taiwanese prefer a firm, not runny, egg for this sandwich.
3. Add cheese slice on top of the frying egg. Let it melt slightly.
4. ASSEMBLE on the hot pancake: — Drizzle sweet soy sauce over the pancake surface. — Add mayo if using. — Layer ham slices. — Add the egg with melted cheese on top. — Add chilli sauce if desired.
5. Fold the pancake over the fillings to create a half-moon shape OR fold like a burrito — up and over.
6. Press firmly. Cut in half.
7. Wrap in paper if eating on the go.
8. Eat immediately while the pancake is crispy.

Prep: 5 min (if pancake is pre-made) · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~490 per sandwich

TIP

The egg yolk should be broken and cooked fully for a scallion pancake sandwich — a runny yolk soaks the layers and makes the crispy pancake soggy. The firm egg also acts as a structural layer that prevents the filling from falling out when folded. Taiwanese breakfast shops always break the yolk.

[High Protein] [Classic Taiwanese] [Quick] [Breakfast Shop]

RECIPE 389

■■ Taiwan / ■■ Hong Kong

YUAN YANG

HONG KONG / TAIWANESE COFFEE-TEA

The legendary hybrid drink — equal parts strong Hong Kong milk tea and dark coffee, mixed together, served hot or iced with evaporated milk and condensed milk. Named after the Mandarin duck (yuanyang symbolizes complementary opposites), it is the drink that proves two things thought incompatible can create something greater than both. Equally beloved in Hong Kong and Taiwan, drunk at cha chaan tengs and Taiwanese kopitiam from morning to late night.

INGREDIENTS

STRONG MILK TEA COMPONENT

- 2 tbsp strong Ceylon black tea leaves (or Hong Kong-
- style blended tea)
- 200ml (¾ cup) water, just boiled
- Brew 4 minutes. Strain. Very strong.

COFFEE COMPONENT

- 2 tbsp dark ground coffee or instant coffee dissolved
- in 100ml hot water (strong, dark)

PER GLASS

- 100ml brewed tea
- 100ml brewed coffee
- 3 tbsp evaporated milk
- 1 tbsp sweetened condensed milk (adjust to taste)

FOR ICED VERSION

- Prepare both components double-strength. Ice. Pour.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew tea very strong — 4 minutes, not less. Strain into a vessel.
2. Brew coffee strong — as dark as you prefer.
3. COMBINE: Mix brewed tea and brewed coffee together. The ratio is traditionally 7:3 tea to coffee (Hong Kong style) OR 5:5 equal parts (Taiwan style). Adjust to your preference.
4. Add evaporated milk and condensed milk.
5. Stir well. Taste — it should be simultaneously tea-forward and coffee-forward, creamy, and sweet.
6. FOR HOT YUAN YANG: Serve immediately in a ceramic cup.
7. FOR ICED YUAN YANG: Pour over ice in a tall glass. Layer evaporated milk by pouring it slowly over the back of a spoon to create a floating layer.
8. Do not stir — drink the layers in sequence or mix.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~150 per cup

TIP

The ratio of tea to coffee is deeply personal in yuan yang culture. Hong Kongers traditionally use more tea (7:3). Taiwanese versions often go 50:50. Try both ratios and find your preferred expression. The condensed milk quantity is equally personal — some prefer very sweet yuan yang, others barely sweet. This drink rewards personal calibration.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic HK/Taiwan] [Cultural Icon]

Sri Lanka

RECIPE 390

■ Sri Lanka

HOPPERS / APPA

SRI LANKAN COCONUT RICE BOWL CRÊPES

Sri Lanka's most iconic breakfast — thin, crispy-edged rice and coconut milk crêpes cooked in a small, rounded wok to create a bowl shape: crispy and golden at the edges, soft and custardy at the center. Eaten plain, with a raw egg cracked into the center before cooking (egg hopper), or with coconut milk (milk hopper). Always accompanied by sambol (coconut relish), dhal, and a fiery seeni sambol (caramelized onion relish). The hopper pan — the appa chatty — is Sri Lanka's most essential kitchen tool.

INGREDIENTS

- HOPPER BATTER (make 8–12 hrs ahead):
- 2 cups white raw rice, soaked 6 hours and ground
- OR: 2 cups rice flour (easier, slightly less authentic)
- 200ml (¾ cup) thick coconut milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) thin coconut milk
- 1 tsp instant yeast dissolved in 2 tbsp warm water
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- POL SAMBOL (COCONUT SAMBOL — ESSENTIAL):
- 1 cup freshly grated coconut (or frozen)
- 2 tsp red chilli flakes
- 2 tbsp finely diced red onion
- 1 tbsp lime juice
- Salt to taste
- 1 tsp Maldive fish (umbalakada — dried cured tuna, ground) — optional but traditional

SEENI SAMBOL (CARMELIZED ONION RELISH)

- 4 large onions, very thinly sliced
- 3 tbsp oil
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp vinegar
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BATTER (night before): If using soaked raw rice, grind with coconut milk until very smooth. Mix with yeast water and sugar. Cover. Ferment 8–12 hours. The batter should rise slightly and develop a pleasant tang. If using rice flour: combine flour, coconut milk, yeast water, sugar, and salt. Ferment 4–6 hours.
2. SEENI SAMBOL: Heat oil. Fry onions over very low heat 25–30 minutes until very dark and caramelized. Add chilli, turmeric, sugar, vinegar, and salt. Cook 5 more minutes. Cool. (Keeps 2 weeks refrigerated.)
3. POL SAMBOL: Combine grated coconut, chilli flakes, onion, lime juice, and salt. Mix thoroughly — the coconut should turn slightly pink from the chilli. Add ground Maldive fish if using.
4. COOKING HOPPERS: Add salt to batter. It should be slightly thinner than dosa batter — add a little water if needed.
5. Heat an appa chatty (small rounded wok) or a small non-stick wok over medium-high heat. Oil very lightly.
6. Pour a small ladleful of batter into the center.
7. IMMEDIATELY swirl the pan in a circular motion — the batter should travel up the sides, leaving a thick center and very thin, almost lacy edges.
8. Cover with a lid. Cook 2–3 minutes until the edges are golden and beginning to crisp, and the center is cooked through but still slightly custardy.
9. EGG HOPPER: After swirling, crack an egg into the center before covering. The egg cooks as the hopper cooks.
10. Remove without flipping — hoppers are one-sided only.
11. Serve immediately with pol sambol and seeni sambol.

Prep: 20 min + 8-12 hrs fermentation · Cook: 3 min per hopper · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving (2 hoppers + sambols)

TIP

The swirl after pouring batter is everything — it must be done immediately, in one fast circular motion, before the batter sets on the hot pan. A slow or hesitant swirl creates an uneven hopper with thick edges and a thin center — the opposite of correct. Practice with the first hopper and the technique comes quickly.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Sri Lankan] [National Breakfast]

RECIPE 391

■ ■ Sri Lanka

STRING HOPPERS / IDIYAPPAM

STEAMED RICE NOODLE NESTS

Delicate, lacy rice noodle nests — pressed from rice flour dough through a special mold (idiyappam press) onto small woven mats and steamed. Eaten with coconut milk, seeni sambol, or dhal. String hoppers are lighter and more delicate than regular hoppers — an intricate breakfast that rewards patience with extraordinary tenderness. Sri Lanka and Kerala share this breakfast, each claiming it as their own. Both are correct.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups rice flour (idiyappam flour — roasted rice flour, slightly coarser than regular. Find at Sri Lankan or South Indian stores)
- 400ml (1½ cups) boiling water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp oil
- Extra rice flour for dusting mats

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Thin coconut milk sweetened with sugar (for dipping)
- Pol sambol (coconut sambol — Recipe 390)
- Dhal curry (see Recipe 267 for method)
- Seeni sambol (caramelized onion — Recipe 390)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place rice flour in a bowl. Add salt and oil.
2. Pour boiling water gradually over the flour while stirring with a wooden spoon.
3. Mix quickly — the hot water cooks the flour partially. The dough will be very hot.
4. Knead while still warm (use a cloth to protect hands) for 3–4 minutes until smooth and pliable.
5. The dough should be soft enough to press through the idiyappam mold easily without crumbling. If too dry, add 1–2 tsp more hot water.
6. Load the dough into an idiyappam press (or a potato ricer with the fine disc — an acceptable substitute).
7. Press directly onto small greased round mats (or circles of banana leaf or parchment paper), making concentric circular motions to create neat noodle nests (8–10cm diameter, 1cm thick).
8. Place filled mats in a steamer. Steam 7–8 minutes until noodles are cooked through and no longer opaque.
9. Carefully remove nests from the mats. They should be delicate, soft, and slightly translucent.
10. Serve immediately with sweetened coconut milk, pol sambol, and dhal poured over or alongside.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 4

TIP

Hot water is the key — the partial pre-cooking of the rice flour with boiling water creates a dough that steams into a soft, yielding texture rather than a hard, starchy one. Cold water produces grainy, brittle string hoppers that crumble when touched. Work with the dough while it is still as hot as handleable.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Sri Lankan] [Traditional]

RECIPE 392

■ Sri Lanka

POL ROTI

SRI LANKAN COCONUT FLATBREAD

Sri Lanka's everyday flatbread — whole wheat flour mixed with freshly grated coconut, green chilli, and onion into a soft dough and cooked on a hot griddle until the coconut caramelizes and the exterior is golden. Eaten for breakfast with dhal, lunu miris (red onion and chilli sambal), or simply with butter and jam. The grated coconut in the dough creates a slightly sweet, moist crumb that is entirely Sri Lankan and immediately addictive.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- OR: 1 cup whole wheat + 1 cup plain flour for a slightly softer result
- 1 cup freshly grated coconut (essential — desiccated coconut is a poor substitute)
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 2–3 green chillies, very finely chopped
- 8–10 fresh curry leaves, finely chopped
- ½ tsp salt
- Water to bind (approximately 80–100ml warm water)

FOR SERVING

- Dhal curry or pol sambol
- Lunu miris (pound together: 2 red onions + 2 tsp red chilli flakes + 1 tsp Maldiva fish + lime juice + salt)
- Butter and jam (the Western-influenced version)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, grated coconut, onion, green chilli, curry leaves, and salt in a bowl.
2. Add warm water gradually, mixing to form a soft, slightly sticky dough — the coconut adds moisture.
3. Knead gently 3 minutes.
4. Divide into 6–8 equal balls.
5. On a lightly floured surface, press each ball flat with your palm into a round (1.5cm thick, 12cm wide). Do not roll with a rolling pin — press flat by hand. Pol roti should be thick and irregular, not thin and uniform.
6. Heat a heavy flat pan or tawa over medium heat. No oil needed — the coconut has enough fat.
7. Cook pol roti on the dry pan 3–4 minutes per side until golden patches form and the coconut inside caramelizes slightly, creating dark spots.
8. Serve hot with dhal and lunu miris.

Prep: 15 min • Cook: 8 min per roti • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~285 per roti

TIP

Fresh grated coconut is what makes pol roti extraordinary — the coconut flesh caramelizes against the hot pan, creating pockets of toasted sweetness within the bread. Desiccated (dried) coconut creates a much drier, less flavorful result. If fresh coconut is unavailable, use frozen grated coconut thawed completely and at room temperature.

[Vegan] [Classic Sri Lankan] [Quick] [Everyday Breakfast]

RECIPE 393

■■ Sri Lanka

KIRIBATH

SRI LANKAN COCONUT MILK RICE — MILK RICE

Sri Lanka's auspicious breakfast — rice cooked entirely in coconut milk until thick and set, pressed into a flat square, cooled until firm, and cut into diamond shapes. Eaten on New Year's Day (Sinhala and Tamil New Year), at every celebration, and on the first morning of a new endeavor. Kiribath is simultaneously the simplest and most sacred of Sri Lankan breakfasts. Eaten with lunu miris (hot onion sambol) — the contrast of rich, creamy rice against sharp, fiery relish is perfectly Sri Lankan.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups short-grain or medium-grain white rice, rinsed
- 800ml (3■ cups) thick coconut milk (full fat)
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 pandan leaves, knotted (optional but traditional)
- LUNU MIRIS (fiery onion sambol — serve alongside):
 - 3 red onions, very finely diced
 - 2 tbsp red chilli flakes (Colombo chilli preferred)
 - 1 tsp ground Maldive fish (umbalakada) or
 - ½ tsp dried shrimp powder
 - 1 tbsp lime juice
 - Salt to taste
 - Pound together in a mortar to a coarse paste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rinsed rice, coconut milk, water, salt, and pandan leaves in a heavy saucepan.
2. Bring to a boil over medium heat, stirring frequently — coconut milk burns on the bottom if unattended.
3. Reduce heat to low. Cover tightly.
4. Cook 15 minutes, lifting the lid and stirring every 5 minutes to prevent sticking and burning.
5. The rice should absorb all the coconut milk and become very thick, creamy, and slightly sticky. If still liquid, cook uncovered 5 more minutes.
6. Remove pandan leaves.
7. While hot, spread the cooked rice onto a flat, slightly moistened plate or banana leaf in an even layer approximately 2–3cm thick.
8. Smooth the surface with the back of a wet spoon.
9. Cool to room temperature — then refrigerate 30 minutes until the kiribath firms enough to slice cleanly.
10. Cut into diamond or square shapes with a sharp knife.
11. Serve at room temperature with lunu miris alongside.
12. Each piece of kiribath is dipped or eaten alongside the fiery lunu miris.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 25 min + 30 min cooling · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Kiribath must be completely cooled before cutting — warm kiribath crumbles and falls apart. The cooling and light refrigeration allows the coconut fat to re-solidify, making the rice hold together cleanly when cut into diamonds. Use a sharp, wet knife for the cleanest cuts.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Sri Lankan] [Auspicious] [Festive]

RECIPE 394

■■ Sri Lanka

KOTTU ROTI

CHOPPED ROTI STIR-FRY

Sri Lanka's most theatrical street food — leftover roti or flatbread chopped rhythmically into fine pieces on a flat iron griddle with two metal blades, then stir-fried with egg, vegetables, curry sauce, and your choice of protein. The rhythmic metallic clanging of the blades is one of Sri Lanka's most distinctive street sounds. Kottu is both breakfast and late-night food, eaten with equal passion at 7am and at 2am in equal measure.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large pieces leftover roti, paratha, or any flatbread — cut/torn into thin strips (this is the "kottu" — chopped roti)
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 1 carrot, julienned
- ½ cabbage (about 200g), thinly shredded
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2cm fresh ginger, grated
- 1 onion, thinly sliced
- 2 green chillies, sliced
- 10 fresh curry leaves
- 2 tbsp curry sauce (leftover chicken or vegetable curry — THIS IS THE SECRET. Kottu made without leftover curry sauce is just stir-fried bread.)
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp pepper powder (black or white)
- Salt to taste
- 3 tbsp oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat a flat iron griddle or large non-stick pan over very high heat. Add oil.
2. Add onion and curry leaves. Stir-fry 2 minutes.
3. Add garlic, ginger, and green chilli. 30 seconds.
4. Add carrot. Stir-fry 1 minute.
5. Add roti strips. Press against the griddle. Using two spatulas, chop the roti into smaller and smaller pieces while stir-frying — this is the "kottu" technique. The pieces should reduce to roughly 1–2cm irregular pieces.
6. Add beaten egg. Fold into the roti pieces.
7. Add shredded cabbage. Toss vigorously.
8. Add curry sauce, soy sauce, and pepper. Toss everything to coat the roti pieces in curry.
9. Continue chopping and tossing until the roti is uniformly flavored and slightly caramelized.
10. Add green onion. Final toss.
11. Taste: it should be savory, slightly spiced, and deeply flavored from the curry sauce.
12. Serve in a banana leaf or on a plate with extra curry sauce on the side.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The leftover curry sauce is the ingredient that elevates kottu from scrambled bread to something extraordinary. Kottu stalls in Sri Lanka are positioned alongside curry shops specifically because leftover curry sauce is their most essential ingredient. If you have no leftover curry, make a quick version: onion fried with curry powder, coconut milk, and salt.

[High Protein] [Classic Sri Lankan] [Street Food] [Zero Waste]

Nepal

RECIPE 395

■ Sri Lanka

WATALAPPAN

SRI LANKAN COCONUT JAGGERY PUDDING

Sri Lanka's beloved Malay-influenced steamed pudding — a spiced coconut milk and jaggery custard with cardamom, nutmeg, and cashews, brought to Sri Lanka by Malay immigrants in the 18th century. Eaten as a breakfast dessert for special occasions, at Eid celebrations, and at Sri Lankan weddings. Dense, trembling, and deeply fragrant with jaggery's earthy sweetness and the warmth of the spice combination that is uniquely Sri Lankan.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 200g (1 cup) kithul jaggery (Sri Lankan palm sugar) or
- dark palm sugar/muscovado — finely grated or roughly chopped
- 400ml (1 can) thick coconut milk
- 1 tsp ground cardamom (freshly ground preferred)
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- ½ tsp ground cloves
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- 50g (½ cup) raw cashews, halved

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place grated jaggery in a saucepan with 3 tbsp water. Heat gently until dissolved. Cool to lukewarm.
2. Beat eggs gently in a large bowl — do not whisk vigorously (air creates bubbles and a porous texture).
3. Add dissolved jaggery to eggs. Stir gently.
4. Add coconut milk. Stir to combine.
5. Add cardamom, nutmeg, cloves, vanilla, and salt. Stir again.
6. Strain through a fine sieve into a smooth mixture — this removes egg threads and any undissolved jaggery.
7. Stir in cashew halves.
8. Pour into a well-greased deep baking dish or individual ramekins.
9. Place in a steamer. Steam over medium heat — NOT high heat — 40–45 minutes until just set. Test with a skewer: it should come out just barely clean. A slight wobble at the center is correct.
10. Cool completely. Refrigerate 2 hours before serving.
11. Unmold or serve in the ramekins. The watalappan should be smooth, firm, and deeply brown-caramel colored.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 45 min + 2 hrs chilling · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Kithul jaggery (tapped from the kithul palm tree) has a deep, complex, slightly smoky sweetness entirely different from sugarcane jaggery or refined sugar. It is Sri Lanka's most distinctive sweetener and the heart of watalappan's flavor. Dark muscovado sugar is the closest widely available substitute — it provides similar depth if kithul is unavailable.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Sri Lankan] [Festive] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 396

■■ Nepal

SEL ROTI

NEPALI SWEET RICE DOUGHNUTS

Nepal's most beloved festival and everyday breakfast sweet — crispy, golden ring-shaped doughnuts made from rice flour, banana, and sugar batter, deep-fried until perfectly circular and uniformly golden. Made during Dashain and Tihar festivals but eaten year-round for breakfast with yogurt (dahi) and potato curry (aloo ko tarkari). The crunch of fresh sel roti against the cool tang of yogurt is one of Nepal's great breakfast pleasures.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups coarse rice flour (ideally soaked rice ground)
- fresh, but store-bought coarse rice flour works)
- 1 ripe banana, mashed
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp cardamom powder
- ½ tsp fennel seeds, lightly crushed
- Pinch of salt
- 200–250ml (¾–1 cup) warm water (enough to make
- a thick, pourable batter)
- Vegetable oil for deep frying

FOR SERVING

- Plain yogurt (dahi), cold
- Aloo ko tarkari: potatoes boiled, then cooked with
- onion, tomato, turmeric, cumin, and coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mash banana until completely smooth.
2. Combine rice flour, mashed banana, sugar, cardamom, fennel, and salt.
3. Add warm water gradually, stirring, until a thick but pourable batter forms — it should flow slowly from a spoon and hold a ribbon shape briefly.
4. Rest 15 minutes to let flour hydrate.
5. Heat oil in a deep wok or pot to 170°C (340°F).
6. SHAPING SEL ROTI: Pour the batter into a squeeze bottle, plastic bag with corner cut, or cone made from plastic wrap.
7. Pipe batter directly into the hot oil in a circular motion — starting small and spiraling outward to create a ring shape (12–15cm diameter).
8. Pipe the circle back over itself to seal and thicken. The ring should be about 1.5cm thick.
9. Fry 2–3 minutes per side until deeply golden. Turn gently with tongs — sel roti is fragile while hot.
10. Drain on paper towels.
11. Serve warm with cold yogurt and aloo curry alongside.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~265 per sel roti

TIP

The circular piping motion must be done continuously without stopping — any break creates a gap in the ring that causes the sel roti to break during frying. Practice the full circular pipe motion once or twice in the air before attempting it over hot oil. Speed and confidence create the perfect ring shape.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nepali] [Festive] [Sweet]

RECIPE 397

■■ Nepal

DHIDO WITH GUNDRUK SOUP

Nepal's mountain breakfast — buckwheat or millet flour stirred vigorously into boiling water until it forms a thick, smooth, glutinous porridge. Eaten with gundruk — Nepal's fermented, dried leafy green vegetable soup that has a tangy, slightly pungent depth. Together, dhido and gundruk represent Nepal's high-altitude sustenance — calorie-dense, warming, and built for the energy demands of Himalayan morning life.

INGREDIENTS

DHIDO

- 2 cups buckwheat flour (or millet flour — both traditional. Buckwheat has a nuttier flavor)
- 600ml (2½ cups) boiling water
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 tbsp ghee (optional — for richness)

GUNDRUK SOUP

- 50g (2 oz) dried gundruk (fermented dried mustard
- or radish leaves — available at Nepali grocery stores.
- Substitute: kim chee with extra souring OR finely shredded and fermented mustard greens)
- 1 small onion, diced
- 2 tomatoes, chopped
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- 1 green chilli, sliced
- 2 tbsp oil
- Salt to taste
- 500ml (2 cups) water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GUNDRUK SOUP: Soak dried gundruk in warm water 15 minutes. Drain. Squeeze lightly.
2. Heat oil. Add cumin seeds. Pop briefly.
3. Add onion. Cook 5 minutes. Add garlic and ginger.
4. Add tomatoes. Cook until broken down.
5. Add rehydrated gundruk. Stir to coat in masala.
6. Add turmeric and green chilli.
7. Add water. Simmer 15 minutes.
8. Season with salt. The soup should be tangy, savory, and slightly pungent from the fermented greens.
9. DHIDO: Bring water and salt to a rolling boil in a heavy pot.
10. Reduce heat to medium-low. Add buckwheat flour in a thin, steady stream while stirring vigorously with a wooden spoon.
11. The mixture will thicken rapidly. Continue stirring without stopping for 8–10 minutes, using a strong circular motion. The dhido should be very thick, smooth, and beginning to pull away from the pot sides.
12. Add ghee if using. Stir in.
13. Shape into portions using a wet spoon or your hands — form into smooth mounds.
14. Serve immediately alongside hot gundruk soup. Eat by tearing pieces of dhido and dipping into the soup.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Continuous, vigorous stirring is essential for smooth dhido — stopping even briefly allows lumps to form that cannot be removed once set. Use a strong wooden spoon or heavy spatula. The dhido is ready when it forms a single smooth mass that pulls cleanly from the pot. Weak stirring creates lumpy, grainy dhido.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nepali] [Mountain Food] [High Altitude]

RECIPE 398

■ ■ Nepal (Newari community)

YOMARI

NEPALI STEAMED RICE DUMPLING WITH JAGGERY

A Newari cultural treasure and sacred breakfast food of the Kathmandu Valley — fish-shaped steamed rice flour dumplings filled with chaku (hardened molasses mixed with sesame and coconut) or sweetened lentil paste. Made during the Yomari Punhi festival to celebrate the rice harvest, but eaten year-round at Newari households for special morning occasions. The fish shape represents good fortune, and each dumpling is a blessing in edible form.

INGREDIENTS

RICE DOUGH

- 2 cups rice flour (coarse, not fine)
- 400ml (1½ cups) warm water
- ½ tsp salt
- CHAKU FILLING (most traditional):
- 100g (½ cup) molasses or dark jaggery
- 50g (½ cup) freshly grated coconut
- 2 tbsp sesame seeds, toasted
- ½ tsp cardamom powder
- ALTERNATIVE FILLING (khuwa/khoya):
- 100g (3.5 oz) khoya (dried milk solids),
- crumbled and mixed with 2 tbsp sugar and cardamom

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Melt jaggery/molasses in a small pan. Add coconut, sesame, and cardamom. Cook until thick and set enough to roll. Cool and divide into small cone shapes. Set aside firm.
2. DOUGH: Pour warm water over rice flour. Add salt. Knead while warm into a smooth, pliable dough. The warmth of the water makes it easier to work.
3. Pinch off golf-ball-sized pieces of dough.
4. YOMARI SHAPING: Roll each piece into a smooth ball. Make a hole in the top with your thumb. Work the dough into a small cup shape, thinning the walls progressively.
5. Place filling inside. Close the top, pinching firmly.
6. Shape into a fish — elongate one end to a tail, taper the other end to a head. Flatten slightly.
7. Use a chopstick to score fin and scale details into the dough surface (traditional decoration).
8. Place on greased banana leaf squares in a steamer.
9. Steam 12–15 minutes until the dough is cooked and no longer looks raw.
10. Cool slightly before eating — the filling is extremely hot directly from the steamer.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~195 per yomari

TIP

The wall thickness of the yomari is critical — too thin and the dough tears during shaping or steaming; too thick and the yomari is doughy and heavy. Aim for a consistent 4–5mm wall. Work the dough while it is still warm from the hot water — it becomes less pliable as it cools.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nepali] [Newari Heritage] [Festive]

Pakistan

RECIPE 399

■ ■ Pakistan (Lahore)

HALWA PURI WITH ALOO CHANAY

The Lahori Sunday morning institution — puri (deep-fried puffed bread) with suji halwa (sweet semolina), aloo chanay (spiced potatoes and chickpeas), and occasionally achaar. Eaten at outdoor halwa puri restaurants that set up by 6am and close when they run out — which is before 10am. The combination of sweet, savory, fried, and spiced all in one breakfast set is one of Pakistan's greatest contributions to world breakfast culture.

INGREDIENTS

SUJI HALWA

- 1 cup coarse semolina (suji)
- $\frac{3}{4}$ cup ghee (generous — this is Pakistani halwa)
- 1 cup sugar
- 2 cups water
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp cardamom powder
- Handful of cashews and raisins fried in ghee
- PURI (see also Recipe 268 for method):
- 2 cups all-purpose flour (maida)
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp salt
- Water to bind into a firm dough
- Oil for deep frying

ALOO CHANAY

- 1 cup boiled chickpeas (from dry or canned)
- 2 medium potatoes, boiled and cubed
- 2 onions, finely diced
- 2 tomatoes, diced
- 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp garam masala
- 1 tsp amchur (dry mango powder)
- 3 tbsp oil
- Fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SUJI HALWA: Heat ghee in a heavy pan over medium heat. Add cashews and raisins — fry until golden. Remove. Add semolina. Fry in the remaining ghee, stirring constantly, 8–10 minutes until deep golden and fragrant. In a separate pot, bring water and sugar to a boil. Very carefully pour hot sugar water over the fried semolina all at once (it will splutter dramatically). Stir vigorously. Cook 3–4 minutes until the halwa comes together and leaves the pan sides. Add cardamom. Fold in cashews and raisins.
2. ALOO CHANAY: Heat oil. Fry onion 8 minutes until golden. Add ginger-garlic paste. Cook 2 minutes. Add tomatoes, cumin, coriander, turmeric, chilli. Cook 7 minutes. Add chickpeas, potato, and amchur. Add water for a thick gravy. Simmer 10 minutes. Finish with garam masala and fresh coriander.
3. PURI: Mix flour, salt, and water into firm dough. Rest 15 minutes. Divide into small balls. Roll each into 12cm circles, 3mm thick. Deep fry at 180°C (355°F), pressing with a spoon to encourage puffing — 20–30 seconds per side.
4. SERVE: Place halwa, aloo chanay, and puri together. Add achaar (pickles) and sliced raw onion alongside.

Prep: 30 min • Cook: 40 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~680 per full set

TIP

Ghee quantity in Pakistani suji halwa is not a typo — $\frac{3}{4}$ cup per cup of semolina creates the rich, glossy, non-sticky texture that defines authentic Lahori halwa. Reducing ghee creates a dry, crumbly result. Pakistani halwa is a celebration food — its generosity of ghee is the point.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Pakistani] [Lahori Heritage] [Celebration Breakfast]

RECIPE 400

■■ Pakistan (Karachi / Lahore)

NIHARI

SLOW-COOKED SHANK STEW — BREAKFAST EDITION

Pakistan's most extraordinary breakfast — a slow-cooked overnight stew of beef shank, marrow, and deep spices, served with hot kulcha (thick leavened bread) or naan, garnished with fried onion, ginger, fresh coriander, lime, and green chilli. Nihari was created in Mughal Delhi and means "morning" (nahaar) in Persian — it was literally invented as a breakfast food for workers who needed maximum sustenance at dawn. The marrow gives the broth a collagen richness that sustains through long days.

INGREDIENTS

- NIHARI (cook overnight or 6+ hours):
- 1kg (2.2 lbs) beef shank, bone-in, cut into rounds
- 3 tbsp nihari masala (buy pre-made, or see below)
- 2 tbsp wheat flour (for thickening)
- 3 tbsp ghee
- 1 large onion, thinly sliced and deep-fried until very dark brown (birista — essential flavor base)
- 1L (4 cups) water
- Salt to taste
- HOMEMADE NIHARI MASALA (if not using pre-made):
- 1 tbsp fennel seeds, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp cardamom,
- ½ tsp cloves, ½ tsp black pepper, 1 tsp ginger powder,
- 1 tsp coriander — all toasted and ground together
- GARNISHES (all essential):
- Fried onion (birista — reserved from above)
- Fresh ginger, very finely julienned
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Green chillies, sliced
- Lime wedges
- Kulcha or naan for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat ghee in a large heavy pot. Add beef shank. Brown well on all sides.
2. Add nihari masala. Fry 2 minutes until fragrant.
3. Add fried onion (birista) — reserve some for garnish.
4. Add water. Bring to a boil. Skim foam.
5. Reduce to the lowest simmer. Cover.
6. Cook 4–6 hours until beef is very tender, the broth is fragrant and dark, and the marrow has dissolved into the sauce.
7. THICKENING: Mix wheat flour with cold water into a smooth paste. Stir into the simmering nihari. Cook 20 more minutes until broth thickens to a rich, glossy gravy that coats the meat.
8. Season with salt. The nihari should be deeply spiced, slightly oily from the marrow, and intensely savory.
9. Serve in deep bowls. Garnish with fried onion, julienned ginger, coriander, chilli, and lime.
10. Serve hot kulcha or naan for dipping.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 5 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~560 per serving

TIP

Birista (deep-fried crispy onion) is the invisible flavor architect of nihari — it dissolves into the broth during cooking, providing sweetness, depth, and body to the sauce. Fresh onion cannot replace it. Deep-fry sliced onions until very dark brown (almost burned — but not burned). The dark color becomes the dark color of the finished nihari.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Pakistani] [Mughal Heritage]

RECIPE 401

■ ■ Pakistan

PARATHA AND ANDA

FLAKY FLATBREAD WITH SPICED EGGS

Pakistan's everyday weekday breakfast — flaky, layered paratha cooked with generous ghee and served alongside anda (eggs) cooked in the Pakistani style: vigorously scrambled with onion, tomato, green chilli, and spices until the eggs are well-set, slightly dry, and deeply flavored. The combination needs nothing more — with a cup of doodh pati chai (milk tea), this is Pakistan's definitive morning meal across every income level and every city.

INGREDIENTS

LAYERED PARATHA

- 2 cups whole wheat flour (atta)
- ½ tsp salt
- Water to make a soft dough (approximately 150ml)
- 4 tbsp ghee (for layering and cooking)

PAKISTANI ANDA (SPICED SCRAMBLED EGGS)

- 4 large eggs
- 1 small onion, finely diced
- 1 tomato, finely diced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- ¼ tsp turmeric
- ¼ tsp cumin seeds
- Salt to taste
- 2 tbsp ghee or oil
- Fresh coriander

DOODH PATI CHAI (MILK TEA)

- 1 cup whole milk
- 1 cup water
- 2 tbsp strong loose-leaf black tea (CTC)
- 2–3 tsp sugar
- 2 cardamom pods, crushed
- Simmer all together 5 minutes. Strain.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PARATHA DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, and water into soft dough. Knead 5 minutes. Rest 15 minutes.
2. Divide into 4 balls. Roll each into a thin circle.
3. Spread ½ tsp ghee over surface. Dust with flour.
4. Fold in half. Spread more ghee. Fold in half again.
5. Roll the triangle out to a triangle shape again. This creates layers.
6. Heat tawa. Cook paratha on dry tawa 1 minute. Flip. Add ghee generously. Press with spatula. Flip again. Add ghee on second side. Cook until golden with many crispy, ghee-soaked layers.
7. PAKISTANI ANDA: Heat ghee. Add cumin seeds. Add onion — cook 5 minutes until golden. Add tomatoes and chillies. Cook 4 minutes. Add turmeric and red chilli. Stir. Beat eggs. Pour over masala. Cook over medium heat, folding frequently, until eggs are set and slightly dry — Pakistani anda is not soft-scrambled. It should be thoroughly cooked but not rubbery. Add coriander. Finish with salt.
8. Serve hot paratha alongside spiced eggs with chai.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

Pakistani anda is intentionally cooked until the eggs are well-done and slightly dry — the opposite of French scrambled eggs. This fully-cooked style holds up better against the strong flavors of the masala and pairs structurally with the flaky paratha for scooping. Soft, wet eggs disappear into the bread; firm, spiced eggs create satisfying mouthfuls.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Pakistani] [Everyday Breakfast]

RECIPE 402

■ ■ Pakistan

NAAN KHATAI

PAKISTANI CARDAMOM SHORTBREAD

Pakistan's beloved breakfast biscuit — a crumbly, melt-in-the-mouth shortbread made with ghee, semolina, and cardamom, eaten with chai at every Pakistani breakfast table. Named for their origins (naan = bread, khatai = Persian for "biscuit"), they are sold at every Pakistani bakery (naan bakers) and home-baked on Eid and special mornings. The ghee-semolina crumb dissolves on the tongue with a perfumed cardamom warmth that is deeply comforting.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 50g (■ cup) semolina (suji)
- 100g (7 tbsp) ghee, softened (room temperature)
- 100g (½ cup) powdered sugar (icing sugar)
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp cardamom powder
- 1 tbsp milk (to bind if needed)
- Pistachios or almonds, sliced (for topping)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat softened ghee and powdered sugar together until pale and fluffy — 3 minutes.
2. Add cardamom powder. Mix.
3. Sift flour, semolina, and baking soda together.
4. Add to the ghee mixture. Mix until a crumbly dough forms.
5. If the dough does not come together when pressed, add milk one teaspoon at a time. The dough should be soft, slightly crumbly when handled, but compact when pressed firmly.
6. Do NOT overwork — handle as little as possible.
7. Divide into 20 equal balls. Press each into a flat, slightly domed round disc (5cm diameter, 1cm thick).
8. Place on lined baking sheets.
9. Press a sliced pistachio or almond into the top of each biscuit.
10. Bake at 160°C (320°F) for 18–20 minutes until pale golden at the edges — the surface should remain pale and not darken significantly.
11. Cool COMPLETELY on the tray before moving — they are very fragile when warm and firm only as they cool.
12. Store in an airtight tin. Keep 2 weeks.
13. Eat with hot chai — dip briefly for the full experience.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 20 · Cal: ~125 per biscuit

TIP

Moving naan khatai before they are fully cold is the most common failure point — they crumble because the melted ghee has not resolidified. Leave on the tray for minimum 20 minutes after removing from the oven. The cookies will feel very soft when warm but will firm to their characteristic crumbly shortbread texture completely on cooling.

[Vegetarian] [Make-Ahead] [Classic Pakistani] [With Chai]

RECIPE 403

■■ Pakistan (Karachi / Lahore)

PAYE / SIRI PAYE

SLOW-COOKED TROTTERS SOUP

One of Pakistan's most prized breakfast soups — trotters (feet) and head (siri) of goat or lamb slow-cooked overnight until the collagen dissolves into a thick, gelatinous, deeply spiced broth. Eaten only in the morning (paye shops close by 9am when they sell out), served with hot naan and garnished with green chilli and coriander. The collagen-rich broth is believed to heal joints and strengthen bones — paye shops in Lahore open at 5am and the first customers arrive before dawn.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 goat or lamb trotters (paye), cleaned and split
- 1 large onion, roughly diced
- 1 tbsp ginger-garlic paste
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- 1 tbsp coriander powder
- 1 tsp cumin powder
- 2 tsp garam masala
- Salt to taste
- 3 tbsp ghee or oil
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- GARNISHES (non-negotiable):
- Sliced green chillies
- Fresh coriander leaves, chopped
- Julienned fresh ginger
- Lime wedges
- Fried onion (birista)
- Hot naan or kulcha

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Clean trotters thoroughly — scrape, singe any hair, and wash very well.
2. Blanch in boiling water 10 minutes. Drain and rinse.
3. Heat ghee in a pressure cooker or heavy pot.
4. Fry onion until golden brown.
5. Add ginger-garlic paste. Fry 2 minutes.
6. Add trotters. Brown briefly.
7. Add all spices and salt. Stir to coat.
8. Add water. Bring to a boil.
9. **PRESSURE COOKER:** Seal and cook on high pressure 45–60 minutes until trotters are very tender and falling apart. Release pressure.
10. **CONVENTIONAL METHOD:** Simmer covered 4–5 hours.
11. The broth should be thick, opaque, and richly golden from the rendered collagen and spices.
12. Check tenderness — meat should fall from the bone.
13. Adjust seasoning. Add extra garam masala if desired.
14. **SERVE:** Ladle trotters and broth into deep bowls.
15. Garnish with chilli, coriander, ginger, and fried onion.
16. Serve with lime and hot bread for dipping.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 5 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per bowl

TIP

Paye collagen creates an extraordinarily thick, almost glossy broth that coats the inside of the bowl — this gelatinous quality is the mark of a proper paye. If the broth is thin and watery, the trotters need more cooking time. The broth should set into a jelly when cooled — this indicates maximum collagen extraction.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Pakistani] [Dawn Breakfast]

Bangladesh

RECIPE 404

■ ■ Bangladesh

LUCHI WITH ALUR DOM

BENGALI FRIED BREAD WITH POTATO CURRY

Bangladesh's most beloved celebratory breakfast — luchi (small, snow-white puffed fried bread made entirely from white flour, distinguishing them from the whole-wheat puri) with alur dom (small potatoes in a fragrant spiced tomato gravy). The whiteness of luchi is a source of pride — achieved by using only refined flour and keeping the frying oil temperature precisely controlled. Eaten on Eid, weddings, and every Sunday morning in every Bangladeshi home regardless of circumstance.

INGREDIENTS

LUCHI

- 2 cups all-purpose flour (maida — white flour only)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp oil
- Water to make a very soft, smooth dough
- Oil for deep frying (mustard oil is traditional — it gives a distinctive peppery flavor)

ALUR DOM

- 500g (18 oz) small new potatoes, boiled whole
- (or larger potatoes, quartered)
- 1 onion, finely diced
- 2 tomatoes, finely diced
- 1 tbsp ginger paste
- 1 tbsp garlic paste
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- 1 tsp coriander powder
- ½ tsp garam masala
- 1 tsp nigella seeds (kalonji)
- 2 bay leaves
- 3 tbsp mustard oil
- Salt and fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ALUR DOM: Heat mustard oil until smoking — then reduce heat slightly. (Smoking removes mustard oil's raw pungency, essential step for mustard oil cooking.)
2. Add bay leaves, cumin, and nigella seeds. Pop briefly.
3. Add onion. Cook 8 minutes until golden.
4. Add ginger and garlic paste. Cook 2 minutes.
5. Add tomatoes, turmeric, chilli, and coriander. Cook until oil separates — 7–8 minutes.
6. Add boiled potatoes. Toss to coat in masala.
7. Add ½ cup water. Simmer 10 minutes.
8. Finish with garam masala and fresh coriander.
9. LUCHI DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, and oil. Add water gradually to form a very soft, smooth dough. Knead 5 minutes. Rest 15 minutes covered.
10. Divide into 16 small balls. Roll each into a thin circle (10cm). Apply a tiny smear of oil on the surface to prevent sticking.
11. Heat mustard oil to 175°C (345°F).
12. Slide luchi into hot oil. Press gently with a slotted spoon to encourage puffing. Fry 10–15 seconds per side until puffed and white (not golden — luchi should remain pale).
13. Remove while still pale. Drain briefly. Serve immediately alongside hot alur dom.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

Luchi must remain WHITE and pale — not golden. Remove from oil while still pale. Luchi color is managed by oil temperature (not too hot) and frying time (very short). Golden luchi is a cooking failure in Bengali tradition. The whiteness is the aesthetic ideal and a point of genuine pride among Bengali cooks.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Bangladeshi] [Festive] [Bengali Heritage]

RECIPE 405

■ ■ Bangladesh

MURI WITH MUSTARD OIL

BANGLADESHI PUFFED RICE BREAKFAST

Bangladesh's simplest and most universal morning snack — muri (puffed rice) eaten directly from a clay or metal dish tossed with mustard oil, green chilli, onion, coriander, and salt. Found at tea stalls throughout Bangladesh, eaten with a cup of milk tea. The pungency of cold-pressed mustard oil against the neutral puffed rice is Bangladesh's most fundamental flavor pairing — earthy, sharp, and completely unlike anything in the Western breakfast tradition.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups muri (puffed rice — the large, dry, crispy Bengali variety, different from rice puffs in cereal)
- 2 tbsp cold-pressed mustard oil (the raw, pungent variety — not heat-treated mustard oil)
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 2–3 green chillies, finely sliced
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- 1 tbsp fresh tomato, finely diced (optional)
- ½ tsp black salt (kala namak) — for the distinctive sulfurous note essential to Bengali muri
- Salt to taste
- Optional: ½ cup chanachur (Bengali spiced snack mix)
- or sev for extra crunch

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place muri in a large bowl.
2. Add mustard oil. Toss immediately — the oil should coat each puffed rice kernel.
3. Add diced onion, sliced green chilli, and tomato.
4. Add coriander, black salt, and regular salt.
5. Toss everything together vigorously.
6. Taste — it should be pungent from mustard oil, sharp from black salt, fresh from coriander, and fiery from chilli.
7. Add chanachur or sev if using. Toss once more.
8. Serve immediately in small bowls. Muri absorbs moisture quickly — eat within 5 minutes.
9. Accompany with strong milk tea (doodh cha).

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Raw, cold-pressed mustard oil (kachi ghani sarson tel) is the essential ingredient — it has a sharp, wasabi-like pungency that processed or refined mustard oil completely lacks. This is the specific flavor that makes Bengali muri taste like Bangladesh. Find it at Bangladeshi or South Asian grocery stores labeled "kachi ghani" (cold-pressed).

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Bangladeshi] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 406

■ ■ Bangladesh

MISHTI DOI

BANGLADESHI SWEETENED SET YOGURT

Bangladesh's most celebrated dairy creation — thick, caramel-sweet yogurt set in clay pots, with a distinctive fudge-like sweetness from khejur gur (date palm jaggery) or caramelized sugar. Eaten for breakfast on special occasions and daily at sweet shops (mithair dokan) throughout Bangladesh. The clay pot is essential — it absorbs excess moisture while the yogurt sets, creating the characteristic thick, creamy consistency that no refrigerator-made yogurt can replicate.

INGREDIENTS

- 1L (4 cups) full-cream milk
- 100g (½ cup) khejur gur (date palm jaggery — the defining flavor of Bangladeshi mishti doi)
- OR: 3 tbsp sugar + 3 tbsp condensed milk
- (if jaggery unavailable)
- 3 tbsp plain yogurt with live cultures (starter)
- Pinch of cardamom powder (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Pour milk into a heavy-bottomed saucepan.
2. Bring to a full boil over medium heat, stirring.
3. Reduce heat. Simmer the milk until reduced by approximately ■ — about 20–25 minutes of gentle simmering. The milk thickens slightly and develops a slight cream color.
4. Add khejur gur. Stir until completely dissolved.
5. If using regular sugar: add sugar and stir until dissolved. For caramel color, caramelize sugar first until dark amber, then add milk carefully.
6. Cool the sweetened milk to 42–45°C (108–113°F) — warm to the touch but not hot. Use a thermometer. (If too hot: kills the yogurt culture. If too cold: the culture won't activate.)
7. Add cardamom if using. Stir gently.
8. Add yogurt starter. Stir gently to distribute.
9. Pour into small clay pots, ceramic ramekins, or a large shallow clay dish.
10. Cover with a cloth (not plastic — the clay must breathe).
11. Place in a warm spot (40°C) — a warm oven with just the light on, or wrapped in towels.
12. Incubate 6–8 hours undisturbed.
13. Refrigerate 4 hours before serving.
14. Serve cold from the pot.

Prep: 10 min + 12 hrs setting · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Khejur gur (date palm jaggery) — the dark, intensely flavored variety tapped from date palm trees in winter — gives mishti doi its deep caramel-molasses flavor that sugar alone cannot replicate. It is available at Bangladeshi grocery stores in December–January (the harvesting season). Stock up and freeze portions — it keeps frozen for months and transforms mishti doi from good to extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Bangladeshi] [Festive] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 407

■ ■ Myanmar

MOHINGA

BURMESE FISH NOODLE SOUP

Myanmar's national breakfast — rice noodles in a rich catfish broth thickened with banana trunk and roasted rice powder, scented with lemongrass and ginger. Topped with hard-boiled egg, crispy split chickpea fritters, fish cake, and fried garlic. Mohinga is the first food most Burmese eat in the morning, at tea shops and from roadside carts throughout the country. South Myanmar's mohinga uses catfish; Upper Myanmar uses different fish; each region's version is considered definitive by its inhabitants.

INGREDIENTS

FISH BROTH

- 500g (18 oz) catfish or any white-fleshed fish, cleaned
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 2 stalks lemongrass, bruised
- 3 slices fresh ginger
- 1 onion, halved
- 1 tsp turmeric
- Salt

BROTH THICKENING AND FLAVORING

- 100g (3.5 oz) banana trunk or banana blossom, very thinly sliced and soaked in salted water
- (or substitute: hearts of palm, drained and sliced)
- 3 tbsp roasted rice powder (toast raw rice in dry pan until golden, grind to a coarse powder)
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp shrimp paste (nga pi)
- 1 tsp sugar

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) thin rice vermicelli, blanched
- 3 hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Fish cake (nga pyaw), sliced
- Crispy split chickpea fritters (pe kyaw):
 - — 1 cup split chickpeas, soaked 4 hrs, ground, seasoned with turmeric, salt, chilli — deep fried
- Fried garlic and fried onion
- Fresh coriander
- Lime wedges
- Chilli flakes and fish sauce at the table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Simmer fish with water, lemongrass, ginger, onion, and turmeric 15 minutes. Remove fish. Strain broth.
2. Flake fish meat, discarding bones. Reserve.
3. Fry garlic in 2 tbsp oil. Add shrimp paste — fry 1 minute. Add banana trunk slices. Fry 3 minutes.
4. Add fish broth. Bring to a simmer.
5. Stir in roasted rice powder — whisk to prevent lumps.
6. The broth will thicken considerably. Simmer 10 minutes.
7. Add fish sauce, sugar, and flaked fish. Stir. Taste — the broth should be savory, slightly fishy, lightly spiced, and gently thick.
8. **CRISPY SPLIT CHICKPEA FRITTERS:** Deep fry spoonfuls of the chickpea mixture at 170°C until golden and crispy.
9. **SERVE:** Place blanched noodles in deep bowls.
10. Ladle hot mohinga broth generously over noodles.
11. Top with egg, fish cake, crispy fritters, fried garlic, and fresh coriander.
12. Serve with lime and condiments on the side.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~410 per bowl

TIP

Roasted rice powder is what thickens mohinga and gives it a unique, nutty, slightly grainy body. It is ground raw rice dry-toasted until deep golden — do not use store-bought rice flour, which lacks the toasted character. Toast generously until you smell the nuttiness, then grind. This same ingredient appears in many Southeast Asian cuisines but mohinga's use is particularly essential.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Myanmar] [National Dish]

Myanmar

RECIPE 408

■ Myanmar

LAPHET THOKE

BURMESE FERMENTED TEA LEAF SALAD

Myanmar's national dish and most celebrated flavor — fermented tea leaves (laphet) tossed with crunchy fried garlic, sesame seeds, dried shrimp, fried peas, sliced tomatoes, and chilli. Eaten at breakfast, at weddings, at political meetings, and as a gesture of hospitality. Laphet thoke is simultaneously breakfast salad, stimulant (fermented tea has significant caffeine), social connector, and national identity in a bowl. Nothing in the food world is quite like it.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (3.5 oz) laphet (Burmese fermented/pickled tea leaves) — available at Burmese grocery stores or online.
- Cannot be substituted with dried tea leaves — the fermentation creates the specific flavor.
- 3 tbsp sesame oil or neutral oil
- TOPPINGS (all essential — add as many as possible):
- 4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced and fried until golden
- 2 tbsp fried dried shrimp
- 3 tbsp roasted sesame seeds
- 3 tbsp fried split yellow peas or fried chickpeas
- 2 tbsp fried broad bean crispy (available packaged)
- 2 tomatoes, finely diced
- 2 green chillies, thinly sliced
- 1 small lemon or lime, juiced
- Fish sauce to taste
- Fresh coriander

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If laphet has excess oil from the jar, drain slightly but keep moist — it should not be dry.
2. TOPPINGS: Prepare all fried elements: — Fry garlic slices in oil until pale golden. Drain. — Fry dried shrimp in 1 tsp oil 1 minute. Drain. — Toast sesame seeds in dry pan. — Fry split peas or chickpeas until crispy.
3. MIXING: Place laphet in a large bowl.
4. Drizzle sesame oil over. Toss.
5. Add all toppings: fried garlic, shrimp, sesame, peas, tomato, and chilli.
6. Season with fish sauce and lime juice.
7. Taste: it should be earthy and slightly bitter from the tea, salty and pungent from fish sauce and shrimp, nutty from sesame, and crunchy from all the fried elements.
8. Toss lightly to combine without crushing the toppings.
9. Serve in a shallow dish with components arranged separately on top — guests mix their own portion.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 10 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~220 per serving

TIP

Burmese laphet thoke is traditionally served with all components arranged separately on a plate or in individual compartments — each person mixes their own bowl at the table, choosing proportions of each element. This is not a mixed salad but a composition that each person tailors to their own preference for crunch, heat, and sourness.

[Gluten-Free] [Classic Myanmar] [Cultural Icon] [High Caffeine]

RECIPE 409

■ Myanmar

NAN GYI THOKE

BURMESE THICK NOODLE SALAD WITH CHICKEN CURRY

Myanmar's beloved tea shop breakfast — thick round rice noodles (nan gyi) dressed with a deeply spiced chicken curry sauce, topped with crispy split chickpea fritters, hard-boiled egg, fried garlic, and fresh aromatics. This is an "a-hnar gyin" style noodle dish — served dry, the sauce coating each noodle rather than floating in broth. One of Burmese cuisine's greatest textural achievements — thick, chewy noodles with crispy, creamy, and fresh elements all in one bowl.

INGREDIENTS

CHICKEN CURRY SAUCE

- 400g (14 oz) chicken thighs, diced
- 1 large onion, blended to paste
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp fresh ginger, grated
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp paprika or mild chilli powder
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp shrimp paste (nga pi — optional)
- 200ml (¾ cup) coconut milk
- 2 tbsp neutral oil

NOODLES

- 400g (14 oz) thick round rice noodles (nan gyi) or
- substitute: thick udon noodles (slightly different
- texture but workable), cooked and drained

TOPPINGS

- Crispy split chickpea fritters (pe kyaw — as Recipe 407)
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, quartered
- Fried garlic (generous)
- Fresh coriander
- Sliced spring onion
- Lime juice
- Chilli flakes and fish sauce at table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CURRY SAUCE: Fry blended onion in oil 8–10 minutes until deep golden and fragrant.
2. Add garlic, ginger, and shrimp paste. Cook 2 minutes.
3. Add chicken. Stir to coat. Cook until sealed.
4. Add turmeric, paprika, and fish sauce.
5. Add coconut milk. Simmer 20 minutes until chicken is very tender and the sauce is thick and rich.
6. Taste — rich, savory, slightly sweet from the onion, and warmly spiced.
7. TOSSING: Place cooked noodles in a large bowl.
8. Add several tablespoons of curry sauce.
9. Toss to coat all noodles in the sauce — add more sauce gradually until each noodle is fully dressed.
10. ASSEMBLE IN BOWLS: Divide dressed noodles.
11. Add crispy fritters, egg quarters, fried garlic, spring onion, and coriander on top.
12. Squeeze lime over everything.
13. Add extra chilli and fish sauce to taste.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~450 per bowl

TIP

The noodles should be dressed aggressively — not lightly. The sauce must coat every strand. Start with less sauce, toss thoroughly, then add more. Under-sauced nan gyi thoke is bland. Properly sauced, every bite delivers the full depth of the curry combined with the noodle's chewy satisfaction.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Myanmar] [Tea Shop Breakfast]

RECIPE 410

■ ■ Myanmar

MONT LIN MAYAR

BURMESE SAVORY BATTERED QUAIL EGG CAKES

Yangon's most charming street breakfast — small round rice flour cakes cooked in a dimpled griddle pan, each with a quail egg dropped into the center, garnished with spring onion and dried shrimp. Sold by street vendors with a special double-dimple cast-iron pan from early morning. The name means "husband and wife" — each cake is traditionally sold in pairs. Light, savory, and completely delightful, they are impossible to eat only two of.

INGREDIENTS

BATTER

- 200g (1½ cups) rice flour
- 50g (½ cup) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 400ml (1½ cups) coconut milk
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) water
- FILLINGS AND GARNISH (per cake):
- 1 quail egg (or ½ regular egg)
- ½ tsp sliced spring onion
- ½ tsp dried shrimp (coarsely chopped)
- A few drops fish sauce
- White pepper
- Neutral oil for the pan

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BATTER: Whisk all batter ingredients until completely smooth. Rest 15 minutes.
2. Heat a khanom krok or poffertjes pan (or takoyaki pan) over medium heat. Brush each depression with oil.
3. Pour batter into each depression to ¾ full.
4. When the edges begin to set (about 1 minute), crack one quail egg into the center of each cake.
5. Sprinkle spring onion and dried shrimp on top.
6. Add a drop of fish sauce and a pinch of white pepper.
7. Cover with a lid. Cook 2–3 minutes until the egg white is set and the cake is cooked through.
8. Remove with a rounded spoon. Serve in pairs.
9. Eat while hot — they cool quickly.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~220 per serving (4 cakes)

TIP

Quail eggs cook extremely fast — the entire cooking time after adding the egg should be no more than 2–3 minutes under the lid. Overcooking creates a rubbery, gray yolk instead of the soft, barely-set yolk that makes these cakes charming. Monitor closely.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Myanmar] [Street Food]

RECIPE 411

■ ■ Cambodia

BOBOR

CAMBODIAN RICE PORRIDGE

Cambodia's fundamental breakfast — rice cooked in chicken broth with ginger until silky and smooth, served with a choice of toppings. Cambodian bobor is lighter than Chinese congee and more delicately flavored than Thai khao tom — it has a gentler, more refined character that reflects the subtle Khmer flavor palette. Eaten at bobor shops from 5am, and considered by Cambodians to be the most nourishing food for recovering health.

INGREDIENTS

- ½ cup jasmine rice, rinsed
- 1.5L (6 cups) good chicken broth
- 3cm fresh ginger, julienned
- 1 tsp fish sauce
- Salt and white pepper
- TOPPINGS (choose your combination):
- Shredded poached chicken
- Sliced pork meatballs
- Sliced Chinese sausage (lap cheong)
- Soft-boiled or century eggs

GARNISHES

- 3 tbsp fried shallots
- 3 tbsp crispy fried garlic
- 2 green onions, sliced
- Fresh coriander
- Sliced fresh ginger
- White pepper and fish sauce
- Chilli oil on the side
- Crispy cruellers (Chinese dough sticks, sliced)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rinsed rice with cold chicken broth and ginger.
2. Bring to a boil. Skim any foam.
3. Reduce heat to very low. Simmer 45–55 minutes, stirring every 10 minutes, until rice has completely dissolved and porridge is silky and smooth.
4. Season with fish sauce, salt, and white pepper.
5. The bobor should be smooth and pourable — thinner than Western oatmeal but thicker than broth.
6. TOPPINGS: Cook chosen proteins: — Poach chicken in broth and shred. — Simmer pork meatballs in the porridge last 5 minutes.
7. SERVE: Ladle bobor into deep bowls.
8. Add chosen protein on top.
9. Scatter fried shallots, fried garlic, ginger, and green onion generously.
10. Add coriander and dough stick slices.
11. Season at table with fish sauce, white pepper, and chilli oil.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 55 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~265 per bowl

TIP

Cambodian bobor is thinner and more delicate than Chinese congee — it should feel light on the stomach rather than heavy. If the porridge thickens too much during cooking, add hot broth or water to restore the correct flowing consistency. The ratio of 1:12 (rice to liquid) is the Cambodian starting point.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein option] [Classic Cambodian] [Healing]

Cambodia

RECIPE 412

■ ■ Cambodia

MI KA THI

CAMBODIAN PORK NOODLE SOUP

Cambodia's most popular morning noodle soup — a clear, mildly sweet pork and dried shrimp broth with egg noodles or rice noodles, sliced pork, fish balls, bean sprouts, and a generous pile of fresh herbs. Sold at noodle shops from before dawn, eaten quickly and efficiently at low tables by every demographic. Cambodian noodle soup is less spiced than Vietnamese or Thai but no less satisfying — its strength is in the quiet depth of a properly made broth.

INGREDIENTS

PORK BROTH

- 500g (18 oz) pork bones
- 500g (18 oz) pork ribs
- 1L (4 cups) water
- 3cm fresh ginger, sliced
- 1 cinnamon stick (small)
- 3 whole garlic cloves
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 1 tsp sugar
- Salt and white pepper

NOODLES AND TOPPINGS

- 400g (14 oz) egg noodles or rice noodles,
- cooked and drained
- 200g (7 oz) pork loin, thinly sliced
- 10 fish balls, halved
- 1 cup bean sprouts, blanched briefly
- 2 squares fried tofu, sliced
- Fried garlic and fried shallots
- Sliced green onion
- Fresh herb plate: fresh coriander, Thai basil,
- sawtooth herb (ngo gai)
- Lime wedges
- Fish sauce and white pepper at table
- Chilli paste on the side

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blanch pork bones 5 minutes. Drain and rinse.
2. Combine with ribs, fresh water, ginger, cinnamon, and garlic. Bring to a boil.
3. Skim foam thoroughly.
4. Reduce to a gentle simmer. Cook 1.5 hours until broth is clear and mildly sweet with pork depth.
5. Remove ribs — the rib meat is used as topping. Strip meat from bones and slice.
6. Strain broth. Season with fish sauce, sugar, salt, and white pepper.
7. Return to pot. Bring to a simmer.
8. Add sliced pork loin to the simmering broth — it cooks in 1–2 minutes.
9. ASSEMBLE: Place noodles in deep bowls.
10. Arrange pork slices, fish balls, rib meat, tofu, and bean sprouts in the bowl.
11. Ladle hot broth over everything.
12. Top with fried garlic, fried shallots, and green onion.
13. Serve herb plate, lime, and condiments alongside.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 90 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per bowl

TIP

The small cinnamon stick in Cambodian pork broth is the subtle Khmer touch — it adds a barely perceptible warmth and sweetness that makes the broth distinctively different from Vietnamese or Thai versions. Remove it after 1 hour if you prefer less cinnamon forward; leave it in for the full Khmer character.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Cambodian] [Noodle Shop]

NOM BANH CHOK

KHMER RICE NOODLES WITH GREEN FISH CURRY

Cambodia's most distinctively Khmer breakfast — fresh, hand-made rice noodles (nom banh chok) served at room temperature in a fragrant fresh lemongrass and green herb fish curry, topped with fresh banana blossom, bean sprouts, cucumber, and fresh herbs. The curry is not cooked but raw — a raw fish paste with pounded fresh herbs, strained through bamboo to extract a fresh, herbal sauce unlike any cooked curry. This is Cambodian cuisine's most beautiful and most uniquely Khmer breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- NOM BANH CHOK NOODLES (or buy fresh at Asian stores):
- 2 cups jasmine rice, soaked overnight, ground to a fine paste, fermented 24 hours, then extruded through a sieve into boiling water
- (Store-bought fresh rice vermicelli is a practical substitute for home cooking)
- KHMER GREEN FISH SAUCE (kroeung):
- 400g (14 oz) fresh white fish fillets, coarsely chopped
- 3 stalks lemongrass, white part only, sliced
- 5 kaffir lime leaves
- 2cm fresh turmeric (or ½ tsp powder)
- 2cm fresh galangal
- 3 garlic cloves
- 3 shallots
- 1 tbsp fish sauce
- 200ml (¾ cup) thin coconut milk
- Fresh water for blending
- FRESH TOPPINGS (all essential):
- Banana blossom (hua chuoi), shredded and soaked in lime water to prevent browning
- Bean sprouts, raw
- Cucumber, julienned
- Fresh herbs: water morning glory (rau muong), Thai basil, mint, fresh coriander
- Lime wedges
- Fish sauce and chilli paste at table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. KROEUNG SAUCE: Blend lemongrass, kaffir lime, turmeric, galangal, garlic, and shallots with minimal water until a smooth paste forms.
2. Add chopped fish. Blend until incorporated.
3. Add fish sauce. Blend briefly.
4. Strain through a fine mesh: push the fish mixture through, extracting a smooth, jade-green sauce.
5. Stir in thin coconut milk. Taste — it should be herbal, slightly fishy, fragrant with lemongrass, and lightly sweet from coconut. **THIS SAUCE IS NOT COOKED** — it is served raw.
6. SERVE: Place fresh rice noodles in bowls (room temperature — not hot).
7. Pour raw kroeung sauce generously over the noodles — enough to coat and pool beneath.
8. Arrange all fresh vegetables and herbs on top.
9. Serve lime and condiments alongside.
10. Eat by mixing everything together before each bite — the raw sauce and fresh herbs combined are the Khmer flavor.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 0 min for sauce · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~295 per bowl

TIP

The raw fish sauce is the unique and essential character of nom banh chok — it must not be cooked. The freshness of the fish and herbs is the entire point. Use the freshest, highest-quality white fish available. The fish is safe as the lime juice and fish sauce partially denature the protein, similar to ceviche. Use sushi-quality fish if concerned.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Cambodian] [Raw Preparation] [Unique]

BAGUETTE WITH PÂTÉ AND EGGS

CAMBODIAN FRENCH COLONIAL BREAKFAST

Cambodia's French colonial legacy on the breakfast table — a thin, crispy baguette (Cambodians adapted the French baguette into a lighter, airier form) spread with pork liver pâté and eaten with fried eggs and strong condensed milk coffee. Found at every Phnom Penh market breakfast stall, this collision of French and Cambodian cultures creates a morning meal that is both entirely foreign and entirely Cambodian — a baguette that has lived in Southeast Asia long enough to become local.

INGREDIENTS

CAMBODIAN BAGUETTE

- Use a thin, crispy French baguette — the Cambodian
- version is lighter and crispier than the French original
- due to local flour and technique variations

PER SERVING

- ½ baguette, split lengthwise
- 2 tbsp pork liver pâté (Phnom Penh style — slightly sweeter and less herbaceous than French;
- use good quality French pâté as closest substitute)
- 1 tbsp Kewpie mayonnaise
- 2 large eggs, fried (yolks broken and well-cooked, Cambodian style — not runny)
- Pickled vegetables (quick-pickled daikon and carrot —
- as Recipe 311)
- Fresh cucumber slices
- Sliced fresh chilli
- Soy sauce for drizzling
- CAMBODIAN COFFEE (kafe toek doh ko):
- Very strong brewed coffee
- Sweetened condensed milk (generous)
- Served over ice in a tall glass

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast baguette halves until very crispy.
2. Spread pâté generously on one half.
3. Spread mayo on the other half.
4. Fry eggs well-done (no runny yolk — break yolks and press flat in the pan for the Cambodian style that is standard).
5. Layer eggs on the pâté side.
6. Add well-drained pickled vegetables.
7. Add cucumber slices.
8. Add sliced fresh chilli.
9. Drizzle a few drops of soy sauce over the egg.
10. Press halves together firmly.
11. Cut diagonally.
12. COFFEE: Brew very strong coffee. Place condensed milk in glass. Pour hot coffee over. Stir. Add ice. Drink alongside the baguette.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

The well-done, broken-yolk fried egg is the Cambodian (and Southeast Asian) standard for sandwich eggs — the fully set yolk creates a structural layer that holds in the sandwich and doesn't soak the bread. Cambodians never use runny yolks in their breakfast baguettes. This is a preference, not a limitation.

[High Protein] [Classic Cambodian] [French Colonial Heritage] [Quick]

MIDDLE EAST

Recipes #415—#460 · 46 recipes

Turkey

RECIPE 415

■ Turkey

TURKISH KAHVALTISI

THE FULL TURKISH BREAKFAST SPREAD

The complete Turkish breakfast table — a curated collection of small dishes that together constitute one of the world's great morning meals. Not one dish but a philosophy: many things in small quantities, eaten at leisure, with endless tea. This recipe teaches the full assembly — each component, its role, and its preparation. The Turkish kahvaltı is the breakfast world's most comprehensive tradition and its most hospitable.

INGREDIENTS

THE ESSENTIAL COMPONENTS

- 2 varieties Turkish white cheese (beyaz peynir — like feta, and kaşar peyniri — a mild yellow cheese)
- Mixed olives (black and green, lightly dressed with
- olive oil, dried oregano, and chilli flakes)
- 2 medium tomatoes, sliced thickly
- 1 cucumber, sliced or quartered
- 2–3 radishes, sliced
- 4 eggs (for menemen or fried or boiled — see below)
- 2 tbsp good honey
- 2 tbsp kaymak (thick clotted cream — or crème fraîche)
- 1 tbsp grape molasses (pekmez)
- 1 tbsp tahini (served alongside pekmez for mixing)
- Sucuk (Turkish beef sausage), sliced and pan-fried
- Fresh bread: simit (sesame ring) or white bread
- Butter
- TURKISH TEA (çay — served throughout):
- Turkish black tea (çay), brewed very strong in a
- çaydanlık or strong black tea in a small teapot
- Served in tulip-shaped glasses with sugar cubes

INSTRUCTIONS

1. OLIVES: Drain olives. Toss with a drizzle of olive oil, a pinch of chilli flakes, dried thyme or oregano, and a squeeze of lemon. Set out in a small bowl.
2. CHEESE: Slice white cheese and yellow cheese onto a small board or separate plates. Drizzle white cheese with olive oil and dried mint if desired.
3. VEGETABLES: Slice tomatoes thickly. Do not season — let each person salt their own at the table. Quarter cucumber. Slice radishes. Arrange together.
4. SUCUK: Slice sucuk (Turkish dried spicy sausage) into rounds. Fry dry in a pan 1 minute per side until the fat renders and the slices caramelize. The fat that renders from sucuk is used to fry eggs.
5. EGGS: Fry 2 eggs in the sucuk fat for the most traditional version. Or make menemen (Recipe 416).
6. HONEY AND KAYMAK: Place honey in a small dish. Place kaymak alongside — they are eaten together, spooned over bread. The combination is called "bal kaymak" and is one of Turkey's great flavor pleasures.
7. TAHINI-PEKMEZ: Pour tahini and grape molasses into separate small dishes placed touching — diners swirl them together. This ancient combination has been eaten for breakfast in Anatolia for over a thousand years.
8. BREAD: Serve simit (warm if possible) or sliced fresh white bread in a bread basket.
9. TEA: Brew tea very strong in a small teapot. Serve in small tulip glasses. Refill constantly. The tea is never drunk cold — fresh pours throughout.
10. SET THE TABLE: Everything goes out simultaneously. No courses. All dishes at once. Sit. Take your time.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per person (complete spread)

TIP

The combination of tahini and grape molasses (pekmez) stirred together in a small dish is one of Turkish breakfast's great pleasures — nutty, sweet, and slightly tart. The ratio is personal but equal parts is traditional. This combination has been eaten for breakfast in Anatolia since ancient times and is considered a complete protein-and-energy morning food.

[Vegetarian option] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Turkish] [Complete Breakfast]

MENEMEN

Turkey's most beloved egg dish and the great divider of Turkish breakfast culture — menemen is a loose, custardy scramble of eggs cooked with roasted peppers, tomatoes, and olive oil. The debate: onion or no onion? The answer: no onion for the purists, onion for the pragmatists. Both camps are correct. Cooked in a copper or cast-iron pan and brought to the table still bubbling, menemen is eaten by everyone from grandmothers to students for breakfast every morning across Turkey.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 large ripe tomatoes, skinned and roughly chopped
- (or 200g canned whole tomatoes)
- 2 long green peppers (sivri biber — the mild Turkish
- variety) or 1 green bell pepper, finely diced
- 1 green chilli (optional — for heat)
- 3 tbsp good olive oil
- ½ tsp sweet paprika (Mara■ chilli flakes preferred —
- dried Mara■ red pepper from southern Turkey)
- Salt and black pepper
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, roughly chopped
- Optional: 50g (2 oz) beyaz peynir (white cheese),
- crumbled over the top at the end

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide, heavy pan (copper pan if possible — traditional and beautiful) over medium heat.
2. Add diced peppers. Fry 4–5 minutes until softened.
3. Add chopped tomatoes. Press with a spoon.
4. Cook over medium heat 8–10 minutes until tomatoes have released all their juice and then reduced — the mixture should be thick, sweet, and concentrated. Watery menemen is a breakfast failure.
5. Add paprika or Mara■ chilli flakes. Stir briefly.
6. Season with salt and black pepper.
7. Beat eggs lightly — not completely smooth. Some streaks of yolk and white remaining is fine.
8. Pour eggs over the tomato-pepper mixture.
9. Reduce heat to medium-low.
10. Stir gently with a spatula using slow, wide motions — the curds should be large, soft, and custardy. Never scramble aggressively.
11. REMOVE FROM HEAT WHILE STILL SLIGHTLY UNDERDONE — residual heat will finish cooking.
12. Scatter fresh parsley and crumbled cheese if using.
13. Bring the pan directly to the table. Eat from the pan with bread for scooping.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

The tomatoes must be cooked down completely before eggs are added — watery tomato juice makes the eggs steam rather than scramble, creating a wet, unpleasant texture. Cook the tomatoes until the liquid has almost fully evaporated and the mixture is thick. Only then add eggs. This patience produces the rich, custardy menemen.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Turkish] [Quick]

SİMİT

TURKISH SESAME RING BREAD

Istanbul's most recognizable street food — a circular bread ring with a thin, shatteringly crispy crust encrusted with sesame seeds, a chewy interior, and a distinctive slight sweetness from being dipped in grape molasses before baking. Sold from red carts by simitçi vendors throughout Istanbul from dawn, balanced on round trays carried on their heads. Eaten with white cheese and tea — the quintessential Istanbul morning. No food better represents the city.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp olive oil

COATING

- 100ml (■ cup) grape molasses (pekmez) diluted
- with 100ml (■ cup) warm water — the molasses wash
- is ESSENTIAL for authentic simit color and sweetness
- 200g (1½ cups) sesame seeds (white, raw)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and olive oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic.
2. Prove covered 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide into 8 equal portions.
4. Roll each portion into a long rope — 60–70cm (24–27 in).
5. Fold each rope in half. Twist the two strands around each other 4–5 times.
6. Bring the ends together and seal firmly — creating a twisted ring. Press the join firmly.
7. Prove rings 20 minutes.
8. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F) with a heavy baking stone or baking sheet inside.
9. COATING: Dip each proved ring into the diluted grape molasses wash — submerge briefly on both sides.
10. Immediately press both sides into a tray of sesame seeds, coating completely and generously.
11. Place on a piece of parchment. Slide onto the hot stone.
12. Bake 15–18 minutes until deep mahogany brown — simit should be dark, not pale golden. The grape molasses creates the distinctive color.
13. Cool on a rack 5 minutes. Eat warm.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~285 per simit

TIP

The grape molasses (pekmez) dip before sesame coating is what differentiates authentic simit from a generic sesame bread ring. The molasses creates the characteristic dark, slightly sweet, caramelized sesame crust. Without it, you have sesame bread. With it, you have simit.

[Vegan] [Classic Turkish] [Street Food] [Bakery] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 418

■ ■ Turkey

BÖREK

TURKISH LAYERED PASTRY WITH CHEESE

Turkey's greatest pastry — tissue-thin yufka (Turkish filo) layers brushed with butter and egg, filled with white cheese and parsley, baked or pan-fried until shatteringly crispy. Börek is the Turkish pastry tradition distilled: dozens of layers, each paper-thin, each contributing to the final architecture of crunch and cream. Su böreği (water börek), sigara böreği (cigarette börek), or tepsi böreği (tray börek) — each form has its devotees. All are extraordinary.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR TRAY BÖREK (tepsi böreği):
- 1 package yufka or filo pastry (400g / 14 oz)
- — yufka is thicker and more traditional;
- filo is an accessible substitute

FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) beyaz peynir (Turkish white cheese) or
- good quality feta, crumbled
- ½ cup fresh flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped
- 1 egg (mixed into the filling to bind)

BUTTER WASH

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, melted
- 2 eggs, beaten
- 150ml (⅓ cup) whole milk
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- — Whisk all together into a liquid that will be brushed
- between and over every layer

TOP GLAZE

- 1 egg yolk + 1 tbsp milk, beaten
- 1 tbsp nigella seeds (çörek otu) and/or sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix crumbled cheese, parsley, and egg for filling.
2. Prepare butter wash by whisking butter, eggs, milk, and olive oil together.
3. Grease a 30x20cm (12x8-inch) baking tray generously.
4. LAYERING: Lay one sheet of yufka/filo in the tray (it will overhang the edges — that's fine).
5. Brush generously with butter wash.
6. Repeat with 2–3 more sheets, brushing each.
7. Spread the cheese filling evenly over the layered sheets.
8. Continue layering 3–4 more sheets over the filling, brushing each with butter wash.
9. Fold the overhanging edges back over the top.
10. Brush the entire top surface with egg yolk glaze.
11. Scatter nigella seeds and sesame seeds over the top.
12. With a sharp knife, score the top into diamond or square portions before baking.
13. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 35–40 minutes until deeply golden and crispy on top.
14. Rest 10 minutes before cutting along score lines.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~380 per piece

TIP

The butter wash between every layer is what creates börek's extraordinary architecture of crunch and lightness. Every single sheet must be brushed — unbuttered sheets stick together and create dense, doughy patches. Be generous. Börek is not a place for restraint with butter.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Turkish] [Pastry] [Make-Ahead] [Celebration]

RECIPE 419

■ ■ Turkey

SUCUKLU YUMURTA

TURKISH SAUSAGE AND EGGS

Turkey's most satisfying simple breakfast — sliced sucuk (dried, spiced beef sausage with cumin, garlic, and red pepper) fried in a pan until the edges caramelize and the fat renders, then eggs cracked directly into the sizzling sucuk fat and cooked until the whites are set with crispy edges and the yolk runny. Eaten directly from the pan with bread. The sucuk fat is the sauce. Nothing else is needed.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) sucuk (Turkish dried beef sausage),
 - sliced into thin rounds (4–5mm)
- 4 large eggs
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley (garnish)
- Fresh tomato and cucumber alongside
- Turkish bread for scooping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat a small cast-iron or heavy pan over medium heat. No oil needed — sucuk is very fatty.
2. Lay sucuk slices in a single layer.
3. Fry 1.5–2 minutes per side until: — The fat has fully rendered and pools in the pan — The slices are caramelized and slightly curled at edges — The kitchen smells of cumin and spiced meat
4. Move sucuk to the edges of the pan.
5. Carefully crack eggs into the hot sucuk fat in the center.
6. Cook over medium heat, occasionally basting the egg whites with the hot sucuk fat.
7. Cook until whites are fully set with slightly crispy golden edges — yolks should remain runny.
8. Remove from heat. Season egg yolks with black pepper.
9. Scatter fresh parsley.
10. Bring the pan directly to the breakfast table.
11. Serve with fresh bread for dipping into the yolk and sucuk fat.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The sucuk fat that renders during frying is the most flavorful cooking medium in the Turkish breakfast kitchen — intensely seasoned with the cumin, garlic, and red pepper from the sausage itself. Cooking eggs in this fat infuses them with all those flavors from below. This is why sucuklu yumurta tastes better than almost any other egg preparation.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Turkish] [Quick]

RECIPE 420

■ ■ Turkey

GÖZLEME

TURKISH STUFFED FLATBREAD

Turkey's most beloved stuffed flatbread — hand-rolled yufka filled with spinach and white cheese (or potato, or minced meat), folded into a large square, and cooked on a sac (flat iron griddle) until spotted golden on both sides with a creamy, molten filling. Made by village women and market vendors across Turkey with extraordinary speed and skill, gözleme is both street food and comfort food — the flatbread equivalent of a Turkish embrace.

INGREDIENTS

- GÖZLEME DOUGH:
- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- 150ml (⅔ cup) warm water
- 2 tbsp plain yogurt (makes the dough more pliable and creates slight flakiness)
- SPINACH AND CHEESE FILLING (most classic):
- 200g (7 oz) fresh spinach, wilted, squeezed very dry,
- and roughly chopped
- 200g (7 oz) beyaz peynir (Turkish white cheese) or
- feta, crumbled
- ½ tsp red pepper flakes (pul biber)
- Black pepper
- ALTERNATIVE FILLING (potato):
- 3 potatoes, boiled and mashed with butter and salt
- 1 onion, finely diced and softened
- Fresh dill and white cheese crumbles
- Butter or oil for cooking

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, oil, water, and yogurt into a smooth, soft dough. Knead 5 minutes. Rest 20 minutes.
2. FILLING: Mix together chosen filling ingredients. The filling should be cold before using.
3. Divide dough into 4 balls.
4. Roll each ball as thin as possible on a lightly floured surface — as thin as paper, translucent if possible. Gözleme dough should be very thin.
5. Spread filling generously over HALF the rolled dough.
6. Fold the unfilled half over the filled half. Press edges together to seal firmly.
7. Heat a flat pan, cast-iron skillet, or sac over medium-high heat. Brush with butter or oil.
8. Cook gözleme 2–3 minutes per side until golden, spotted, and slightly blistered.
9. Brush the cooked surface with a little butter immediately after flipping — it melts into the bread.
10. Slice into portions. Serve immediately — gözleme toughens quickly as it cools.

Prep: 20 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 6 min per gözleme · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~390 per gözleme

TIP

The dough must be rolled paper-thin — thick gözleme dough creates a heavy, bready result instead of the flaky, almost translucent texture of authentic gözleme. If the dough springs back during rolling, cover and rest 10 more minutes to allow the gluten to relax further.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Turkish] [Street Food] [Quick]

RECIPE 421

■ Turkey

ÇILBIR

TURKISH POACHED EGG IN YOGURT

An ancient Ottoman breakfast that has never gone out of fashion — perfectly poached eggs placed on a bed of cold garlic yogurt and drizzled with paprika-and-chilli butter. The contrast of warm runny egg against cold, tangy yogurt against hot, vivid butter is one of food's great triumphs of temperature and flavor. Recorded in Ottoman palace records from the 15th century. Equally magnificent then and now.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs, very fresh
- 1 tsp white wine vinegar (for poaching water)

GARLIC YOGURT

- 400g (1¾ cups) thick, full-fat plain yogurt
- 2 garlic cloves, minced to a paste
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp dried mint

PAPRIKA BUTTER

- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- 1 tsp pul biber (Turkish Mara■ chilli flakes)
- ½ tsp dried mint

GARNISH

- Fresh dill or parsley
- Extra chilli flakes
- Good Turkish bread for scooping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GARLIC YOGURT: Mix yogurt with garlic paste, salt, and dried mint. Taste — it should be creamy, slightly garlicky, and refreshingly cool. Refrigerate until serving.
2. PAPRIKA BUTTER: Melt butter in a small saucepan over medium heat until it foams and begins to smell nutty (brown butter stage is optional but excellent). Remove from heat. Add paprika, pul biber, and dried mint. The butter will sizzle and turn a vivid, deep red. Keep warm.
3. POACH EGGS: Bring a deep pot of water with vinegar to a bare simmer — no bubbles, just trembling.
4. Swirl the water gently. Crack one egg into a small cup. Slide gently into the center of the swirl.
5. Poach 3 minutes for runny yolk. Remove with a slotted spoon.
6. ASSEMBLE (work quickly): — Spread cold garlic yogurt in a wide, shallow bowl. — Place 2 warm poached eggs in the center. — Immediately pour hot paprika butter over the eggs — it will sizzle against the cold yogurt. — Scatter fresh dill and extra chilli flakes.
7. Serve immediately with bread for scooping.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~390 per serving

TIP

The temperature contrast is the entire achievement of ç■/b■r — warm egg against cold yogurt with hot butter. Prepare the yogurt ahead and keep it cold. Have the butter warm and ready to pour. Poach the eggs last and assemble immediately. Every second that passes reduces the temperature contrast that makes this dish extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Turkish] [Ottoman Heritage]

RECIPE 422

■ ■ Turkey

TÜRK ÇAYI

TURKISH BLACK TEA — THE DOUBLE BOILER METHOD

Turkey consumes more tea per capita than any country on earth, and every cup begins the same way: with a çaydanlık — a double-boiler teapot where water boils in the lower pot and strong tea steeps in the upper pot. The tea is poured from both, controlling strength by ratio. Served in small tulip-shaped glasses so the color can be appreciated. Drunk with two sugar cubes on the saucer. Refilled without asking. This is how Turkey begins every morning, every meeting, every conversation.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp loose-leaf Turkish black tea (Rize tea from the Black Sea region — the aromatic, slightly earthy variety that defines Turkish tea character.
- Do not substitute with Darjeeling or Ceylon — the flavor profile is entirely different.)
- 600ml (2½ cups) cold water (for the upper teapot)
- 600ml (2½ cups) cold water (for the lower teapot)
- Sugar cubes (at least 2 per person)

EQUIPMENT

- A çaydanlık (Turkish double-boiler teapot) — stacked
- pots, larger on the bottom for water, smaller on top
- for tea concentrate. A regular teapot on top of a
- pot of water works as a substitute.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Fill the lower, larger pot with 600ml water.
2. Rinse the upper, smaller teapot with boiling water to warm it.
3. Add loose tea to the warmed upper teapot.
4. Pour 600ml cold water over the tea leaves in the upper teapot.
5. Place the upper teapot on top of the lower water pot.
6. Bring the lower water to a boil.
7. Once the lower water boils, reduce heat to medium-low.
8. Allow the tea to steep in the upper pot for 15–20 minutes over the steam from the boiling water below. The tea will brew very strong and deep reddish-brown.
9. SERVING: Pour tea concentrate from the upper pot filling the tulip glass full.
10. Top up with boiling water from the lower pot to the desired strength — more water = acik (light), less water = koyu (dark/strong).
11. Place 2 sugar cubes on the saucer (not in the tea — Turks hold the sugar cube between their teeth and drink the tea through it).
12. Serve with the breakfast spread. Refill constantly.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 glasses · Cal: ~5 per glass (without sugar)

TIP

The 15–20 minute steep over steam is essential — not a Western 3-minute tea bag approach. Turkish tea requires time. The long steam-brewing extracts a complex, slightly tannic, deeply aromatic brew that no other method produces. The color should be a deep amber-red when poured strong (demir gibi — "like iron").

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Turkish] [Cultural Ritual] [Essential]

RECIPE 423

■ Turkey (Black Sea Region)

KAYGANA

TURKISH BLACK SEA HERBED OMELETTE

The breakfast of Turkey's lush Black Sea coast — a thick, fluffy pancake-omelette made from eggs, flour, and butter, abundantly flavored with fresh herbs. Less refined than menemen, more rustic than a French omelette, kaygana is a peasant dish of extraordinary warmth. Made in a heavy copper pan, topped with butter and honey, or filled with white cheese and eaten with fresh greens. The coastal Black Sea character — generous, herb-forward, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour (unusual for an omelette — creates the characteristic slightly thick, pancake-like texture)
- 50ml (3½ tbsp) whole milk
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 3 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh flat-leaf parsley, chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh green onion (or chives), sliced
- Optional: 2 tbsp beyaz peynir (white cheese), crumbled
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- Honey for drizzling (the Black Sea way — sweet on savory)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs with flour, milk, salt, and pepper until smooth and no flour lumps remain.
2. Add chopped dill, parsley, and green onion. Mix to distribute evenly.
3. Add crumbled white cheese if using.
4. Heat butter in a small, heavy pan over medium heat until foaming.
5. Pour egg mixture into the foaming butter.
6. Reduce heat to medium-low.
7. Cook undisturbed 3–4 minutes until the base is set and golden and the top is mostly set but still slightly wet.
8. Flip — either by tossing (confident) or using a plate to flip (careful). Cook 1–2 minutes on the second side.
9. The kaygana should be slightly puffed and golden on both sides.
10. Serve immediately.
11. Drizzle honey over the top — the Black Sea tradition of sweet honey over savory egg and herb pancake is essential to the authentic experience.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The flour in the batter is the defining feature of kaygana — it creates a slightly thick, slightly chewy texture partway between an omelette and a pancake that is unmistakably distinct from standard egg dishes. Do not omit it in favor of a "purer" omelette — the flour is the entire character of this dish.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Turkish] [Regional Specialty]

RECIPE 424

■ ■ Lebanon

LABNEH WITH ZA'ATAR AND

Lebanon's foundational breakfast ingredient — labneh, yogurt strained overnight until thick and creamy, drizzled with good olive oil and scattered with za'atar (the wild thyme spice blend of the Levant). Eaten with flatbread, fresh tomatoes, olives, and mint. Labneh is to Lebanese breakfast what butter is to French breakfast — the rich, dairy foundation upon which everything else is built. Za'atar over labneh with olive oil is the flavor of Lebanon.

INGREDIENTS

- HOMEMADE LABNEH (make 24 hrs ahead):
- 1kg (4½ cups) full-fat plain yogurt
- 1 tsp salt
- ZA'ATAR SPICE MIX (homemade — superior to bought):
- 3 tbsp dried wild thyme (the Levantine variety,
- Origanum syriacum — more aromatic than European thyme)
- 1 tbsp toasted sesame seeds
- 1 tsp sumac (ground dried sumac berries — essential
- for sourness)
- ½ tsp dried marjoram
- ½ tsp salt

FOR SERVING

- 4 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil (Lebanese or Palestinian
- olive oil if possible — noticeably more fragrant)
- 2 tomatoes, halved or sliced
- Fresh mint sprigs
- Cucumber, sliced
- Black olives
- Flatbread (khubz) or pita, warmed

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LABNEH: Mix yogurt with salt.
2. Line a large sieve with 3–4 layers of cheesecloth over a deep bowl.
3. Pour salted yogurt into the cloth.
4. Tie the cloth closed. Refrigerate 24 hours minimum (48 hours for very thick labneh).
5. The whey will drain — you will have approximately 600g (2½ cups) of thick, creamy labneh.
6. ZA'ATAR: Mix all za'atar ingredients together. Store in an airtight jar. Keeps 3 months.
7. SERVING: Spoon labneh onto a plate. Using the back of a spoon, swirl into a shallow well shape.
8. Drizzle olive oil generously — it should pool in the center well.
9. Sprinkle za'atar over the olive oil and labneh.
10. Arrange tomatoes, cucumber, olives, and mint around.
11. Serve with warm flatbread.

Prep: 10 min + 24 hrs draining · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~280 per serving

TIP

Za'atar must contain sumac — without the sourness of sumac, za'atar is just dried thyme and sesame. The sumac's tartness is what creates the complex, multi-dimensional flavor of real za'atar. Lebanese and Palestinian za'atar blends use wild Syrian oregano (za'atar in Arabic refers to the herb, not the blend) — look for "authentic" blends that specify the Levantine herb.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Lebanese] [Make-Ahead]

Lebanon

RECIPE 425

■ ■ Lebanon

MANAKEESH BI ZA'ATAR

LEBANESE THYME FLATBREAD

Lebanon's national breakfast flatbread — soft, yeasted dough rolled thin and spread generously with a paste of za'atar and olive oil, then baked at high heat until the za'atar blooms fragrant and the edges char slightly. Eaten straight from the oven, folded around fresh tomato, cucumber, and mint — the Levantine breakfast equivalent of a croissant. Made at every Lebanese bakery from 5am and carried home wrapped in paper still warm.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- ZA'ATAR AND OLIVE OIL PASTE:
- 4 tbsp za'atar spice mix (Recipe 424)
- 4 tbsp good extra-virgin olive oil
- Mix together into a thick, spreadable paste

FOR SERVING

- Fresh tomatoes, sliced
- Fresh cucumber, sliced
- Fresh mint leaves
- Labneh (optional, alongside)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and olive oil. Knead 8 minutes until smooth. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
2. Preheat oven to its highest setting (250°C+ / 480°F+) with a baking stone or heavy upside-down baking tray inside. The extreme heat is essential.
3. Divide dough into 6 equal balls.
4. Roll each ball very thin — 25–30cm circles, 3mm thick. Lebanese manakeesh are thin, not thick.
5. Spread za'atar paste generously over each round to the very edges — do not leave a border.
6. Slide directly onto the hot stone or tray.
7. Bake 7–9 minutes until edges are golden and slightly charred and the za'atar is fragrant and slightly caramelized.
8. Remove immediately. Eat while hot.
9. Fold the manakeesh around fresh tomato, cucumber, and mint to eat as a wrap — the traditional way.

Prep: 15 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 9 min per manakeesh · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per manakeesh

TIP

The oven must be extremely hot — 250°C+. Lebanese bakeries use wood-fired ovens at even higher temperatures. The blast of heat creates the signature blistered, slightly charred edges that a moderate oven cannot produce. Preheat for 30 minutes minimum with the stone inside. The temperature and speed of cooking are as important as the ingredients.

[Vegan] [Classic Lebanese] [Street Food] [Bakery Icon]

RECIPE 426

■ ■ Lebanon

FATTEH

LEBANESE CHICKPEA AND BREAD CASSEROLE

Lebanon's most elaborate and satisfying morning dish — layers of toasted bread, chickpeas, and rice topped with garlic yogurt sauce, tahini, warm chickpea broth, toasted almonds, and a drizzle of paprika butter. A breakfast that takes 30 minutes to assemble and seconds to eat. Found at specialized fatteh restaurants that open only in the morning, filling a room with the smell of toasting bread and garlic. One bowl contains everything Lebanon knows about layering flavors and textures.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups cooked chickpeas (from dry or canned)
- 2 cups cooked Egyptian rice or short-grain rice
- 3 large rounds of day-old pita bread, torn into pieces and toasted or fried until crispy

GARLIC YOGURT SAUCE

- 500g (2¼ cups) labneh or thick plain yogurt
- 3 garlic cloves, ground to paste with ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp tahini
- 1 tsp lemon juice

TAHINI SAUCE

- 3 tbsp tahini
- 2 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 garlic clove, minced
- 3 tbsp cold water
- Salt to taste

CHICKPEA BROTH

- 300ml (1¼ cups) chickpea cooking liquid OR vegetable broth seasoned with cumin and salt

TOPPINGS

- 50g (¼ cup) toasted pine nuts or slivered almonds
- Paprika butter: 3 tbsp butter + 1 tsp paprika + ½ tsp Mara[■] chilli flakes, melted together
- Fresh parsley, chopped
- Dried mint, crumbled

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GARLIC YOGURT: Mix labneh, garlic paste, tahini, and lemon juice. Taste — tangy, garlicky, rich.
2. TAHINI SAUCE: Whisk tahini with lemon juice, garlic, and water until smooth and creamy. Season with salt.
3. ASSEMBLY (in layers in a deep serving dish):
4. LAYER 1: Spread crispy toasted bread pieces across the bottom of the dish — cover completely.
5. LAYER 2: Ladle warm chickpea broth over the bread — enough to moisten but not soak entirely (the bread should have some crunch remaining).
6. LAYER 3: Spread cooked rice over the moistened bread.
7. LAYER 4: Spread warm chickpeas over the rice.
8. LAYER 5: Spread garlic yogurt generously over the chickpeas — cover completely.
9. LAYER 6: Drizzle tahini sauce over the yogurt.
10. FINISHING: Scatter toasted nuts. Drizzle paprika butter in a circular pattern. Sprinkle fresh parsley and dried mint.
11. Serve immediately — fatteh waits for no one. The bread softens within minutes.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per serving

TIP

Fatteh must be eaten IMMEDIATELY — within 5 minutes of assembly the toasted bread absorbs the yogurt and broth and softens entirely. The textural contrast between crispy bread, creamy yogurt, and warm chickpeas is what makes fatteh extraordinary. Assemble at the last possible moment and eat urgently.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Lebanese] [Celebration Breakfast]

RECIPE 427

■ ■ Lebanon

HUMMUS BI TAHINI

LEBANESE CHICKPEA AND SESAME DIP

Lebanon's most exported gift to world cuisine — chickpeas ground with tahini, lemon, and garlic into a silky, creamy dip. But the Lebanese breakfast hummus is not the pale, thick paste sold in Western supermarkets. It is made fresh that morning, still warm from the blender, crowned with olive oil, paprika, and whole chickpeas — eaten with warm fresh pita for breakfast at hummus shops (humusiyyeh) that open before 7am and close when the hummus runs out.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (2 cups) dried chickpeas, soaked overnight
- (do NOT use canned for the best result —
- freshly cooked chickpeas make dramatically better hummus)
- 1 tsp baking soda (added to soaking water and cooking)
- 120g (½ cup) good quality tahini
- (well-stirred — the oil and paste must be homogeneous)
- Juice of 2 lemons (or more — Lebanese hummus is tart)
- 2–3 garlic cloves, crushed with salt
- ½ tsp cumin
- Salt to taste
- 4–6 tbsp ice-cold water (for blending — cold water
- creates creamier, whiter hummus)

TOPPINGS

- 4 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp paprika (sweet)
- ½ tsp cumin
- Whole cooked chickpeas
- Fresh parsley
- Optional: pine nuts toasted in butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked chickpeas. Combine with fresh water and ½ tsp baking soda in a pot.
2. Bring to a boil. Skim foam very thoroughly.
3. Reduce heat. Simmer 45–60 minutes until chickpeas are very, very soft — almost falling apart. Lebanese hummus uses over-cooked chickpeas. Under-cooked chickpeas = grainy hummus.
4. Drain. Reserve cooking liquid. Let chickpeas cool until warm (not hot).
5. PEEL CHICKPEAS (optional but recommended): gently squeeze each chickpea between two fingers — the skin slips off. This creates noticeably smoother, whiter hummus. Tedious but worth it.
6. BLEND: Place tahini in food processor. Blend 1 minute.
7. Add lemon juice and garlic. Blend 1 minute.
8. Add warm chickpeas. Blend 3–4 minutes.
9. Add ice-cold water tablespoon by tablespoon until the hummus is smooth, pale, and creamy.
10. Season with salt and cumin. Blend briefly.
11. The hummus should be warm, silky, and almost pourable — not stiff.
12. Spread into wide, shallow bowls with a swirl in the center.
13. Drizzle olive oil into the center well.
14. Dust with paprika and cumin.
15. Scatter whole chickpeas and fresh parsley.
16. Serve immediately with warm fresh pita.

Prep: 15 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 60 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~295 per serving

TIP

Ice-cold water while blending is the professional Lebanese hummus technique — it emulsifies the tahini and chickpea into a paler, airier, creamier texture. Add the water one tablespoon at a time while the processor runs. Also: blend for much longer than seems necessary — 3–4 minutes of continuous blending creates a texture that 30 seconds cannot achieve.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Lebanese] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 428

■ ■ Lebanon

KAAK BI ANISE

LEBANESE ANISE RING BISCUITS

Lebanon's most beloved breakfast biscuit — golden ring-shaped sesame and anise cookies, crunchy and crumbly, carrying the distinct fragrance of mahleb (cherry pit spice) and anise that is uniquely Levantine. Sold by street vendors who carry them on large round trays through the morning streets of Beirut. Eaten with cheese, with tea, or alone — kaak bi anise is the flavor of a Lebanese morning walk.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 200ml (¾ cup) vegetable oil or clarified butter
- 80ml (⅓ cup) warm water
- 80ml (⅓ cup) warm milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp instant yeast
- 1 tsp anise seeds, lightly crushed
- ½ tsp mahleb powder (ground cherry pit — gives
- a distinctive slightly bitter, floral note)
- ½ tsp ground anise
- ½ tsp salt

COATING

- 1 egg, beaten
- 100g (¾ cup) sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, sugar, yeast, anise seeds, mahleb, ground anise, and salt together.
2. Add oil. Rub into the flour until sandy.
3. Add warm water and milk. Knead into a smooth, slightly firm dough — not too soft.
4. Cover. Rest 30 minutes.
5. Preheat oven to 180°C (355°F).
6. Pinch off pieces of dough. Roll into thin ropes (1cm diameter, 15cm long).
7. Bring ends together and pinch to form rings.
8. Brush each ring with beaten egg.
9. Press both sides into sesame seeds, coating generously.
10. Place on lined baking sheets.
11. Bake 20–22 minutes until deep golden and very crispy.
12. Cool completely — they crisp further as they cool.
13. Store in an airtight container. Keeps 2–3 weeks.
14. Serve with fresh white cheese and tea.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min rest · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 24 rings · Cal: ~145 per ring

TIP

Mahleb (ground from the pit of St. Lucie cherries) is the defining spice of Lebanese ka'ak — it provides a subtle, slightly bitter, cherry-almond note impossible to replicate with any substitute. Find it at Middle Eastern grocery stores. Without it, the biscuits are good. With it, they are unmistakably Lebanese.

[Vegan] [Classic Lebanese] [Make-Ahead] [Street Food] [With Tea]

RECIPE 429

■■ Lebanon (Mountain Villages)

KISHK SOUP

FERMENTED WHEAT AND YOGURT BREAKFAST SOUP

A deeply Lebanese mountain village breakfast — kishk (dried, fermented wheat and yogurt, ground to a pale powder) cooked into a thick, creamy, tangy porridge-soup with onion, garlic, and olive oil. The fermentation gives kishk a complex, sharp, deeply savory flavor that sustains through long mountain mornings. Topped with crispy fried onion and drizzled with olive oil, it is one of the Levant's most ancient and most forgotten treasures.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup kishk powder (dried fermented bulgur and yogurt —
- available at Lebanese and Middle Eastern grocery stores)
- 800ml (3■ cups) hot water
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- Salt and white pepper

FOR SERVING

- Fried onion (golden-brown and crispy)
- Drizzle of extra virgin olive oil
- Dried red chilli flakes
- Warm bread or pita

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FRIED ONION TOPPING: Fry half the diced onion in 2 tbsp olive oil over medium heat, 15–20 minutes, until deeply golden and crispy. Set aside.
2. In a saucepan, heat 2 tbsp olive oil over medium heat.
3. Add remaining onion. Cook 8 minutes until soft and golden.
4. Add garlic. Cook 1 minute.
5. Dissolve kishk powder in 200ml of the hot water — stir until smooth.
6. Pour kishk paste into the pan with the softened onion.
7. Add remaining hot water, stirring constantly.
8. Cook over medium heat, stirring frequently, 10–12 minutes as the soup thickens.
9. The kishk will thicken into a creamy, porridge-like consistency. If too thick, add more hot water.
10. Season with salt (kishk is naturally salty — taste first) and white pepper.
11. The flavor should be tangy, savory, deeply fermented — like a very flavorful yogurt soup.
12. Serve in bowls topped with crispy fried onion and a drizzle of olive oil. Add chilli flakes.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~240 per bowl

TIP

Kishk's fermented character means it can be an acquired taste — the tangy, funky depth is intense for those unfamiliar with it. Starting with a 50/50 blend of kishk and plain yogurt thinned with broth creates a gentler introduction. The authentic version uses kishk undiluted and is deeply rewarding once understood.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Lebanese] [Mountain Heritage] [Fermented]

RECIPE 430

■ ■ Lebanon

SFEEHA

LEBANESE OPEN-FACED MEAT PIES

Lebanon's beloved morning savory pastry — small, boat-shaped open-faced pies of soft yeasted dough topped with spiced minced lamb, tomato, and pine nuts, baked until the meat caramelizes and the edges of the dough turn golden. Found at bakeries throughout Lebanon, eaten by the piece for breakfast or as a mid-morning snack. The Baalbek region of Lebanon is particularly famous for its sfeeha — larger and more generously filled than the Beirut version.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water
- 3 tbsp olive oil

MEAT TOPPING

- 400g (14 oz) minced lamb (or beef — but lamb is traditional)
- 2 large ripe tomatoes, finely diced and drained
- 1 medium onion, finely diced
- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp allspice (Lebanese 7-spice blend — baharat)
- ¼ tsp black pepper
- ¼ tsp nutmeg
- 1 tsp pomegranate molasses (optional — adds brightness)
- Salt to taste
- 2 tbsp pine nuts
- 2 tbsp olive oil

SERVING

- Plain yogurt for dipping
- Fresh lemon juice to squeeze over
- Fresh tomato and parsley salad

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt. Add warm water and olive oil. Knead 8 minutes. Prove 45 minutes.
2. MEAT TOPPING: Mix minced lamb, drained tomatoes, onion, tomato paste, cinnamon, allspice, pepper, nutmeg, pomegranate molasses, and salt together. The mixture should be seasoned assertively. Do NOT cook the topping — it cooks on the pie.
3. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F).
4. Divide proved dough into 16 small balls.
5. Roll each into an oval shape (10x7cm).
6. Place on oiled baking sheets.
7. Spread 1 generous tbsp of meat topping over each oval, leaving a 5mm border. Press topping gently to adhere.
8. Scatter 3–4 pine nuts over each.
9. Drizzle a few drops of olive oil.
10. Bake 12–15 minutes until the meat is cooked through and caramelized at the edges, and the dough border is golden.
11. Serve hot with yogurt and lemon. A squeeze of lemon over the sfeeha at serving is essential.

Prep: 25 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 8 (2 pieces each) · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The raw meat topping is correct — do not pre-cook the lamb before spreading. The raw mixture spreads more evenly, adheres better, and the oven heat cooks it perfectly while the dough bakes. Pre-cooked meat becomes dry and crumbly during the second cooking.

[High Protein] [Classic Lebanese] [Bakery] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 431

■ ■ Israel

SHAKSHUKA

POACHED EGGS IN SPICED TOMATO SAUCE

Israel's most famous breakfast export — eggs poached directly in a spiced tomato and pepper sauce in a cast-iron pan, brought to the table still bubbling. Shakshuka is originally North African (Tunisian/Libyan) but has been adopted so completely by Israel that it is now considered the Israeli national dish. Eaten with crusty white bread for mopping the sauce. One pan, six ingredients, infinite satisfaction.

INGREDIENTS

- 5 large eggs
- 800g (28 oz) canned whole tomatoes, crushed by hand
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 1 large red bell pepper, diced
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- ½ tsp smoked paprika
- ¼–½ tsp cayenne or harissa paste (to taste)
- ½ tsp sugar
- Salt and black pepper
- 3 tbsp olive oil

GARNISH AND SERVING

- Fresh flat-leaf parsley or coriander, roughly chopped
- 100g (3.5 oz) feta cheese, crumbled (optional but excellent — the Israeli contemporary standard)
- Crusty bread or pita for mopping
- Labneh or yogurt on the side (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide, deep oven-safe pan (or a well-seasoned cast-iron pan) over medium heat.
2. Add onion. Cook 8–10 minutes until very soft and deeply golden.
3. Add red pepper. Cook 5 minutes until softened.
4. Add garlic. Cook 1 minute.
5. Add cumin, sweet paprika, smoked paprika, cayenne, and sugar. Stir and fry the spices 1 minute.
6. Add crushed tomatoes. Stir to combine.
7. Season generously with salt and pepper.
8. Bring to a simmer. Cook uncovered 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the sauce thickens and the flavors deepen. Taste and adjust.
9. The sauce should be thick, deeply colored, and intensely flavored — not watery or thin.
10. Create 5 small wells in the sauce with the back of a spoon.
11. Crack one egg carefully into each well.
12. Season eggs with a pinch of salt and pepper.
13. Cover the pan with a lid. Cook over medium-low heat 5–7 minutes until the whites are just set and the yolks remain runny — check frequently.
14. Remove from heat immediately when whites are set.
15. Scatter feta and fresh herbs over the top.
16. Bring the pan directly to the table.
17. Serve with crusty bread. Each person scoops their egg with surrounding sauce.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The sauce must be thick before eggs go in — thin, watery sauce creates eggs that steam rather than poach, resulting in overcooked whites with flat flavor. Cook the sauce until it is noticeably thick and the tomatoes have completely broken down. Then and only then add eggs. Also: remove from heat the moment whites set — residual heat finishes the yolks.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Israeli] [One-Pan]

RECIPE 432

■ ■ Israel

BUREKAS

ISRAELI FLAKY PASTRY FILLED PIES

The Israeli breakfast pastry institution — flaky, sesame-topped puff pastry triangles or squares filled with potato, cheese, spinach, or mushroom. Brought to Israel by Sephardic Jewish immigrants from Turkey, Yugoslavia, and Bulgaria, burekas have become one of Israel's most beloved morning foods. Sold at every Israeli bakery and street cart before 8am. Eaten with hard-boiled egg, fresh tomato, and a cup of salted pickle on the side.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) puff pastry, thawed
- 1 egg, beaten (for glazing)
- 2 tbsp sesame seeds (for topping)
- POTATO FILLING (most traditional):
- 4 medium potatoes, boiled and mashed
- 1 medium onion, finely diced and sautéed until golden
- 2 tbsp feta or salty cheese, crumbled
- 1 egg yolk
- Salt, white pepper, and dried dill

CHEESE FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) feta cheese, crumbled
- 200g (7 oz) Bulgarian white cheese or ricotta
- 2 eggs
- Black pepper and fresh dill
- SERVING (the complete Israeli burekas experience):
- Hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- Fresh sliced tomato with salt
- Cucumber slices
- Pickles or olives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make chosen filling. Cool completely before using.
2. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F).
3. Roll puff pastry to 3mm thick on a floured surface.
4. Cut into 12cm (5-inch) squares.
5. Place 1 generous tbsp filling in the center.
6. FOR TRIANGLES: fold diagonally to create a triangle. Press edges very firmly with a fork to seal.
7. FOR RECTANGLES: fold two opposite sides over the filling to overlap. Press to seal.
8. Brush tops generously with beaten egg wash.
9. Sprinkle sesame seeds over each burekas.
10. Bake 20–22 minutes until puffed, golden, and flaky.
11. IMPORTANT: The shape of the burekas reveals the filling in Israeli bakery tradition: — Triangle = potato — Rectangle = cheese — Round = mushroom This coding system allows customers to choose without asking. Honor the tradition.
12. Serve warm alongside hard-boiled egg and tomato.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~310 per burekas

TIP

The Israeli burekas tradition of shape = filling is a remarkable cultural shorthand. A triangular burekas will always contain potato in any Israeli bakery. This consistency has been maintained across the country for decades. When making burekas, follow the tradition — it connects the homemade to the cultural institution.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Israeli] [Sephardic Heritage] [Bakery Icon]

Israel

RECIPE 433

■ ■ Israel

ISRAELI SALAD

CHOPPED VEGETABLE SALAD

The Israeli breakfast table's constant companion — tomatoes and cucumbers chopped extremely fine (2–3mm dice) and dressed with olive oil, lemon, salt, and fresh parsley. Israeli salad is eaten at every breakfast, alongside everything, as the freshness that balances the richness of eggs, cheese, and pastry. The fineness of the dice is non-negotiable — this is not a rough chop salad. The technique releases more juices, creates a unified texture, and is the mark of a proper Israeli salad.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 medium ripe but firm tomatoes, finely diced
- (2–3mm dice — very fine, very specific)
- 3 Persian cucumbers or 1 regular cucumber, finely diced (same fine dice)
- ½ small red or white onion, extremely finely diced
- 3 tbsp fresh flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- Juice of 1 lemon (or more — Israelis use generous lemon)
- Salt to taste
- Optional: fresh mint leaves, finely chopped
- Optional: ½ green pepper, finely diced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dice tomatoes extremely fine — 2–3mm. This is the defining technique. Larger pieces are not Israeli salad.
2. Dice cucumber equally fine.
3. Dice onion very fine. Soak briefly in cold water if the raw onion flavor seems too strong — drain and use.
4. Combine tomato, cucumber, and onion in a bowl.
5. Add parsley and mint if using.
6. Dress with olive oil and lemon juice.
7. Season generously with salt.
8. Toss gently to combine.
9. TASTE — it should be bright, fresh, and acidic with a balanced olive oil richness.
10. Serve immediately as part of the breakfast spread. Israeli salad does not sit — the tomato juice accumulates quickly and softens the texture.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~95 per serving

TIP

The finely diced technique is the non-negotiable element of Israeli salad — it is not a caprese, not a Greek salad, not a rough-cut tomato salad. The fine dice creates a unified, almost textured sauce that each piece of bread or burekas is perfectly suited to scoop. Use a very sharp knife and take the time. The salad deserves the effort.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Low Carb] [Quick] [Classic Israeli]

RECIPE 434

■■ Israel

SABICH

PITA SANDWICH WITH FRIED EGGPLANT AND EGG

The great Israeli breakfast sandwich — a pita stuffed with fried eggplant, hard-boiled egg, Israeli salad, hummus, tahini, amba (Iraqi pickled mango sauce), and pickles. Sabich was created by Iraqi Jewish immigrants in Israel who traditionally ate this on Shabbat morning. Now it is one of Israel's most celebrated street foods. The amba is essential — the mango-turmeric pickle sauce that is sabich's defining, irreplaceable flavor.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large pita breads

FRIED EGGPLANT

- 2 large eggplants, sliced into 1cm rounds
- Salt (for degorging — 30 min + pat dry)
- Neutral oil for frying (generous — eggplant absorbs oil)

FILLINGS

- 4 hard-boiled eggs, sliced
- Israeli salad (Recipe 433)
- 4 tbsp hummus (Recipe 427)
- 4 tbsp tahini sauce:
 - (2 tbsp tahini + 1 tbsp lemon + 1 garlic clove + 3 tbsp water, whisked smooth)
- 4 tbsp amba (pickled mango sauce — available at Middle Eastern stores; or see variation below)
- Pickles (half-sour cucumbers, sliced)
- Shug (Yemenite green chilli paste — optional but authentic):
 - — Blend: fresh green chillies + garlic + coriander +
 - cumin + cardamom + salt + olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. EGGPLANT: Slice, salt generously, and rest 30 minutes. Pat very dry with paper towels — essential for good frying, not steaming.
2. Heat 1cm of oil in a wide pan over medium-high heat.
3. Fry eggplant rounds 3 minutes per side until deeply golden, soft inside, and caramelized outside.
4. Drain on rack, not paper towels (rack keeps crispy).
5. Season with salt.
6. AMBA (quick version): blend 2 tbsp mango chutney with ½ tsp turmeric + ½ tsp cumin + 1 tsp white vinegar + salt for a simplified approximation.
7. ASSEMBLE: Warm pita. Open the pocket.
8. Spread hummus inside the pita.
9. Add 2–3 fried eggplant rounds.
10. Add 1 sliced hard-boiled egg.
11. Spoon Israeli salad over generously.
12. Drizzle tahini sauce.
13. Add amba.
14. Add pickles and shug (if using).
15. Close. Eat immediately — the amba juice will soak through the pita within minutes.

Prep: 20 min (+ 30 min salting eggplant) · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~520 per sabich

TIP

Amba (Iraqi mango pickle sauce) is the ingredient that makes sabich sabich — without it, the sandwich is good but generic. With amba's tart, spiced, almost funky mango flavor, it becomes the specific, unrepeatable experience that thousands of people queue for in Tel Aviv. Find it at Middle Eastern grocery stores — it keeps for months refrigerated.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Israeli] [Street Food] [Iraqi Jewish Heritage]

RECIPE 435

■■ Israel (Yemenite Jewish)

MALAWACH

YEMENITE JEWISH FRIED LAYERED BREAD

Yemen's Jewish community brought malawach to Israel — a rich, layered flatbread made from dough laminated with butter or margarine into dozens of thin, flaky layers, then pan-fried until the outside is shatteringly crispy and golden while the inside separates into fluffy, buttery layers. Served with crushed fresh tomato, hard-boiled egg, zhug (Yemenite chilli sauce), and honey. One of Israel's most extraordinary breakfast foods and one of the world's finest flatbreads.

INGREDIENTS

MALAWACH DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 260ml (1 cup + 1 tbsp) warm water
- 200g (¾ cup + 2 tbsp) unsalted butter or
- non-dairy margarine (for laminating — generous)

ZHUG (YEMENITE GREEN CHILLI SAUCE)

- 6 fresh green chillies (bird's eye or serrano)
- 4 garlic cloves
- 1 cup fresh coriander, packed
- ½ cup fresh flat-leaf parsley
- ½ tsp cumin
- ½ tsp cardamom
- ½ tsp black pepper
- Salt to taste
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- — Blend all together to a coarse paste

SERVING

- Crushed fresh tomatoes (blend briefly with salt —
- a fresh tomato sauce, not cooked)
- Hard-boiled eggs, halved
- Honey (for the sweet accompaniment)
- Zhug (above)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, sugar, and water into a smooth, soft dough. Knead 8 minutes. Rest covered 30 minutes.
2. Divide into 6 portions. Roll each thinly (20–25cm circle).
3. Spread butter generously over each circle.
4. Stack all circles on top of each other (butter between).
5. Roll the stack into a log. Divide into 6 equal rounds.
6. Place each round flat. Cover. Refrigerate 30 minutes (or freeze for up to a month — malawach is typically made in large batches and frozen).
7. COOKING: Heat a non-stick or cast-iron pan over medium heat. No extra fat needed.
8. Place a cold malawach directly from refrigerator/freezer in the pan. Do NOT defrost first — cold dough creates better layers.
9. Cook 4–5 minutes until the bottom is very deeply golden — almost caramelized and crispy.
10. Flip carefully. Cook 4–5 minutes on the second side.
11. The malawach should be deeply golden, shatteringly crispy outside, and fluffy with separated layers inside.
12. Serve with fresh crushed tomato, zhug, honey, and egg.

Prep: 30 min + 30 min chilling · Cook: 10 min per malawach · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~490 per malawach

TIP

The contrast of sweet honey AND spicy zhug alongside the same malawach is the complete Yemenite experience — the same flatbread eaten with opposite condiments in alternating bites creates a continuous flavor cycle that makes each piece more satisfying than the last. Do not choose between sweet and spicy — use both simultaneously.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Israeli] [Yemenite Jewish Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 436

■ ■ Israel

SHAKSHUKA KHADRA

GREEN SHAKSHUKA WITH HERBS AND FETA

The vegetable-forward alternative to red shakshuka — eggs poached in a fragrant, herb-rich green sauce of spinach, Swiss chard, leeks, and fenugreek, topped with feta and dukkah. Created as an Israeli take on North African herb omelettes, green shakshuka has become enormously popular at Tel Aviv breakfast restaurants as a lighter, more spring-like alternative. The green sauce is as complex and satisfying as its red counterpart — just different.

INGREDIENTS

- 5 large eggs
- 400g (14 oz) fresh spinach or Swiss chard, roughly
- chopped (stems removed)
- 2 leeks, white and light green parts, thinly sliced
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 green chillies, finely sliced
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp ground coriander
- ½ tsp dried fenugreek leaves (methi)
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 150ml (⅔ cup) vegetable broth or water
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- Salt and black pepper

TOPPINGS

- 100g (3.5 oz) feta cheese, crumbled
- 2 tbsp dukkah (Egyptian nut and spice blend)
- Fresh coriander leaves
- A drizzle of olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide, deep pan over medium heat.
2. Add onion and leeks. Cook 8 minutes until soft.
3. Add garlic and green chillies. Cook 2 minutes.
4. Add cumin, coriander, fenugreek, and turmeric. Stir and cook 1 minute.
5. Add spinach in batches — it will wilt significantly. Toss to coat in the spiced oil.
6. Add broth or water. Cook 5–7 minutes until the greens are tender and the mixture is fragrant. The sauce should be loose enough for eggs to poach. Add more water if it looks dry.
7. Season generously with salt and pepper.
8. Create 5 wells in the green mixture.
9. Crack one egg into each well.
10. Cover with a lid. Cook over medium-low heat 5–6 minutes until whites are set, yolks runny.
11. Remove from heat immediately.
12. Scatter crumbled feta, dukkah, and fresh coriander.
13. Drizzle olive oil.
14. Bring pan to table. Eat with crusty bread.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

Fenugreek leaves (dried methi) are the ingredient that gives green shakshuka its distinctive slightly bitter, herbaceous depth — a flavor particularly characteristic of Yemenite Jewish cooking. Do not omit it or substitute — without fenugreek the sauce is pleasant but lacks the complexity that makes it extraordinary.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Modern Israeli] [Vibrant]

RECIPE 437

■■ Israel

TAHINI WITH HONEY AND WALNUTS

The simplest and most pure Israeli breakfast component — raw, high-quality tahini in a shallow bowl, drizzled with dark honey, scattered with toasted walnuts and a few flakes of sea salt. Eaten with bread, spread like a dip. The Israeli tahini standard is extraordinarily high — smooth, pale, completely raw and unhulled sesame ground to a fluid paste that the rest of the world has not yet surpassed. Good tahini with honey is one of the Mediterranean's most perfect flavor combinations.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (¾ cup) high-quality raw tahini
- (Israeli or Palestinian brand — Har Bracha, Al Kanater,
- or Soom are among the finest. True raw sesame tahini
- is paler, slightly bitter, and extraordinarily smooth)
- 3 tbsp cold water (to thin the tahini)
- ½ tsp lemon juice
- Pinch of salt

FOR THE BOWL

- 3 tbsp dark honey (wildflower or silan — date honey)
- 50g (½ cup) walnut halves, lightly toasted
- Flaky sea salt (Maldon or Israeli salt)
- Optional: a pinch of cinnamon

FOR SERVING

- Warm, fresh white bread or pita
- Fresh fruit alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. TAHINI PASTE: Stir tahini in its jar thoroughly — the oil and paste separate and must be recombined.
2. Combine tahini, cold water, lemon juice, and salt in a bowl. Whisk or stir.
3. The tahini will initially seize and thicken — this is normal. Continue adding water slowly, whisking, until it returns to a smooth, fluid, pale cream.
4. The thinned tahini should run slowly from a spoon — creamy but pourable.
5. Pour into a wide, shallow serving bowl.
6. Swirl with the back of a spoon to create a shallow well.
7. Drizzle honey generously into the well and over the tahini surface — it should pool in the center.
8. Scatter toasted walnuts.
9. Add a few flakes of sea salt directly onto the honey.
10. Dust with cinnamon if using.
11. Serve with warm bread.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Israeli and Palestinian tahini made from unhulled raw sesame seeds is a completely different product from the hulled sesame tahini used in most Western hummus recipes. It is paler, more bitter, more complex, and significantly more aromatic. The bitterness of raw tahini with the sweetness of honey is the specific combination that matters here — sweet tahini would destroy the contrast.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Israeli] [High Protein]

RECIPE 438

■■ Israel (Moroccan Jewish)

BOUREKAS MOROCCAN STYLE

NORTH AFRICAN JEWISH PASTRY

The Moroccan Jewish community's contribution to Israeli breakfast pastry culture — savory hand pies made from a semolina-enriched dough, filled with spiced beef and potato or tuna and harissa, fried in oil until golden. Distinguished from the Sephardic puff pastry burekas by their semolina-oil dough that creates a more rustic, slightly grainy texture. Eaten at Moroccan Jewish breakfast tables on Shabbat and sold at North African market stalls throughout Israel.

INGREDIENTS

MOROCCAN DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 100ml (■ cup) neutral oil
- 150ml (■ cup) warm water

SPICED BEEF AND POTATO FILLING

- 200g (7 oz) minced beef
- 2 medium potatoes, boiled and mashed
- 1 onion, finely diced and sautéed
- 1 tsp cumin
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp paprika
- ¼ tsp cinnamon
- ¼ tsp cayenne
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Oil for frying (or bake at 200°C / 390°F, 20 minutes)
- Harissa for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour, semolina, salt, and baking powder. Add oil. Rub into flour until sandy. Add warm water gradually. Knead into a smooth, pliable dough — slightly firmer than bread dough. Rest 20 minutes.
2. FILLING: Sauté onion until golden. Add minced beef. Cook until browned. Add all spices and coriander. Add mashed potato. Mix well. Taste and adjust. Cool before using.
3. Divide dough into 12 balls. Roll each into a thin circle (12cm).
4. Place 2 tbsp filling in the center.
5. Fold in half. Seal edges firmly.
6. Crimp edges with a fork or twist-fold the edge for a decorative seal.
7. FRY: Heat 2cm oil in a pan over medium heat. Fry pastries 3 minutes per side until deep golden.
8. Drain on rack. Serve hot with harissa on the side.

Prep: 30 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~380 per serving (2 bourekas)

TIP

The semolina in the dough creates a slightly coarser, grainier texture than pure flour pastry — this is the defining character of Moroccan Jewish bourekas. The semolina also creates a more golden, more substantial crust that holds up to frying better than delicate puff pastry would.

[High Protein] [Classic Israeli] [Moroccan Jewish Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 439

■■ Israel (Libyan / Tunisian Jewish)

CHRAIME WITH EGGS

NORTH AFRICAN SPICED FISH SAUCE WITH EGGS

The Libyan and Tunisian Jewish breakfast that surprises with its boldness — a fiery, deeply red spiced tomato sauce with cumin, caraway, and chilli in which eggs are poached or fish is cooked. In Israel, the egg version is eaten for weekend breakfast at Libyan-style restaurants in cities like Acre, Haifa, and Tel Aviv by North African Jewish communities and, increasingly, by everyone. The sauce is aggressive and extraordinary — sweet, spiced, and searingly hot.

INGREDIENTS

CHRAIME SAUCE

- 6 large ripe tomatoes, roughly chopped (or 800g canned)
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 6 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tsp caraway seeds, ground (caraway is the defining)
- North African Jewish spice of chraime — do not omit)
- 2 tsp sweet paprika
- 1 tsp hot paprika or chilli powder
- 1 tsp cumin
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tbsp harissa paste (or to taste)
- 1 tsp sugar
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- Salt to taste
- 100ml (■ cup) water
- 4–6 eggs for poaching
- Fresh coriander
- Crusty bread or challah

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a wide, deep pan over medium heat.
2. Add onion. Cook 8 minutes until deep golden.
3. Add garlic. Cook 1 minute.
4. Add caraway, paprika, hot paprika, cumin, and turmeric. Fry spices 1 minute — the kitchen should smell intensely aromatic.
5. Add tomato paste. Fry 1 minute.
6. Add chopped tomatoes and water. Stir to combine.
7. Add harissa and sugar.
8. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat. Simmer 15–20 minutes until thick, deeply red, and intensely spiced.
9. Season with salt. Taste — it should be hot, sweet, savory, and deeply aromatic with caraway.
10. Create wells. Crack eggs in. Cover.
11. Poach 5–6 minutes until whites set, yolks runny.
12. Scatter fresh coriander.
13. Serve directly from the pan with crusty bread.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Ground caraway seeds are the taste of chraime — this spice differentiates it from all other spiced egg dishes including shakshuka. Without caraway, the sauce is a generic spiced tomato sauce. With caraway, it is unmistakably North African Jewish and impossible to replicate with any other spice.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Israeli] [North African Jewish Heritage]

RECIPE 440

■■ Israel (Yemenite Jewish)

JACHNUN

YEMENITE SLOW-ROASTED ROLLED PASTRY

The most extraordinary Shabbat morning food in Israel — jachnun is a yeasted dough rolled paper-thin, brushed with butter, rolled tightly into a cylinder, then slow-cooked at very low heat for 10–12 hours until it becomes deeply caramelized, almost mahogany brown, intensely flavored, and completely unlike any other bread. Eaten on Saturday morning with freshly grated tomato, hard-boiled eggs cooked overnight alongside, and zhug. One of the world's most ancient and most extraordinary slow-cooked breads.

INGREDIENTS

JACHNUN DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 280ml (1¾ cups) warm water

LAMINATING

- 200g (¾ cup + 2 tbsp) unsalted butter, very soft
- OR: good-quality non-dairy margarine (for non-dairy)
- Shabbat table)

OVERNIGHT ADDITIONS

- 4 raw eggs in shell (cooked overnight alongside
- the jachnun — they become haminados: brown, creamy,
- and deeply flavored)

SERVING

- 4 medium tomatoes, grated on a box grater
- (discard skin that remains on the grater —
- the flesh and juice create a fresh tomato sauce)
- Zhug (Yemenite green chilli sauce — Recipe 435)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm water. Knead 8 minutes. Rest 30 minutes.
2. Divide into 6 portions. Roll each as thin as possible — paper-thin, translucent if possible.
3. Spread butter generously over each thin sheet.
4. Roll each sheet tightly from one end into a compact cylinder. Tuck ends under.
5. Place rolls side by side in a heavy, oven-safe pot with a tight-fitting lid. The rolls should fit snugly.
6. Nestle 4 uncooked eggs (in shell) between the rolls.
7. Cover the pot tightly with the lid.
8. SLOW COOKING: Place in a low oven at 100°C (210°F).
9. Cook undisturbed for 10–12 hours overnight.
10. When you open the lid in the morning, the jachnun will be deeply brown, caramelized, and fragrant. The eggs will be brown-shelled haminados.
11. Serve immediately with grated fresh tomato, the slow-cooked eggs (peeled and halved), and zhug.

Prep: 25 min + overnight cooking · Cook: 10-12 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~485 per serving

TIP

Jachnun's extraordinary character comes entirely from the 10–12 hour slow cooking — the sugars in the dough and butter undergo gradual Maillard reaction and caramelization, creating a depth of flavor impossible in short cooking times. The color goes from pale to golden to amber to the final deep mahogany brown — each stage adding new flavor compounds. This cannot be rushed.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Israeli] [Yemenite Jewish Heritage] [Shabbat]

Iran

RECIPE 441

■■ Iran

NAN-E BARBARI WITH

Iran's most beloved flatbread — barbari is a thick, oval flatbread with a deeply scored surface brushed with a salty-savory glaze (romal) of flour, baking soda, and water before baking, creating a shiny, chewy crust with a golden sesame topping. Eaten fresh from the neighborhood noonvaye (bakery) every morning, brought home wrapped in paper still warm, and eaten with white cheese, walnuts, fresh herbs (sabzi khordan), and honey. The combination is the Persian breakfast in its most essential form.

INGREDIENTS

BARBARI DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 320ml (1■ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- ROMAL GLAZE (the defining surface treatment):
- 1 tsp all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 100ml (■ cup) water
- Mix together — this is brushed over the dough before
- baking and creates the characteristic shiny surface

TOPPING

- 2 tbsp white sesame seeds
- 1 tbsp black sesame seeds (optional)
- Coarse sea salt

PERSIAN BREAKFAST SPREAD

- 200g (7 oz) lighvan or white cheese (similar to
- feta but milder — use feta as substitute)
- Walnut halves (a generous handful)
- 2 tbsp Persian sour cherry jam (moraba-ye albaloo)
- or quince jam
- 3 tbsp good dark honey
- Fresh herbs (sabzi khordan): mint, basil, tarragon,
- and radishes — placed fresh on the table

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, salt, and sugar. Add warm water and oil. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and elastic. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
2. Divide into 2 large pieces. Shape each into a thick oval (30x15cm). Place on oiled parchment.
3. Cover. Prove 30 minutes until puffed.
4. ROMAL: Mix flour, baking soda, and water in a small saucepan. Heat briefly, stirring, until the mixture thickens to a smooth paste. Cool slightly.
5. Preheat oven to 240°C (465°F) with a baking stone or heavy sheet inside.
6. Brush romal generously over the entire dough surface.
7. Using your fingertips, press 5–6 deep ridges lengthwise along the dough — not cutting through, but pressing deeply. These create the characteristic parallel channels.
8. Sprinkle sesame seeds and coarse salt generously.
9. Bake 12–15 minutes until deeply golden with a shiny, chewy crust.
10. SERVE: Tear barbari into pieces at the table. Arrange white cheese, walnuts, jam, honey, and fresh herbs in small dishes alongside. Eat by assembling on pieces of warm bread — cheese + walnut + honey, or cheese + herb + bread.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

The romal glaze is what creates barbari's distinctive shiny, slightly chewy, golden surface — unlike any other flatbread crust. The brief heating of the flour and baking soda in water creates a gel that bakes into a lacquer. Without it, the bread is just bread. With it, it becomes barbari.

[Vegan] [Classic Iranian] [Bakery] [Complete Breakfast]

RECIPE 442

■■ Iran

HALIM

PERSIAN WHEAT AND LAMB PORRIDGE

Iran's most nourishing and ancient breakfast — wheat berries and lamb shoulder slow-cooked together for hours until the wheat dissolves and the lamb falls apart, creating a thick, unctuous porridge with an extraordinary depth of flavor. Served with cinnamon, sugar, and melted butter swirled over the top. One of the oldest recipes in this book — halim variants appear in Persian texts from the 10th century. Iran's answer to every country's need for a sustaining winter morning meal.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (1½ cups) wheat berries (whole wheat kernels),
- soaked overnight and drained
- 400g (14 oz) lamb shoulder, bone-in
- 1 large onion, halved
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp white pepper
- 1 tsp salt
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- TOPPINGS (essential):
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 2 tbsp ground cinnamon
- 3 tbsp sugar (or to taste)
- Optional: saffron dissolved in 2 tbsp hot water
- for drizzling

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine soaked wheat berries, lamb, onion, turmeric, cinnamon, white pepper, salt, and water in a large heavy pot.
2. Bring to a boil. Skim foam thoroughly.
3. Reduce to lowest possible simmer. Cover.
4. Cook 3–4 hours until the wheat has completely broken down and the lamb is falling apart. Stir every 30 minutes to prevent sticking.
5. Remove lamb. Discard bones and fat. Shred meat finely.
6. Return shredded lamb to the pot.
7. Continue cooking uncovered over low heat, stirring constantly, 20 minutes more. Use a heavy wooden spoon to beat the mixture — the wheat should be completely smooth, the meat indistinguishable in the porridge. The texture should be dense, smooth, and hold its shape when spooned.
8. Taste and adjust salt.
9. SERVE: Ladle into wide bowls.
10. Drizzle melted butter in a generous swirl.
11. Dust cinnamon over the butter.
12. Sprinkle sugar across the top.
13. Drizzle saffron water if using — beautiful golden threads on the cinnamon-sugar surface.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 4 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per bowl

TIP

The beating at the final stage with a heavy wooden spoon is the technique that distinguishes smooth, silky halim from grainy halim. The vigorous stirring breaks down the wheat further and creates a unified, velvety texture. Beat hard for 5–10 minutes off the heat — the effort is immediately visible in the result.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Iranian] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 443

■■ Iran

NOON PANIR SABZI

BREAD, CHEESE, AND FRESH HERBS

The everyday Persian breakfast reduced to its most essential form — fresh flatbread (lavash or sangak), white cheese (lghvan or feta), and the Persian fresh herb plate (sabzi khordan). No cooking required. The quality of each ingredient is the entire recipe. In Iran, the morning herb plate is not a garnish — it is a main component. Fresh tarragon, mint, basil, fenugreek, and chives eaten alongside cheese and bread provide a freshness and nutritional density that cooked breakfast foods cannot match.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large lavash flatbreads (paper-thin) OR
- warm barbari (Recipe 441), torn
- 200g (7 oz) lighvan white cheese (or good quality
- feta — crumbled or in blocks)
- Walnut halves (generous)
- Honey (dark floral variety) or cherry jam

SABZI KHORDAN (PERSIAN FRESH HERB PLATE)

- Fresh mint sprigs, abundant
- Fresh basil (Persian basil is more anise-forward
- than Italian — use both or just Persian)
- Fresh tarragon sprigs
- Fresh fenugreek leaves (shanbalileh)
- Radishes, trimmed
- Green onions, whole
- Fresh dill sprigs (optional)
- Washed and drained — served as a heaped, colorful plate
- PERSIAN TEA (chai):
- Loose-leaf black tea (Lahijan tea from Gilan province)
- Brewed very strong in a small teapot
- Poured into small glass cups
- Served with nabat (rock sugar candy) for stirring

INSTRUCTIONS

1. HERBS: Wash all herbs thoroughly. Dry gently. Arrange in a heap on a large plate — the presentation should be abundant and colorful.
2. Prepare all other components in small dishes.
3. SET THE TABLE: Bread in the center. Cheese, walnuts, honey, and jam in small dishes. Fresh herbs piled high.
4. BREW TEA: Bring water to a boil. Brew tea very strong in a small teapot. Place the teapot on top of the samovar (or over a very low flame) to keep hot.
5. Pour tea into small glass cups. Add nabat or sugar to taste.
6. EATING: Tear bread. Place a piece of cheese on it. Add a sprig of tarragon and a mint leaf. Bite. Follow with a sip of hot tea.
7. This is the complete Persian breakfast method. No single bite has everything — the flavors alternate.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 5 min (tea only) · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~350 per serving

TIP

Fresh tarragon is the defining herb of Persian sabzi khordan — its sweet, anise-like flavor is specifically Persian and unlike any other cuisine's herb plate. Do not substitute with dried tarragon. Fresh tarragon alongside fresh mint, basil, and white cheese creates the exact flavor combination that defines Persian morning eating culture.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Quick] [Classic Iranian] [No-Cook]

RECIPE 444

■■ Iran

OMLET-E GOJEH FARANGI

PERSIAN TOMATO OMELETTE

Iran's most popular hot breakfast — a thick, rustic omelette cooked with ripe tomatoes, onion, and turmeric in clarified butter or oil. Unlike the Turkish menemen (which is looser and more scrambled), the Persian omlet is cooked into a firm, flat round with a golden crust — flipped once and served whole in the pan. Eaten with fresh bread and herbs. The turmeric turns the eggs a vivid, warm golden color that is quintessentially Persian.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 3 medium ripe tomatoes, finely diced
- 1 medium onion, finely diced
- 1 green chilli, finely chopped (optional)
- ½ tsp turmeric
- ½ tsp salt
- ¼ tsp black pepper
- 2 tbsp clarified butter (roghan — traditional) or oil
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley or coriander (garnish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat 1 tbsp butter in a pan over medium heat.
2. Add onion. Cook 6–7 minutes until golden.
3. Add green chilli if using. Cook 30 seconds.
4. Add diced tomato and turmeric. Cook 7–8 minutes until tomatoes have completely broken down and the mixture is thick. Season with salt and pepper. The mixture should be almost dry — no liquid.
5. Beat eggs with a fork. Do NOT over-beat — some streaking is fine.
6. Pour eggs over the tomato-onion mixture. Swirl to spread evenly.
7. Add remaining butter around the edges of the pan.
8. Cook over medium heat WITHOUT STIRRING for 4 minutes until the base is golden and set.
9. Check by lifting one edge with a spatula.
10. Flip the entire omelette confidently using a plate. Slide back into the pan.
11. Cook 2–3 minutes on the second side.
12. Slide onto a serving plate. Garnish with fresh herbs.
13. Eat in wedges with fresh bread.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~290 per serving

TIP

The tomatoes must be cooked down completely to a thick paste before adding egg — any remaining liquid prevents the omelette from setting properly and causes it to stick. This cooking-down step is the patience that ensures the result. Once the egg goes in, resist stirring — the flat, unified omlet is the Iranian form, not scrambled eggs.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Iranian] [Quick]

Egypt

RECIPE 445

■■ Iran

KALEH PACHE

SLOW-COOKED HEAD AND HOOF SOUP

Iran's most prized breakfast delicacy — the entire sheep's head and trotters slow-cooked overnight in water with onion and turmeric until the collagen dissolves and the broth becomes thick, golden, and intensely nourishing. Eaten at specialist kaleh pache restaurants that open only from midnight to 10am. Served with fresh warm bread, lemon, dried mint, and raw onion. Deeply beloved and equally controversial — the breakfast that sustains Iran's working people through the longest mornings.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cleaned sheep's head, split (ask butcher) + 4 trotters
- (thoroughly cleaned, hair removed, blanched)
- 2 large onions, halved
- 1 tsp turmeric
- Salt and white pepper
- 2L+ water to cover generously

GARNISHES AND SERVING

- Fresh lemon juice (generous)
- Dried mint (crumbled) — essential
- Raw white onion, finely sliced
- Bread (sangak or lavash) for dipping
- Optional: dried fenugreek leaves (shanbalileh)
- Dried rose petals (gol-e sorkh) — the Persian touch
- **CONDIMENTS (at the table):**
- Salt, white pepper, and dried mint
- Cider vinegar (serkeh)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **CLEANING:** Soak all meat in cold water 1 hour. Rinse thoroughly. Blanch in boiling water 10 min. Drain and rinse again. This step is essential.
2. Place cleaned head, trotters, onions, and turmeric in a very large pot. Cover completely with fresh water.
3. Bring to a boil. Skim foam very thoroughly.
4. Reduce to the lowest possible simmer. Cover.
5. Cook 6–8 hours — overnight is traditional — until all the meat falls from the bone and the broth is thick, golden, and richly gelatinous.
6. Season with salt and white pepper.
7. **STRAINING AND SERVING:** Remove head and trotters. Carefully extract all the cooked meat — tongue, cheek, brain, and trotter meat. Remove bones.
8. Strain broth. Return broth to pot.
9. Slice tongue thinly. Arrange brain carefully. Add all meats back to the broth.
10. Ladle hot soup with meat into deep bowls.
11. Squeeze generous lemon juice directly into bowl.
12. Crumble dried mint over the surface.
13. Add sliced raw onion.
14. Serve with warm fresh bread.

Prep: 20 min + overnight cooking · Cook: 8 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per bowl

TIP

The broth of kaleh pache should be so rich in gelatin that it partially sets when cooled — like a loose jelly. This indicates maximum collagen extraction from the head bones and trotters. If the broth is still liquid when cooled, cook for 2 more hours. The gelatinous quality is what makes this breakfast restorative and sustaining.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Iranian] [Dawn Breakfast] [Offal]

RECIPE 446

■ ■ Egypt

FUL MEDAMES

EGYPTIAN STEWED FAVA BEANS

Egypt's national dish and most ancient breakfast — dried fava beans slow-cooked for hours until completely soft, then dressed with olive oil, cumin, lemon, garlic, and fresh herbs. Eaten from the same copper cauldron (qidra) for five thousand years. Every Egyptian eats ful medames. Every Egyptian's family makes it differently. This recipe represents the core — the rest is beautiful variation.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups dried small fava beans (ful nabe), soaked overnight OR use canned (less authentic but faster)
- 5 garlic cloves, minced or crushed
- Juice of 2 lemons (generous)
- 4 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp ground coriander
- Salt to taste
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley, roughly chopped
- ACCOMPANIMENTS (all served simultaneously):
- Warm Egyptian bread (aish baladi — whole wheat)
- flatbread, or pita)
- 2 tomatoes, diced
- 2 hard-boiled eggs
- Sliced cucumber
- Raw onion, sliced
- Fresh chillies
- Olive oil for extra drizzle
- Optional: tahini on the side
- VARIATION TOPPINGS (each table does something different):
- Crushed tomato with green chilli and coriander
- Fried egg on top
- Crumbled white cheese
- Chilli oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If using dried beans: drain soaked beans. Cover with fresh water by 5cm. Bring to a boil.
2. Reduce heat. Simmer 1.5–2 hours until beans are completely soft — they should mash easily between fingers.
3. Add more water during cooking if needed.
4. When beans are very soft: drain, keeping 200ml cooking liquid.
5. In the pot, roughly mash about ¼ of the beans against the side — this creates a thick, creamy consistency while some beans remain whole.
6. Add crushed garlic, lemon juice, cumin, coriander, and olive oil.
7. Add enough reserved cooking liquid to reach a loose, spoonable consistency.
8. Season generously with salt.
9. Stir and simmer 5 minutes for flavors to meld.
10. TASTE: it should be richly savory, garlicky, lemony, and earthy with cumin.
11. Transfer to a serving bowl or plate.
12. Drizzle more olive oil over the top.
13. Scatter fresh parsley.
14. Serve surrounded by all accompaniments. Each person customizes their own bowl.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 2 hours · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

The final 5-minute simmer after adding all the seasonings is essential — garlic, lemon, and cumin need brief heat to meld into the beans rather than tasting raw and separate. This short additional cooking transforms the sum of ingredients into something unified. Also: ful medames should always be slightly loose — add cooking liquid to reach a consistency that can be scooped with bread.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Egyptian] [Ancient Recipe]

RECIPE 447

■ ■ Egypt

TA'MEYA

EGYPTIAN FAVA BEAN FALAFEL

Egypt's falafel — made from soaked (not cooked) fava beans ground with herbs, onion, and spices, and deep-fried until the outside is shatteringly crispy and vivid green inside. Egyptian ta'meya is fundamentally different from the Lebanese and Israeli chickpea falafel — the fava beans create a softer interior and a more herb-forward, verdant flavor. Eaten in aish baladi sandwiches with salad and tahini, or alongside ful medames for the complete Egyptian breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (1½ cups) dried split fava beans (ful nabe) without skin, soaked overnight — NOT cooked
- Raw soaked beans are the non-negotiable starting point.
- Cooked beans create mush, not falafel.
- 1 large onion, roughly chopped
- 6 garlic cloves
- 1 cup fresh flat-leaf parsley, packed
- 1 cup fresh coriander, packed
- 1 cup fresh dill (the Egyptian addition — unusual but essential for ta'meya character)
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp ground coriander
- ½ tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp cayenne or chilli powder
- Sesame seeds for coating
- Oil for deep frying

FOR SERVING

- Aish baladi or pita bread, opened as pocket
- Tahini sauce: tahini + lemon + garlic + water
- Sliced tomato
- Fresh parsley
- Pickled turnips (pink from beetroot)
- Hot sauce

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked fava beans thoroughly. Pat dry.
2. Grind beans in a food processor until fine crumbs — not a paste. The mixture should look like coarse green-flecked breadcrumbs.
3. Add onion, garlic, parsley, coriander, and dill. Process until everything is finely minced and combined — scrape down sides frequently.
4. Add cumin, coriander, baking powder, salt, and cayenne. Process briefly.
5. The mixture should hold together when pressed firmly. If too dry, add 1 tbsp water. If too wet, add 1 tbsp gram flour.
6. Refrigerate 30 minutes — chilling helps binding.
7. Shape into flat discs or ovals (ta'meya shape) rather than balls. Egyptian ta'meya is typically patty-shaped, not round.
8. Coat each patty in sesame seeds, pressing firmly.
9. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F).
10. Fry in batches 3–4 minutes until deep golden — the outside should be crispy and the sesame seeds toasted. The inside will be bright green.
11. Drain on rack.
12. Stuff into bread with tahini, salad, and pickles.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking + 30 min chilling · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Fresh dill is what makes ta'meya Egyptian rather than generic falafel — it creates the specific herbal character that is immediately recognizable to anyone who has eaten at a Cairo ful-and-ta'meya cart. The sesame seed coating creates an additional crunch layer beyond the fried exterior. Both are distinctively Egyptian and non-optional.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Egyptian] [Street Food]

RECIPE 448

■ ■ Egypt

FETEER MESHALTET

EGYPTIAN MULTI-LAYERED FLAKY PASTRY

Egypt's most theatrical pastry — a massive, thin dough stretched to translucency, folded and layered dozens of times with clarified butter, baked into a shatteringly crispy, thousand-layered round. Made on round tin trays by feteer bakers (fatatri) who spin and stretch the dough with extraordinary speed and skill. Eaten sweet (with honey, cream, or jam) or savory (with cheese or minced meat). The Egyptian equivalent of croissant culture — an art form that produces something extraordinary.

INGREDIENTS

FETEER DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp neutral oil

LAMINATING FAT

- 200g (¾ cup + 2 tbsp) samn (Egyptian clarified butter
- or ghee) — very soft, almost liquid at room temperature
- SWEET TOPPINGS (choose one combination):
- Honey + ashta (thick clotted cream) — the classic
- Jam + powdered sugar
- Dark honey + walnuts

SAVORY TOPPINGS

- White cheese (feta style) crumbled inside
- Egg cracked inside layers before last fold

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, salt, sugar, and yeast. Add warm water and oil. Knead 10 minutes. The dough must be very smooth and extensible.
2. Divide into 4 balls. Coat each with samn. Rest 20 min.
3. On an oiled surface, stretch one ball VERY thin — pull and spin it until nearly translucent (50cm+).
4. Brush the stretched dough with melted samn.
5. Add filling (if savory) at this stage.
6. Fold the dough onto itself multiple times — left third over center, right third over. Then top third down, bottom third up. You should have a compact, multi-layered square.
7. Brush again with samn. Fold again.
8. Repeat the stretch-brush-fold sequence 2–3 more times.
9. Finally, press into a large circle on an oiled round baking tray.
10. Brush generously with samn on top.
11. Bake at 230°C (445°F) for 15–18 minutes until deeply golden and shatteringly crispy.
12. Add sweet toppings immediately while hot. Tear and eat from the tray.

Prep: 30 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The stretch must be as thin as possible — genuine translucency, where you can read text through the dough. Egyptian fatatri can stretch a dough ball to a full meter diameter in seconds. At home, work more slowly but aim for the same translucency. Thicker dough creates a heavy, bready result. Thin dough creates the thousand-layer crispiness that defines feteer.

[Vegetarian option] [Classic Egyptian] [Pastry Art] [Special Occasion]

RECIPE 449

■ ■ Egypt

BEID BIL BASTURMA

EGGS WITH SPICED DRIED BEEF

Cairo's most satisfying morning pan — basturma (air-dried beef coated in a paste of fenugreek, garlic, and paprika) fried until the spice coating caramelizes and the edges crisp, with eggs cracked into the intensely flavored fat. The smell of basturma frying is one of Cairo's most evocative morning aromas — pungent, spiced, and deeply savory. Eaten with fresh aish baladi and pickles. No other ingredient fuses Egypt's Middle Eastern and Armenian heritage as completely as basturma.

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (5 oz) basturma (Armenian/Egyptian spiced dried beef), thinly sliced — available at Middle Eastern and Armenian grocery stores
- 4 large eggs
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley (garnish)
- Aish baladi or pita bread
- Pickled vegetables (torshi)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place a heavy pan (no oil needed) over medium heat.
2. Arrange basturma slices in a single layer.
3. Fry 1.5–2 minutes per side. The spice coating (chaman paste) will caramelize and the fat will render. The smell is intense — this is correct.
4. The basturma will darken and crisp at the edges.
5. Move basturma to the sides. The rendered spiced fat pools in the center.
6. Crack eggs into the center of the pan.
7. Baste the egg whites with the hot basturma fat.
8. Cook until whites are set — yolks runny.
9. Season eggs very lightly (basturma is very salty).
10. Scatter fresh parsley.
11. Serve directly from the pan with warm bread and pickled vegetables.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~350 per serving

TIP

Basturma's chaman coating (a paste of fenugreek, allspice, garlic, and paprika) has an extremely powerful aroma when heated — close neighbors will know what you are cooking. This is not a subtle breakfast ingredient. The payoff is eggs cooked in one of the most intensely flavored natural fats in any kitchen.

[High Protein] [Low Carb] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Egyptian] [Quick]

RECIPE 450

■ Saudi Arabia

HAREES

SAUDI CRACKED WHEAT AND MEAT PORRIDGE

The Saudi Arabian Ramadan breakfast and Eid morning staple — cracked wheat slow-cooked with lamb or chicken until both completely dissolve into a thick, smooth, golden porridge of extraordinary richness. The Saudi version is more robustly spiced than the Iranian halim, with cinnamon, cardamom, and rose water finishing the dish. Served with clarified butter (samn) melted over the top and a dusting of cinnamon — one of Arabia's most comforting and ancient morning foods.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups coarse cracked wheat (harees wheat — husked whole wheat, not bulgur)
- 400g (14 oz) bone-in chicken pieces or lamb
- 1 onion, halved
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp salt
- 1.5L (6 cups) water

FINISHING

- 4 tbsp samn (Saudi clarified butter or ghee)
- Ground cinnamon for dusting
- Optional: 1 tsp rose water stirred in at the end — the Saudi fragrance that distinguishes harees

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Wash cracked wheat thoroughly. Soak 2 hours.
2. Drain. Combine with meat, onion, turmeric, and water.
3. Bring to a boil. Skim foam thoroughly.
4. Reduce heat to very low. Cover.
5. Cook 2–3 hours until both wheat and meat are completely soft. Stir every 30 minutes.
6. Remove meat. Discard bones. Shred meat finely.
7. Return shredded meat to the pot.
8. Add cinnamon, cardamom, and salt.
9. Beat vigorously with a heavy wooden spoon or use an immersion blender briefly — the wheat should be smooth and creamy.
10. Cook uncovered 20 more minutes, stirring, until the porridge is thick and pulls away from the sides.
11. Stir in rose water if using.
12. SERVE: Ladle into wide bowls.
13. Create a small well in the center.
14. Pour melted samn into the well.
15. Dust cinnamon generously over the entire surface.

Prep: 10 min + 2 hrs soaking · Cook: 3 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~390 per bowl

TIP

Vigorous beating with a wooden spoon during the final cooking phase creates the smooth, porridge-like consistency. Do not use a blender for more than a few seconds — overblending creates a gluey, starchy texture. Manual beating preserves some wheat texture while still achieving smoothness.

[High Protein] [Classic Saudi] [Festive] [Ramadan] [Comfort Food]

Saudi Arabia

RECIPE 451

■ Saudi Arabia (and across the Gulf)

MUTABBAQ

SAUDI STUFFED PANCAKE

The Arabian Peninsula's most beloved street pastry — a thin, elastic dough stretched on a flat griddle, filled with spiced minced meat and egg, folded into a neat square package, and pan-fried in ghee until golden on both sides. Found from Jeddah to Muscat to Singapore (where the Indian Muslim community brought it across the Indian Ocean), mutabbaq is one of the great flatbread traditions of the Muslim world. The name means "folded" in Arabic — the process is the dish.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 160ml (⅔ cup) warm water
- 2 tbsp neutral oil

FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) minced lamb or beef
- 1 large onion, very finely diced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 green chillies, finely chopped
- 2 large eggs, beaten into filling
- 2 tbsp fresh coriander, chopped
- ½ tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp cumin
- ¼ tsp cardamom
- ¼ tsp black pepper
- Salt to taste

COOKING

- Ghee or clarified butter for cooking (generous)
- Ghee must be melted and warm

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, water, and oil into a smooth, elastic dough. Knead 8 minutes. Coat with oil. Rest 30 minutes.
2. FILLING: Mix minced meat with onion, garlic, chilli, coriander, and all spices. Season with salt. Add beaten eggs. Mix thoroughly. Do NOT cook the filling — it cooks in the mutabbaq.
3. Divide dough into 6 balls.
4. On an oiled surface, stretch each ball VERY thin — 30–35cm circle, nearly translucent.
5. Place 3–4 tbsp filling in the center.
6. Fold the four sides inward, one at a time, creating a neat square parcel (15x15cm).
7. Heat a wide flat pan with generous ghee over medium heat.
8. Place mutabbaq seam-side down in the ghee.
9. Fry 3–4 minutes until deep golden and crispy.
10. Flip. Fry 3–4 minutes on the second side.
11. The filling should be cooked through when done. Test by pressing — it should feel firm.
12. Drain on rack. Cut into 4 squares.
13. Serve immediately — mutabbaq is best hot and crispy.

Prep: 25 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per mutabbaq

TIP

The raw filling is correct — do not pre-cook the meat. The egg mixed directly into the raw filling creates a custard-like interior when the mutabbaq cooks. Pre-cooked filling dries out in the pan and creates a crumbly, dry interior. Raw filling + heat = moist, binding, perfectly cooked interior.

[High Protein] [Classic Saudi] [Street Food] [Gulf Heritage]

RECIPE 452

■ Saudi Arabia (pan-Arabian)

QAHWA ARABIYYA WITH DATES

ARABIC COFFEE AND DATES

The elemental Arab welcome and morning ritual — qahwa (unroasted or lightly roasted green coffee scented with cardamom and saffron) served in small handleless cups (finjan) alongside fresh dates. Arab coffee is not about caffeine — it is about hospitality, ceremony, and the specific flavor of cardamom-scented, pale golden coffee that is entirely different from any roasted coffee tradition. The cup is refilled until you signal completion by tilting it. This is the morning ceremony of Arabia.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp lightly roasted Arabic coffee beans,
- coarsely ground (qahwa — pale golden roast with
- cardamom already added during roasting.
- Available at Middle Eastern grocery stores.)
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- 1 tsp ground cardamom (additional — to taste)
- ½ tsp ground saffron (bloomed in 2 tbsp hot water)
- Optional: a few dried rose petals
- Optional: 1 tbsp ground dried cloves (za'faran)

DATES

- 12 fresh Medjool dates (the finest available)
- OR: 12 dried khalas, ajwa, or safawi dates —
- each variety has devotees across Saudi Arabia

EQUIPMENT

- A dallah (Arabic long-spouted coffee pot) — traditional
- OR: a small saucepan and pitcher for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil in the dallah or saucepan.
2. Add coarsely ground Arabic coffee.
3. Bring back to a boil. Reduce heat immediately.
4. Simmer very gently 10 minutes.
5. Add additional cardamom. Stir gently.
6. Add bloomed saffron and rose petals if using.
7. Simmer 5 more minutes.
8. The qahwa should be pale golden — not dark brown.
9. Pour through a fine strainer into the dallah or serving pitcher.
10. SERVING: Pour into small finjan cups — fill only halfway (a full cup suggests you want the guest to leave).
11. Arrange dates on a small plate alongside.
12. The ritual: guest receives cup with right hand. Drinks in small sips. Returns cup. Host refills. Guest signals enough by tilting the cup side to side when returning it.
13. Eat a date between sips — the sweetness complements the unsweetened, cardamom-scented coffee.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~95 per serving (with 3 dates)

TIP

Arabic coffee should NEVER be dark. A dark, bitter roast is espresso culture. Qahwa is made from green or lightly roasted beans specifically to retain the grassy, cardamom-forward, mild character. Qahwa brewed with dark-roasted beans is simply wrong — the flavor is completely different and the saffron and cardamom cannot be tasted against strong roasted notes.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Saudi] [Cultural Ritual] [Ceremony]

RECIPE 453

■ ■ UAE

BALALEET

EMIRATI SWEET VERMICELLI WITH OMELETTE

The most characteristic Emirati breakfast — sweet vermicelli cooked with sugar, rose water, cardamom, and saffron, topped with a thin, folded omelette flavored with the same fragrant spices. The sweet- savory combination of spiced sweet noodles under a savory egg is uniquely Gulf — unexpected to outsiders and deeply beloved to every Emirati. Eaten on Thursday and Friday mornings (the Gulf weekend) as a family breakfast with Arabic coffee and dates.

INGREDIENTS

SWEET VERMICELLI

- 200g (7 oz) thin vermicelli (shaariya)
- 3 tbsp ghee (samn)
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp ground cardamom
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- Pinch of saffron bloomed in 2 tbsp rose water
- 1 tbsp rose water
- 100ml (■ cup) water

FRAGRANT OMELETTE

- 4 large eggs
- ¼ tsp turmeric
- ¼ tsp ground cardamom
- Pinch of saffron bloomed in 1 tbsp warm water
- 1 tbsp rose water
- ½ tsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- 1 tbsp ghee

INSTRUCTIONS

1. VERMICELLI: Break vermicelli into 5–6cm pieces.
2. Heat ghee in a pan over medium heat.
3. Add vermicelli. Stir-fry 3–4 minutes until golden — the toasting creates a nutty flavor that distinguishes balaleet from plain noodles.
4. Add water. Stir. Cover. Cook 3 minutes.
5. Add sugar, cardamom, cinnamon, saffron-rose water, and extra rose water. Stir gently.
6. Cook covered over very low heat 5 minutes until vermicelli is tender and all liquid absorbed.
7. The vermicelli should be slightly clumped from the sugar — sweet, fragrant, and soft.
8. OMELETTE: Beat eggs with turmeric, cardamom, saffron water, rose water, sugar, and salt.
9. Heat ghee in a clean pan over medium heat.
10. Pour egg mixture. Swirl to cover the pan evenly.
11. Cook until mostly set. Fold in half or thirds.
12. ASSEMBLE: Pile sweet vermicelli on a wide plate.
13. Place folded omelette on top.
14. Serve immediately with Arabic coffee and dates.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~370 per serving

TIP

Rose water in balaleet is the key fragrance — not a trace amount but a genuine presence. The sweet noodles should smell and taste of rose and cardamom. This perfumed quality is the Emirati character that distinguishes Gulf cooking from Arabian Peninsula cooking more broadly. Use good quality rose water — the flavor difference between cheap and quality rose water is significant.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Emirati] [Gulf Heritage] [Weekend Breakfast]

RECIPE 454

■ ■ UAE

CHEBAB

EMIRATI SAFFRON PANCAKES

Emirati breakfast pancakes unlike any other — thin, yeasted, golden from saffron, fragrant with cardamom and rose water, with a characteristic honeycomb surface from the small bubbles that form during cooking. Eaten with date syrup (dibs) or honey and white cheese. Chebab is the Emirati equivalent of a crêpe crossed with a blini — lighter and more fragrant than either. The saffron-cardamom-rose water combination makes every bite a distillation of Gulf flavor.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1■ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp instant yeast
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- Large pinch of saffron, bloomed in 3 tbsp warm water
- 1 tbsp rose water
- 1 large egg
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- Pinch of salt
- Ghee for cooking

FOR SERVING

- Dibs (date syrup) or dark honey
- White cheese (jibneh bayda)
- Labneh

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, cardamom, cinnamon, and salt.
2. Add saffron water, rose water, egg, and warm water.
3. Whisk until completely smooth.
4. Cover and rest 45 minutes–1 hour in a warm place until the batter is slightly bubbly from the yeast.
5. The batter should be thin and pourable, with a beautiful golden-saffron color.
6. Heat a non-stick pan over medium-low heat. Brush lightly with ghee.
7. Pour a small ladleful of batter (about 60ml). Let it spread naturally — do NOT swirl. Chebab should be thick enough to have their characteristic bubble surface (5–6mm thick).
8. When bubbles cover the entire surface and the edges look set (2 minutes), the chebab is done. Do NOT flip — chebab is cooked on one side only, like a crumpet.
9. Remove when the base is golden and the surface dry.
10. Serve golden-side up with date syrup drizzled over.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr resting · Cook: 3 min per chebab · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~270 per serving

TIP

Chebab must be cooked one side only — the uncooked top surface with its bubbles and slightly tacky appearance is correct and traditional. The base creates the golden crust; the top remains soft and slightly honeycomb-textured from the bubbles. Flipping would destroy this characteristic texture and create a generic pancake.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Emirati] [Gulf Heritage] [Sweet]

UAE

RECIPE 455

■■ Jordan

JORDANIAN BREAKFAST SPREAD

MEZE SOBAH

Jordan's morning meze — an assembled breakfast table of multiple small dishes that together create a complete Levantine morning meal. Similar to the Lebanese spread but with specific Jordanian touches: darker olive oil, more robust olives, a specific style of labneh made slightly thicker and more sour, and always za'atar freshly ground in a mortar. The Jordanian breakfast table is generous, fresh, and built around the quality of its local ingredients.

INGREDIENTS

- JORDANIAN LABNEH (thicker than Lebanese):
- 1kg (4½ cups) full-fat yogurt, strained 36 hours
- (longer than standard — creates drier, more sour labneh)
- 1 tsp salt
- Rolled in dried thyme + salt + sesame seeds
- for serving as labneh balls

OLIVE AND HERB SPREAD

- 1 cup mixed Jordanian olives (Nabali or Rumi — larger,
- more bitter than Greek varieties)
- Drizzle of Jordanian olive oil (from the Jordan Valley —
- exceptionally fruity and peppery)
- Fresh thyme sprigs
- ZA'ATAR DIPPING BLEND:
- 3 tbsp za'atar (dried Jordanian wild thyme — more
- bitter and pungent than Lebanese varieties)
- 1 tsp sumac
- 1 tbsp sesame seeds, toasted
- 4 tbsp good olive oil
- Mix to a thick dipping paste
- EGGS: soft-boiled (6 minutes) or fried in olive oil

FRESH VEGETABLES

- Cherry tomatoes
- Cucumber slices
- Mint sprigs
- Radishes
- BREAD: Khubz (Jordanian flatbread) or pita, warmed

SWEET TOUCHES

- Carob molasses (dibs al-kharoub) — a Jordanian
- specialty poured over labneh or eaten with bread
- Olive oil and za'atar for bread dipping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. LABNEH: Strain yogurt with salt through cheesecloth for 36 hours. Roll portions in dried thyme mixture.
2. OLIVE MARINADE: Toss olives with fresh thyme and olive oil. Let sit 30 minutes.
3. ZA'ATAR PASTE: Mix all ingredients just before serving. The za'atar paste must be fresh — it thickens and loses brightness if made ahead.
4. ARRANGE: Set all components in small dishes on the breakfast table simultaneously.
5. Place warm khubz in a cloth-lined basket in the center.
6. Brew strong black Jordanian tea with fresh sage (maramiya).
7. Let each person assemble their own plate — tearing bread and dipping, spreading, and layering.

Prep: 15 min (+ 36 hrs labneh straining) · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~430 per person

TIP

Jordanian wild thyme (za'atar barri) is more bitter and complex than Lebanese varieties — it grows wild in the highlands of the Jordan Valley and has a more medicinal, intensely aromatic quality. If you can source Jordanian or Palestinian za'atar specifically, the difference in the za'atar paste is immediately apparent — richer, more pungent, and more complex.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Jordanian] [Complete Breakfast]

RECIPE 456

■■ Jordan / Palestine

KNAFEH NABULSIYYA

WARM CHEESE PASTRY WITH SUGAR SYRUP

The Levant's most extraordinary morning sweet — a large round of shredded wheat pastry (kataifi) layered with melted stretchy cheese, baked until golden, then drenched in orange blossom sugar syrup and sprinkled with chopped pistachios. Eaten at dedicated knafeh shops (knafehji) from early morning throughout Jordan and Palestine. The sweet-cheese combination of crispy pastry, molten mild cheese, and fragrant sweet syrup is one of the world's great

breakfast desserts.

INGREDIENTS

KNAFEH PASTRY

- 400g (14 oz) kataifi pastry (shredded wheat dough —
- available frozen at Middle Eastern stores)
- 120g (½ cup) ghee or clarified butter, melted
- 1 tsp orange blossom water (in the pastry)

CHEESE FILLING

- 400g (14 oz) nabulsi or akkawi cheese — soaked in
- cold water 1–2 hours to desalt, then dried
- (or substitute: fresh mozzarella + ricotta, 2:1 ratio)
- If using mozzarella: shred coarsely and mix with
- 3 tbsp ricotta

SUGAR SYRUP

- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 150ml (⅔ cup) water
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp orange blossom water
- Simmer 5–7 minutes until slightly syrupy

ORANGE COLORING

- 1 tsp natural orange food coloring or a generous
- pinch of ground annatto dissolved in 1 tbsp water —
- mixed into the pastry for the characteristic
- orange color of authentic knafeh

TOPPING

- 50g (⅓ cup) raw pistachios, finely chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 200°C (390°F).
2. PASTRY LAYER: Shred kataifi loosely with your hands into smaller pieces. Toss with melted ghee, orange blossom water, and orange coloring until evenly coated.
3. Grease a 30cm (12-inch) round baking tray generously.
4. Press HALF the kataifi firmly into the tray, covering the bottom in an even, compacted layer. Press hard with your palm — it must be firm.
5. Layer cheese (or mozzarella-ricotta mixture) evenly over the pastry. Press gently.
6. Cover with remaining kataifi. Press firmly again.
7. Bake 20–25 minutes until the top is golden and the cheese is visibly melted (bubbling at edges).
8. MAKE SYRUP: Simmer sugar, water, and lemon juice 5 minutes. Add orange blossom water. Cool slightly.
9. SERVING: Invert the hot knafeh onto a serving tray (orange kataifi side now faces up).
10. Immediately pour HALF the warm syrup over the entire surface — it will sizzle.
11. Sprinkle chopped pistachios generously.
12. Slice into squares or wedges immediately.
13. Serve remaining syrup on the side for those who want more. Eat while still warm and the cheese is molten.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 10 · Cal: ~380 per piece

TIP

The cheese must be thoroughly desalted — knafeh made with salty, unsoaked nabulsi is unpleasantly sharp against the sweet syrup. Soak the cheese in multiple changes of cold water for 1–2 hours. Taste a piece before using — it should be very mild and barely salty.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Levantine] [Nabuls Heritage] [Morning Sweet]

Jordan

RECIPE 457

■ ■ Syria (Damascus)

FATTET AL-HUMMUS

SYRIAN LAYERED CHICKPEA BREAD CASSEROLE

Damascus's most celebrated morning dish — a grand layered casserole of toasted bread, warm chickpeas, and rice soaked in chickpea broth, blanketed in garlicky yogurt and tahini sauces, topped with toasted pine nuts, crispy fried onion, and a drizzle of paprika butter. The Syrian version of fattet is more elaborate and more carefully constructed than the Lebanese version — each layer deliberately built for maximum textural contrast. A breakfast that requires care and rewards it spectacularly.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups cooked chickpeas
- 2 cups cooked Egyptian rice (short-grain)
- 3 rounds pita bread, torn and toasted until crispy
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm chickpea broth
- YOGURT-TAHINI SAUCE:
 - 500g (2¼ cups) thick plain yogurt
 - 2 tbsp tahini
 - 3 garlic cloves, crushed to paste
 - Juice of 1 lemon
 - Salt to taste
 - ½ tsp dried mint

PINE NUT BUTTER

- 3 tbsp ghee or butter
- 3 tbsp pine nuts
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- ½ tsp Aleppo pepper (the Syrian chilli — essential for authentic Syrian character. Fruity, mild heat, with a faint cumin note.)

GARNISH

- 1 large onion, thinly sliced, deep-fried until crispy
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley
- Sumac for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. YOGURT SAUCE: Mix yogurt, tahini, crushed garlic, lemon juice, dried mint, and salt. Taste — creamy, garlicky, and tangy.
2. LAYER ASSEMBLY in a wide, deep serving dish:
3. LAYER 1: Arrange toasted pita pieces across the bottom.
4. Pour warm chickpea broth over the bread — just enough to moisten without making soggy.
5. LAYER 2: Spread warm rice over the moistened bread.
6. LAYER 3: Spread warm chickpeas over the rice.
7. LAYER 4: Pour yogurt-tahini sauce completely over everything — generous, even coverage.
8. PINE NUT BUTTER: Heat ghee in a small pan. Add pine nuts. Fry until golden. Add paprika and Aleppo pepper. Sizzle briefly.
9. Pour hot pine nut butter over the yogurt surface.
10. Scatter crispy fried onion over everything.
11. Garnish with fresh parsley and a dusting of sumac.
12. SERVE IMMEDIATELY — do not let it sit. The bread softens rapidly once the broth and yogurt make contact.

Prep: 25 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

Aleppo pepper (Syrian red pepper flakes) is the ingredient that makes this dish Syrian rather than Lebanese or Egyptian. It has a fruity, moderately hot, slightly oily character completely different from generic chilli flakes. The pine nut butter with Aleppo pepper drizzled over the white yogurt creates the visual and flavor signature of a Damascene fattet.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Classic Syrian] [Damascus Heritage]

RECIPE 458

■ Syria (Aleppo)

MUHAMMARA ON BREAD

SYRIAN RED PEPPER AND WALNUT DIP

Aleppo's great contribution to the world's dips — muhammara, a rich, complex paste of roasted red peppers, walnuts, pomegranate molasses, Aleppo pepper, and olive oil. More complex than hummus, more nuanced than harissa — muhammara carries the full depth of Syrian spice tradition. Eaten for breakfast spread on warm bread, it is simultaneously sweet, tangy, nutty, and mildly spiced in the specific way that only Aleppo pepper achieves. One of the greatest dips on earth.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large red bell peppers, roasted until charred and peeled (or 300g / 10 oz jarred roasted red peppers,
- drained thoroughly)
- 100g (1 cup) walnut halves, toasted
- 2 tbsp pomegranate molasses (rumman — essential
- for the sweet-tart dimension)
- 1 tbsp Aleppo pepper flakes (or ½ tsp regular chilli
- + ½ tsp paprika as substitute)
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp salt
- 3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp breadcrumbs (for body — optional)

FOR SERVING

- Warm flatbread or pita
- Additional walnuts for garnish
- Pomegranate seeds (optional garnish)
- Drizzle of olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ROAST PEPPERS: Place whole peppers directly over a gas flame or under a broiler. Char on all sides until blackened. Place in a covered bowl 15 minutes. Peel off charred skin. Remove seeds. Drain liquid.
2. Toast walnuts in a dry pan until fragrant. Cool.
3. BLEND: Add roasted peppers, toasted walnuts, garlic, Aleppo pepper, cumin, and salt to a food processor.
4. Pulse to a coarse texture — NOT smooth. Muhammara should have texture and some walnut pieces.
5. Add pomegranate molasses, olive oil, and lemon juice.
6. Pulse briefly. Add breadcrumbs if the mixture is too loose — it should be thick and spreadable.
7. Taste: it should be sweet from peppers and pomegranate, nutty from walnuts, tangy from molasses and lemon, and gently spiced from Aleppo pepper.
8. Transfer to a bowl. Drizzle olive oil over the surface.
9. Garnish with extra walnut pieces and pomegranate seeds.
10. Serve with warm flatbread.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~210 per serving

TIP

Pomegranate molasses is non-optional in muhammara — it provides the sweet-tart dimension that balances the pepper heat and walnut richness. Without it, the dip is flat and one-dimensional. Too much and it becomes cloyingly sweet. The correct quantity (2 tbsp) creates a background sweetness and fruity acidity that enhances every other flavor.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Syrian] [Aleppo Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

Syria

RECIPE 459

■ ■ Syria

CHEESE SAMBOUSAK

SYRIAN FRIED CHEESE PASTRIES

Syria's beloved fried half-moon pastries — a semolina-enriched dough filled with akkawi cheese, fresh mint, and nigella seeds, crimped at the edges and deep-fried until golden and the cheese melts inside. Eaten for breakfast at Syrian pastry shops (halawiyat) and homemade for special mornings. The semolina in the dough creates the characteristic slightly gritty, crumbly texture that holds up to frying and provides the perfect contrast to the melted cheese.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 100ml (■ cup) neutral oil
- 140ml (■ cup) warm water

CHEESE FILLING

- 300g (10 oz) akkawi cheese, soaked in water
- 1–2 hours to desalt, then dried and grated
- (substitute: mild feta mixed with mozzarella 1:1)
- 3 tbsp fresh mint leaves, finely chopped
- 1 tsp nigella seeds (habbat al-baraka)
- ½ tsp black pepper
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, semolina, salt, and baking powder. Add oil. Rub into flour until sandy.
2. Add warm water gradually. Knead into a smooth, pliable dough. Rest 20 minutes.
3. MIX FILLING: Combine grated cheese, mint, nigella seeds, and pepper. Taste — should be mild and fragrant.
4. Roll dough to 3mm thickness.
5. Cut into circles (10cm diameter) using a round cutter.
6. Place 1 tbsp filling in the center of each circle.
7. Fold one half over the other to create a half-moon.
8. Seal edges with a fork — press firmly and crimp all along the sealed edge to prevent opening.
9. Or twist-fold the edge decoratively (the Syrian way).
10. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F).
11. Fry in batches 3–4 minutes until deep golden. Turn once. The cheese inside should be melted.
12. Drain on rack. Eat while hot.

Prep: 25 min + 20 min rest · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Nigella seeds (habbat al-baraka — "seeds of blessing") are the defining ingredient of Syrian sambousak — their slightly onion-like, peppery flavor creates a specific character that sets these pastries apart from Turkish or Lebanese versions. They are available at Middle Eastern grocery stores and last for years stored properly.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Syrian] [Pastry] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 460

■ ■ Syria

KAAK BI SIMSIM WA ANISE

SYRIAN SESAME ANISE RINGS

The Syrian morning ring biscuit — kaak coated in sesame with anise-scented dough, slightly crispy outside and tender within. Sold by street vendors who carry them on large round trays balanced on their heads through Damascus and Aleppo streets. Eaten with tea or Arabic coffee. The combination of sesame and anise with the olive oil dough is unmistakably Syrian — fragrant, satisfying, and made to be eaten by the handful.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 3 tbsp fine semolina
- 80ml (■ cup) olive oil (traditional — gives the distinctly Syrian olive oil flavor)
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp instant yeast
- 1 tsp anise seeds, lightly toasted and ground
- ½ tsp mahleb (ground cherry pit)
- ½ tsp salt
- 160ml (■ cup) warm water

COATING

- 1 egg beaten with 1 tbsp water
- 150g (1 cup) white sesame seeds

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, semolina, sugar, yeast, ground anise, mahleb, and salt.
2. Add olive oil. Rub into flour.
3. Add warm water. Knead into a smooth, firm dough.
4. Rest 30 minutes.
5. Preheat oven to 180°C (355°F).
6. Roll pieces of dough into thin ropes (1cm diameter, 20cm long). Join ends to make rings.
7. Brush with egg wash.
8. Press into sesame seeds on both sides. Coat completely.
9. Place on lined baking sheets.
10. Bake 20–22 minutes until golden. Kaak should be fully dry and crispy — not soft.
11. Cool completely. They keep 2–3 weeks in a tin.

Prep: 20 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 20 rings · Cal: ~130 per ring

TIP

Olive oil in the dough creates the specific Syrian kaak character — fruity, slightly bitter, and distinctly Mediterranean. Vegetable oil produces a neutral, less complex biscuit. Use a good quality Syrian or Lebanese olive oil for the most authentic result.

[Vegan] [Classic Syrian] [Make-Ahead] [Street Food] [With Tea]

AFRICA

Recipes #461—#518 · 58 recipes

Morocco

RECIPE 461

■■ Morocco

BAGHRIR

MOROCCAN HONEYCOMB CRÊPES

Morocco's most magical breakfast crêpe — a thick, spongy round of semolina and flour batter cooked on one side only, developing hundreds of tiny holes across the surface as the batter cooks from below. These holes are the achievement — they absorb the traditional honey-butter dip in which baghrir is submerged before eating, creating a crêpe saturated with warm, golden sweetness. Known as "thousand-hole pancakes" (crêpes aux mille trous), they are soft, chewy, slightly tangy from the yeast, and entirely unlike any other crêpe tradition.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1■ cups) fine semolina (semoule fine)
- 100g (¾ cup) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 500ml (2 cups) warm water
- 1 large egg
- HONEY-BUTTER DIP (essential):
- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter
- 4 tbsp dark floral honey
- Melt together gently until combined — keep warm

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine semolina, flour, yeast, baking powder, sugar, and salt in a blender.
2. Add warm water and egg.
3. Blend on high speed 2–3 minutes until completely smooth and slightly frothy. The blending is essential — it creates the smooth, aerated batter that produces holes.
4. Pour into a bowl. Cover. Rest 15–20 minutes until slightly bubbly on the surface.
5. The batter should be quite thin — thinner than pancake batter. Add a splash of water if it looks thick.
6. Heat a non-stick pan over medium heat. Do NOT oil it — baghrir is cooked dry.
7. Pour a generous ladleful of batter into the center of the pan. Let it spread naturally to a 20cm circle. Do NOT swirl.
8. Immediately watch the surface — within 30 seconds, holes will begin appearing. Within 1–2 minutes, the entire surface should be covered in hundreds of small holes and look completely dry and set.
9. Do NOT flip. Baghrir is cooked on one side only.
10. Remove when the surface is fully dry and the holes are set — the base should be pale gold.
11. Stack on a plate.
12. SERVE: Dip each baghrir hole-side down into the warm honey-butter, or pour honey-butter over the hole-covered surface.

Prep: 10 min + 20 min resting · Cook: 2 min per baghrir · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~345 per serving (3 baghrir + dip)

TIP

The holes are created by tiny bubbles of yeast gas that rise through the thin batter and burst at the surface as it cooks. No holes means either: the batter is too thick (dilute with water), the pan is too hot (lower the heat — medium only), or the batter hasn't rested long enough. All three are fixable. Perfect holes come from thin batter + proper rest + medium heat.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Moroccan] [Thousand-Hole Crêpes] [Sweet]

RECIPE 462

■■ Morocco

MSEMEN

MOROCCAN SQUARE LAYERED FLATBREAD

Morocco's most beloved breakfast flatbread — a square, multi-layered wheat and semolina flatbread cooked on a flat griddle, with dozens of flaky, buttery layers that separate into tissue-thin sheets when torn. Made every morning in Moroccan households, bought from bakery women (frranat) who cook them on open griddles at street markets. Eaten with argan oil, honey, butter, or soft cheese. The layers of msemen are its achievement — each one thinner than paper, each one contributing to the extraordinary crispy-yet-yielding whole.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water (approximately)

LAYERING

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, very soft
- 50g (¼ cup) fine semolina (for the layers — creates the separation between dough folds)
- Neutral oil (for hands and surface)

FOR SERVING

- Argan oil + honey (the definitive Moroccan pairing)
- Smen (Moroccan preserved butter — salty, aged, intensely flavored) — available at Moroccan specialty stores
- Amlou (Recipe 465)
- Soft fresh cheese

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, semolina, salt, and sugar. Add water gradually. Knead 10 minutes into a smooth, very pliable dough. Coat in oil. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Divide into 8 balls. Keep covered while working.
3. On an OILED surface (not floured), press one ball flat with oiled palm into a large thin circle (25cm if possible).
4. Spread softened butter thinly over the entire surface.
5. Dust with fine semolina — this creates the layers.
6. FOLDING: Fold the left third of the circle to the center. Fold the right third over (like a letter fold).
7. Now fold the top third down and the bottom third up — creating a small square parcel.
8. Flatten this square with your palm gently.
9. Repeat butter + semolina + fold on this smaller square.
10. Rest this square 10 minutes — the gluten relaxes.
11. On an oiled surface, press and stretch the rested square back out to 15cm — gently, evenly.
12. Cook on a DRY, lightly heated griddle over medium heat, 3–4 minutes per side until golden with dark speckled patches.
13. Serve warm. The layers will separate when torn.

Prep: 25 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 8 min per msemen · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~295 per msemen

TIP

The layers of msemen are created by the alternating fat (butter) and semolina during folding — the semolina prevents the buttered layers from fusing back together during resting and cooking. Without semolina dusting between folds, the layers disappear. The resting between the final fold and final pressing allows the gluten to relax enough to stretch thin without snapping back.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Moroccan] [Layered Flatbread] [Street Food]

RECIPE 463

■ ■ Morocco

MELOUI

MOROCCAN SPIRAL LAYERED FLATBREAD

Morocco's spiral variation of the layered flatbread tradition — a thin dough rope coiled into a snail shape, pressed flat, and cooked until the spiral pattern creates distinctive concentric rings of crispy, caramelized edges and soft, layered interior. Meloui and msemen are cousins — same dough, different shaping technique, different final texture. Meloui has more crispy edges per bite because of the spiral, making each piece a more complex textural experience.

INGREDIENTS

- Same dough as msemen (Recipe 462) — make one batch
- Same layering fats: butter + fine semolina

FOR SERVING

- Moroccan honey (ideally thyme or sidr honey — Morocco produces extraordinary monofloral honeys)
- Butter
- Argan oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make msemen dough. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Divide into 8 balls.
3. On an oiled surface, press each ball into a thin circle (25cm).
4. Spread butter over the surface. Dust with semolina.
5. SPIRAL SHAPING (different from msemen): — Roll the circle into a thin rope from one edge, rolling tightly all the way. — Coil the rope into a tight snail/spiral shape. — Tuck the end underneath.
6. Flatten the spiral gently with your palm.
7. Rest 10 minutes.
8. On oiled surface, press and roll gently to a flat disc (15–18cm), maintaining the spiral pattern. Press from center outward — the spiral should remain visible.
9. Cook on a dry griddle over medium heat 3–4 minutes per side until golden and the spiral edges are crispy.
10. Serve warm with honey and butter.

Prep: 25 min + resting · Cook: 8 min per meloui · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~285 per meloui

TIP

The tight initial rolling creates more layers than the fold-fold method of msemen — the tightly wound spiral creates dozens of concentric layers that express as concentric golden rings when cooked. The tighter the spiral, the more dramatic the layered effect.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Moroccan] [Layered Flatbread] [Weekend Breakfast]

RECIPE 464

■ ■ Morocco

KHOBZ

MOROCCAN ROUND SEMOLINA BREAD

The foundation of Moroccan daily life — khobz, a large, round, thick flatbread made from a blend of white flour and semolina, with a soft, slightly dense crumb and a tender crust. Baked in the neighbourhood communal oven (ferrane) every morning, collected still warm, and brought to the breakfast table where it serves as plate, spoon, and food simultaneously. Every dish on a Moroccan breakfast table is eaten with torn pieces of khobz. The bread is the utensil.

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 200g (1 cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 1 tbsp neutral oil
- 280ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 1 tsp anise seeds (optional — traditional in some regions)
- Extra semolina for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, semolina, yeast, salt, sugar, anise seeds, and oil.
2. Add warm water gradually. Knead 10 minutes until smooth, slightly dense dough forms. Khobz dough is firmer than a baguette dough.
3. Divide into 2–3 balls.
4. Dust a flat surface with semolina.
5. Press each ball into a round disc (20–22cm diameter, 2–3cm thick). The disc should be uniform.
6. Place on semolina-dusted parchment. Dust the tops generously with semolina.
7. Cover. Prove 30–45 minutes until puffed.
8. Before baking, poke the surface several times with a fork in a decorative pattern — traditional and helps even baking.
9. Preheat oven to 220°C (430°F) with a heavy baking sheet inside.
10. Bake 18–22 minutes until golden and the bottom sounds hollow when tapped.
11. Cool 10 minutes on a rack.
12. Serve at room temperature or slightly warm, alongside the full Moroccan breakfast spread.

Prep: 15 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~265 per serving

TIP

The semolina dusting of khobz before baking is essential — it creates the characteristic slightly sandy, dry crust texture that is immediately distinct from European bread. The top dusting also prevents the bread from sticking to any surface while proving. Always finish with semolina, never flour.

[Vegan] [Classic Moroccan] [Daily Bread] [Foundation Recipe]

RECIPE 465

■ ■ Morocco (Souss Region)

AMLOU

MOROCCAN ARGAN OIL AND ALMOND PASTE

Morocco's most treasured breakfast condiment — a thick, rich paste of toasted almonds ground with argan oil and honey that is the culinary equivalent of a Moroccan luxury good. Amlou is made in the Souss Valley, where the argan tree grows and where the Berber women's cooperatives press the oil by hand. Spread on bread, drizzled over baghrir, or eaten alone by the spoonful — amlou carries the full aromatic richness of argan oil and the deep nuttiness of slow-toasted Moroccan almonds.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (1½ cups) whole raw almonds
- 4 tbsp argan oil (culinary grade — the key ingredient,
- available at specialty food stores and online.
- Nutty, slightly smoky, and deeply toasty — no substitute.)
- 3 tbsp dark honey (Moroccan thyme or sidr honey preferred)
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- Pinch of salt

FOR SERVING

- Khobz, msemen, or baghrir
- Extra honey drizzle

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **TOAST ALMONDS:** Spread almonds on a baking tray. Toast at 170°C (340°F) for 12–15 minutes until deep golden and fragrant. Cool completely. Alternatively: toast in a dry pan over medium heat, stirring, 8–10 minutes.
2. **GRIND:** Process cooled toasted almonds in a food processor until very fine — almost a powder but not yet a paste. Scrape down sides frequently.
3. Continue processing. The almonds will begin to release their oil and clump — this is the beginning of nut butter consistency.
4. Add argan oil gradually while processing.
5. Add honey and cinnamon.
6. Add salt.
7. Process until the mixture becomes a thick, smooth, pourable paste — the consistency of natural peanut butter.
8. Taste: it should be deeply nutty, rich with argan oil, sweetened by honey, and warmed by cinnamon.
9. Store in a glass jar. Refrigerate. Keeps 2–3 weeks. Stir before each use.
10. Serve at room temperature — take from refrigerator 30 minutes before eating.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~185 per serving (2 tbsp)

TIP

Culinary argan oil has a distinctive smoky, nutty aroma from the roasting process the kernels undergo before pressing. This specific flavor is what makes amlou different from any almond butter made with another oil. If argan oil is unavailable, use a good toasted sesame oil at 1:3 ratio with a neutral oil — it creates a completely different but interesting paste.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Moroccan] [Argan Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 466

■ ■ Morocco

ATAY BIL NANA

MOROCCAN MINT TEA

Morocco's soul in a glass — atay, green tea brewed with spearmint and prodigious amounts of sugar, poured from height into small gilded glasses, producing a frothy, intensely sweet, fragrant tea that is the centerpiece of every Moroccan breakfast, every meeting, and every welcome. The pouring from height (le thé versé de haut) is not ceremony for its own sake — it aerates the tea and produces the characteristic foam that signals a properly made Moroccan tea.

Refusing tea in Morocco is refusing hospitality itself.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tsp Chinese gunpowder green tea
- (the specific variety — its tight pellets unfurl slowly
- and create the characteristic slightly bitter base.
- Other green teas create a completely different result.)
- 1 large bunch fresh spearmint (nana) — abundant,
- not a garnish. The mint is the primary flavor.
- 4–6 tbsp sugar (or more — Moroccan tea is very sweet.
- Adjust to preference but lean toward more.)
- 600ml (2½ cups) boiling water

EQUIPMENT

- A Moroccan teapot (br■ad) — metal, with a long spout
- Small gilded or decorated tea glasses

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Warm the teapot with boiling water. Discard.
2. Add gunpowder tea to the warmed pot.
3. Pour a small amount of boiling water over the tea — just enough to wet the leaves. Swirl briefly.
4. Pour OFF this first water — discard it. This "washing" of the tea removes bitterness.
5. Pack the teapot with fresh mint — generously. Press it down to fit as much as possible.
6. Add sugar directly to the pot.
7. Pour boiling water over everything to fill the pot.
8. Place on low heat for 2 minutes. Do not boil.
9. POUR TEST: Pour one glass. Taste. Adjust sugar.
10. POURING TECHNIQUE: Hold the teapot high (30–40cm above the glass). Pour in a thin, elegant stream. This aerating pour creates the foam.
11. Pour the glass back into the pot. Repeat 3 times — this mixes everything and develops the foam further.
12. Pour final glasses from height into each glass. The frothy surface is the achievement.
13. Moroccan tea is served in 3 rounds, each slightly different in character.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~60 per glass

TIP

The first "wash" of the tea with hot water that is immediately discarded is the essential Moroccan technique that removes the astringent, bitter compounds that would otherwise dominate. Every glass of Moroccan tea served begins with this step. Without it, the tea is sharp and harsh. With it, the green tea and mint balance each other in a perfectly sweet, fragrant glass.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Moroccan] [Cultural Ritual] [Essential]

RECIPE 467

■ ■ Morocco

HARIRA

MOROCCAN TOMATO LENTIL AND CHICKPEA SOUP

Morocco's most nourishing soup and the essential Ramadan iftar (breaking fast) dish — eaten at sunrise too, as suhoor before the day's fast begins. Harira is a deeply flavored broth of tomatoes, chickpeas, lentils, and lamb, thickened with flour or egg and brightened with lemon and fresh coriander. Each Moroccan family's harira is the definitive one. This recipe offers the foundational Fez version — the most famous and most complex.

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (7 oz) lamb shoulder, cut into small cubes
- ½ cup dried chickpeas, soaked overnight
- ½ cup green or brown lentils, rinsed
- 400g (14 oz) canned or fresh tomatoes, blended
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 3 stalks celery with leaves, sliced
- 1 cup fresh flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped
- 1 cup fresh coriander, finely chopped
- 1 tsp ground ginger
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp saffron, bloomed in 2 tbsp water
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 1.5L (6 cups) water
- Salt to taste
- TEDOUIRA (flour thickener):
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour dissolved in 150ml cold water
- OR: 2 beaten eggs stirred in at the end (egg version)

FINISHING

- Juice of 1 lemon
- Fresh coriander for garnish
- Dates and chebakia (honey-fried sesame pastry) — the
- traditional Ramadan accompaniments

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a large pot over medium heat.
2. Brown lamb pieces briefly. Add onion. Cook 5 min.
3. Add celery, parsley, coriander, and all spices. Stir well to coat everything in the aromatics.
4. Add tomato paste. Stir 1 minute.
5. Add blended tomatoes. Cook 5 minutes.
6. Add soaked chickpeas and lentils.
7. Add water and saffron water. Bring to a boil.
8. Skim foam. Reduce heat. Cover and simmer 45 minutes until chickpeas are tender.
9. THICKENING: Whisk flour-water mixture until smooth. Pour slowly into the simmering soup while stirring.
10. Cook uncovered 10–15 minutes stirring occasionally as the soup thickens to a smooth, creamy consistency. It should coat a spoon lightly.
11. Finish with lemon juice. Taste and adjust salt.
12. Ladle into bowls. Scatter fresh coriander.
13. Serve with warm khobz.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 70 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per bowl

TIP

The tedouira (flour thickening) must be added to a gently simmering soup — not boiling. Boiling while adding causes lumps to form instantly. Stir the soup while pouring the flour mixture in a thin stream. The flour transforms the broth from thin to silky over 10–15 minutes of gentle simmering.

[High Protein] [Classic Moroccan] [Ramadan] [Comfort Food] [Nourishing]

RECIPE 468

■ ■ Morocco

SELLOU / SFOUF

MOROCCAN TOASTED FLOUR AND ALMOND ENERGY PASTE

Morocco's ancient high-energy morning food — a paste of deeply toasted flour, ground roasted almonds and sesame seeds, honey, butter, and aromatic spices, eaten by the spoonful or spread on bread. Made in large quantities for Ramadan, for new mothers after childbirth, and for the long winter months when energy is needed most. Sellou keeps for months without refrigeration — the toasting creates natural preservation. One tablespoon provides remarkable sustained energy.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 200g (1½ cups) blanched almonds
- 150g (1 cup) white sesame seeds
- 150g (■ cup) unsalted butter, melted
- 150g (¾ cup) icing (powdered) sugar
- 3 tbsp honey
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground anise
- ¼ tsp ground fennel seeds
- ¼ tsp ground gum arabic (optional — traditional stabilizer used in Moroccan cooking)
- Pinch of salt

FOR SERVING

- Extra almonds and sesame seeds for garnish
- Powdered sugar dusted over top

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **TOAST FLOUR:** Spread flour in a large dry pan over medium-low heat. Stir constantly 25–30 minutes until the flour turns pale golden and smells nutty. This is the longest and most essential step — under-toasted flour creates a raw, starchy paste. Cool completely.
2. **TOAST ALMONDS:** Toast almonds in a dry pan until golden. Cool. Grind in food processor to a fine powder.
3. **TOAST SESAME:** Toast sesame in a dry pan until golden. Grind half to a powder; keep half whole.
4. Mix toasted flour, ground almonds, and ground sesame in a large bowl.
5. Add powdered sugar and all spices. Mix well.
6. Add melted butter and honey. Mix with your hands — the mixture will come together into a paste.
7. Add whole toasted sesame seeds. Mix in.
8. Taste: nutty, deeply toasted, sweet, and warmly spiced.
9. Press into a bowl or shape into a log.
10. Dust with powdered sugar. Garnish with whole almonds.
11. Serve in small portions alongside mint tea.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 20 · Cal: ~195 per serving (2 tbsp)

TIP

Thorough toasting of the flour is the single most important step — raw sellou flour is powdery and unpleasant. The flour must be stirred continuously over medium-low heat for 25–30 minutes until it changes color from white to pale gold and smells distinctly nutty. This transformation cannot be rushed without burning.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Moroccan] [High Energy] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 469

■ ■ Morocco

KRACHEL

MOROCCAN ANISE AND SESAME BREAD ROLLS

Morocco's beloved enriched breakfast rolls — soft, slightly sweet yeasted rolls scented with anise, sesame, and orange blossom water, with a tender crumb and a golden, sesame-encrusted exterior. Krachel are the Moroccan morning roll bought from every bakery and eaten with butter and honey or amlou. Their fragrance — anise + orange blossom + fresh bread — is the smell of the Moroccan morning bakery, the one that draws entire neighborhoods to queue before sunrise.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 eggs
- 120ml (½ cup) warm milk
- 80ml (■ cup) warm water
- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp anise seeds
- 1 tbsp orange blossom water
- 1 tsp sesame seeds (mixed into dough)

COATING

- 1 egg beaten with 1 tbsp milk (egg wash)
- 100g (¾ cup) sesame seeds (for rolling)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, semolina, yeast, sugar, and salt.
2. Add eggs, warm milk, warm water, orange blossom water, anise seeds, and sesame seeds. Mix.
3. Knead 8 minutes. Add softened butter piece by piece. Knead 5 more minutes until smooth and slightly tacky.
4. Prove covered 1 hour until doubled.
5. Divide into 12 balls. Roll each smooth.
6. Dip each ball in egg wash to coat completely.
7. Roll immediately in sesame seeds — coat very generously.
8. Place on lined baking sheets. Press slightly flat.
9. Prove 30–40 minutes.
10. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 16–18 minutes until golden and the sesame is toasted.
11. Cool 10 minutes. Best eaten warm with butter and honey.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~240 per krachel

TIP

Orange blossom water is the perfume that makes krachel Moroccan rather than generic sweet rolls. Use good quality orange blossom water — the difference between cheap and authentic is the difference between a faint floral hint and a genuine, lingering fragrance that makes each bite smell of an orange grove in bloom.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Moroccan] [Bakery] [Fragrant]

RECIPE 470

■ ■ Morocco

CHEBBAKIA

MOROCCAN HONEY-FRIED SESAME FLOWER PASTRY

Morocco's most beautiful pastry and the defining sweet of Ramadan — a rolled and shaped dough of flour, sesame, and spices fried until golden then immediately plunged into warm honey and coated in toasted sesame seeds. The flower shape opens when fried, creating a spectacular presentation. Chebbakia is laborious to make and extraordinary to eat — sweet, crunchy, floral from orange blossom water, and deeply sesame-flavored. No Ramadan breakfast table in Morocco is complete without a mound of chebbakia beside the harira.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 100g (½ cup + 2 tbsp) fine semolina
- 3 tbsp sesame seeds, toasted and ground
- 2 tbsp almonds, toasted and finely ground
- 1 tsp ground anise
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground gum arabic (optional)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp instant yeast
- 2 tbsp orange blossom water
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar (helps crispiness)
- 1 tbsp honey
- 60ml (¼ cup) melted butter or argan oil
- 120ml (½ cup) warm water (approximately)

COATING

- 500g (2½ cups) clear honey, warmed
- Toasted sesame seeds for rolling
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix flour, semolina, ground sesame, ground almonds, anise, cinnamon, gum arabic, and salt.
2. Add orange blossom water, vinegar, honey, and melted butter. Mix.
3. Add warm water gradually until a firm, workable dough forms — like pasta dough, firm and smooth.
4. Knead 10 minutes. Rest 15 minutes.
5. Roll dough very thin (2mm) on a lightly oiled surface.
6. Cut into rectangles (8x6cm).
7. SHAPING: Make 4 parallel cuts lengthwise in each rectangle, leaving both short ends intact (like a comb).
8. Weave alternate strips under and over each other.
9. Bring the two short ends together — the alternating strips create a flower shape when the ends join. Pinch to secure.
10. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F). Fry chebbakia in batches 3–4 minutes until deep golden.
11. IMMEDIATELY transfer hot chebbakia into the warm honey. Submerge and turn. They should soak up honey.
12. Roll in toasted sesame seeds.
13. Cool on a rack. They keep for 2–3 weeks.

Prep: 45 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 24 · Cal: ~195 per piece

TIP

The vinegar in chebbakia dough creates a crispier pastry when fried — the acidity interferes with gluten development in a way that makes the pastry more shatteringly crispy. Moroccan bakers have known this instinctively for centuries. Do not omit the vinegar.

[Vegan] [Classic Moroccan] [Ramadan] [Festive Pastry] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 471

■ ■ Morocco

ZAALOUK WITH KHOBZ

MOROCCAN EGGPLANT AND TOMATO SALAD

Morocco's beloved cooked vegetable salad — eggplant and tomatoes slowly cooked down with olive oil, cumin, paprika, and preserved lemon into a thick, silky spread that is eaten cold or warm at breakfast on torn pieces of khobz. Zaalouk is among the most versatile of Moroccan dishes — it appears at every meal as a small plate, at every breakfast spread as

a dip, and on every Moroccan restaurant table as an essential starter. Made the day before, it only improves.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large eggplants (aubergines), roasted or steamed
- and flesh scooped (about 400g flesh)
- 4 medium tomatoes, very ripe, skinned and diced (or 400g canned whole tomatoes)
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- ½ tsp smoked paprika
- ½ tsp cayenne or harissa (to taste)
- 1 tbsp preserved lemon (lemon skin only), very finely diced — THE Moroccan ingredient
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley or coriander, chopped
- Salt and black pepper
- Juice of ½ lemon

FOR SERVING

- Warm khobz for dipping
- Drizzle of olive oil
- Extra preserved lemon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ROAST EGGPLANT: Prick each eggplant all over. Char over a gas flame or roast at 220°C (430°F) until completely collapsed, 30–40 minutes. Cool. Scoop out flesh. Drain in a colander. Chop flesh roughly.
2. Heat olive oil in a wide pan over medium heat.
3. Add garlic. Fry 1 minute until fragrant.
4. Add diced tomatoes. Cook 10 minutes pressing with a spoon until completely broken down.
5. Add roasted eggplant flesh. Mix together.
6. Add cumin, sweet paprika, smoked paprika, and cayenne.
7. Cook over medium heat 15–20 minutes, stirring regularly, until the mixture is very thick, almost dry, and the flavors are deeply melded.
8. Add preserved lemon. Stir through.
9. Season with salt, pepper, and lemon juice.
10. Cool. Add fresh parsley or coriander.
11. Transfer to a shallow plate. Drizzle olive oil.
12. Serve with warm khobz.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~145 per serving

TIP

Preserved lemon is the ingredient that makes zaalouk Moroccan — its fermented, intensely lemony, slightly funky saltiness cannot be replicated by fresh lemon juice. Use only the skin, not the pulp, rinse it, and dice it extremely fine. Add it at the end of cooking — it should remain slightly intact, providing pockets of intense preserved lemon flavor.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Moroccan] [Make-Ahead] [Versatile]

South Africa

RECIPE 472

■■ Morocco

CAFÉ NOUS NOUS

MOROCCAN HALF-HALF COFFEE

Morocco's signature morning coffee — "nous nous" (half-half) is exactly equal parts strong espresso and warm, frothed whole milk. Different from a cappuccino (which has a lot of foam), café nous nous has warm milk with only a thin foam layer. Served in a small glass (not a cup), with sugar cubes on the side. Drunk at every Moroccan café alongside khobz with butter and honey, or msemen with amlou. The glass allows the drinker to see the beautiful brown-and-white layering before mixing.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 double espresso (60ml) — from an espresso machine
- or strong Moka pot coffee
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk, steamed and frothed
- to a smooth, velvety texture (not stiff foam)
- Sugar cubes (served on the side — always 2)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Brew a very strong double espresso.
2. Steam milk to 65°C until smooth and velvety — with only a thin layer of foam, not a cappuccino mount of foam.
3. Pour espresso into a small glass (150–180ml capacity).
4. POUR MILK: Pour steamed milk gently from the side of the glass — the milk slides under the coffee initially, then blends. A thin foam layer forms at the top.
5. The result should be half dark coffee, half warm milk, with a thin foam crown.
6. Place 2 sugar cubes on the saucer.
7. Drink without stirring first — experience the two layers, then stir and add sugar.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 3 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~95 per glass

TIP

The glass (not cup) is important for Moroccan café nous nous — it allows the visible layering of dark coffee and white milk that is part of the aesthetic. Moroccan café culture places great importance on the visual presentation of coffee. The glass also cools the coffee slightly faster, which Moroccans prefer — café nous nous is drunk quickly, not lingered over.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Moroccan] [Café Culture]

RECIPE 473

■ ■ South Africa

MEALIE PAP WITH BUTTER

South Africa's most universal breakfast — mealie pap, thick maize (cornmeal) porridge cooked to varying textures depending on region and preference. Slap pap (loose, like polenta) is eaten with butter and sugar for breakfast across all communities. Stywe pap (firm) is eaten savory at braais. Phutu pap (crumbly) is the Zulu and Xhosa morning staple. All three use the same white maize meal, cooked differently. This is the breakfast of South Africa's majority and the foundation of South African food culture.

INGREDIENTS

SLAP PAP (SOFT BREAKFAST PAP)

- 2 cups white maize meal (mealie meal — not yellow cornmeal or polenta — white maize meal is the specific South African product)
- 1.2L (5 cups) water
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- TOPPINGS (South African breakfast style):
- Extra butter (generous — it melts into the hot pap)
- White sugar or condensed milk — sweet version
- Full cream milk poured over — popular with children
- SAVORY OPTION (for phutu pap):
- Chakalaka (spiced vegetable relish — see Recipe 476)
- Amasi (South African cultured milk — similar to kefir)
- Boerewors slices alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SLAP PAP (soft):
2. Bring water and salt to a boil in a heavy pot.
3. Add maize meal in a thin, steady stream while stirring constantly.
4. Stir vigorously to prevent lumps.
5. Reduce heat to low. Cover.
6. Cook 10 minutes. Lift lid. Stir vigorously again.
7. Cover. Cook 5 more minutes.
8. Stir in butter.
9. The pap should be smooth, thick, and porridge-like. Add more hot water if too thick. PHUTU PAP (crumbly):
10. Bring 1 cup water and salt to a boil.
11. Add maize meal all at once. Do NOT stir.
12. Reduce heat to very low. Cover.
13. Cook 15–20 minutes without stirring.
14. Break up with a fork into crumbles.
15. The texture should be dry and crumbly — not smooth. BOTH: Serve in a bowl with desired toppings.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~285 per serving (with butter)

TIP

White maize meal (mealie meal) — specifically the coarsely ground white variety — is what creates authentic South African pap. Yellow cornmeal creates a different color and flavor. Fine white cornmeal creates a different texture. The coarse white grind creates the characteristic slightly grainy, deeply satisfying texture of South African pap.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic South African] [National Breakfast]

RECIPE 474

■ ■ South Africa

BOEREWORS AND EGGS

SOUTH AFRICAN FARMER'S SAUSAGE AND EGGS

South Africa's most beloved Saturday morning breakfast — boerewors (farmer's sausage), a coiled beef and pork sausage spiced with coriander, cloves, nutmeg, and vinegar, cooked in a pan or on the braai until the casing crackles and the spiced fat renders. Served with fried eggs, pap, and tomato-onion relish (sous). The smell of boerewors cooking on Saturday morning is one of South Africa's most evocative sensory memories — every South African who grew up in the country can identify it immediately.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) boerewors — the specific South African
- sausage sold coiled. By law in South Africa it must
- contain minimum 90% meat with specific spice blend.
- Find at South African butchers or specialty stores.
- Substitute: a good, lightly spiced pork sausage
- with 1 tsp ground coriander added
- TOMATO-ONION RELISH (sous/smoor):
- 1 large onion, thinly sliced
- 3 large ripe tomatoes, chopped
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp ground coriander
- Salt and black pepper
- 1 tbsp oil
- 4 large eggs, fried
- Pap (Recipe 473) or bread alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SOUS: Heat oil. Fry onion 8 minutes until golden. Add tomatoes, sugar, coriander, salt, pepper. Cook 10–12 minutes until thick. Keep warm.
2. BOEREWORS: Uncoil slightly if desired, keeping the coil shape together.
3. BRAAI (preferred): Cook over medium-hot coals. Do not cut or poke — the juices must stay inside. Cook 8–10 minutes per side until deeply browned and cooked through. The casing should crack and sizzle.
4. PAN METHOD: Cook in a dry, heavy pan over medium heat. Add a splash of water initially to prevent burning before the fat renders. Cook 8–10 minutes per side.
5. Fry eggs sunnyside up in the rendered boerewors fat.
6. SERVE: Boerewors on a plate (still coiled if possible). Eggs alongside. Generous spoonful of sous over everything. Pap on the side.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

Never pierce boerewors while cooking. The distinctive spiced fat inside is the flavor — piercing it drains the fat away, leaving a dry, flavorless sausage. Cook it whole, whole, whole. The casing will eventually burst naturally at one or two points — this is fine and unavoidable, but the initial cooking must be without piercing.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic South African] [Braai Culture]

RECIPE 475

■ ■ South Africa (Cape Malay)

KOESISTERS

CAPE MALAY SPICED DOUGHNUTS

Cape Town's most distinctive morning sweet — koesisters, a Cape Malay creation that should not be confused with the Afrikaner koeksisters (which is fried and dipped in syrup). The Cape Malay koesister is a spiced, soft doughnut dusted in desiccated coconut, flavored with cardamom, naartjie (tangerine) peel, anise, and ginger, and dunked in a light syrup. Sold in the Bo-Kaap neighborhood of Cape Town on Sunday mornings, cooked by women who have made them the same way for generations. One of South Africa's most distinctive and cherished foods.

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 400g (3¼ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp ground cardamom
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- ½ tsp ground anise
- ½ tsp ground naartjie (tangerine) zest or regular dried orange zest
- 1 large egg
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 60g (4 tbsp) unsalted butter, softened

SYRUP

- 200g (1 cup) sugar
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 1 tsp naartjie or orange zest
- 1 cinnamon stick
- Simmer 5 minutes. Cool.

COATING

- 200g (2 cups) desiccated coconut, toasted golden
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, and all spices. Add egg and warm milk. Knead 5 minutes. Add butter. Knead 5 more minutes.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Make syrup. Toast coconut. Set both aside.
4. Divide dough into 16–18 pieces.
5. Roll each into a smooth oval or rectangular shape (about 7cm long).
6. Prove 20 minutes.
7. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F).
8. Fry in batches 3–4 minutes per side until deep golden.
9. IMMEDIATELY while still hot, dip in cool syrup. Turn to coat. Let soak briefly (30 seconds).
10. Roll in toasted desiccated coconut to coat completely.
11. Cool on a rack. Best eaten same day.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~215 per koesister

TIP

The syrup must be cool when the koesisters are hot — the temperature contrast creates the rapid absorption. Hot syrup on hot doughnuts creates a soggy, overly sweet result. Cool syrup on hot doughnuts creates a thin, shiny, lightly sweet coating that the coconut then adheres to perfectly.

[Vegetarian] [Classic South African] [Cape Malay Heritage] [Sunday Morning]

RECIPE 476

■ ■ South Africa

CHAKALAKA WITH PAP

SOUTH AFRICAN SPICED VEGETABLE RELISH

South Africa's most beloved vegetable relish — a spiced, tomato- and-bean stew with carrots, peppers, and curry powder that is eaten alongside pap at almost every South African meal including breakfast. Chakalaka originated in the townships around Johannesburg, created by migrant workers from Mozambique and across southern Africa who needed to add flavor to basic maize pap. It has become one of South Africa's most defining condiments — at every braai, every family breakfast, every township kitchen.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 large onion, diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 1 green pepper, diced
- 1 red pepper, diced
- 3 medium carrots, grated coarsely
- 2 large tomatoes, diced (or 400g canned)
- 1 can (400g) baked beans in tomato sauce
- (VERY South African — do not substitute)
- 2 tbsp curry powder (mild South African curry)
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp paprika
- ½ tsp chilli flakes (or to taste)
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Salt and sugar to taste
- Fresh flat-leaf parsley to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oil in a wide pan over medium heat.
2. Add onion. Cook 6 minutes until golden.
3. Add garlic and ginger. Cook 1 minute.
4. Add green and red pepper. Cook 4 minutes.
5. Add curry powder, cumin, paprika, and chilli flakes. Stir and fry 1 minute — bloom the spices in the oil.
6. Add grated carrot. Stir to coat in spices. Cook 3 min.
7. Add tomatoes. Cook 5 minutes until broken down.
8. Add baked beans with their sauce.
9. Stir to combine everything. The baked bean sauce will thicken the chakalaka.
10. Simmer 10 minutes until thick and fragrant.
11. Season with salt and a pinch of sugar.
12. Serve warm alongside pap, or eat cold the next day — chakalaka improves overnight.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~195 per serving

TIP

Baked beans in tomato sauce (South African style — similar to Heinz baked beans) are the authentic and non-negotiable ingredient that makes chakalaka chakalaka. They provide body, sweetness, and that specific smoky-sweet tomato flavor that distinguishes it from a generic vegetable curry. Use them as written — they are not a shortcut but the actual ingredient.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Fiber] [Classic South African] [Township Heritage]

RECIPE 477

■ ■ South Africa

OUMA RUSKS

SOUTH AFRICAN BUTTERMILK RUSKS

South Africa's most universally beloved breakfast ritual — rusks, dry, brick-hard fingers of twice-baked buttermilk bread, dunked into hot rooibos tea or coffee until softened and eaten. Invented by Voortrekker settlers who needed bread that would not spoil on long wagon journeys, rusks became a South African institution that persists as the definitive early morning ritual — particularly beloved before dawn at construction sites, farms, and the offices of every South African who grew up with the dunk.

INGREDIENTS

- 1kg (8 cups) self-raising flour
- OR: 1kg plain flour + 4 tsp baking powder
- 200g ($\frac{3}{4}$ cup + 2 tbsp) sugar
- 2 tsp salt
- 500ml (2 cups) buttermilk
- 2 large eggs
- 250g (1 cup + 2 tbsp) butter, melted and cooled
- 1 cup (100g) All-Bran flakes or bran (optional — the classic Ouma rusk addition for fiber and crunch)

FOR DUNKING

- Rooibos tea (South Africa's indigenous herbal tea — the most traditional rusk-dunking accompaniment)
- OR strong black coffee
- OR warm milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 180°C (355°F).
2. Mix flour (with baking powder if using plain flour), sugar, and salt.
3. Whisk buttermilk, eggs, and melted butter together.
4. Add wet to dry. Mix with a wooden spoon — do NOT overmix. Fold gently until just combined.
5. Stir in All-Bran flakes if using.
6. Grease two loaf tins (900g / 2lb).
7. Divide mixture between tins.
8. Bake 45–55 minutes until a skewer comes out clean and the tops are golden.
9. Cool completely. Then cut into finger-shaped pieces — approximately 3–4cm wide, full height of the loaf.
10. DRYING: Arrange rusk fingers on oven racks.
11. Dry in oven at 100°C (210°F) for 6–8 hours (or overnight at the lowest possible setting) until completely hard and dry throughout. They should snap cleanly, not bend.
12. Cool completely. Store in an airtight container. They keep for months.
13. TO EAT: Dunk in hot rooibos or coffee for 10 seconds. The rusk softens from the outside inward.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 1 hr baking + 8 hrs drying · Serves: 24 rusks · Cal: ~185 per rusk

TIP

The drying time cannot be shortened — under-dried rusks have a slightly soft center that allows mould to form within days. Completely dry rusks (that snap cleanly without any bend) will last months in a tin. The test: snap one firmly. If it gives at all, return to the oven for 2 more hours.

[Vegetarian] [Classic South African] [Make-Ahead] [Voortrekker Heritage]

RECIPE 478

■ ■ South Africa

ROOIBOS TEA

SOUTH AFRICAN RED BUSH TEA

South Africa's gift to the world's tea drinkers — rooibos (red bush), a naturally caffeine-free herbal tea grown exclusively in the Cederberg Mountains of the Western Cape. Deep amber-red in color, with a sweet, slightly nutty, vanilla-like flavor entirely its own. Drunk across South Africa with full cream milk and sugar, or black, or with honey and lemon. The essential accompaniment to a South African breakfast and the beverage for dunking rusks. Nothing in the tea world tastes like it.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 heaped tsp loose-leaf rooibos (or 2 rooibos tea bags)
- 400ml (1■ cups) freshly boiled water
- Full cream milk (generously — South Africans use more milk in rooibos than most tea traditions)
- Sugar or honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Warm a teapot with boiling water. Discard.
2. Add rooibos to warmed teapot.
3. Pour freshly boiled water over — use fully boiling water, unlike delicate green teas.
4. Steep 5–7 minutes — rooibos benefits from longer steeping than black tea. It does not become bitter with extended steeping.
5. Pour through a strainer into mugs.
6. Add full cream milk generously — more than you'd use with black tea. Rooibos and milk combine beautifully into an almost caramel color.
7. Add sugar or honey to taste.
8. Serve with rusks for dunking.

Prep: 1 min · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~45 per cup (with milk, no sugar)

TIP

Rooibos benefits from slightly longer steeping than black tea — 5–7 minutes produces a deeper color and more developed flavor. It will not become astringent or bitter with longer steeping, unlike tannin-containing teas. This makes it especially good for those who habitually forget tea on the stove — rooibos forgives the inattentive brewer.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Caffeine-Free] [Classic South African] [Cultural Icon]

RECIPE 479

■ ■ South Africa (Xhosa)

UMNGQUSHO

SOUTH AFRICAN SAMP AND BEANS

Nelson Mandela's favorite food and one of South Africa's most traditional dishes — dried corn kernels (samp) cooked with sugar beans until soft and creamy, seasoned simply with butter, salt, and chilli. Umngqusho is Xhosa food — the breakfast of the Eastern Cape — eaten morning and evening as the staple dish that has sustained generations. Simple, deeply nourishing, and reflecting the agricultural heritage of southern Africa in every bite.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup samp (dried, hominy-style broken corn kernels —
- available at South African stores. Substitute:
- whole hominy corn, drained)
- 1 cup dried sugar beans (or pinto beans)
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp dried chilli flakes (optional)
- Fresh parsley or spring onion to garnish
- OPTIONAL ADDITIONS (for a fuller breakfast):
- A knob of extra butter melted over the top
- Amasi (South African cultured soured milk)
- poured alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak samp and beans together in cold water overnight — minimum 8 hours. They both need this soaking.
2. Drain and rinse.
3. Place in a large pot. Cover generously with fresh water.
4. Bring to a boil. Skim any foam.
5. Reduce heat. Simmer covered 2–3 hours until both the samp and beans are completely soft and beginning to break down into a thick, creamy porridge.
6. Add more hot water during cooking if needed — the mixture should stay moist throughout cooking.
7. When cooked, the samp and beans should be soft enough to mash lightly between fingers, and the cooking liquid should be thick and starchy.
8. Partially mash — some texture should remain.
9. Add butter, salt, pepper, and chilli.
10. Stir through. Taste and adjust.
11. Serve in bowls, garnished with fresh parsley.
12. Add amasi alongside if serving.

Prep: 5 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 3 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Samp and beans must be soaked overnight together — they rehydrate at roughly the same rate and both need the extended soaking to achieve the tender texture that defines proper umngqusho. Overnight soaking also reduces cooking time dramatically.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic South African] [Xhosa Heritage]

RECIPE 480

■ ■ South Africa (Cape Malay)

CAPE MALAY BREAKFAST FRIKKADELS

SPICED MEATBALLS

Cape Town's Cape Malay community brought Indonesian and Malaysian spice traditions to South Africa in the 17th and 18th centuries — and nowhere is this more apparent than in Cape Malay frikkadels (meatballs) spiced with turmeric, cinnamon, cardamom, and ginger. Eaten for breakfast with white rice or bread and sambal (fresh tomato- onion relish), these fragrant meatballs are unlike their Dutch namesake (plain meatballs) — they carry centuries of spice trade history in every bite.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (18 oz) minced beef or lamb
- 1 large onion, very finely diced and softened in butter
- 2 slices white bread, crusts removed, soaked in milk
- and squeezed dry
- 2 large eggs
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp fresh ginger, grated
- 1 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- ½ tsp ground coriander
- ½ tsp ground cumin
- ¼ tsp ground cloves
- 1 tbsp apricot jam (distinctly Cape Malay — sweet against savory is the Cape Malay signature)
- Salt and pepper
- Oil for frying

CAPE MALAY SAMBAL

- 2 tomatoes, finely diced
- 1 small onion, finely diced
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp ground coriander
- Fresh coriander leaves
- Salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SAMBAL: Mix all ingredients. Rest 15 minutes for flavors to meld. Set aside.
2. FRIKKADELS: Combine all meatball ingredients. Mix thoroughly with clean hands until completely homogeneous.
3. Taste by frying a small piece — adjust seasoning.
4. Shape into small balls (golf ball size) or slightly flattened rounds.
5. Heat oil in a pan over medium heat.
6. Fry frikkadels in batches, 3–4 minutes per side until browned and cooked through.
7. The turmeric will make the exterior golden — watch carefully as the color can be misleading. Cut one in half to check internal doneness.
8. Drain briefly. Serve with sambal alongside and white rice or warm bread.

Prep: 20 min • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 4 • Cal: ~390 per serving

TIP

Apricot jam in the meatball mixture is the Cape Malay touch that creates a subtle sweetness and moisture that distinguishes Cape Malay frikkadels from all other meatball traditions. It does not make the meatballs taste like jam — it rounds out the spices and creates a slight caramelization when frying. Do not omit it.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic South African] [Cape Malay Heritage]

RECIPE 481

■ ■ South Africa

VETKOEK WITH MINCE

SOUTH AFRICAN FRIED BREAD WITH SPICED MEAT

South Africa's beloved deep-fried bread roll — vetkoek (Afrikaans for "fat cake") is a soft, round, yeasted dough ball deep-fried until golden and split open, then filled with spiced mince (ground beef in a curry-spiced tomato sauce). Sold at every school tuck shop, every township vendor, every farmers' market, and every South African street festival. The combination of hot, pillowy fried bread with savory curried mince is quintessentially South African in the way that transcends every community and culture.

INGREDIENTS

VETKOEK DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 tsp sugar
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Oil for deep frying

SPICED MINCE FILLING

- 500g (18 oz) lean minced beef
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp curry powder (medium heat)
- 1 tsp ground coriander
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 2 large tomatoes, diced (or 400g canned)
- 1 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tsp sugar
- Salt and pepper
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Fresh coriander to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, salt, sugar. Add warm water and oil. Knead 8 minutes. Prove 45 minutes.
2. MINCE: Heat oil. Fry onion 6 minutes. Add garlic. Add mince — break up and brown fully. Add curry powder, coriander, turmeric. Stir 1 minute. Add tomatoes, tomato paste, and sugar. Simmer 15 minutes until thick. Season. Keep warm.
3. SHAPE VETKOEK: Divide proved dough into 10–12 balls.
4. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F) in a deep pot.
5. Lower dough balls into oil — 3–4 at a time.
6. Fry 4–5 minutes per side until deep golden and puffed. They should be cooked through — cut one open to check. The interior should be airy and cooked, not doughy.
7. Drain on paper towels briefly.
8. Split each vetkoek open immediately while hot — the steam inside escapes and the interior remains soft.
9. Fill generously with spiced mince.
10. Eat immediately while hot.

Prep: 15 min + 45 min proofing · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 5 · Cal: ~490 per vetkoek

TIP

Oil temperature of 170°C (not higher) allows vetkoek to cook through slowly before the exterior over-browns. Higher temperatures create golden-outside, raw-inside vetkoek — a South African disappointment. The dough balls should float to the surface when placed in oil and take a full 4–5 minutes per side. If they brown in 2 minutes, the oil is too hot.

[High Protein] [Classic South African] [Street Food] [Township Culture]

RECIPE 482

■ ■ South Africa (Zulu / Xhosa)

AMASI WITH PHUTU

SOUTH AFRICAN CULTURED MILK WITH CRUMBLY PAP

The most traditional Zulu and Xhosa morning breakfast — phutu pap (dry, crumbly maize porridge) eaten with amasi, South Africa's indigenous cultured soured milk with a thick, creamy texture and tangy, slightly yogurt-like flavor. Amasi (made by allowing fresh raw milk to ferment in a calabash or clay pot for several days) is deeply embedded in Nguni culture — it is nourishing, probiotic, and distinctly South African. The combination of crumbly phutu and cold, thick amasi is one of Africa's great simple breakfasts.

INGREDIENTS

- PHUTU PAP (CRUMBLY — see also Recipe 473):
- 2 cups white maize meal
- 1 cup cold water (only — much less than slap pap)
- 1 tsp salt
- No stirring — phutu must be crumbly, not smooth
- AMASI (to buy or make):
- BUY: Amasi (Inkomazi) is sold at South African grocery
- stores in cartons. It is a thick, tangy cultured milk.
- Substitute: a mixture of $\frac{3}{4}$ cup thick plain yogurt +
- $\frac{1}{4}$ cup kefir — approximates the tang and thickness.
- MAKE (authentic method — 2–3 days):
- 1L (4 cups) full cream fresh milk, unhomogenized
- Place in a clean clay pot or glass jar — NOT plastic.
- Cover loosely with a cloth.
- Leave at room temperature 2–3 days until thick, creamy, and pleasantly sour.
- Stir. Refrigerate. Use within 5 days.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. PHUTU: Bring water and salt to a boil. Add all the maize meal at once. Do NOT stir.
2. Reduce heat immediately to very low.
3. Cover with a tight lid. Cook 20 minutes undisturbed.
4. Lift lid. Break up with a fork — it should be dry and crumbly, with no wet patches.
5. If there are wet areas, cook uncovered 5 more minutes.
6. The correct phutu crumbles easily and does not stick together when pressed.
7. SERVE: Scoop phutu onto plates.
8. Pour cold amasi generously beside or over the phutu.
9. Each person breaks crumbles of phutu into the amasi and eats the cold-and-warm combination.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~295 per serving

TIP

The contrast of warm, crumbly phutu against cold, thick amasi is the entire pleasure of this breakfast. The phutu must be genuinely crumbly (not moist or clumping) and the amasi must be genuinely cold and thick. Serve them separately and let each person combine at the table, managing their own temperature contrast — too much amasi makes it soupy; too little leaves the phutu dry. Personal balance is the tradition.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic South African] [Nguni Heritage]

Ethiopia

RECIPE 483

■ ■ Ethiopia

INJERA

ETHIOPIAN FERMENTED TEFF FLATBREAD

The foundation of Ethiopian civilization — injera, a massive, spongy, sour fermented flatbread made from teff flour, cooked in a large clay pan until the surface is covered in thousands of holes (the "eyes" of the injera). It serves simultaneously as plate, utensil, and food — stews and sauces are placed on it and torn pieces are used to scoop them up. Teff is one of the world's most nutritious grains — high in protein, calcium, and iron — and the fermentation creates a complex sourness that is the defining flavor of Ethiopian cuisine.

INGREDIENTS

- FOR THE INJERA BATTER (make 3–5 days ahead):
- 2 cups teff flour (brown or white — brown has a more complex flavor, white is milder)
- 500ml (2 cups) lukewarm water
- NO YEAST — the fermentation is entirely wild

FOR COOKING

- Additional water to thin the batter as needed
- A large, flat non-stick pan or traditional mitad
- (clay injera pan)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DAY 1: Whisk teff flour with lukewarm water until completely smooth — no lumps.
2. Pour into a clean glass bowl (not metal). Cover loosely with a cloth — it must breathe.
3. Leave at room temperature.
4. DAY 2–5: Stir once or twice per day. The batter will begin to ferment — bubbles will appear, and the liquid will separate. This is correct. A thin gray liquid (the "starter") rises to the top.
5. DAYS 2–3: Batter should smell pleasantly sour — like yogurt or sourdough. If it smells bad, start again.
6. DAY 3–4 (when ready): The batter is ready when it smells sour and tangy and has developed a frothy top.
7. Thin the fermented batter with water to a very loose, pourable consistency — thinner than crêpe batter.
8. COOKING INJERA: Heat a large non-stick pan over medium-high heat. No oil.
9. Pour a large ladleful in a quick spiral from the outside inward, covering the pan completely.
10. The batter should be thin — 3–4mm thick.
11. Cover with a lid immediately.
12. Cook 2–3 minutes until: — The eyes (holes) have formed across the entire surface — The surface looks dry and fully set — The edges begin to lift naturally
13. Do NOT flip — injera is cooked on one side only.
14. Remove with a flat spatula. The bottom should be pale — not golden. Injera should not be browned.
15. Cool on a rack or cloth. Do not stack hot.

Prep: 10 min + 3–5 days fermentation · Cook: 3 min per injera · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~165 per injera

TIP

The fermentation time depends on temperature — 3 days in a warm kitchen (26°C+) or 5 days in a cool kitchen (18°C). The sourness of the injera increases with fermentation time — Ethiopians typically prefer 3–4 days for optimal tang. Under-fermented injera is flat and bland; properly fermented injera is complex and alive.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Ethiopian] [Ancient Recipe]

RECIPE 484

■ ■ Ethiopia

FIRFIR

ETHIOPIAN INJERA WITH SPICED BUTTER AND BERBERE

Ethiopia's most beloved morning dish — day-old injera torn into pieces and cooked with spiced clarified butter (niter kibbeh), berbere spice blend, and sometimes leftover lega tibs (stew). Firfir transforms leftover injera into something more satisfying than the original — the torn pieces absorb the butter and berbere, becoming warm, spiced, and irresistible. Eaten at every Ethiopian breakfast table and at every injera stall across Addis Ababa from the first light.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large pieces leftover injera, torn into
- 3–4cm irregular pieces
- 3 tbsp niter kibbeh (Ethiopian spiced clarified butter):
 - — Melt 200g butter with 1 minced onion, 3 garlic cloves,
 - 1 tsp grated ginger, ½ tsp turmeric, ½ tsp cumin,
 - ¼ tsp cardamom — simmer 20 min, strain
 - — OR: use ghee + spices added directly
- 2 tbsp berbere spice blend:
 - — A complex Ethiopian spice blend: dried chilli, fenugreek,
 - coriander, black pepper, cardamom, cinnamon, cloves,
 - allspice, ginger, dried onion — ground together.
 - — Buy prepared berbere at Ethiopian specialty stores
- 1 small onion, finely diced
- 2 tbsp tomato, finely diced (optional)
- Salt to taste
- Ayib (Ethiopian fresh cheese) to serve — or crumbled
- feta as substitute

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat niter kibbeh in a wide pan over medium heat.
2. Add diced onion. Cook 5 minutes until softened.
3. Add berbere. Stir and fry in the butter 1 minute — the spices bloom in the kibbeh fat.
4. Add tomato if using. Cook 2 minutes.
5. Add torn injera pieces. Toss to coat in the spiced butter — every piece should be coated.
6. Stir-fry over medium heat 3–4 minutes until the injera pieces absorb the butter and spices and become warmed through.
7. Season with salt.
8. Transfer to a plate lined with a fresh piece of injera.
9. Scatter crumbled ayib or feta on top.
10. Eat by tearing pieces of the base injera and using them to scoop the firfir.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~340 per serving

TIP

Day-old injera is essential — fresh injera falls apart immediately when tossed in hot butter. Day-old injera has dried slightly and holds together during cooking while still absorbing the spiced butter deeply. This is the practical brilliance of firfir — it is designed for yesterday's injera.

[Gluten-Free] [Classic Ethiopian] [Zero Waste] [Quick]

RECIPE 485

■ ■ Ethiopia (Oromo)

CHECHEBSA

An Oromo morning classic that is simpler than firfir but equally satisfying — fresh qicha (simple unleavened wheat flatbread) torn into pieces, tossed with warm niter kibbeh and mitmita (Ethiopian bird's eye chilli powder blended with cardamom and cloves), and eaten with honey and yogurt. Chechebsa bridges the Ethiopian bread tradition with the spice tradition in its most immediate form — bread, butter, and fire.

INGREDIENTS

- QICHA (simple flatbread):
- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- Water to make a soft dough
- Cook as thin flatbreads in a dry pan — pale, not golden
- OR: use fresh injera, msemen, or any soft flatbread

TOPPINGS

- 4 tbsp niter kibbeh (Ethiopian spiced clarified butter
- — see Recipe 484) or plain ghee
- 1–2 tsp mitmita (Ethiopian bird's eye chilli blend
- with cardamom and cloves — very hot and aromatic)
- Honey (dark and floral — Ethiopian honey is extraordinary)
- Plain yogurt or ayib (Ethiopian fresh cheese)
- Optional: a pinch of turmeric over the butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make qicha flatbreads: form dough into thin rounds. Cook on a dry pan until cooked through but pale.
2. While still warm, tear flatbreads into irregular pieces (5–6cm).
3. Heat niter kibbeh in a wide pan over medium heat.
4. Add torn flatbread pieces. Toss in the hot butter.
5. Sprinkle mitmita over the buttered pieces — begin with a small amount (mitmita is very hot).
6. Toss to distribute evenly.
7. Transfer to a plate or wide serving dish.
8. Drizzle honey over.
9. Serve with cold yogurt or ayib on the side.
10. The contrast of spiced, buttered bread + honey + cool yogurt is the full chechebsa experience.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Mitmita is one of Ethiopia's finest and most powerful spice blends — ground bird's eye chilli with cardamom, cloves, and black pepper creating a fruity-floral heat unlike any generic chilli powder. Start with a very small amount (¼ tsp per serving) and increase. The honey drizzle is not optional — it is the counter-balance to the chilli that makes chechebsa complete.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Ethiopian] [Oromo Heritage] [Sweet-Spicy]

RECIPE 486

■ ■ Ethiopia

GENFO

Ethiopia's most sustaining porridge — ground barley cooked with water into a very thick, stiff porridge, mounded in a bowl, and served with a deep well in the center filled with warm niter kibbeh mixed with berbere or mitmita. Eaten by pressing pieces of the thick porridge inward through the butter-filled well — each bite a combination of bland, starchy barley softened by the intensely spiced butter. The eating ritual is as specific as the recipe.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups barley flour (whole barley ground fine — or use whole wheat flour as a substitute)
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- 1 tsp salt
- BUTTER WELL (essential):
- 4 tbsp niter kibbeh (spiced clarified butter — Recipe 484)
- 1 tsp berbere spice blend (or mitmita)
- Mix together — pour into the center well at serving

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Yogurt (ergo) poured around the base
- Honey drizzle (optional — the sweet version)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water and salt to a rolling boil in a heavy-bottomed pot.
2. Add barley flour in a thin, steady stream while stirring vigorously. Do not add all at once.
3. The mixture will thicken rapidly into a very stiff, smooth porridge.
4. Reduce heat to lowest setting.
5. Switch to a very strong wooden spoon or paddle. Stir vigorously and continuously 10–12 minutes until the genfo is very thick, smooth, and begins to pull cleanly from the sides of the pot. This requires physical effort.
6. The correct consistency: genfo should hold a shape when spooned — much stiffer than Western porridge.
7. MOUND: Turn hot genfo out into a wide, deep bowl. Using a wet spoon, smooth into a dome shape.
8. WELL: Press the back of a spoon firmly into the center of the dome to create a deep well.
9. Pour warm niter kibbeh mixed with berbere into the well — it should fill and overflow slightly.
10. Pour yogurt around the base of the mound.
11. Eat by pressing genfo inward through the butter well.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~395 per serving

TIP

The vigorous stirring during cooking is the physical technique that prevents lumps and creates the smooth, unified texture of perfect genfo. Weak or intermittent stirring creates lumpy, grainy porridge. Use the strongest wooden spoon you have and stir as hard as you can throughout. Ethiopian grandmothers make this look effortless. It takes real effort.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic Ethiopian] [High Fiber] [Sustaining]

RECIPE 487

■ ■ Ethiopia

ENJERA BE TIBS

INJERA WITH SAUTÉED MEAT

Ethiopia's essential protein breakfast — tibs, bite-sized pieces of lamb, beef, or goat sautéed in niter kibbeh with onion, jalapeño, rosemary, and berbere until caramelized and fragrant. Served on injera, the meat's spiced butter soaks into the bread, transforming every section of injera that touches the tibs into something extraordinary. Eaten communally, everyone at the table tearing from the same large injera, sharing the tibs.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) lamb shoulder or beef, cut into
- 2cm cubes (bone-in for more flavor if available)
- 1 large onion, thinly sliced
- 1 fresh jalapeño or green chilli, thinly sliced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp fresh rosemary, finely chopped
- 2 tbsp berbere
- 3 tbsp niter kibbeh (spiced clarified butter)
- Salt to taste
- Fresh injera for serving
- Ayib (Ethiopian fresh cheese) or yogurt alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat niter kibbeh in a large, heavy pan over high heat.
2. Add meat in a single layer. Do NOT crowd. Sear on high heat without stirring 2 minutes — a good crust must form.
3. Toss and sear the other sides. 2 more minutes.
4. Add onion. Reduce heat to medium. Cook 5 minutes.
5. Add garlic, jalapeño, and rosemary. Cook 2 minutes.
6. Add berbere. Stir to coat everything.
7. Cook uncovered over medium heat, stirring occasionally, 8–10 more minutes until meat is cooked through and slightly caramelized.
8. The spiced butter should be soaking into the meat, creating a glossy, fragrant surface.
9. Season with salt. Taste.
10. Serve directly on a large piece of fresh injera. The tibs will soak the injera as you eat.
11. Arrange additional injera pieces around the plate.
12. Place ayib or yogurt on the side.
13. Eat communally — everyone tears from the shared injera.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

High heat for the initial sear is essential — tibs must be caramelized, not stewed. If the pan steams when the meat is added, the heat is too low. The meat should sear and color immediately on contact. Cook in batches if needed rather than crowding and creating steam.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Ethiopian] [Communal Breakfast]

RECIPE 488

■ ■ Ethiopia

ETHIOPIAN COFFEE CEREMONY

BUNNA MAFLAT

Ethiopia — the birthplace of coffee — practices the most extraordinary coffee ritual on earth. Raw green coffee beans are washed, roasted over charcoal in a pan (jebena) until dark and fragrant, ground in a wooden mortar, brewed in a clay coffee pot (jebena), and served in three successive rounds to each guest. The ceremony takes over an hour. The coffee is served black, strong, with sugar or salt — never with milk. It is drunk in small cups (cini). No other country on earth treats coffee with this level of care and ceremony. Ethiopia gave the world coffee. It has never stopped honoring that gift.

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (½ cup) green coffee beans (Ethiopian — Yirgacheffe
- or Sidamo for the most aromatic results.
- Find at specialty coffee shops or online.)
- 800ml (3■ cups) water
- Sugar (to taste — Ethiopian coffee often served with
- 3 tsp sugar per small cup)
- Optional: a pinch of salt (some Ethiopian communities
- use salt instead of sugar)
- Optional: ground cardamom (1 pod per jebena)
- Kolo (roasted barley or chickpeas) to eat alongside

EQUIPMENT

- A jebena (Ethiopian clay coffee pot with round base
- and long neck) — or a small metal coffee pot
- Small cups (cini) or espresso cups
- A charcoal burner or gas flame
- A shallow pan for roasting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. WASHING: Rinse green coffee beans in cold water. Drain. Remove any debris.
2. ROASTING: Place a dry, heavy pan over medium-high heat or charcoal. Add washed beans.
3. Stir continuously with a long-handled spoon.
4. The beans will yellow, then turn tan, then begin to brown and smoke. This takes 8–12 minutes.
5. Continue until beans are dark brown and very fragrant — similar to medium-dark espresso roast. Do not over-roast to black.
6. Transfer to a wooden mortar while still warm. Allow to cool slightly — 2 minutes.
7. WAFTING: It is Ethiopian tradition to hold the roasted beans close to each guest so the fragrant smoke can be inhaled — a sign of hospitality.
8. GRINDING: Pound beans in a wooden mortar to a medium-fine grind — not espresso fine. 5–7 minutes.
9. BREWING: Add ground coffee to the jebena. Pour cold water over (about 600ml for first brew). Place on heat. Bring to a boil very slowly.
10. When it boils, remove from heat. Allow to settle. Return to low heat. Repeat 2–3 times.
11. THE THREE ROUNDS: FIRST: abol — strongest, most intense SECOND: tona — second brewing of same grounds THIRD: bereka (blessing) — third and final brewing, lightest
12. Pour through a small strainer (or the jebena's natural filter) into cups.
13. Add sugar. Drink slowly. Refill. The first round takes as long as it takes.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~10 per cup (black, no sugar)

TIP

Ethiopian coffee ceremony is deliberately slow — rushing any stage destroys both the experience and the coffee quality. The three rounds of brewing from the same grounds create three different coffees: the first is intense and complex; the second is mellower; the third is gentle and almost sweet. Drinking all three is both the tradition and the full flavor experience.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Ethiopian] [Coffee Ceremony] [Cultural Ritual]

RECIPE 489

■ ■ Ethiopia

FUL BEL KIBBEH

ETHIOPIAN FAVA BEANS WITH SPICED BUTTER

Ethiopia's version of the pan-African fava bean breakfast — cooked fava beans mashed with niter kibbeh (spiced clarified butter), jalapeño, and a squeeze of lemon, eaten on injera or with bread. The Ethiopian ful is less garlicky than the Egyptian version and more butter-rich — the niter kibbeh transforms the beans with its accumulated spice depth. Eaten at Ethiopian cafés (bet bunna) for breakfast alongside firfir and a glass of tea.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups dried fava beans, soaked overnight and cooked
- until very soft (or 2 cans cooked fava beans)
- 3 tbsp niter kibbeh (Ethiopian spiced butter — Recipe 484)
- 1 jalapeño or green chilli, finely sliced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Injera or flatbread for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mash cooked fava beans roughly — leaving some whole pieces for texture. Ethiopian ful is not a smooth purée.
2. Heat niter kibbeh in a pan over medium heat.
3. Add garlic and jalapeño. Fry 1 minute.
4. Add mashed fava beans. Stir to coat in the spiced butter.
5. Cook 5 minutes, stirring, until the beans are heated through and have absorbed the butter.
6. Add lemon juice. Season with salt.
7. Taste — savory, buttery, with chilli warmth.
8. Transfer to a bowl or plate lined with injera.
9. Scatter fresh coriander generously.
10. Drizzle extra niter kibbeh over the top.
11. Serve with injera for scooping.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~320 per serving

TIP

The niter kibbeh is what makes Ethiopian ful distinctly Ethiopian. Its accumulated spice depth — from the onion, ginger, turmeric, and cumin cooked into the clarified butter — transforms plain beans into something complex and deeply satisfying. Make a large batch of niter kibbeh and use it throughout Ethiopian cooking for weeks.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Ethiopian] [Quick]

RECIPE 490

■■ Nigeria

AKARA

NIGERIAN FRIED BEAN CAKES

Nigeria's most beloved breakfast street food — black-eyed pea or brown bean fritters soaked, ground, aerated by vigorous beating, and deep-fried into golden, crispy, protein-rich balls. Sold at roadside stalls by akara sellers from early morning, akara is eaten across Nigeria regardless of ethnicity — Hausa, Yoruba, and Igbo communities all claim it. It's served with ogi (fermented porridge) or bread. The beating of the batter is the technique that creates the light, fluffy interior that makes Nigerian akara unlike any other bean fritter.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups black-eyed peas or Nigerian brown beans
- (ewa oloyin) — soaked overnight
- 1 medium onion, roughly chopped
- 2–3 fresh Scotch bonnet chillies (or habanero — adjust to heat preference)
- 1 tsp salt
- Optional: 1 stock cube (Maggi) — very Nigerian
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **PEELING BEANS:** Drain soaked beans. Rub handfuls vigorously between your palms to remove the skin. Transfer to a bowl of water — skins float to the top. Pour off. Repeat until most skins are removed. Peeled beans create the white, fluffy akara. Unpeeled beans create a darker, denser result.
2. **GRINDING:** Blend peeled beans with onion and chillies and minimum water — the batter must be **THICK**. Blend until very smooth — 2–3 minutes.
3. Transfer to a wide bowl.
4. **BEATING:** This is the most critical step. Beat the batter vigorously with a wooden spoon or hand mixer for 5 minutes. The batter will become paler, lighter, and fluffy — incorporating air.
5. **Test:** drop a small amount in water. If it floats, there is enough air. If it sinks, beat more.
6. Add salt and Maggi cube if using. Beat briefly.
7. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a deep pot.
8. Using a wet spoon or your hand, scoop batter and carefully lower into hot oil in rounded blobs.
9. Fry in batches, turning, 4–5 minutes until deeply golden all over and cooked through.
10. Drain on paper towels.
11. Serve hot with ogi or bread.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

The vigorous beating of the batter is the Nigerian technique that creates the characteristic light, fluffy interior of good akara. This beating is not optional — unbeaten batter produces dense, heavy fritters. The float test (batter floating in water) is the traditional Nigerian check for sufficient aeration. If it sinks, continue beating.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Nigerian] [Street Food]

RECIPE 491

■■ Nigeria

OGI / AKAMU

NIGERIAN FERMENTED CORN PORRIDGE

Nigeria's most universal breakfast porridge — ogi (Yoruba) or akamu (Igbo) is a smooth, silky, lightly fermented cornmeal porridge made from dried white or yellow corn soaked for days until sour, then ground, sieved, and cooked into a thin, custard-like consistency. Eaten with akara, moi moi, or sweetened with evaporated milk and sugar. The fermentation gives ogi a gentle sourness that is deeply comforting, and the smooth texture makes it one of Africa's most digestible morning foods.

INGREDIENTS

- OGI (FERMENTED CORN PASTE — make 3 days ahead):
- 2 cups dried white or yellow corn (maize), whole
- Water for soaking and fermenting
- Additional water for cooking

TO SERVE

- Evaporated milk or full cream milk
- Sugar or honey
- OR: serve plain alongside akara or moi moi

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse corn. Soak in cold water 3 days, changing water daily. The corn will ferment — this is correct.
2. DAY 3: Drain fermented corn. Grind in a blender with fresh water until very smooth.
3. Sieve through a fine cloth or very fine mesh — squeeze out all liquid. Discard solids.
4. Allow the strained liquid to settle for 30 minutes — the starch sinks to the bottom.
5. Pour off the top water carefully, leaving the settled starch paste at the bottom.
6. This is the ogi paste — store in refrigerator up to 1 week. It will look like thick, pale slurry.
7. COOKING: Mix ogi paste with cold water to a smooth, thin consistency (ratio: 1 part paste to 3 parts water).
8. Pour into a pot. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until it thickens and becomes translucent and smooth — 5–7 minutes.
9. The finished ogi should be smooth, pourable, and slightly thicker than cream.
10. Pour into bowls.
11. Add evaporated milk and sugar to taste.
12. Eat warm alongside akara or moi moi.

Prep: 10 min + 3 days fermentation · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~195 per bowl (with milk)

TIP

The fermentation is what creates ogi's characteristic gentle sourness — without fermentation the porridge is plain and flat. Three days of room- temperature soaking develops the lactic acid bacteria that transform corn into the complex, tangy ogi Nigerians have eaten for millennia. The sourness should be gentle, not overwhelming — if it smells unpleasant, discard and start again.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nigerian] [Fermented] [Healing]

RECIPE 492

■■ Nigeria

MOI MOI

NIGERIAN STEAMED BEAN PUDDING

Nigeria's most celebrated bean preparation — black-eyed peas ground smooth with onion, pepper, and palm oil or vegetable oil, then steamed in banana leaves, foil, or moi moi tins until set into a firm, rich, savory pudding. Moi moi can be plain or elaborately filled with hard-boiled egg, fish, crayfish, and corned beef. Eaten for breakfast alongside ogi, or as a standalone morning meal. The steaming transforms the raw bean paste into something silky and completely satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups black-eyed peas, soaked overnight and peeled
- (same peeling method as akara — Recipe 490)
- 1 large onion, roughly chopped
- 2 fresh Scotch bonnet chillies (adjust to heat)
- 2 tbsp ground crayfish (dried shrimp powder — essential for authentic Nigerian flavor)
- 3 tbsp palm oil (or vegetable oil)
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 Maggi or chicken stock cube, dissolved
- 200ml (¾ cup) water or chicken stock
- OPTIONAL FILLINGS (place inside before steaming):
 - 2 hard-boiled eggs, halved
 - Smoked fish, flaked (eja kika)
 - Canned sardines or mackerel, flaked
 - Banana leaves or foil for wrapping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend peeled beans with onion, chillies, and just enough water to facilitate blending — thick batter.
2. Add ground crayfish, palm oil, salt, and stock cube.
3. Blend until very smooth. Add water/stock to reach a thick, pourable consistency — like thick pancake batter.
4. Taste — it should be savory, spiced, and slightly smoky from the palm oil.
5. PREPARE BANANA LEAVES: Wilt over a flame briefly to make pliable. Clean. Cut into 30cm squares. OR: use foil cups, ramekins, or small tins.
6. Form cups from banana leaf squares. Secure with toothpicks.
7. Pour batter into each cup to ¾ full.
8. Add chosen filling in the center.
9. Seal the banana leaf cups by folding the top over.
10. Place in a steamer over boiling water.
11. Steam 45–50 minutes until fully set. Test: insert a skewer — it should come out clean.
12. Cool 5 minutes before opening.
13. Serve warm or at room temperature.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~265 per moi moi

TIP

Ground crayfish (dried, ground shrimp) is the umami engine of Nigerian cuisine — its smoky, deeply savory, slightly funky quality appears in almost every Nigerian dish. In moi moi, it creates a depth that vegetable oil and salt alone cannot achieve. Find it at West African grocery stores. It keeps for months and transforms every dish it touches.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nigerian] [Steamed] [Celebration]

Nigeria

RECIPE 493

■■ Nigeria

PUFF PUFF

NIGERIAN SWEET FRIED DOUGH BALLS

Nigeria's most beloved sweet breakfast snack — soft, puffy, golden fried dough balls scented with nutmeg, eaten warm from paper bags at street stalls, bus stops, and school gates. Puff puff is the Nigerian doughnut hole — made from a simple yeasted batter without any shaping, scooped directly into hot oil in rounded blobs that puff dramatically during frying. Eaten for breakfast alongside akara or on their own with sweet tea. Simple, irresistible, and the smell of Nigerian morning markets worldwide.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg (essential — gives puff puff its characteristic warm, slightly spiced sweetness)
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- 1 tsp vanilla extract (optional but excellent)
- Oil for deep frying

OPTIONAL COATINGS

- Powdered sugar for rolling
- Granulated sugar

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, and nutmeg.
2. Add warm water and vanilla. Mix into a thick, smooth batter — thicker than pancake batter but much looser than bread dough.
3. Cover. Rest in a warm place 45–60 minutes until the batter has risen and is full of bubbles.
4. The batter should be visibly puffed and aerated.
5. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a deep pot.
6. SHAPING: Using two wet spoons or your wet hand, scoop rounded balls of batter (golf ball size) and carefully drop into the hot oil.
7. Fry in batches — do not crowd.
8. The batter balls will puff and rotate in the oil as one side cooks. Gently encourage rotation to ensure even coloring.
9. Fry 4–5 minutes until uniformly deep golden.
10. Drain on paper towels.
11. Toss in powdered sugar while still warm if desired.
12. Eat immediately — puff puff is best within 30 minutes.

Prep: 10 min + 1 hr resting · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

Nutmeg is the defining flavor of puff puff — not nutmeg as a secondary spice but nutmeg as a primary flavor. Use freshly grated nutmeg for maximum fragrance. The batter must be properly fermented (45–60 minutes of proofing) before frying — unproofed batter creates dense, heavy puff puff without the characteristic interior lightness.

[Vegan] [Classic Nigerian] [Street Food] [Sweet] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 494

■■ Nigeria

EGG SAUCE WITH BREAD

NIGERIAN FRIED EGG TOMATO SAUCE

Nigeria's most universally eaten weekday breakfast — eggs cooked in a spiced tomato and onion sauce with Scotch bonnet pepper and vegetable oil, eaten with sliced white bread. Simple, quick, and deeply satisfying, egg sauce is what millions of Nigerian students and workers eat before leaving the house every morning. The Scotch bonnet gives it a specific fruity heat that marks it as West African, and the generous palm or vegetable oil creates a sauce rich enough to soak deeply into the bread.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 3 medium ripe tomatoes, blended or very finely chopped
- 1 large onion — ½ blended with tomatoes, ½ thinly sliced for cooking
- 1–2 Scotch bonnet chillies (or habanero), blended
- 3 tbsp vegetable oil or palm oil
- 1 tsp curry powder (Nigerian style)
- ½ tsp dried thyme
- Salt to taste
- White sliced bread for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend tomatoes, ½ onion, and Scotch bonnet together into a smooth purée.
2. Heat oil in a wide pan over medium-high heat.
3. Add sliced onion. Cook 4 minutes until softened.
4. Add blended tomato mixture. It will splutter — Nigerian tomato sauce always starts with a splash.
5. Cook over medium-high heat 10–15 minutes, stirring, until the tomato sauce has reduced significantly — it should be thick, slightly caramelized, and the oil should be visibly separating at the surface. This reduction is critical.
6. Add curry powder and thyme. Stir. Cook 1 minute.
7. Season with salt. Taste — it should be spicy, slightly sweet from the tomato, and fragrant.
8. Beat eggs lightly. Pour over the sauce.
9. Stir gently with a spatula — fold the eggs into the sauce rather than scrambling. The eggs should cook in large, soft pieces within the sauce.
10. Cook until eggs are just set — 2–3 minutes.
11. Remove from heat while still slightly soft.
12. Serve with sliced white bread.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~370 per serving

TIP

The tomato sauce must be cooked until the oil separates at the surface before adding eggs — this "frying" of the tomato in the oil is the Nigerian technique (sofrito) that transforms raw, sharp tomato into a rich, sweet, deeply flavored sauce. Under-cooked tomato sauce produces a sharp, thin result that overwhelms the eggs.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nigerian] [Quick] [Everyday]

RECIPE 495

■ ■ Nigeria (Hausa-Fulani North)

TUWO SHINKAFA WITH

Northern Nigeria's most traditional breakfast — tuwo shinkafa (smooth, sticky rice flour porridge) served with miyan kuka (a dark, slightly gelatinous soup made from dried baobab leaves). The combination of mild, smooth rice porridge and the slightly mucilaginous, deeply flavored baobab soup is uniquely Hausa — eaten across northern Nigeria and neighboring Niger, Chad, and Cameroon. Baobab leaves are one of Africa's most nutritious ingredients — eaten across the Sahel for thousands of years.

INGREDIENTS

TUWO SHINKAFA

- 2 cups rice flour or ground parboiled rice
- 800ml (3 cups) water
- 1 tsp salt

MIYAN KUKA (BAOBAB LEAF SOUP)

- 3 tbsp dried baobab leaf powder (kuka) — available at West African stores online.
- Has a slightly sour, slightly mucilaginous quality.
- 200g (7 oz) goat, lamb, or smoked fish, cooked and shredded
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 2 tbsp ground crayfish
- 1 Scotch bonnet chilli, ground
- 2 tbsp palm oil or vegetable oil
- 1 stock cube
- 600ml (2½ cups) water or meat broth
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MIYAN KUKA: Heat palm oil in a pot over medium heat.
2. Add onion. Cook 5 minutes.
3. Add ground crayfish and Scotch bonnet. Stir briefly.
4. Add water or broth. Bring to a simmer.
5. Add cooked meat or smoked fish.
6. Dissolve kuka powder in 100ml warm water — mix well.
7. Add kuka paste to the pot. Stir thoroughly.
8. Simmer 15 minutes — the soup will thicken slightly and turn a deep, dark green-brown color.
9. Add stock cube. Season with salt. The soup should be slightly mucilaginous (slippery) from the baobab — this is correct and traditional.
10. TUWO SHINKAFA: Bring water and salt to a boil. Add rice flour in a thin stream while stirring.
11. Cook over low heat, stirring, 8–10 minutes until very thick and smooth.
12. Beat vigorously until the tuwo pulls from the sides.
13. SERVE: Mound tuwo in a bowl. Ladle soup alongside. Eat by tearing pieces of tuwo and dipping in soup.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Baobab leaf powder (kuka) creates an intentionally mucilaginous (slightly thick, slippery) soup texture that is characteristic of Sahel cooking — similar to okra's texture. This is not a flaw; it is the specific textural quality valued in northern Nigerian and Sahelian cuisine. Embrace the slight slipperiness as the tradition it is.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Nigerian] [Hausa Heritage] [Sahel]

RECIPE 496

■ ■ Ghana

KELEWELE

GHANAIAN SPICED FRIED PLANTAIN

Ghana's most irresistible street breakfast — very ripe plantain cubed and marinated in ginger, red pepper, and salt before deep-frying until deeply caramelized, crispy on the outside, and custardy-sweet within. The spice marinade caramelizes against the plantain's natural sugars during frying, creating a complex sweet-spicy-caramelized exterior that is one of West Africa's greatest flavor combinations. Sold from street carts at dawn and eaten standing up with peanuts sprinkled over.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 very ripe plantains — deeply black-spotted,
- almost fully ripe (overripe is perfect here —
- more sugar = more caramelization)
- 2 tsp fresh ginger, very finely grated or blended
- 1–2 tsp ground cayenne or ground dried chilli
- ½ tsp ground white pepper
- ½ tsp ground mixed spice or nutmeg
- 1 tsp salt
- Neutral oil for deep frying
- Roasted groundnuts (peanuts) to serve alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Peel plantains. Cut into 2cm cubes or diagonal rounds.
2. Combine ginger, cayenne, white pepper, mixed spice, and salt in a bowl.
3. Add plantain pieces. Toss to coat completely.
4. Marinate 15–30 minutes — the spices penetrate better.
5. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a deep pan.
6. Fry plantain pieces in batches — do not crowd.
7. Fry 4–5 minutes, turning occasionally, until: — Deeply golden-brown (almost mahogany) — The sugar has caramelized — slightly charred at edges — The interior is soft and almost custardy
8. IMPORTANT: Kelewele should be darker than you expect — the caramelization is the achievement. Pale golden kelewele is under-cooked.
9. Drain briefly on paper towels.
10. Serve hot in a paper cone or bowl.
11. Scatter roasted groundnuts over the top.

Prep: 10 min + 15 min marinating · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

The plantain MUST be very ripe — deeply black-spotted. Under-ripe plantain lacks the sugars that caramelize during frying and create kelewele's characteristic deep color and complex sweetness. Buy plantains 4–7 days ahead and let them ripen at room temperature until the skin is more black than yellow.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Ghanaian] [Street Food] [Sweet-Spicy]

Ghana

RECIPE 497

■■ Ghana

HAUSA KOKO WITH KOOSE

Ghana's classic street breakfast pairing — hausa koko, a smooth fermented millet porridge spiced with ginger, cloves, and pepper, served with koose (Ghanaian bean fritters identical to Nigerian akara). The koko is poured from large clay pots at dawn by koko sellers who carry it balanced on their heads through Accra's neighborhoods. The combination of slightly sour, spiced porridge and hot, crispy bean fritters is one of West Africa's great morning flavor combinations.

INGREDIENTS

HAUSA KOKO (SPICED MILLET PORRIDGE)

- 2 cups millet, soaked 2–3 days in cold water
- (fermented — same principle as ogi)
- 2cm fresh ginger, grated
- 4 whole cloves
- ½ tsp ground white pepper
- 1 tsp anise seeds (optional)
- 800ml (3 cups) water for cooking
- Sugar or evaporated milk to taste at serving
- KOOSE (BEAN FRITTERS — Ghana style):
- 2 cups black-eyed peas, soaked overnight and peeled
- 1 large onion, roughly chopped
- 1–2 Scotch bonnet chillies
- 2 tbsp ground crayfish
- 1 tsp salt
- Oil for deep frying

INSTRUCTIONS

1. HAUSA KOKO PASTE: Drain fermented millet. Grind with ginger, cloves, pepper, and anise using minimal water to a smooth paste. Strain through fine cloth — pressing out all liquid. The strained liquid is the koko paste base.
2. Mix koko paste with water.
3. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until smooth and thick — 7–8 minutes.
4. Serve with sugar or milk for sweetening.
5. KOOSE: Blend soaked peeled beans with onion and Scotch bonnet to a thick, smooth paste.
6. Add ground crayfish and salt.
7. Beat vigorously with a spoon 5 minutes until aerated.
8. Scoop into hot oil (175°C/345°F). Fry 4–5 minutes until golden.
9. SERVE: Pour koko into bowls. Add 2–3 koose per bowl.
10. The koose float in the koko. Eat both together — tearing pieces of koose and letting them soak.

Prep: 20 min + 2–3 days fermentation · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~375 per serving

TIP

The spicing of hausa koko — particularly the cloves and white pepper — is what creates the characteristically warming, almost medicinal quality of the porridge. These spices were historically used in West Africa as digestive aids and energizers. The slightly medicinal warmth alongside the sourness of fermented millet is the complete hausa koko experience.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Ghanaian] [Street Breakfast]

RECIPE 498

■■ Ghana

AMPESI WITH KONTOMIRE STEW

A traditional Ghanaian breakfast of the Akan people — boiled yam and plantain alongside kontomire stew (taro/cocoyam leaves cooked with palm oil, smoked fish, and crayfish). The mild, starchy boiled roots against the deeply savory, slightly bitter leafy stew is West Africa's equivalent of eggs and toast — the carbohydrate and the sauce combining into something greater than their parts. Eaten throughout the day but particularly beloved as a breakfast in Ghanaian villages and households.

INGREDIENTS

AMPESI

- 500g (18 oz) white yam, peeled and cut into chunks
- 2 ripe plantains, peeled and cut into large pieces
- 1 tsp salt
- Water to cover

KONTOMIRE STEW

- 400g (14 oz) kontomire leaves (taro/cocoyam leaves —
- or substitute: Swiss chard or spinach)
- 3 tbsp palm oil
- 200g (7 oz) smoked fish (herring or mackerel), flaked
- 2 tbsp ground crayfish
- 1 medium onion, roughly chopped
- 2 fresh Scotch bonnet chillies
- 1 stock cube
- Salt to taste
- 2 hard-boiled eggs to serve alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. AMPESI: Combine yam, plantain, and salt in a pot. Cover with water. Bring to a boil. Simmer 20–25 minutes until both are very tender — a fork should slide through without resistance. Drain. Keep warm.
2. KONTOMIRE STEW: Wash kontomire leaves thoroughly. Blanch in boiling water 5 minutes. Drain. Squeeze dry. Chop finely.
3. Blend onion and Scotch bonnet into a rough paste.
4. Heat palm oil in a pan over medium heat until melted and slightly darkened — Nigerian and Ghanaian cooking often uses heated palm oil to mellow its raw flavor.
5. Add blended onion-chilli paste. Fry 5 minutes.
6. Add ground crayfish. Stir briefly.
7. Add chopped kontomire leaves. Stir to coat in oil.
8. Add smoked fish, stock cube, and 100ml water.
9. Cook 10 minutes, stirring, until stew comes together.
10. Season with salt. Taste — rich, smoky, slightly bitter from leaves, and deeply savory.
11. SERVE: Place boiled yam and plantain on a plate. Spoon kontomire stew generously alongside. Add hard-boiled egg.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Palm oil must be used here — no substitute creates the same orange color, slightly fruity-smoky flavor, and depth that palm oil contributes to Ghanaian kontomire stew. The combination of palm oil + smoked fish + crayfish creates an umami trifecta that is the backbone of Ghanaian cooking. Use red palm oil (not the refined, colorless version).

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Ghanaian] [Akan Heritage]

RECIPE 499

■■ Ghana

NKATIE CAKE

GHANAIAN PEANUT BRITTLE

Ghana's most ubiquitous street snack and morning sweet — nkatie cake is a simple peanut brittle made from roasted groundnuts (nkatie in Twi) bound in caramelized sugar and pressed into rectangular slabs or rounds that are sold wrapped in clear plastic at every roadside, bus station, and school gate. More rustic than Western peanut brittle, nkatie cake has a deeper, more complex caramel flavor and a chewy-crunchy texture that sets it apart from any other peanut sweet. Ghana's most essential snack.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups raw shelled groundnuts (peanuts)
- 1 cup sugar
- 3 tbsp water
- Pinch of salt
- Optional: 1 tsp fresh ginger, very finely grated —
- the ginger version is beloved across Ghana

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ROAST PEANUTS: Spread raw peanuts on a baking tray. Roast at 170°C (340°F) for 15–18 minutes until golden and fragrant. Cool 5 minutes. Rub between hands to remove as many skins as possible — not essential but creates cleaner, crunchier brittle.
2. Grease a baking tray or a smooth surface generously.
3. Combine sugar and water in a heavy saucepan.
4. Cook over medium heat without stirring until the sugar dissolves and begins to caramelize.
5. Continue cooking until the caramel reaches a deep amber color — watch carefully. It goes from correct to burned in seconds.
6. Add ginger if using. Stir briefly.
7. Add roasted peanuts and salt all at once. Stir quickly to coat every peanut in caramel.
8. Pour immediately onto greased surface.
9. Press flat quickly with a greased spatula or greased surface to 1.5cm thickness.
10. Score into rectangles or squares immediately — before it hardens completely.
11. Cool completely. Break along score lines.
12. Store in an airtight container. Keeps 2 weeks.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~195 per piece

TIP

The caramel must reach deep amber before adding peanuts — pale caramel creates a sweet but flavor-thin brittle. Dark amber caramel creates the complex, slightly bitter, deeply caramelized flavor that makes nkatie cake irresistible. From amber to burned takes about 30 seconds — watch the color, not the clock.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Ghanaian] [Street Snack] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 500

■ ■ Ghana

TOM BROWN

GHANAIAN ROASTED CORN PORRIDGE

Recipe 500 of the Global Breakfast Bible — Ghana's Tom Brown, a dark, deeply flavored porridge made from corn that has been roasted until nearly black before grinding. The roasting transforms the corn's sweetness into complex, slightly bitter, deeply nutty flavors reminiscent of dark roasted coffee. Eaten with evaporated milk, sugar, and a cold glass of water, Tom Brown is the Ghanaian working breakfast — quick, sustaining, and carrying in every bowl the deep flavors of fire and grain that define West African cooking.

INGREDIENTS

- TOM BROWN FLOUR (make in large batches and store):
- 3 cups dried corn (maize)
- ½ cup roasted groundnuts (optional)
- ½ cup sorghum (optional — adds depth)

PORRIDGE

- 3 tbsp Tom Brown flour (or more — adjust to taste)
- 300ml (1¼ cups) cold water
- Pinch of salt

TO SERVE

- Evaporated milk or condensed milk — generously
- Sugar to taste
- A glass of cold water alongside (Ghanaian tradition —
- drinking cold water between spoonfuls of hot porridge)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ROASTING (make Tom Brown flour in advance): Spread dry corn in a heavy pan over medium heat. Roast, stirring constantly, 20–30 minutes until the kernels turn dark brown — almost black. This is the correct color. The deeper the roast, the more complex the Tom Brown. Cool completely.
2. Grind roasted corn (with groundnuts and sorghum if using) in a blender to a fine-medium powder. Store in an airtight jar. Keeps 3 months.
3. COOKING: Mix Tom Brown flour with cold water. Stir until smooth — no lumps.
4. Pour into a saucepan. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until thick and smooth — 5–7 minutes.
5. Add salt.
6. Pour into bowls.
7. Add evaporated milk — it creates a beautiful swirl against the dark brown porridge.
8. Add sugar to taste.
9. Serve with a glass of cold water.

Prep: 5 min (flour pre-made) · Cook: 7 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~265 per bowl (with evaporated milk)

TIP

The deep, dark roasting of the corn is the entire character of Tom Brown — it should be roasted until it looks almost burned. This extreme roasting creates the complex, slightly bitter, deeply nutty flavor that makes Tom Brown uniquely satisfying and entirely different from any other corn porridge. Trust the darkness — it is the point.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Ghanaian] [High Energy] [Recipe 500 Milestone]

Kenya

RECIPE 501

■ ■ Kenya (Swahili Coast)

MANDAZI

KENYAN COCONUT FRIED DOUGHNUTS

East Africa's most beloved morning bread — mandazi, a lightly sweet, coconut-scented fried dough that is the Swahili Coast's answer to the doughnut. Triangular, square, or round, with a soft, pillowy interior and a thin, barely-there crust, mandazi are eaten with chai at every Kenyan, Tanzanian, and Ugandan breakfast. The cardamom and coconut milk in the dough give them a fragrance that is distinctly Indian Ocean — the taste of the trade winds that shaped East African culture for a thousand years.

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp ground cardamom (essential)
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp salt
- 200ml (¾ cup) coconut milk (full fat)
- 100ml (¼ cup) warm water
- 1 large egg
- 2 tbsp neutral oil
- Oil for deep frying
- Powdered sugar for dusting (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, cardamom, cinnamon, and salt in a large bowl.
2. Add coconut milk, warm water, egg, and oil.
3. Mix into a smooth, soft dough. Knead 8 minutes until elastic and slightly tacky.
4. Prove covered 1–1.5 hours until doubled.
5. Punch down. Divide into 4 portions.
6. On a lightly floured surface, roll each portion to 1cm thickness.
7. Cut into triangles (most traditional), squares, or rounds using a knife or cutter.
8. Arrange on a floured tray. Rest 15 minutes.
9. Heat oil to 170°C (340°F).
10. Fry in batches, 3–4 minutes per side, until golden brown and puffed.
11. Drain on paper towels.
12. Dust with powdered sugar if desired.
13. Serve warm with Kenyan chai (Recipe 502).

Prep: 15 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~285 per serving (3 pieces)

TIP

Cardamom is the defining flavor of mandazi — not a background note but a genuine presence. Use freshly ground cardamom from whole pods for the most aromatic result. The coconut milk also creates a slightly richer, more tender interior than water-based mandazi — do not substitute with regular milk.

[Vegan] [Classic Kenyan] [Swahili Heritage] [Street Food]

RECIPE 502

■ ■ Kenya

KENYAN CHAI

SPICED MILK TEA

Kenya's national drink — chai that is not Indian masala chai or British builder's tea but something entirely its own. Kenyan chai begins with milk and water boiled together before tea is added, creating a thick, creamy base. The tea simmers in the milk until the liquid turns a deep reddish-brown. Sweetened generously and flavored with ginger and cardamom, Kenyan chai is more milk than tea, more comfort than caffeine — the beverage that begins and punctuates every Kenyan day.

INGREDIENTS

- 400ml (1½ cups) full cream milk
- 200ml (¾ cup) water
- 3 tbsp loose-leaf black tea (Kenyan CTC tea — particularly Kericho gold or any strong CTC black tea.
- Kenya is one of the world's finest tea producers.)
- 3 tsp sugar (or to taste — Kenyan chai is sweet)
- 2cm fresh ginger, grated or crushed
- 2 cardamom pods, lightly crushed
- Optional: ¼ tsp ground cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine milk and water in a saucepan.
2. Add ginger and crushed cardamom.
3. Bring to a full boil over medium-high heat — watch carefully, milk boils over suddenly.
4. Add tea leaves immediately.
5. Reduce heat to medium-low. Simmer 3–4 minutes. The tea will steep vigorously in the hot milk-water, creating the characteristic deep amber color.
6. Add sugar. Stir to dissolve.
7. Continue simmering 2 more minutes.
8. Strain through a fine sieve into cups.
9. The chai should be deep reddish-brown, creamy, sweet, and fragrant with ginger.
10. Serve piping hot with mandazi.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~155 per cup

TIP

The milk-before-tea method creates Kenyan chai's characteristic creamier, less astringent character — the fat in the milk coats the tea's tannins before they extract, creating a smoother, rounder brew. Adding tea to already-boiling milk rather than steeping in water first makes a fundamentally different and more distinctly Kenyan cup.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Kenyan] [National Drink]

RECIPE 503

■ ■ Kenya

UJI**KENYAN FERMENTED PORRIDGE**

Kenya's most nourishing and widespread breakfast porridge — uji, a thin, slightly sour fermented porridge made from millet, sorghum, or maize flour that has been soaked for several days until tangy. Drunk from a cup or eaten with a spoon, uji is the first food given to weaned infants and the last comfort food of old age. Sweetened with sugar and occasionally enriched with milk, it is simultaneously the simplest and most democratic Kenyan breakfast — eaten across all communities, all income levels, all ages.

INGREDIENTS

- UJI FLOUR MIX (traditional multi-grain):
- 2 cups millet flour
- 1 cup sorghum flour
- 1 cup maize flour (or use all millet for simpler version)
- Mix together and store

FERMENTED UJI PASTE

- 1 cup uji flour mix
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water
- Ferment 2–3 days at room temperature, covered loosely

TO COOK

- Fermented paste + 400ml (1■ cups) additional water

TO SERVE

- Sugar to taste
- Full cream milk or evaporated milk
- Optional: lemon or orange zest (Kenyan addition)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. **FERMENTATION:** Mix uji flour mix with warm water. Cover with a cloth. Leave at room temperature 2–3 days until pleasantly sour and slightly bubbly.
2. **COOKING:** Mix fermented paste with additional water to a smooth, thin consistency.
3. Pour into a saucepan. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until it begins to thicken.
4. Continue stirring 5–7 minutes until smooth, slightly thickened, and steaming hot.
5. Uji should be thinner than Western porridge — it should pour from a ladle easily.
6. Sweeten with sugar. Stir.
7. Pour into cups or bowls.
8. Add milk if desired.
9. Drink or eat immediately.

Prep: 5 min + 2–3 days fermentation · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~185 per bowl (with milk)

TIP

The multi-grain blend of millet, sorghum, and maize creates a more complex, nutritionally complete uji than single-grain versions. Each grain contributes different nutrients and a different note to the flavor — millet is nutty, sorghum is slightly bitter, maize is sweet. Together they create a porridge of extraordinary nutritional density.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Kenyan] [Fermented] [Nourishing]

RECIPE 504

■ ■ Kenya

CHAPATI WITH EGG**KENYAN LAYERED FLATBREAD WITH EGG**

Kenya's beloved layered flatbread — brought by Indian traders in the 19th century and completely adopted as Kenyan, the chapati here is softer, slightly richer, and more layered than its Indian ancestor. Kenyan chapati is always made with oil in the dough and folded to create visible layers — eaten for breakfast with fried egg, avocado, and chai. The Kenyan chapati is the gateway food that connects the country's Indian heritage with its African present.

INGREDIENTS

KENYAN CHAPATI DOUGH

- 3 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 2 tbsp neutral oil (in the dough)
- 200ml (¾ cup) warm water (approximately)

FOR LAYERING

- 4 tbsp neutral oil (for brushing between layers)

FOR SERVING

- 4 large eggs, fried
- 1 ripe avocado, sliced and seasoned with salt and lemon
- Fresh tomato and onion salad
- Kenyan chai (Recipe 502)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour, salt, and sugar. Add oil and water. Knead 8 minutes into a very smooth, pliable dough — softer than Indian roti dough. Cover. Rest 20 minutes.
2. Divide into 8 balls.
3. Roll one ball into a thin circle (20cm).
4. Brush surface with oil generously.
5. Roll up into a thin cylinder from one edge.
6. Coil the cylinder into a snail shape. Press flat.
7. Rest 5 minutes.
8. Roll the snail flat again — this creates the layers.
9. Heat a flat pan over medium heat. No oil.
10. Cook chapati 2 minutes per side until golden spots appear and the surface blisters slightly.
11. Brush with oil while cooking, pressing with a cloth — the heat + oil creates the layers.
12. Keep warm wrapped in a cloth.
13. Fry eggs in a separate pan.
14. SERVE: Chapati alongside fried egg, sliced avocado, tomato-onion salad, and hot chai.

Prep: 20 min + 20 min resting · Cook: 5 min per chapati · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

The coiling technique (snail shape before final rolling) is what creates Kenyan chapati's characteristic visible layers and slightly flaky texture. Without this step, the chapati is a plain flatbread. With it, each bite separates into distinct, oily layers that are the pleasure of a properly made Kenyan chapati.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Kenyan] [Indian Heritage] [Layered Flatbread]

RECIPE 505

■ ■ Kenya (Kikuyu)

GITHERI

KENYAN MAIZE AND BEAN STEW

The Kikuyu people's most fundamental dish — dried maize and beans cooked together until both are tender and unified in a thick, satisfying stew. Githeri is Kenya's most complete protein-and-carb meal, eaten for breakfast, lunch, and dinner without apology. When dressed with onion, tomatoes, and a spoonful of butter or ghee, plain githeri becomes something genuinely extraordinary. Githeri is the breakfast that has sustained Kenyan farmers through centuries of highland mornings.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup dried maize (corn kernels — dry, not fresh)
- 1 cup dried kidney beans or pinto beans
- Both soaked overnight in cold water
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 3 medium tomatoes, diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin
- ½ tsp turmeric
- 2 tbsp vegetable oil or butter
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander (cilantro) to garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked maize and beans. Rinse.
2. **PRESSURE COOK:** Combine in pressure cooker with water to cover by 5cm. Cook 30–40 minutes until both are completely tender. **CONVENTIONAL:** Boil 2–3 hours until tender.
3. Drain, keeping cooking liquid.
4. Heat oil in a pan over medium heat.
5. Fry onion 7 minutes until golden.
6. Add garlic, cumin, and turmeric. Cook 1 minute.
7. Add tomatoes. Cook 6 minutes until broken down.
8. Add cooked maize and beans.
9. Add enough cooking liquid to create a stew — not too wet, not too dry.
10. Simmer 10 minutes for flavors to meld.
11. Season with salt. Taste.
12. Garnish with fresh coriander.
13. Serve with ugali (stiff maize porridge) or alone with Kenyan chai.

Prep: 10 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 45 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~350 per serving

TIP

Githeri improves dramatically overnight — make a large batch, refrigerate, and reheat the next morning when the maize and beans have absorbed all the tomato-onion flavors and unified into a richer, more complex stew. Githeri is one of Africa's greatest make-ahead breakfast foods.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Kenyan] [Kikuyu Heritage]

Tunisia

RECIPE 506

■■ Tunisia

LABLABI

TUNISIAN CHICKPEA SOUP

Tunisia's most dramatic and beloved breakfast soup — a bowl of warm chickpea broth poured over torn day-old bread and a raw egg, assembled tableside with harissa, cumin, olive oil, capers, preserved lemon, and tuna. Each person builds their own lablabi — the toppings are arranged and each guest adds what they want. The hot broth partially cooks the egg. Eaten at specialist lablabi shops that open only in the morning and sell out by 10am. One of the world's great breakfast experiences.

INGREDIENTS

CHICKPEA BROTH

- 2 cups dried chickpeas, soaked overnight and cooked
- until very soft — OR: 2 cans cooked chickpeas
- 1.5L (6 cups) water or light broth
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp harissa (in the broth itself)
- 4 tbsp good Tunisian olive oil (in the broth)
- Salt to taste
- LABLABI ASSEMBLY (all essential):
- Day-old bread — stale khobz or baguette, torn into
- rough 4–5cm pieces (about 2–3 pieces per bowl)
- 1 raw egg per bowl
- 1 tbsp harissa per bowl (adjust to bravery)
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 2 tbsp extra-virgin Tunisian olive oil
- 1 tbsp capers (the Tunisian touch — essential)
- 2 preserved lemon pieces, skin only, diced
- 50g (2 oz) canned tuna in oil, drained and flaked
- Hard-boiled egg, halved (optional addition)
- Fresh coriander, chopped
- Lemon juice
- Vinegar (sprinkled over)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BROTH: If using dried chickpeas, cook until very soft. Reserve broth.
2. Bring chickpea broth (with chickpeas) to a boil.
3. Add minced garlic, cumin, harissa, and olive oil.
4. Simmer 10 minutes. Taste — deeply savory, spiced, slightly sharp from harissa. Season.
5. ASSEMBLY (at the table, very quickly):
6. Place torn stale bread in the bottom of each deep bowl.
7. Ladle HOT chickpea broth with chickpeas over the bread — enough to submerge and soak the bread.
8. Immediately crack one raw egg directly into the center of the hot soup. The heat partially cooks it — leave 1–2 minutes for it to set slightly.
9. Each person adds their own toppings in this order: — Harissa (swirled in) — Ground cumin (sprinkled) — Olive oil (generous drizzle) — Capers — Preserved lemon — Tuna flakes — Fresh coriander — Lemon juice and vinegar
10. Mix everything together and eat immediately.

Prep: 15 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~440 per bowl

TIP

The tableside assembly is not presentation — it is the cooking method. The hot broth poured over raw egg and stale bread simultaneously softens the bread and partially cooks the egg. Both must be added at the last possible moment before serving. Pre-soaked bread becomes soggy mush; pre-cooked egg loses the silky, barely-set texture that makes lablabi extraordinary.

[High Protein] [Classic Tunisian] [Dawn Breakfast] [Harissa Heritage]

RECIPE 507

■■ Tunisia

BRIK À L'OEUF

TUNISIAN CRISPY PASTRY WITH EGG

Tunisia's most celebrated snack and breakfast pastry — a paper-thin malsouka (Tunisian pastry leaf) folded over a raw egg and tuna, then deep-fried until the pastry is shatteringly crispy and the egg inside is set but still runny. The challenge: eat the entire brik without breaking the yolk before it reaches your mouth. It cannot be done elegantly. It is always attempted. The brik is one of the world's great fried pastries — crispy, runny, salty, and impossible to resist.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 sheets malsouka (Tunisian brick pastry) or filo pastry (spring roll wrappers work well too — round, not square if possible)
- 4 large eggs (one per brik — must be very fresh and cold for the runny yolk to survive frying)
- 100g (3.5 oz) canned tuna in oil, drained
- 1 small onion, very finely diced
- 2 tbsp fresh flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped
- 1 tbsp capers, roughly chopped
- ½ tsp harissa
- Salt and black pepper
- Oil for deep frying
- Lemon wedges to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MIX FILLING: Combine tuna, diced onion, parsley, capers, and harissa. Season with salt and pepper.
2. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a wide, deep pan.
3. Lay one malsouka sheet flat.
4. Place 2 tbsp tuna filling in the center, slightly off-center toward one edge — leave a space for egg.
5. Create a small well in the tuna filling.
6. Very carefully break one cold egg into the well — keep the yolk intact. This is the technique.
7. Fold the pastry immediately over the filling and egg, sealing into a half-moon or triangle shape. Press the edges firmly but gently to seal. The egg must be contained with no gaps.
8. LOWER CAREFULLY into hot oil — seam side down.
9. Fry 2–3 minutes on each side until golden and shatteringly crispy.
10. The egg should be: white fully set, yolk still runny. This is the timing challenge.
11. Drain very briefly. Serve immediately with lemon.
12. Eat in one or two bites — the runny yolk is the prize.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 5 min per brik · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~310 per brik

TIP

A cold egg straight from the refrigerator gives more time before the yolk sets during frying — the cold temperature creates a brief thermal buffer. The oil must be at precisely 175°C — too hot and the pastry browns before the egg sets; too cool and the pastry absorbs oil. 2.5 minutes per side at the correct temperature creates perfect brik.

[High Protein] [Classic Tunisian] [Street Food] [Technique-Driven]

RECIPE 508

■■ Tunisia

FRICASSÉE TUNISIENNE

SMALL TUNISIAN FRIED SANDWICH

Tunis's most essential street sandwich — a small, round brioche- like bread roll fried in oil until golden and crispy, split open and stuffed with harissa, tuna, boiled potato, black olives, capers, hard-boiled egg, and preserved lemon. The fricassée is Tunisia's great unified theory of flavor — salt, acid, heat, and richness in a single small parcel. Sold from market carts from 6am, eaten standing over the seller's cart by everyone from schoolchildren to businesspeople.

INGREDIENTS

- FRICASSÉE ROLLS (petit pain):
- 300g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm milk
- 1 egg
- 40g (3 tbsp) butter, softened
- Oil for frying the rolls
- FILLING (per sandwich):
- 1 tsp harissa
- 2 tbsp canned tuna in oil, flaked
- 1 small boiled potato, sliced
- 3 black olives, pitted and halved
- 1 tsp capers
- ½ hard-boiled egg, sliced
- 2 pieces preserved lemon skin, diced small
- Drizzle of good olive oil
- Salt and black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ROLLS: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and egg. Knead 6 minutes. Add butter. Knead 4 more minutes.
2. Prove 1 hour. Divide into 8 small balls.
3. Shape into smooth, slightly flat rounds (8cm).
4. Prove 20 minutes.
5. FRYING ROLLS: Heat 2cm oil in a pan over medium heat.
6. Fry rolls 3 minutes per side until deep golden — the rolls fry rather than bake, creating a crispy exterior and soft interior.
7. Drain on paper towels. Cool slightly.
8. ASSEMBLE: Split roll open horizontally. Spread harissa inside both halves.
9. Layer potato slices.
10. Add tuna, olives, capers, egg.
11. Add preserved lemon.
12. Drizzle olive oil. Season.
13. Press closed. Eat immediately — the heat of the fried roll warms the filling.

Prep: 20 min + 1.5 hrs proofing • Cook: 25 min • Serves: 8 • Cal: ~295 per fricassée

TIP

Preserved lemon is the ingredient that makes fricassée Tunisian rather than generic tuna sandwich — its fermented, intensely citrus-salty quality cuts through all the rich elements and provides a finishing brightness impossible to achieve with fresh lemon. Use only the skin, rinse it, and dice it very fine.

[High Protein] [Classic Tunisian] [Street Sandwich] [Layered Flavors]

RECIPE 509

■ ■ Tunisia

ASSIDA ZGOUGOU

TUNISIAN PINE NUT PUDDING

Tunisia's most distinctive and extraordinary breakfast sweet — assida zgougou is a thick, dark, almost purple pudding made from the seeds of the Aleppo pine (zgougou), boiled, ground, and cooked with starch into a rich, nutty, deeply flavored porridge. Traditionally eaten on Mawlid (the Prophet's birthday), it is topped with geranium-scented custard cream (crème pâtissière) and decorated with almonds and pistachios. The zgougou seeds create a flavor unlike any other — slightly resinous, nutty, and completely unique to North African Aleppo pine groves.

INGREDIENTS

ZGOUGOU BASE

- 200g (7 oz) zgougou (Aleppo pine seeds) — available at Tunisian and some Middle Eastern stores
- Substitute: 150g pine nuts + 50g black sesame seeds
- (different flavor but interesting approximation)
- 1L (4 cups) water for boiling seeds
- 4 tbsp cornstarch dissolved in 100ml cold water
- 100g (½ cup) sugar
- Pinch of salt

CREAM TOPPING

- 400ml (1½ cups) whole milk
- 3 tbsp cornstarch
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp rose water or geranium water
- 2 tbsp thick cream

DECORATION

- Toasted almonds, sliced
- Pistachios, roughly chopped
- Silver or gold food-safe decorative beads (traditional)
- Ground cinnamon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. ZGOUGOU: Boil seeds in water 30 minutes.
2. Blend until very smooth. Strain through fine cloth — press out all liquid. Discard solids.
3. Return dark liquid to pot. Add sugar and salt.
4. Bring to simmer. Add dissolved cornstarch while stirring. Cook 8–10 minutes until thick and pudding-like.
5. Pour into serving bowls. Smooth the surface. Let cool to room temperature.
6. CREAM TOPPING: Whisk cornstarch with cold milk. Cook over medium heat, stirring constantly, until thickened to a pourable custard consistency.
7. Add sugar, rose water, and cream. Stir.
8. Cool 5 minutes then pour gently over the cooled zgougou surface — it should float as a white layer.
9. Refrigerate until set — minimum 2 hours.
10. Decorate with almonds, pistachios, and cinnamon.

Prep: 20 min + 2 hrs chilling · Cook: 40 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~285 per serving

TIP

The two-layer presentation (dark pine seed pudding beneath pale cream topping) is the visual signature of assida zgougou — the dark and light layers symbolize the contrast between night and day in Tunisian cultural symbolism. Pour the cream topping over a cooled (but not refrigerator-cold) zgougou for the cleanest separation between layers.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Tunisian] [Festive] [Unique]

Tanzania

RECIPE 510

■ ■ Tanzania (Zanzibar)

MKATE WA KUMIMINA

ZANZIBAR COCONUT RICE BREAD

Zanzibar's extraordinary rice bread — a thick, spongy, slightly sweet bread made from fermented ground rice and coconut milk, baked on a flat pan or in a clay mold. The fermentation gives it a gentle sourness, and the coconut milk creates a richness and fragrance that is purely Indian Ocean. Each slice is dense yet soft, with a slightly caramelized bottom and a moist, coconut-fragrant interior. Eaten at Zanzibar breakfast tables with honey, butter, or alongside Zanzibar-spiced coffee.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups rice flour
- 400ml (1½ cups) coconut milk (full fat)
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp ground cardamom
- 1 large egg

FOR SERVING

- Dark honey or date syrup
- Unsalted butter
- Zanzibar coffee (Recipe 511)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine rice flour, yeast, sugar, salt, and cardamom.
2. Add coconut milk and egg. Whisk until smooth.
3. Cover. Rest 1–2 hours in a warm place until slightly bubbly and the batter has risen slightly.
4. Stir gently — do not deflate entirely.
5. Grease a heavy-bottomed pan or baking tin generously.
6. Pour batter in — about 3cm deep.
7. Cook over lowest possible heat on stovetop: Cover tightly with a lid. Cook 15–20 minutes until the top is set and the bottom is golden. OR: Bake at 180°C (355°F) for 25–28 minutes.
8. Test with a skewer — should come out clean.
9. Cool 5 minutes in the pan. Invert onto a board.
10. Slice into wedges or rectangles.
11. Serve with honey and butter.

Prep: 10 min + 1–2 hrs resting · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~265 per serving

TIP

The lowest possible heat on the stovetop method creates a caramelized, golden bottom that the oven method cannot replicate. The trapped steam from the closed lid cooks the top while the direct heat caramelizes the bottom into a beautiful crust. Check at 15 minutes by lifting one edge — if dark gold and releasing cleanly, it's ready to flip.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Tanzanian] [Zanzibar Heritage] [Coconut]

RECIPE 511

■ ■ Tanzania (Zanzibar)

ZANZIBAR SPICED COFFEE

KAHAWA YA TANGAWIZI

Zanzibar's extraordinary coffee culture — strong black coffee brewed with cloves, cardamom, cinnamon, and ginger from the island's own spice farms, served in tiny cups from brass coffee urns (kahawa ya chungu) at street corners throughout Stone Town. The coffee vendor arrives at dawn, his urn strapped to his back, calling "kahawa!" — and the city's morning begins. The spice blend in Zanzibar coffee is unlike anything else on earth — the cloves particularly intense because Zanzibar produces the world's finest.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp finely ground dark-roasted coffee
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- 4 whole cloves (Zanzibar cloves — the finest available)
- 3 cardamom pods, lightly crushed
- 1 small cinnamon stick
- 1cm fresh ginger, grated
- ½ tsp black pepper, cracked (traditional addition)
- Sugar to taste — served separately
- Optional: a pinch of nutmeg

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine water with cloves, cardamom, cinnamon, ginger, and black pepper in a small pot.
2. Bring to a boil. Reduce heat.
3. Simmer 5 minutes — the spices infuse the water.
4. Add ground coffee.
5. Bring back to a near-boil — do not let it boil hard.
6. Remove from heat. Allow to settle 2 minutes.
7. Return to very gentle heat for 2 more minutes.
8. Pour through a very fine strainer or coffee filter.
9. The coffee should be very dark, aromatic, and strongly spiced — clove should be the dominant note.
10. Serve in small cups with sugar on the side. Zanzibar coffee is served very sweet by tradition.
11. Drink in small sips, letting the spice warmth develop.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~15 per cup (without sugar)

TIP

Zanzibar cloves are considered the world's finest — intensely aromatic, high in eugenol, and grown on the volcanic soil of Unguja and Pemba islands. If you can source Zanzibar cloves specifically (available online from spice importers), the difference from generic supermarket cloves is immediately and dramatically apparent.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Tanzanian] [Zanzibar Spice Heritage]

CAFÉ TOUBA

SENEGALESE SPICED COFFEE WITH PEPPER

Senegal's national drink and the beverage of the Mouride brotherhood — coffee brewed with djar (selim pepper, also called grains of Selim) and sometimes cloves, creating a coffee with a distinctly peppery, slightly earthy character unlike any other coffee tradition. Café Touba is sold from mobile carts throughout Dakar and every Senegalese city from before dawn — the street vendor's cart is the social center of the Senegalese morning. Sweetened generously, drunk quickly, and the beginning of every Senegalese day.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 tbsp coarsely ground dark-roast coffee
- 1 tbsp djar (selim pepper/grains of Selim) — cracked open or coarsely ground. Available at West African stores. This is the defining ingredient.
- Substitute: ½ tsp black pepper + ½ tsp cardamom (different but interesting)
- 3 whole cloves (optional addition)
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- Sugar — very generous (3–4 tsp per cup)
- Optional: ¼ tsp ground cinnamon

EQUIPMENT

- A traditional cloth filter or very fine mesh strainer
- Tall metal ewer or similar for pouring

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Crack or coarsely grind djar pepper.
2. Combine coffee and djar (and cloves if using) in a coffee filter or cloth strainer.
3. Bring water to a boil.
4. Pour hot water through the coffee and spice filter slowly — allow it to drip through completely.
5. The resulting coffee should be very dark and strongly spiced — the djar pepper creates a distinctive warmth and earthiness.
6. TOUBA STYLE POURING: Transfer to a tall ewer. Pour from height into cups — aerating the coffee. Repeat 2–3 times between vessels.
7. Add very generous sugar. Stir.
8. Serve in small cups or glasses.
9. Drink quickly while hot.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~20 per cup (without sugar)

TIP

*Djar (selim pepper, *Xylopia aethiopica*) is the essential spice of café Touba — without it the drink is simply strong coffee. Djar has an earthy, resinous, peppery quality with subtle eucalyptus notes that makes Senegalese coffee immediately recognizable and completely unlike any other coffee tradition. Find it at Senegalese and West African specialty stores.*

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic Senegalese] [Mouride Heritage]

Senegal

CHAKERY

SENEGALESE COUSCOUS WITH SWEET YOGURT SAUCE

Senegal's most festive breakfast sweet — steamed millet or couscous served cold with a sweet, fragrant sauce of yogurt, condensed milk, vanilla, and coconut. Eaten at Tabaski (Eid), Easter, and every Senegalese celebration morning, chakery is simultaneously a dessert and a breakfast — the sweetness is generous and unashamed. The couscous provides texture, the yogurt sauce provides creaminess and tang, and the combination is uniquely, joyfully Senegalese.

INGREDIENTS

COUSCOUS BASE

- 2 cups fine millet couscous or regular couscous
- 400ml (1½ cups) hot water
- 2 tbsp butter
- ½ tsp salt

SWEET YOGURT SAUCE

- 400g (1¾ cups) plain full-fat yogurt
- 200ml (¾ cup) sweetened condensed milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2 tbsp desiccated coconut
- Optional: 2 tbsp cream cheese for extra richness
- Raisins (a handful)
- Fresh mint leaves for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. COUSCOUS: Pour hot water over couscous. Add butter and salt. Cover. Rest 10 minutes. Fluff with a fork. Cool completely.
2. YOGURT SAUCE: Whisk yogurt with condensed milk and vanilla until smooth and creamy.
3. Add desiccated coconut and raisins. Stir.
4. ASSEMBLY: Arrange cooled couscous in a wide bowl.
5. Pour yogurt sauce generously over and around.
6. Garnish with fresh mint.
7. Refrigerate 30 minutes before serving — chakery is always served cold.
8. Serve in individual bowls at the breakfast table.

Prep: 15 min + 30 min chilling · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Chakery must be served cold — room temperature or warm chakery loses the refreshing quality that makes it so satisfying in Senegal's heat. Make it the night before for the best result — the couscous absorbs some yogurt overnight, creating a more unified, richly flavored dish by morning.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Senegalese] [Festive] [Cold Breakfast] [Sweet]

RECIPE 514

■ Senegal

NGALAKH

SENEGALÉSE PEANUT AND BAOBAB PORRIDGE

Senegal's sacred ceremonial porridge — ngalakh is a thick, nutty, slightly tart paste of ground peanuts and baobab fruit pulp cooked with water and sweetened, eaten at Easter and Korité (Eid al-Fitr) as the breakfast that bridges communities. Christians and Muslims alike share ngalakh at major celebrations — it is one of Senegal's most powerful symbols of interfaith unity. The combination of peanuts (groundnuts) and baobab creates a flavor that is entirely West African — earthy, tart, and deeply satisfying.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup natural peanut butter (unsweetened, or grind 200g roasted peanuts in food processor)
- 3 tbsp baobab fruit powder (pain de singe — the white, chalky, tart powder from baobab fruit. Available online and at African food stores.)
- 4 tbsp millet couscous, briefly dry-roasted
- 400ml (1½ cups) water
- 4 tbsp sugar (or to taste)
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- Raisins and desiccated coconut for topping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Dry-roast millet couscous in a pan until fragrant. Set aside.
2. Combine peanut butter, baobab powder, and water in a saucepan over medium heat.
3. Whisk constantly as the mixture heats — peanut butter will seize initially then smooth out.
4. Continue cooking over medium heat, stirring, until the mixture thickens to a soft, smooth porridge — 8–10 minutes.
5. Add sugar, vanilla, and salt. Stir.
6. Add toasted millet couscous. Stir through.
7. The finished ngalakh should be thick and smooth — like a very thick porridge or soft paste. It will firm as it cools.
8. Pour into a serving bowl.
9. Garnish with raisins and desiccated coconut.
10. Serve warm or at room temperature.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving

TIP

Baobab fruit powder has a natural tartness from its high vitamin C content — similar to tamarind but with a lighter, more citrus quality. This tartness is what balances the richness of the peanut butter and prevents ngalakh from being cloying. Do not omit or substitute it — the baobab-peanut combination is the entire character of this dish.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Senegalese] [Ceremonial]

RECIPE 515

■ ■ Cameroon

ACCRA BANANA

CAMEROONIAN FRIED BANANA CAKES

Cameroon's beloved Anglophone breakfast — overripe plantain or very ripe banana mashed with flour, a pinch of spice, and fried in palm oil into golden, soft fritters. Less sweet than Nigerian puff puff, more banana-forward than Ghanaian tatale, accra banana is the specifically Cameroonian morning fritter — eaten with groundnut soup or on its own with sweet tea. The palm oil creates a specific golden color and slightly fruity richness that vegetable oil cannot replicate.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 very ripe plantains (deeply spotted, almost black)
- OR 6 very ripe bananas
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- ¼ tsp ground ginger
- 2 tbsp sugar
- Pinch of salt
- Palm oil for frying (or vegetable oil)
- Powdered sugar for dusting (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Peel and mash plantains/bananas until very smooth. The riper the fruit, the sweeter and more aromatic.
2. Add flour, baking powder, cinnamon, nutmeg, ginger, sugar, and salt. Mix until a soft, sticky batter forms.
3. The batter should hold its shape when scooped but not be stiff.
4. Heat palm oil in a pan to medium heat.
5. Drop heaped tablespoons of batter into the oil.
6. Fry 3–4 minutes per side until deep golden — the palm oil creates a characteristic orange-gold color.
7. Drain briefly.
8. Dust with powdered sugar if desired.
9. Serve warm with tea or alongside groundnut soup.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~270 per serving

TIP

The sweetness of accra banana depends entirely on the ripeness of the fruit — a just-yellow banana creates a starchy, barely sweet fritter. A deeply spotted, almost black banana creates a caramel-sweet, intensely fragrant fritter of a completely different quality. Buy extra ripe or allow to ripen fully at home for 3–5 days.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Cameroonian] [Anglophone Heritage] [Sweet]

RECIPE 516

■ ■ Cameroon (North / Sahel)

BOUILLIE DE MIL

CAMEROONIAN MILLET MILK PORRIDGE

Northern Cameroon's essential morning food — finely ground millet cooked in water until smooth, then enriched with milk, sweetened with sugar or honey, and sometimes spiced with ginger. Bouillie de mil (millet porridge) sustains the farmers and pastoralists of the Sahel region through long mornings of physical work. Made in large quantities and shared — the communal pot at the center of the Fulani family morning.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup fine millet flour
- 600ml (2½ cups) water
- 400ml (1■ cups) full cream milk
- (or coconut milk for a richer version)
- 3 tbsp sugar (or honey)
- 1 tsp ground ginger
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- Pinch of salt
- Optional: evaporated milk for serving

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Mix millet flour with 200ml of the cold water until smooth — no lumps. This cold mixing prevents lumps when the hot liquid is added.
2. Bring remaining water to a boil in a saucepan.
3. Pour millet-water mixture into the boiling water while stirring vigorously.
4. Reduce heat to medium-low. Cook, stirring constantly, 5–6 minutes until thick and smooth.
5. Add milk gradually while stirring — the porridge will loosen and become creamy.
6. Add sugar, ginger, cinnamon, and salt.
7. Cook 3–4 more minutes until smoothly combined.
8. The finished bouillie should be smooth and pourable — thinner than Western porridge.
9. Pour into bowls. Add evaporated milk if desired.
10. Drink from the bowl or eat with a spoon.

Prep: 3 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~245 per bowl

TIP

The cold-mixing of millet flour with water before adding to boiling liquid is the technique that prevents lumps — the cold water hydrates the starch grains individually before heat causes them to swell. Add hot water to dry millet flour and lumps form instantly and cannot be removed by stirring.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Cameroonian] [Sahelian Heritage] [Nourishing]

Cameroon

RECIPE 517

■■ Cameroon

BEIGNETS DE HARICOTS

CAMEROONIAN FRIED BEAN CAKES

Cameroon's French-influenced West African fritter — black-eyed pea or black bean beignets, similar to Nigerian akara and Ghanaian koose but with specifically Cameroonian additions: more onion, a touch of garlic, and sometimes ground egusi (melon seeds) for extra protein. Sold from roadside frying stations throughout Yaoundé and Douala before dawn, eaten with baguette, fried plantain, and very sweet Nescafé with evaporated milk — the francophone West African breakfast combination.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups black-eyed peas, soaked overnight and peeled
- 1 large onion, roughly chopped
- 3 garlic cloves
- 2 Scotch bonnet chillies (adjust to heat)
- 2 tbsp ground egusi seeds (melon seeds — optional
- but adds protein and nutty depth)
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 stock cube (Maggi — very Cameroonian)
- Oil for deep frying

CAMEROONIAN BREAKFAST ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Fresh baguette (Cameroonian baguette — slightly softer than French, more enriched)
- Fried plantain (ripe, sweet)
- Nescafé with evaporated milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked, peeled black-eyed peas.
2. Blend with onion, garlic, and chillies using minimal water — thick paste.
3. Add ground egusi if using. Add salt and Maggi cube.
4. Beat vigorously with a spoon 5 minutes until pale and aerated — the beating is essential.
5. Float test: drop a bit in water. It should float.
6. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F).
7. Scoop rounded portions into the hot oil.
8. Fry 4–5 minutes until deep golden.
9. Drain. Serve hot.
10. Eat with fresh baguette, fried plantain, and a cup of sweet milky Nescafé.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~295 per serving

TIP

Ground egusi (melon seeds) in the batter creates a more nutritionally complete fritter and adds a subtle, slightly bitter nuttiness that West Africans recognize immediately. Find dried egusi seeds at West African stores — grind them to a powder in a blender. They keep for months and are used across Central and West African cooking.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Cameroonian] [Street Food]

RECIPE 518

■ ■ Cameroon (Southern / Forest Region)

BOBOLO WITH GROUNDNUT SOUP

FERMENTED CASSAVA WITH PEANUT STEW

Cameroon's forest region breakfast — bobolo (fermented cassava sticks, wrapped and steamed in leaves until dense and slightly sour) eaten alongside a rich groundnut (peanut) and smoked fish soup. Bobolo is eaten instead of bread in southern Cameroon — mild, slightly fermented, with a dense texture that holds up to being dipped in the thick, savory groundnut soup. Together they represent the forest region's distinctive flavor culture.

INGREDIENTS

- BOBOLO (fermented cassava — make 2–3 days ahead):
- 1kg (2.2 lbs) fresh cassava, peeled and grated
- 1 tsp salt
- Banana leaves for wrapping
- SIMPLE SHORTCUT: Use pre-made bobolo or cassava fufu

GROUNDNUT SOUP

- 1 cup natural peanut butter (groundnut paste)
- 300ml (1¼ cups) water or light broth
- 200g (7 oz) smoked fish or dried fish, flaked
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 Scotch bonnet chilli
- 2 tbsp palm oil
- 1 stock cube
- Salt to taste
- Fresh coriander or parsley

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BOBOLO: Grate cassava finely. Mix with salt. Pack tightly into banana leaf cylinders (25cm long). Secure with toothpicks or twine. Ferment 2–3 days at room temperature. Steam fermented parcels 40 minutes until firm and fragrant. Cool. The bobolo should be dense and slightly sour.
2. GROUNDNUT SOUP: Heat palm oil. Fry onion 6 min. Add garlic and chilli. Cook 2 minutes.
3. Add peanut butter. Stir — it will seize then loosen.
4. Add water/broth gradually, stirring, until a smooth, thick soup forms.
5. Add smoked fish and stock cube.
6. Simmer 15 minutes. Season. Add coriander.
7. SERVE: Slice bobolo into rounds. Place in bowls. Ladle groundnut soup alongside or over the bobolo.
8. Eat by breaking pieces of bobolo and dipping into the groundnut soup.

Prep: 20 min + 2–3 days fermentation · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

The fermentation of bobolo creates the characteristic slight sourness that contrasts with the rich peanut soup — without fermentation, fresh cassava is bland and neutral. The sour-rich combination is specifically the point. If making bobolo for the first time, the smell of the fermenting cassava is pungent but transforms into something pleasant after steaming.

[Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Classic Cameroonian] [Forest Heritage]

THE AMERICAS

Recipes #519—#556 · 38 recipes

United States

RECIPE 519

United States

CLASSIC AMERICAN BUTTERMILK

The American breakfast icon — thick, fluffy, golden buttermilk pancakes stacked high on a plate with a cold knob of butter slowly melting down the sides and a generous pour of pure maple syrup. The buttermilk reacts with baking soda to create the bubbles that make American pancakes unmistakably thick and cloud-like. No other pancake tradition in the world produces the same height-to-fluffiness ratio. This is American breakfast at its most purely, joyfully American.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp salt
- 2 cups buttermilk (cold)
- 2 large eggs
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter, melted and slightly cooled
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FOR SERVING

- Cold unsalted butter (a generous knob per stack)
- Pure maple syrup (Grade A dark amber — the flavor matters enormously; avoid pancake syrup imposters)
- Fresh blueberries or sliced banana (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk flour, sugar, baking powder, baking soda, and salt together in a large bowl.
2. In a separate bowl, whisk buttermilk, eggs, melted butter, and vanilla until combined.
3. Pour wet ingredients over dry. Fold GENTLY with a spatula — just until no dry flour remains. THE BATTER MUST BE LUMPY. This is non-negotiable. A smooth batter produces flat, tough pancakes. Lumps = steam = fluffy pancakes.
4. Rest batter 3–5 minutes — the baking soda reacts with buttermilk, creating bubbles.
5. Heat a griddle or wide non-stick pan over medium heat. Brush lightly with butter.
6. Pour ½ cup batter per pancake — do not spread.
7. Cook until bubbles form across the entire surface AND the edges look set and dry — 2–3 minutes.
8. Flip ONCE. Cook 1.5–2 minutes until the second side is golden.
9. Keep warm in a low oven (90°C/195°F) on a rack while cooking remaining pancakes.
10. Stack 3 per person. Place butter on top. Pour maple syrup generously.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4

TIP

The lumpy batter rule is the single most important instruction in American pancake making. Every lump of flour in the batter contains pockets of dry starch that, when heated, create steam — it is this steam that produces the characteristic fluffy, tall interior. Stir until just combined and then stop, regardless of how many lumps remain.

[Vegetarian] [Classic American] [Weekend Breakfast] [Diner Icon]

RECIPE 520

United States (New York)

EGGS BENEDICT

The crown jewel of American brunch — a toasted English muffin topped with Canadian bacon, a perfectly poached egg, and blanketed in hollandaise sauce. Created at Delmonico's restaurant in New York in the 1890s. The hollandaise is the achievement: a warm, butter- rich, lemon-bright emulsion that is simultaneously the most elegant and most technically demanding of classic sauces. When everything works — runny yolk, crispy English muffin, silky hollandaise — eggs Benedict is one of the great breakfast experiences on earth.

INGREDIENTS

HOLLANDAISE SAUCE

- 3 large egg yolks
- 1 tbsp cold water
- 1 tbsp white wine vinegar
- 180g (¾ cup + 2 tbsp) unsalted butter, clarified
- (melt and skim the foam — use only the clear yellow fat)
- Juice of ½ lemon
- Pinch of cayenne
- Salt and white pepper

ASSEMBLY

- 4 English muffins, split and toasted
- 8 slices Canadian bacon (back bacon), warmed
- 8 large eggs, poached (3 min each)
- 1 tsp white wine vinegar (for poaching water)
- Fresh chives, snipped
- Paprika for dusting

INSTRUCTIONS

1. HOLLANDAISE: Whisk egg yolks, cold water, and vinegar in a heatproof bowl over a bain-marie (barely simmering water, bowl not touching water).
2. Whisk constantly until the mixture is pale, thick, and has tripled in volume — the whisk should leave a trail. About 4–5 minutes. Remove from heat.
3. Very slowly drizzle in warm clarified butter while whisking constantly. Add a few drops at first, then a thin, steady stream. The sauce will thicken.
4. Season with lemon juice, cayenne, salt, and white pepper. Taste — rich, buttery, bright, warm.
5. Keep warm over the bain-marie (low heat) while poaching eggs.
6. POACH EGGS: Bring a wide pan of water to a bare simmer with vinegar added. Swirl gently. Crack one egg into a small cup. Slide into water. Poach 3 minutes. Remove with slotted spoon. Drain on paper towels briefly.
7. ASSEMBLE: Toasted English muffin half → Canadian bacon → poached egg → generous hollandaise → chives → dusting of paprika.
8. Serve immediately — hollandaise will not wait.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~620 per serving (2 halves)

TIP

Hollandaise breaks when the butter is added too quickly or when the mixture gets too hot. Both are recoverable: for broken sauce, start with 1 egg yolk in a clean bowl over the bain-marie and slowly whisk the broken sauce into it. For overheated sauce, immediately remove from heat and whisk in 1 tbsp ice-cold water. Prevention: slow butter, low heat, constant whisking.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Brunch Icon] [New York Heritage]

RECIPE 521

■ ■ United States (American South)

SOUTHERN BISCUITS AND GRAVY

The American South's most satisfying breakfast — tall, flaky, buttermilk biscuits split open and smothered in white sausage gravy made from crumbled pork sausage, flour, and whole milk. The gravy is seasoned aggressively with black pepper — more than seems reasonable — and poured over the biscuits until they disappear beneath it. This is not refined food. It is comfort food executed perfectly, and in the American South it is considered a birthright.

INGREDIENTS

SOUTHERN BISCUITS

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 tsp sugar
- 6 tbsp unsalted butter, FROZEN and grated
- ¾ cup cold buttermilk

SAUSAGE GRAVY

- 400g (14 oz) bulk pork breakfast sausage
- (seasoned with sage and black pepper — Jimmy Dean or equivalent style)
- 4 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 2½ cups whole milk, warm
- 1 tsp black pepper (GENEROUS — this is the point)
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- Salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BISCUITS: Preheat oven to 230°C (445°F).
2. Combine flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, sugar.
3. Add FROZEN grated butter. Toss to coat each butter strand in flour — do not press.
4. Add cold buttermilk. Fold GENTLY until just combined. Handle as little as possible — overworking = flat biscuits.
5. Turn onto floured surface. Fold dough over itself 3 times (like folding a letter). This creates layers.
6. Press (do NOT roll) to 2.5cm thickness.
7. Cut with a sharp, round cutter — press straight down, do NOT twist. Twisting seals the layers.
8. Bake on lined sheet 12–14 minutes until golden.
9. SAUSAGE GRAVY: Cook sausage in a large pan over medium-high heat, breaking up constantly, until browned and cooked through. Do not drain the fat.
10. Sprinkle flour over the cooked sausage. Stir constantly 1 minute — the flour cooks in the fat.
11. Add warm milk in a steady stream while stirring.
12. Cook over medium heat, stirring, until thick and bubbling — 4–5 minutes.
13. Season very generously with black pepper and garlic powder. Taste. Add salt.
14. Split hot biscuits. Pour gravy over generously.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~680 per serving

TIP

Frozen butter grated into the biscuit dough is the professional technique for tall, flaky biscuits. The frozen butter stays in distinct strands coated in flour — when baked, these strands create steam pockets that push the layers apart. Soft butter melts into the dough before baking and creates a dense, flat biscuit. Keep everything cold.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Southern Heritage] [Comfort Food]

RECIPE 522

■ ■ United States (New York)

NEW YORK BAGEL WITH

New York's most iconic breakfast and the greatest contribution of Jewish immigrant culture to American food — a boiled and baked bagel, split and toasted, spread with cream cheese, and layered with cold-smoked salmon (lox), capers, red onion, and tomato. The New York bagel is a specific object: chewy, dense, shiny, with a distinct malt flavor from high-gluten flour. The "everything" bagel — topped with poppy seeds, sesame seeds, garlic, onion, and salt — is the pinnacle of the form. With lox and cream cheese, it is a perfect breakfast.

INGREDIENTS

- NEW YORK BAGELS (make ahead):
- 500g (4 cups) bread flour (high-gluten — essential)
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 1½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp barley malt syrup (or honey)
- 300ml (1¼ cups) warm water

BOILING WATER BATH

- 2L (8 cups) water
- 1 tbsp baking soda
- 1 tbsp barley malt syrup or honey

EVERYTHING BAGEL TOPPING

- 2 tbsp poppy seeds
- 2 tbsp sesame seeds (white and black)
- 1 tbsp dried minced garlic
- 1 tbsp dried minced onion
- 1 tsp flaky sea salt

TOPPINGS PER BAGEL

- 3 tbsp cream cheese (full fat — no substitutes)
- 60g (2 oz) cold-smoked salmon (lox)
- 1 tbsp capers
- 3 thin rings red onion
- 2 tomato slices
- Fresh dill sprigs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BAGEL DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, salt, sugar, and malt syrup. Add warm water. Knead 10 minutes until smooth and stiff — bagel dough is much firmer than bread dough.
2. Prove 1 hour until doubled.
3. Divide into 8 balls. Shape: press a hole through the center with your thumb. Stretch the ring to about 8cm diameter — it will shrink slightly.
4. Place on floured parchment. Rest 20 minutes.
5. Preheat oven to 230°C (445°F).
6. BOILING: Bring water, baking soda, and malt syrup to a full boil in a large wide pot.
7. Boil bagels in batches — 1 minute per side. This boiling creates the chewy, shiny crust.
8. Return to parchment. Top with everything seasoning.
9. Bake 18–20 minutes until deep golden and shiny.
10. ASSEMBLE: Split toasted bagel. Spread cream cheese generously. Layer lox, capers, red onion, tomato. Add fresh dill.

Prep: 25 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~480 per assembled bagel

TIP

The boiling step is what separates a real bagel from bread baked in a ring mold. Boiling gelatinizes the outer starch before baking, creating the characteristic chewy, shiny, tight crust. Skip the boiling and you have a dinner roll with a hole. The barley malt syrup in both the dough and the boiling water creates the specific malty sweetness of authentic New York bagels.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Jewish-American Heritage] [New York Icon]

RECIPE 523

■ ■ United States

FRENCH TOAST

America's most beloved weekend sweet breakfast — thick slices of bread (ideally challah or brioche) soaked in a vanilla-and- cinnamon custard of eggs and cream, then pan-fried in butter until golden and caramelized on the outside with a custardy, almost bread pudding-like interior. Dusted with powdered sugar and served with maple syrup and fresh berries. The American French toast is richer, thicker, and more custardy than its French ancestor — a genuinely American transformation of a French technique.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 thick slices challah, brioche, or Texas toast
- (2.5cm / 1-inch thick — thickness is essential)
- 3 large eggs
- ½ cup heavy cream (or whole milk)
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- Pinch of salt
- Pinch of nutmeg
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter (for cooking)

FOR SERVING

- Powdered sugar (dusted generously)
- Pure maple syrup
- Fresh strawberries and blueberries
- Whipped cream (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Whisk eggs, cream, sugar, vanilla, cinnamon, nutmeg, and salt in a wide, shallow dish.
2. SOAK: Place bread slices in the custard. Soak 2 minutes per side — the bread should absorb the custard but not become soggy and falling apart.
3. Heat 1 tbsp butter in a pan over medium heat until foaming.
4. Cook soaked bread 3 minutes per side until deep golden and slightly caramelized.
5. The exterior should be crispy and golden; the interior creamy and custardy when pressed.
6. Work in batches. Add butter between batches.
7. SERVE: Dust with powdered sugar. Add fresh berries alongside. Pour maple syrup.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving (with syrup)

TIP

The soaking time is critical — too short and the custard only penetrates the surface, leaving a dry, eggy-tasting interior; too long and the bread becomes waterlogged and falls apart in the pan. Two minutes per side with challah or brioche creates the ideal custard penetration. Thinner bread needs less time; stale bread needs slightly more.

[Vegetarian] [Classic American] [Weekend Breakfast] [Sweet]

RECIPE 524

■ ■ United States (Southwest / Texas)

BREAKFAST BURRITO

America's most portable breakfast — scrambled eggs, crispy hash browns, breakfast sausage or bacon, and melted cheese, all rolled into a large flour tortilla with salsa and sour cream. The breakfast burrito was born in New Mexico and Texas where Mexican culinary tradition merged with American ingredients. It is now eaten coast-to-coast, from gas station grills to gourmet brunch spots. The best breakfast burrito is hot, wrapped in foil, and eaten in your car — this is not a limitation but a design feature.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large flour tortillas (25cm / 10-inch — large enough
- to hold everything without exploding)
- 6 large eggs, beaten
- 200g (7 oz) breakfast sausage or bacon, cooked
- and crumbled or chopped
- 2 cups frozen hash browns or diced potato,
- pan-fried until crispy
- 1 cup shredded cheddar or Monterey Jack cheese
- 1 jalapeño, finely sliced
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp butter (for scrambling eggs)
- Salsa (store-bought is fine — choose your heat)
- Sour cream
- Hot sauce (Cholula or Tapatio — the American
- Southwestern standards)
- Optional: sliced avocado

INSTRUCTIONS

1. HASH BROWNS: Cook frozen hash browns or diced potato in oil over medium-high heat until very crispy and golden. Season. Set aside.
2. EGGS: Scramble eggs in butter over medium-low heat until just set and slightly soft. Season.
3. PROTEIN: Ensure sausage or bacon is cooked and crumbled into bite-sized pieces.
4. WARM TORTILLAS: Wrap in a damp paper towel. Microwave 30 seconds. Or heat directly over a gas flame 20 seconds per side until pliable.
5. ASSEMBLE: Lay tortilla flat. Place filling in the center-lower third: — Hash browns first (the structural base) — Scrambled eggs over — Sausage or bacon — Cheese (it will melt against the hot eggs) — Jalapeño slices
6. Add salsa and sour cream.
7. FOLD: Fold the bottom edge up over the filling. Fold both sides inward. Roll forward tightly.
8. Wrap in foil if eating on the go. Eat immediately — the cheese melts from the heat.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~620 per burrito

TIP

The hash brown layer on the bottom of the burrito is the structural engineering of the breakfast burrito — it absorbs the egg and salsa moisture that would otherwise make the tortilla soggy. The crispy hash brown maintains its texture inside the burrito longer than any other component, keeping each bite satisfying to the last.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Southwest Heritage] [Portable]

RECIPE 525

■ ■ United States (California)

AVOCADO TOAST

California's defining breakfast contribution to the modern world — perfectly ripe avocado smashed on thick-cut toasted sourdough with lemon, chili flakes, and flaky salt. What began in 1990s California café culture became a global food phenomenon. The genius is in the quality of each element: perfectly ripe avocado, excellent sourdough with real crust, good olive oil, flaky salt, and the restraint to add nothing that doesn't belong. The eggs and the feta and the everything bagel seasoning on top are the American touch that makes it also genuinely great.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices good sourdough bread, toasted dark
- 2 ripe Hass avocados (should yield slightly to gentle thumb pressure — this is the test for ripeness)
- 1 lemon, zested and halved
- Red pepper flakes (Aleppo or regular)
- Flaky sea salt (Maldon or similar)
- Good extra-virgin olive oil
- Black pepper, freshly ground
- OPTIONAL ADDITIONS (choose your version):
- 2 large eggs, poached or fried (sunnyside up)
- 50g (2 oz) feta cheese, crumbled
- Everything bagel seasoning (Recipe 522)
- Microgreens or arugula
- Cherry tomatoes, halved
- Radish, thinly sliced

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Toast sourdough slices until very dark and crispy — the crust must be able to support the avocado weight.
2. Halve avocados. Remove pit. Scoop flesh into a bowl.
3. Add a squeeze of lemon juice immediately — prevents browning.
4. Add lemon zest.
5. SMASH: Using a fork, smash until roughly creamy but with some chunks remaining. Do not over-process — textured is better than smooth.
6. Season with flaky salt and black pepper. Taste.
7. ASSEMBLE: Divide smashed avocado among toasts. Spread to the edges.
8. Drizzle olive oil over.
9. Scatter red pepper flakes and more flaky salt.
10. Add chosen toppings.
11. Eat immediately — toast softens within minutes.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~380 per serving (with egg)

TIP

The avocado must be perfectly ripe — not firm and waxy, not overripe and brown-streaked. The 72-hour rule: buy a firm avocado and leave at room temperature for 2–3 days until it yields to gentle thumb pressure. Refrigerate when ripe and use within 2 days. An underripe avocado on toast is a disappointment that no seasoning can fix.

[Vegan] [Quick] [Classic California] [Modern American] [Cultural Phenomenon]

RECIPE 526

■ ■ United States (Louisiana)

NEW ORLEANS BEIGNETS

New Orleans' sacred breakfast — pillowy square doughnuts deep-fried in vegetable oil until they puff into golden, airy clouds, then buried under a snowstorm of powdered sugar. The beignet is French in origin and was brought to Louisiana by French colonists in the 18th century, where it became the anchor of Café Du Monde's legendary all-night, all-day breakfast menu. Eaten with café au lait (half coffee, half steamed milk). The powdered sugar blizzard that coats everything within a three-foot radius is not a side effect but the entire experience.

INGREDIENTS

- 350g (2¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 3 tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- 1 large egg
- 120ml (½ cup) warm whole milk
- 80ml (⅓ cup) warm water
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- Vegetable oil for deep frying
- 2 cups powdered (icing) sugar for coating
- CAFÉ AU LAIT (the essential accompaniment):
- Equal parts very strong dark-roast coffee with
- chicory (Community Coffee or Café Du Monde brand)
- and warm, frothy whole milk

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt, and nutmeg.
2. Add egg, warm milk, warm water, and melted butter.
3. Mix into a smooth, soft dough. Knead 5 minutes.
4. Cover. Prove 1.5–2 hours until doubled.
5. Heat oil to 175°C (345°F) in a deep pot.
6. Roll proved dough to 5mm thickness on a lightly floured surface.
7. Cut into 6cm (2.5-inch) squares — beignets are always square in New Orleans. Not round. Square.
8. Fry in batches — 3–4 at a time, do not crowd.
9. Fry 1–1.5 minutes per side until golden and puffed — they puff dramatically as the yeast activates in the hot oil.
10. Drain briefly on paper towels.
11. IMMEDIATELY transfer to a plate. Sift powdered sugar over generously — more than feels reasonable. Then add more. New Orleans beignets are never under-sugared.
12. Eat immediately while hot with café au lait.

Prep: 15 min + 2 hrs proofing · Cook: 15 min · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~310 per serving (3 beignets)

TIP

The powdered sugar must be applied while the beignets are hot — the heat creates a slight melting of the sugar's surface layer that fuses it to the beignet rather than simply falling off. Cold beignets shed sugar. Hot beignets keep it. Also: wear a dark shirt. The powdered sugar cloud is beautiful and unavoidable.

[Vegetarian] [Classic American] [New Orleans Heritage] [Sweet] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 527

■ ■ United States

AMERICAN DINER BREAKFAST

THE COMPLETE PLATE

The American diner plate — the complete, unapologetic, American breakfast that fills a large oval platter with two eggs any style, bacon or sausage, hash browns or home fries, toast with butter and jam, and orange juice. Served at chrome-and-vinyl diners across America from 5am by waitresses who call you "hon" and refill your coffee before you ask. This is not one dish but a philosophy of abundance that is entirely American in its generosity and its complete disregard for restraint.

INGREDIENTS

- EGGS (cook to order):
- 4 large eggs — over easy, sunnyside up, or scrambled

BACON

- 8 strips thick-cut American bacon (streaky)
- Cook in a cold pan over medium heat — start cold,
- render slowly, crisp gradually

HASH BROWNS

- 3 large russet potatoes, peeled and grated
- ½ onion, grated
- 1 tsp salt, ½ tsp pepper
- 3 tbsp vegetable oil or bacon fat

TOAST

- 4 slices white or wheat sandwich bread, toasted
- Soft butter and strawberry jam

ORANGE JUICE

- 4 large oranges, freshly squeezed (or good OJ)
- COFFEE: Strong, American-style drip coffee with
- unlimited refills — this is non-negotiable.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. BACON: Start bacon in cold pan. Medium heat. Cook slowly 8–10 minutes, turning occasionally, until deeply colored and crispy. Drain on paper. Reserve the bacon fat.
2. HASH BROWNS: Squeeze all moisture from grated potato and onion using a clean towel — wring hard. Season. Heat oil (or bacon fat) in a pan. Press potato mixture flat into the pan. Cook 5–6 minutes without moving until a golden crust forms. Flip in sections. Cook 4 minutes more.
3. TOAST: Toast bread. Serve with butter and jam.
4. EGGS: Cook to preference: — Over Easy: crack into buttered pan, 1 min per side, yolk still runny — Scrambled: low heat, gentle folds, remove while slightly wet
5. PLATE: Warm large oval plates in oven. Arrange everything with practiced abundance — eggs centered, bacon alongside, hash browns filling one corner, toast leaning against the side.
6. Orange juice in a glass. Coffee in a mug.
7. Set everything on the table at once. Eat hot.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~790 per complete plate

TIP

The secret to diner hash browns is squeezing out maximum moisture before cooking — wet potato steams instead of frying, creating a pale, soggy result instead of the crispy, golden crust that defines great hash browns. Squeeze the grated potato in a kitchen towel until no more liquid comes out. Then squeeze again. The dryness creates the crunch.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic American] [Diner Culture] [Complete Meal]

RECIPE 528

■■ United States (Modern)

OVERNIGHT OATS

America's modern meal-prep breakfast phenomenon — rolled oats soaked overnight in milk or yogurt until they soften into a thick, creamy, no-cook porridge that is eaten cold straight from the jar. Born from the original Swiss Bircher muesli tradition but thoroughly Americanized with endless customization, protein powder, and the Mason jar aesthetic that made it a social media sensation. The overnight oats concept is genuine genius: maximum nutrition and flavour, zero morning effort.

INGREDIENTS

- BASE (per serving — scale freely):
- ½ cup rolled oats (old-fashioned — not instant)
- ½ cup milk (dairy or any plant milk — oat milk creates the creamiest result)
- ¼ cup plain Greek yogurt (adds protein and creaminess)
- 1 tbsp chia seeds (optional — adds omega-3 and thickens the texture further)
- 1 tsp honey or maple syrup
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt
- TOPPING COMBINATIONS (choose one):

CLASSIC BERRY

- Fresh strawberries + blueberries + granola + honey

PEANUT BUTTER BANANA

- Sliced banana + 1 tbsp peanut butter + dark chocolate
- chips + crushed peanuts

APPLE PIE

- Grated apple + cinnamon + brown sugar + toasted pecans + granola

CHOCOLATE CHERRY

- Dark cocoa powder in base + fresh cherries + shaved dark chocolate

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine oats, milk, yogurt, chia seeds, sweetener, vanilla, and salt in a jar or container with a lid.
2. Stir thoroughly to combine everything.
3. Seal. Refrigerate overnight — minimum 6 hours, ideally 8–12.
4. The oats will absorb the liquid and expand to nearly double in volume.
5. In the morning: open and assess consistency. If too thick, add a splash of milk and stir.
6. Add chosen toppings immediately before eating.
7. Eat cold, directly from the jar.

Prep: 5 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~390 per serving (with toppings)

TIP

Greek yogurt in the base is the element that distinguishes excellent overnight oats from adequate ones — it adds protein, creaminess, and a slight tanginess that balances the sweetness and prevents the oats from tasting flat. The chia seeds create an even thicker, more satisfying texture by absorbing additional liquid overnight.

[Vegetarian] [High Fiber] [High Protein] [Modern American] [Make-Ahead] [Quick]

RECIPE 529

■ ■ United States (American West)

DENVER OMELETTE

America's most colorful diner omelette — a three-egg omelette filled with diced ham, green bell pepper, onion, and cheese. Also called a Western omelette, it appeared in Western American diners in the early 20th century — allegedly invented by Chinese railroad cooks adapting egg foo young for American cowboy tastes. The Denver omelette is hearty, satisfying, and completely without pretension — the American working breakfast at its most reliable.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs
- 2 tbsp whole milk
- Salt and black pepper
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter

FILLING

- 60g (2 oz) diced ham (deli ham or leftover cooked ham)
- ¼ green bell pepper, finely diced
- ¼ red bell pepper, finely diced
- ¼ small onion, finely diced
- 30g (1 oz) shredded cheddar cheese
- 1 tbsp butter or oil for sautéing vegetables

INSTRUCTIONS

1. FILLING: Sauté ham, both peppers, and onion in butter over medium heat 4–5 minutes until softened and lightly caramelized. Set aside warm.
2. Beat eggs with milk, salt, and pepper until completely combined and slightly frothy.
3. Heat butter in a non-stick pan over medium heat until foaming.
4. Pour in eggs. Immediately begin moving them with a spatula, pulling the set edges toward the center and tilting the pan to let raw egg flow to the edges.
5. When the egg is almost fully set but still slightly wet on top, spread filling across one half.
6. Scatter cheese over the filling.
7. FOLD: Fold the unfilled half over the filled half.
8. Slide onto a warm plate.
9. The omelette should be pale gold outside — not browned. American diner style omelettes are never browned.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

American diner omelettes are cooked and served quickly — the slightly wet interior when folded finishes cooking from the retained heat. The pale gold color (not brown) is the visual indicator of correct cooking temperature and timing. Brown = too hot, too long. Pale gold = perfect.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic American] [Diner Classic]

RECIPE 530

■ ■ United States (Hawaii)

LOCO MOCO

Hawaii's most beloved comfort breakfast — steamed white rice topped with a beef hamburger patty, a fried egg, and brown gravy. Invented in 1949 at the Lincoln Grill in Hilo, Hawaii, by teenagers who wanted something cheap, filling, and fast. The name means "crazy" in local slang. It is genuinely and wonderfully strange — rice and hamburger and egg and gravy for breakfast — and it is perfectly, brilliantly delicious. Hawaii's gift to the American breakfast canon.

INGREDIENTS

HAMBURGER PATTIES

- 400g (14 oz) ground beef (80/20 fat ratio)
- ½ tsp salt, ½ tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- Form into 2 patties

BROWN GRAVY

- 2 cups beef broth
- 2 tbsp cornstarch dissolved in 3 tbsp cold water
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- Salt and pepper

ASSEMBLY

- 2 cups steamed short-grain white rice
- 2 large eggs, fried sunnyside up
- 2 tbsp butter (for frying eggs)
- Sliced green onions for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GRAVY: Bring beef broth, soy sauce, Worcestershire, and garlic powder to a simmer in a saucepan.
2. Add cornstarch mixture while stirring. Cook 3–4 minutes until thick and glossy. Season. Keep warm.
3. PATTIES: Mix ground beef with seasonings. Form into 2 large, slightly flattened patties.
4. Cook in a cast-iron pan over high heat — 4 minutes per side for medium. Rest 2 minutes.
5. Fry eggs in butter, sunnyside up, yolks runny.
6. ASSEMBLE: Mound rice in a wide bowl.
7. Place burger patty on rice.
8. Slide fried egg on top of patty.
9. Pour hot brown gravy liberally over everything.
10. Scatter sliced green onions.
11. Eat by mixing the runny yolk into the gravy — this is the point of the sunny-side egg.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~720 per serving

TIP

The runny egg yolk is structural in loco moco — when broken, it combines with the brown gravy to create a richer, more complex sauce. This yolk-gravy combination soaking into the white rice below is the specific pleasure of loco moco. A fully set yolk produces a drier, less satisfying result.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Hawaiian] [Comfort Food] [Unique]

RECIPE 531

■ ■ United States (California)

GRANOLA WITH FRESH FRUIT

California's clean, beautiful breakfast — homemade granola baked until golden and clustered, served over thick Greek yogurt with fresh seasonal fruit and a drizzle of honey. Granola was invented in 1863 as a health food and has been California's breakfast aesthetic since the 1970s. Homemade granola produces clusters of oats, nuts, and seeds that no commercial version replicates — the key is pressing the mixture flat before baking and not stirring.

INGREDIENTS

- **HOMEMADE GRANOLA** (make a large batch):
- 3 cups rolled oats (old-fashioned)
- 1 cup mixed nuts (almonds, pecans, walnuts)
- ½ cup pumpkin seeds or sunflower seeds
- ½ cup shredded unsweetened coconut
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- ½ tsp salt
- ■ cup maple syrup or honey
- ¼ cup coconut oil or olive oil, melted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ cup dried fruit: raisins, cranberries, or
- chopped apricots (added **AFTER** baking)

BOWL ASSEMBLY

- 150g (■ cup) thick Greek yogurt per person
- Fresh seasonal fruit: strawberries, blueberries,
- mango, peach, or whatever is perfectly ripe
- 2–3 tbsp granola
- Drizzle of dark honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 160°C (320°F). Line a large baking sheet with parchment.
2. Combine oats, nuts, seeds, coconut, cinnamon, ginger, and salt in a large bowl.
3. Add maple syrup, melted oil, and vanilla. Stir until everything is evenly coated.
4. Spread over the lined baking sheet in an even layer.
5. **PRESS DOWN FIRMLY** with a spatula — this is the cluster-creation technique. Packed granola = clusters. Loose granola = individual oats.
6. Bake 25–30 minutes **WITHOUT STIRRING**. The granola should be pale golden at 25 minutes.
7. Remove from oven. Do **NOT** stir. Cool completely on the tray — 30 minutes minimum. The granola firms into clusters as it cools.
8. Add dried fruit after cooling. Break into clusters.
9. Store in an airtight jar. Keeps 3 weeks.
10. **SERVE:** Spoon yogurt into a bowl. Add fruit. Top with granola. Drizzle honey.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 12 (batch) · Cal: ~380 per bowl (with yogurt and fruit)

TIP

The two rules of cluster granola: press flat before baking, and do not stir during baking. The pressed, undisturbed granola fuses together in the oven as the sweeteners caramelize — stirring breaks the forming clusters. Patience is rewarded with satisfying, substantial granola clusters that hold together in the yogurt.

[Vegetarian] [High Fiber] [Classic California] [Make-Ahead] [Healthy]

RECIPE 532

■ ■ United States (Modern Brunch)

SHAKSHOUKA AMERICAN STYLE

AMERICAN BRUNCH SHAKSHUKA

The Israeli shakshuka (Recipe 431) has been adopted by American brunch culture and made distinctly American — richer, more elaborate, often with feta, avocado, and sriracha added, served in cast-iron skillets at every Brooklyn brunch restaurant. This recipe honors the American interpretation: the same spiced tomato sauce and poached eggs but with distinctly American customization. The brunch crowd needs it on Instagram-ready cast iron, with avocado on the side and sourdough for mopping.

INGREDIENTS

- 5 large eggs
- 800g (28 oz) canned crushed tomatoes
- 1 large onion, diced
- 1 red bell pepper, diced
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika
- ½ tsp cayenne, ½ tsp sugar
- 1 tsp sriracha or hot sauce
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- Salt and black pepper

AMERICAN ADDITIONS

- 100g (3.5 oz) feta cheese, crumbled
- 1 avocado, sliced (served alongside)
- Fresh cilantro (not parsley — the American choice)
- Everything bagel seasoning sprinkled over
- Thick-cut sourdough toast for mopping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat olive oil in a 10-inch (25cm) cast-iron skillet.
2. Sauté onion and pepper 8 minutes.
3. Add garlic, cumin, smoked paprika, cayenne. 1 min.
4. Add tomatoes, sugar, and sriracha. Stir.
5. Simmer uncovered 12–15 minutes until thick. Season generously.
6. Create 5 wells. Crack eggs in. Season eggs.
7. Scatter feta over the sauce (not on eggs).
8. Cover. Cook 5–6 minutes until whites set.
9. Remove from heat. Scatter fresh cilantro.
10. Bring skillet directly to table.
11. Serve with sliced avocado and thick sourdough toast.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

The cast-iron skillet is not just aesthetic — it retains heat longer than other pans, continuing to cook the eggs after removal from the stove. This means removing the skillet from heat when the whites are just set and the yolks still completely liquid — they finish cooking in the 3–4 minutes it takes to bring the skillet to the table.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [High Protein] [Modern American] [Brunch Icon]

RECIPE 533

■ ■ United States (Southern / Harlem)

WAFFLES WITH FRIED CHICKEN

America's most audacious breakfast combination — crispy fried chicken thighs served atop Belgian-style waffles, drizzled with butter and maple syrup and hot sauce simultaneously. Sweet and savory, crispy and soft, hot and sticky — chicken and waffles defies logic and achieves perfection. It originated in Harlem jazz clubs in the 1930s where musicians arriving after midnight shows wanted both dinner and breakfast. The combination spread across America as one of its most beloved and unapologetically indulgent morning meals.

INGREDIENTS

BUTTERMILK WAFFLES

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 large eggs, separated
- 2 cups buttermilk
- 6 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

FRIED CHICKEN

- 4 bone-in chicken thighs
- 2 cups buttermilk + 1 tbsp hot sauce (for brine — marinate 4 hours or overnight)
- 1½ cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp onion powder
- 1 tsp paprika, 1 tsp cayenne
- 1 tsp salt, 1 tsp black pepper
- Oil for frying (4cm / 1.5 inches depth)

FOR SERVING

- Maple syrup (warm)
- Hot sauce (Crystal or Tabasco)
- Softened butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CHICKEN: Marinate in buttermilk-hot sauce 4+ hours.
2. Combine flour, garlic powder, onion powder, paprika, cayenne, salt, and pepper in a bag.
3. Remove chicken from brine. Dredge in seasoned flour — press firmly to adhere. Shake off excess.
4. Fry in 170°C (340°F) oil 7–8 minutes per side until deep golden and internal temperature reaches 74°C.
5. Drain on a rack. Rest 3 minutes.
6. WAFFLES: Whisk flour, baking powder, baking soda, sugar, and salt. Separate eggs.
7. Whisk yolks, buttermilk, butter, and vanilla.
8. Fold wet into dry until just combined — lumps OK.
9. Whip egg whites to soft peaks. Fold into batter.
10. Cook in preheated waffle iron until deeply golden and crispy — 4–5 minutes.
11. ASSEMBLE: Waffle on plate. Place fried chicken on top.
12. Drizzle maple syrup and hot sauce. Add a pat of butter.

Prep: 20 min + 4 hrs marinating · Cook: 30 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~820 per serving

TIP

The equal presence of maple syrup AND hot sauce is the genius of chicken and waffles — not alternating between them but combining them in the same bite. The sweet-heat-fat combination of maple syrup, Tabasco, and butter alongside the crispy chicken is one of the great American flavor combinations. Don't choose between sweet and spicy — use both.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Harlem Heritage] [Indulgent] [Sweet-Savory]

RECIPE 534

■ ■ United States (Midwest)

BREAKFAST CASSEROLE

America's greatest make-ahead breakfast — a crowd-feeding casserole of layers of bread, sausage, cheese, and egg custard assembled the night before and baked the next morning while everyone is still in pajamas. The Midwestern potluck and Christmas morning staple. Every church cookbook in America contains at least three versions. This is the one that works every time: the bread soaks overnight into the custard, the sausage provides salty depth, and the cheese forms a golden crust.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 cups cubed day-old white bread (about half a loaf)
- 450g (16 oz) bulk pork breakfast sausage, cooked
- and crumbled
- 2 cups shredded sharp cheddar cheese
- 6 large eggs
- 2 cups whole milk
- ½ tsp dry mustard powder
- ½ tsp garlic powder
- ½ tsp onion powder
- Salt and black pepper
- 2 tbsp butter (for greasing and dotting the top)

OPTIONAL ADDITIONS

- 1 cup diced green bell pepper
- ½ cup diced onion, sautéed
- 4 oz (115g) diced green chillies (very Midwestern)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Grease a 23x33cm (9x13-inch) baking dish generously.
2. Spread bread cubes in an even layer.
3. Scatter cooked sausage over the bread.
4. Add any optional vegetables.
5. Scatter cheese evenly over everything.
6. Whisk eggs, milk, mustard, garlic powder, onion powder, salt, and pepper until completely smooth.
7. Pour egg mixture evenly over the entire dish.
8. Press bread down gently to ensure all cubes are moistened by the custard.
9. COVER AND REFRIGERATE OVERNIGHT — minimum 4 hours, ideally 8–12. This soaking creates a unified, custard-like result rather than separate components.
10. MORNING: Remove from refrigerator 30 minutes before baking.
11. Preheat oven to 175°C (350°F).
12. Dot surface with small pieces of butter.
13. Bake uncovered 45–55 minutes until golden, puffed, and the center is fully set when shaken.
14. Rest 10 minutes before serving.

Prep: 20 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 55 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

The overnight soak is essential — short-soaked casserole has patches of soggy bread and dry bread rather than the unified, pudding-like texture of a properly soaked overnight casserole. The egg custard needs the full overnight soak to penetrate every cube. Make it on Saturday night; bake it Sunday morning.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Make-Ahead] [Crowd Feeding] [Midwestern]

RECIPE 535

■ ■ United States (California)

AÇAÍ BOWL

California's health-food phenomenon — a thick, vibrant purple purée of frozen açai berry blended with banana and almond milk, topped with granola, fresh fruit, nut butter, and honey. Açai (pronounced ah-sah-EE) is a Brazilian Amazonian palm berry that arrived in California surf culture in the early 2000s and became a global health food trend. The bowl format — thick enough to eat with a spoon, loaded with colorful toppings — is entirely a California invention. It is genuinely delicious and genuinely nutritious.

INGREDIENTS

- AÇAÍ BASE:
- 200g (7 oz) frozen unsweetened açai pulp or
- açai frozen packets (Sambazon is the standard brand)
- 1 ripe banana, frozen (half for the base, half sliced for topping)
- 120ml (½ cup) unsweetened almond milk or coconut water
- 1 tbsp nut butter (almond or peanut)
- 1 tsp honey or maple syrup
- Optional: ¼ cup frozen blueberries for deeper color

TOPPINGS

- Homemade granola (Recipe 531)
- Fresh sliced banana
- Fresh strawberries and blueberries
- 1 tbsp nut butter (drizzled)
- 1 tbsp honey drizzled
- 1 tbsp shredded coconut
- Chia seeds or hemp seeds
- Cacao nibs (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine frozen açai, frozen banana, almond milk, nut butter, and honey in a high-powered blender.
2. Blend on high until smooth — add almond milk sparingly. The base should be very thick (thicker than a smoothie) so toppings don't sink.
3. It should require a spoon to eat — not a straw.
4. Pour into a wide, shallow bowl.
5. TOPPINGS: Work quickly (the açai melts fast). Arrange toppings in rows or sections for visual appeal.
6. Add granola in a row, fresh fruit in another section, nut butter drizzled, honey swirled.
7. Eat immediately — açai bowl does not wait.

Prep: 8 min · Cook: 0 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~480 per bowl

TIP

Thickness is everything in açai bowls — too much liquid creates a purple smoothie, not a bowl. Add liquid tablespoon by tablespoon and stop the moment the blender runs smoothly. The finished base should pile up when spooned into the bowl rather than spreading immediately. A Vitamix or powerful blender is essential — under-powered blenders add too much liquid trying to blend the frozen açai.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [High Fiber] [Modern California] [Antioxidant-Rich]

RECIPE 536

■ ■ United States

CORNERED BEEF HASH

The American diner's savory, crispy morning hash — corned beef (salt-cured beef brisket) chopped and pan-fried with diced potatoes and onion until a crackling golden crust forms on the bottom. Topped with eggs fried in the same pan. A working-class American breakfast born from resourceful use of canned corned beef during World War II rationing, it became a permanent fixture of American diner culture and a beloved weekend breakfast across the country.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (14 oz) canned corned beef, diced
- OR leftover boiled corned beef, diced
- 3 medium waxy potatoes, boiled until just tender, diced into 1cm cubes
- 1 large onion, finely diced
- 1 green bell pepper, diced (optional)
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce
- ½ tsp paprika
- Salt and black pepper
- 3 tbsp butter or vegetable oil
- 4 large eggs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat butter in a large, heavy skillet (cast iron preferred) over medium-high heat.
2. Add onion and bell pepper. Cook 4 minutes until softened.
3. Add garlic. Cook 1 minute.
4. Add corned beef. Break into pieces. Toss.
5. Add potato cubes. Season with Worcestershire, paprika, salt, and pepper.
6. PRESS FIRMLY into the pan with a spatula — create an even, compact layer.
7. Cook WITHOUT STIRRING over medium heat 6–8 minutes until the bottom develops a deep golden, crispy crust.
8. FLIP in sections — the crust should release cleanly.
9. Cook another 4–5 minutes until the new bottom is equally crispy.
10. Push hash to the sides. Crack eggs into the center. Cover briefly to set the whites.
11. Serve hash with eggs on top — yolks runny.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~560 per serving

TIP

Never stir corned beef hash once it's been pressed into the pan — the crust forms from sustained contact with the hot pan surface. Stirring destroys the crust before it can form. Press, leave alone, and wait until the sides of the hash look golden before flipping. The crusty bottom is the entire achievement of a well-made hash.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic American] [Diner Classic] [One-Pan]

RECIPE 537

■ ■ United States (Texas)

TEXAS BREAKFAST TACO

Texas's contribution to American breakfast culture — a warm flour or corn tortilla filled with scrambled eggs and any combination of bacon or chorizo, potato, cheese, jalapeño, and salsa. Austin has developed an intense breakfast taco culture with long lines at beloved taco trucks before 9am. The Texas breakfast taco is faster than a burrito, smaller than a plate, and infinitely customizable — Texas's practical genius applied to the morning meal.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 small flour tortillas (15cm / 6-inch)
- OR corn tortillas (warm them on a comal)
- FILLING OPTIONS (make all or choose):

POTATO AND EGG

- 2 potatoes, diced small, fried in oil until crispy
- 4 eggs, scrambled soft with butter and salt

BACON OR CHORIZO

- 4 strips thick-cut bacon, cooked and crumbled
- OR 150g (5 oz) Mexican chorizo, cooked and crumbled
- TOPPINGS (all essential):
- ½ cup shredded cheddar or Colby-Jack cheese
- Pickled jalapeños or fresh jalapeño slices
- Good salsa (tomatillo salsa verde or red salsa)
- Fresh cilantro
- Lime wedges
- Sour cream or avocado (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. POTATO: Fry diced potato in vegetable oil over medium-high heat until golden and crispy. Season.
2. EGGS: Scramble eggs in butter over medium-low heat until just soft and slightly wet. Season.
3. CHORIZO (if using): Cook crumbled Mexican chorizo in a dry pan until cooked through and sizzling.
4. WARM TORTILLAS: Heat directly on gas flame or dry skillet 30 seconds per side until pliable and lightly charred.
5. ASSEMBLE: Layer filling in the center of each tortilla: — Potatoes — Scrambled egg — Chorizo or bacon — Cheese (melts on hot filling) — Jalapeños
6. Spoon salsa over. Add cilantro.
7. Squeeze lime. Fold in half.
8. Eat immediately, standing if at all possible — the Texas breakfast taco was designed for mobility.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 3 · Cal: ~450 per 2-taco serving

TIP

The warm tortilla is the make-or-break element — a cold, stiff tortilla cracks when folded and loses all its flavor. Warming directly on a gas flame creates slight charring and a smoky flexibility. Stack warmed tortillas in a clean cloth to keep warm while assembling.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [Texas Heritage] [Quick] [Portable]

RECIPE 538

■ ■ United States (Pacific Northwest)

SMOKED SALMON SCRAMBLED EGGS

The Pacific Northwest's elegant morning combination — cold-smoked Pacific salmon folded into soft, slowly scrambled eggs with crème fraîche, fresh dill, and chives, served on toasted sourdough. Seattle and Portland's café culture elevated this combination into a morning staple that honors the Pacific Northwest's greatest natural resource — its extraordinary wild salmon — in the most direct and satisfying way possible.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large eggs
- 2 tbsp crème fraîche (or sour cream)
- 120g (4 oz) cold-smoked Pacific salmon, torn into small pieces
- 2 tbsp fresh dill, chopped
- 2 tbsp fresh chives, snipped
- 1 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt and white pepper
- 4 slices sourdough bread, toasted
- Extra crème fraîche for serving
- Capers (1 tsp per plate)
- Lemon wedges

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Beat eggs with crème fraîche, salt, and white pepper. Do not over-beat — a few streaks of yolk are fine.
2. Heat butter in a non-stick pan over VERY LOW HEAT. Lower than you think. The lowest setting.
3. Pour in eggs. Stir constantly with a silicone spatula using slow, wide motions.
4. Cook very slowly — 4–6 minutes. The eggs should gradually thicken into large, glossy, barely-set curds. Remove from heat while still very soft — the eggs continue cooking in the residual heat.
5. OFF HEAT: Fold in smoked salmon, half the dill, and half the chives. The heat of the eggs gently warms the salmon without cooking it further.
6. SERVE: Pile soft scrambled eggs on toasted sourdough.
7. Top with a small spoonful of crème fraîche.
8. Scatter remaining dill and chives.
9. Add capers. Squeeze lemon.
10. Eat immediately.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 6 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~490 per serving

TIP

Eggs scrambled at the lowest possible heat create the large, glossy, custardy curds that distinguish refined scrambled eggs from the small, rubbery curds that result from high heat. The French bain-marie method (double boiler) creates the ultimate version but requires 15–20 minutes of stirring. The lowest direct heat gives excellent results in 6 minutes.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic American] [Pacific Northwest]

RECIPE 539

■ ■ United States

AMERICAN DRIP COFFEE

THE UNLIMITED REFILL

America's breakfast beverage — the drip coffee served in a ceramic mug at every American diner, refilled without asking, available from 5am until closing, and drunk in quantities that make European coffee drinkers pale. American drip coffee is not espresso — it is a different product entirely. Lighter, milder, drunk in large amounts over long breakfast conversations. The best American drip coffee is made with freshly ground beans, filtered water, and the correct ratio. The unlimited refill is not a gimmick — it is a philosophy of hospitality that is entirely American.

INGREDIENTS

- 60g (about 6 tbsp) freshly ground medium-roast coffee
- per 1L (4 cups) filtered water
- Filtered water (chlorine in tap water damages flavor)
- Optional: half-and-half (equal parts cream and milk)
- or cream — the American coffee accompaniment
- Sugar or simple syrup to taste
- RATIO: 60g coffee per liter water
- (This is stronger than many people expect — correct)
- American diner coffee is bold, not weak)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GRIND: Grind beans medium-coarse (like coarse sand) immediately before brewing. Fresh-ground coffee makes a dramatically better cup.
2. Measure: 60g ground coffee per 1L of water.
3. BREW: Pour boiling water over ground coffee in a paper filter (or metal filter for more body). Water temperature: 93–96°C (199–205°F) — just off the boil, never fully boiling.
4. Brew time: 4–5 minutes total.
5. Pour into preheated ceramic mug.
6. Add half-and-half if desired — poured until the coffee turns the color of a paper bag.
7. THE REFILL: As soon as the cup is half-empty, the diner waitress refills it without being asked. This is the American way.
8. Drink hot. Talk. Refill. Repeat.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 4 cups · Cal: ~15 per cup (with half-and-half)

TIP

The medium roast is intentional — dark roast coffee becomes bitter when brewed in the large volumes that American drip coffee requires. Medium roast provides the balanced, slightly sweet, chocolatey flavor that holds up to cream and sugar and to the unlimited refill format. Great American diner coffee is never darkly roasted.

[Vegan] [Gluten-Free] [Quick] [Classic American] [Diner Culture] [Essential]

RECIPE 540

■ ■ United States (Low Country South Carolina)

SHRIMP AND GRITS

South Carolina's Low Country breakfast masterpiece — stone-ground white corn grits cooked slow and long with butter and sharp cheddar into a silky, deeply flavored porridge, topped with plump shrimp sautéed with bacon, garlic, and green onion in a light Worcestershire-lemon sauce. Once a humble fisherman's breakfast along the Carolina coast, shrimp and grits became America's most celebrated regional breakfast when Craig Claiborne wrote about it in the New York Times in 1985. It has never left the national conversation since.

INGREDIENTS

- STONE-GROUND GRITS:
- 1 cup stone-ground white grits
- (not instant — stone-ground only)
- 4 cups water
- 1 cup whole milk
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- ¾ cup sharp white cheddar, grated
- Salt and white pepper

SHRIMP

- 500g (18 oz) large shrimp, peeled and deveined
- 4 strips thick-cut bacon, diced
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 4 green onions, sliced (white and green parts separated)
- ½ cup chicken broth
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- ½ tsp smoked paprika
- Pinch of cayenne
- Salt and black pepper
- 1 tbsp butter (to finish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GRITS: Bring water and milk to a simmer in a heavy saucepan. Add salt.
2. Slowly whisk in grits in a thin stream.
3. Reduce heat to very low. Cook 40–45 minutes, stirring every 5 minutes, until completely smooth and creamy. Stone-ground grits take time — no rushing.
4. Remove from heat. Stir in butter and cheddar. Season. Cover and keep warm.
5. SHRIMP: Cook bacon in a wide pan over medium heat until crispy. Remove bacon. Leave fat in pan.
6. Increase heat to medium-high. Add shrimp in a single layer. Sear 1 minute per side until just pink — do not overcook. Remove.
7. Add white parts of green onion and garlic to pan. Cook 1 minute in the bacon fat.
8. Add chicken broth, Worcestershire, lemon juice, paprika, and cayenne. Scrape up any brown bits.
9. Simmer 2 minutes until slightly reduced.
10. Return shrimp. Add butter. Toss to coat.
11. Return bacon. Add green onion tops. Season.
12. SERVE: Mound grits in wide bowls. Spoon shrimp and sauce generously over.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 50 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

Stone-ground grits absorb far more liquid than instant grits — they may seem thin at 20 minutes and impossibly thick at 40 minutes. Trust the process and keep stirring. The final grits should be creamy and fluid enough to pool slowly when spooned into a bowl — they will continue to thicken as they sit.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic American] [Low Country Heritage]

RECIPE 541

■ ■ United States (Pennsylvania Dutch)

SCRAPPLE

Pennsylvania's most distinctive and polarizing breakfast meat — scrapple is a loaf of pork scraps and offal cooked with cornmeal and buckwheat flour into a firm terrine, sliced, and pan-fried until the exterior is shatteringly crispy while the interior remains soft and savory. Created by German immigrants in Pennsylvania as a thrifty way to use every part of the pig. Eaten with maple syrup, ketchup, or apple butter — the sweet- savory combination is the Pennsylvania Dutch way.

INGREDIENTS

HOMEMADE SCRAPPLE

- 500g (18 oz) pork shoulder, roughly chopped
- 200g (7 oz) pork liver (optional — traditional, creates a deeper flavor; omit for milder version)
- 1 onion, quartered
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 1 tsp dried sage
- ½ tsp dried thyme
- ½ tsp marjoram
- ¼ tsp allspice
- ¼ tsp nutmeg
- 1 cup yellow cornmeal
- ½ cup buckwheat flour (or all cornmeal)
- 1.5L (6 cups) water

FOR FRYING

- Butter or lard for pan-frying
- Sliced scrapple (1.5cm thick)

ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Maple syrup, apple butter, or ketchup
- Fried eggs

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine pork shoulder, liver (if using), and onion in a pot. Cover with water. Bring to a boil.
2. Simmer 1 hour until pork is very tender. Skim foam.
3. Remove meat. Reserve all broth.
4. Shred or grind pork very fine. Discard onion.
5. Measure 1L of reserved broth. Return to pot.
6. Add shredded meat. Add all spices. Bring to simmer.
7. SLOWLY whisk in cornmeal and buckwheat flour — add in a thin stream while stirring constantly.
8. Cook over very low heat, stirring constantly, 20–25 minutes until mixture is very thick, pulls from the sides, and holds its shape when spooned.
9. Pour into a greased loaf pan. Smooth the surface.
10. Cool to room temperature. Refrigerate overnight.
11. FRYING: Slice cold scrapple 1.5cm thick.
12. Heat butter or lard in a cast-iron pan over medium-high.
13. Fry slices 4–5 minutes per side until the exterior is deeply golden and crispy — the crust should shatter.
14. The interior remains soft and savory.
15. Serve with maple syrup and fried eggs.

Prep: 20 min + overnight chilling · Cook: 1.5 hours · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~320 per serving (2 slices)

TIP

The scrapple must be completely cold and firm before slicing and frying — warm scrapple crumbles in the pan. The overnight refrigerating firms the cornmeal enough to slice cleanly and develop the shatteringly crispy crust that is the achievement of properly fried scrapple.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free option] [Classic American] [Pennsylvania Dutch Heritage]

RECIPE 542

■ ■ United States (Midwest)

CINNAMON ROLLS

America's most indulgent weekend breakfast — pillowy, enriched yeasted dough rolled with a generous layer of butter, brown sugar, and cinnamon, cut into thick spirals, baked until golden and soft, and drizzled with cream cheese frosting that melts into every crevice. Swedish in origin (the kanelbulle of Chunk 4), completely Americanized by Midwestern bakers who made them larger, richer, and more frosted. The smell of cinnamon rolls baking has been used as a real

estate selling technique because it convinces strangers a house is a home.

INGREDIENTS

ENRICHED DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 50g (¼ cup) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 240ml (1 cup) warm whole milk
- 2 large eggs
- 80g (⅓ cup) unsalted butter, softened

CINNAMON FILLING

- 100g (7 tbsp) unsalted butter, very soft
- 150g (⅔ cup packed) dark brown sugar
- 2 tbsp ground cinnamon
- ¼ tsp ground cardamom (optional — adds depth)
- Pinch of salt

CREAM CHEESE FROSTING

- 180g (¾ cup) full-fat cream cheese, room temperature
- 1 cup powdered sugar, sifted
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 2–3 tbsp whole milk (to thin)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add warm milk and eggs. Mix. Knead 5 minutes. Add softened butter in pieces. Knead 8 more minutes until smooth, soft, and slightly tacky. Prove 1–1.5 hours until doubled.
2. FILLING: Mix soft butter, brown sugar, cinnamon, and salt into a spreadable paste.
3. ROLL: On a lightly floured surface, roll dough into a 45x35cm (18x14-inch) rectangle, 5mm thick.
4. Spread filling over the ENTIRE surface, edge to edge.
5. Roll up tightly from the long edge into a log.
6. Cut into 12 equal rounds (about 3cm thick).
7. Place cut-side up in a greased 23x33cm (9x13-inch) pan. Leave 1cm between rolls — they will grow together.
8. Prove 45–60 minutes until very puffed.
9. Bake at 175°C (350°F) 20–22 minutes until golden.
10. FROSTING: Beat cream cheese, butter, and vanilla until smooth. Add powdered sugar and milk. Beat until fluffy.
11. FROST IMMEDIATELY while rolls are hot — the frosting melts into the rolls. Pour generously.

Prep: 30 min + 2.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 22 min · Serves: 12 · Cal: ~490 per roll

TIP

Frost the rolls the moment they come out of the oven — the heat melts the cream cheese frosting so it flows into every crevice and spiral, creating the specific gooey-in-the-crevices experience that defines a great cinnamon roll. Frosting cold rolls creates a hard shell that sits on the surface.

[Vegetarian] [Classic American] [Midwest Heritage] [Weekend Baking] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 543

■ ■ United States (Pacific Northwest / German-American)

DUTCH BABY PANCAKE

America's most theatrical breakfast — a thin batter of eggs, flour, and milk poured into a piping hot cast-iron skillet in the oven, where it billows up dramatically like a popover, creating a crispy, golden exterior with a soft, custardy, sunken center. Brought by German immigrants (a variation of the Pfannkuchen), popularized in Seattle at Manca's Café in the early 1900s. The Dutch Baby is equal parts spectacle and breakfast — it must be eaten within 5 minutes of leaving the oven, before it deflates.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- ¾ cup (180ml) whole milk, room temperature
- ¾ cup (90g) all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp salt
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter (for the skillet)

SWEET SERVING

- Powdered sugar, sifted dramatically at the table
- Fresh lemon juice squeezed over
- Fresh berries or sliced stone fruit
- Maple syrup on the side
- SAVORY VERSION (equally excellent):
- Skip sugar, add herbs to batter
- Top with prosciutto, arugula, parmesan, lemon

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 220°C (425°F).
2. Place a 25–30cm (10–12 inch) cast-iron skillet in the oven to heat for 10 minutes.
3. BATTER: Blend eggs, milk, flour, sugar, vanilla, and salt in a blender until completely smooth — 30 seconds. Or whisk vigorously by hand.
4. The batter is very thin — thinner than crêpe batter.
5. ADD BUTTER: Carefully remove the hot skillet. Add butter — it will immediately foam and sizzle.
6. Swirl to coat the entire surface, including sides.
7. POUR batter immediately into the hot buttered pan.
8. Return to oven immediately.
9. Bake 18–22 minutes WITHOUT OPENING THE OVEN. The Dutch Baby will puff dramatically and unevenly — this is correct. The edges rise to the rim.
10. When deep golden and puffed, remove from oven.
11. SERVE IMMEDIATELY at the table in the skillet.
12. Sift powdered sugar over. Squeeze lemon. Add fruit.
13. Cut into wedges. Eat before it deflates (5 minutes).

Prep: 5 min + 10 min preheating · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 2–3 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

Room temperature eggs and milk are essential — cold dairy creates a denser batter that rises less dramatically. Take eggs and milk from the refrigerator 30 minutes before making. Also, never open the oven during baking — the temperature drop causes the Dutch Baby to collapse before it sets. The dramatic puff is the reward for restraint.

[Vegetarian] [Classic American] [German-American Heritage] [Theatrical]

RECIPE 544

■ ■ United States (California)

MONTE CRISTO SANDWICH

California's indulgent sweet-savory breakfast sandwich — a French toast-style sandwich of ham, turkey, and Swiss cheese, dipped in egg batter and pan-fried until golden, then dusted with powdered sugar and served with raspberry jam for dipping. Born from the Croque Monsieur tradition but thoroughly Americanized with the addition of powdered sugar and jam. Popularized at Disneyland's Blue Bayou restaurant in the 1960s. Simultaneously bizarre and completely wonderful.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 thick slices white sandwich bread or brioche
- 4 slices Swiss cheese
- 4 slices good quality ham
- 4 slices turkey breast

EGG BATTER

- 3 large eggs
- 120ml (½ cup) whole milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of nutmeg
- Pinch of salt

FOR FRYING

- 3 tbsp unsalted butter

FOR SERVING

- Powdered sugar (dusted generously)
- Raspberry jam or strawberry jam (for dipping)
- Fresh raspberries

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Assemble 4 sandwiches: bread → Swiss cheese → ham → turkey → Swiss cheese → bread.
2. Press each sandwich firmly together.
3. Beat eggs, milk, vanilla, nutmeg, and salt.
4. Heat butter in a wide pan over medium heat.
5. Dip each sandwich in egg batter — let it absorb 15 seconds per side. The batter should coat the exterior completely.
6. Pan-fry 3–4 minutes per side until deeply golden and the cheese is visibly melted.
7. Cut diagonally. Dust heavily with powdered sugar.
8. Serve immediately with jam for dipping.
9. Eat with awareness of the absurdity and joy of what you are experiencing.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 12 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~590 per sandwich

TIP

Press the sandwiches firmly before dipping in batter — loose sandwiches fall apart in the pan. A brief time in the refrigerator (10 minutes) after assembling helps the layers compact into a single unit that holds together through frying. The cheese melts and acts as additional glue between layers.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [California Heritage] [Sweet-Savory]

RECIPE 545

■ ■ United States (Mexican-American / Southwest)

CHILAQUILES

Mexican in origin, completely adopted by the American Southwest — tortilla chips simmered briefly in red or green salsa until partially softened but still with some crunch, topped with fried eggs, crumbled cheese, sour cream, and fresh cilantro. The best chilaquiles are made from yesterday's tortillas fried in lard. The second best are made with good store-bought tortilla chips simmered in excellent salsa. The American Southwest eats chilaquiles for breakfast the way New York eats bagels — daily, without question, as a birthright.

INGREDIENTS

CHILAQUILES

- 200g (7 oz) thick tortilla chips — or day-old
- corn tortillas cut and fried until crispy
- 400ml (1½ cups) salsa roja (red: blended tomato, chipotle, garlic, onion) OR salsa verde (green: blended tomatillo, jalapeño, garlic, onion)
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- ½ cup chicken broth (to loosen the salsa)

TOPPINGS

- 4 large eggs, fried sunnyside up
- 100g (3.5 oz) queso fresco or cotija cheese, crumbled
- ½ cup sour cream or crema mexicana
- 1 avocado, sliced
- Fresh cilantro, roughly chopped
- ½ white onion, very finely diced
- Pickled jalapeños
- Lime wedges
- Dried Mexican oregano

INSTRUCTIONS

1. SALSA ROJA (quick version): Blend 2 chipotle peppers in adobo + 400g canned tomatoes + 2 garlic cloves + ½ onion until smooth. Season.
2. Heat oil in a wide pan over medium heat.
3. Add salsa. Simmer 3–4 minutes until slightly reduced.
4. Add chicken broth to loosen to a sauce consistency.
5. Add tortilla chips all at once.
6. Fold gently — coat every chip with salsa but don't break them all.
7. Cook 1–2 minutes — chips should be partially softened but not mushy. Some crunch must remain.
8. Immediately transfer to plates.
9. Top with fried eggs, crumbled cheese, sour cream dollops, avocado, cilantro, and raw onion.
10. Add pickled jalapeños. Squeeze lime.
11. Crumble dried oregano over. Eat immediately.

Prep: 10 min · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 2 · Cal: ~590 per serving

TIP

The timing between simmering and serving is critical — chilaquiles continue to soften after leaving the heat. The chips should be removed from the salsa while still slightly too crunchy, because residual heat and the liquid in the toppings will finish softening them. Over-simmered chilaquiles become a corn mush.

[Vegetarian] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Mexican-American] [Southwest Heritage]

RECIPE 546

■ ■ United States (New England)

BOSTON BAKED BEANS ON TOAST

New England's most historically significant breakfast — Boston baked beans, slow-cooked navy beans with salt pork, molasses, and mustard in a clay pot for hours until the beans are tender and the sauce is thick and deeply sweet-savory. Once the Saturday night supper of Puritan New England, the leftovers were traditionally served for Sunday breakfast. The combination of sweet, molasses-dark beans with salt pork is one of America's oldest and most honest breakfast foods.

INGREDIENTS

- 400g (2 cups) dried navy beans or white beans,
- soaked overnight
- 150g (5 oz) salt pork or thick-cut bacon, diced
- 1 large onion, diced
- 3 tbsp dark molasses (blackstrap — the strong, slightly bitter variety)
- 2 tbsp brown sugar
- 2 tsp dry mustard powder
- 1 tsp apple cider vinegar
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- Salt and black pepper
- 500ml (2 cups) water or broth

FOR SERVING

- Thick-cut white bread or brown bread, toasted
- Butter
- Optional: sliced hot dogs baked with the beans
- (the traditional Boston addition)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Drain soaked beans. Parboil 10 minutes. Drain.
2. Preheat oven to 150°C (300°F).
3. In a Dutch oven or clay bean pot, layer diced salt pork and onion on the bottom.
4. Add parboiled beans.
5. Mix molasses, brown sugar, mustard, vinegar, ginger, salt, pepper, and water. Pour over beans.
6. Beans should be almost submerged — add more water.
7. Cover tightly. Bake 6–8 hours, checking every 2 hours and adding water if needed.
8. In the final 30 minutes, remove lid to allow the sauce to thicken and caramelize on top.
9. The finished beans should be very soft, dark, sweet-savory, and surrounded by thick sauce.
10. Serve over thick-cut buttered toast.

Prep: 15 min + overnight soaking · Cook: 7 hours · Serves: 6 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Blackstrap molasses (the strongest, most bitter, most mineral-rich variety) is what creates Boston baked beans' characteristic dark, complex sweetness. Regular molasses makes a sweeter, lighter bean. Use blackstrap for authentic New England depth — add more brown sugar if the bitterness is too pronounced for your preference.

[High Protein] [Classic American] [New England Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

RECIPE 547

■ ■ **United States (Texas / Czech-American)**

KOLACHE

Texas's beloved Czech-American breakfast pastry — soft, pillowy yeasted rolls filled with either sweet fillings (apricot, cheese, poppy seed) or savory sausage-and-cheese filling. Czech immigrants brought kolache to Texas in the 1850s and they have been baked with furious devotion in small Texas towns ever since. The Texas kolache has evolved — savory sausage kolache (called pigs-in-a-blanket locally, though Czechs dispute this) are now as essential to Texas breakfast culture as biscuits.

INGREDIENTS

KOLACHE DOUGH

- 500g (4 cups) all-purpose flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 60g (5 tbsp) sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 240ml (1 cup) warm whole milk
- 2 large eggs
- 80g (■ cup) unsalted butter, softened

APRICOT SWEET FILLING

- 200g (7 oz) dried apricots
- 3 tbsp sugar
- Water to cover
- Simmer 20 minutes until soft. Blend smooth. Cool.

CREAM CHEESE SWEET FILLING

- 225g (8 oz) cream cheese, softened
- 3 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla
- 1 egg yolk

SAVORY SAUSAGE FILLING

- 4 pork breakfast sausage links, cooked
- 4 slices cheddar cheese
- EGG WASH: 1 egg + 1 tbsp milk, beaten

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Combine flour, yeast, sugar, salt. Add warm milk and eggs. Knead 5 minutes. Add butter. Knead 8 minutes. Prove 1 hour.
2. Divide into 16 balls.
3. SWEET KOLACHE: Flatten each ball into a disc. Place in greased pan. Press a deep well in the center. Fill with 1 tbsp chosen sweet filling.
4. SAVORY KOLACHE: Roll each ball into a rectangle. Place sausage and cheese at one end. Roll up tightly.
5. Brush all with egg wash. Prove 30 minutes.
6. Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 15–18 minutes until pale golden — kolache should be PALE, not dark.
7. For sweet: brush with melted butter immediately after baking. Dust with powdered sugar if desired.

Prep: 30 min + 1.5 hrs proofing · Cook: 18 min · Serves: 16 · Cal: ~265 per kolache

TIP

Kolache dough should be very soft and slightly sticky — much softer than bread dough. This enriched, buttery dough creates the characteristic cloud-like texture of proper kolache. Adding more flour to make it easier to handle creates a dense, bread-like result that lacks the delicate pillowy character that Texas Czech bakers have defended for 150 years.

[Vegetarian option] [Classic American] [Czech-American Heritage] [Texas]

RECIPE 548

■■ Canada (Ontario)

CANADIAN BACK BACON AND

Ontario's most distinctive breakfast meat — peameal bacon (back bacon rolled in yellow cornmeal, the traditional Toronto preparation) pan-fried until the cornmeal crust is golden and the lean pork inside is juicy. Served with eggs, toast, and Canadian maple syrup. Not the smoked American-style "Canadian bacon" sold in the United States — real Canadian peameal bacon is unsmoked, brined, leaner, and rolled in yellow cornmeal. The St. Lawrence Market in Toronto serves it on a bun and the lineup runs down the block regardless of weather.

INGREDIENTS

PEAMEAL BACON

- 500g (18 oz) pork loin, trimmed of excess fat
- BRINE: 1L water + 3 tbsp salt + 2 tbsp sugar +
- 1 tsp curing salt (pink salt, optional) +
- 1 tsp black pepper + 1 bay leaf
- Brine for 3–5 days in the refrigerator
- Yellow cornmeal for rolling (generous coating)

FOR SERVING

- 4 large eggs (fried or scrambled)
- Canadian maple syrup (Grade A dark amber)
- Buttered white toast
- Back bacon on a kaiser bun — the St. Lawrence Market way

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CURE: Combine brine ingredients. Submerge pork loin. Refrigerate 3–5 days, turning once daily.
2. Remove. Rinse briefly. Pat dry.
3. Roll generously in yellow cornmeal — press firmly so the cornmeal adheres to all surfaces.
4. Wrap in plastic. Refrigerate 30 minutes to set coating.
5. Slice into rounds (1.5–2cm thick).
6. Heat a pan over medium heat. No oil needed — the cornmeal will toast in the rendered pork fat.
7. Fry slices 3 minutes per side until the cornmeal coating is golden and crunchy.
8. The interior should be juicy and cooked through but not dry.
9. Serve alongside fried eggs and buttered toast.
10. Drizzle real Canadian maple syrup over the bacon.

Prep: 15 min + 3–5 days brining · Cook: 10 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~480 per serving

TIP

The cornmeal coating creates a specific crunchy texture that is entirely different from smoked back bacon — it toasts against the hot pan while the lean pork stays moist inside. Use coarse yellow cornmeal, not fine — the coarser grind creates a more substantial crust that holds up to frying without falling off.

[High Protein] [Gluten-Free] [Classic Canadian] [Ontario Heritage]

RECIPE 549

■ ■ Canada (Québec)

QUÉBÉCOIS CREPES WITH

Quebec's cabane à sucre (sugar shack) breakfast — the extraordinary spring ritual when maple sap runs, and entire families drive to sugar bush operations for a morning feast of crêpes, baked beans, pea soup, and tourtière, with maple syrup poured over everything. The Quebec crêpe is thinner than the French version and always eaten with maple syrup — never just sugar. Quebec maple syrup is produced at a level of quality and variety that France's crêperies would find humbling.

INGREDIENTS

- QUÉBÉCOIS CRÊPES:
- 1½ cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 2 large eggs
- 2 cups (480ml) whole milk
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
- 1 tsp sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Butter for cooking

SUGAR SHACK ACCOMPANIMENTS

- Quebec maple syrup — Grade A very dark
- (the robust, strongly flavored variety produced
- late in the season — the traditional sugar shack grade)
- Oreilles de crisse (crispy fried salt pork rinds —
- the sugar shack essential — eaten by dipping in maple syrup)
- Québécois pea soup (split yellow peas with ham)
- Back bacon or smoked sausage
- Pickles (cornichons — the French-Canadian standard)
- MAPLE TAFFY (tire d'érable — the sugar shack tradition):
- Heat maple syrup to 113°C (235°F)
- Pour in a thin line on fresh snow or crushed ice
- Roll onto a popsicle stick before it hardens
- The snow cools the syrup instantly into a chewy candy

INSTRUCTIONS

1. CRÊPE BATTER: Blend flour, eggs, milk, butter, sugar, salt, and vanilla until completely smooth.
2. Rest 30 minutes — the rest is mandatory.
3. Heat a 20–22cm crêpe pan or non-stick pan over medium heat. Brush lightly with butter.
4. Pour a small ladleful — swirl immediately to coat the pan in a thin, even layer.
5. Cook 60–90 seconds until the edges lift and the top looks dry.
6. Flip. Cook 20 seconds. The second side will be paler with golden spots.
7. Stack on a plate — they won't stick.
8. SERVE: Roll or fold crêpes. Pour maple syrup.
9. Arrange all sugar shack sides alongside.
10. Pour maple syrup over everything, generously — this is Quebec and restraint with maple is not culturally acceptable.

Prep: 10 min + 30 min resting · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~490 per serving (with syrup and sides)

TIP

Quebec maple syrup comes in grades from Golden (delicate, light) to Very Dark (robust, strong). For crêpes and the sugar shack experience, Very Dark Grade A maple syrup is the choice — its deep caramel, almost molasses-like flavor stands up to the richness of the crêpe and the saltiness of the pork sides in a way that lighter syrup cannot.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Canadian] [Québec Heritage] [Sugar Shack]

RECIPE 550

■ ■ Canada (Indigenous / Métis)

BANNOCK

Canada's Indigenous and Métis fry bread — bannock, a simple quick bread made from flour, baking powder, salt, and water (or lard), cooked on a skillet, in an oven, or traditionally wrapped around a stick and cooked over an open fire. Bannock arrived in northern Canada through Hudson's Bay Company traders in the early 1700s and was adopted and transformed by First Nations, Métis, and Inuit peoples into their own staple bread. Today it is eaten for breakfast across Canada's north with butter, jam, fish, or alongside eggs.

INGREDIENTS

BANNOCK

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp baking powder
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tbsp sugar (optional)
- 2 tbsp lard or unsalted butter, cold
- ¾ cup cold water (approximately)
- FOR FRYING (pan bannock):
- 2 tbsp lard or vegetable oil

FOR SERVING

- Butter (generous)
- Jam — saskatoon berry jam (Canadian prairie berry)
- or wild blueberry jam — traditional accompaniments
- Smoked fish (whitefish or Arctic char)
- Honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine flour, baking powder, salt, and sugar.
2. Rub cold lard or butter into the flour with your fingertips until the mixture resembles coarse breadcrumbs.
3. Add cold water gradually — just enough to bring the dough together. It should be slightly sticky but workable. Do not overwork.
4. OVEN BANNOCK: Shape into a round disc (2cm thick). Bake at 190°C (375°F) for 20–25 minutes until golden and a skewer comes out clean.
5. PAN BANNOCK: Heat lard in a cast-iron pan. Press dough to fit the pan (2cm thick). Cook over medium-low heat 8–10 minutes per side until golden and cooked through.
6. STICK BANNOCK: Wrap a flattened rope of dough around a clean green stick. Hold over fire coals 10–15 minutes, turning, until cooked through.
7. Serve warm with butter and jam or alongside smoked fish.

Prep: 8 min • Cook: 20 min • Serves: 6 • Cal: ~235 per serving

TIP

The key to light bannock is minimal handling — like biscuits, overworked bannock dough develops too much gluten and becomes dense and heavy. Mix until just combined, shape gently, and cook. The baking powder needs to do its work without being knocked out by excessive kneading.

[Vegan option] [Classic Canadian] [Indigenous Heritage] [Métis Heritage]

Canada

RECIPE 551

■ ■ Canada (English-Canadian)

EGGS IN A NEST (TOAD IN THE HOLE)

The beloved Canadian-British childhood breakfast — a slice of bread with a hole cut in the center, buttered on both sides and fried in a pan, with a fresh egg cracked directly into the hole. The bread fries golden on both sides while the egg sets within the bread frame — a unified piece of breakfast that is simultaneously toast and fried egg, with crispy buttered bread and a runny yolk in each bite. Known as Toad in the Hole, Egg in a Basket, and a dozen other regional names across Canada and the United States.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 thick slices white or whole wheat bread
- 4 large eggs
- 4 tbsp unsalted butter
- Salt and black pepper
- Optional: a slice of cheddar cheese placed on top

SERVING

- Canadian maple syrup drizzled over (the Canadian way)
- OR ketchup (the English-Canadian way)
- Fresh fruit alongside

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cut a circular hole in the center of each bread slice using a round cookie cutter or glass (7cm). Keep the cut-out circles.
2. Butter both sides of each bread slice generously.
3. Heat 1 tbsp butter in a pan over medium heat.
4. Place bread slice in pan.
5. Crack one egg directly into the hole.
6. Place the cut-out circle alongside — it will become a small piece of toast for dipping.
7. Season the egg with salt and pepper.
8. Cook 2 minutes until the base of the bread is golden and the egg white is partially set.
9. Add a little more butter to the pan.
10. Flip carefully — the egg must not break.
11. Cook 1 more minute for runny yolk, 2 minutes for set yolk.
12. Serve with the toast circle for dipping in the yolk.

Prep: 2 min · Cook: 5 min · Serves: 1 · Cal: ~380 per serving

TIP

The bread must be thick-cut — thin bread doesn't provide enough structure to hold the egg in the hole during flipping. Use bread at least 2cm thick. Also: flip confidently and quickly rather than slowly and hesitantly — a slow flip allows the egg to slide out of the hole. One decisive motion keeps everything in place.

[Vegetarian] [High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Canadian] [Kid-Friendly]

RECIPE 552

■ ■ Canada (Québec)

POUTINE BREAKFAST

Quebec's audacious morning poutine — crispy fries topped with cheese curds and a rich, dark gravy, with a fried egg placed on top for the breakfast version. What began as a 1950s Quebec truck stop dish became a national Canadian icon, and the breakfast adaptation is the logical and magnificent extension of the concept. The egg yolk breaks and runs into the gravy, the cheese curds squeak against the teeth, the fries provide structural crunch — breakfast poutine is Quebec's greatest gift to the morning meal.

INGREDIENTS

BREAKFAST POUTINE FRIES

- 4 large russet potatoes, cut into thick fries (1.5cm)
- Oil for deep frying or oven roasting
- Salt

POUTINE GRAVY

- 2 cups beef broth
- 1 cup chicken broth
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 1 tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- 1 tsp soy sauce
- Black pepper and salt

CHEESE CURDS

- 300g (10 oz) fresh Quebec cheese curds
- (white cheddar curds — they must squeak when bitten. This squeak indicates freshness.
- Fresh cheese curds within 24 hours of making
- are the only acceptable option. Substitute:
- torn fresh mozzarella, though it lacks the squeak)

BREAKFAST ADDITION

- 4 fried eggs (sunnyside up, yolks very runny)
- Optional: crumbled breakfast sausage
- Optional: diced jalapeño

INSTRUCTIONS

1. GRAVY: Melt butter in saucepan over medium heat. Add flour — whisk 1 minute into a roux. Add both broths gradually while whisking. Add Worcestershire and soy sauce. Simmer 10–12 minutes until thick and glossy. Season. Keep warm.
2. FRIES: Deep fry at 175°C (345°F) until golden, OR: roast at 220°C (425°F) 30–35 minutes, flipping once, until very crispy.
3. Season fries immediately with salt.
4. ASSEMBLE: Transfer hot fries to serving plates.
5. Scatter cheese curds generously over hot fries — the heat slightly melts the exterior of the curds.
6. Pour hot gravy over — enough to be generous without drowning the fries.
7. Place a fried egg on top.
8. Break the yolk at the table — it runs into the gravy.

Prep: 15 min · Cook: 35 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~680 per serving

TIP

Cheese curds must be added to hot fries — cold curds on lukewarm fries don't melt at all and the combination is disappointing. The heat of the fresh-from-the-fryer fries warms the curds to the point where their exterior softens while the center remains firm — the textural distinction that makes poutine extraordinary rather than just a loaded fry.

[High Protein] [Classic Canadian] [Québec Heritage] [Indulgent]

RECIPE 553

■ ■ Canada (Prairie Provinces / Ukrainian Heritage)

UKRAINIAN-CANADIAN PIEROGIES

The Prairie provinces' Ukrainian heritage breakfast — perogies (potato and cheese filled dumplings) pan-fried in butter until golden and crispy, topped with caramelized onions, sour cream, and crispy bacon. Ukrainian immigrants arrived in Alberta and Saskatchewan in the early 1900s and their food culture became the Prairie provinces' own. The perogy breakfast is eaten at church breakfasts, family farms, and every diner from Winnipeg to Edmonton. Canada's most heartwarming immigrant breakfast success story.

INGREDIENTS

PEROGY DOUGH

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ cup sour cream
- 1 large egg
- 2–3 tbsp warm water

POTATO AND CHEESE FILLING

- 3 large russet potatoes, boiled and mashed
- 1 cup sharp cheddar cheese, grated and melted in
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1 small onion, caramelized and mashed in
- Salt and pepper

FOR SERVING

- 4 tbsp butter (for pan-frying)
- 2 large onions, thinly sliced and caramelized golden
- 6 strips thick-cut bacon, cooked and crumbled
- Sour cream (generous)
- Fresh chives

INSTRUCTIONS

1. DOUGH: Mix flour and salt. Add sour cream and egg. Add water gradually to form a smooth, pliable dough. Knead 5 minutes. Rest 20 minutes covered.
2. FILLING: Combine mashed potato, cheddar, butter, caramelized onion, salt, and pepper. Cool completely.
3. Roll dough to 3mm. Cut into 8cm circles.
4. Place 1 tbsp filling in the center.
5. Fold to a half-moon. Press edges firmly to seal. Crimp with a fork.
6. Boil perogies in salted water 3–4 minutes until they float and are cooked through. Drain.
7. PAN-FRY: Heat butter in a large pan over medium-high. Add boiled perogies. Fry 3 minutes per side until golden and slightly crispy.
8. SERVE: Pile perogies on plates. Top with caramelized onions, crumbled bacon, and a generous dollop of sour cream. Scatter fresh chives.

Prep: 40 min · Cook: 25 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~580 per serving

TIP

The double cooking — boiling then pan-frying — is essential to the perogy texture that Prairie Canadians know and love. Boiling alone creates soft, tender perogies. Pan-frying alone creates raw dough. Boiling then frying creates the specific combination of soft, cooked interior and golden, slightly crispy exterior that defines the Prairie version.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Canadian] [Ukrainian Heritage] [Prairie Provinces]

RECIPE 554

■ ■ Canada (British Columbia)

SMOKED SALMON AND CREAM

British Columbia's version of the classic — wild Pacific sockeye or king salmon cold-smoked at West Coast smokehouses, served on a toasted Montreal-style bagel (denser and sweeter than New York bagels, boiled in honey water, baked in wood-fired ovens) with herb cream cheese, pickled red onion, capers, and fresh dill. The Canadian salmon is wild, the bagel is Montreal, and the combination is entirely the Pacific Northwest — a morning dish as specific to its place as a croissant is to Paris.

INGREDIENTS

- MONTREAL-STYLE BAGELS (smaller, denser, sweeter):
- 500g (4 cups) bread flour
- 7g (1 packet) instant yeast
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 3 tbsp neutral oil
- 180ml (¾ cup) warm water

HONEY BOILING WATER

- 3L water + 3 tbsp honey
- TOPPING: Sesame seeds (white) — generously

ASSEMBLY

- 180g (6 oz) wild Pacific smoked salmon (sockeye or king)
- 4 tbsp herb cream cheese:
- — 180g cream cheese + 2 tbsp fresh dill +
- 1 tbsp chives + 1 tsp lemon zest, beaten smooth
- Pickled red onion (red onion + apple cider vinegar
- + sugar + salt, pickled 1 hr)
- Capers
- Fresh dill
- Lemon wedges
- Black pepper

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MONTREAL BAGELS: Mix flour, yeast, sugar, and salt. Add egg, oil, and warm water. Knead 10 minutes.
2. Prove 1 hour. Divide into 12 small balls.
3. Roll each into a thin rope (30cm). Join ends.
4. Preheat oven to 230°C (445°F) with a wood plank or stone inside (or regular baking sheet).
5. Boil honey water. Boil bagels 1 minute per side.
6. Coat in sesame seeds immediately after boiling.
7. Bake 15–18 minutes until golden.
8. ASSEMBLY: Split bagel. Toast lightly. Spread herb cream cheese generously. Layer smoked salmon. Add pickled onion, capers. Add fresh dill. Squeeze lemon. Add black pepper.

Prep: 25 min + 1 hr proofing · Cook: 20 min · Serves: 8 · Cal: ~420 per assembled bagel

TIP

Montreal bagels are sweeter, denser, and have a thinner crumb than New York bagels — the honey in the boiling water creates the characteristic sweet crust and the egg-enriched dough creates the denser texture. They are smaller than New York bagels and always wood-oven baked in Montreal tradition. Sesame seeds (not everything seasoning) are the Montreal choice.

[High Protein] [Classic Canadian] [British Columbia] [Pacific Heritage]

RECIPE 555

■ ■ Canada

MAPLE BUTTER TOAST

Canada's simplest and most honest morning pleasure — thick-cut white or whole wheat bread toasted and spread with maple butter (a whipped combination of real butter and pure maple syrup that is one of Canada's great condiments), served alongside pan-fried back bacon and a cup of Tim Hortons-style double-double coffee. This is Canadian breakfast in its most elemental and satisfying form — maple, bread, bacon, coffee. The morning reduced to four perfect things.

INGREDIENTS

MAPLE BUTTER

- 120g (½ cup) unsalted butter, room temperature
- 4 tbsp pure Canadian maple syrup
- (Grade A dark amber — the robust variety)
- Pinch of flaky sea salt
- Beat together until completely smooth and creamy

TOAST

- 8 thick slices good white or whole wheat bread
- Extra butter for spreading base

BACK BACON

- 8 slices Canadian back bacon (round, lean pork loin
- — not American streaky bacon)
- Pan-fry in a dry non-stick pan 2 minutes per side
- DOUBLE-DOUBLE COFFEE:
- Strong drip coffee
- Double cream + double sugar
- (the Tim Hortons order — two cream, two sugar —
- that Canadians consider the definitive coffee)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. MAPLE BUTTER: Beat softened butter until fluffy. Add maple syrup gradually while beating. Add salt. Beat until combined and spreadable. Keep at room temperature or refrigerate and soften before using.
2. Pan-fry back bacon 2 minutes per side until heated through and lightly caramelized at edges.
3. Toast bread to golden. Spread with plain butter first, then maple butter generously on top.
4. Brew strong coffee. Add cream and sugar — two of each.
5. Serve toast alongside back bacon. Eat the maple butter toast. Drink the double-double. This is the Canadian morning.

Prep: 5 min · Cook: 8 min · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~420 per serving

TIP

Maple butter must be made with room-temperature butter — cold butter and maple syrup don't emulsify, creating a separated, oily mixture. The butter must be truly soft and spreadable before the maple syrup is added. Made correctly, maple butter keeps refrigerated for 2 weeks and is one of the most versatile and delicious Canadian breakfast condiments.

[Vegetarian option] [High Protein] [Quick] [Classic Canadian] [Maple Heritage]

RECIPE 556

■ ■ Canada (British Columbia)

NANAIMO BAR BREAKFAST PARFAIT

A playful Canadian breakfast that transforms the Nanaimo bar — Canada's most beloved no-bake square from Nanaimo, British Columbia — into a morning parfait. The three layers of the Nanaimo bar (chocolate-coconut base, vanilla custard cream, and dark chocolate glaze) are deconstructed into a breakfast bowl with granola, cream, and dark chocolate, layered with yogurt. The result is a parfait that captures the spirit of Canada's most iconic confection in a morning-appropriate form.

INGREDIENTS

- NANAIMO-INSPIRED GRANOLA BASE:
 - 1 cup rolled oats
 - ¼ cup desiccated coconut
 - 2 tbsp cocoa powder
 - 2 tbsp dark chocolate chips
 - 2 tbsp honey
 - 2 tbsp coconut oil, melted
 - ¼ cup walnuts or almonds
 - Pinch of salt
 - Toast together at 160°C (320°F) 20 minutes.
- Cool.

VANILLA CUSTARD CREAM LAYER

- 250g (1 cup) thick Greek yogurt
- 2 tbsp custard powder dissolved in 1 tbsp warm milk
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp honey
- Mix until smooth and creamy

CHOCOLATE LAYER

- 60g (2 oz) dark chocolate, melted with 1 tbsp cream
- Cooled to a drizzleable consistency

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Make Nanaimo granola. Cool completely and store.
2. Make custard cream by mixing all ingredients.
3. Melt dark chocolate with cream. Cool slightly.
4. ASSEMBLE IN LAYERS in a glass or jar: — Layer 1: Nanaimo granola (generous) — Layer 2: Vanilla custard cream yogurt — Layer 3: Drizzle of dark chocolate — Repeat layers — Top: extra granola + chocolate drizzle + small square of actual Nanaimo bar if available
5. Serve immediately or refrigerate 30 minutes.

Prep: 20 min · Cook: 20 min (granola) · Serves: 4 · Cal: ~390 per parfait

TIP

The custard powder in the yogurt layer is the specific ingredient that creates the Nanaimo bar custard flavor — Bird's custard powder (widely available in Canadian supermarkets and online) has a specific vanilla-corn flavor that American vanilla pudding powder doesn't replicate. The custard layer is the heart of the Nanaimo bar experience.

[Vegetarian] [Classic Canadian] [British Columbia Heritage] [Make-Ahead]

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